ROUTLEDGE HANDBOOKS



The Routledge Handbook of Organizational Leadership Communication

Edited by Guowei Jian and Gail T. Fairhurst

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THE ROUTLEDGE HANDBOOK OF ORGANIZATIONAL LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION

This handbook captures a rapidly developing body of scholarship to map out the terrain of leadership communication and stimulate interdisciplinary dialogue among leadership communication scholars for future research.

The Routledge Handbook of Organizational Leadership Communication surveys various areas of leadership communication, critically assesses their development, and proposes guidance for future research. It begins by addressing prominent theories or emerging theoretical perspectives that help conceptualize leadership communication, ranging from collective leadership approaches and critical perspectives to theories of practice and communicative constitution of organization. The second section focuses on reviewing the latest research on leadership communication in various organizational contexts, such as work teams, hybrid and virtual work contexts, and interorganizational collaboration. Informed by diverse theoretical perspectives, chapters in the final section examine the practice of leadership communication in dealing with both common and novel organizing challenges and processes, for example, the formation and execution of organizational vision and strategies, the use of emerging media technologies, and organizational decision making.

The handbook will be an indispensable resource for researchers and advanced students in leadership communication and leadership studies and practicing managers and consultants in leadership and communication training and development.

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Edited by Guowei Jian and Gail T. Fairhurst

Routledge
Taylor & Francis Group
LONDON AND NEW YORK

Designed cover image: Getty Images

First published 2025
by Routledge
605 Third Avenue, New York, NY 10158

and by Routledge
4 Park Square, Milton Park, Abingdon, Oxon, OX14 4RN

Routledge is an imprint of the Taylor & Francis Group, an informa business

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ISBN: 978-1-032-46107-6 (hbk)
ISBN: 978-1-032-46108-3 (pbk)
ISBN: 978-1-003-38011-5 (ebk)

DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115

Typeset in Sabon
by Newgen Publishing UK

CONTENTS

Acknowledgements
List of Contributors

Introduction
Guowei Jian and Gail T. Fairhurst

PART I
Theory

1 Leadership Communication from Collective Leadership Approaches
Renato Souza and Brad Jackson

2 Dialogical Leading
J. Kevin Barge

3 Dialectical and Paradoxical Leadership Communication
Gail T. Fairhurst

4 Leadership Communication from a CCO Perspective
Jonathan Clifton and Jakob Rømer Barfod

5 Leadership Communication from the Perspective of Leadership-as-Practice
Brigid Carroll

6 Critical Perspectives on Leadership Communication
David L. Collinson

7 The Dark Side of Leadership Communication
Dennis Tourish

8 The Ethics of Leadership Communication
Ryan S. Bisel and Justin Mahutga

9 Identity-Constitutive Leadership Communication: Discourse, Crisis, and Morality
Mathew L. Sheep

10 Leadership Communication and Social Influence
Ralph A. Gigliotti and Brent D. Ruben

PART II
Context

11 Leadership Communication from the Perspective of Leader-Member Exchange
Leah M. Omilion-Hodges

12 Leadership Communication and Workplace Mentoring
Ziyu Long

13 Leadership Communication in Work Teams
Nale Lehmann-Willenbrock and Clara Sofie Hemshorn de Sanchez

14 Leadership Communication in Hybrid and Virtual Contexts
Stacey L. Connaughton, Ryan N. Funkhouser, and Katelyn E. Brooks

15 Leadership Communication in Interorganizational Collaboration
Matthew Koschmann

16 Leadership Communication in the Context of Organizational Change
Guowei Jian

17 Leadership Communication and Resistance
Zhuo Ban, Heather M. Zoller, and Bhoopali K. Nandurkar

18 Crisis as a Leadership Context: Roles and Responsibilities
Matthew W. Seeger and Robert S. Littlefield

PART III
Practice

19 Leadership Framing and Tactics of Influence
Scott E. Shank Jr., Leah M. Omilion-Hodges, and Vernon D. Miller

20 Narratives in Leadership Communication
Dorien Van De Mieroop and Stephanie Schnurr

21 Leadership Communication as Materiality, Embodiment, and Aesthetics
Christian Dyrlund Wåhlin-Jacobsen and Magnus Larsson

22 Leadership Communication and Technology
Keri K. Stephens and Yifan Xu

23 Emotion and Humor in Leadership Communication
Karen Kroman Myers, Courtney Wong Davis, and David R. Seibold

24 Leadership Communication and Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion
Patrice M. Buzzanell and Evgeniya Pyatovskaya

25 Leadership Communication and Organizational Learning and Development
Jeremy P. Fyke and Amy M. Schmisseur

26 The Intersection of Leadership, Strategy, and Communication
Paul A. Argenti and John A. Haynes

Index

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

The publication of this handbook is not only a collective endeavor but also a testament of first-class expertise, dedication, love, and patience of people who supported us throughout this journey. First, we would like to express our immense gratitude to our contributors. The book is impossible without their commitment and expert knowledge. We would also like to thank Felisa Salvago-Keyes, Sean Daly, Sarah Pickles, and Zoya Gayle at Routledge for guiding us throughout the production process of this book.

Our sincere thanks also go to our colleagues Karen Aschcraft, Nico Bechercki, Vidhi Chaudhri, James McDonald, Linda Putnam, Shawna Redden, Sarah Riforgiate, Anu Sivunen, and the anonymous reviewers for your generosity and insightful comments on the book proposal and various chapters during the editorial process. Finally, we would like to thank our families for their unbending love and support during the journey of completing this book.

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INTRODUCTION

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-1

Over the past half-century, the study of organizational leadership communication[1] has grown and developed, been in and out of favor, and generally formed a patchwork of approaches embracing or challenging the postpositivist and psychological leanings of traditional leadership research (e.g., Liu et al., 2023). While some might liken the study (and this volume) to a crazy quilt, we see something more substantial. Much as Craig (1999) described communication theory as a dialectical-dialogical field of diverse theories that compete yet speak to one another, we find an emerging field of leadership communication that manifests these same qualities. In and through this dialogue, communication materializes as a primary, constitutive social process and mode of explanation for leadership and followership. Moreover, a metadiscourse to this effect is shaping up around it that challenges unified paradigmatic goals (e.g., Antonakis et al., 2023). In this introductory chapter, we survey the dialectical-dialogical field to argue for its constitutive nature, describe the metadiscourse, and situate the book's chapters accordingly.

Leadership Communication as a Constitutive Social Process

Historically, several metatheoretical perspectives mark the research field of organizational leadership communication. For example, prior to the 1980s, early (predominately, North American) leadership communication research was postpositivist, communication was considered ancillary to leaders' psychologistics, and surveys and seven-point scales (e.g., the ICA Audit) measured the communication implications of leadership psychology (e.g., influence tactics, neo-charisma,

socialization research). Starting in the early 1980s, more interpretive, constructionist approaches challenged this model (Putnam & Pacanowsky, 1983) through a meaning-centered, relational, and processual view of leadership communication (e.g., leadership's influence on culture, leader-member exchange, relational control and negotiation studies) (Fairhurst & Uhl-Bien, 2012; Smircich & Morgan, 1982). In the 1990s, critical management studies (CMS) would criticize both of these forerunners for their collective inattention to issues of structural and economic power, discursive closure, manufactured consent, and other forms of asymmetric power (Alvesson & Deetz, 1996; Deetz, 1992), although CMS itself was criticized for its inattention to leadership (Zoller & Fairhurst, 2007). Starting in the late 1990s and early 2000s, communicative constitution of organization (CCO) scholars critiqued most all previous conceptions of communication for lacking a wider emphasis on the material world and sociomaterial performances and practices (Ashcraft et al., 2009; Taylor & Van Every, 2000), with major implications for leadership (Fairhurst, 2007). Harkening back to the ICA audit, leadership communication as praxis was also taken up during this time, but with a greater emphasis on dialogue, relationality, reflexivity, and the generative qualities of theory to inspire change (Barge, 2001; Jian, 2022).

While each successive wave of theorizing suggests a game of one-upmanship and either-or choice making, in fact, a great many course corrections were made by researchers to stay within their perspectives and further them, often in response to the critiques leveled at them. As such, metatheoretic perspectives are not independent thought systems (Craig, 1999; Deetz, 1996), encyclopedia entries notwithstanding. They "speak" to one another, and there is evidence that they listen.

For example, postpositivist leadership communication research was arguably influenced by constructionist models to become more relational (Uhl-Bien & Ospina, 2012) through theories of followership (Uhl-Bien et al., 2014) and collective leadership (Denis et al., 2012; Ospina et al., 2020). It also moved beyond a strictly transmissional view of human communication with the likes of the Leader-Member Exchange Conversational Quality Scale (Jian et al., 2014), which blended information transfer and interpretive views of communication to better understand the conversations that shape LMX quality. Jacquart and Antonakis (2015) followed suit with charismatic leadership measurement, while Rego et al. (2024) blended information transfer with dialogic views of leadership communication in their practical wisdom scale.

Many constructionist researchers morphed into poststructuralists to take on the critical project in two ways. First, they embraced the ubiquity of power through the disciplinary potential of leadership and management discourses (du Gay et al., 1996;

Fairhurst, 2007), while earlier constructionists (e.g., ethnomethodologists) would have waited for power to be occasioned (Boden, 1994). Second, they confronted issues of materiality more forcefully, specifically, the role of the body in performing leadership (Johansson et al., 2017; Sinclair, 2005) and the material presence of leadership more generally (Ford et al., 2017).

Sociomaterialists (e.g., CCO scholars) went a step further to argue against the artificiality of any social and material divide, arguing that "there is no social without the material, and no material that is not also social" (Cooren, 2018; Orlikowski, 2007, p. 1437). Especially with respect to leadership in a technological world, it is impossible to tell where one begins and the other leaves off (Ashcraft, 2022).

Critical theorists responded to critiques of arm-chair theorizing (Alvesson & Deetz, 1996) by moving into the field in at least two ways. First, they adopted the process orientation of constructionists through a focus on leadership dialectics while still retaining its focus on power (Collinson, 2005; for a review, Fairhurst & Collinson, 2023). Second, they embraced praxis with "critical performativity", addressing issues of power facing practitioners through a more affirmative public engagement (Alvesson & Spicer, 2012; Spicer et al., 2016).

Finally, the dialogic tradition embraced "practical theory", which accepts or rejects other traditions based on their utility for praxis (Argyris & Schön, 1996; Barge, 2001; Dewey, 1938). For example, Barge's (2014) pivotal leadership drew from a poststructuralist emphasis on material realities and bodies to assist with a reflexive analysis of a crisis. Barge and Fairhurst's (2008) "systemic story-making" used systems theory to understand how narratives and stories facilitate collective sensemaking. The dialogic tradition thus opens and closes itself to other traditions, depending on their praxis implications.

Three themes emerge from the evolving conversations among these perspectives. First, contra early organizational leadership research, communication is no longer secondary or epiphenomenal to leader cognition. It has emerged as a mode of explanation that is central, defining, and constitutive of leadership and followership. Especially with the publication of Fairhurst's (2007) *Discursive Leadership: In Conversation with Leadership Psychology*, a communicational mode of explanation emerged as coherent and viable. Fairhurst achieved this through demonstrating: 1) the organizing potential of little "d" discourse i.e., language and social interaction that ongoingly positions leaders and followers with respect to one another to achieve the dynamics of organizing anchored in task accomplishment; 2) the disciplinary power of big "D" leadership Discourses showing ubiquitous and paradoxical power effects, for

instance, how executive coaching Discourses reined in the alpha male leader at the same time it privileged him; and 3) the material basis of charismatic leadership, well beyond sophisticated linguistic appeals. The upshot of this work underscored the constitutive character of a communicational explanation through putting interpretive, critical, and sociomaterialist perspectives into dialogue with postpositivist leadership psychology.

Second, a constitutive focus has been a rising tide that lifts all boats. By that we mean that the role of communication has been elevated as a mode of explanation and object of study, even among postpositivist leadership approaches that historically cast communication as of secondary interest (e.g., Carol & Gillen, 1987). Indeed, in *Leadership Quarterly*, Liu et al.'s (2023, p. 2) postpositivist review suggest "looking under the hood" of most leadership theories today (e.g., charismatic, ethical, crisis leadership) to discover how central communication is to leadership effectiveness, although there is still work to be done. Several of today's surveys and scales strive to capture communication more complexly (e.g., Jian et al., 2014), even if leaders still come off as the primary symbolizing agents (e.g., Jacquart & Antonakis, 2015; Liu et al., 2023; Rego et al., 2024). Complex characterizations of communication are more apt to demonstrate its consequentiality (Sigman, 1995), its organizing potential (Taylor & Van Every, 2000), and the capacity to constitute organizational life, including that of leadership and encompassing phenomena like followership and authority (Craig, 1999; Fairhurst, 2007; Taylor & Van Every, 2014).

Third, leadership communication research is marked by a proliferation of theories and metatheoretic perspectives, each with distinct orientations. To postpositivists, this may seem piecemeal and faddish – antithetical to the broader accumulation of knowledge, formal modeling, and mathematics as the lingua franca of science (Antonakis et al., 2024; Pfeffer, 1993). For many wrestling with communication's complexity, however, physics envy of the natural sciences is a thing of the past (Van Maanen, 1995). Indeed, it is worth remembering that existing modes of social science explanation get supplanted by others because something is found lacking in extant theorizing (Deetz, 1994; Hassard et al., 2008).

Recalling our brief survey above, leadership communication as information transfer was supplanted by a focus on meaning, relationality, and co-construction. Why? The constitutive and aesthetic aspects of leadership were at stake here (Bennis & Nanus, 1985; Fairhurst & Uhl-Bien, 2012), but so was an overly romanticized view of leadership as "belief in the power of one" (Gronn, 2000, p. 319; Yukl, 1999). A meaning-centered model was useful until power's structural and disciplinary effects on

opaque, naturalized, or neutralized management communication could not be easily explained (Deetz, 1992; Frost, 1987). At stake here was the leadership literature's inability to fully reckon with issues of power, which assumes a number of intersecting forms well beyond influence tactics (Collinson, 2020; Collinson & Tourish, 2015). More recently, all aspects of a material world are capturing communicative effects beyond the linguistic realm (Cooren, 2018). Once again, extant research cannot adequately explain the role of leader and follower bodies and the hybridizing agency between humans and nonhumans in the production of leadership effects (Ashcraft, 2022; Ford et al., 2017). Finally, dialogic models of communication challenge all of these views because of an insufficient focus on reflexivity, the communicative basis of collective sensemaking on transformation, and the shifting and distributed nature of leadership and followership in such efforts (Barge, 2004; Cunliffe, 2002; Jian, 2022).

In short, what Collinson (2020, p. 14) said of power is true of communication: both in theory and practice, communication assumes "a plurality of simultaneous and intersecting forms, and thus is likely to require multiple interwoven theoretical frameworks". Regarding leadership, we have an added element: changing times place demands on the institution of leadership, witness the advent of globalization's impact on visionary leadership or the current era's search for authentic leadership amidst the "saying anything in the moment" post-truth leadership of Trump and Enron (Fairhurst et al., 2024). The ever-changing context of life in organizations (Hassard et al., 2008) is leadership's *raison d'être*. Its plasticity, and the communication theorizing that accompanies it, should come as no surprise.

That said, a multi-theoretic or multi-metatheoretic perspective on leadership communication is not automatically a recipe for more pop-up shop theorizing. On the contrary, Craig (1999, p. 124) argues that a view towards multiples can give "dialogic-dialectical coherence" to a field when: 1) researchers are aware of that which complements and that which produces tensions across theories or metatheoretic perspectives; and 2) they emerge in and through sustained dialogue with other theories and perspectives. Not unlike the parable of the blind men and the elephant, ideas about communication can oppose one another yet be interdependent.

Regarding the first point, we established complementarity through the constitutive principle (Craig, 1999), highlighting its consequentiality and organizing potential when different traditions strive for fulsome views of communication. We also showed a tensional field marked by debates over the inadequacy of information transfer over meaning creation; a sole focus on meaning to the exclusion of power; a focus on meaning and power absent an encompassing view of materiality; and a focus on theory

absent a focus on praxis. We established the second point's emphasis on dialogue by revealing how theoretical traditions have responded to criticisms leveled by the others.

However, there is yet another way to further the argument for a field of leadership communication research by articulating the emerging metadiscourse around it. It is a topic to which we now turn.

Leadership Communication as Metadiscourse

Drawing from the work of Taylor (1992), Craig (1999, p. 129) argues that all communication theory is "a kind of metadiscourse, a way of talking about talk…an open field of discourse engaged with the problems of communication as a social practice, a theoretical metadiscourse that emerges from, extends, and informs practical metadiscourse". To understand how this applies to leadership communication research as a field, we start with a very basic question: *how do we talk about leadership?*

A clue to answering this question lies in Greek mythology, specifically, with the sea god, Proteus, the most elusive of prophets. Proteus was a shapeshifter, known for contorting himself into a myriad of forms unless the captor could catch him unaware and hold fast. Only then would he give the hoped-for answer before seeking solace again in the sea. The word "protean" derives from this myth; it signifies the changeable or mutable nature of certain phenomena – much like leadership in modern times.

For example, consider the image of leadership in early psychological theories: men who led through command and control, mirroring their military service. By contrast, post-bureaucracy saw the rise of the putative "soft" skills of leaders. In neo-charisma theories, leadership morphed into heroes with seductive visions to woo the masses beyond their employment contracts. Then as organizations found religion through team-based systems and flatter hierarchies, leadership morphed into coaching, cheerleading, and resourcing. Leadership could also shift and distribute itself based on expertise so, at last, followers could be something more than passive audiences. In the era of Enron and Trumpian politics, post-truth leadership is an effort to win hearts and minds through emotional appeals, exaggerations, and lies, while authentic leadership tries to capture its antithesis. Leadership is morphing still as technology evolves and remote work, the child of the pandemic, introduces distance and mediated leader-follower images. Finally, unyielding change is producing paradoxical leadership where contradictions and paradoxes are the new normal and leaders acting consistently no longer matters.

Suffice it to say that Proteus walks amongst us as leadership scholars. We enact leadership in and through language games as "forms of life" (Wittgenstein, 1958). To

"talk the walk" as editors, we cannot proffer a right and final definition of leadership because definitions will be useful for some games with some purposes (Fairhurst et al., 2024: Grint et al., 2016).[2] Thus, as a first step in articulating a metadiscourse of leadership communication, we hold to Kelly's (2014) view that leadership is best seen as a family resemblance amongst power and influence-oriented language games. Our challenge as scholars is to interrogate the context of their use, which we try to do in this volume in several interesting ways.

A second basic question we must ask is, *how do we talk about leadership (and followership or other constituent) communication?* In their review of the postpositivist leader communication research, Liu et al. (2023) criticize it for lacking a clear definition of communication, decrying too many specific definitions (e.g., leader style or leader competence) or vague "I'll know it when I see it" inferences. Despite the ongoing claims of postpositivists over the doing of leadership science (e.g., Antonakis et al., 2024; Liu et al., 2023), there is no one best way to apprehend communication. Just as we must account for variety in leadership language games through definitional elasticity, we must also try to capture the multifarious nature of leader-follower communication. One of the best ways to do this is to focus on metatheoretic epistemologies (Deetz, 1996; Hassard et al., 2008) i.e., postpositivist, interpretive, sociomaterialist, critical, or dialogic – because they often ask different but interrelated questions about the communication between leaders and followers. In scope but also with methods and ways of establishing validity, these perspectives interrogate their communication in disparate yet interdependent ways.

Highlighting their differences, postpositivists often orient their communication questions around information transfer vis-à-vis prediction, statistical reduction, regularity, pattern recognition, and normalized communication experiences (Deetz, 1973). Interpretivists turn to the sociocultural, sensemaking, sensegiving, shared versus equifinal meaning, and the specific means by which social realities come into being. Sociomaterialists focus on a material world, the technological realm, hybrid agency, and the indecipherability of social and material actants. Critical scholars emphasize the sociohistorical, sources of domination, asymmetry or distorted communication, the manufacturing of consent, normalization, and emancipation. Finally, dialogue scholars look to unmake hardened realities, focus on language a system of distinctions and privilege, surface mental models to question assumptions, and commit to democratic, ethical, and authentic interactions.

Highlighting their interrelatedness, consider an information transfer view of leader communication, a favorite among postpositivists. Who would deny that this view

doesn't also presume leader-follower co-constructed meaning in interaction à la the interpretivists? Or leaders' asymmetric power to define "the situation here and now" à la the critical scholars? Consider critical, interpretive, or dialogic views of leadership communication. Who would deny elements of information transfer, especially in a technological world of drive-by social media, giving and receiving technical instructions, or any communication in which technology's role was blackboxed (made invisible) à la the sociomaterialists?

Metatheory silences on opposing aspects of communication do not negate them. On the contrary, they account for the evolving nature of communication beyond hypodermic needle models of leaders as the only symbolizing agents for undifferentiated, passive followers (Carol & Gillen, 1987); viewing communication as epiphenomenal, in which the "real work" of leadership is individualistic, cognitive, and rational (cf. Fairhurst, 2007); static models of leader-follower communication that fail to capture the constitutive and processual dynamics (Fairhurst & Uhl-Bien, 2012; Fairhurst et al., 1995); communication that floats ethereally above task accomplishment (Robinson, 2001); or seeing the only function of communication as clarity without understanding the organizing potential of ambiguity (Eisenberg, 1984).

Each communication metatheory converts to a set of discursive resources for leadership researchers. They name the communication practicalities of interest, justify the research questions they inspire, pose standard arguments around the view of communication they embrace, silence themselves on others and, over time, counter and/or co-opt arguments on opposing communication stances that are also true. Of course, they also suggest methods, project praxis outcomes, and suggest directions for future research that set the stage for testing more assumptions, more co-optation, and so on.

For this reason, Deetz (1996) argues for treating metatheoretic or paradigmatic perspectives as discourses i.e., more or less interesting ways of talking about a subject. The debates within and between discourses are ongoing, tensional, often conflictual, and without clearly demarcated boundaries. Researchers eschew strict prototypes because they "gather at the crossroads" through mixing their metaphors, sponging from other discourses, and dodging criticism through cooptation (p. 199). Of course, Deetz wasn't writing about leadership communication per se, but he could have been.

Thus, a third foundational question for a leadership communication metadiscourse is, *what do we see, think, and talk about with respect to leadership and followership with one metatheoretical discourse over another?* (Deetz, 2001). Viewing metatheoretic perspectives as discourses minimizes their reification and helps reclaim

their complementarities, tensions, and debates (Deetz, 1996). On the subject of demonstrating complementarities, Fairhurst's (2007) discursive leadership is an early example of interwoven interpretive, critical, and sociomaterialist perspectives, while more recently Ashcraft (2022) interweaves interpretive, critical, sociomaterialist, and postpositivist views of communication. Ashcraft (2022) critiques a distinctively 21st-century hypermasculinity wrought by the internet's ability to intensify feelings of entitlement and resentment, increasing strains toward global authoritarian leadership, and the myth of impermeable bodies in a technological world. For the organizational context, the communicability of feeling via technological means creates a viral hypermasculinity that reinforces the longstanding trope, "think leader, think male" in today's society. It informs charismatic, transformational, and visionary leadership by directing us less to the psychologistic (e.g., intellectual stimulation, idealized influence, inspirational motivation) and more to the embodied, connected, material, and sociohistorical. Indeed, a focus on the sensorial may better explain the contagion of charismatic leadership, especially in a technology-heavy era. Her rich view of communication is thus anchored in shared meaning, manufactured consent, and asymmetric power, to be sure. But it is also rooted in a postpositivist view of communication as information transfer through technology's sensorial effects. Such an accomplishment could not be achieved unless there was metatheoretic dialogue around opposing yet interdependent ideas around communication, along with at least an implicit recognition of a metadiscourse.

On the subject of reclaiming tensions and debates within and between metatheoretic perspectives, as editors we have a longstanding commitment to metatheoretic plurality in previous reviews and discussions (Fairhurst et al., 2024; Jian & Fairhurst, 2019, 2017). We remain committed to do so in this volume. In the next section we explain our choices of topics, orient readers to the book's structure, and provide chapter previews.

The Organization of the Handbook

This handbook differs from other handbooks or reviews that are more generally focused on communication in organizations (Miller & Poole, 2024), more generally focused on leadership (Schedlitzki et al., 2023), postpositivist leader communication (Liu et al., 2023), or issues of leadership power (Knights et al., 2024). For us, the broad question: *what and how do communication theories and research inform our understanding and practice of leadership?* guides our efforts in choosing topics for this volume. More specifically, our topic selection followed an abductive process (i.e., iteration between

deduction and induction). In a deductive sense, we look for theoretical developments that resemble the metadiscursive crossroads where communication theories intersect, and are productively in dialogue with, leadership theories. Inductively, we aim to take stock of empirical research that surfaces key relational contexts and communicative practices in and through which leadership is constituted and understood. The result of this abductive iteration is the three parts that we briefly preview next: theory, context, and practice.

Theory

As a formative field of study, leadership communication does not possess ready-made theories or neatly packaged frameworks. Rather, at this intellectual crossroads between communication and leadership research, rich theoretical insights have emerged from the dialogue and crosscutting efforts by scholars in diverse social science disciplines who challenge conventional leadership understandings. The ten chapters included in this part intend to capture several growing theoretical streams in which communication approaches have made significant contributions to widening and, in most cases, deepening or innovatively re-framing our metadiscourses of leadership.

More specifically, one radical shift in leadership theorizing has been to move from a predominant individual-based leader focus to one that attempts to locate leadership as a property of the collective, otherwise known as collective leadership. How do communicative approaches advance theories of collective leadership? Following Ospina et al. (2020), Souza and Jackson in Chapter 1 address this question by presenting two communicative approaches of studying collective leadership either as a "type" or a "lens". For the former, scholars pay attention to the communicative construction of various types of collective leadership, such as team leadership or dual/co-leadership while the latter focuses on the performative process of accomplishing leadership collectively irrespective of leadership types or formal leadership roles. Their review also underscores challenging conceptual questions about the role of power in collective leadership and the conundrum of the potential disintegration of leadership as a concept in collective contexts (Denis et al., 2012; Fairhurst et al., 2020).

As a collective endeavor, organizing requires the coordination of diverse goals, interests, relational dynamics, and conflicting interpretations of reality. Dialogue, as Barge observes in Chapter 2, is the crucial form of leadership communication that helps achieve such coordination. He goes on to delineate two streams of dialogical

leadership: one focuses on leading dialogue as structured communicative interventions designed for facilitating organizational learning through reflective inquiry, while the other represents an approach to leadership as developing relationally-responsive practices and coordinating complex conversational flows.

Adding complexity to our theories of organizing, dialectics and paradoxes are increasingly recognized as both challenges and sources of positive change and innovation. It can be argued that managing complex dialectics and paradoxes often provides the crucible for leadership. By introducing organizational theories of dialectics and paradoxes, Fairhurst in Chapter 3 explores leadership communication praxis in experiencing and leveraging dialectics and paradoxes ranging from dialogic organizational interventions and conflict management to the development of communication-centered paradox skill set. She draws attention to how dialectics and paradoxes can intertwine and, thus, pose challenges for researchers to unravel their complexity and for leadership actors to manage their potent effects.

To delve deeper into the collective and sociomaterial nature of leadership, Clifton and Barfod introduce and extend a theoretical perspective known as the communicative constitution of organization (CCO) to theorizing leadership as distributed in both human and other-than-human actants. Through an exemplar of analyzing naturally occurring interaction between soldiers in a military operation, the authors effectively demonstrate how ventriloquism as a communicative lens sheds light on the achievement of leadership in situ by humans together with other-than-human actants.

Along with CCO and other prominent approaches to theorizing leadership, Carroll in Chapter 5 juxtaposes leadership-as-practice (LAP), one of the latest strands of leadership theories, which conceptualizes leadership as emergent accomplishment in embodied and materially mediated social practices (Raelin, 2016). Noting the curious absence of the word "communication" in LAP research thus far, she aims to tease out the ways in which communicative practice constitutes the very moment and flow of leadership as practice. To reclaim and more fully appreciate the communicative practice, she argues, would require a more holistic methodology that goes beyond previously predominant interview-based LAP research.

Although the theoretical streams previewed so far have more or less noted the role of power and authority in leadership, the next two chapters focus squarely on the mutual shaping between power asymmetry and leadership communication. Drawing upon critical theories Collinson in Chapter 6 shows that not only toxic leadership communication but also Prozac (i.e., excessively positive) leadership communication can be coercive and detrimental. He also highlights the dialectic nature of power in

creating control and resistance moves as often enacted in contradictory leader and follower communication. In Chapter 7, Tourish further extends the critical tradition to draw attention to the dark side of leadership and reveal the communicative mechanisms by which destructive leaders manipulate power, conceal, and alter reality for their own gain. His penetrating analysis provides a sobering reality check to a world saturated by positive leadership biases.

Taking a different critical route to engage organizational ethics, Bisel and Mahutga in Chapter 8 observe that organizations often suffer from a state of moral mindlessness, an inability to notice ethical concerns and an absence of ethical deliberation here and now, resulting in detrimental moral and organizational failures. To tackle this challenge, the authors put forth a theory of ethically-reliable organization in which they conceive leadership communication practices central in promoting moral mindfulness and here-and-now ethics talk.

The remaining two chapters in Part I offer insights into the integral nature of communication to two leadership processes: identity formation and social influence. Eschewing the common psychologized view of leadership identity, Sheep in Chapter 9 theorizes how a leader identity can take shape in what he terms "identity-constitutive leadership communication" that brings "clarity and focus in the face of muddy, complex (wicked, paradoxical) problems" (p. 120). He further illustrates how such leader identity formation works in crisis contexts and in the debate of moral leadership. In Chapter 10, drawing parallels between communication and leadership scholarship in their historical evolvement, Gigliotti and Ruben see the convergence of these two bodies of scholarship in their common concern with the production of social influence. Building on this convergence, they theorize the reciprocal influence between leaders and members through a series of communicative mechanisms of resonance, such as activation, cultivation, and reinforcement, embedded in larger organizational and sociocultural contexts.

As shown above, the chapters in Part I not only share a common interest in theorizing communication in the collective production of leadership but also suggest that understanding the contexts in which the collective is defined and operates be integral to theorizing and practicing leadership communication. The next part of the Handbook turns to the empirical research of leadership communication organized around significant leadership contexts.

Context

Context matters. As Fairhurst (2011) argues, "leaders must figure out what leadership is in the context of what they do" (p. 8). Existing leadership literature has conceptualized context in varied ways. In leadership psychology studies, for example, context is often conceived as a container of constraining or enabling factors moderating leadership behaviors, whereas discursive leadership studies tend to treat context as both interactional resources and achievement through leadership communication, that is, a reflexive relationship between leadership and context (Fairhurst, 2009).

Not meant to be exhaustive, the eight chapters included in Part II intend to highlight commonly researched leadership contexts, not in the sense of containers of leadership communication, but what leadership scholars have foregrounded in their investigations. Each chapter aims to present an exemplary review of the key literature in relation to a given context. Part II starts with the context of dyadic leader-member exchange (LMX). Based on a prolific body of empirical research, Omilion-Hodges in Chapter 11 explicates the communicative nature of LMX and its outcomes. Recognizing the relational contexts at work exist more like a matrix than neatly stacked layers, Omilion-Hodges emphasizes how LMX is intricately related to peer and team relationships. Also taking the dyadic relational context as a starting point, Long in Chapter 12 explores how leadership manifests in the context of mentoring. Her comprehensive review distills leadership communication practices that enact both the traditional dyadic model and alternative forms of mentorship, such as group-based collaborative mentoring and mentoring networks.

Moving beyond the dyadic context in Chapter 13, Lehmann-Willenbrock and Hemshorn de Sanchez intend to capture the dynamic of both formal and informal leadership communication in teams as a central organizing form. While research on the former focuses on communication styles and characteristics of titled team leaders, the latter has garnered growing insights into how verbal and nonverbal communication features among team members contribute to leadership emergence. The authors reflect on how embedding temporal considerations can significantly enhance our knowledge about leadership communication in team settings.

Adding complexity to leadership contexts, virtual work and hybrid work have become increasingly prevalent since the COVID-19 pandemic. How does communication shape leadership and leadership outcomes in these contexts? In Chapter 14, Connaughton, Funkhouser, and Brooks set out to address this question by tracing the emergence of virtual leadership communication. Their empirical review highlights the tensions and paradoxes that virtual leadership has to engage as well as the impact of virtual leadership and dispersed work arrangements on equity and inclusion.

Beyond contexts of organizing internally, to confront increasingly complex societal challenges such as poverty and climate change, interorganizational collaboration (IOC) is a growing arrangement that often spans multiple industry sectors and professions. In Chapter 15, Koschmann draws upon CCO to explain how communication works as a central process in which authority and leadership emerge to enable collective action and decision making among voluntary organizational actors. He then highlights several IOC leadership challenges, including establishing trust and legitimacy, cultivating interaction through communication design, and conducting boundary work.

Besides contexts in terms of organizational levels, changes in market, strategy, and power also serve as contexts that demand and transform leadership. What then is the nature of leadership communication in the context of change and how does it impact change? To address these questions, Jian in Chapter 16 presents three forms of leadership communication as change information management, influential communicative performance, and discursive struggle over power and control, respectively. Each form is shown to carry its distinct implications for change leadership practitioners.

Organizational change is invariably associated with resistance. Although resistance often takes on a negative connotation or remains as a backdrop in much of the mainstream leadership and management literature, Ban, Zoller, and Nandurkar in Chapter 17 foreground resistance by contrasting a managerial view of resistance with critical perspectives of resistance vis-à-vis leadership. Taking a dialectical approach to power and resistance, they illustrate how *resistance to leadership* and *resistance leadership* are two viable lines of inquiry that counter the conventional managerial approaches to resistance.

Finally, crises are contexts in which uncertainty and perceived threat dominate and demand leadership for active sensemaking and immediate response. To effectively manage crises, Seeger and Littlefield in Chapter 18 describe five communication activities key to crisis leadership, including monitoring and risk sensing, sensemaking and sensegiving, decision making and crisis management, recovery and renewal, and learning and preparing for future crisis. As they argue, crisis communication is an essential part of the leadership skill set in contemporary organizations as multiple crisis events often converge with unforeseen consequences.

Practice

We title Part III with the term "practice" not intending to denote the opposite of "theory" or practical application of theory. Rather, practice here refers to lines of empirical inquiries organized around leadership communication practices aimed at their cultivation through research and meta-theoretical reflection. As Craig (2007) argues, "communication itself [is] a socially constructed practice and communication theory [is] a practical way of participating in a societal discourse about the norms of that practice" (p. 127). The reviews offered by the chapters in this section serve as metadiscourses of leadership communication practices grounded in social scientific research. In the following we preview these topics.

The first two chapters of this section focus on the discursive practices of leadership communication. Chapter 19, by Shank Jr., Omilion-Hodges, and Miller, offers a careful comparison of four social scientific approaches to framing as an essential leadership practice and skill in constructing reality and making and giving sense. In Chapter 20, Van De Mieroop and Schnurr focus on the workings of leadership narrative. Through two analytical exemplars the authors richly demonstrate how narrative helps construct leadership identity and achieve leadership interactionally.

Going beyond the discursive practices, Wåhlin-Jacobsen and Larsson in Chapter 21 explore how materiality, embodiment, and aesthetics constitute leadership communication. Their review assembles research showing how outward appearance, gestures, non-human objects, spatial positioning of the body, and aesthetic sensual perception, for example, contribute to the construction of leadership in powerful ways. Concentrating on materiality, Stephens and Xu in Chapter 22 grapple with how information and communication technologies (e.g., enterprise social media) and automation (e.g., technologies driven by artificial intelligence) evolve and alter power configurations in the workplace, thus both influencing and being reconstituted by leadership communication practices. Extending our understanding of the embodiment of leadership communication in Chapter 23, Myers, Davis, and Seibold zoom into the processes and functions of emotion and humor. Conceptualizing emotion as enacted through communication, they illustrate how emotion functions in the complex leader-follower relational dynamic. They also explicate the motives and contexts in which humor is deployed as a forceful leadership communication strategy.

While the five chapters (Chapters 19–23) previewed so far illuminate the discursive, sociomaterial, and embodied aspects of communication practices, the next three chapters (Chapters 24–26) deal with organizational challenges that leadership communication practices can help address in systematic ways. These challenges include managing diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI), organizational learning, and strategy.

First, Buzzanell and Pyatovskaya in Chapter 24 explain why DEI is critical for leadership when operating and competing in an increasingly diverse world. They then explore ways in which leadership communication practices can contribute to the implementation of DEI. To succeed, the authors argue, would require radical transformation in our conception and construction of leadership. Second, for organizations to develop and grow, learning is a practical challenge that Fyke and Schmisseur address in Chapter 25. Their review sheds light on the learning-leadership connection by zooming into communication at individual, team, and organizational levels of learning along with challenges posed by evaluation and technological advances. Finally, developing and executing organizational strategies are essential organizing practices. Integrating the latest research with first-hand insights from industry leaders, Argenti and Haynes in Chapter 26 articulate how strategic leadership, strategic thinking, and strategic communication connect and form the core competencies of strategy making and execution.

The Future of Leadership Communication Research

Although communication has long been a prized skill for leadership, rigorous and systematic examination of leadership communication from social science perspectives has been relatively recent. As indicated earlier, past leadership handbooks and reviews either left communication entirely unattended or treated communication in rather narrow or tangential ways. We hope that the chapters in this handbook, as previewed above, capture the burgeoning body of scholarship of leadership communication. We also hope that this handbook can serve as an authoritative and comprehensive resource for scholars, students, and practitioners alike on the subject, while being able to stimulate interdisciplinary dialogue for future research.

Designed to spur this dialogue, each chapter offers suggestions for future research on its specific topic or area of research. What we intend to do in the following is to propose several general directions for future research that may cut across a range of topics within organizational leadership communication. First of all, we argue that advancing leadership communication research requires that scholars further confront the often messy and paradoxical nature of organizing and organizational life. Instead of reducing and segmenting our literature into neat binaries like informal/formal, transformational/transactional, and ethical/abusive leadership categories (Collinson, 2005), future research should capture and theorize leadership practices entangled in an organizational world where contradictions and paradoxes are the norm – where

binaries coexist and form interdependencies, or shade into one another. This handbook has taken some steps in this direction. For example, Chapter 3 by Fairhurst on dialectics and paradoxes and Chapter 5 by Carroll on leadership-in-practice offer important theoretical and analytical resources; Chapter 11 by Omilion-Hodges shows how conventional leadership categories like LMX, team leadership, and peer relationships intersect to form complex relational matrix and effect leadership dynamic; and Chapter 15 by Koschmann illuminates leadership as emerging from a process of authority in interorganizational collaborations where competition and collaboration often coexist to define stakeholder relationships. By building on these developments, we wish future research can offer more robust theoretical accounts of leadership communication that better resonate with the actual lived experience of leading and following, which is more complex and dynamic than that presented in much of the existing research.

Second, as critical scholars (e.g., Alvesson, 2020; Alvesson & Blom, 2022; Alvesson & Einola, 2019; Learmonth & Morrell, 2021) incisively observe, the broader leadership scholarship in general suffers from a positive bias, often producing hagiographic accounts that portray leaders as "saviors" possessing god-like characteristics (i.e., authentic, transformational, servant-oriented, humble, charismatic, etc.) with positive outcomes (e.g., follower and organizational performance). Critical scholars caution that such scholarship is not only questionable in their scientific quality, divorced from reality, and misleading, but also runs the risk of turning itself into an ideology in service of managerial control and hegemony (Alvesson & Blom, 2022; Learmonth & Morrell, 2021). Sensitive to this concern, although not completely immune from it, the research presented in this handbook endeavors to address and counter the positive bias in several ways. For example, to avoid perpetuating the romance of either the leader or follower, the majority of our contributors' chapters take seriously the mutually dependent roles of leaders and followers in shaping the leadership communication process. Also, several chapters extend the critical tradition to deconstruct Prozac leadership (Chapter 6), uncover the communicative production of dark side leadership (Chapter 7), and the control and resistance dialectic (Chapter 6 and Chapter 17). To further counter the positive bias, future research should integrate critical lens sensitivities into all its theorizing and investigation of leadership communication. For example, research should not only pay more attention to power but also to the simultaneous functioning of multiple forms of power, such as episodic power and systemic power (see Chapter 17) in exerting influence. Following Alvesson (2020), researchers should use "leadership vocabularies sensitively" (p. 10), for instance, by practicing reflexivity (e.g., asking whether the leadership language by researchers

themselves naturalizes inequality in the workplace). Moreover, instead of drawing simplistic conclusions regarding leadership outcomes devoid of complex social contexts, future research should critically trace both intended and unintended consequences of leadership actions as contexts and power relationships evolve over time.

Speaking of time, our third suggestion draws greater attention to the temporality of leadership communication. Several chapters in the handbook have touched upon temporality either explicitly (e.g., as speaking time in Chapter 12 on team leadership) or implicitly (e.g., as stages of crisis leadership in Chapter 18 and change leadership in Chapter 16, or as turn-taking in conversational analysis in Chapter 4 on CCO and Chapter 20 on leadership narratives). However, we should move beyond an understanding of temporality as clock time and focus more on the qualitative and intersubjective time as social construction (Dawson, 2014; Jian, 2019; Karlsen, 2023), the timeliness of communication (Jian, 2019), the temporal rhythm (Fisher et al., 2018), the allocation of temporal resources as capital (Ernst, 2023), and the synchronization and management of individual temporal differences/diversity and group temporal norms in pacing style, urgency, and future time perspectives (Mohammed & Nadkarni, 2011), to name a few. Examining and incorporating these temporal elements would greatly enrich our understanding of communication in constituting leadership and shaping organizational life.

Finally, one of the advancements of leadership communication research we discussed earlier is a sociomaterial understanding of communication that constitutes leadership. Several chapters in this handbook have elucidated this both theoretically (e.g., Chapter 4 on CCO) and through empirical reviews (e.g., Chapter 21 on materiality, embodiment, and aesthetics of leadership communication). However, our current coverage only scratches the surface. Future research could unleash its potential in several ways. First, certain topics can significantly benefit from a sociomaterial emphasis. For example, when examining leadership communication in relation to new automation and AI-powered technologies (Chapter 22), a sociomaterial emphasis is indispensable in unraveling the entanglement of the discursive, performative, and material dimensions. Similar arguments can be made about future research on such topics as virtual and hybrid work (Chapter 14) and organizational learning (Chapter 25) where fast advancing technological/material elements constantly reconfigure with the conflict-ridden and political human elements through communication. Furthermore, as demonstrated in previous research, the sociomaterial performance by organizational actors not only helps construct paradoxes but also shapes tensional responses (Chapter

3; Fairhurst & Collinson, 2023). Thus, addressing sociomateriality is a necessary step in advancing our understanding of the paradoxes and tensions involved in leadership communication.

In conclusion, we hope that the *Routledge Handbook of Organizational Leadership Communication* demonstrates the richness of this fast-developing research field. More importantly, we would be gratified to see if the knowledge assembled here can serve as heuristic lenses to speed up future scholarly work and enable innovative leadership actions.

Notes

1. This handbook will focus on leadership communication in relation to organizations and organizing, excluding areas such as politics and social movements, given the unique leadership challenges associated with these social contexts.⏎
2. However, the definition by DeRue (2011, p. 126) comes closest. Leadership is "a social interaction process where individuals engage in repeated leading–following interactions, and through these interactions, co-construct identities and relationships as leaders and followers. These leader–follower identities and relationships are influenced but not entirely constrained by formal authority structures, such that the direction of influence in leading–following interactions can move up, down, and/or lateral in formal organizational structures." This definition tries to capture leadership's plasticity through formal and informal relationships, although it elides issues of materiality and asymmetric power.⏎

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PART I

Theory

1

LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION FROM COLLECTIVE LEADERSHIP APPROACHES

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-3

Introduction

Collective leadership scholarship incorporates several theoretical perspectives on leadership, each underpinned by different ontological and epistemological assumptions. This umbrella term includes a wide variety of "adjective-based" forms of leadership, which most prominently includes shared, distributed, networked, plural, collaborative, integrative, processual and complexity leadership (Ospina et al., 2020). Despite their different assumptions about what leadership is and how we can know it, these approaches attempt to redefine leadership as a property of the collective (e.g., a group, organization, social system), they bring social interactions to the fore, they view leadership as being co-constructed in multiple configurations, and they all hold a rich appreciation of context (Jackson & Parry, 2018).

The rapidly growing body of literature devoted to collective leadership has demonstrated the range and depth of theoretical and empirical research that conceptualizes and examines leadership as a fundamentally communicative and discursive activity. The emphasis that is placed on leadership being an "interactive process" essentially highlights the central role that communication plays in creating collective leadership (Fairhurst et al., 2020). Leadership communication scholarship that is informed by collective leadership theories has emphasized how leadership is communicatively and discursively constituted in interactions and through the

relationships of organizational actors (e.g., Fairhurst & Connaughton, 2014; Tourish, 2014).

The investigation of communicative processes and mechanisms in accomplishing collective leadership has taken different approaches, depending on how scholars conceptualize where to look for leadership, the "locus of leadership," and how they conceptualize the collective, that is, their view of "collectivity" (Ospina et al., 2020). Accordingly, the first aim of this chapter is to analyze and compare distinct approaches to investigate communicative processes and mechanisms from collective leadership theories, depending on how researchers conceptualize leadership (e.g., either leadership as primarily a "type" or primarily as a "lens"). Depending on the approach taken, quite different insights about leadership are yielded that have substantially different implications for practicing leadership communication.

Additionally, the studies that acknowledge the communicational dimension of leadership and provide researchers with accounts of how leadership is shaped by actors linguistically have had to deal with two important and interrelated issues: the place of power in collective leadership approaches and the methodological consequences of defining leadership as a property of the collective that these perspectives bring to the fore (Denis et al., 2012). Although some of these contributions do indeed acknowledge the poignancy of power issues in the collective, communicative, relational, and contextual production of leadership, most theorists tend to overlook power relations (Tourish, 2014). In view of this shortfall, the second aim of this chapter is to analyze the research (or lack of) that investigates power in communicative and discursive collective leadership approaches. Additionally, we aim to discuss the implication of these power-based aspects in leadership communication practice and lay out an agenda for future research.

Approaching leadership as a dynamic phenomenon that is enacted communicatively brings to the fore the need for methodologies that allow the observation of interactions and capture the relational and communicative dynamics as they are happening in situ (Denis et al., 2012). Therefore, the third aim of this chapter is to analyze how methodological choices, and the use of multiple and more sophisticated methods, have made possible the investigation of discursive/communicative collective leadership. We will show that changes in how leadership is linguistically performed have enacted new methodological approaches. These are dedicated to analyzing the specific discursive processes through which leadership is accomplished at the micro level of interaction. We will discuss the implications of this theory-method alignment for practicing leadership communication and formulate an agenda for future research.

Communication in Collective Leadership Approaches

The investigation of communicative processes and mechanisms in accomplishing collective leadership has taken distinct approaches, depending on how researchers decide to study the collective nature of leadership (Ospina et al., 2020). Along one dimension, some approaches are grounded in an analytical intention to explore where leadership is located or situated (e.g., the "locus of leadership"). These look for leadership either within the group or within the system. The second dimension relates to how scholars conceptualize human relations and interactions (i.e., their view of what "collectivity" means). Those who view leadership as a "type" stress the role played by organizational actors in the communicative processes and mechanisms. However, those who view leadership as a "lens" place the emphasis upon leadership as a fluid process emerging from the communicatively constituted interactions of organizational actors, regardless of their formal organizational roles.

Communicative Approaches that see Collective Leadership as a "Type"

Scholars who view leadership as a "type," residing in the group or in the system, have investigated communicative processes using collective leadership theories such as shared leadership, team leadership, distributed leadership, and complexity leadership. Table 1.1 summarizes the most significant contributions made by collective leadership researchers who have approached leadership as a particular "type." This table highlights what types of communication are the primary foci of this research as well the wide range of theoretical frameworks and methodologies that underpin their analyses. Scholars have focused on analyzing specific discursive practices (Clifton, 2017; Thomas et al., 2011; Weibler & Endres, 2010), as well as leadership and communicative behaviors (Friedrich et al., 2009; Friedrich et al., 2016; Kramer & Crespy, 2011; Vine et al., 2008). They tend to be guided by questions such as, "how are leaders doing (or how should they do) leadership?"; "how does a designated leader enact his or her role?"; or "how are identities constructed in interaction?" (Larsson, 2016). Consequently, despite the interest in investigating collective leadership processes, such scholarship tends to be very person-centered and generally places emphasis upon "leaders" or "followers" and their distinctive role in the communicative process of leadership construction.

Table 1.1 Representative communicative approaches to collective leadership as a "type"

Authors	*Collective leadership emphasis*	*Communication focus in collective leadership*	*Theoretical framework/methodology*
Vine et al. (2008)	Co-leadership: the process by which two leaders in vertically contiguous positions share the responsibilities of leadership	• Examination of speech practices of leaders in their interactions with their followers to show how leadership is performed • Task and maintenance leadership behaviors • How leaders talk ~~to~~ reinforce their position as leaders	Interactional sociolinguistics /Ethnography
Friedrich et al. (2009)	Collective leadership as a function of selectively utilizing the information or specialized expertise that individuals within a network possess	Bi-directional and uni-directional communication impacts group process related to collective leadership. • Bi-directional o Consultation o Feedback exchange o Information sharing • Uni-directional o Direction-giving language o Meaning-making language o Empathetic language	Integrated framework for understanding collective leadership process/Conceptual development

Authors	*Collective leadership emphasis*	*Communication focus in collective leadership*	*Theoretical framework/methodology*
Weibler & Rohn-Endres (2010)	Shared network leadership: Interplay between individual and collective network leadership	Emergence of shared network leadership through generative dialogue, which emerges after three stages of a learning conversation: • Talking nice • Talking tough • Reflective dialogue • Generative dialogue	Learning conversation/ Grounded theory
Larson & Lundholm (2010)	Team leadership	How managers and their subordinates talk in the reconciling of agendas for action, negotiation, and resistance	Conversation analysis-Observation of meetings
Thomas, Sargent & Hardy (2011)	Group interactions and meaning negotiation in an organizational change process	Communicative practices that promote either generative dialogue or degenerative dialogue: • Inviting • Affirming • Clarifying • Building • Dismissing • Reiterating • Deploying authority • Invoking hierarchy • Reifying • Proposing • Challenging • Undermining • Holding to account	Organizational becoming/non-participant observation, semi-structured interviews, documents analysis

Authors	*Collective leadership emphasis*	*Communication focus in collective leadership*	*Theoretical framework/methodology*
Kramer & Crespy (2011)	Collaborative (shared) leadership	Communication behaviors and processes use to create collaborative leadership: • Framing situations or problems • Motivating group members to action • Working through dialogue to minimize power differences • Empowering groups	Collaborative leadership/Ethnography
Larson & Lundholm (2013)	Team leadership	Role of communication in creating collective identities	Conversation analysis/ Observation of meetings
Friedrich et al. (2016)	Dimensions of collective leadership behaviors: Communication, Network Development, and Leader-Team Exchange	Leader's communication behaviors: • Feedback exchange • Information sharing • Communication norms • Voice • Consultation	Collective leadership framework/Psychometric measurements of intelligence, personality, as well as biographical data such as age, gender, prior experience in organizations, and leadership experiences; Leadership simulation tasks

Authors	*Collective leadership emphasis*	*Communication focus in collective leadership*	*Theoretical framework/methodology*
Clifton (2017)	Distributed leadership as social practice	• Linguistic space in which the participants communicatively constitute the organization • Distributed leadership in decision making talk • Leader and follower fluid identities.	Discursive Approach to leadership/Meeting recordings and fine-grained analysis of sequences of talk
Leach et al. (2021)	Distributed leadership	Effective communication: • Timely communication • Clear messaging between departments resulting in improved care delivery • Open communication model Communication breakdown: • Poorly written communication (i.e., incomplete patient notes) • Problems with verbal communication (i.e., no follow-up, communication gaps) • Disconnected leaders	Social identity theory/ semi-structured interviews

Authors	*Collective leadership emphasis*	*Communication focus in collective leadership*	*Theoretical framework/methodology*
Jian (2022)	Empathy construction in relational leadership	• Empathetic leadership through synchronic and diachronic practice • Synchronic practice: Embodied conversational practice by which co-present leadership actors achieve an understanding of the other's perspective and emotional state • Diachronic practice: Narrative practice across time and space by which leadership actors facilitate the understanding of members of one social group toward a collective other's perspective and emotional state	Social constructionist approach to empathy/ Conceptual development

While they are also interested in studying discursive practices, some contributions in the "leadership as a type" stream have also added empirical work to their reflections. In particular, Weibler and Rohn-Endres (2010) argue that the emergence of shared network leadership is dependent on the specific support of individuals who are concerned about designing network context and conditions for learning conversations. Similarly, Thomas et al. (2011) develop a model showing how the intersection of particular communicative practices by the two groups of managers led to different dynamics in the negotiation of meaning that have implications for organizational change. In the same vein, Clifton (2017) shows how leader and follower identities are fluid and that leadership identity is achieved in talk, shifting on a turn-by-turn basis so that everybody can potentially lead. In this way the management of meaning is negotiated.

Some contributions within this stream of research have focused on the role of leadership and communicative behaviors. For example, Vine et al. (2008) have

highlighted the communication dimension of leadership to illustrate how co-leadership talk and conversations promote task accomplishment and the maintenance of relationships within the group. For the authors, leaders orient themselves to different facets of leadership according to the specific context in which they are operating as well as in a process of dynamic interplay with their co-leaders. Kramer and Crespy (2011) have examined the specific communication behaviors and processes used to create collaborative leadership, exploring how the leader's attitudes, behaviors, and communication supported collaboration and how the group members participated in creating a collaborative culture. Similarly, Friedrich et al. (2009; 2016) have suggested that, through communication, the leader exchanges information and expertise with the team, which serves to shape team parameters and affective climate.

These authors also assert that the leader's characteristics, such as intelligence, experience, and personality, will determine how capable they are in building the network and communication conditions that facilitate the emergence of collective leadership. They will also determine the degree to which the leader can recognize the opportunity and advantages of exchanging elements of the leadership role between team members. Consequently, communication is the means through which the leadership role is shared and plays a key part in creating the conditions of trust that facilitate the emergence of leaders and the ability of the focal leader to pass the role to others. Other contributions such as Larsson and Lundholm (2010; 2013) explore how leadership is enacted in talk-in-interaction.

Communicative Approaches that see Leadership as a "Lens"

Some scholars invoke a "lens" approach to studying leadership. They are more inclined to investigate how leadership is actually performed linguistically. Table 1.2 summarizes the most significant contributions that have been made by scholars who take a communicative perspective that approached leadership as a "lens." This table highlights the types of communication that are at the forefront of this research as well as a similarly diverse range of theoretical frameworks and methodologies that underpin these studies that were evidenced in Table 1.1. From a "lens" approach, leadership resides either in interpersonal relationships or in systemic dynamics (Ospina et al., 2020). They tend to be more interested in answering questions such as "where is leadership happening?," "who is participating in these processes (and who is not)?," "how is this (discursively and usually collectively) accomplished?," and "what responses do the various claims for leadership generate?" (Schnurr & Schroeder,

2019). This lens has enabled inquiry into flows that represent the co-active moments of leadership (e.g., Sklaveniti, 2020); the emergence of informal leadership through talk, gaze, use of space and artifacts (e.g., Van De Mieroop et al., 2020); the examination of discursive moments, strategies and devices (e.g., Carroll & Simpson, 2012; Gordon, 2010; Holm & Fairhurst, 2018; Wodak et al., 2011); the performative effects of turning points in the flow of ordinary conversation (e.g., Simpson et al., 2018); the leadership effects produced during interaction (e.g., Sergi, 2016); and the advocation of conversational dynamics that can identify leadership without the need to identify specific individual roles (Ramsey, 2016).

Table 1.2 Representative communicative approaches to collective leadership as a "lens"

Authors	*Collective leadership emphasis*	*Communication focus in collective leadership*	*Theoretical framework/methodology*
Sklaveniti (2020)	Collective leadership team processes Collective co-action	Flow of conversations that represents the co-active moments of leadership: • Invitation • Exploration • Affirmation	Gergen's work on responsive interplay/Observation (non-participant, synchronous observation of meetings, asynchronous observation of online communication platform) and reflective research diary
Maupin et al. (2020)	Collective leadership in dyads, groups, and systems	• Interpersonal verbal and nonverbal communications to uncover meaning • The unfolding of leadership, communication, and influence across time and levels	Organizational discourse analysis Relational event modeling Dynamic network analysis

Authors	*Collective leadership emphasis*	*Communication focus in collective leadership*	*Theoretical framework/methodology*
Van De Mieroop et al. (2020)	Shared leadership configuration Interplay between formal and informal leaders	Emergence of informal leadership through talk, gaze, use of space and artifacts	Conversation analysis (multimodal conversation analysis)/Observation of business meetings Videorecording of interactions
Carroll & Simpson (2012)	Leadership Development Group	Discursive movements: • Kindling • Stretching • Spanning	Mead's notion of sociality/ Examination of online forum
Wodak et al. (2011)	Discursive leadership	Discursive strategies which meeting chairs employ in driving decision making: • Bonding • Encouraging • Directing • Modulating • Re/Committing	Critical discourse analysis/ Observation and recording of meetings Interviews
Gordon (2010)	Disperse leadership	Communicative framework • Taken-for-granted realities • Historical delineation of relationships • Historical decision legitimacy • The ordering of statements • Boundaries of discursive action	Discourse analysis Storytelling Narrative analysis/ Interviews, Observation of interactions Analysis of memos, flyers, newsletters, and public documents

Authors	*Collective leadership emphasis*	*Communication focus in collective leadership*	*Theoretical framework/methodology*
Holm & Fairhurst (2018)	Shared leadership (Interplay between shared and hierarchical leadership)	Discursive devices: Bookending (leader bookends meetings: ends discussion, sets the context, opens discussion, sets the agenda, delegates responsibilities)	CCO/Ethnography (observation and recording of meetings; ethnographic interviews; written communication – texts)
Simpson et al. (2018)	Leadership-as-practice	Performative effects of turning points in the flow of ordinary conversation: • Problematizing • Committing • Justifying • Imagining • Recalling	Mead's pragmatism thinking/Observation and Recording of meetings
Sergi (2016)	Leadership-as-practice	Leadership effects produced during interaction: • Directing • Shaping • Ordering	CCO – communicative constitution of organizations Conversation analysis/ Observation of team meeting
Ramsey (2016)	Leadership-as-practice	Acts of offering (inviting), blocking, accepting Sequential talk as a process of accepting or blocking others	Conversational travel/ Video recording of meetings

This form of scholarship privileges the conceptualization of collective leadership as being something that is co-produced in and located within relations and interactions. Therefore, researchers try to identify and describe the discursive processes through which leadership is collectively constructed and negotiated among interlocutors (Schnurr & Schroeder, 2019). For example, Sklaveniti (2020) argues that leadership is co-constructed through moments of conversations that connect individuals to the

collective. In addition, Van De Mieroop et al. (2020) examine the interplay between formal and informal leaders and the emergence of informal leadership through talk, gaze, use of space and artifacts. The authors show that leadership is negotiated in subtle ways that allow informal leadership to emerge in conjunction with, and sometimes in conflict with, formal leadership.

Other contributions foreground discursive strategies or practices that explain how leadership is performed linguistically. For example, Carroll and Simpson (2012) explore the notion of Mead's sociality to show how wider discourses are framed by each other and, in fact, need to be framed for each other for individuals/groups to see new possibilities. Similarly, Wodak et al. (2011) investigate the role of specific discursive strategies and related linguistic-pragmatic and argumentative devices employed by meeting chairs in driving decision making. Gordon (2010) investigates how communication that maintains power relations also creates tension when an organization attempts to shift from traditional forms of leadership (i.e., differentiation and domination) to dispersed forms of leadership (i.e., dedifferentiation and democracy). A similar inquiry has been conducted by Holm and Fairhurst (2018). They explore the interplay between shared and hierarchical leadership, showing how a leader bookends meetings and, in doing this, sets the context and ends the discussion, yet curiously fails to intervene in the discussion when he is most needed.

Another group of studies have explored the "lens" approach to leadership in the context of "leadership-as-practice" investigations. For example, Simpson et al. (2018) explore the performative effects of turning points in the flow of ordinary conversation within the context of the leadership talk of a senior management team. Similarly, Sergi (2016) and Ramsey (2016) also investigate the co-production of leadership through interactions. Overall, these studies aim to describe the specific discursive practices through which leadership is accomplished at the micro-level of an interaction, and how the various processes associated with influencing and organizing are enacted throughout an interaction (Schnurr & Schroeder, 2019).

Power and Control in Communicative Leadership

Communication fundamentally defines the structural relationships of power and control. Despite continued calls to decipher the power-based foundations of collective leadership configurations and highlight issues of conflict, dissent, competition, control, and resistance that go to the heart of the communication process (e.g., Collinson, 2018; Fairhurst et al., 2020; Holm & Fairhurst, 2018), research into the communicative

processes and mechanisms from collective leadership approaches has only barely begun to investigate how issues of power and conflict might interfere with or constrain the emergence of communicative leadership.

While there has been a recent welcome effort into research that shows how leadership is constructed linguistically (by showing discursive and communicative practices, strategies, behaviors, and ordinary conversation that produces collective leadership effects), little or no attention has been paid to issues of dissent, resistance, control, and conflict. In the same vein, much attention has been paid to discourse that refers to talk and text in social practices within specific contexts (or little “d” discourse) but much less attention has been paid to Discourse (or big “D” discourse) that relates to general and enduring systems that form and articulate ideas in a historically situated time (Alvesson & Kärreman, 2000; cf. Fairhurst, 2007). Big “D” discourses are macro, societal-level formal communication conventions that are socially constructed and historically reproduced. Little “d” discourse by contrast is manifested informally at the everyday micro-level of small or large group conversations. Of course, “big D” and “little d” discourses are intricately intertwined and can and should be profitably explored (Fairhurst, 2007). The answer to the question, “How are talk and language (little "d") in situated collective leadership constrained and enabled by wider systems of control, power relationships and organizational processes (big "D")?,” would reveal relatively underexplored but important elements of collective leadership practices, including relevant sociomaterialities.

Foldy and Ospina (2023) highlight empirical work that explores the role of power in the co-construction process, much of it based on analyses of communication and discourse. The authors identify ways in which power shapes the emergence and enactment of collective leadership. They conclude that:

> Even in collective leadership, individual power matters; Leaders can devolve power to their subordinates by empowering them; Contextual characteristics related to power can influence the possibility and enactment of collective leadership; Collective leadership can create the collective power necessary for people in marginalized positions to challenge embedded power dynamics; Power is intrinsic to the co-construction process; Attributions affect who can enact collective leadership, how they are viewed, and whether they have power.
>
> (2023, p. 546)

Additionally, research conducted by Aromaa et al. (2020) explore how emotions (in the form of "we-discourse") serve to forge soft power, helping leader and followers to enact meanings attached to a democratic rather than a hierarchical organization. Along similar lines, Gordon (2010) explores the situated power relations through which discursive practices are socially constructed. Humphreys and Rigg (2020) also explore how power relations can prevent the construction of collective by suggesting that the discourse of distributed leadership itself created the illusion of success. Finally, the discursive study produced by Holm and Fairhurst (2018) explores the complex, co-constructed relationships between authoring, authority, leadership, and power. To these empirical articles we add Joullié et al.'s (2021) theoretical article, which discuss how leaders obtain their power through language use, using "noble" (authoritative) or "base" (authoritarian) language. Although this article is not meant to address collective leadership per se, it provides a useful pointer for further research on power and communicative leadership. These contributions share a fundamental interest in explicating issues of power. They are all aligned with little "d" discourse discussions on leadership.

One promising pathway for the analysis of discursive and communicative approaches to collective leadership might consider the implications of the current Discourse advocating that we are now living a "shared-power world" in that workplaces are now democratic spaces, and everyone is called to participate in the leadership process (Raelin, 2003; 2016). Consequently, collective approaches to leadership have relied on Discourses of collaboration and sharing and emphasized that leadership comprises local decentered practices resulting in a collective achievement (Crevani, 2018; Raelin, 2011) or conjoint actions of leaderless collectives who engage in decision-making processes (McHugh et al., 2016). These processes entail a collaborative agency where there are "no leaders" (Raelin, 2016). We all need to assume collaborative and collective responsibility (Crevani et al., 2007) and, as a result, distinctions between leaders and followers are less useful for understanding leadership. Such views of collective leadership configurations have underscored notions of mutuality and fluid power relations (Fletcher, 2004). Thus, the "who" of leadership is now less important than the "how," "where," and "why" leadership is enacted (Crevani et al., 2010; Raelin, 2011), with an emphasis on collective impact (Quick, 2017).

In almost all the contributions we have reviewed in this chapter, power is not a matter for primary attention, regardless of whether scholars take a "lens" or "type" approach to collective leadership. On a more general level, the collective nature of

leadership is assumed to be given (for example, see the criticism levelled by Collinson (2018) to the Leadership-as-Practice approach). In these cases, our interest relies heavily on deciphering how leadership is enacted discursively, including considering how meanings are managed and negotiated, which would minimize the tendency to overlook power relations and questions related to formal positions (Sergi et al., 2012).

Recent discursive approaches to leadership still tend to avoid, ignore, or downplay issues of power, control, and hierarchy in the workplace and are politically naïve (Collinson, 2018; Denis et al., 2012). This indeed may signify an uncritical shift from the romance of leadership to the romance of collective leadership (Collinson et al., 2018; Schweiger et al., 2020). As emphasized by Sveiby (2011) and Fletcher (2004), despite the Discourses of shared and distributed leadership, the paradigm of individualistic leadership maintains its grip, at least at a subconscious and cultural level (Denis et al., 2012). Therefore, the perennial issue of asymmetrical power relations within collective leadership needs to be recognized and addressed.

Methodological Questions of Collective Leadership Approaches

The challenge of aligning theory with method raises methodological issues in collective leadership research (Fairhurst et al., 2020). Traditional methodologies (e.g., surveys, experiments) used to study individualized notions of leadership tend to focus on either the nominal or emergent leader, thus are less appropriate to conduct collective leadership research. Collective leadership research, by contrast, requires multiple and often more sophisticated methods (Ospina et al., 2020).

Specifically, methodological choices regarding the investigation of communicative processes should try to capture the everyday co-construction of leadership in naturally occurring work interactions, focusing less on cognition and more on the negotiation of meaning and discursively enacted sensemaking processes. In this regard, we are encouraged by an increasing range of methodological approaches to collective leadership.

For example, Maupin et al. (2020) highlight three different methods (i.e., organizational discourse analysis; relational event modeling; and dynamic network analysis) that are utilized to study dyads, groups, and systems. These methods can work for researchers with both "type" and "lens" approaches, as does the interaction process work by Sklaveniti (2020) and Van De Mieroop (2020) that shows the "doing" of leadership is not just confined to the formal leader. Similarly, other collective leadership researchers used interactional sociolinguistics (Schnurr, 2009; Vine et al.,

2008); a communicative constitution of organizations (CCO) approach (Sergi, 2016); applied linguistics and pragmatics (Schnurr & Schroeder, 2019); and critical discourse analysis (Gordon, 2010; Wodak et al., 2011) to capture a range of everyday work interactions.

In our view, there are two underlying themes related to the challenge of properly aligning theory-building with method development: first, the acknowledgement, as discussed in the previous session, that hierarchical and collective leadership forms are inevitably intertwined (Fairhurst et al., 2020; Holm & Fairhurst, 2018), and that methodologies (e.g., sociolinguistics, ethnomethodology, conversation analysis, speech act schematics, interaction analysis, and semiotics) need to be able to capture this fundamental duality. These methods should allow us to study distinct configurations of leadership, including how asymmetrical power relations influence and are influenced by the emergence of communicative and discursive leadership.

Second, methodologies should also address the notion of what fundamentally makes a collective's interaction "leadership" as compared with, let us say, "teamwork," "collaboration," and other organizing processes (Denis et al., 2012). Communication that is aimed at forging shared purpose, direction and identity is fundamentally in the realm of leadership (Jackson & Parry, 2018), but what if participants do not see it that way? Relatedly, both Chreim (2015) and Gronn (2015) have pointed to the ambiguous leadership spaces that emerge when people come together to share in leadership roles and practices. Such ambiguous leadership spaces bring to the fore the need to (while collecting and analysing data) hold multiple definitions of leadership in tension with one another (e.g., actor vs. analyst views) (Fairhurst et al., 2020).

Both themes present conceptual issues as well as methodological problems: what counts as leadership and what does not count? The discursive and communicative leadership lens (Fairhurst, 2007; Fairhurst & Uhl-Bien, 2012) has the capacity to analyze leadership configurations, consider power dynamics and processes, and uphold leadership as a distinct concept.

Recent literature focusing on collective leadership has illuminated a growing body of theoretical and empirical research dedicated to conceptualizing and scrutinizing leadership as an inherently collective endeavor (e.g., Eva et al., 2021; Ospina et al., 2020). Nevertheless, notable methodological challenges persist: (1) Untangling the inherent tensions between leadership's individual and collective facets due to its inherently multi-level nature; (2) Dealing with the methodological implications of theory, encompassing issues like conceptual ambiguity, and the alignment of ontological

principles with analytical units of inquiry; and (3) Deciding on the how to capture the less visible aspects of collective leadership.

A significant factor contributing to the state of collective leadership research lies in the proliferation of concurrent and conflicting research streams. While these diverse paradigms and viewpoints enrich our field, they complicate the contributions of this body of scholarship. A lack of dialogue across perspectives with competing assumptions fosters misunderstandings, creates blind spots that reduce the chances of developing robust and actionable knowledge, and reduces opportunities for heuristic cross-pollination (Ospina & Uhl-Bien, 2012).

Hence, addressing the connections between theory and methodology in the study of collective leadership necessitates a deliberate commitment from scholars of leadership. This commitment entails aligning underlying assumptions and theoretical lenses with methodologies, research framework choices, and implementation decisions. This includes the selection of units of analysis and observation, as well as the tools employed for data collection and analysis (Fairhurst & Antonakis, 2012). When scholars undertake this endeavor systematically, they can bolster the internal coherence of independent research initiatives on collective leadership, while simultaneously enriching the quality of discourse across various research streams. Both outcomes serve to cultivate superior knowledge for informed action within a wide range of organizational contexts (Jackson & Parry, 2018). It is time that collective leadership researchers committed to their own prescriptions of collective leadership and began collectively practicing what they individually preach.

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Further Reading

Fairhurst, G., Jackson, B., Foldy, E., & Ospina, S. (2020). Studying collective leadership: The road ahead. *Human Relations*, *73*(4), 598–614. (The closing essay of the Special Issue provides a "travel guide" to inspire both experienced and novice travelers to push out the research frontiers of Collective Leadership.)

Hamrin, S. (2016). Communicative leadership and context: Exploring constructions of the context in discourses of leadership practices. *Corporate Communications: An International Journal*, *21*(3), 371–387. (Discursive constructions of context and its significance in employees' accounts of leadership practices.)

Johansson, C., Miller, V. D., & Hamrin, S. (2014). Conceptualizing communicative leadership: A framework for analysing and developing leaders' communication competence. *Corporate Communications: An International Journal*, *19*(2), 147–165. (A very helpful theoretical framework is provided to enable the concept of "communicative leadership.")

Ladkin, D., & Probert, J. (2021). From sovereign to subject: Applying Foucault's conceptualization of power to leading and studying power within leadership. *The Leadership Quarterly*, *32*(4), 101310. (Implications for researching power from Michel Foucault's conceptualization of power to rethink how power operates within leadership relations.)

Ospina, S., Foldy, E., Fairhurst, G., & Jackson, B. (2020). Collective dimensions of leadership: Connecting theory and method. *Human Relations*, *73*(4), 441–463. (The introductory essay to a Special Issue on Collective Leadership that features a map of the terrain of the field. The Special Issue itself is worth reading as it features five pioneering empirical studies of collective leadership.)

2

DIALOGICAL LEADING

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-4

Gergen (2016) observes that the traditional model of leadership, grounded in the notion of individual leaders who exercise command and control over organizations, is being replaced by a model of relational leading that "draws primary attention to processes of relationship essential to organizing, sustaining, creating and developing the activities of people working together" (p. 28). Social constructionist approaches to relational leadership emphasize a shift from viewing organizations as living biological or physical systems to organizations as meaning making or dialogical systems. A focus on meaning making systems emphasizes the interconnections among persons-in-conversation, nonhuman actors, action, meaning, and context that constitute our reality and patterns of organizing. Dialogue has been proposed as a form of communication that is central to relational leading because it focuses on the meaning-making process and facilitates creating new lines of action that enables people to address important differences in values, beliefs, and traditions of practice.

The purpose of this chapter is to overview different approaches to dialogical leading by exploring the relationships between dialogical forms of communication and leadership. I begin by overviewing key assumptions that are shared among various approaches to dialogue followed by a presentation of two distinct approaches to dialogical leading: (1) dialogical leading as reflective inquiry; and (2) dialogical leading as relational becoming. I conclude by discussing the importance of practical wisdom and multiple modalities of communication to dialogical leading.

Articulating the Contours of Dialogue

The concept of dialogue has caught the attention of scholars within numerous academic traditions such as religious studies, philosophy, literary studies, physics, and education. While many different approaches to dialogue exist, scholars have identified a set of cross-cutting assumptions that most dialogical approaches share (see Barge, 2017; Gergen et al., 2004; Gergen, 2023; Stewart et al., 2004). These shared beliefs include: (1) dialogue is a form of discursive coordination in the service of social ends; (2) dialogue emphasizes holism and recognizes systemic connections; (3) dialogue acknowledges the tension-filled nature of human experience, giving attention to oppositions and dualities within meaning-making systems; and (4) dialogue can generate, as well as limit, new forms of meaning making and system transformation.

Discursive Coordination

Gergen et al. (2004) propose that dialogue is profitably viewed as "discursive coordination in the service of social ends" (para 6). They contend treating dialogue simply as conversation is "ambiguous and conceptually thin" (para 6) and suggest it is more profitable to view dialogue as a form of discursive coordination that provides a basic scaffolding for theorists to embed their own aspirational social ends or ideals for dialogue. They do not equate dialogue "with any particular vision of ideal interchange" and instead want to provide "an elemental descriptive definition…[where] Variations in the specific patterning of interchange may thus reflect the various ideal forms sought by differing scholars" (para 6).

It is through the pursuit of different social ideals that important differences among dialogical approaches can be discerned as they highlight particular kinds of relationships and frameworks to engage interaction and not others. For example, Bohmian dialogue is concerned with using structured reflection to address the problem of fragmentation in individual and collective thinking with a hope of facilitating holistic thinking and the development of a common consciousness and collective mind (Bohm, 2004). While Bohmian dialogue does not fully address issues of power and agency, critical approaches to dialogue as exemplified by Freire's (2018) work on learning centers power dynamics and issues of conflict and control at the heart of the interchange. He emphasizes the importance of being cautious about too easily accepting a particular perspective as "normal" and allowing it to dominate without considered reflection.

Dialogue as a form of discursive coordination emphasizes the importance of context. Gergen et al. (2004) argue that communication occurs in a relational matrix and that this matrix is composed of different dimensions centered around time and space. First, the utterances of a dialogue are located within the temporal flow of interaction. Dialogue is centered on patterns of interaction and the conjoint activity that occurs among interlocutors as opposed to individual utterances (Shotter, 1993, 2008). As Bateson (1972) observed, what is text at one point in an interaction becomes context at a later point thus framing the interpretation of subsequent utterances. The meaning of any individual utterance is shaped by what utterances preceded it and what follow. Second, dialogue is historically and culturally situated. Utterances or conversational moves that are viewed as useful in achieving social ends may vary depending on the historical and cultural context as they may facilitate accomplishing social ends in one cultural context and hurt their accomplishment in another cultural context.

Holism

Dialogue emphasizes holism and how various elements within a dialogical system cohere. Dialogue scholars take a keen interest in the interplay among persons in conversation as they interact with other human and nonhuman actors and how various contextual factors such as time, space, and setting shape how the boundaries of a dialogical system are drawn as well as the possibilities for meaning making and action. Stewart et al. (2004) observe that dialogue approaches adopt a systemic orientation invoking the common saying that "the sum is more than its parts." This requires engaging with the totality of the world and its interconnected parts by balancing "our tendencies toward analysis, separation, and categorization with attempts to be aware of and understand a totality, and a whole" (p. 23).

Reitz' (2017) research on leader-follower encounters reflects dialogue's commitment to holism. Drawing on Buber's dialogical approach, she is interested in developing resources and capacities that help us "regain our capacity to genuinely relate to one another as Thou rather than It (Buber, 1958) in our organisations" (p. 516). Her focus centers on what it means to fully engage the complexity of people and situations as they construct the dynamic processes associated with I-Thou relationships such as presence and the ability to turn to one another to cultivate mutuality. Reitz and Chaskalson's (2020) subsequent work on mindfulness highlights the importance of curiosity in driving inquiry at three levels: (1) the habits and preferences of individual team members including your own; (2) team dynamics; and (3) larger organizational,

cultural, or societal systems. Mindfulness allows leaders to engage the dialogical system of which they are part more fully by allowing them to inquire into different levels and their interrelationships holistically.

Tensionality

Dialogue emphasizes tensionality by giving attention to oppositions, dualities, and differences that surface before, during, and after interaction. Several tensions have emerged within various approaches to dialogue including: the ability to stand one own's ground while simultaneously being open to the other; managing the tension between advocacy and inquiry; dealing with the convergence and divergence among perspectives, voices, and discourses; making choices as when to emphasize consensus or conflict; and determining when to engage in more monologic versus dialogic forms of communication.

Barthold et al. (2022) observe that the idea of tensionality is clear in Raelin's (2011, 2012, 2016a, 2016b) leadership-as-practice approach. They observe that his approach has a democratic flavor as it emphasizes the importance of dialogue to facilitate the direct participation of people regarding issues that are important to them. Raelin's approach implicitly recognizes that tensions exist between certainty and doubt as well as being critical and being non-judgmental. The former is represented by the importance of individuals being able to voice what they know to be true while simultaneously being able to suspend their assumptions and act from a "temporary state of ignorance." The latter is characterized as being able to make critical decisions regarding issues while simultaneously being able to engage in nonjudgmental inquiry. They contend that a leadership-as-practice perspective recognizes that managing tensions does not mean either emphasizing certainty or doubt but making choices as how to manage their interrelationship at different moments in interaction by emphasizing one over the other, splitting the difference, or integrating them in new ways.

Generativity

Dialogue as a form of discursive coordination is generative when it facilitates the emergence of new forms of meaning making, innovation, and learning. Deetz and Simpson (2004) suggest that generativity occurs through productive versus reproductive dialogue. Productive dialogue occurs when, "the taken-for-granted assumptions of dominant ideologies are made visible through juxtaposition with alternative

understandings. If we encounter others in this way, we not only challenge the status quo of existing systems, but also open the door to deeper self-awareness" (p. 145). Productive dialogue allows us to generate new ways of making sense of situations and create novel lines of action that can engage emerging challenges. On the other hand, the danger of reproductive dialogue is discursive closure where we reproduce existing systems of thought and living and diminish our capability to adapt to emerging situations and innovate (Deetz, 1992).

Dialogical Leading

A variety of leadership approaches such as relational leadership, discursive leadership, and leadership-as-practice have identified dialogue as an important communicative activity. Two distinctive threads have emerged regarding dialogical leading: (1) dialogical leading as reflective inquiry; and (2) dialogical leading as relational becoming.

Dialogical Leading as Reflective Inquiry

Dialogical leading as reflective inquiry treats dialogue as an intentional practice to understand the experience of people and organizations through conscious contemplation. A variety of communication structures and practices have been developed to surface the assumptions that inform individual and organizational sense making and to gain insight into the way that different systems of meaning may serve as a resource to enable new forms of meaning making and choice making. It is premised on the assumption that people, organizations, and communities live in a VUCA world – a world filled by vulnerability, uncertainty, chaos, and ambiguity where diverse sets of perspectives and ideas exist for making sense of the world and developing lines of action for managing it (Bushe & Marshak, 2016). The idea that dialogue can be utilized to facilitate reflection has a rich history starting with action research and reflective practice approaches and more recently with the MIT learning organization and dialogue projects in the 1980s and 1990s (e.g., Isaacs, 1999; Senge, 1990) and the dialogical organizational development movement that emerged in the 2000s (e.g., Bushe & Marshak, 2015).

Dialogue as reflective inquiry makes several key assumptions. First, dialogue is a planned communication intervention focused on a selected topic or issue, designed for a specific moment in organizational life, and involves selected organizational members and stakeholders engaged in conversation over the selected topic for a finite period.

The focus for dialogue is triggered by disturbances, disruptions, and differences that require individuals and organizations to adapt and change. The kinds of disturbances may range from performance difficulties to lack of a strategic vision to conflict and are typically associated with complex adaptive problems that require learning and change as opposed to simple technical problems (Bushe, 2021). Dialogue sessions normally employ a tight-loose structure where general structures are established to conduct the dialogue and keep it focused while simultaneously allowing flexibility for participants to inquire into the topic or issues in various ways. For example, Bohmian dialogue groups are designed to reflect on some aspect(s) of people's experience using open-ended conversation involving between 20–40 members sitting in a circle that can last from a few hours to a few days following certain normative principles for interaction (Cayer, 1997).

Second, dialogue is designed to create awareness and meta-awareness regarding the meaning making and choice-making processes of individuals and organizations that constitute their experience. For example, large group interventions such as Future Search are purposefully designed to bring diverse stakeholders together. Participants can learn how different stakeholders make sense of situations and what assumptions guide their actions. They also develop a sensitivity to possible future scenarios and common ground that can lead to the development of action plans to address the issue in focus (Weisbord & Janoff, 2010). Raelin (2012) observes that, "People join a dialogue provided they are interested in listening to one another, in reflecting upon perspectives different from their own, and in entertaining the prospect of being changed by what they learn." (p. 8). Dialogue theorists recognize that multiple stories can be told about any situation and that listening to these different stories generate different ways of making meaning about situations.

Third, a container for dialogue must be created that provides a safe space for conversation. As Bushe and Marshak (2009) state, "dialogic interventions are more choreographed events that create a 'container' or enabling conditions within which stakeholders can share their views of social reality and seek common agreements in real time" (p. 356). Given that the topics which are the focus for dialogue are often tied to issues of identity and deeply held beliefs, people may feel vulnerable and at risk when discussing them. Montiero et al. (2021) observe that individuals may face, "*dialogical discomfort* that arises by questioning and possibly shaking our most important beliefs" (p. 174). Therefore, it becomes important to create a container or safe space that can hold these diverse perspectives and treat them as legitimate and worthy of being heard and respected.

Leaders and facilitators may employ a variety of conversational structures to encourage participants to focus attention on their own experience and analyze it. For example, dialogical organizational development is a relatively new approach aimed at facilitating change and learning that is rooted in a social constructionist perspective (Bushe & Marshak, 2015). The mantra of dialogical OD approaches is, "If you want to change the organization, change the conversation," which assumes that by changing the content and structure of conversations that organizational members have with one another, new mental models, shared understanding, and identities can be created which inform behavioral change. Individuals may appropriate a variety of existing dialogical OD interventions when leading change initiatives that restructure existing conversations including Appreciative Inquiry Summits (Ludema et al., 2003), Future Search (Weisbord & Janoff, 2010), Open Space (Owen, 2008), and World Café (Brown & Isaac, 2005). The goal of such structures is to reorient the shape and flow of the conversation in ways that: (1) surface differences among the multiple realities that people experience and their interpretations of them; (2) leverage these differences to create new interpretations and lines of action to create new pathways for the future; and (3) deliberate on what lines of action to pursue and how to implement them.

Dialogue as reflective inquiry also assumes that leaders and facilitators need to develop communication skills and practices that create and sustain reflective inquiry and thinking for themselves and others once they have created the space for a dialogue session. These communication skills and practices constitute a "living technology" that can be used by individual leaders to center themselves in dialogue as well as to be used collectively within the group to encourage participants to interact in particular ways (Ellinor & Gerard, 1999). It is important to observe that these communication skills and practices have been intentionally developed to facilitate dialogue within discrete events or interventions but could also be used as part of the daily practice of a leader when engaging with conversation with others.

Three clusters of communication skills and practices for dialogue as reflective inquiry are common within the literature. One cluster centers on speaking and listening and is grounded in a transmissive model of communication that emphasizes the processes of sending and interpreting messages. The skills and practices associated with speaking focus on identifying what needs to be said at a particular moment and how to express it clearly without succumbing to the pressures of censorship. Listening involves attuning oneself to the whole system or as Isaacs (1999) puts it, "listening from the 'net' of thought that I cast on a particular situation" (p. 92) as well as people's sense of reality.

A second cluster centers on communication skills and practices that promote respect and safety. Isaacs (1999) suggests that it is important to be curious about people's perspectives and "treat them as a mystery that you can never fully comprehend" (p. 117) and to support people who challenge one another's ideas. van Nistelrooij (2021) observes that participants in dialogues often project their own insecurity and anxiety onto the individuals leading the dialogue and that leaders need to "have ways of containing and reducing his or her own anxiety as well as that of the other participants" (p. 191).

A third skill cluster gives attention to inquiry and reflection by employing suspension and curiosity. A number of tools and techniques have been identified as fostering suspension and curiosity including being curious about and assessing your ignorance, posing generative questions that ask what is missing from the dialogue, using the Ladder of Inference to reflect on knowledge claims, engaging in frame experiments, making assumptions visible, and acting as a devil's advocate to surface and generate alternative perspectives (Ellinor & Gerard, 1998; Isaacs, 1999; van Nistelrooij, 2021).

Dialogical Leading as Relational Becoming

A second stream of dialogical leadership research centers attention on the way multiple conversational flows within organizing processes are coordinated by people to co-create meaning that allows them to move forward together. This approach to dialogical leading adopts a relationally-responsive approach to social constructionism, which emphasizes the polyvocal and fluid character of organizing as reflected in the work of Gergen (2016), Cunliffe (2001), Shotter (1993; 2008), and Barge (2012; 2014; Barge & Fairhurst, 2008). Polyvocality and heteroglossia refer to the idea that multiple voices are present in organizational life, representing different ways of making sense of experience, and that these voices are in ongoing conversation with one another generating new possibilities for meaning making and action (Cunliffe & Erickson, 2011).

Individuals wishing to exercise leadership are viewed as practical authors of conversational landscapes within organizations. They shape the emergent process of meaning making as their conversational moves or utterances gesture to new imaginary realities and opportunities for meaning making. Cunliffe (2001, p. 352) notes, "authorship occurs between people, dialogically, as they respond to each other in their everyday conversations" and that authors are, "concerned not merely with the design of

organizational structures, systems, or goals, but with creating new possibilities for action, new ways of being and relating in indeterminate, ill-defined realms of activity."

The dynamic interplay of voices means that organizing and meaning making are fluid and changing, continually shifting as new voices enter flows of conversation and others recede to the background. Conceptualizing leadership, "as embedded in the everyday relationally-responsive dialogical practices of leaders…requires a way of engaging with the world in which the leader holds herself/himself as always in relation with, and therefore morally accountable to others" (Cunliffe & Erickson, 2011, p. 1425). Dialogical leading is not restricted to discrete events characterized by a fixed set or sequence of stages but occurs in the spontaneous everyday mundane conversations of leaders. Dialogical leading is not only a way of being for individuals and organizations that is associated with a particular orientation toward interaction, but also a way of becoming with others as our conversational landscapes and relationships are constantly being re-authored and changing with each new interactional move or utterance.

The coordination of conversational flows is a collaborative process among people that shapes how people make sense of their social worlds and what ends-in-view become important to pursue and how they may accomplish them. The possibilities for collaboration expand when people develop their capacity for being more relationally-responsive with one another. Shotter (1993) originally used the term rhetorically-responsive as opposed to relationally-responsive to characterize the kind of communication practice that he envisioned suggesting that individuals:

> when faced with… unchosen conditions can, by producing an appropriate *formulation* of them, create (a) a 'landscape of enabling – constraints (Giddens, 1979) relevant for a range of next possible actions; (b) a network of 'moral positions' or 'commitments' (understood in terms of the rights and duties of the 'players' on that landscape); and (c) are able to argue persuasively and authoritatively for this 'landscape' amongst those who must work within it.
>
> (Shotter, 1993, p.149, original emphasis)

Shotter (2008) later shifted from using the term rhetorically-responsive to relationally-responsive signaling the importance of being mindful to all aspects of conversation that include but are not limited to persuasion and argumentation. Nonetheless, the notion remains that becoming a practical author requires giving attention to the way that our conversational contributions shape the moral landscape of relationships with others by

creating a set of permissions, obligations, and prohibitions that constrain and enable how we make sense of our social realities and what we view as possible future actions.

A relationally-responsive approach to leadership does not mean that all voices are weighed equally as there may be moments when privileging one voice over another is needed. Cunliffe (2001, p. 361) observes that individuals such as managers and leaders, "may become 'good' authors by developing a reflexive awareness of how their ways of talking impact this process, and how they may become more responsive to the many voices that surround them" (p. 361) Barge and Little (2002) observe that any number of conversational positions can be created in conversations that invite voices to be positioned differently in relation to one another including singular voice (where one set of ideas, perspectives, or thoughts are foregrounded and others backgrounded), unified voice (where a common voice is created from multiple voices), or blended voices (where multiple voices are orchestrated in useful opposition to one another such as constructive cacophony or multiple voices retain their own distinct quality while harmonizing with each other in the case of positive polyphony). The challenge is to create the moral space within a conversational landscape where foregrounding certain voices and backgrounding others is viewed as legitimate. For example, Grint (2005) highlights how framing a situation as a crisis can legitimate forms of command leadership where a single leader's voice may dominate.

Dialogic leading as reflective inquiry and relational becoming both emphasize the importance of reflexivity but in different ways. Dialogic leading as reflective inquiry emphasizes maintaining reflexivity about one's thinking and how it may shape people's understanding of the situation and what future actions may be developed. Dialogical leading as relational becoming emphasizes maintaining reflexivity regarding communication and relationships. Hedman and Barge (2017) suggest that communicative and relational reflexivity, "focuses people's attention on the forms of communication, that is, how the way people talk influences what they create – their identities, their relationships, and team outcomes" (p. 259). Communicative and relational reflexivity recognize the circularity in relationships among communication, relationships, and identity as speakers appropriate existing stocks of cultural and organizational understandings regarding relationships and identities as they speak while recognizing that these understandings may be revised given what they say and how others may respond.

Relationally-responsive approaches to leadership give attention to the way that leaders develop a sensitivity to the swirl of activity within constantly emerging dialogical systems and mobilize linguistic resources from within the flow of

conversation. The methods and practices that are needed for individuals to enable productive forms of joint action center on attuning to interplay of multiple voices within conversation and understanding the enabling constraints that they create in the moment as well as the capacity for imagining new pathways for meaning making and action. The practices that inform the development of structures and individual capacities for facilitating relational-responsiveness involve: (1) sense making; (2) reflection; and (3) framing.

First, sense making involves the ability to pick up and select elements from within conversational flows and shape them into sensible intelligible formulations. Individuals need to develop the ability to know how and when to give attention to certain conversational elements from within the flow of interaction. Shotter (2011) suggests that creating a focus for sense making within the present moment is premised on the simple idea of stopping, looking, listening, and anticipating. This means individuals should take a reflective pause to focus on something that strikes them as important or what Shotter and Katz (1996) call a conversational-poetic stance. A conversational-poetic stance emphasizes the fleeting images or "arresting moments" that capture people's imagination and grab their attention, providing a resource for orienting themselves to some aspect of the flow of communication. Cunliffe (2001) highlights that a variety of intralinguistic elements that may prompt "arresting moments" including, "stories, metaphors, dialogue-within-dialogue, archetypes and contradiction" (p. 358).

Leaders can build on these "arresting moments" using narratives and stories to help make sense of them. Barge (2004) identified the practice of systemic story making as a discursive practice that centers on how the various fragments leaders find important can be woven into a coherent story. Systemic story making is a polyphonic approach to story making as it emphasizes surfacing the various voices that constitute the present moment and to create a story the respects and legitimates the perspectives and perceptions associated with each voice. Jian's (2019, p. 87) work on hermeneutic leadership reflects the kind of polyphonic story making and narrativization envisioned by a relationally-responsive approach articulating, "leadership as an artful engagement in polyphonic conversation and collective narrativization through a hermeneutic circle" that enables sense making within the present moment that accounts for the collective past and the future.

Second, dialogical leading as relational becoming emphasizes the importance of reflecting on the interrelationships among emerging conversational flows and relationships. The idea is that we need to create reflective pauses in the conversational flow and shift from being an interactional participant and take a meta-position where

we observe the interaction. The idea of reflecting processes is not only drawn from action-research models but also reflective practice models (Schön, 2017) and systemic therapy (Anderson, 1991) that emphasizes the role of reflective practices such as questioning.

The way that questions are posed in dialogical leading as relational becoming are different than those in dialogue as reflective inquiry as they shift attention from the way that people think and how they generate knowledge claims to the way that people make sense of their communication and relationships. Hersted and Frimann (2020, p. 85) provide an example of the way that a consultant posed questions to a leadership team focusing directly on the interconnections among communication, relationships, and meaning making:

- How do you view your relationship with X?
- How do you think the other party/parties view it?
- How do you think the various parties view and influence each other?
- What kind of language do people use to describe what happens in these relationships?
- How do this kind of language constructions affect participants, the relationship and the view of future possibilities?
- How could you, as a leader, disrupt degenerative language games and encourage new forms of communicating?

Asking these kinds of question help individuals and collectivities reflect on the implications of different kinds of leadership conversations and what they construct.

Meta-awareness of conversational flows and structures can also be created using reflecting teams (Anderson, 1991). A reflecting team is tasked with taking an observer position to interaction and provide contemplations on its potential interpretations and consequences. Hedman and Barge (2017) demonstrated how a leadership team used reflection on their own conversational activity to understand how their communicative actions shaped their team identity, relationships, and culture. By analyzing transcripts of their team meetings turn-by-turn, they became more aware of how different conversational patterns created certain identities and relationships enabling an understanding of how they could alter existing patterns to create new imagined realities.

Third, the idea that utterances can shape the meaning making potential and trajectory of conversations foregrounds the importance of interactional framing. Dewulf et al. (2009) observe that interactional framing concerns how frames are invoked through

language use and may be either taken up or rejected by others. Fairhurst (2011) highlights how leaders may invoke linguistic devices such as metaphors, jargon and catchphrases, contrast, spin, and stories to shape the meaning making and reality construction process. Leadership scholars operating within a conversational analytic framework have demonstrated how linguistic devices such as acknowledgments and explanations (Minei et al., 2018), adjacency pairs and membership categorization devices (Clifton, 2012), and categorization practices (Whittle et al., 2015) (re)shape conversational flows by introducing new frames that may be accepted or rejected by others.

Future Research: The Role of Judgment and Multiple Conversational Modalities

Dialogical forms of communication are present in several traditions of leadership. These different traditions variously employ a dialogical approach to communication to accomplish desired social ends. Dialogical leading can take many forms and future research should continue exploring how dialogue is jointly accomplished within different traditions to facilitate various social ends including collective thinking, relational being, change, innovation, and learning. However, an overarching need for future research that cuts across many of these traditions is the need to investigate how a dialogical perspective informs the way individuals and organizations make wise choices when structuring multiple linguistic, material, and mediated conversations. If we begin with the premise that our social worlds are dialogically structured, leaders are always working within a relational matrix of ongoing conversational flows, identities, and relationships that require them consciously or unconsciously to make moment-by-moment choices regarding their coordination.

First, how do leaders make judgements regarding the way they manage the emerging flux of multiple conversational flows? Several researchers point to the importance of practical wisdom or phronesis when making judgments about how to respond to the present moment (e.g., Barge & Little, 2002; Grint, 2007). Shotter and Tsoukas (2014) observe that rationalist choice-making approaches are limited in their ability to examine how perceptions, emotions, and the moral qualities of individuals intertwine to produce conversational acts that are responsive to the present moment. Phronesis provides an alternative ontological approach grounded in the embodied living relations of the conversational moment that facilitates our ability to make situated judgments that are attuned to the particulars of the moment. There are many different ways to create joint

action when one operates from a dialogical orientation to communication, but additional work needs to focus on the way choices are made to pursue and invite certain conversational trajectories and not others.

Second, how do leaders manage multiple conversational flows across different modalities? Much of the dialogical leadership literature centers on synchronous linguistic face-to-face conversation. Yet, conversations can occur in many modalities including material and mediated forms of communication. Conversations within organizations occur in the language of materiality as is the case with the exchange of economic resources, the distribution of technology and equipment, and physical working arrangements and space. The combination of advanced information technologies and living in a post-COVID world has moved many of our conversations to online or virtual settings. Taking a page from CCO approaches to leadership (see Chapter 4 in this volume), future research should focus on the way that human and nonhuman actors contribute to dialogue and how online and virtual conversations intersect with nonmediated face-to-face conversations (e.g., Hills et al., 2023).

Contemporary organizations exist in increasingly complex social, cultural, political, and material worlds characterized by wicked problems. Dialogical leading represents one approach to engaging the complex challenges that we face in our social worlds by managing conversations that enable us to engage our differences and learn from one another.

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3

DIALECTICAL AND PARADOXICAL LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-5

Many leadership theories came of age in an era of relatively stable organizational environments (e.g., leadership style, leader-member exchange) or were developed as resources for changing them (e.g., neo-charisma leadership). However, today's conditions are far more volatile with rapidly changing technologies, global markets, shifting labor practices, and the like. Once considered anomalies in putatively stable environs, tensions, contradictions, and paradoxes have become the new normal (Ashcraft & Trethewey, 2004). Organizational theories such as dialectical and paradox perspectives have thus emerged to address the contradictory aspects of this new normal, each with major implications for leadership communication.

Dialectical theories have a long tradition of studying the evolution of systemic change through conflict (Benson, 1977; Marx, 1906). Stability and change are cast as products of the balance of power between opposing social structural forces (Van de Ven & Poole, 1995, p. 517), a highly relevant notion for organizations (Benson, 1977). Paradox theory is the relative new kid on the block but draws dialectical theories into its orbit (Putnam et al., 2016). Its focus is also systemic, but the individual experience of paradox in organizations figures prominently. Dialectical and paradox perspectives are thus distinct but overlap enough to be considered jointly in this chapter for three reasons.

First, both are interested in the study of opposing forces in (inter)organizational contexts. Paradox theory spans tensions (stress-inducing oppositions), contradictions

(interdependent oppositions that potentially negate each other), dialectics (negating oppositions with an ongoing dynamic interplay), and paradoxes (persistent oppositions that often result in an ironic or absurd outcome) (Fairhurst & Putnam, 2019), although the first and last terms are frequent shorthands for this array (Lewis, 2000; Smith & Lewis, 2011). Dialectical perspectives are most likely to center on contradictions (Benson, 1977; Farjoun, 2017; Hargrave, 2021).

Second, both perspectives often grapple with problems of immense complexity. These include grand challenges (George et al., 2016) like COVID-19 (Carmine et al., 2021), racial/gender equity (A.N. Smith et al., 2019), and globalization (Jarzabkowski et al., 2022) but also, others more discrete with relatively defined goals, locations, and players (e.g., Jarzabkowski et al., 2019; Jian & Fairhurst, 2025). Both showcase multiple opportunities for leadership set amidst complex organizational and interorganizational contexts.

Third, while the managerial role is a focus of research in both perspectives, it is not the only means for discussions of leadership. This is because problems of immense complexity require collaboration; leadership and followership must shift and distribute itself according to where the expertise lies (Grint, 2005). As such, a broader term like "actors" better describes this fluidity. Who or what carries the day in innovatively responding to tension, contradiction, and paradox is just as important as the designated leader/manager, albeit the individual likely to be held accountable (or credited) at the end of the day.

This chapter compares and contrasts dialectical and paradox approaches to leadership in terms of historical roots, current theory, and implications and interventions in leadership communication based on the question posed. Table 3.1 summarizes this content.

Table 3.1 Comparison of dialectical and paradox perspectives[1]

	Dialectics	*Paradox*
Historical organizational emphasis	Explanatory, historical, macro, societal. The ongoing development of social structures through conflict, interconnection, and change (Benson, 1977; Clegg & Cunha, 2017; Farjoun, 2017; Hegel, 1969; Marx, 1906).	Prescriptive, agential, cognitive, problem-oriented. Paradoxes are socially constructed *and* inherent in objective systems (Lewis, 2000; Smith & Lewis, 2011).

	Dialectics	*Paradox*
Current organizational theorizing	*Contradictions perspective* describes and helps organizational actors transform through changing contradictions (Hargrave, 2021; Hargrave & Van de Ven, 2017).	*Traditional* – see above. *Constitutive* – Addresses multiple paradoxes, variety in paradox responses, power, materiality, and the organizing potential of responses at individual and system levels (Berti et al., 2021; Fairhurst & Putnam, 2024; Jarzabkowski et al., 2022).
	Performative/Relational Dialectics uses a relational ontology to explore how tensions/paradox dialectically develop in sociomaterial performances (Berti et al., 2021; Fairhurst & Putnam, 2024; Lê & Bednarek, 2017; Putnam et al., 2016).	Same; dialectics and paradox are dynamic and reciprocally related, despite being different concepts.
	Critical Leadership Dialectics - problematizes dialectical power relations in organizational leader-follower interactions (Collinson, 2005; Collinson & Fairhurst, 2024; Fairhurst & Collinson, 2023).	Same; dialectics and paradox are dynamic and reciprocally related, despite being different concepts.

	Dialectics	*Paradox*
Interventions	Contrarian, marked by struggle and conflict e.g., *Dialectical Inquiry* –seeks structured debate around plans and counterplans to amplify differences for more effective vetting, synthesis, decision-making, and strategic planning (for a review, see Fairhurst, 2019).	Surfaces paradoxes as problems, both-and management strategies, seeks to avoid either-or responses that may engender vicious cycles. Often this is done through action research or training involving play, experimentation with higher order thought processes e.g., third spaces (Fairhurst, 2019; Jay, 2013; Lüscher & Lewis, 2008).
	Dialectical/Narrative Thinking – transcending opposites through dialogue, debate, constructive conflict, seeing the narrative arc of progress (or lack of) (Farjoun, 2017; Langley & Sloan, 2011).	*Paradoxical Thinking* – reflexively embracing contradiction and paradox as solvable problems, seeking energy from opposites, seeking both/and solutions (Lewis, 2000; Smith & Lewis, 2011; Waldman & Bowen, 2016).
Intervention communicator	*Question prone:* What in this evolving story do we not know? (Farjoun, 2017); Critical performativity to foster engagement (Alvesson & Spicer, 2012; Spicer et al., 2016).	*Answer prone:* How can we get to the both-and?
Senior management communication	*Sponsor/endorse* dialectical methods.	*Sponsor/endorse* action research, paradox training.

	Dialectics	*Paradox*
Leadership actor communication	Attuned to power. Resistance and consent interweave, blur boundaries, create unintended consequences. Subtle and inventive discursive strategies to keep dialectical tensions in play. Sociomateriality figures into tensional responses (for a review, see Fairhurst & Collinson, 2023).	*Negatives:* Paradoxical communication can manage (false) impressions, gloss complexity, foster ambiguity, manipulate, silence disempowered voices. *Positives:* Paradoxical communication can promote creativity, address opposing demands, capture complexity and ambiguity, foster inclusive thinking (for a review, see Nielsen et al., 2023).

Dialectics

Historical and Current Theory

Dialectics represents a long tradition rooted in classical philosophy and the humanities (Bhaskar, 1993; Clegg & Cunha, 2017). Greek philosophers, for example, viewed dialectics as a form of reasoning, a dialogic quest for truth, and a means for resolving contradictory views through refutation, synthesis, integration, or improved quality. Dialectics has also been central to Eastern philosophy (Lao Tzu, 2020), socio-political economic philosophy (Marx, 1906/2010), the Frankfurt School's social philosophy (Gramsci, 1971; Horkheimer & Adorno, 1988; Lukács, 1971), dialogism (Bakhtin, 1981), and relational meta-theory (Baxter, 2011; Baxter & Montgomery, 1996).

However, dialectics made its way into the organizational context in three ways. First, most famously is Benson's (1977) application of Marx's dialectical materialism to institutional analyses. Benson posited four principles: *social construction/production* – production of the world through ongoing interactions that (re)produce social orders; *totality* – the interpenetrating parts and wholes of social orders, where a wholistic focus captures the partial autonomy of its parts; *contradiction* – radical breaks with the social order marked by ruptures or incompatibilities that are often necessary to the functioning of systems; and *praxis* – the creative reconstruction of social arrangements based on critical analyses of social forms. Structuration theory

(Giddens, 1979, 1984), and the considerable research it generated, would later take up the organizational focus on structural, societal, and systemic sources of contradiction.

Second is the portrayal of dialectics as a logic of change (Ford & Ford, 1994), as distinct from models stressing evolution through competitive survival; organic growth vis-à-vis life-cycles; or teleology through purposeful cooperation (Van de Ven & Poole, 1995). The most prominent of the dialectical change principles is the Hegelian (Hegel, 1969) dialectic in which a thesis leads to a reaction, an antithesis contradicts or negates the thesis, and the subsequent tension gets resolved through synthesis, an ideal state. For this reason, the Hegelian dialectic is often portrayed as a model for organizational change (Garner & Poole, 2009; Hargrave & Van de Ven, 2006).

However, the interplay of contradictions does not always lead to a final synthesis. Instead, contradictions can remain in continuous play to create new conditions and possibilities that require constant adjustment (Benson, 1977; Calori, 2002; Carlo et al., 2012). This is sometimes known as the tension dialectic, or dialogic model of change (Bakhtin, 1981). It references institutional arrangements of multiple tensions in which change is marked by opposing groups' political strategies seeking to address the dialectics and the ongoing challenges and conflicts they engender (Hargrave & Van de Ven, 2006, p. 878).

Third is a critical dialectical leadership perspective, which explicitly problematizes dialectical power relations in organizational leader-follower interactions (Collinson & Fairhurst, 2024). Collinson (2005) was among the first to reframe traditional leadership binaries that foster essentialized thinking around opposites into control-resistance, dissent-consent, and male-female dialectics. Zoller and Fairhurst (2007) followed with more dialectics, a heavy attention to communication dynamics, and an argument for the compatibility of critical (dialectical) theory and leadership studies. More recently, Fairhurst and Collinson (2023) reviewed 35 studies over the past 20 years on several leadership/followership dialectics. Here, different forms of leaders' power are in tension with one another, produce unanticipated and unacknowledged effects, and may appear paradoxical. Followers' practices are also more proactive, informed, and oppositional than has often been appreciated, especially in traditional leadership theorizing (Collinson & Fairhurst, 2024). Critical leadership dialectics is representative of current dialectical theorizing that finds dialectics and paradox to be distinct concepts yet related to one another. More about this later in the chapter.

Leadership Communication

To fully understand the leadership communication implications of the dialectical perspective, it must include three forms. The first focuses on dialectically based interventions, which are planned approaches for eliciting structured debate (for a review, see Fairhurst, 2019). Such interventions amplify differences, for example, around plans and counterplans for more effective vetting, synthesis, decision making, and strategic planning (Cosier & Aplin, 1980; Hedberg & Jonsson, 1978; Mason & Mitroff, 1979). The aim is constructive conflict management, although this is not always achieved when conflicts devolve (Langley & Sloan, 2011). As such, the conflictual nature of these interventions requires management's sponsorship through initiation, participation, or simple approval.

A second dialectical method is much less structured yet oriented towards dialectical or narrative thinking through philosophical questioning and doubt of central frames and meanings to pursue change (Calori, 2002). Specifically, when the firm is viewed as a distributed knowledge system, dialectical thinking reveals itself through narratives, or what Nonaka and Toyama (2002, 2005) call "lay ontologies" that incorporate oppositions that build to higher order models of change (Calori, 2002). For example, organizational change narratives specifically articulate ongoing tensions, previously failed responses, and organizational learning around more efficacious ones. Actors' journeys appear question-prone as they continually ask, "What in this evolving story do we not know?" (Farjoun, 2017).

Third is a panoply of findings on critical leadership dialectics, which focus on issues of power in leader-follower relationships. Fairhurst and Collinson's (2023) review of dialectical studies found that leaders' power may be extensive, but follower autonomy and discretion can check it, especially given how complexly consent and resistance interweave (often concealing the latter) (Ashcraft, 2005; Carlone & Larson, 2006; Gagnon & Collinson, 2017; Lynch, 2009).

Other studies focus on the subtle and inventive discursive strategies to keep dialectical tensions in play. For example, in Tracy's (2004) prison study, guards didn't try to resolve contradictory norms for inmates but kept their underlying tensions in play by framing them as complementary edicts (e.g., respect but be suspicious; nurture yet discipline them). Similarly, Smith and Besharov (2019) found that invoking guard rails protected the hybrid social-business mission of the nonprofit they studied by preventing too much drift towards one pole. Kreiner et al. (2015) found that clergy in the Episcopal Church used dialectical category work (i.e., modifying categories through talk so they contain their opposites) to achieve identity elasticity over the conflict generated by its first openly gay bishop. Again, they did not seek to resolve liberal-conservative

tensions but kept them in play by reinterpreting categories for inclusiveness, a strategy made all the more salient when the Methodist Church broke up over the very same issue.[2]

Finally, in a few studies, sociomateriality figured into dialectical responses through a focus on texts, technology, the role of the body, and spaces (Deye & Fairhurst, 2019; Holm & Fairhurst, 2018; Van De Mieroop et al., 2020). All contribute to the ongoing power dynamics of dialectical processes.

To summarize, dialectical approaches have a long history informing the study of leadership through organizational theorizing and change initiatives, as well as articulating several relational dialectics in the leader-follower relationship. Communication can range from sponsoring dialectical interventions designed to spur constructive conflict over competing tensions, organizational change narratives that are question-prone, or finding ways to creatively keep tensions in play in leader-follower communication. In the following, a dialectical perspective differs from a paradox one, but will be contributory in important ways.

Paradox

Historical and Current Theory

Recent reviews of the paradox literature (Berti et al., 2021; Fairhurst & Putnam, 2024; Putnam et al., 2016; Schad et al., 2016; Smith et al., 2017) suggest five recurring themes (Town et al., 2023). First, paradoxes (broadly defined) are inherent in modern organizational life; leadership actors, in particular, must find ways to cope with them (Clegg & Cunha, 2017; Knight & Paroutis, 2017; Smith & Lewis, 2011).

Second, paradoxes are regularly cast as problems for managers and others to solve (Cameron & Quinn, 1988; Farjoun, 2017). This, in turn, invites a heavy cognitive lens, which traditional paradox theory embraces through a focus on sensemaking. For example, actors cognitively and socially construct paradoxes in discerning a relationship between poles and rendering them salient (Lewis, 2000). Sensemaking processes and system tensions converge in dynamic equilibrium models of organizing in which latent tensions turn salient when actors perceive changes in environmental conditions (e.g., tensional plurality, scarcity, and change) (Smith & Lewis, 2011), and actors use paradoxical cognition to effectively embrace rather than avoid contradictions (Smith & Tushman, 2005).

Third, either-or thinking (that prioritizes opposites) is the default logic of many leaders. Both-and thinking (that balances opposites) is central to paradoxical cognition,

which is much harder to achieve. Paradoxical cognition includes paradoxical thinking (Waldman & Bowen, 2016; Waldman & Javidan, 2020), which balances *specific* sets of opposites. By contrast, paradoxical mindset is an overall disposition to embrace opposites and comfortably navigate them (Miron-Spektor et al., 2018). Both are more enlightened than either-or thinking, where sensemaking is often cast as automatic or superficial (Collins & Porras, 2005; Smith & Lewis, 2022).

Fourth, leaders and other actors can be taught to be more reflexive about their choices to achieve paradoxical cognition (Poole & Van de Ven, 1989). This is often done through action research, that is, undertaking research and action concurrently to: 1) view complexity as paradoxical tensions; and 2) use both-and thinking to interrupt paralytic cycles (e.g., Jay, 2013; Lüscher & Lewis, 2008).

Fifth, leaders and others are going to vary in their ability to see, articulate, and respond to paradoxical tensions, because it requires both cognitive complexity and verbal and behavioral dexterity (Denison et al., 1995; Knight & Paroutis, 2017; Sheep et al., 2017). Hargrave and Van de Ven (2017) make a similar point regarding the cognitive limitations and biases of managers, their short- versus long-term orientation, and difficulties in detecting embedded contradictions and unforeseen circumstances.

While foundational, these five recurring themes suggest a more entitative or static view of paradox because its underlying dynamics are not spelled out. Responding to this concern, recent paradox theorizing incorporates dialectics (Hargrave, 2021; Hargrave & Van de Ven, 2017). One of the most communicative approaches of these adopts a performative focus. For both the experience of paradox and system functioning, they use a relational ontology to explore how paradoxical tensions dialectically develop in sociomaterial performances (Berti et al., 2021; Fairhurst & Putnam, 2024; Putnam et al., 2016). For example, Fairhurst and Putnam (2024) focus on how paradox manifests in the body when words fail and dialectical tensions intensify. They also demonstrate how micro-level (e.g., double binds, opening up/closing down participation), meso-level (e.g., enabling/constraining action, reinforcing cycles), and macro-level (producing/reproducing systems) outcomes of dialectical processes recursively interrelate with the unintended consequences of actions taken. They used a case study of the fallout from Boeing's two catastrophic airplane crashes in 2018 and 2019 to demonstrate how these outcomes embed themselves in one another.

Leadership Communication

Similar to dialectical leadership communication, there is senior-level leadership communication around paradox through the sponsorship of interventions. This involves activities like action research (Jay, 2013; Lüscher & Lewis, 2008) or other kinds of organizational development that engages in "play," improvisation, or other high order thought processes (e.g., third spaces) that creatively envision possible futures with the both-and approach of paradoxical thinking (Fairhurst, 2019).

Other forms of communication tend to play second fiddle to the emphasis on paradoxical cognition, but emerging research suggests both negative and positive communication effects (for a review, see Nielsen et al., 2023). For example, leaders must freely admit to uncertainty surrounding paradox complexity as they collaborate with others for the ideal both-and solution. This runs counter to leaders as "pillars of certainty and 'final' decisions" (Nielsen et al., 2023, p. 155). As such, leader paradoxical communication can gloss complexity and manage (false) impressions (Gaim et al., 2021), foster ambiguity (Cappellaro et al., 2021), appear manipulative (Argyris, 1990), silence disempowered voices (Berti & Simpson, 2021), and provoke anxiety, stress, or other defensive routines (Berti & Simpson, 2021; Lewis, 2000; Miron-Spektor et al., 2018) that result in paralysis (McGuire et al., 2006).

On the positive side, more dialogic interactions can spur creative outcomes if paradoxical tensions are accepted and remain in play (Gaim et al., 2022), encourage inclusivity (Miron-Spector et al., 2011), capture complexity and ambiguity (Schad et al., 2016), assist sensemaking (Sharma & Good, 2013), and foster empowerment (Miron-Spektor et al., 2018). Actors in a youth prison study achieved many of these aims through daily communication and treating their interpretations as tentative (Wenzel et al., 2019).

Suffice it to say that paradox praxis recommendations may appear simple if one focuses only on paradoxical thinking – although looks deceive. For example, Nielsen et al. (2023) argue that actors (who are not formal leaders) will vary greatly in the kinds of leader communication they require. Some seek clarity while others feel patronized and insufficiently empowered with too much direction. Qu et al. (2022) studied trait mindfulness as a boundary condition for paradoxical leadership, finding that trait mindfulness in followers is a necessary condition for effective paradoxical leadership in teams. This important study suggests that followers must be able to embrace contradictions to fully appreciate leader communication around paradox. To get comfortable with contradiction, Town et al. (2023) found that mindful leaders call attention to bodily responses as much as cognitive ones, stay with (dissonance-causing) tensional conditions to ensure emotional reserves to deal with them, and alternate

between rational and other more physical/emotional ways of processing tensions. How leaders *and* followers process tensions thus appears critical to paradoxical leadership.

At the heart of the matter is the salience of paradoxical tensions (specifically, the interrelated, contradictory relationship between poles), which may or may not be apparent to all, including formal leaders. This is all the more complicated when multiple paradoxical tensions entangle themselves to form knotted interrelationships (Sheep et al., 2017). To navigate this kind of complexity, senior leaders must orchestrate "attention to a repeated and converging constellation of cues" to appropriately set the interpretive context for the rank and file (Knight & Paroutis, 2017, p. 423). However, the skill set, according to Brughmans (2023), is itself paradoxical because communication must be used to foster, *inter alia,* a unified diversity of interpretations, a disciplined empowerment, change through continuity, two-sidedness by first organizing one's own opposition, and a market *and* vision-driven purpose. In short, leaders must set the conditions for acting "consistently inconsistent" (Smith et al., 2016).

To summarize, the current popularity of a paradox approach lies in the tensions, contradictions, and paradoxes increasingly confronting organizations and society today. Leadership communication can take the form of sponsoring paradox interventions through action research or others forms of dialogic organizational development. However, we appear to be on the cusp of discovering some complex communication dynamics surrounding leader-follower capabilities to communicate and think with a paradoxical skill set. In the following section we address these dynamics, as well as how a paradox orientation can complement a dialectical one.

Discussion

Clearly, the paradox perspective has much more of a managerialist orientation than a dialectical perspective (Farjoun, 2017). However, a dialectical perspective is more sociohistorical and sensitive to issues of power in ways the paradox perspective is only beginning to realize (cf. Berti & Simpson, 2021; Fairhurst & Putnam, 2024). While the paradox perspective has a systemic focus (Jarzabkowski et al., 2022; Smith & Lewis, 2011), it is not necessarily temporal, given a heavy reliance on interview methods. However, its heavy focus on actor cognition can complement the more macro, socio-historical focus on dialectics, and scholars are beginning to realize that.

For example, "paradoxing the dialectic" (McGuire et al., 2006) and "dialecting the paradox" (Fairhurst & Putnam, 2024) are two concepts marking the crossover of

paradox and dialectics with communication implications for actors. According to McGuire et al., paradoxing the dialectic occurs in irrational situations in which both-and responses (e.g., vacillating between poles, integrating them, or otherwise seeking balance) fail and produce paralysis. Actors narrating chaotic environments often fall prey to this phenomenon by communicating inertia or helplessness. Following Fairhurst and Putnam (2024), dialecting the paradox occurs when actors' responses to paradoxes stretch, split, or reconfigure opposites to create a space for action (read, resistance) in the process. They demonstrated how various members of the clergy, from different denominations, inventively resisted heavily institutionalized hierarchies through category work, sociomaterial reconfigurations, and turning church ritual on its head.

Aside from the agency implications of these two phenomena, dialectics and paradox are dynamic processes that intertwine and co-produce one another (Fairhurst & Putnam, 2024). To study these phenomena constitutively (i.e., communicatively) requires a temporal focus, at a minimum, to understand the ebbs and flows of reciprocated action and the recursivity that builds towards (dis)equilibrating systems. However, extant research also points to a need to focus on sociomateriality and the subtle and not-so-subtle ways in which power manifests itself among actors, witness the ways in which compliance and resistance to paradoxical tensions can appear simultaneously (Ashcraft, 2005).

Regarding praxis, the paradox perspective is already supplying a metalanguage to understand tension, contradiction, and paradox (e.g., Brughmans, 2023; Nielsen et al., 2023; Smith & Lewis, 2022, among several others). However, it can and must go deeper – beyond celebrating the cognitive and further into the communicative realm – to help leaders and followers alike better understand the negotiation of paradox meaning(s) (as opposed to simple transmission), the elasticity of categories that inventively use paradox (as opposed to their unconscious use), navigating the agency to respond to paradox (including the paralysis or either/or automaticity of it), and (dis)entangling tensional complexities and responses, including justifying of paradox responses through the problem setting of multiple tensions (Fairhurst & Putnam, 2024; Nielsen et al., 2023; Sheep et al., 2017). While early reports suggest that paradox actors can expect challenges as they help others to understand dialectical and paradoxical relationships and the appropriate responses to them (Nielsen et al., 2023; Qu et al., 2022), the nature of these challenges require a great deal more research with an explicit focus on communication. Only then will the promise of paradox and dialectical approaches be fully realized.

Acknowledgement

I am indebted to Linda Putnam and Guowei Jian for reading earlier versions of this chapter.

Notes

1. This table draws from Farjoun (2017).⏎
2. For example, see www.washingtonpost.com/outlook/2020/01/16/why-split-methodist-church-should- set-off-alarm-bells-americans/⏎

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4

LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION FROM A CCO PERSPECTIVE

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-6

Leadership

Leadership studies have put forward a multitude of different ways of considering leadership and leaders. It seems fair to say that until recently most leadership research tended to focus on the individual atomized leader – the so-called "great man" (Carlyle, 1841). This leader was often assumed to be the hierarchic superior, and researchers often focused on the individual traits and characteristics that made this person a leader (usually a tall, white, alpha male of privileged background [Grint, 2010, p. 69]). However, since the 2000s, these assumptions have been challenged by post-heroic trends in leadership research which attend to the collective, distributed, shared, and plural nature of leadership (see, e.g., Denis et al., 2012; Gronn, 2002; Pearce & Conger, 2003). Such post-heroic leadership research, avoiding conflating leadership with position, focuses on all participants, not just the hierarchic superior. Consequently, leadership is conceived of as a social and relational process which allows the researcher to zoom in on the process of doing leadership, rather than the traits or actions of individuals (Fairhurst & Uhl-Bien, 2012).

More specifically, aligning with this move to post-heroic interpretations of leadership, we work from Pearce and Conger's (2003) classic definition of distributed leadership which they define as: "a dynamic, interactive influence process among individuals in groups for which the objective is to lead one another to the achievement

of group or organizational goals or both" (p. 1). This definition, which envelops post-heroic notions of leadership, thus opens up the analysis of leadership to all participants, yet it retains the one ingredient of leadership that, as Yukl (1989) pointed out, most leadership research has in common, i.e., that leadership is to do with influence.

Commensurate with such a move to post-heroic notions of leadership, there has also been a turn to communication (Connaughton & Fairhurst, 2014; Tourish, 2014). This turn to communication can be seen for example in Gail Fairhurst's (2007) work on discursive leadership whereby she argues that focusing on communication allows the researcher to investigate "how leadership is brought off in some here-and-now moment of localized interaction" (p. 15). In other words, by looking at interaction, the researcher can make visible, and thus analyzable, how leadership is achieved as in situ social practice. This groundbreaking research has been followed by a body of work which, inter alia, uses fine-grained linguistic analyses of transcripts of naturally-occurring talk to reveal the doing of leadership as in situ social practice (for a summary of this work, see Clifton et al., 2020). Moreover, some of this linguistically-inspired research has specifically focused on the communicative achievement of distributed and post-heroic forms of leadership (see, e.g., Choi & Schnurr, 2016).

Similarly, in recent years, there has also been increasing recognition of the role of materiality in the doing of leadership (see, e.g., Sergi, 2016). As Grint (2005) notes: "a naked Napoleon would have been markedly less effective than a clothed Napoleon surrounded by clothed soldiers with weapons" (p. 22). Consequently, over the past few years, numerous studies have been produced which take the materiality of leadership seriously. For example: Ropo et al. (2015) consider the use of space and place in relation to leadership; Parry and Hanson (2007) move beyond the idea of leaders telling stories to propose that the cultural artefact of the story can also "do" leadership; and Barfod (2021), drawing on Goodwin (1994), explores how graphic representations such as aerial photographs, whiteboards, and maps contribute to the doing of leadership in military high-risk contexts.

However, so far, these three emergent trends (the material, the communicative, and the post-heroic) in leadership research have been advancing largely, though not entirely, independently of each other. Whilst post-heroic trends in leadership have considered the way in which leadership is distributed as an in situ achievement (see, e.g., Holm & Fairhurst, 2018), little research has sought to combine the insights of discursive leadership with materiality. And work that investigates the materiality of leadership has so far tended to overlook both the role of other-than-human actants in the in situ communicative achievement of leadership and the distributed nature of leadership. In

this chapter, we argue that these three research foci can be profitably combined to advance our understanding of leadership.

The Communicative Constitution of Organization

The roots of CCO can be traced back to the move within organizational research which considers communication to be the stuff of organizing and organizations (e.g., Taylor & Van Every, 2000). Thus, rather than considering organization to be a noun in which communication takes place, CCO considers organizations to be communicative constructions, communicated into being in and through the process of organizing. Kuhn (2012) sums up CCO as having four core tenets. First, a CCO approach to organizing and organization posits that communication, rather than being an asocial conduit for the transmission of pre-existing realities that are "out there somewhere," is an in situ social practice that is constitutive of organizational realities. Second, communication is not regarded as something that takes place within an organization; rather the organization is regarded as an ongoing accomplishment sustained in and through sociomaterial practices. In other words: "communicative practice is the fundamental site of the organizational" (Kuhn, 2012, p. 549). Third, to investigate CCO, researchers privilege the analysis of communicative events, both conceptually and methodologically. Fourth, communication is understood as a process that is "uncertain, ambiguous, paradoxical, fragmented, and dilemmatic" (Kuhn, 2012, p. 549).

Yet, despite the centrality of these four tenets, Bencherki et al. (2022) nevertheless point out that CCO is more of a collection of perspectives than a single stance, and that, moreover, it does not have a methodological preference for the way in which research is carried out. For the purposes of this chapter, it is the Montreal School's approach to communication and its notion of ventriloquism that interests us most for its ability to engage with emerging communicative, material, and post-heroic trends in leadership research. The Montreal School's capacity to address these trends is explained because ventriloquism can make visible, and therefore analyzable, the communicative constitution of leadership through the analysis of "the assemblages of humans and other-than-humans emerging and engaged in the active production of leadership" (Sergi, 2023, p. 269).

The Montreal School and Ventriloquism

The Montreal School was founded by James Taylor and colleagues at the University of Montreal in the 1980s, and it was from this university that Taylor and colleagues' pioneering research on CCO was disseminated (e.g., Taylor & Van Every, 2000). Whilst the Montreal School is still largely dominated by scholars, such as Nicolas Bencherki, Boris Brummans, and François Cooren who are based in and around Montreal, nevertheless it has also rapidly gained an international following. The Montreal School is thus best considered as a loose ensemble of researchers who draw on CCO, discourse analysis, interactional analysis, rhetoric, semiotics, pragmatics, conversation analysis, and actor network theory (ANT). ANT (Callon, 1986a; Latour, 2005) is especially relevant for the notion of ventriloquism. It is key to scholars from the Montreal School because of the centrality of the notion of generalized symmetry (Callon, 1986b) whereby the roles of human and material actants[1] are taken equally seriously by researchers. Such an approach challenges the dichotomization of the world into the human, which has agency, and the other-than-human which is acted upon by humans.

The classic example of ANT's notion of generalized symmetry is Latour's (1999) discussion of a speedbump. When a motorist sees a speedbump, they slow down. The other-than-human is therefore said to have acted on the human. However, Latour also points out that it is not only the (other-than-human) speedbump that has acted on the (human) driver. Rather, a network of actants is invoked and it is this network which forces the human to slow down. In other words, a plenum of agencies, both human and other-than-human, is at play. This plenum of agencies, such as the legislation that authorized the speedbump to be built, the workers who built it, notions of road safety that informed the construction of the speedbump, and so on form a network of actants that make something happen. Consequently, from this perspective, agency is shared across a plenum of intertwined agencies, both human and other-than-human (Latour, 1999).

However, ANT does not concern itself with how actor networks function as part of everyday in situ communicative practice. Conversely, the Montreal School gives ANT an "interactional and organizational twist" (Fairhurst & Cooren, 2009, p. 474). The interactional and organizational twist is achieved through the use of transcripts of naturally-occurring interaction which capture, as Cooren (2010) puts it, the "*terra firma*" (p. 6) of everyday social life. These transcripts are then analyzed using techniques derived from the fine-grained analysis of sequences of talk in the conversation analytical tradition (Sacks, 1992). Further, if video-recorded data is used,

ventriloquial analyses draw on the insights of multimodal conversation analysis and so they take into account such things as the use of artefacts, eye-gaze, and gesture.

However, unlike conversation analysis, the Montreal School's approach to analysis does not stop at the human. Rather, it seeks to inform our understanding of the interplay between networks of human and other-than-human actants. From this perspective, other-than-human "actants," such as speedbumps, have agency. They are not simply passive objects that are manipulated by the human. Consequently, the agency of other-than-human actants, the way they make a difference to interaction, should be taken as seriously as that of the human participants. In this respect, ventriloquism is also different from other concepts of speaker identity, such as Goffman's (1981) notion of the animator (the person who speaks), the author (the person from whom the actual words originate), and the principal (the person ultimately responsible for the words). This is because, following Goffman (1981), communication and agency are considered in purely human terms, never in terms other-than-human actants.

Cooren and colleagues catch the interplay of the agency of both humans and other-than-humans through the metaphor of ventriloquism which invites the researcher to conceptualize communication in terms of what is materialized and invoked by interlocutors and how this animates them in particular ways. Simply defined, ventriloquism comprises "actions through which someone or something makes someone or something else say or do things" (Cooren, 2015, p. 476). In other words, just as the ventriloquist makes a dummy speak or do things, so organizational players (whether human or other-than-human) make things beyond them speak and do things. However, this effect is not unidirectional: the dummy also makes the ventriloquist say and do things, and in the same way organizational players (whether human or other-than-human) are made to do and say things by other agents. Cooren (2010) captures this notion of reciprocity in the concepts of downstream and upstream ventriloquism which refer, respectively, to the way in which spokespeople or spokesobjects, such as speedbumps, animate others and the way in which they are animated. Cooren (2010) also notes that there is a constant oscillation between upstream and downstream ventriloquism so that a spokesperson/spokesobject simultaneously animates, and is animated by, other actants.

Further, the notion of ventriloquism means that communicating about something is a way of materializing it. From this perspective, Cooren (2020) goes beyond the idea of entanglement whereby the social and the material are ontologically separated, but inextricably intertwined, to suggest that sociomateriality should be understood in terms of properties (Cooren, 2020). Consequently, as we will argue, an organizational procedure not only has material properties, it also has social properties. This is

because it has to be materialized through the communicative acts of a spokesperson/object. In this respect, the social is always material, and the material is always social.

For example, Benoit-Barné and Cooren (2009) illustrate how a medical coordinator for the humanitarian group *Médecins Sans Frontières* (Doctors without Borders) is able to influence what technicians at a medical center do, not because she speaks as an individual but because she is able to speak on behalf of, and so ventriloquize, the organization which gives her authority to act on the technicians (downstream ventriloquizing). When she speaks, she is speaking on behalf of the organization which is part of a network of actants that she makes present (presentifies) and relevant to the talk. Simultaneously, the organization also ventriloquizes her by speaking through her (upstream ventriloquizing). The organization, writ large, is thus incarnated in, and through, the interaction and the process of organizing. Moreover, through a process of scaling up (i.e., moving from the local to the dis-local [Taylor & Van Every, 2000]) the researcher can make tangible how the organization writ large is simultaneously locally grounded in conversation, yet animated through the presentification of text that makes the wider (dis-local) organization relevant to the interaction which is reflexively communicatively constituted in the interaction.

The Montreal School and Leadership

Whilst recent reviews of CCO and leadership, notably Bisel et al. (2022) and Sergi (2023) point out that CCO and leadership have had an ambivalent relationship, nevertheless the Montreal School's focus on interaction, materiality, and the process of organizing resonates with current post-heroic, material, and communicative trends in leadership studies. Cooren (2010) in his discussion of President Obama suggests that ventriloquism could be:

> a new way of addressing the question of leadership or charisma (Fairhurst, 2007; Fairhurst & Cooren, 2009) since it consists of acknowledging what this person called Barack Obama ventriloquizes or animates in his discourse, his decisions, or, more generally, his conduct.
>
> (p. 151)

In other words, leadership research could be informed by ventriloquial analyses because in the process of doing leadership some networks of actants (both human and

other-than-human) make others (both human and other-than-human) say or do things. Interestingly, Grint (2005) comes close to making this link when he argues that "it isn't the consciousness of leaders that makes them leaders or makes them effective, it's their hybridity; not how they think but how they are linked" (p. 22). Drawing no doubt on Latour's (1999) discussion of speedbumps, Grint (2005) discusses how networks of material objects, such as speed cameras and traffic lights, with the threat of police enforcement, *lead* us to drive in a particular way. However, he does not show how leadership, so defined, as in situ social action is achieved in real time through communicative practices.

Unfortunately, despite Grint's (2005) discussion of leadership and ANT, the notion of ventriloquism has largely passed unnoticed within leadership studies and, as Sergi (2023) notes, only a small body of work exits that has taken the proposition that ventriloquism may be a new way of looking at leadership seriously. For example: Cooren and Fairhurst (2003), using narratives of downsizing as data, show how the leader enlists hybrid networks of both humans and other-than-humans to create an appealing vision; Fairhurst (2007) and Fairhurst and Cooren (2009), using data drawn from media reports and interviews, show how politicians during times of crisis draw on networks of other-than-humans to do (charismatic) leadership; Clifton (2017), using transcripts of naturally-occurring meeting talk, shows how the hierarchic leader mobilizes a plethora of both human and other-than-human actants so as to influence others to follow her; Clifton et al. (2021), using interactional data from a start-up, investigate how hybrid presences of human and other-than-human actants are made relevant to the interaction to do leadership by providing authoritative grounds for influencing others so that the group's goals are achieved; and Poon and Kohlberger (2022), using posts on Twitter as data, illustrate how Twitter is an active agent in producing authoritative texts that influence the unfolding of the Hong Kong protest movement.

CCO and Leadership

In order to showcase what the Montreal School's notion of ventriloquism can offer to leadership research we illustrate our argument with a short ventriloquial analysis using transcripts of naturally-occurring interaction recorded during military operations in Afghanistan in 2018. The recordings were made by the second author who is also a major in the Danish army and who was embedded in the unit for research purposes. The premise of our analyses is that if leadership is distributed, as post-heroic trends in

leadership research would have it, then it is not only distributed across human social actors. Rather, leadership is distributed across both human and other-than-human actants that are ventriloquized in interaction so as to influence other actants to achieve organizational goals. As Cooren (2010), citing Latour (1996), in his discussion of agency says, "to do is causing to do" (p. 4).

Following Clifton et al. (2021), we argue that the influence process is not solely amongst individuals; rather it is hybrid and distributed through networks of both human and other-than-human actants. Therefore, we modify Pearce and Conger's definition of leadership to: a dynamic, interactive influence process among *both human and other-than-human actants in networks* for which the objective is to lead one another to the achievement of group or organizational goals or both. In the next section we analyze a transcript of talk taken from naturally-occurring interaction video-recorded whilst Danish soldiers were on active service in Afghanistan in 2018.

Analysis

The Danish troops, with whom the second author is embedded, have arrived in the secure compound of the Ministry of Interior Affairs just outside Kabul where a NATO military advisor is attending a meeting with local Afghan officials. In the hope of carrying out a field interview, the second author is looking for the team leader. He meets Pavs, a private soldier, and they go to the platoon leader's vehicle to speak to him. The vehicles are armored personnel carriers with crew compartments at the rear, and ramps for the soldiers to dismount from the vehicles (see Figure 4.1a). The driver is at the wheel of the vehicle and one soldier (Gurli) remains sitting in the crew compartment of the vehicle (Figure 4.1a). Pavs peers into the back of the vehicle and talks to Gurli, who is also a private soldier (Figure 4.1b). However, Pavs has more experience than Gurli and despite being a private has been acting as second in command in the absence of the team sergeant (the positional leader). In this case, Pavs is responsible for the crew of the vehicle. The exchange, which basically consists of a discussion about why Gurli has remained in the vehicle, was recorded by the second author's helmet camera. At the end of the exchange, Gurli leaves the vehicle (Figure 4.1c). The second author translated the original Danish into English. The original Danish appears in italics below the English translation.

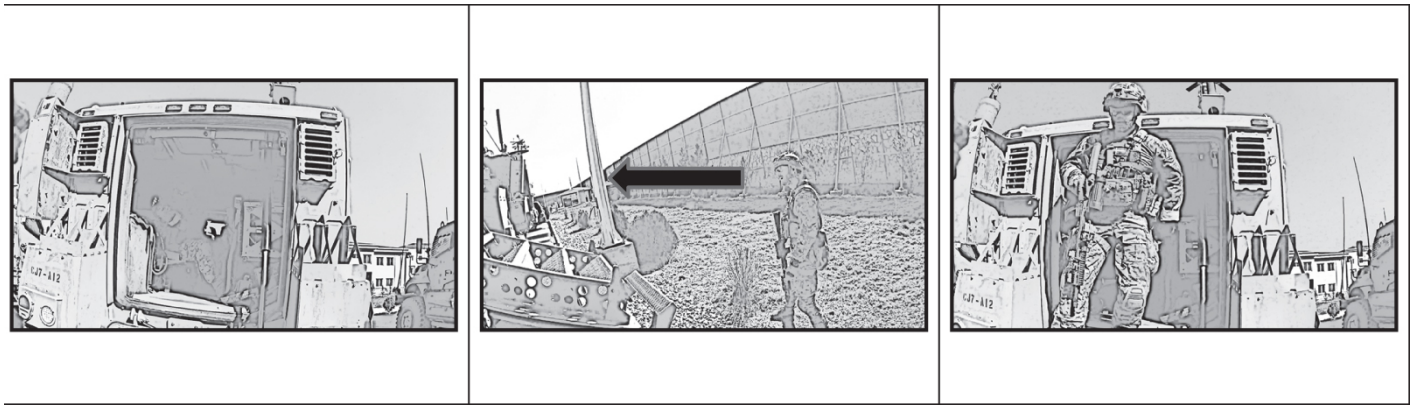


Figure 4.1 a: Gurli sits in the vehicle; 4.1b: Pavs peers into the vehicle; 4.1c: Curli leaves the vehicle

We start the analyses as Pavs peers into the back of the vehicle (Figure 4.1b).

1. Gurli: should I dismount or what?
   jeg sku ikke med på jorden eller hvad?
2. (1.0)
3. Pavs: yea::h GA[2] and Pax[3] dismount aren't you GA?
   jo:: GA og pax afsiddet er du ikke GA?
4. Gurli: yeah but it was not said
   jo men det blev ikke sagt
5. (1.6)
6. Gurli: there was not I mean neither was there a radio check on SPR[4]
   der var ikke altså der blev heller ikke lavet modtagerkontrol på SPR
7. I mean we [we just have to talk about it when we get home]
   altså vi [vi skal lige snakke om det når vi kommer hjem]
8. Pavs: [it it Gurli Gurli]
   [det det Gurli Gurli]
9. Gurli↑
   Gurli↑
10. Gurli: yes
    ja
11. Pavs: it is a standard
    det er en standard

12. Gurli: yes it is a standa::rd
ja det er en standa:::rd

As Pavs peers into the crew compartment, Gurli asks "should I dismount or what?" In terms of leadership, this question displays that he orients to Pavs' right, as the person responsible for the crew of the vehicle, to tell him what he should, and should not, do in the circumstances, i.e., to lead him and influence his actions to achieve the team's goals. However, as we see below, it is not only Pavs who leads. Rather, it is the hybrid presence of Pavs and a standard (i.e., a standard operating procedure [SOP]) which lead. SOPs are important in the military. SOPs are generally formal written procedures, but they can also be locally agreed and produced procedures in the team or platoon. In either case, SOPs instruct the soldiers how to carry out routine tasks. If X happens, soldiers should do Y. Thus, as we demonstrate below, SOPs also make the soldiers act in certain ways and so "do" leadership by influencing them to achieve organizational aims.

In this case, Pavs responds to Gurli's question with an agreement token, (yea::h) i.e., Gurli should dismount. Pavs accounts for this by adding "GA and Pax dismount aren't you GA?" On the one hand, Pavs ventriloquizes the SOP: GA (i.e., Gurli) and Pax (i.e., the NATO military advisor) dismount after the vehicle commander had swept the vehicles for such things as magnetic improvised explosive devices. And, on the other hand, the SOP is animating Pavs and speaking through him (upstream ventriloquizing). In short, the SOP and Pavs form what Fairhurst and Cooren (2009) call a hybrid presence of human and other-than-human. This is because, as Fairhurst and Cooren (2009) explain: "agency thus manifests itself in a hybrid of human and nonhuman forms because collectively, or by association, they all make a difference" (p. 472).

In the following turn, Gurli (line 4: "yeah") confirms that he is a guardian angel (GA), and therefore that he should have dismounted. In the continuation of his turn, using a contrastive "but," Gurli accounts for his action of staying in the vehicle by saying "it [i.e., to dismount] was not said." He then accounts for his actions by saying that because he was not explicitly told (by a human) to dismount, he stayed in the vehicle. Thus, in terms of leadership, he orients to the relevance of a human social actor telling him what to do in a particular circumstance, not an SOP.

Further, he orients to this situation as something problematic and which therefore has to be talked about when they get back to base. As Gurli sets out the solution (talk about it when we get home) to the problem (his failure to leave the vehicle), Pavs overlaps Gurli addressing the next turn to him by repeating Gurli three times. Gurli acknowledges

this attempt to get the floor (line 10: "yes") and when Pavs gets the floor he states that it (i.e., dismounting from the vehicle) is an SOP.

In line 11, Gurli agrees with this and after some more talk, accounting for his failure to dismount (not analyzed here for reasons of space), Gurli leaves the vehicle. By saying that leaving the vehicle is an SOP, Pavs explicitly animates, and is animated by, the SOP. In so doing, the SOP is presentified and made relevant and consequential to the interaction. As Benoit-Barné and Cooren (2009) explain, presentification signifies ways of speaking and acting that make present other-than-human and human actants that, although not being physically present, are transported thorough time and space so as to be present in, and so influential on, the unfolding situation. Moreover, as Benoit-Barné and Cooren (2009) argue, such ventriloquial acts "do" authority because they demonstrate that a proposal is authorized by a legitimate source. Authority, as Benoit-Barné and Cooren (2009) point out, differs from other acts of influence in that it is perceived to be in agreement with more or less established organizational roles, rules, practices, and beliefs. As such it is *an act of influence perceived to be* "*right*" because it is in concordance with accepted organizational structures (p. 6, italics added)

In this case, Pavs' turn at talk does authority because it ventriloquizes the legitimate source (i.e., the SOP) of the proposal to leave the crew compartment. The effect of this comes a few seconds later when Gurli gets up and leaves the vehicle. In other words, Gurli orients to Pavs' turn at talk as an order to leave the vehicle. As Latour (1996) famously said "to do is to make happen" (p. 237), so in this case the action of leaving the crew compartment is made to happen by the hybrid presence of Pavs and the SOP. Together, as a hybrid presence, they influence Gurli to take a particular course of action to fulfil organizational goals.

So, returning to our definition of leadership as a dynamic, interactive influence process among *both human and other-than-human actants in networks* for which the objective is to lead one another to the achievement of group or organizational goals or both, we argue that this short interaction illustrates leadership-in-action distributed across human and other-than-human actants. It is not Pavs alone who leads Gurli to take a particular action, nor is it the SOP alone – indeed Gurli displays that he is aware of the SOP but that he ignores it until he is reminded of it by Pavs. It is the hybrid presence of Pavs and the SOP that leads Gurli to act. Thus, leadership is not only dependent on the human social actor (in this case Pavs), but it is also dependent on the authoritative texts that he can deploy and make present, such as the SOP which also leads Gurli to act as he does. We therefore argue that leadership, as an interactional achievement, can be seen to be distributed between both human and other-than-human actants.

Conclusion

As Grint (2005) stated: "if leadership cannot be reduced to a naked and individual human then we should start to consider both the collective and the hybrid nature of leadership" (p. 62). It is exactly in response to this proposition that, aligning with Sergi (2023), we suggest that taking a CCO, and more specifically a ventriloquial, approach to leadership is one way, among others, of addressing the issue of leadership as a sociomaterial, rather than purely human, communicative practice. We argue that taking a ventriloquial approach to leadership works in synergy with three important trends in contemporary leadership research. First, not only does a ventriloquial approach complement trends in post-heroic leadership by showing that leadership is distributed across other-than-human, as well as human, actants, but it is also capable of giving such research a communicative edge by showing how leadership is communicatively enacted and distributed across human and other-than-human actants. Second, a ventriloquial approach to leadership builds on discursive approaches to leadership by moving beyond the talk of human social actors to illustrating how other-than-human actants are also an integral part of the communicative process of influencing, in and through which leadership is achieved as part of in situ social practice. Ventriloquism also offers a way of scaling up from local conversations to the organization writ large, which can be more problematic in purely discursive approaches such as conversation analysis. This is because a ventriloquial approach does not consider the communicative achievement of leadership solely in terms of localized inter-personal interaction, rather it shows how organizational texts, inter alia, that incarnate the organization also have a role to play in the doing of leadership. Third, a ventriloquial approach supplements studies in the sociomateriality of leadership by revealing how hybridity is brought off communicatively in the here-and-now of social interaction.

Considering the relatively limited amount of research, to date, which has combined leadership and CCO, and more specifically ventriloquial analyses, the canvas upon which researchers can write is still relatively blank and many avenues for further research remain open. For example, ventriloquial studies have investigated extensively the doing of authority (see, e.g., Benoit-Barné & Cooren, 2009). In the analysis that we have presented above, Pavs ventriloquizes the SOP "GA dismount" which authorizes him to say what he says and gives him legitimate authority which influences Gurli to act. In this particular case, authority could be seen as an integral part of leadership. However, we do not seek to extrapolate this finding to other situations. Under what local circumstance leadership and authority are intertwined and the extent to which

leadership relies on some form of authority deserve further and more in-depth investigation.

Also, in the brief analysis that we have presented here, we have looked at SOPs, but further research could look at the role of artefacts such as, in a military context, maps, human or electronic intelligence reports, "intelligent" weapon systems, and so on in leading. Further, in the analysis we have presented, Gurli is compliant, but if hybrid presences can be used to "do" leadership, the question of how hybrid presences can be used to resist leadership remains. Also, in our analyses we considered leadership as a process of influence. This offers a foundation for going on to analyze the ventriloquial achievement of different types of adjective-plus-leadership (e.g., transformational, servant, charismatic, etc.) which entail other definitions of leadership which may focus on other aspects of leadership such as vision, inspiration, or authenticity. Finally, as suggested by Holm and Fairhurst (2018), researchers could enhance analyses and open up avenues for further research through the use of post-hoc interviews with the participants.

We end this brief chapter with a call for action. On the one hand, this is a call for researchers who are already taking a ventriloquial approach to the study of organizational phenomena to seize the opportunity to provide new and innovative research in the field of leadership. And, on the other hand, this is a call for leadership researchers to consider what CCO, and more specifically ventriloquism, has to offer to their current research agendas. This potential for synergy could be particularly interesting for researchers who are already interested in the achievement of leadership as part of in situ communicative practice, but who want to go beyond the human to consider the communicative constitution of the hybridity of leadership.

Notes

1. Both ANT and the Montreal School prefer the term actant to actor. This is because the word "actant" avoids confusion with the more common usage of "social actor" which limits agency to that of the human and human intentions (Latour, 1999, p. 80).⏎
2. GA is an acronym for Guardian Angel, i.e., a soldier who, working in teams of two or three, bodyguards NATO advisors.⏎
3. Pax is a slang expression, taken from the travel industry, used by soldiers to refer to a passenger.⏎
4. Secure Personal Radio.⏎

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5

LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION FROM THE PERSPECTIVE OF LEADERSHIP-AS-PRACTICE

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-7

Introduction

It would not take anyone long to discover that there are no books, articles, or even chapters with titles that encompass leadership-as-practice (L-A-P) and communication. Closer perusal would reveal that the words "communication" and "communicate" seldom feature in the text of an article, chapter or book informed by L-A-P. It would be easy to jump to an assumption that L-A-P and communication have little to do with each other, although we note important exceptions throughout this chapter (such as Carroll, 2016; Carroll & Simpson, 2012; Crevani & Endrissat, 2016; Ramsey, 2016). We hold to the view that communication is not only at the heart of leadership (Tourish & Jackson, 2008), but "central, defining and constitutive" of it (Fairhurst & Connaughton, 2014, p. 8).

Such a contradiction of the concurrent significance but invisibility of a phenomena has been addressed by Jian et al. (2008) in their scrutiny of the relationship between leadership scholarship and communication more generically. They point to the general invisibility of communication in all but functionalist research where communication is anchored in linear processes of transmission and transaction. Approaches seeking to work with more language-sensitive concepts appear to simply avoid the term and indeed replace it with a wide variety of other words such as discourse, interaction, conversation, talk, and text. At this point, we need to note that such research does

indeed often identify and analyze communicative episodes and phenomena and contributes much to this domain. My starting point in this chapter is merely that such research seldom frames their inquiry within the field of communication and shows a reluctance to directly engage with communication as a field of theoretical and empirical terrain. The result is that any chapter on L-A-P and communication is going to have to frame communication as a "floating signifier" (Jian et al., 2008, p. 299), that is, as a construct we accept with an underdetermined meaning that can only be tracked through a whole raft of other signifiers that reference language related phenomena.

This chapter then is going to engage with the L-A-P and communication nexus as an invitation to "re-map" a terrain that is currently most characterized not by the absence of the direct "communication" discourse but the presence of its many "near-synonyms." It will start by searching for a communication orientation in L-A-P theory and ask how distinctive a communication orientation is to the notion of practice.

Searching for "Communication" in L-A-P

According to scholar and critic Margaret Collinson (2018, p. 368), "The practice view in a nutshell depicts immanent collective action emerging from mutual discursive, sometimes recurring and sometimes evolving patterns in the moment and over time among those engaged in the practice" (from Raelin, 2017, p. 216). While Collinson (2018, p. 369) is critical of the definition's "lack of theoretical significance and clarity," it does nonetheless point to L-A-P as firstly recognizing leadership as the property of a collective, secondly as a temporal process or something in movement, and thirdly as something constituted through moments and patterns as opposed to existing a priori.

Given that relational, complexity, and processual theories share some common assumptions, then any point of distinction around L-A-P must be around the significance of practice. We can take both an early and more contemporary definition of practice as "embodied, materially mediated arrays of human activity centrally organized around shared understandings" (Schatzki, 2001, p. 3) and "discrete spatiotemporal entities (comprised of actions, doings and sayings) linked by understandings, rules, material arrangements, and time-spaces" (Willocks, 2023, p. 708). Both definitions share a reference to human agency ("human activity" and "actions, doings and sayings"), materiality ("embodied, materially mediated arrays" and "discrete spatiotemporal entities"), and what we could call structure ("centrally organized around shared

understandings" and "linked by understandings, rules, material arrangements and time-spaces").

Crevani and Endrissat (2016) further attempt to pin down practice as both a unit of analysis and social accomplishment and make some important distinctions as they do so. They locate L-A-P within a relational ontology (as opposed to entitative) that is orientated to practice (as opposed to practices). In doing so they locate a practice approach within an emerging, unfolding dynamic as opposed to prioritizing existing entities or states. This is a key distinction as it suggests that leadership is an emergent accomplishment from the intersection of multiple phenomena and processes rather than an intentional act that can be attributed to anything singular. They further distinguish it from trait approaches that align leadership within or from individual and even relational approaches, which prioritize the "interactional dynamic" (p. 27) rather than the "doing" of leadership. Those distinctions may appear subtle and at times slight but become really important when we seek to assess the contribution of a practice perspective to leadership.

Crevani and Endrissat (2016, p. 38) also separate out L-A-P from other practice orientated approaches such as strategy-as-practice. They note that the practices involved in "the accomplishment of strategy" could strongly overlap with the practices that accomplish leadership. While they attempt to distinguish the two along temporal lines (strategy-as-practice as orientated to the future and L-A-P as orientated to the present), they do prompt us to ask the questions about what might distinguish leadership practice alongside all the other kinds of practice that become entangled in organizations and work. This is a question that more recent writing from Raelin (2023, p. 19) addresses directly. He depicts leadership in the practice view specifically as "unfolding social processes" that either "change the trajectory of the flow" or "change the turning points in the spaces between these participants." Those "unfolding social processes" could be attributed to a "new condition, a novel or better idea, a contextual event, or a unique solution" (Raelin, 2023, p. 23). Hence, the specific leadership component of the broader practice approach understands leadership as a disruption, discontinuity, or novelty to what is in play at any given time. Trajectory change and turning points, therefore, can act as clues and signals that enable a researcher to track leadership through the broader world of organizing practices without having to attribute it to an individual or any single phenomena.

All of these trajectory changes and turning points obviously involve communication as the "mutual discursive" and "sayings," which the earlier Collinson and Willock's definitions clearly signal. It is difficult to imagine communication and related concepts

as not central to L-A-P but, as we have argued, surprisingly rare to find them prioritized, and foregrounded. The bulk of L-A-P research assumes communication-type activity but doesn't always engage in-depth with it as a communicative phenomenon in and of itself. We could surmise that the bundled nature of practice (Schatzki, 2016, p. 32) means that communication is both "everywhere and nowhere." The next task therefore of this chapter is to differentiate the communication in L-A-P from other leadership approaches so we can properly recognize, acknowledge, and grapple with it.

Distinguishing Communication in L-A-P

This part of the chapter explores what would be distinctive about an L-A-P approach to communication. It does so in two ways. This section engages with communication across the leadership landscape employing a number of typologies that offer the opportunity to demonstrate where communication in L-A-P overlaps and/or pulls apart from communication in other leadership theorizations. The next section identifies research that fits this section's conceptualization of leadership as a communicative practice and discusses the nature of this research in more detail.

The typologies that construct this version of the landscape incorporate Collinson's (2018) typography of leadership approaches along heroic, post-heroic, and critical lines, Simpson's (2016) three types of agency (self-action, inter-action, and trans-action), and Fairhurst's (2014) distinction of communication as transmission, meaning, and interaction. I have extended these typologies to encompass the communicative constitution of organizations (CCO) (Cooren, 2018a, 2020). CCO's emphasis on materiality makes it a potentially interesting counterpoint to L-A-P, although it must be said from the outset that CCO is a relatively new entrant into the leadership studies field. The following doesn't represent a "complete" leadership and communication landscape, but a series of useful points of reference from which to locate and build leadership as a communicative practice. Table 5.1 gives an overview of these reference points with the proposed terrain of leadership as a communicative practice highlighted. This section will focus on the three non-highlighted rows leaving a focus on leadership as a communicative practice to the next section, the L-A-P.

Table 5.1 Leadership and Communication: Contrasting Four Approaches

Approaches to leadership (from Collinson, 2018)	*Theorizing action and agency (from Simpson, 2016)*	*Theorizing communication (from Fairhurst, 2014)*	*Leadership principles and issues (derived generally from research)*
Functionalist (heroic)	Self-action	Communication as transmission	*Principles* Individual/entity centered Positional formal leader role focussed Leader follower relationship as transactional *Critique* Linearity Leader-centrism Overly rational and cognitive approach to communication
Social constructionist (post-heroic)	Inter-action	Communication as meaning Communication as interaction	*Principles* Communication/language/discourse considered constitutive, not merely reflective, of reality Leadership as embodied, situational, contextual, processual Language/discourse attuned *Critique* Relies often on one primary point of focus (discourse or interaction or conversation) to the exclusion of other entangled phenomena
CCO (post-heroic)	Hybrid	Communication as organization	Hybrid and beyond human agency recognized Text/interaction analysis Authority/power is made visible through text and interaction

			Critique Limited by what is directly evoked in text and interaction Orientated towards agency (as opposed to structure) Underdoes attention to macro and structural power
Leadership-as-practice (post-heroic)	Trans-action	Communication as practice	*Principles* Process orientated and recognizes leadership/followership as an accomplishment Practice/"doing" based Leadership as emergent within interactions and routines and temporal flow Recognizes artefacts, spaces, non-language dimensions *Critique* Lacking a focus on power Recognizes but doesn't tend to analyze agency beyond human agents Difficult to differentiate leadership/non-leadership in interactions

Collinson provides a simple breakdown of leadership studies into the three domains of heroic, post-heroic, and critical paradigms. Heroic approaches reflect the dominant functionalist paradigm and encompass much of what would be termed mainstream research. Those tend to attribute leadership to individuals and pay attention to the traits, behaviors, styles, motivations, and characteristics of those in positions that appear to assume leadership. Such leadership is strongly interested in the performance of leaders and is driven by assumptions of effectiveness, positiveness, and success. The individual is pre-eminent in the heroic paradigm with an identification of some individuals as leaders and the recipients of that leadership as followers. Drawing from pragmatic theory, Simpson argues that what underpins heroic leadership is the assumption of self-action where "things, or entities, act under their own powers" (Dewey & Bentley, 1949, as cited in Simpson, 2016, p. 160). She is critical of such an assumption as the result of

"mechanistic logics that draw overly simplistic connections between discrete phenomena" (2016, p. 160), but acknowledges their pervasiveness and dominance over much of the mainstream leadership studies field.

Frames of heroism and self-action understand communication as transmission. Here communication is "a simple transmission, a process variable, or a behavioral outcome" (Fairhurst, 2014, p. 9). Communication becomes a channel for something that essentially is conveyed from the psyche of an individual to the psyche of a recipient or audience. Communication is, therefore, "a conduit that carries messages, a lens that filters information, or a link that connects people or social units" (Jian et al., 2008, p. 301). Research orients to improving transmission in terms of the choice of channels, direction, distribution, and reception. Its appeal to heroic and functionalist approaches to leadership is motivated by performing more effectively as a leader, lending itself to mostly quantitative and experimental research methodologies that simplify the communication process.

Post-heroic approaches to leadership constitute a rich range of theories seeking to decenter leadership from individuals, switch from a psychological to a sociological framing, adopt a processual rather than an entitative perspective, and anchor it in relational, collective, and distributed dynamics (Collinson, 2018). Crevani et al. (2010, p. 81) characterize leadership in such a paradigm as understood as "socially constructed, emergent organizing embedded in sociocultural contexts." The different theories under this approach, while differing significantly on "the how," agree on the need to look beyond the individual and their attributes to recognize and attribute leadership. What underpins such explorations is what Simpson terms "inter-action" conducted by "inter-acting entities" who can be "understood as things, essences, actions, states of being, discourses, practices, institutions, or indeed any circumscribed, substantialist unit of inquiry" (2018, p. 620). While inter-action appears to greatly expand the phenomena that constitute leadership, Simpson points out that is still a largely entitative perspective that assumes entities "come first" (p. 640). which means it can better account for followers, context, artefacts, spaces, and processes but not necessarily power, inequality, asymmetry, and identity.

Post-heroic, social constructionist research into communication privileges meaning. What it means to privilege meaning, however, is not straightforward; for example, the emphasis may be relational (being "in relation to"), intersubjective (shared assumptions in-between social actors), interactional (action involving others), discursive (the production of meaning through text and language forms), or sociomaterial (the entanglement of people, processes, technologies, and artefacts). It is probably better to

understand these different approaches as related with clear overlaps and blurred boundaries between all the above approaches. What they all share, however, is a more expansive and complex understanding of communication, which we could term "more muscular" i.e., communication is constitutive, performative and "the essence of action" (Flores, 2013, p. 5). Crevani et al. (2010, p. 80) usefully frame the research required to grapple with such communication as focusing on "situated micro-processes in organizations" and the tracking of such "micro-processes to societal discourses on leadership on macro- and meso-levels."

One more distinctive member of this post-heroic family (although reluctant to put the "social" in front of constructionism due to its emphasis on the "material"), CCO is well worth discussing explicitly here given it "engineers a major reversal" (Schoeneborn et al., 2019 p. 476) in our understanding of the relationship between organization and communication. Here communication is radically transformed from something that happens "in" organizations to the very phenomena that constitutes organization and organizing. This is a reversal from seeing communication as "not merely a participant in organization (e.g., functionalist approaches) but, much more radically, [as] equivalent to organization" (Schoeneborn et al., 2019, p. 476). CCO is better understood as an umbrella term for a number of perspectives that privilege the constitutive power of communicative interaction and texts (see Chapter 4 by Clifton & Barfod in this volume). Hence, the discussion of CCO in this chapter is confined to the principles that offer a broad base of comparison with the other approaches discussed.

The first of these is materiality and the challenge in "taking matter seriously" (Cooren, 2020, p. 2). Given this is also a crucial claim of L-A-P, it becomes a critical debate in any comparison of the two approaches. For CCO, "taking matter seriously" means to "to stop thinking about the material world as something ontologically separated or severed from the social" and the vehicle to do so is to "understand materiality communicatively" (Cooren, 2020, p. 3). Communication becomes the site that holds the material and social in a relationship i.e., "the way two beings are held in common or held together" (Cooren, 2018b, pp. 283–4). Human agents, therefore, need to be understood "as media through which other beings communicate" (Cooren, 2018, p. 279), rendering conversation as active processes of becoming, relating, and constituting.

Second and, relatedly, is hybridity. As Grint (2005, p. 2) famously noted, "leadership is essentially hybrid in nature" where "there are, in effect, almost no cases of successful human leadership bereft of any "non-human" supplement – that is naked." CCO, in effect, recognizes "the contributions of many types of 'actants' in the

constitution" (Fairhurst & Cooren, 2009, p. 472) of organization itself, but also related phenomena such as leadership. Leadership may be comprised of both human and nonhuman actants. Hence "a variety of forms of agency is always in play in any interaction" (Del Fa & Kärreman, 2022, p. 168), and it is communication that materializes and authorizes such hybrid agency.

In leadership studies, CCO owes much to Gail Fairhurst's (2007) *Discursive Leadership: In Conversation with Leadership Psychology*. It carved out from leadership's psychological norm a discursive approach to leadership that paid fine-grained analytic attention to how leadership materialized in situated interactional moments and episodes. Such fine-grained attention extended to human and nonhuman agents during the 9/11 terrorist attacks in which then New York Mayor, Rudy Giuliani, networked with a plenum of non-human agents, including "funeral rites, the 'fallen' and their remains, caskets covered by the American flag, fire trucks as hearses, uniformed officers as pallbearers, churches with bells tolling, children clutching their fathers' helmets" (p. 158). Fairhurst and Cooren (2009) showed how Hurricane Katrina found then Louisiana's Governor Kathleen Blanco overtaken by the hurricane and its related actants (floating bodies in the streets, insufficient plans, slow federal support) rendering her "flustered … overwhelmed … (and) shaken up" and the "antithesis of a heroic leadership or command presence" (p. 476).

The point, of course, is that neither Giuliani nor Blanco should be viewed as independent actors but "a distributed actor network of human and non-human entities" (Fairhurst, 2007, p. 170). They are recognized (or not) for their capacity to "mobilize or associate [themselves] with the central and sacred routines of authority (and its accoutrements)" (Fairhurst & Cooren, 2009, p. 476) in any given context. From a CCO perspective, leadership is "textual, scenic, technological, cultural, and embodied, that is, hybrid" (p. 476) which, while it usually contains individuals, cannot be attributed to them. Hence, a CCO perspective "demands that we reverse the causal direction typical in our theories: Individuals don't make communication so much as individuals are made by communication" (Shepherd, 1999, p. 163). The post-heroic dream of separating leadership from "the leader" thus is realized in a unique way.

Constituting Leadership as Communicative Practice

The starting point for this section on the nature of L-A-P centers on whether leadership-as-practice is just another "social constructionist variant" of post-heroic leadership (Collinson, 2018, p. 364) or whether it can be considered as distinctive in its own right.

Given that social constructionism encompasses a “family” of approaches that prioritize a particular phenomenon (e.g., interaction, relationship, discourse), then it would be fairly straightforward to prioritize “practice” and join that family. However, Kuhn (2021) argues that a practice approach “advances beyond the constructionist move" (p. 110) based on three commitments. First is sociality or “that situated actions are consequential for the generation of social life.” Second is complementarity over conflict, or “that dualisms are to be transcended in favour of dualities,” and third is relationality or “that relations (rather than entities) are the basis upon which phenomena exist.” The effect of these three commitments is the promise of practice as “a more thoroughgoing re-orientation for the entire field” (p. 110) through: 1) interrogating the construct of organization and organizing more radically; 2) works more powerfully with distributed agency; and 3) engaging more critically with power, control, and domination.

What offers the possibility of realizing such a promise is an exploration of the performative dimension of communicative practice (Raelin, 2023; Simpson et al., 2018). This exploration relies on the distinction between “practices” (“the stuff of human activity”) versus “practice” (“the ongoing, never-ending, always changing flow of action that emerges out of social engagement”) (Simpson, 2018, p. 647). This is an ontological distinction, primarily, given that “practices” leave the apparatus of leaders and followers largely intact thus prioritizing entities, while “practice” reframes leadership as the movement from an unfolding social process thus prioritizing process. Both “practices” and “practice” oriented research has been bundled under the L-A-P umbrella. However, working this distinction further should give L-A-P scholars the opportunity to cross “the invisible line” between the conventional and radical (Simpson, 2016, p. 164).

“Trans-action” marks the ontological point where practice crosses the line to the performative. Trans-action locates practice within a processual and agentic flow. Scholarly attention is diverted from entities “towards movement, flux, flow, emergence, passage, continuity, confluence, diffluence, turbulence and smoothness” (Simpson, 2016, p. 165) from which “new and un-folding meanings” (trans-actions) emerge from “human or non-human, micro or macro” agents (trans-actors) (Simpson, 2016, p. 167). This is characterized powerfully as "'doings' over time rather than the isolated 'doers' of action" (Simpson, 2016, p. 168). Practice is thus a “trans-actional accomplishment” and central to such an accomplishment. It is what Simpson variously terms a “conversation of gestures,” “conversational process,” or “ongoing dialogical accomplishment of meaning” (p. 168). Leadership emerges in turning points provided through collective

agency that produces movement. Communicative practice (in its broadest sense of bundled words and action) constitutes these turning points.

Consider three such examples of exemplary L-A-P research. The first is Ramsey's (2016) process of conversational travel which, as its name suggests, offers a way of studying "conversations as 'wholes' as opposed to their 'constituent parts'" (p. 202). Here conversation is a form of communication that needs to be understood as visceral, responsive, invitational, improvizational, and in movement. Changes to the trajectory of that conversation can be considered leadership, but such changes always come from relational and social interplay and the dynamics of the travelling; they cannot be attributed to any single entity, prior intention, or single conversational element. Ramsey (2016) analyzes a conversation between four health sector leaders and identifies those critical moments that change the nature and trajectory of the travelling. She proposes that analysing the travelling enables researchers to: 1) hone in on shifts, turning points, and the "re-invigoration of practice" (p. 214); 2) recognize the generativity of conversation with their capacity to co-create multiple trajectories going forward; and 3) acknowledge the bundling of utterances and responses (offers, blocks, acceptances) to co-constitute leadership practice.

Second, Carroll and Simpson (2012) closely track a series of postings between an in-house leadership development group on a dedicated online platform where programme participants initiate online conversations on organization issues that concern them. Carroll and Simpson (2012) identify a series of frames that the group draw on and then a series of movements involving those frames: 1) creating or offering a frame (kindling); 2) fleshing out a frame (stretching); and 3) connecting more than one frame (spanning). Kindling, stretching, and spanning are characterized as three forms of communicative practice that refine a collective identity, develop sociality (social capital), and negotiate power dynamics. Carroll and Simpson (2012) ultimately seek to redefine leadership development experiences as "liminal spaces" (p. 1305) where the creation, adoption, and collective use of such practices become "the work" of claiming and exercising leadership.

Finally, Carroll's (2016) ethnographic study of leadership in an IT firm focuses on a stand-up meeting that had become a daily routine for each team. Her attention was focussed on one team that essentially followed the lead of a koosh ball whose appearance caused them to form into a stand-up circle and, when tossed from person to person, established a speaking order for a team check-in. In this example, spaces and artefacts were central to the communicative practice (the koosh ball itself, the wall chart with post-it notes tracking project progress, the layout of the room where multiple

groups worked within their own and across others). This was not in the CCO sense of being materialized within communication, but as agents brought into relation to each other and the human agents enrolled to accomplish a routine from which leadership might/might not emerge. Carroll (2016) argues that the space and artefacts support a distributed leadership practice where leadership appears deliberately low key so as to foreground the technical expertise that can emerge from any agent through any communicative activity such as the stand-up meeting she observed.

All three examples differ in their focus on conversation, online, and material-spatial forums, but they share a commitment to a radical/performative practice ontology and a particular attentiveness to communicative practice. In all three, communicative practice offers the potential to locate, track, and explore the collective "doings and sayings" that accomplish leadership over a period of time. The practices (offering, blocking, and accepting conversational gestures; kindling, stretching, and spanning, and tossing a koosh ball in a stand-up meeting) create a space of potential leadership emergence. In all three, it is the communicative practices that direct the leadership without communication as a phenomenon being explicitly evoked.

Future Directions

This chapter ends by offering some directions for a future research agenda centered on leadership as communicative practice. In so doing, I seek to renew the promise offered by Jian et al. (2008) to better locate communication in relation to "key process issues – such as co-creation, connection, uniqueness, and emergence – associated with the *experience* of interacting with others" (p. 315). Such a promise speaks to exactly the performative, trans-actional theorization of practice that this chapter has committed L-A-P to but also its original commitment "to put something of the lived experience of such a landscape into words" (Carroll et al., 2008, p. 364) for both academics and practitioners. Jian et al. (2008), after all, make the point that "organizational participants much more readily identify themselves as communicators than discourse analysts" (p. 315), thus it is the experience of being leadership communicators that L-A-P should pursue.

The three examples of communication orientated L-A-P research from the previous section do help differentiate the L-A-P approach from the others, namely constructionist and CCO approaches. Three points of comparison seem salient here in that L-A-P: 1) pays attention to communicative events and episodes as "wholes;" 2) tracks communicative trajectories and movement through identifying their turning points; and

3) analyzes how phenomena are brought into both existence and relationality with each other in communication. Unlike the majority of social constructionist approaches, leadership is not attributable to any one analytic strand, phenomenon or entity/entities but is bundled across the multiple dimensions of a practice. Unlike CCO, it does not rely on text or interaction to formally "speak" the spatial, material, and nonhuman but emphasizes a more processual tracking of what communicatively constitutes the accomplishment of leadership.

The methodology challenges of analysing the "whole" of communication, processual movement, and emergence, and the relationality that constitute practice is truly formidable. Unlike either social constructionism or CCO, it cannot rely on "seeking to split conversation into constituent parts" (Ramsey, 2016, p. 201) to "locate the 'bricks' from which conversations are built" (Ramsey, 2016, p. 202). This tends to rule out well-established communication methodologies centered exclusively on interactions, conversation, or discourse (although those could clearly contribute in part to practice methodologies). Indeed, a practice methodology might need to pioneer the intersections of such methodologies given processual turning points should be accessible from a wide variety of methodological lenses. This presumably is the "holistic methodology" that Kempster et al. (2016) advocate.

What should be crystal clear is that L-A-P has overrelied to date on interview-based studies much to its detriment. While interviews have a place as a component of a broader practice inquiry into leadership, they are not well placed to understand "historic antecedent influence, phenomena emergence, becoming and recursivity" (Kempster et al., 2016, p. 243). Indeed, their performed, retrospective quality tends to create a narrative that minimizes, transforms, and rationalizes the above into more cognitive, conceptual, and linear narratives than the "doing of leadership" that practice demands. Clearly, there should be an ethnographic, virtual ethnographic, and/or autoethnographic component of practice work to observe the sequencing, pacing, movement, transitions, turning points, and bundling through which L-A-P emerges. At that point, different and intersecting analytic frameworks around interaction, conversation, discourse, text, and other materialities can be drawn in. Within such a holistic methodology, the word "communication" could be reclaimed to indicate a level of analysis that reflects an attempt to work with the "whole" emergence or accomplishment of a practice. Such an ambition to work with "wholes" is perhaps ideally suited to everyday routines (online communication spaces, planned meetings, informal café conversations, email trails) whose repetition across time provides multiple chances to see similar constellations of practice actors come together in the

emergence of something distinctive and different each time. Leadership practice, of course, moves across different mediums, modes, forums and spaces, and a practice approach is well placed to track its communicative travelling.

An exhortation to work with "wholes" is ambitious and necessarily complex. An alternative would be to work more analytically with the turning points and trajectory changes through which L-A-P recognizes the appearance of leadership. Such trajectory changes or turning points could only arise in communicative episodes and/or be punctuated or confirmed by them thus suggesting that attention to communicative practice could progress L-A-P as a field. The identification of turning points and trajectory changes and the communicative practices that constituted them, of course, was the focus of the three L-A-P studies discussed earlier in this chapter (i.e., Carroll, 2016; Carroll & Simpson, 2012; Ramsey, 2016). However, while these provide excellent exemplars of such work, they didn't in themselves discuss the identification of turning points and trajectories as a methodological challenge. A number of questions present themselves at this point. What signifies such a turn or change, for instance, be it content, focus, form, emotional valence, movement of an agent, or conflictual energy (or some intersection of these)? Are researchers or communicative participants the best placed to do this identification work or can inquiry encompass a dialogue or debate that itself forms part of such research processes? What methodological practices including coding, theming, mapping, storying, and categorizing could be developed or adapted for such inquiry? The reward of future work along these lines seems high given L-A-P has never had a methodology "of its own" leaving L-A-P research often theoretically distinct but empirically disappointedly normative.

In addition to methodology, there would appear new and currently underutilized opportunities for leadership as communicative practice in the leadership development sphere. Such sites effectively are communicative spaces where leadership can be researched, co-created, practised, and evaluated as the development practice itself. Examples where development interventions have acted as sites of practice research include Carroll and Simpson's (2012) study of communicative practices in a participant led series of leadership conversations and Lloyd and Carroll's (2021) study of the discursive practices between CEO and frontline leadership occasioned by a rare joint leadership forum between the two. Examples where leadership development is approached as a site for explicit communicative practice development include Gergen and Hersted's (2016) chapter on developing leadership as dialogic practice and Raelin's (2010) piece on public reflection as a form of reflective practice. We should also note Iszatt-White et al.'s (2017) dialogic "testimonio" study of the power and

identity practices of working reflexively with learning participants to unsettle and destabilize traditional educator/learner asymmetries and power dynamics. If indeed "leadership is made in the doing" (Denyer & James, 2016), then much of that "doing" (p. 265) moves into and from the leadership development site offering the possibility of bringing inquiry and practice together into a shared leadership practice. That in itself provides new forms of communicative practice as evidenced in Kempster and Stewart's (2010) work where scholars and practitioners actively research leadership practice together in a way that seeks to speak to both research and practice domains.

Where there is the biggest challenge and possibility for L-A-P is in engaging with the "unresolved conflicts, ambiguities and debates" (Crevani, 2010, p. 81) that have closely followed its own development. Kempster (in Raelin et al., 2018) argues that L-A-P is still in the first stages of its theory development where it is focussed on concept introduction and elaboration. To move into the next stage, it needs to embrace "attention, argument and contestation" (p. 372) and adopt critique as a catalyst of its own further movement. Those critiques are well established now and tend to highlight power, resistance, materiality, agency, and structure as problematic for a practice approach. It's at this point we should take Kuhn's (2021) challenge of "refusing to see communication as merely one among many practices, as only one organizing phenomena" but "as practice" (p. 120). For him that necessitates a journey from practice to CCO to new materialism as a family of practice orientated approaches. That is out of our scope, but not out of our sympathy, for this chapter. However, if communication *is* practice then leadership, akin to following a thread in a labyrinth, can follow communication to arrive at practice.

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6

CRITICAL PERSPECTIVES ON LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-8

Leadership is one of the most widely researched areas in organization and management studies. Many studies concentrate on identifying effective leaders' traits, qualities, styles, and behaviors. These leader-centered and heroic perspectives pay less attention to the structural, cultural, and discursive conditions and consequences of leadership relations. Post-heroic approaches focus on relational and collective dynamics, examining processes such as distributed, shared, and collaborative leadership (Edwards & Bolden, 2023; Fairhurst et al., 2020). Shifting the analytical lens from the individual to the collective, post-heroic perspectives recognize the socially constructed nature of leadership and the importance of followers. Yet, these perspectives also tend to neglect the typically asymmetrical nature of leadership relations and leaders' exercise of power and control through more subtle processes. While organizations can certainly be understood as collective endeavors, their interdependence may be in tension with how organizational power and privilege is conferred, enacted, and legitimized.

Questioning the assumptions of both heroic and post-heroic perspectives, critical researchers show how power asymmetries, control practices, and their underlying political processes are frequently implicated in the conditions, processes, and consequences of leadership dynamics (e.g., Alvesson & Spicer, 2012; Collinson, 2011; Fairhurst, 2007; Wilson, 2016). These and other contributions acknowledge that, for good or ill, leaders exercise considerable power and influence in organizations, and

much of this is enacted through communication processes. Rather than focus narrowly on individual leaders' traits, styles, and behaviors, critical perspectives explore how, why, and with what consequences power and control dynamics reflect and reinforce leadership practices (and vice versa). They examine how leaders can exercise power and influence through communication and, equally, how communication processes may reinforce leaders' control and authority. Challenging deep-rooted ideas about the meaning of leadership, they also question the romanticism and excessive positivity often evident in leader-centered theories and practices (Collinson, 2020).

For critical leadership perspectives, how power and control are conceptualized, institutionalized, (re)produced, and legitimized within asymmetrical organizational structures, cultures, and practices is of primary theoretical and empirical concern. This explicit focus on power dynamics can in turn provide innovative insights into leadership communication processes. The term critical leadership studies (CLS) refers to a diverse set of perspectives from more established fields such as critical management studies, critical communication studies, postcolonialism, and (eco-)feminism as well as post-structuralism, radical psychology, and psychoanalysis. While sometimes offering competing perspectives, CLS share a view that leadership and power are inextricably linked and mutually-reinforcing. They see questions of power and politics as fundamental constructs of leadership dynamics even when the latter are more shared, distributed, or democratically established.

Critical perspectives contend that both leaders and managers are typically concerned to enact and maintain organizational control as a means of achieving effective performance. In this sense, they are informed by the critical management studies' focus on the twentieth century rise of management as the professional function concerned with organizational control (Edwards, 1979). Scientific management principles transferred knowledge and information from skilled manual workers to the new function of management. The ensuing deskilling of craft workers (Braverman, 1974) resulted in managers becoming proactive agents while shopfloor workers were largely cast as passive recipients. As companies expanded, hierarchy, technology, and bureaucracy became central features of organizational control and communication. More recently, digital technologies have enhanced leaders' and managers' capacity to control and communicate at a distance (Zuboff, 2019). Accordingly, knowledge, information, and communication have tended to become not only the top-down prerogative of leaders and senior managers, but also highly politicized, contested, and surveilling processes.

Critical studies recognize the centrality of communication in understanding leadership dynamics. Leaders typically play a key organizational role in defining

strategies, initiating change programmes, shaping structures and cultures as well as monitoring performance, providing rewards, applying sanctions, and in hiring and firing. In all these processes communication is vital. Critical studies are concerned to show that leaders' power is not so much a dependent variable or a commodity to be used or abused at will, but rather a deeply embedded and inescapable feature of leadership communication reproduced through organizational structures, cultures, relations, and practices. From a critical perspective, power is not only structural, hierarchical, material, and practice based, but also symbolic, cultural, discursive, psychological, intersectional, and relational (Lumby, 2018). Critical writers argue that (leaders') power can take many forms, and numerous theories are available to conceptualize these processes. Those examining the gendered dimensions of leadership are exemplary.

Gendered Leadership

Critical perspectives recognize that gender and intersectionality are important dynamics through which leadership power is often enacted and communicated. Historically and across many cultures, leadership has been male-dominated and assumed to be the preserve of men (Collinson, 2024). In contemporary societies and organizations, leadership is still frequently conflated with qualities and behaviors stereotypically associated with men and masculinity, such as rationality, authority, and toughness. Despite well-established equality legislation in Western countries, women continue to comprise a small fraction of those occupying senior leadership and boardroom positions (Fawcett Society, 2022). Typically, when people "think leader," they still "think male."

Feminist studies show how romanticized notions of the heroic and charismatic leader are saturated with assumptions of men and masculinity (Johnson & Lacerenza, 2019) and how organizational hierarchies often reflect and reinforce men's gendered power and control (Acker, 1990). Challenging taken-for-granted views that white, middle-aged men are inevitably the people in charge, feminist studies demonstrate that gender is an important source of power and influence typically embedded in organizations and communication dynamics (Lui, 2021; Lui & Baker, 2016). Drawing on discursive analysis of workplace interaction, Holmes (2009) documents how men often perform leadership in conventionally masculine ways through discourse styles of "hero" (authoritative), "father" (paternalistic), and "good bloke or mate" (egalitarian). Gregory and Alsarve (2024) show how men in leadership positions frequently

communicate by drawing on hypermasculine metaphors that view markets, business, and politics through the imagery of war or as highly competitive, masculine sports contests. Berdahl et al. (2018) reveal how the intense competition often found in men's "workplace contest cultures" significantly shapes and often distorts organizational communication.

Feminist studies have focussed on women's experiences of male-dominated leadership and management cultures (Wajcman, 1999), the barriers they face in climbing hierarchies (Carli & Eagly, 2011), the transformative potential of their leadership (Klenke, 2011), and possible differences in communication styles between women and men leaders (Rosener, 1990). Studies have also explored how women leaders navigate between cultures of masculinity and femininity (Hobbins et al., 2022), how they are represented in the media (Elliott & Stead, 2018), and how they can challenge gender stereotypes (Bowring, 2004). Similar (and overlapping) arguments can be made for other intersecting sources of power and inequality, such as race, ethnicity, religion, disability, and sexual orientation.

Informed by feminist research, critical studies of men and masculinities (CSMM) highlight the socially constructed, gendered, and intersectional nature of men and masculinities (Hearn et al., 2023). Rather than viewing masculinity as singular or universal, CSMM recognize that masculinities can take multiple, shifting, asymmetrical forms related to intersecting inequalities across time and space (Collinson et al., 2023; Connell & Wood, 2005). Connell's (1995) focus on hegemonic masculinity problematizes men's structural dominance over women and subordinated men, with particular emphasis on intersectional gendered power relations. She argues that gendered power relations are characterized by hegemonic (e.g., white, heterosexual, affluent, neo-colonial) and subordinate/non hegemonic masculinities (e.g., complicit, marginalized masculinities such as black, gay, working class).

A few studies have applied hegemonic masculinity to the critical analysis of senior organizational positions (Collinson, 2024; Kahn et al., 2022; Tiernari et al., 2010), including entrepreneurial founders (Hytti et al., 2024). Galea et al. (2022) argue that men maintain their power, privilege, and overrepresentation in senior positions through processes of homosociality: the informal gendered rules and communication networks through which some men collaborate with and support other men. Homosocial processes improve certain men's access to networks of power, conferring greater guidance, opportunities, and career advocacy while excluding women and undermining transparency. Poorhosseinzadeh and Strachan (2021) show how "the ideal executive" is defined as working long hours, being geographically and internationally mobile, having

an unbroken career path, and prioritizing career over family. These criteria tend to legitimize men as ideal candidates, to wit: single-minded careerists who avoid caring and family responsibilities.

The foregoing critical studies of organizational power, control, and gender/intersectionality have important implications for understanding leadership communication, as the next section elaborates.

Leadership, Power, and Communication

The history of leadership communication in management studies has tended to assume a transmissional view of human communication: one-way, a neglect of meaning in the communication process (e.g., Axley, 1984), and inattention to power processes. Contrary to this view, Smircich and Morgan (1982) argued that leaders exercise power symbolically by "managing meaning," i.e., defining "the situation here and now" in ways that suit their purposes. However, in these approaches leaders were still the primary symbolizing agents (Fairhurst, 2001). In the late 1980s, interactionist scholars addressed the relational aspects of human communication (neither leader-centric nor follower-centric), although issues of power were surface-level control patterns (e.g., Courtright et al., 1989). Scholars who believe that organizations are communicatively constituted (CCO approaches) have since addressed relationality with human and material actants, but they have been similarly criticized for their lack of attention to issues of power (Bisel et al., 2022).

Responding to this neglect, critical and discourse studies adopted a more constitutive, material, and complex (surface *and* deep-structured) view of power that is both relational and meaning-centered (Fairhurst & Putnam, 2014; Fairhurst & Uhl-Bien, 2012). Fairhurst's (2007) "discursive leadership" is emblematic in this regard, as surface-level power issues are cast in language and social interaction (little "d" discourse), while Foucault's (1975) view of discourse (big "D" Discourse) as enduring systems of thought captures deep structure power processes through disciplinary effects. The latter not only disciplines followers through various management Discourses, but disciplines leaders through executive coaching Discourses and a confessional technology between coach and leader.

Fairhurst and Connaughton (2014) subsequently argued that leadership communication is inherently power based, a site of contestation about the nature of leadership with the potential for reflexivity, moral accountability, and change. This focus on power, the politics of meaning, and the possibility of conflict and dissent are

central concerns for more critical approaches. Arguing that communication processes lie at the heart of the mutually constitutive interactions between leaders and followers, critical perspectives investigate the deeply relational and asymmetrical character of leadership communication. They reveal how communication, which is sometimes opaque and ambiguous, can shape leaders' and followers' ability to exert power, and how the search to achieve control can, in turn, influence the nature, extent, and effects of communication.

Critical leadership perspectives also show how leaders can enact power by drawing on ideologies that redefine sectional as universal interests, sometimes communicating in ways that pressurize followers to conform (Tourish & Willmott, 2023). Spector (2020) documents how "post-truth claims making" has emerged as a defining cultural and political communication phenomenon, fuelling the contemporary rise of autocrats and dictators. It is now an important tool of control for authoritarian political leaders posing as populists, for example, Donald Trump (Deye & Fairhurst, 2019). Ciulla (2020) contends that so-called strong man leaders communicate in ways specifically designed to intensify followers' resentment and grievances. Ashcraft (2022) argues that such manipulative communication strategies reinforce followers' "aggrieved masculinity" and dangerous sense of victimhood. These studies illustrate how leaders can use communication to reinforce their control and how their power is often exercised in and through messages, discourses, and ideologies.

Even in less conscious ways organizational power dynamics can be reproduced through localized communications and micro-interactions. For example, in face-to-face interactions hierarchical power and status differentials might be communicated simply in the ways individuals stand, sit, and hold their bodies (Sinclair, 2005), whether, and if so how, they make eye contact when communicating (Scott, 1985), the unwitting gestures they make, the words they choose (Wilson & Wedlock, 2023), the tone and cadence of their voices, the jokes they tell (Collinson, 2002), the clothes they wear (Elfving-Hwang, 2020), as well as in the physical arrangements and features of rooms and locations in which meetings take place (Dick & Collings, 2014). Through these and other localized leader-follower interactions power and identity can be unconsciously communicated and reproduced.

Similarly, the architecture of buildings can implicitly convey important messages about leaders' power, status, and their detachment from followers (Dale & Latham, 2015). Those in senior positions are typically located on the top floors of buildings, well away from subordinates and frontline operations, often with highly controlled and separated entries and exits. Spatial segregations such as these tend to constrain the

frequency and quality of leader-follower interactions and communication. This is particularly the case when organizational headquarters are located far away from frontline operations, and/or when communication is primarily virtual and digital and thus largely detached and disembodied (Bligh & Riggio, 2013). Critical studies argue that distance in all its many forms (e.g., hierarchical, spatial, geographical, technological, cultural, and psychological) constitutes an important barrier to effective organizational communication (Collinson, 2005). As the TV show "Undercover Boss" demonstrates, overcoming leader-follower distance typically improves communication, trust, mutual understanding, and organizational performance (Lambert & Holzman, 2011).

Having highlighted the importance of power (a)symmetries in shaping leadership communication processes, the chapter now considers two examples of coercive communication in practice drawn from the critical leadership literature.

Toxic Leadership Communication

Various studies document how leaders may communicate information to followers in coercive and intimidating ways creating cultures of fear, insecurity, and defensiveness (Kellerman, 2024; Schyns et al., 2019). Critical studies of dysfunctional, destructive, and toxic leadership (Lipman-Blumen, 2005; Matos et al., 2018) highlight the centrality of bullying and coercive forms of communication in some leaders' attempts to ensure conformity and increase productivity (Schyns & Hansbrough, 2010). Enron's rise and fall is a classic example of toxic leadership communication, revealing cult-like dynamics that rewarded follower conformity, punished employee dissent, and produced disastrous organizational and societal consequences (Tourish & Vatcha, 2005). At Enron, employees were regularly threatened with losing their jobs if they did not perform exactly as required. Experiencing high levels of anxiety in such intimidating cultures, employees can feel compelled to conform, or at minimum to give the appearance of conformity. In cultures of fear, employees may become defensive, risk-averse, and largely silent.

Toxic leaders can also exercise power by controlling the circulation of information (Pelletier et al., 2018). Leaders may, for example, communicate in secretive and covert ways through informal networks or closed-door meetings. In such cases, leaders' exercise of power through communication might be disguised, obscured, or denied. Lumby (2018) explores how subtle and indirect forms of leaders' power can influence communication and interaction by "shaping discussion and decisions," "acquiring the

support of others," "weakening opposition," "denying power," and "creating a favourable impression." Focusing on "stealth power," O'Connor et al. (2019) illustrate how higher education leaders in three different countries utilized covert and opaque communication to exercise control in secretive, invisible, and disguised ways.

Restricting information to only a small elite of senior people tends to both reflect and reinforce prevailing power relations. Yet, excessive secrecy can have destructive consequences. Excluding the flow of communication from all but an elite few can exacerbate the insecurities of the rank and file which, in turn, may fuel rumors and misinformation. As Foucault (1975) highlighted, power and knowledge are often mutually reinforcing and, in many cases, being uninformed and outside the channels of communication will disempower and subordinate employees. Power can therefore be enacted by *not* communicating.

Critical studies point to other possible leadership motives for withholding information. Power can be intoxicating (Owen, 2012) in ways that encourage leaders to be less empathetic (Asad & Sadler-Smith, 2020), unable or unwilling to appreciate other people's point of view (Useem, 2017). Senior positions typically confer greater autonomy, status, and privilege, but they may also nurture leaders' hubris, narcissism, and arrogance (Sadler-Smith, 2019). This, in turn, can inform a failure to consult – even a disregard of others' views – and a desire to hold onto power even when support for a leader fades. Power can also be corrupting (Kipnis, 1972). In so far as leaders enjoy high degrees of autonomy, they may come to believe they are protected from any potential costs of deception. Such perceptions of immunity are conducive to corruption (Giurge et al., 2021), corporate "psychopathology" (Boddy, 2011), and authoritarianism (Harms et al., 2018).

Toxic leadership communication can in turn inform problematic leadership decision making. Critical research on gender has found that men in organizations often construct masculine sub-cultures celebrating male breadwinner identities and men's heterosexuality (Cockburn, 1983). These cultures can be intimidating and humiliating for heterosexual women, some heterosexual men, and for homosexual women and men (Eigenmann, 2024). Yet, research suggests that men leaders sometimes view such dynamics as "normal" and "natural" and "turn a blind eye" (Collinson & Collinson, 1989, 1996). This can have significant consequences for employees and organizations when legal cases are lost, damages must be paid, and reputations undermined. As the #MeToo movement revealed, men in senior positions may use their hierarchical power to conceal information about sexual relationships with women subordinates. They may also resort to harassing subordinates in strategically ambiguous ways – messaging that

is deniable in a court of law but unambiguous to victims ("I'm just the friendly sort," "I was only joking").

Research also reveals how men leaders can misunderstand what constitutes harassment and misjudge the most effective ways to address victim's claims. Within the UK police service, research highlights how senior officers have ignored deeply masculine, "warrior" cultures characterized by overt sexual harassment, misogyny, and the abuse of women (Cunningham, 2022). Rather than deal with sexual harassment claims openly and formally, some men leaders try to protect perpetrators, blame victims, and resolve matters informally (Collinson & Collinson, 1992). Women's skepticism that their claims of harassment will be dealt with seriously and professionally remains an important barrier to disclosure. Having said that, the progress made by the #MeToo movement demonstrates the power of women's resistance to challenge men's sexual harassment and its mismanagement.

Men leaders' hypermasculine risk-taking and decision-making can even have lethal consequences. The tragically flawed decision-making by Morton-Thiokol executives that led to the Challenger disaster is a case in point (Maier & Messerschmidt, 1998). The all-male executive team overruled specialist advice about the threat to safety in launching the shuttle in very cold conditions, defining this as "an acceptable risk." Focussing narrowly on the task – "to get Challenger up" – their high-risk decision revealed a reckless indifference to its human consequences. The tragedy of the Challenger shuttle exemplifies the disastrous outcomes that can result from the hypermasculine tendency to downplay or underestimate risk. The cost-cutting scandal at Boeing with its disastrous effects on flight safety is another example of toxic leadership both in communications and decision-making (Fairhurst & Putnam, 2024).

The foregoing examples illustrate how toxic and coercive forms of communication can cloud leaders' judgment, resulting in risky and reckless decision-making with counter-productive, even lethal outcomes. In addition to toxic leadership, critical studies also point to an ostensibly more "positive" but in practice equally disciplinary way that power and communication can be enacted in leader-follower relations. Research has examined how, why, and with what consequences leaders communicate through excessively positive discourses and definitions of reality.

Prozac Leadership Communication

Positivity is widely seen as an important quality of effective leadership. Leaders who communicate in upbeat and optimistic ways are thought to inspire creativity, innovation,

and loyalty. Practitioner-oriented leadership books typically emphasize that effective leaders should display passionate commitment, infectious optimism, and enthusiastic confidence. In many workplaces "good news" is the order of the day, and employees are required to disclose "success stories" so they can be used in the PR strategies of marketing departments. In Western cultures the pressure to be positive is now so ubiquitous that it is rarely questioned (Ehrenreich, 2009). While it is certainly the case that leaders who communicate in positive and authentic ways are more likely to motivate employees, there is growing evidence that positive communication can also become excessive and insincere.

Research on Prozac leadership (Collinson, 2012) demonstrates that leaders who seek to communicate through excessively positive messages may divert attention away from important issues. Rather than concern themselves with the detailed challenges of policy construction and implementation, the overriding concern of Prozac leaders is to communicate positivity. They are not only over-optimistic themselves, but also demand positivity from those around them. Employees may respond to such pressures to be upbeat by censoring their views as a way of protecting themselves and their careers.

Believing their own rhetoric that everything is going well, Prozac leaders refuse to heed cautionary voices and alternative views, effectively silencing upward critical communication. As a result, they misunderstand or ignore problems, leaving organizations ill-prepared to deal with unforeseen events and setbacks. The absence of open debate, the silencing of committed employees, and the punishing of those who dissent typically result in overoptimistic projections, poor decisions, lack of timely responses to problems, and the potential for business collapse.

The Global Financial Crash of 2007–2008 is a case in point. In the years preceding the crash, excessively positive cultures fuelled a climate of reckless selling of subprime mortgages (Ehrenreich, 2009). Executives' over-optimism resulted in a collective failure to recognize the risks involved in extending credit and loans to people who could not afford to repay and then aggregating these debts into mortgage bonds before selling them on to other financial organizations. The result was huge corporate losses, the collapse of famous, longstanding financial organizations, and governments bailing out companies deemed "too big to fail."

In the UK, the Royal Bank of Scotland's (RBS) acquisition of the Dutch Bank ABN Amro in 2007 exemplifies how excessive positivity can inform executive decisions with disastrous consequences. Despite being the biggest banking takeover in history and fuelled by over-optimism and hubris, senior executives at RBS failed to undertake due diligence of the purchase (Fraser, 2015). Occurring just as the global liquidity crisis

began to bite, the deal fundamentally weakened RBS mainly because of ABN's exposure to the U.S. subprime mortgage crisis. The takeover threatened RBS's survival and the savings of millions. In 2009, RBS posted a loss of £24.1 billion, the biggest in U.K. corporate history. Consequently, RBS had to be bailed out by the U.K. government, and in 2025 the Bank remained, with: was still partly state-owned.

The tendency for leaders to insist on excessively positive communication can also have lethal outcomes. George W. Bush defined the role of U.S. President as one of "cheerleader:" encouraging optimism, inspiring confidence, dispelling doubts, and pumping up the spirit of national self-congratulation. In her memoires, Secretary of State Condoleezza Rice wrote that she withheld communicating various concerns to Bush precisely because he demanded optimism. Despite advance warnings about three major disasters during Bush's period in office – the 2001 attack on the World Trade Centre in New York; the 2005 Hurricane Katrina floods in New Orleans; and the 2007 financial meltdown – the Bush administration responses in each case were slow and inadequate.

These examples comport with critical researchers who argue that an optimistic bias in leadership communication can hinder people's ability to envisage worst case scenarios, undermine preparedness, and invite disaster. Cerulo (2006) described how FBI leaders in Washington repeatedly disregarded warnings of possible terrorist attacks by air, including the significant alert in the "Phoenix memo" prior to September 11. Within the FBI, a predominantly top-down flow of information combined with the complacency of over-optimism were fundamental barriers to communication. Cerulo concludes that President Bush's preoccupation with positivity eroded his administration's ability to anticipate major disasters and to deal with the consequences.

In sum, while positivity can be an empowering and effective mode of communication, it may also be unrealistic, manipulative, and counterproductive. The delusional optimism of Prozac leaders can damage performance by eroding trust, communication, and learning. Like toxic leadership, excessive positivity can close down constructive dialogue and two-way communication. By actively discouraging critical upward communication, Prozac leaders make it more likely that organizations will be less prepared to deal with future threats and dangers. More effective leadership communication is likely to emerge when leaders' optimism is combined with critical thinking, when their positivity is tempered with a willingness to confront difficult realities, and when an upbeat vision is blended with a capacity to listen to alternative voices.

Power-Resistance Dialectics

An emerging critical approach to understanding leadership views power as a dialectical process (Fairhurst & Collinson, 2023). Critical dialectical perspectives argue that asymmetrical power relations take multiple, economic, discursive, and embodied forms, interconnecting in ways that are mutually reinforcing but also sometimes in tension. They highlight how leaders' power can simultaneously be positive, productive, and empowering, as well as coercive, destructive, and corrupt. Dialectical perspectives also challenge the dichotomization and determinism evident in leadership studies (Collinson & Fairhurst, 2024). They eschew binaries like leader-follower, leader-manager, transformational-transactional, and so on, arguing that dichotomization oversimplifies complex interrelationships. Instead, leadership dialectics focus on "interdependent opposites aligned with forces that push-pull on each other like a rubber band and exist in an ongoing dynamic interplay as the poles implicate each other" (Putnam et al., 2016, p. 7).

Careful to avoid treating leaders' power as all-determining, dialectical perspectives recognize that control is rarely, if ever, fully achieved. Leaders' and managers' recurrent search for control tends to be fluid, unfinished, ongoing, and contested (McCabe et al., 2022). Critical dialectical approaches also contend that followers are frequently more proactive, knowledgeable, and oppositional than is often acknowledged (Collinson, 2020). They emphasize that leader–led relations always contain the potential for conflict and dissent (Zoller & Fairhurst, 2007). Leaders cannot simply assume followers' obedience or loyalty; indeed, their exercise of power and control can stimulate follower resistance (Gagnon & Collinson, 2017). Oppositional practices in organizations can take numerous forms including strikes, working-to-rule, output and knowledge restriction, working the system, whistleblowing, and sabotage (Courpasson & Vallas, 2016). In exceptional cases, subordinates may even (seek to) depose leaders. So rather than treat control and resistance as separate binaries, critical dialectical perspectives highlight their mutually reinforcing interconnections (Mumby, 2005).

Feminist studies demonstrate that resistance can take gendered forms. Research reveals, for example, how male-dominated, shop-floor countercultures are frequently characterized by masculine breadwinner identities, aggressive and profane forms of humor, and the elevation of "practical," manual work as confirmation of working-class manhood. Workers in countercultures are likely to be highly skeptical of leaders' excessively positive claims, for example, that the company is a collaborative team working harmoniously together (Collinson, 1992). Cockburn (1983) illustrates how in the U.K. printing industry male-dominated shop-floor countercultures and exclusionary trade union practices advantaged men, while subordinating women. Research in female-

dominated organizations suggests that women workers often engage in (feminine) countercultures characterized by similarly aggressive and sexualized joking practices.

Employees might express their opposition by withholding information and/or refusing to communicate openly with those in authority. Collinson (2000) identified two distinct forms of employee opposition. In "resistance through distance" employees are primarily concerned to differentiate themselves psychologically and culturally from the organization and those in power. In so doing they "distance" themselves and deny responsibility for organizational decision making. By contrast, in "resistance through persistence" employees seek to question and overturn managerial decisions, rendering them more visible, transparent, and accountable. To be successful, this demand for greater information and accountability must be extremely persistent and resilient.

Some writers argue that employee resistance is more likely to emerge when followers believe that leaders are exercising control in unfair, dictatorial, coercive, and/or nepotistic ways (Mumby et al., 2017). Equally, followers are more likely to resist when their views are being ignored, when they perceive leaders to be "out of touch" and/or when they detect discrepancies between leaders' policies and practices. Krysfeldt et al. (2024) found that employees in a Danish sports and fashion company were more likely to resist when they detected inconsistencies between managerial practices and the "Karma culture" introduced by management. Employees criticized managers for not living up to the cultural norms management had instigated. When employees identify such inconsistencies between managerial words and their actions, they can become increasingly cynical about leaders (Fleming, 2005).

While employees might be highly critical of leaders' toxic and Prozac practices, they may censor their views and camouflage their actions through a kind of resistance that "covers its own tracks" (Scott, 1985, p. 278). Seeking to avoid sanctions, followers may resist in more subtle and disguised ways, such as absenteeism, "foot-dragging," or disengagement. Employees may even undermine leaders' change initiatives simply by doing nothing (Grint, 2005). Disguised dissent is particularly likely where surveillance is extensive. Under the gaze of authority, individuals are increasingly aware of themselves as monitored objects and may disguise their response to "the gaze" in ways that are conformist (e.g., telling leaders what they want to hear) or more oppositional (e.g., restricting knowledge and output). Employees may respond to surveillance by restricting or massaging upward communication (Collinson, 1999, 2003).

In sum, the asymmetrical inter-relationships between power and resistance are persistent features of leadership communication. Focusing on power-resistance dialectics highlights how leadership communication can be paradoxical, contradictory,

and contested. These arguments in turn raise important questions for future critical research about what constitutes dissent in communication and about who resists, how, why, and with what consequences.

Conclusion

Critical perspectives examine the asymmetrical power relations and control strategies through which leadership communication processes are frequently enacted, often rationalized, sometimes resisted, and occasionally transformed. Exploring toxic and Prozac leadership in particular, this chapter has argued that both these communication processes can have coercive and disciplinary effects on followers, organizations, and even leaders themselves. The chapter has also considered the value of dialectical perspectives for leadership communication research, focussing especially on the often mutually reinforcing relationship between power and resistance. This suggests that leaders' attempts to control through communication may not only be permanently in flux and unfinished, but also paradoxical and contradictory, creating unintended consequences such as follower indifference, cynicism, disguised dissent, and/or more overt resistance.

Communication is a central and indeed defining feature of leadership. In many organizational contexts communication and leadership are inextricably linked and more research is needed to examine their interconnections and tensions. Future research could address other leadership dialectics and their interrelations, not least those between power relations, identity constructions, and communication processes. Of relevance here is the increasing use of online/digital communication and artificial intelligence. These disembodied modes of communication can crucially impact leader–follower relations in many ways. Equally, the dialectics between gender, intersectionality, and power is a fertile area for future critical research on leadership communication.

Also important is the related dialectic between communication (which tends to take symbolic forms) and material, physical, and embodied realities. While communication is increasingly recognized as a significant area of research in leadership studies (Fairhurst & Uhl-Bien, 2012), critical perspectives emphasize that there is also a need to explore the inter-connections between symbolic/linguistic/interactive processes and the material realities of organizations. Some critical writers have highlighted important links between class inequalities, capital accumulation, and leadership (e.g., Smolović Jones et al., 2022). It is certainly the case that leadership dynamics can be significantly enabled and shaped by capitalist, neo-liberal (and neo-colonial) agendas, and that

locating these dynamics within economic systems like capitalism requires further research (Kuhn et al., 2017). Suffice it to say here that by addressing these material and symbolic dialectics as they are enacted in practices of power, conformity, compliance, and resistance and by viewing them as a set of often mutually reinforcing but sometimes contradictory processes, critical perspectives have the potential to create new ways of understanding, researching, and enacting leadership communication.

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Further Reading

Baxter, L. A., & Montgomery, B. M. (1996). *Relating: Dialogues and dialectics*. New York: Guilford Press. (A brilliant analysis of the dialectical and dialogical nature of interpersonal communication and social life which the authors view as a "dynamic knot of contradictions, a ceaseless interplay between contrary or opposing tendencies" (p. 3).)

Cunningham, C. M., Hazel, M., & Hayes, T. J. (2020). Communication and leadership 2020: Intersectional, mindful, and digital. *Communication Research Trends*, *39*(1), 4–23. https://link.gale.com/apps/doc/A621691480/AONE?u=anon~881ab76d&sid=googleScholar&xid=119df90c (A good summary of important overlaps between communication and leadership.)

Kenski, K., & Jamieson, K. H. (Eds.). (2017). *The Oxford handbook of political communication.* Oxford: OUP. (A wide-ranging overview exploring contemporary thinking on the P/political nature of communication.)

Knights, D., Lui, H., Smolović-Jones, O., & Wilson, S. (Eds.). (2024). *The Routledge critical companion to leadership studies*. London: Routledge. (A useful companion covering contemporary thinking in critical leadership studies.)

Schedlitzki, D., Larsson, M., Carroll, B., Bligh, M. C., & Epitropaki, O. (Eds.). (2023). *The Sage handbook of leadership, 2nd edition*. London: Sage. (A valuable overview exploring contemporary thinking in leadership studies, including critical and dialectical approaches.)

7

THE DARK SIDE OF LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION

Dennis Tourish

DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-9

Introduction

There are at least 93 academic journals devoted exclusively to "leadership," in one context or another. Airport business books and practitioner-oriented outlets such as *Harvard Business Review* seem to imagine that all our problems can be solved if only the right leader is in place. As Tourish (2019) noted: "Leaders are often depicted as some version of Superman – strong, confident, bold, decisive, empathic and visionary. Researchers identify an ever-greater range of attributes and skills that all leaders should aspire to develop and which a select few are deemed to possess" (p. 161). While this may flatter CEOs and wannabe CEOs, it is questionable whether it accords with reality, or is in fact really helpful.

This chapter challenges the "relentless positivity" that Alvesson and Einola (2019) argue characterizes much of this discourse. It focuses on the communication practices that characterize what is termed the "dark side" of leadership. The chapter begins by defining what is meant by this term. It then proceeds to unpack how such leadership is manifest in the communication practices of dark side leaders. Their communication includes the relentless promotion of a unifying ideology and vision, often used to quash dissent and ensure excessive conformity. Examples are provided, particularly from the biotech firm Theranos. The resulting environment is conducive to hubris, and the chapter identifies some characteristics of hubristic communication. Such communication

often shades into what has been called bullshit, while also using the more familiar tool of outright lies. Finally, the chapter considers what can be done to reduce the prevalence of dark side leadership communication within business organizations.

The Dark Side of Leadership Defined

Dark side leaders are interested only in themselves. They lie, cheat, manipulate, and abuse their followers to achieve power, status, and wealth (Tourish, 2013). Such leadership can be found in business, politics, and throughout society. Mehraein et al.'s (2023) review of the literature on the dark side of leadership illustrates the multiple dysfunctional forms in which it manifests itself. Their literature search deployed 66 key terms, including hubris, exploitative leadership, abusive supervision, despotic leadership, toxic leadership, narcissism, psychopathy, petty tyranny, and poor leadership. Mehraein et al. (2023) also note three different approaches in the way that researchers define and approach the term "the dark side of leadership." Thus, "The first group focuses on negative outcomes as the basis of their definition… The second group emphasizes the leadership process, without tying it to outcomes… The third group, on the other hand, considers both process and outcomes in their definition" (p. 3). There is, they warn, the possibility here of considerable construct overlap and redundancy – that is, of different terms being used to describe the same things.

Another widely employed term is "destructive leadership." Marshall (2023) defines this as "the voluntary and intentional acts committed by specific bad or toxic leaders that are perceived by their followers (and others around them) as harmful to both the followers and the organization" (p. 42). Consequently, "coercion and force are invariably necessary and present in destructive leadership episodes." Einarsen et al.'s (2007) discussion of destructive leadership stresses the importance of "repeated and systematic behaviours" (p. 209). They therefore argue that "isolated misbehaviour such as an uncharacteristic outburst of unjustified anger" is not sufficient to indicate its presence. Everyone, after all, is prone to emotional lapses.

Fischer and Sitkin (2023) note that "destructive leadership is also often invoked as an umbrella term for the 'dark side of leadership' in general, spanning distinct concepts such as petty tyranny, toxic leadership, or simply bad leadership" (p. 349). Kulik and Alarcon (2016) raise the worrying possibility that "there may be an emerging trend that today's destructive leaders are learning to adapt, to transform themselves into constructive, successful leaders that nevertheless lead businesses in unethical directions and manipulate its members and constituents" (p. 248).

Mainstream leadership theorizing has been complicit in minimizing the importance of dark side leadership. Transformational leadership theory (Bass & Riggio, 2006), the dominant approach within leadership studies over several decades, puts "the leader" at the center of more or less solid hierarchies and stable networks in which greater agency is attached to the leader than to followers (Alvesson, 2020; Banks, 2008). Such leaders act *on* others rather than *alongside* them. They decide on a vision and then align followers' mind-sets with goals that are consistent with the vision, while assuming that such visions capture the unitarist interests of far more people than they do (Hartnell & Walumba, 2011). As Ford et al. (2023) point out, "in presuming harmony, leadership theories ignore organizational realities that are often hostile rather than inspiring" (p. 821). Consistent with this pervasive sense of denial, much of the literature on the role of CEOs assumes that their charisma, reputation, and symbolic power impacts positively on corporate reputation (Cravens et al., 2003) and firm performance (Pollach & Kerbler, 2011).

The more recently in vogue theory of authentic leadership (AL) suffers from similar problems. AL has been defined by its proponents as follows:

> a *pattern of leader behaviour that draws upon and promotes both positive psychological capacities and a positive ethical climate, to foster greater self-awareness and an internalised moral perspective, balanced processing of information, and relational transparency on the part of leaders working with followers, fostering positive self-development.*
>
> (Walumbwa et al., 2008, p. 94: Italics in the original)

It has been argued that such leaders satisfy followers' basic needs (Leroy et al., 2015) encourage followers to be more authentic in their own behaviors (Yagil & Medler-Liraz, 2014) and cause them to display moral courage (Hannah et al., 2011). It is also claimed that they produce superior business results (Walumbwa et al., 2011), exemplify high moral standards, integrity, and honesty, and that "their favourable reputation fosters positive expectations among employees, enhancing their levels of trust and willingness to cooperate with the leader for the benefit of the organization" (Hsieh & Wang, 2015, p. 2341). This is magical thinking masquerading as scholarship. It is somehow fitting that a number of key papers promoting the theory have been retracted from the premier journal *The Leadership Quarterly*, for insurmountable problems with statistical analysis. It turns out that much of the research promoting authentic leadership was inauthentic.

The problem is that the vast range of positive expectations that are promoted by enthusiasts for AL helps to justify the accumulation of power in the hands of leaders. Unscrupulous leaders abuse this power in the pursuit of self-interest, while using the language of authenticity to proclaim that they are acting for the common good. If the leader's vision genuinely benefits followers, all this may sometimes work out in everyone's interests. But, as Waldman (2023) points out, "there can be a fine line between vision and what might be viewed by others as simply insanity" (p. 332). It is in such dimly lit spaces that dark side leaders are free to roam.

Communication and the Dark Side of Leadership in Business

Here, I take a critical approach, to look at how the language of CEOs often "tacitly condones deceptive conduct or the possibility of active involvement by a CEO and senior executives in deceptive practices" (Craig & Amernic, 2021, p. 53). I follow Fairhurst and Connaughton (2014) in arguing that "leadership communication is inherently power-based, a site of contestation about the nature of leadership" (p. 8). Yet most discussions of the role that communication plays in leadership view it simply as "a strategic mechanism – or technique – to be employed by leaders in efforts to achieve specific purposes" (Ruben & Gigliotti, 2017, p. 12). This is an inadequate approach when viewing dark side leadership, since it ignores how oppressive power relations between leaders and followers are communicatively co-constructed. Applied to imbalanced power relationships in the workplace, dark side leaders use communication to promote a uniform definition of reality, claim to be following a noble purpose when in fact they are in hot pursuit of the opposite, and to signal the undesirability of dissent (Leclercq-Vandelannoitte, 2011). The "stories" that dark side leaders articulate "present certain ways of seeing the world which legitimize or condemn certain moral orders which are constituted in and through the interplay of relationships among people" (Clifton et al., 2020, p. 91).

Consider, for example, how banking CEOs tried to account for their role in the Great Recession of 2008, where the mis-selling of subprime mortgages precipitated a global crash in financial markets. Four banking CEOs from the UK provided testimony to the Treasury Committee of the UK House of Commons in 2009. Tourish and Hargie (2012) subsequently analyzed the root metaphors that characterized their testimony. They identified four such root metaphors, as follows. First, "the wisdom of the crowd," in that bankers claimed they were influenced by the behavior of significant others. Second, the bankers depicted themselves as the passive observers of events leading up to and

during the crisis. Third, they characterized themselves as victims of the crisis, sharing in the widespread pain it produced. Fourth, they sought to depict themselves as penitent learners, able and willing to improve. Tourish and Hargie (2012) concluded that their main intent was to frame public discussion of the crisis in terms which minimized their responsibility for what happened, while implicating everyone else in their accounts of who was to blame. Tourish and Hargie (2012) also argued that the impact of metaphors can be considered in terms of what they termed "the exclusion principle." This suggests that, while metaphors achieve some of their effects by a process of comparison between adjacent domains, and a consideration of differences between them, they can also seek to exclude categories of meaning from consideration. In this case, the bankers were attempting to minimize their own responsibility and diminish any sense of their agency for the crisis. Needless to say, when times were better they were more than keen to take full credit for anything remotely positive that occurred on their watch. This split approach – claiming credit for success but denying responsibility for failure – is a further trait of dark side leadership communication.

The Hazards of a Compelling Vision and a Unifying Ideology

Dark side leaders often attempt to conceal their real intentions by promoting a compelling vision and a unifying ideology (Waldman, 2023). Arguably, the rhetoric of higher aims – conveyed by such organizational ideals as changing the world, eradicating poverty, achieving peace, or transforming the health of the world's population – is used by dark side leaders to conceal venal and/or self-aggrandizing ends such as the pursuit of great wealth. I offer here the example of Theranos. This was a biotech company founded in 2003 by Elizabeth Holmes, then aged 19. At the time of writing, she is serving an 11-year jail sentence for fraud. The other senior person involved with Theranos, Ramesh "Sunny" Balwani, is serving a 13-year prison sentence. The company claimed it had developed a revolutionary technology that could administer hundreds of tests on small blood samples, thereby speeding up diagnosis and treatment. In fact, its technology never worked, and the blood tests Theranos said it had run were mostly carried out with technology bought from other companies for this purpose (Tourish & Willmott, 2023).[1] Deception and lies of this kind are common in the communication of dark side leaders. So is the attempt to camouflage these by boasting of good intentions.

Exemplifying this, Holmes declared the following in a *Fortune* (2014) magazine interview, broadcast before a large audience:

> I started this company because I believe that nothing matters more than what people go through today when you lose someone you loved because you found out it was too late in the process to do something about it… We have an opportunity to do good in the world… by building a business that is a vehicle for making a change in the world.

This emotive message had considerable appeal. In the *Fortune* interview, the audience spontaneously applauded her statement. But it was also useful for convincing Theranos's employees that they were among a chosen few fortunate enough to have more than just a job. They had devoted themselves to a noble cause. The incipient ideology also offered an invigorating sense of a shared identity – membership of a revolutionary movement out to change the world. Revealingly, the *Fortune* interview is captioned "*Elizabeth Holmes Mission*." Such a belief galvanized extra effort, but also policed dissent, since hard questions could be denounced as a challenge to the organization's unassailable moral purpose.

Following a number of resignations, Holmes convened a staff meeting in 2014 which exemplified her style of communication. During it, she announced "that she was building a religion. If there were any among them who didn't believe, they should leave" (Carreyrou, 2018, p. 173). This messianic message was reinforced by Balwani who declared that Theranos's blood testing technology would have the same impact on public health as antibiotics, and that the company was working "to build something that we think is magical." Being part of the "magic" of Theranos was presented as a unique opportunity for its staff to redouble their efforts to build a world-changing company that, of course, was also destined to enhance their vitae and future careers. But there was always an alternative. At the same meeting where Holmes talked of building a religion Balwani declared that anyone not prepared to "show complete devotion and unmitigated loyalty to the company should 'get the fuck out'" (Carreyrou, 2018, p. 173). Enticement and threat co-existed, in a style of communication that resembles what has been described as "coercive persuasion" (Tourish et al., 2009).

Exaggerated claims for a company's vision – e.g., we are changing the world – are a recurrent pattern in the communication of dark side leaders. WeWork and the rise and fall of its charismatic and founding CEO, Adam Neumann, provides yet another example of this dynamic. WeWork provides shared office space for freelance employees. Once valued at $47 billion, a failed effort to launch an Initial Public Offering saw over $40 billion in estimated value wiped out, and Neumann depart the company. He repeatedly declared that WeWork was creating a "revolution," and transforming the world by

bringing people together – bold and exaggerated claims for what was, and is, an organization renting office space (Brown & Farrell, 2021). It transpired that Neumann was using much of the money raised from investors to live like a billionaire rather than grow the business. Apparently, he took the view that the task of transforming the world could begin with transforming his own lifestyle.

Unidirectional Communication and Dark Side Leadership

Within most business organizations communication tends to flow from those in positions of authority to employees rather than the other way round (Tourish & Robson, 2006). Joullié et al. (2021, p. 6) point out that "Valid critical arguments… clarify problems, debunk fallacies, reveal biases and expose lies. Critical thinkers unmask autocrats, pseudo-experts advancing reasoning based on faulty data and others who, for various motives, seek to make issues appear unduly complex." It is precisely such "unmasking" that dark side leaders are keen to prevent. Accordingly, as Stein (2008) noted: "Corporate executives… use language in an effort to manage (which most commonly means to control) dissent. Their tactics include denying, constraining, subverting, transforming, quashing and discrediting challenges that oppose orthodox ideologies and policies" (p. 75).

Such was indeed the case within Theranos. Anyone who raised criticisms was instantly dismissed. In the gallows humor of employees, they had joined the ranks of "the disappeared." This one-way approach to communication suits dark side leaders, since it insulates them from critical feedback and reinforces their image as charismatic leaders atop the organizational pyramid, devoted only to the pursuit of noble goals. It also prevents them from developing a full awareness of the problems that arise from their decisions, and ultimately is a key factor in driving many organizations that they lead over the precipice to ruin. In consequence, dark side leaders are prone to hubris, which comes with additional communication dynamics that I now explore.

Hubristic Leadership Communication

Hubris is generally defined in terms of excessive self-confidence, over-optimism, exaggerated self-esteem, pride, and arrogance (Hayward, 2007; Sadler-Smith, 2019; Sadler-Smith et al., 2017). It has become a popular explanation for organizational failures in general (Bollaert & Petit, 2010). From a communication perspective, hubristic leaders also display excessive confidence in their own judgment, a messianic

manner of talking, and a disproportionate concern with image and presentation. Tourish (2020) cites the following testimony from a former banking CEO to illustrate this:

> (I) saw X standing on a platform talking to his troops about what they were going to do. It was very sophisticated. It reinforced their belief in themselves as participants in this transformation that was going to be wrought, and it very much reinforced their belief in him as their leader. Now, from his point of view, all these were desirable. And actually to endow people with internal rivalries with a sense of common purpose was not an easy thing. It's a performance. This is a highly theatrical business. And having people feel that they're part of some great wave, it's messianic.
>
> (p. 95)

I noted earlier in this chapter that critical upward communication is a widespread problem in organizations, particularly where dark side leaders are concerned. It is also a recurrent issue in studies of hubris. Tourish (2020) offers the following example from a male senior manager:

> A major financial services takeover was going down. A friend of mine… was in a meeting with the acquisition team, was running the takeover, and he sort of felt, you know, what's going on here? And the guy said… we just don't think this deal should be done. We think it's getting too expensive, it's getting too complex, the market's changing, we shouldn't be doing this deal. So this chum of mine said, well, have you told the chief executive or the chairman? No. So he told them, I'm having breakfast with him tomorrow morning. Shall I say there's concerns in the team about this? Anyway, so (they) are having breakfast, talking through what they need to go through. And (he said) there's a lot of concern about this deal in the team. So there was a bit of a pause, chief executive: clear your desk, get out, you're fired… . And if you open your mouth about this I will sue you to hell and back.
>
> (p. 100)

Abusive communication is thus an indispensable tool employed by hubristic leaders. Consistent with this, Button (2011) suggests that hubris is "marked by a settled disposition to reduce, shame, or humiliate others as a means of asserting, consolidating, or relishing in one's own relative pre-eminence" (p. 312).

Such abusive communication legitimizes the concentration of power in the hands of hubristic leaders, minimizes the importance of corrective communication from others, and assumes that the leader is entitled to demand complete devotion by employees to whatever corporate ideal is currently in favor. Fairhurst (2007) offers the example of Linda Wachner, at one point the CEO of apparel maker Warnaco. Wachner was profiled by *Fortune* magazine in 1993 as one of the seven "toughest" bosses in the U.S. On one occasion, she ordered a colleague to fire people at random to show that he was serious about improving performance. *Fortune's* profile reported that she had lectured senior executives in terms like this: "You're eunuchs. How can your wives stand you? You've got nothing between your legs." Her rationale was that this approach ensured that the company was run "efficiently," and that if people didn't like it, they could leave.

Subordination of the Self to Corporate Purpose

Consequently, one sign of dark side leadership communication in business is the persistent demand that employees devote themselves whole-heartedly to the corporate ideal and its requirement that work should colonize the entirety of their lives. Elon Musk infamously communicated with X (formerly Twitter) employees in precisely these terms following his takeover of the company in 2022. Emailing them at midnight Pacific time midweek, he informed them that they would be fired unless they committed to working at an "extremely hardcore" rate to build "Twitter 2.0." This meant that they would need to work "long hours at high intensity" or resign in return for three months' salary.[2]

Consider also the example of General Electric, under the leadership of Jack Welch, its CEO from 1981 to 2001. Despite the acclaim heaped on him during his tenure, many have viewed him as a dark side leader who ruthlessly prioritized shareholder value over the needs of employees, customers, or society (Amernic et al., 2007). To achieve this, he fired more than 100,000 employees in the 1980s, a quarter of the company's payroll. This earned him the nickname "Neutron Jack," since he got rid of people but left buildings intact. Such brutality became systematized through a Welch inspired appraisal system that he termed "differentiation." This compelled managers to rank their employees each year. They were divided into three categories, with the bottom ten per cent to be fired. Welch defended this as "always fighting to raise the bar" (Gelles, 2022, p. 28). If this sounds brutal, one wouldn't imagine so from Welch's own statements on the matter. Rather, he urged those who were adversely affected to see their termination as an act of kindness: "Some think it's cruel or brutal to remove the bottom 10 per cent

of our people… It isn't. Just the opposite. What I think is brutal and 'false kindness' is keeping people around who aren't going to grow and prosper" (Welch, 2001, p. 161). The job of managers, he asserted, was to "cull the weak" (Welch & Welch, 2005, p. 37) – a form of career euthanasia that those targeted were expected to welcome.

In terms of framing (Fairhurst, 1996), I suggest that several dynamics can be observed here. First, actions that can be viewed as detrimental are depicted as something positive – in this instance, kindness. Second, the underlying purpose behind it – the promotion of shareholder value – is viewed as so beyond interrogation that it doesn't even need to be stated. Third, power differentials are ignored. It is simply assumed that managers have the authority, and the requisite insights into each person's behavior, to take monumental decisions that often have a devastating impact on those concerned. Such rhetorical tropes are common to the narratives produced by those who see themselves as transformational leaders and who therefore have the right to impose their values on others (Clifton, 2019, 2020).

I also argue that dark side leaders rely on bullshit and lies in their communication to an inordinate extent.

Bullshit and Lies in the Communication of Dark Side Leaders

The philosopher Harry Frankfurt (2005) sparked a storm of interest in discourse that he defined as "bullshit." According to his analysis, bullshit involves a "lack of connection with a concern for the truth" and an "indifference to how things really are" (pp. 33–34). Following Frankfurt, Gabriel (2021) argues that:

> Bullshit is not just meaningless words but an unending stream of empty verbiage, hype, buzzwords, clichés, tedious puns and double entendres, self-referential parodies, witticisms, platitudes, banalities, half-truths and outright lies which neither speaker nor audience seriously expect or demand that they should represent reality in some accurate way.
>
> (p. 36)

Spicer (2020) defines bullshit as "empty and misleading communication." He argues that "bullshitters are driven by Machiavellian motives like deceiving their audience to gain power and resources" (p. 5). Gaining power and resources are, of course, central preoccupations for those who occupy leadership roles.

A good example comes from WeWork's Adam Neumann during a speech to employees:

> Thank you for being part of something that has a meaning… The thing that all of us know is, if you want to succeed in this world, you have to build something that has intention, everyone of us is here because it has a meaning – because we want to do something that actually makes the world a better place.
>
> (Brown & Farrell, 2021, p. 76)

Neumann's emphasis on changing the world was soon revealed as empty verbiage, designed to camouflage his real intention – enriching himself. Clearly, we need greater scepticism towards the communication of business leaders, perhaps never more so than when they are expressing noble aspirations. I recognize that not all such claims are bogus. But enough are to encourage caution.

None of this displaces the role and importance of outright lies in the statements made by dark side leaders. There is, of course, nothing new in the suggestion that leaders lie. Writing in the 16th century, Machiavelli (1532) counselled would-be leaders that "it is necessary… to be a great pretender and dissembler; and men are so simple, and so subject to present necessities, that he who seeks to deceive will always find someone who will allow himself to be deceived" (p. 46). As Spoelstra (2020) observes, "the relationship between leadership and truth is, and always has been, a complex one" (p. 758). He argues that promoting false images of the self is common, as leaders strive to project an aura of charisma and avoid implications of weakness. This dynamic can be understood in terms of what Gabriel (2016) describes as "narrative ecologies" – that is, communicative spaces where different narratives emerge, interact, compete, adapt, and die. The ability to create a dominant narrative is crucial for the acquisition of power. It tempts leaders to bend the truth into whatever shape they think will gain traction.

In one sense, this means that dark side leaders are like the rest of us. Research suggests that deception is widespread in human communication (Docan-Morgan, 2019). As Vrij (2007) concluded, lies "often serve as a social lubricant. Given this positive aspect of deception, it is not surprising that lying is a daily life event" (p. 335). Hargie's (2022) summary of the research suggests that some form of deception, albeit often in the form of "white lies," occurs in at least one quarter of all conversations. In contrast, I suggest that deception and lies are a defining feature of dark side leadership. This was certainly the case within Theranos, where a key objective was to maintain the

lie that the company had developed a working technology that would indeed deliver on its promises. This is much more common than we might like to think.

As one example, Trevor Milton, former CEO of the vehicle manufacturing firm Nikola, was convicted on three out of four charges of wire fraud in 2022. He claimed to have developed a battery technology using hydrogen that would enable vehicles to drive with zero emissions. But, in an echo of Theranos, the claimed technology did not exist. Nikola went to elaborate lengths to hide this. For example, it issued a video showing a lorry propelled along a country road by its technology. However, the wheels came off this particular deception when Hindenberg Research (2020) revealed the startling truth: "… the video was an elaborate ruse – Nikola had the truck towed to the top of a hill on a remote stretch of road and simply filmed it rolling down the hill."[3]

Conclusion

As Fairhurst et al. (Forthcoming) argue, "There has never been a time when leadership communication mattered so much and yet so little. Coming to terms with this paradox is a major challenge for leadership communication scholars today" (p. 3). What, then, is to be done? The management scholar Sydney Finkelstein has said that "Being the CEO of a sizable corporation today is probably the closest thing to being king of your own country." He went on to add: "that's a dangerous title to assume."[4] For the leader/ king there is the omnipresent fear of regicide. For the organizations that they lead, there is the prospect of an imbalanced leader making decisions that lead to ruin. As Grint (2000) put it, "the most successful leaders appear to be those who cultivate the least compliant followers, for when leaders err – and they always do – the leader with compliant followers will fail" (p. 420). Rebalancing power relationships will include rethinking the nature of followership, to encourage what I think of as "activist dissent" in which followers are enabled to challenge the views of those at the top. This would shift our focus on communication from how senior leaders can "get their message across" to one in which such messages are shaped by input from a much wider constituency than at present.

Lastly, I argue that the academic and popular literature on leadership needs to change. The literature has long suffered from a "heroic bias," in which all good things flow from the actions of leaders, who should therefore have more power to use communication to shape the behavior, attitudes, and feelings of others (Collinson et al., 2018). Despite growing interest, the dark side of leadership remains insufficiently explored. A more critical approach is needed if leadership scholars are to contribute to

creating a more sustainable world, in which the dark side of leadership is ushered towards the exit.

Notes

1. I draw extensively on Tourish and Willmott's paper in the analysis that follows.⏎
2. Website: www.businessinsider.com/read-musks-midnight-email-telling-twitter-staff-work-long-hours-2022-11?r=US&IR=T⏎
3. You can see the video in question at www.youtube.com/watch?v=b5TPIjiCd5c. Accessed 18 August 2023.⏎
4. See www.forbes.com/sites/ericjackson/2012/01/02/the-seven-habits-of-spectacularly-unsuccessful-executives/?sh=4f34bb86516b. Accessed 28 February 2023.⏎

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Further Reading

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article offers a thorough theoretical analysis of what bullshit is and how widely used it is in business.)

Tourish, D. (2013). *The Dark Side of Transformational Leadership: A Critical Perspective*. London: Routledge. (A critical analysis of transformational leadership theory, that also offers several case studies of the dark side in action.)

8

THE ETHICS OF LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-10

Organizational leadership is a process of influence that inevitably involves ethics (Yukl, 2012). This chapter provides an overview of recent advancements in leadership, communication, and ethics, which have implications for leadership communication. Specifically, the chapter explains that organizational members tend to avoid explicit discussion of widely shared standards of right and wrong conduct (i.e., ethics) as they relate to the specific and situated doing of work. Instead, discussions of ethics tend to occur abstractly and in ways that do not have immediate implications for decisions as they unfold – if discussions occur at all. In this chapter, these communication dynamics are described in detail and a new vision for leading organizational cultures marked by the normalization of explicitly ethical deliberation is described.

In pursuing organizational goals, a wide range of conduct may arise – not all of it ethical. For example, Enron's members – following the directions of top-level leaders – engaged in a variety of unethical business practices that bolstered its market position at the time but ultimately led to its demise (Bisel, 2018). Lessons learned from high-profile examples have pushed organizations and their titled leaders to question whether their standards of conduct are *right*, not just in terms of organizational prerogatives but also socially. Corporate social responsibility, for instance, is one common response companies pursue in the moral accounting of their organizational efforts (Deetz, 1995; Dhanesh, 2015). Accordingly, scholarly attention must be paid to the ethics of organizational practices and the processes of leadership influence that shape them.

Importantly, in the chapter that follows, the words "ethics" and "morals" are used interchangeably, in keeping with moral psychology. From a communication perspective, ethics and morals both refer to standards of right conduct and these labels tend to differ only in context-of-use – professional or personal, respectively.

Advancements in moral psychology and neuroscience since the turn of the century have revealed insights about human beings' ethical decision making, which can help inform the intersection of leadership, communication, and ethics. According to moral foundations theory and the latest science of moral decision making, moral intuitions are an innate feature of typical, healthy human brains from very early in life (Haidt, 2001). Furthermore, a small and finite set of innate moral intuitions (e.g., care/harm; fairness/cheating) are sensitized or desensitized via cultural messages and experiences throughout the lifespan (Haidt, 2013). While some cultures emphasize certain response sets to a moral intuition – thus, heightening the likelihood of its activation under certain circumstances – other cultures deemphasize them, resulting in less sensitive activations (Haidt, 2013). Differences in cultural elaborations of universal, biological foundations lead to a plethora of (mostly overlapping) ethical codes. In short, research reveals that ethics have both biological (innate) and cultural (learned) origins.

If ethics have biological and cultural origins, then organizational ethics do too. On one hand, typical, healthy humans are born with an innate sensitivity to right conduct (e.g., do not hurt people). Therefore, ethics span beyond the boundary of any one organization. Our moral outrage at cases such as Enron and our moral admiration for whistleblowing and corporate social responsibility demonstrate this point well: Organizations are beholden to ethical standards somewhat apart from their internal cultures or professional norms. On the other hand, and in keeping with moral foundations theory, over time local organizational cultures are an important influence on members' moral intuitions, deliberation, and decision making. Organizational culture comes to shape, in large part, what actions activate our moral intuitions and which do not (Haidt, 2001, 2013). Furthermore, *leaders*' interactions with members are a potent source of organizational culture creation and reinforcement (Keyton, 2010).

The following section explains the contemporary research on organizational communication as it relates to conversations about workplace ethics. But first, to understand that scholarship, an important distinction should be made: Generally, ethics-related communication in organizations can be classified under two types of talk: there-and-then versus here-and-now. There-and-then ethics talk can be commonplace and occurs when communicators are *not* directly involved in the object of conversation, such as when coworkers express disgust with a politician's philandering (Bisel, 2018).

Such talk has little relevance for the adaptation of work. Here-and-now ethics talk, on the other hand, is much less common, referring to discussions of "some decision, action, or practice that has real consequences for those involved in the conversation" (Bisel, 2018, p. 102). When consequences of ethics-related talk and deliberation are real, individuals have good reason to change unethical organizational routines. Thus, here-and-now ethics talk is preferable to there-and-then ethics talk for understanding how leaders' communication can shape the ethical dimensions of organizational culture in situ.

Leadership Framing and Culture

Titled leaders' communication is important in creating and maintaining organizational culture and is especially influential in sanctioning standards of right conduct (or not) – that is, for an organization's ethics (Keyton, 2010). Framing is a process by which leaders can shape organizational reality, including organizational ethics. A *frame* refers to a belief about how the world should or does operate, and *framing* is an attempt to influence others' frames (Fairhurst, 2010; Fairhurst & Sarr, 1996). From a communication perspective, the process of organizational leadership unfolds as a series of framing attempts about aspects of experience and behavior in organizations. These frames and framing attempts are conveyed through messages – that is, they are communicated, and anybody with the ability to formulate and convey messages has some capacity to frame reality. Importantly, the most influential frames take poetic forms, such as metaphor, contrast, story, spin, or jargon (Fairhurst & Sarr, 1996) and come from those with the authority to sanction others materially (i.e., titled leaders). Furthermore, individuals act in accordance with their *frames* of reality – according to their beliefs about how the world should or does operate, though they may not always be aware of this correspondence.

The concept of leader framing itself is ethically-neutral and does not privilege any particular standard of conduct. That is, framing itself is an instrument of reality construction (Fairhurst, 2010). This conceptualization implies that leadership can be diffused through interactants with capacity to generate and share framed messages. While conceptually neutral, framing is ethically laden in practice. We observe that organizational authority to sanction others materially is rarely diffused but is rather often concentrated in a small number of organizational members – C-level executives, a board of directors, or managers. Similarly, though anyone may attempt framing an experience, *successful* framing tends to be concentrated wherever power is

concentrated – in both positional and personal power bases (Rahim, 2009; Yukl, 2009). In short, power holders have advantages in their framing attempts. Moreover, leadership becomes defined reflexively by successful framing attempts, and the adoption of frames by others defines the cultural reality of an organization. Insofar as ethics are influenced by culturally-defined sensitivities toward moral foundations, it follows that successful framing also engenders elaborating organizational ethics and moral actions that follow (Palmer, 2012).

Unfortunately, organizational leaders do not always put forth ethically excellent frames for other members, and therefore, sometimes members' moral intuitions are *dulled* by organizational culture. Though self-interest and corruption play roles in leadership framing resulting in unethical behavior, other less malicious forces, such as bounded rationality (Simon, 1991) and psychosocial coping (Weick et al., 2005), may also contribute. Whenever members experience ambiguity in their environment, they require a frame to make sense of what may have transpired and what therefore to do next (Weick, 1995; Weick et al., 2005). However, individuals are imperfect at extracting information from their environments, so frames offered to address such ambiguities are never based on complete information (Weick, 1995). Limited individual capabilities paired with time constraints often result in "satisficing" responses to problems (Simon, 1991). Furthermore, the impulse of individuals is to produce frames that alleviate identity-based anxieties, often at the expense of adaptiveness and accuracy (Weick et al., 2005). Here, defensive and self-serving frames may be soothing, but they may also fail to consider downstream ethical consequences (Palmer, 2012).

Moreover, the repetition of frames comes to constitute organizational culture. Culture refers to

> a pattern of shared basic assumptions that was learned by a group as it solved its problems of external adaptation and internal integration, that has worked well enough to be considered valid, and therefore, to be taught to new members as the correct way to perceive, think, and feel in relation to those problems.
>
> (Schein, 2010, p. 17)

These patterns of assumptions are manifested in norms and espoused values (Schein, 2010). Norms refer to expected and accepted behaviors that, when followed, typically allow individuals "to avoid rejection and gain social approval" (Cialdini et al., 1999, p. 196). In other words, norms are the cultural and behavioral blueprints by which

members go about their routine operations. In sum, leadership framing influences the formation, maintenance, and change of organizational culture.

The Problem: Moral Mindlessness and Organizational Communication Patterns

Routines permeate organizations. On one hand, routines help make members' responses to organizational situations more uniform and predictable. On the other hand, new and evolving situations will often mean that yesterday's routines will not match today's challenges (Weick & Sutcliffe, 2015). Yet, ordinary sensemaking processes in organizations tend to guide members into overreliance on routines, which, over time, can reduce how well teams and organizations perform. Overreliance on routine can result in a sense of "autopilot" or widespread *mindlessness* – an inactive state of mind characterized by an inability to notice new differences and distinctions. Not surprisingly, mindlessness is common in organizations and a key source of big and small mistakes (Palmer, 2012). Importantly, *moral* mindlessness in organizations is common, too. Here, moral mindlessness refers to a widespread tendency toward a failure to adjust routines based on evolving ethical concerns and aspirations. Moral mindlessness is often the result of socialization forces and face-saving dynamics in organizational communication (Bisel, 2018).

Contemporary scholarship in organizational communication ethics demonstrated that members do not discuss private ethical concerns openly or candidly (Bisel et al., 2011). Additionally, the silencing power of power exacerbates the "rhetorical absence" of explicitly-moralized here-and-now ethics talk during upward ethical dissent episodes (Ploeger et al., 2011). Instead, private ethical concerns tend to be *displaced* to friends and family outside the organization (Kassing & Armstrong, 2002), or *replaced* by silence (Morrison, 2014), ethics-neutral policy discussions (Bisel & Kramer, 2014), or conversations about money (Sonenshein, 2007). The displacement and replacement of here-and-now ethics talk in organizations means that members and managers will rarely be confronted with the idea that policies and practices need ethical updating. Furthermore, pervasive absence of here-and-now ethics talk in organizations can make incremental rationalizations, self-deception, and corruption more likely (Anand et al., 2004). In sum, "if employees cannot label behavior as unethical publicly, organizational members will be unable to reflect on those judgments collectively and, in turn, will remain unable to update their work practices and policies accordingly" (Bisel &

Adame, 2019, p. 139). Thus, advancements in organizational communication support the notion that moral mindlessness in organizations is unfortunately widespread.

An Analogy: Mindfulness and High Reliability Organizing

These advances in our understanding of organizational communication ethics raise pressing questions for leadership communication scholars and leaders. We put the question this way: *What can leaders do, if anything, to cultivate organizations marked by ethically-reliable performances, given that open discussion of ethics in workplaces is so rare and complicated?* Despite the challenges of that question, important analogies exist. Applications of analogical problem-solving has been known to provide breakthroughs in engineering (Ball & Christenson, 2009) and business (Wright et al., 2004). Importantly, organizational communication scholars have been working on a similar problem for more than three decades.

Scholarship on high-reliability teams and organizations (HRT&Os) emerged at the end of the last century (Scott et al., 2023). High-reliability teams and organizations accomplish tasks that could threaten human life and wellbeing (e.g., Roeder et al., 2021). Surgical teams, military, and wildland firefighting organizations are just a few examples of HRT&Os (Jahn & Black, 2017). The high-hazard exigencies faced by HRT&Os means that their members tend to develop unique cultural mindsets that can be observable in their rare – yet admirable – work practices and norms (Weick & Sutcliffe, 2015). Investigations of these teams and organizations were motivated by a theoretically interesting observation: Namely, that these forms of high-risk organizing tended to be remarkably good at suppressing mindless mistakes and performing reliably, despite the difficulty of their tasks and the challenges of their operational environments. In other words, how is it that 20-somethings manage to do the work of operating nuclear aircraft carriers so mindfully and reliably, despite such challenging circumstances? High reliability organizing (HRO) theory suggest that the answer lies in cultural influences that tend to arise when the potential for catastrophic outcomes (e.g., death) must be avoided (Barbour & Gill, 2017). More specifically, HRT&Os tend to reinforce cultures that encourage members' collective mindfulness – rich and ongoing awareness of discriminatory detail distributed among members (Weick & Sutcliffe, 2015). That collective mindfulness helps organizational members remain humble and vigilant in ways that avoid or mitigate catastrophe.

Weick and Sutcliffe's (2007, 2015) books outlined five cultural values enacted by members, which create a system-wide culture of mindfulness and, in turn, suppress

mistakes. According to the theory, three cultural value commitments shape how HRT&O members think about future possible errors and their detection (i.e., preoccupation with failure, reluctance to simplify, and sensitivity to operations). Two cultural value commitments shape how members correct the presence of errors (i.e., commitments to resilience and deference to expertise). Importantly, these cultural elements – when enacted and reinforced – tend to help members maintain a shared posture in which mistakes are expected, reported, and corrected quickly by accumulated resources. According to the theory, these cultures are created by *small wins* (i.e., taking concrete, controllable steps of moderate importance that earn minor, but visible results; Weick, 1984), which can be accomplished in the ordinary flow of work through communication norms (e.g., Roeder et al., 2021) and leadership communication practices (Jahn & Black, 2017).

Importantly, HRT&O theory assumes that mindfulness culture is, in part, a product of informal *and* formal leadership processes. Mindfulness culture can be reinforced informally through the leadership of any influential organizational member via championing and role modeling of practices. Similarly, mindfulness culture can be reinforced by the beliefs, values, and actions of titled leaders, especially if they are perceived as credible figures and as consistent in their allocation of organizational rewards (Weick & Sutcliffe, 2007, 2015).

HRT&O theory explains how organizational culture can help members to reduce mistakes, in part, through normalizing communication systems that encourage the avoidance of or reporting-and-remediation of errors. These intellectual contributions represent an exciting analogy to leading cultures that can *minimize organizational wrongdoing* by normalizing communication systems that encourage the avoidance of or reporting-and-remediation of ethical lapses while they remain resolvable and before they become large and intractable.

A Theoretical Framework and Research Agenda for Leading Organizational Ethics

Mistakes made in the context of HRT&Os can result in tragic outcomes. Similarly, unethical organizational behaviors can link and amplify to cause devastating outcomes for stakeholders, members, organizational reputations, and even global stability. Bisel (2018) leveraged that similarity by proposing an extension of high-reliability organization (HRO) theory designed to deal specifically with leading organizational

cultures marked by ethically-reliable performances, named *ethically-reliable organization* (ERO) theory.

According to ERO theory, ethical organizations will tend to develop a system-wide culture of moral mindfulness through the enactment of specific cultural value commitments (see below). *Moral mindfulness* refers to an ongoing, updating of the discriminatory details of right conduct. Similar to HRO cultures, the collective mindset of moral mindfulness is admirable, but likely *un*common. The main idea is that common and ordinary sensemaking processes in organizations will tend to make organizational members increasingly complacent and prideful about their assumed ethicality (Bisel, 2018). Believing the organization and its members are *un*ethical is an anxiety-inducing attribution, which members will tend to avoid via sensemaking that soothes egos through defensiveness and rationalizations (Ploeger & Bisel, 2013). Anxiety-soothing complacency and pride around ethics will tend to dampen the ongoing updating about right conduct that is needed for moral mindfulness. Yet, according to ERO theory, EROs will tend to avoid those common traps and keep moral mindfulness active through the reinforcement of ERO cultural values (Bisel & Adame, 2019).

Bisel (2018) proposed that five cultural value commitments support the rise of moral mindfulness in organizations. Importantly, both culturing (Keyton, 2010) and mindfulness are reciprocally influenced by communication processes (Burgoon et al., 2000). ERO theory provides a theoretical framework from which to explore how strategic (a) *leadership* communication can shape (b) organizational members' *moral* mindfulness and (c) *ethical* organizational culture. To be clear, the values and practices described below assume that "leadership" can involve the influence of coworker/role-model champions as well as powerholders' messages and behaviors. Presumably, the alignment of both informal and formal organizational leadership processes give rise to the strongest forms of cultural influence on members' moral mindfulness. Thus, use of the term, *leader(ship)*, in the following section should be applied with these points in mind. In the following, we explain each ERO cultural value commitment in turn and then provide several ideas for how leaders can communicate strategically to reinforce each value. Taken together, these represent a set of leadership communication principles and practices for leading ethical organizational cultures. Furthermore, many of these recommendations have yet to be tested empirically and thus represent a research agenda for confirming and extending ERO theory.

Preoccupation with Institutionalizing Ethical Excellence

EROs are characterized by ongoing collective attention to how routines can be closer to ethical ideals while being skeptical of the possibility of ethical perfection, which is labeled *preoccupation with institutionalizing ethical excellence* (Bisel, 2018). Here, two equal and opposite errors are actively avoided. On one hand, in non-EROs, many discussions and decision making around organizational ethics presume that if a course of action is technically *not unethical*, it must therefore be ethical. That presumptive frame tends to short-circuit further deliberation and reflection. ERO theory explains that ethically-reliable organization members move beyond such low standards for ethical deliberation and aspire to ethical excellence, thereby creating a range of nuance for richer deliberation. On the other hand, ethical perfection – or the desire to be seen as ethically flawless – is another potential pitfall. For example, Enron was an award-winning company for its outstanding ethics – a credibility bolstering achievement that may have lulled management into thinking that the "ethics issue" was already mastered (Treviño & Brown, 2004). ERO theory explains that ERO members assume ethical perfection is impossible and a problematic impediment to seeing where (moral) improvement is needed (Ploeger & Bisel, 2013).

The following are leadership communication practices that enact a preoccupation with institutionalizing ethical excellence. First and foremost, the value is reinforced where leaders find and correct those organizational routines that virtually require even minor unethical behaviors. For example, sometimes contradictory timecard reporting policies can make it virtually mandatory for employees to report wrong data into electronic databases to get paid (Bisel, 2018). Identifying those problematic routines, correcting them, and notifying employees of changes enact this ERO cultural value. Second, leaders can engage in framing by collecting and sharing stories of ethical excellence by members. Third, leaders can provide (minor) confessional and cautionary stories of themselves in which being mindless or on autopilot resulted in less-than ethically ideal actions. Fourth, mantras that mock perfection can be helpful, such as *Learning laughs at perfection*, and *Perfection and its pride are the enemies of good ethics*. Finally, leaders can make phrases, such as *ethical excellence*, or *less than ethically ideal* commonplace in moving ethics-related conversations beyond the common, problematic binary standard of ethical versus not-unethical.

Future research should use qualitative positive deviance case studies (Bisel et al., 2020) to confirm and elaborate on how informal and formal leaders of ethically excellent organizations get members to avoid the twin pitfalls described here. Furthermore, experimental designs can help researchers to confirm whether the

storytelling and ethics-related sayings recommended above result in greater willingness to engage in upward ethical dissent.

Commitment to Interpersonal Consideration

EROs are characterized by ongoing concern for the integrity of stakeholder connections with one another and especially to the organization broadly, which is termed *commitment to interpersonal consideration*. In other words, this cultural value commitment is seen in action where members, especially powerholders, show concern for how organizational decisions affect even single individual members and stakeholders, such as customers and community members (Bisel, 2018). Thus, organizational policy deliberation will involve a rich interplay of give-and-take, which includes individual stakeholder's interests as a genuine element of concern. Furthermore, here-and-now ethics-related conversations and decisions in the workplace can be emotionally charged and have the potential to shame and alienate individual members. Without question, severe and criminal acts of wrongdoing should result in termination of organizational membership. However, for ambiguous and minor lapses, ERO theory recommends that individuals' connection to the organization be a relevant influence on decision making and relating. "Making a practice of considering individuals' interpersonal connection to the organization stimulates moral mindfulness by expanding the categories of ethical thinking to include interests of the organization … individuals … and their connections" (Bisel, 2018, p. 201).

The following are leadership communication practices that enact commitment to interpersonal consideration. First, leaders can engage in framing by collecting and sharing stories of customers or members who were grateful to the organization for considering how planned changes would affect them personally. The inclusion of exceptions, addendums, workarounds, and grandfathering in planned changes enact this value. Second, leaders can tell cautionary tales of times decisions were made too quickly and their implications for customers or members resulted in harm. Third, and likewise, leaders can collect and tell stories of times when giving a member a second chance after an infraction or minor lapse resulted in redemption and greater long-term loyalty to the organization (Kelley & Bisel, 2014). Fourth, leaders can make a habit of asking members regularly how upcoming changes or decisions might affect them personally.

Future studies should collect retrospective accounts from members, bosses, and bystander-coworkers of redemption or "second chance" moments and their

consequences for employee-organization relationships (EOR) and coworker perceptions of (in)justice. Additionally, researchers could conduct cross-sectional survey-based studies to confirm whether a relationship exists between inquiries into how policy changes affect stakeholders and their organizational commitment as well as their perceptions of ethical organizational climate.

Reluctance to Simplify Ethical Applications

EROs are characterized by a doubt that present situations can be reduced to or solved by a single ethical principle. Similarly, there is a healthy skepticism that past ethics-related decisions will work mechanistically for present cases. Taken together, this mindset is termed *reluctance to simplify ethical applications* (Bisel, 2018). Without question, ethical principles are widely agreed upon. For example, caring for innocent people and conducting fair business dealings are principles that have widespread support across time and national cultures (Haidt, 2013). Yet, in actual practice, ethical principles will only be experienced phenomenologically – that is, in the context of lived situations with all their particularities and messiness. In other words, there remains a space between ethical principles in the abstract and the complex reality of ethical practice in experience. Members of EROs are aware of that space, which motivates an ongoing humility in their conversations about here-and-now ethics. Practically, a reluctance to simplify ethical applications means that ERO members will enact a readiness to rethink past policies and practices aloud together in terms of their ethical fit for the present situation and do so with tempered defensiveness.

The following are leadership communication practices that enact a reluctance to simplify ethical applications. First and foremost, carving out regular times and spaces for members to reflect aloud together about the ethics of work and its unfolding situations is important. The harried nature of work life means that institutionalizing time for reflection – much less ethical reflection – is a major cultural accomplishment. These times and spaces can be integrated into existing after-action-reviews, debriefings, or post-mortem meetings (Keiser & Arthur, 2021). Second, members can use language forms that signal the need for vigilance in which members doubt and update the ethics of organizational routines ongoingly (Burgoon & Langer, 1995; Maitlis & Sonenshein, 2010). Examples of conditional language forms include qualifying expressions, such as *perhaps*, *at this time*, *it seems*, and *considered from one point of view*. Third, leaders can emphasize valuing context-boundedness with questions that ask about the ethics of

this situation and ethics considering *current circumstances*. Fourth, members can emphasize uniqueness of the present situation and use surprising turns-of-phrase.

Future studies could engage in action research by identifying existing teams and organizations where after-actions-reviews (AARs) are already practiced regularly. Then, researchers could collaborate with members on strategies for integrating ethical deliberation explicitly in AARs, alongside operational and logistical reviews of action. Finally, researchers could observe and ask members whether important – but previously undiscussed – ethical concerns surface verbally and get discussed aloud together, resulting in nuanced decisional changes. Additionally, researchers could create language processing experiments to determine whether conditional language forms from leaders and influential members about work situations help individuals reason through ethical challenges with greater detail, contingency, and sensitivity.

Deference to Embodied Moral Knowing

EROs are characterized by honoring the use of plain language about ethical concerns and references to what the body "knows," which is termed deference *to embodied moral knowing*. In other words, ERO theory recommends normalizing the voicing of organizational communication about emotional and physical cues our bodies send us about the ethics of situations (Bisel, 2018). Ethics-related conversations can seem too fuzzy, naïve, philosophical, or religious to be appropriate in organizational settings (Treviño et al., 2000). Perhaps normative and philosophical writing on organizational ethics themselves have (unfortunately) contributed to those concerns, which tend to result in moral muteness (Bird & Waters, 1989). Yet, when organizational members do not discuss their private ethical concerns publicly, they cannot deliberate as a group aloud together about ethics (Bisel, 2018). When ethics talk does occur, it can quickly become the domain of those members who are most verbally-skillful, while excluding voices that are not. In contrast, ERO theory recommends that organizational members honor plain talk about ethics from all voices as much or more than complex legal or ethics-related jargon. Even more specifically, ERO theory recommends use of here-and-now ethics talk that describes the signals we receive from our emotions and bodies. One practice ERO members may use for enacting this value is talking about their bodily signals and perceptions. Advances in neuroscience, brain imagining, and behavioral ethics have demonstrated that healthy human beings make ethical evaluations very rapidly and without much effort (Haidt, 2013; Kish-Gephart et al., 2010). Indeed, a relevant portion of ethical cognitions are emotional, intuitive, and even *bodily*

(Damasio, 1994). Furthermore, ethical cognitions are available to healthy humans at a very early, even preverbal, age (Hamlin, 2015). To be clear, "feelings need not be a final arbiter of decision making, but they can be an important input," to ethics-related deliberation (Bisel, 2018, p. 244). The point is getting members' private moral concerns voiced publicly, so that their contributions can increase requisite complexity and improve the ethical excellence of ordinary organizational decision making.

The following are leadership communication practices that enact deference to embodied moral knowing. Leaders and members can engage in framing by role-modeling and normalizing the use of bodily references and metaphors, such as *my gut says*, *my heart was hurt by*, and *that gives me goosebumps*. Second, leaders and members can make a habit of asking others their opinions of policy and practice changes with reference to emotional and physical cues, such as with *What does your gut say about this?* and *What are our hearts telling us here?*

Experimental data demonstrated that employees were more likely to deny an unethical business request on explicitly-ethical grounds from managers who were known for using body-referencing language in conversation with them (Bisel & Adame, 2019). Future research should continue to validate and extend this interesting leadership communication finding as well as explore its influence on reducing acquiescent and defensive forms of employee silence, especially ethical silence among employees.

Sensitivity to the Ethics of Operations (SEO)

EROs are characterized by an ongoing monitoring for ethical lapses, which is usually achieved through upward communication and listening in the context of trusting work relationships. Written differently, EROs are attentive to "the ethics of decisions and actions at the frontline, where the real work of the organization gets done" (Bisel, 2018, p. 245). That ongoing monitoring and attentiveness is labeled *sensitivity to the ethics of operations*. Here, the notion is that organizational ethics are deeply embedded in the *doing* of the organization's everyday work (Palmer, 2012). As such, ERO theory proposes that those who are doing the work of the organization have a crucial vantage point and should be valued as important barometers regarding the details of ongoing operational decisions and actions. Yet, in most organizations, frontline employees have limited organizational decision-making authority. In EROs, upward and candid ethics-related concerns and aspirations are voiced and considered. The silencing power of power, which is common in non-EROs (Ploeger et al., 2011), is supplanted by ongoing efforts to build and maintain mutual trust across levels of hierarchy. Frontline

employees trust that sharing their ethics-related concerns candidly will not result in browbeating or retribution, but sincere listening and discernment.

The following are leadership communication practices that enact a sensitivity to the ethics of operations. First, leaders and members can engage in framing by role-modeling and normalizing the use of explicitly ethical language by using vocabulary, such as *ethics*, *integrity*, and *morals*, related to conversations about the here-and-now. Second, and perhaps even more powerfully, leaders and members can ask one another about their opinions of policy and practice changes with these explicitly-moralized terms. The net effect will be to make here-and-now ethics talk commonplace and reduce its stigma.

Experimental data demonstrated that employees were more likely to deny an unethical business request from manager they trusted and who were known for using explicitly-moralized language in conversation with them (Zanin et al., 2016). Future research should continue to validate and extend this finding. Additionally, researchers could collect qualitative retrospective accounts of the sensebreaking and sensemaking that may occur for members who experience leaders' normalization of explicitly-moralized language at work.

Conclusion

In conclusion, contemporary communication ethics scholarship has identified strong influences that push ethics-based deliberations out of the workplace. Yet, organizational members remain unable to think about the ethics of real work *together* until they can talk about the ethics of real work *aloud together*. Ethical leadership must help to solve that problem by normalizing explicit ethics-based deliberations. Ethically-reliable organization (ERO) theory represents a promising way forward for scholars and practitioners interested in promoting ethical leadership and more humane organizations.

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9

IDENTITY-CONSTITUTIVE LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION

Discourse, Crisis, and Morality

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-11

The chapter title calls forth three of the most prolific literatures in the social sciences – those of leadership, communication, and identity. Thorough reviews are beyond the scope of this chapter. Instead, the focus is on their nexus in several specific ways that suggest a way forward in research that could be theoretically novel and practically relevant for our times.

Toward that end, the chapter proposes a focused view of *identity-constitutive leadership communication* as that which is uttered by an actor with the effect of providing "clarity" (comprehensibility and plausibility) in the face of complex or ill-defined problems, especially while other actors have fallen short of doing so. If taken up in subsequent communication as having had that effect, that actor is positioned *in situ* as influencing and leading, discursively constituting (for whatever duration) a "leader(ship)" identity. Identity-constitutive leadership communication does *not* merely simplify problems or erase uncertainty but instead articulates and provides a way forward through complexity that is often tensional/paradoxical. The chapter elaborates three discursive perspectives to analyze *how* communication can constitute a leader identity – membership categorization, discourse analysis, and "communication as constitutive of organization" (CCO). Two illustrative types of communicatively constituted leader identities are presented that have generated growing literatures that

call for further work: (1) crisis-based leader identity; and (2) moral/ethical leader identity.

Identity-Constitutive Leadership Communication: A Focused Perspective

U.S. Coast Guard Admiral (retired) Thad Allen has been interviewed and described as an exemplar of leadership in multiple studies and articles since his pivotal roles in leading Coast Guard responses to such crises as the 2005 Hurricane Katrina disaster and the 2010 Deepwater Horizon oil spill. I had the privilege of interacting with (following) Admiral Allen when we were both cadets in the same company at the U.S. Coast Guard Academy (he was two years my senior), and I admired his leadership and character even in those early days of his career. Shotter and Tsoukas (2014, p. 226) described Admiral Allen as having "the mental agility required when confronting a complex, fast-moving crisis." That is, he demonstrated the ability to "bring into clear focus a line of action, which, so to speak, will fit the irregular contours of a particular circumstance, and the inner experiences (feelings) involved in such a process" (Shotter & Tsoukas, 2014, p. 240).[1] Such "clear focus" is primarily accomplished through communication – which suggests a working definition of *identity-constitutive leadership communication* as *bringing clarity and focus in the face of muddy, complex (wicked, paradoxical) problems*.[2]

Such communication that brings clarity/focus leading to plausible courses of action, uttered while others are still wallowing in the muddiness, can work toward constructing an identity (i.e., identity work) for the individual who utters it – an ascription of the identity category "leader" as one who is leading or demonstrating "leadership." All of that begs the question of whether the individual must already *have* a "leader" self-identity cognitively (I am the leader; therefore, I say such clarifying and influential things), or whether the leader identity is *constituted in and through* discourse (because I have said such clarifying and influential things, I have demonstrated "leadership," and I now identify as a "leader"). Additionally, has the clarifying and focusing discourse resulted in (as evidenced in further communication) a leader identity to be *ascribed by others* to the individual who uttered such discourse, and how has that been discursively accomplished?

A Caveat: Clarification Does Not Equate to Simplification

To be clear, I am *not* proposing that a "clear focus" equates to simplification or reduction of a complex problem to a simple choice, nor does it put all ambiguity to rest. Much has been written regarding tensional, dialectical, or paradoxical perspectives of leadership (vis-à-vis followership) begetting multiple and potentially knotted paradoxes of leader identity (Collinson, 2005; Karp & Helgo, 2008; Nielsen et al., 2023; see Fairhurst, Chapter 3, this volume). Sheep et al. (2017b) noted an entanglement (knot) of four individual identity paradoxes that could well apply to leader identities: (1) a paradox of *entity* (identity as characteristic versus process); (2) a paradox of *conformity* (identity as conforming to norms versus having distinctive features); (3) a paradox of *temporality* (current identity versus past/future identity); and (4) a paradox of *elasticity* (leader identity as requiring an expansion of one's multiple identities to accommodate leader identity versus integrating them so that they can still "hold together").

Also paradoxically, clarity must often co-exist *in tension* with its opposite – ambiguity. As noted by Eisenberg (1984, p. 227):

> a critical examination of communication processes in organizations reveals that clarity is both nonnormative and not a sensible standard against which to gauge individual or organizational effectiveness. People in organizations confront multiple situational requirements, develop multiple and often conflicting goals, and respond with communicative strategies which do not always minimize ambiguity, but are nonetheless effective.

Another leader identity paradox is cued by leadership often being framed as a "positive" identity (to which all should aspire). However, as noted by Sheep (2020, pp. 618–619), "the pursuit of the positive does not altogether negate the negative, nor is it a simple, linear path…identity is often a precarious accomplishment to be negotiated rather than an objectively inherent attribute." The precarity of the positive "is exacerbated by its threats, detractors, sceptics, competitors, and social stigmas that continually nip at the heels of one's best efforts at self-presentation."

Thus, through a paradox lens (Lewis & Smith, 2014; Smith & Lewis, 2011), effective leadership communication does not involve ignoring complexities, negatives, or uncertainties, but rather "admitting uncertainty while still accepting responsibility" (Nielsen et al., 2023, p. 155). For example, Admiral Allen (2010, p. 77) did not deny the complexity of problems but rather communicated shared understanding of it to achieve results. As he put it:

> You have to understand at a very large, macro level what the problem is that you're dealing with and what needs to be done to achieve the effects you want – and you have to be able to communicate that. You also have to create a set of shared values that everybody involved can subscribe to.

Organizational crises or strategic initiatives that beget ill-defined problems "highlight the need to explain and translate paradox" (Nielsen et al., 2023, p. 155) for both internal and external stakeholders of the organization. That is,

> While employees and stakeholders may request simplicity and clear accountability, change also exacerbates mutual dependencies, demonstrating that sustainable coping must involve a broad group of stakeholders. This places an emphasis on the ability of managers to translate paradoxical strategies to stakeholders.
>
> (Nielsen et al., 2023, p. 166)

For example, referring to tensional stakeholder interests in the Deepwater Horizon oil spill, Admiral Allen (2010, p. 77) stated:

> The challenge of creating unity of effort involves dealing with issues that you're not statutorily allowed to pay for, but that still need to be done for the public. In the Gulf we had to deal with things like seafood safety and behavioral health problems; there were socioeconomic issues in play that were never anticipated by the response doctrine. Those were the problems that required the most leadership.

Thus, in the context of a messy or knotted problem, while a simple solution may be popular due to over-simplified "clarity," its social or material consequences may lead to a fresh round of cascading, unintended problems (to which the literature on *wicked problems* attests; Rittel & Webber, 1973). Glossing over persistent "both-and" paradoxes as though they are simplistic "either-or" contingencies (Lewis & Smith, 2014) will construct a *more* perplexing/paralyzing version of reality for others because it could "sabotage the opportunity to develop the very competency that activation of paradoxical thinking was intended to facilitate" (Nielsen et al., 2023, p. 158).

Thus, a leader identity is communicatively constituted (however shifting and/or shared) through cogent discourse that sets and positively frames complex and knotted problems (Karp & Helgo, 2008; Schön, 1983; Sheep et al., 2017a). Such clarification is

accomplished by discursive moves/narratives that articulate (in ways that others are influenced, as evidenced in subsequent communication) a set of problematic tensions in comprehensible (not simplistic) terms and courses of action that can plausibly and responsibly navigate them. As articulated by Admiral Allen (2010, p. 79), "my favorite definition of leadership is the ability to reconcile opportunity and competency."

Perspectives that Enable Analysis of How Communication Constitutes Leader Identity

Cognitive/Psychological and Discursive Perspectives Contrasted

The novel insights gained from discursive perspectives are better understood when contrasted with more traditional cognitive approaches. Cognitive perspectives of leadership and communication differ markedly from social constructionist (Fairhurst & Grant, 2010) or discursive perspectives (Fairhust & Putnam, 2014) in that the latter emphasize leadership as a co-constructed reality in which communication and discourse are seen as *constitutive* of leader identity rather than simply as a *representation* of prior cognitive processes.

That is not to diminish the contributions of cognitive perspectives. For example, one of the key insights gained from a social psychological view of leadership identity is that it focuses on two strands of research: (1) identity of leaders as individuals (research on "leader identity"); and (2) identity of leaders as group members (work on "identity leadership" as informed by social identity models) (Haslam et al., 2022, p. 2). The latter perspective opens a space for leadership that can be co-constructed between individuals in groups and can accommodate a follower-centric approach (e.g., DeRue & Ashford, 2010; Meindl, 1995). However, a social identity model of leadership is based on cognitive prototypes – representations of depersonalized group attributes (does this individual fit the prototype of "leader"?) (Hogg & Terry, 2000). Thus, cognitive prototype-matching cannot account for fine-grained and widely varying ways in which actors invoke social identities as discursive resources in everyday talk.

Narrative approaches to leadership identity work (Ibarra & Barbulescu, 2010; see Kuhn & Simpson, 2020, for a review) sound a bit more communication-based, but they can proceed from cognitivist assumptions. For example, leaders' *origin stories* are posited as the means by which "leaders make sense of 'becoming' a leader (origin stories) and 'doing' leadership (enactment stories)" and "through which they understand, articulate, and enact their leader identities" (Vough et al., 2020; Zheng et al., 2021, p. 1178). In such a view, narrative communication is primarily treated as

representational of leader identities that are to be made sense of and "understood" cognitively rather than as *constituted* by communication (i.e., speaking the self into being).

In contrast to cognitive perspectives, discourse-based approaches to leadership and leader identities (Fairhurst, 2007) unpack ways to investigate leader identity work as relational (Fairhurst & Uhl-Bien, 2012) and as *constituted* in and through discursive interaction. As noted by Fairhurst and Grant (2010, p. 183), "Ethnomethodological methods are thus necessary to interrogate leadership in action and to focus on the logics and labeling that organize situated applications of the term – for both actors and analysts alike."

Membership Categorization: Clarity (But Not Consistency) of Categories and Features

One ethnomethodological perspective (conversation analysis) holds *membership categorization* as a key feature of analysis. Drawing on the work of Kelly (2008), Fairhurst and Connaughton (2014, p. 18) note that leadership is "best seen as a family resemblance among language games… .a 'design problem' in which actors must figure out what leadership is in the context of what they do and persuade themselves and others that they are doing it."

In that vein, the perspective of *membership categorization analysis* (or MCA; Jayyusi, 1984) can usefully be brought to bear, in that clarifying communication (as conceptually developed above) can work toward fulfilling the activities, rights, obligations, and competencies imputed to a "leader" identity category incumbent – however shifting or dynamic it might be. Such communication can be heard as a "genuine performance" of the category (Jayyusi, 1984, p. 42) – what leaders *do* (discursively as a social practice) and what leadership *is* (communicating clarity in the face of ill-defined or knotted problems leading to productive courses of action). In short, the ascription of identity as "leader" – whether by self or others – does not depend on official title for legitimacy, or on a cognitive stereotype, but upon discursive communication that influentially provides a clear(er) way forward for others such that they categorize *in situ* the speaker as one who delivers a genuine performance of the identity category.

The key point in MCA, however, is that a "leader" identity category may vary widely across individuals or groups in what the "genuine performance" can or should be. The category features that constitute a leader identity are thus fluid and situationally

accomplished in discourse rather than pre-determined from a prototypical mental model.

An example of scholarship from this perspective is that of Iszatt-White et al. (2019, p. 535), who employ MCA to examine "how authentic leadership is evaluated in naturally occurring discourse" in a "complex and contradictory discursive landscape." A category claim alone would not be sufficient to accomplish that identity work but would require corroboration by the discourse of others that constituted such a categorization. In their study, the "authentic" category was contested in subsequent discourse and set in tension with "effective" leadership.

One might well ask, what then are the *features* of the category "authentic" versus the features of "effective"? These are what Jayyusi (1984, pp. 36–37) would call "open-textured" categories – i.e., open to generation and modification as "ad hoc practical accomplishments." That is, memberships categorizations (whether one is seen as belonging to the identity category of "leader") are analyzed "from a detailed analysis of participants' own use of discourse" (Potter & Wetherell, 1987, p. 124), as next discussed from a discourse analytic perspective.

Discourse Analysis: Clarity as a Discursive Accomplishment Constructed in Talk

Although there are multiple varieties of discourse analysis, the key concerns in all of them are *how discourse is organized and what it is doing* (Potter & Wetherell, 1987).[3] In contrast with cognition, "Asking what discourse is *doing* is a very different theoretical question than focusing on how it *represents* ideas and objects" (Fairhurst & Putnam, 2014, p. 272).

Meanings are thus dependent upon the task(s) to which everyday talk is put (Boden, 1994). In terms of leader identity, talk will in some way involve the articulation of the self "in ways that will maximize one's warrant or claim to be heard" (Potter & Wetherell, 1987, p. 108). To contend for one's version of reality (to influence) is to work toward legitimacy of one's leader identity (as one who brings clarity in the midst of complexity). Thus, the concern of discourse analysis becomes a question of "How is discourse put together, and what is gained by this construction?" (Potter & Wetherell, 1987, p. 55). Is leader identity one of the accomplishments of the discourse?[4]

Examples of scholarship explicating how discourse analysis can produce novel and useful insights in leadership communication/identity work may be found in the book introducing the perspective of *Discursive Leadership* (Fairhurst, 2007) as well as a

foundational article by Fairhurst and Uhl-Bien (2012) in which the methods of organizational discourse analysis (ODA) are applied to the study of relational leadership as a co-created process.

Communication as Constitutive of Organization (CCO): Leadership as Authority and "Making a Difference" in Communication Events

Kuhn and Simpson (2020, p. 151) stated the basis for seeing discourse/communication as producing rather than only expressing a leader identity:

> discourse and communication are increasingly understood not as representational, but as constitutive: identities do not draw upon discourse and communication to express or represent themselves, but instead are generated, sustained, and altered exclusively in and through discursive and communicative practices.

Nowhere is this view more evident than in the literature of CCO perspectives. Bisel et al. (2022; see Chapter 8, this volume) reviewed three CCO perspectives in terms of how their analytical insights can expand our *communicative* understanding of what we typically call "leadership" and, by extension, leader identity. Here, two CCO perspectives are applied: the Montreal School and Luhmannian Systems Theory.

First, the *Montreal School* (MS) theorizes the concepts of *authoring* and *authority* (same root word) to "impute agency to nonhumans, such as texts, objects, spaces, bodies, or any 'thing' that makes a difference in social interaction (Cooren, 2004)" (Bisel et al., 2022, p. 300). Authoring and authority communicatively bring into view what might constitute a leader identity because they facilitate interrogation of "who or what decides and directs (i.e., authors) action … Authority, then, is an emergent claim on action shaped by multiple interrelating texts that cohere in the continual here and now of conversation" (Wright et al., 2023, p. 317). Another MS concept, *ventriloquism* (or ventriloqual authority) "problematizes who (or what) is talking. What humans say and do is often the result of other voices speaking through them" (Wright et al., 2023, p. 318). Who or what *authors* the communication that constitutes leadership – the speaker or the ventriloqual authority of a superordinate agent (e.g., a text such as a policy or procedures document; Fairhurst & Sheep, 2019)? In such cases, the human actor's discourse is simply a vehicle, implicating questions of where leadership and leader identity discursively reside. Can ventriloqual discourse constitute leader identity, or is the speaker only a messenger?[5]

Second, the systems theory of Niklas Luhmann is the most radical in assigning agency for organizing (and leadership) to communication *events*, asserting that systems consist entirely of ongoing sequences of "decision communication" and nothing else. Indeed, Luhmann (2018, p. 64; Cooren & Seidl, 2020) calls systemic leadership a "fiction," "control illusions" that allow managers to "feel good": "Decision communication" marks what is and is not part of a system, including its identity – whether it is an organizational or human (Luhmann would call it "psychic") system (Bisel et al., 2022). In a sense, the ongoing sequence of communication itself "leads" and "decides" for the system. For organizational systems to attend to the effects of individual "psychic" systems (i.e., *as if* leadership and leader identity were possible), then organizational communication events must "decide" to treat it with such status. A potentially fruitful research stream would be to examine the discursive constructions of such communication events in terms of how leader identity status could be systemically constituted.

Overall, through CCO, we may study leadership identity in ways that decenter human agency and therefore depart from the notion of heroic leadership of an individual to the shared, shifting, and relational effects of *authoring* and *decidability* in a communication system or event. Despite differences in perspectives, the common focus on communication processes turns the analytical lens toward discovering *how* communication constitutes leader identities by focusing on communication that "makes a difference" in influencing subsequent communication.

While few studies have deployed CCO perspectives to the research of leader identity, an exception is that of Meier and Carroll (2020, p. 1225) as they asked "How is a leader produced in a Leadership Development Program? Which actors and agencies are involved in the process, and how do they change?" Their CCO analysis enabled them to theorize leader "identity reconfiguration" as a "continual staging and authoring of diverse figures" (Meier & Carroll, 2020, p. 1227).

Two Illustrative Types of Leader Identity Born of Crisis and Morality

The communicative constitution of leader identity goes beyond invoking a category of "leader," but identity work (as category work) would call for more specification by investigating what *types* of leader identity are being constituted (e.g., authentic, moral, ethical) and *how*. Upon what basis and in what way is a leader identity being communicatively described, ascribed, and justified (legitimated)?

Two streams of literature are emerging that are ripe for further development in that they are not only problem-driven but also relevant to the contemporary milieu of "grand challenges" and increasing leadership politicization (and polarization) in an array of contexts: (1) leaders as our perpetual saviors from *permanent states of crisis*; and (2) leaders as the legitimated guardians/ exemplars of *morality and ethics*.

Leader Identity as Perpetual Savior from a Permanent State of Crisis

First, crises can be manufactured internally by organizations or their leaders, or they can be perpetrated by external adversaries or competitors. Referring to the typology introduced by Grint (2005), Fairhurst and Grant (2010, p. 183) note that "a crisis, real or fabricated, can justify a command posture (think of former U.S. President George W. Bush's case building for the war in Iraq)."[6] In our Coast Guard example, Admiral Allen's crises were "real" in that they were brought on by external, material causes (a hurricane and oil spill) that no one desired. In contrast, fabricated crises may be brought about for self-serving reasons to bolster political or organizational power, to distract from other issues, or to upset an unwanted status quo.

Importantly (sometimes unfortunately), legitimation of a leader identity can be communicatively constructed by fostering wide acceptance of a crisis narrative (see Chapter 18, this volume) in which an aspiring "leader" presents discursively as "the (only) one" who can navigate the crisis successfully. Individuals who willfully take this approach for self-serving ends are attempting to construct a heroic version of themselves that may or may not be met with material circumstances or human responses in further communication that cooperate with that identity construction.

Crisis event(s), whether materially or discursively imposed, may or may not be identity-implicating (Sheep et al., 2023). Nonetheless, the mix of human and non-human (or material) agencies discursively/communicatively made relevant in the context of crisis define *exigencies* (or set problems; Schön, 1983) that beg action, which in turn *opens a space* for leadership communication (by one or a competing throng) to address the crisis.

In this vein, Kerr (2008, p. 201) put forth two identity-relevant questions (as identity work is an attempt at legitimation/acceptance of the identity): "Are leaders most legitimate or authentic in times of crisis or permanent crisis? And does this suggest that leaders who desire legitimacy and/or authenticity should persuade followers that such crisis conditions exist?"

Throughout history, crises could be discursively constructed as threats from social/political/organizational outgroups (the "other" to be "feared"), resulting in a polarized society. To some degree (but seemingly on the increase in recent years), politics has always been a site of what McCoy and Somer (2019, p. 234) call "pernicious polarization" accomplished through "mobilizing voters with divisive, demonizing discourse and exploiting existing grievances" as well as failure "to develop effective nonpolarizing responses."

Pertaining to *business organizations*, Kerr (2008, p. 201) asks "whether the discourse of the 'leader' as authentic decision-maker can be transferred across (political and corporate) fields" as a "permanent state of emergency." Corporate examples abound of creating a discourse of crisis that works toward a leader identity as savior of the organization in the midst of economic or competitive crisis and/or, at a higher level, the *identity of the organization* itself as leader of the charge against (or the only hope to overcome) the crisis.

For example, the late Steve Jobs is remembered for many things, one of them being his introductory speech for the now-legendary 1984 MacIntosh Computer Superbowl commercial, in which he characterized Apple's primary competitor (IBM) as an Orwellian "Big Brother" who "wants it all." As Jobs told it, "dealers initially welcoming IBM with open arms now fear an IBM dominated and controlled future. They are increasingly and desperately turning back to Apple as the only force that can ensure their future freedom."

The discourse of this speech positioned both Steve Jobs and Apple as the lone "saviors" from a crisis that would entail loss of computing freedom if IBM prevailed. Did Steve Jobs establish or enhance his *leader identity* communicatively in this speech? Supported by the enthusiastic reaction of the audience and the enduring stature of the commercial itself in the annals of marketing history, one could conclude that Jobs' discourse influentially accomplished/constituted just that.

Whether the premise relating to IBM had any representational or material basis is beside the point – the branding of Apple led by Steve Jobs as the champion for computing liberty was underway. Jobs ended the speech by re-highlighting the *crisis*: "Will big blue dominate the entire computer industry? The entire information age? Was George Orwell right about 1984?"[7]

Other examples of a crisis-based leadership identity (as discursively constituted) abound in all types of contexts – business competition, partisan politics, international conflicts, religious sermons, higher education debates, military conflict, social movements, and so on. Consider the example of former New York Mayor, Rudolph

Giuliani, during the World Trade Center crisis of September 11, 2001. Whereas his leadership status and identity were less than remarkable prior to the crisis (some might argue, like today), they were significantly enlarged after he "incarnated the proper response that New Yorkers and Americans hoped for in these situations… Giuliani was subsequently given every award and accolade imaginable such that it became almost impossible to discern where Giuliani's behavior stopped and the social shaping began" (Fairhurst & Cooren, 2009, pp. 476–477; Fairhurst, 2007).

Whether materially thrust upon a system or fabricated for self-serving ends, all types of crises open a space for leadership to be *seen as* effective and for leader identities to be born of discursive identity work and ensuing action – a "genuine performance" of leader identity, or in the opposite case, a category performance failure if expectations are not met.

Leader Identity as Legitimated Guardian/Exemplar of Morality and Ethics

Second, another leader identity type that has emerged as a growing research stream is that of moral/ethical leadership. While it is not mutually exclusive from the crisis mode discussed above (as one *can* be a moral/ethical leader in a crisis), it does not depend on it. Examples abound of leader identities that do not depend on the constant construction of crisis but rather on an attempt to frame leader identity in terms of moral and ethical accountability (implicating identity category features of a leader who can be trusted in judgment, decision-making, fairness, honesty, and so on).

As noted by Mayfield and Mayfield (2017, p. 111), "Often research neglects the ethical implications of events, but ultimately these events should be integral to our investigations of leadership communication." Typically, leadership studies have categorized such approaches as authentic, ethical, or servant leadership (Lemoine et al., 2019), which can be seen as types of leader identities – e.g., "I am an ethical, moral leader," or "I am a servant leader."

These differently categorized "moral" leader identities overlap conceptually with a "plethora of commonalities," which Lemoine et al. (2019, p. 149) sought to untangle and then integrate by showing each approach's "unique and even contrasting answer to the question: 'What is moral?'" They found *ethical leadership* to focus on compliance with normative standards, *authentic leadership* on self-awareness and moral self-concordance, and *servant leadership* on serving multiple stakeholder interests. While redundancy and correlations among these identities may cause some concern

theoretically, the distinctive moral content suggests that each can be communicatively constituted with different category features (in terms of what counts as "moral").

Indeed, membership categorization analysis concerns itself with establishing a "moral order" in the sense of "genuine" or "moral" performance that discursively constitutes the competencies/knowledge expected of the category (Jayusi, 1984). Likewise, category performance failures can also be constituted as moral leader *identity* category failures, showing category description as well as ascription by others to be "unrelievedly judgmental" (Jayusi, 1984, p. 40).

More critically, others have problematized the three dominant "moral" leadership approaches – as well as what constitutes leadership itself. For example, Fischer and Sitkin (2023, p. 331) have questioned the evidence of leadership style research by arguing that "specifying behaviors as inherently positive or negative…leads to mixing the description of the content of leadership behaviors" with that conflation leading to "amalgamation, construct redundancy, and most problematically, causal indeterminacy."

Also critically, "leadership studies…exude an 'unrealistic moral optimism' regarding the charismatic or transformational leader" (Kerr, 2008, p. 202). Thus, some scholars are skeptical about what constitutes a moral or positive leader identity, as it can stray into the "dark side" of leadership (Fischer & Sitkin, 2023; see Chapter 7, this volume), in which even followers "play a critical role in constructing and maintaining toxic leaders" (Mergen & Ozbilgin, 2021, p. 45). Thus, future research should take care not to romanticize, gloss, or overlook the potential negatives of what have been traditionally cast as positive moral leader identities – particularly when viewed through a tensional/paradox lens (Sheep, 2020).

Future Research: Leadership and Leader Identity Born of Discursive Clarity

Leadership and leader identity are constituted in discourse because the clarity itself is discursively constituted. As noted, much work in the research of leadership communication and identity has yet to be accomplished. By deploying the methods and perspectives highlighted in this chapter, such studies are likely to produce both theoretically novel and practically useful insights that can more broadly impact leadership studies as well as studies in the communicative constitution of identities.

First, the illustrative applications noted above (leadership identities born of a permanent state of crisis and moral/ethical leader identities) are both in need of new empirical work that can further develop theory. For example, permanent states of crises

– whether externally driven or internally fabricated – are asserted by some as persistent and even necessary to both geopolitical and corporate life (Kerr, 2008; cf. Hannah, 2023; Yuhas, 2023). If so, how does crisis discourse evolve to constitute a leadership identity, and if it does, how do the types of identities vary that are so constituted?

In terms of a "moral" leader identity and its several types or "styles," Fischer and Sitkin (2023) call for research that "deconflates" their conceptual overlaps and redundancies. Several of the perspectives above might be deployed to accomplish that end, such as membership categorization analysis that can unpack the varying category features constructed in their eight positive and two negative leader identities. Moreover, they call for integration of these where possible to reduce construct redundancy and causal indeterminacy. Similarly, Lemoine et al. (2019, p. 174) call for "refining distinctions among ethical, authentic, and servant leadership based on their respective moral philosophies" leading to research questions regarding whether leaders can hold multiple moral philosophies/identities simultaneously or whether there might be interactions (or tensions) between them.

Second, CCO perspectives suggest future research agendas that can produce insightful contributions to leadership communication and identity theories. Since all three major CCO schools "strike a blow to heroic, essentializing theories of leadership in favor of the study of its relationalities" (Bisel et al., 2022, p. 306), CCO perspectives can be useful in the study of collective and distributed "difference-making" and "decidability" in a communication system both at a micro- and macro-levels. Bisel et al. (2022) call for further work in CCO itself as it applies to leadership – e.g., in remedying the lack of theorization of materiality in the "four flows" model and Luhmannian systems theory. They also ask whether the three CCO perspectives might inform one another by their simultaneous deployment in the same study – i.e., "zooming in" using the Montreal School perspective, while "zooming out" to more macro system dynamics in the other two perspectives.

Certainly, the grand challenges of our time require that we better understand processes of influence and leadership as they are accomplished communicatively – especially if we accept the assertion of Wright et al. (2023, pp. 315–316) that "nothing can persist outside of communication… Communication is the only site at which coordination and control can happen."

Notes

1. Shotter's perspective of constructionist leadership goes back to his concept of practical authorship, which he described as "the ability of people in otherwise vague, or only partially specified, incomplete situations…to 'give' or to 'lend' to such situations a more determinate linguistic formulation" (Shotter, 1993, pp. 149–150).⏎
2. Not tame, routine problems, which would be more the purview of management communication – e.g., Grint (2005).⏎
3. For useful reviews of discourse analysis, see (Fairhurst & Putnam, 2014; Kuhn & Simpson, 2020; Phillips & Jorgensen, 2002).⏎
4. The discursive psychology of Potter and Wetherell (1987) differs from ethnomethodologically-informed MCA because it combines a Foucauldian view of Discourse (as linguistic repertoires) along with little "d" discourse (language-in-use).⏎
5. Such a question also suggests potential for theorization of how artificial intelligence will figure into the leadership of individuals, groups, and organizations. Is AI itself leading and influencing, or are the texts (ventriloqual authority) that feed its algorithms, or the algorithms themselves (decision communication) that select and integrate the texts?⏎
6. Note the difference between construction – how materiality or demonstrable context is attended to and ascribed meaning – and pure fabrication – constructing a narrative without correspondence to any materiality or demonstrable context.⏎
7. Steve Jobs quotes are transcribed from the video of the speech: "Steve Jobs Introduces the Famous '1984' Apple Commercial". www.youtube.com/watch?v=zlQvMp5rB6g⏎

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Further Reading

Ashcraft, K.L., Kuhn, T.R., & Cooren, F. (2009). Constitutional amendments: "Materializing" Organizational Communication. *The Academy of Management Annals*, *3*(1), 1–64. (Extensive review article that explicates the CCO communication-as-constitutive principle, particularly to scholars in disciplines other than organizational communication – e.g., management and organization studies.)

Fairhurst, G.T., Jackson, B., Foldy, E.G., & Ospina, S.M. (2020). Studying collective leadership: The road ahead. *Human Relations, 73*(4), 598–614. (Since CCO perspectives favor a collective and distributed understanding of leadership and identity in which communication "defines relationships of power and control in every utterance," this article provides insightful understanding and way forward of the research of collective leadership.)

Fairhurst, G.T., & Putnam, L.L. (2019). An integrative methodology for organizational oppositions: Aligning grounded theory and discourse analysis. *Organizational Research Methods*, *22*(4), 917–940. (As both grounded theory and discourse analysis are often employed as perspectives/methods in leadership and identity research, this study shows how they might be integrated, particularly as paradox/tension are to be analyzed.)

Seidl, D. (2007). General strategy concepts and the ecology of strategy discourse: A systemic-discursive perspective. *Organization Studies*, *29*, 197–218. (The article opens a way to the possibility of using such discursive methods as membership categorization to analyze communication events in Luhmannian autopoietic communication systems – e.g., the same category labels are packed with different features and mean different things in different systemic contexts.)

Sveningsson, S., & Alvesson, M. (2003). Managing managerial identities: Organizational fragmentation, discourse and identity struggle. *Human Relations*, *56*, 1163–1193. (This case study addresses the "interplay between organizational discourses, role expectations, narrative self-identity, and identity work.")

10

LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION AND SOCIAL INFLUENCE

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-12

Introduction

Social influence and persuasion are among the most basic functions of communication. One's effectiveness in organizational leadership relies on the ability to connect with, and in some cases, encourage a shift in the thoughts, feelings, or behaviors of others. Our writing on the subject has led us to characterize leadership as the design and implementation of messages, strategies, processes, and structures to facilitate social influence (Ruben & Gigliotti, 2019). Given the centrality of influence to leadership goals and outcomes, it is no surprise that leadership communication and the desire for social influence in personal and professional affairs have long been of interest to scholars and practitioners. Issues related to the intersection of leadership, communication, influence, and persuasion are recurring themes among professional development programs, popular press, and everyday discourse – and we are often reminded of the immediate and long-term impact of leadership influence in our teams, workplaces, and communities. Tracing the broad evolution of dominant thinking related to leadership and communication reveals how the dynamics of social influence converge with leadership theory and practice. The topic of leadership resonance helps to explain the leadership-communication relationship, as will be discussed in this article, and through this lens, leadership is viewed as a systemic outcome brought about through connections and the construction of meaning between a would-be leader and

potential followers (Ruben & Gigliotti, 2021). We conclude with implications for advancing organizational leadership research and practice that take account of the role of social influence.

Situating Influence in the Contemporary Context

Leadership research has advanced in ways that parallel changes in the broader historical context. This shift, particularly informed by communication theory, moves us away from focusing solely on the individual leader and their traits and behaviors and towards a more comprehensive understanding of the broader leadership system and the ways in which leadership is co-constructed between leaders and followers in the context in which these interactions occur. As part of this evolution in leadership thinking, influence is not seen as residing solely in the actions of one individual, but rather as a byproduct of the interaction among those engaged in leadership and followership. As Forsyth (2014) writes, "accepting a leader's influence is an adaptive process that helps people deal with situations that vary from the cooperative and collaborative to those rife with conflict, tension, and animosity" (p. 12). Some of the more dominant leadership theories, such as transformational and adaptive leadership, draw attention to the ways in which leadership efforts can bring about social, organizational, political, and cultural change. The widespread challenges and pressures of the contemporary moment, including the threats posed by climate change, war, public health, poverty, racial disparities, and a growing sense of distrust in formal institutions, amplify the need for systemic change and transformation. Within this broader context, leadership influence can have life-or-death implications – and considerations of influence must take account of both the role of leaders and followers in these interactions.

The goals and intentions underlying social influence efforts often involve altering – or in some cases, disrupting – the status quo. In other cases, the forces promoting influence seek to stabilize and harmonize, sometimes returning to previously discarded perspectives, policies, or practices. Many options exist relative to influence goals that may be pursued in varying settings and levels of organizations, and as evidenced by the conditions of the present historical moment, the presence of multiple and often-competing narratives remains a hallmark of contemporary life. Accompanying these contending narratives are alternative views of the appropriate aims and outcomes of leadership communication and the innumerable possibilities for influence in personal and professional settings.

Leadership communication, persuasion, and social influence are topics of attention in the scholarly and professional writing in communication, leadership, and organizational studies, as well as other fields. Moreover, professional development programs and workshops tend to address these themes in groups, organizations, communities, and the broader societal context. Common to these efforts is the need to better understand the dynamics of influence and the role of leadership communication in helping to shape the outcomes that result among these intentional and unintentional influence pursuits. In order to more fully understand the complexities of social influence and leadership resonance, one can explore the evolution of thinking on communication and leadership and the parallels between these paths that help to inform how they intersect in practice.

Tracing the Evolution of Social Influence Theory and Practice

While the focus on social influence is a timely one, it is certainly not new. As Forsyth (2014) notes, philosophers and political theorists alike have characterized leadership as a form of social influence. In the early writings on the subject of rhetoric, Aristotle advanced what might be considered a theory of social influence:

> Rhetoric exists to affect the giving of decisions … the orator must not only try to make the argument of his speech demonstrative and worthy of belief; he must also make his own character look right and put his hearers, who are to decide, into the right frame of mind.
>
> (Roberts, W. R. (1924) *Works of Aristotle.* Oxford, p. 1377b)

Building upon the writing of Aristotle and others, early views of communication and social influence centered on the process by which senders create and disseminate messages to establish credibility and persuade others to accept their views (Ruben, 1984; Ruben & Stewart, 2020). Communication, from this perspective, was portrayed as a simple, one-way, linear, cause-and-effect endeavor, in which its effects were attributed to the actions of senders and the impact of their messages (Lasswell, 1948). This paradigm guided communication theory and research for much of its early history notwithstanding its limitations, particularly as multiple audience members experienced different effects when exposed to identical source(s) and message(s) (Ruben & Stewart, 2020). These anomalies, as they were originally conceived, were attributed to a range of possible factors, including: (a) noise in the system (Shannon & Weaver, 1948); (b) an

absence of feedback (Shannon & Weaver, 1948); (c) the influence of opinion leaders who mediated and interpreted messages through multiple channels (Katz & Lazarsfeld, 1955; Westley & MacLean, 1957); and (d) the realities of differing experiences, cultures, and frames of reference (Schramm, 1954).

The limitations of a one-way, sender and message-centered paradigm of communication led to more bi-directional and circular views of communication (Schramm, 1954), and contributed to the emergence of perspectives that attributed a far more active role to receivers and their interpretative processes (Dance, 1967; Thayer, 1968). This shift in the dominant paradigm elevated the influence of the receiver in helping to shape communication outcomes, leading to far more complex, interactive, multidimensional, transactional, constitutive, and systemic perspectives on the communication process which continue to inform contemporary communication scholarship (Rogers & Kincaid, 1981, Thayer, 1968; Watzlawick et al., 1967). This shift in paradigm places a more prominent emphasis on the intersection of senders, receivers, messages, channel/media, context, and other factors at play in communication encounters and the outcomes that result from this meaning making process.

Curiously, the evolution of leadership theory and research parallels that of communication in many ways. Indeed, the quotation offered above from Aristotle can be interpreted as a view for how leadership influence is enacted and made possible through communication. It also typifies what can be described as a linear, one-way view of leadership that held sway during much of the early writing on leadership theory and practice – as it did in communication. The accepted understanding of the leadership and influence process focused on a single individual – the leader – and their words and actions, with the presumption that those engaged in leadership were largely responsible for the behaviors of followers.

The parallels to the linear, cause-and-effect thinking underpinning traditional communication research are obvious. From the perspective of a traditional view of leadership, individuals who were the intended recipients of influence efforts were seen as largely passive and powerless when confronted with effective and skilled leaders. Appropriating this time-honored view of influence from communication, many leadership theories portrayed leaders as omnipotent and all-powerful drivers of influence. These early views of leadership scholarship tended to focus on the individual traits, skills, or capabilities that allow leaders to influence others. These targets of influence – colleagues, supporters, or followers – were often portrayed as passive recipients of leadership communication, seemingly lacking in both agency and authority.

As with the evolution of communication theory, the dominant paradigm shifted gradually away from a focus on a single individual – what Meindl and colleagues (1985) characterized as the romanticization of leadership influence. Other theories challenged the relevance and appropriateness of these individual leader-centered perspectives on leadership, focusing more broadly on the impact of followers in helping to shape leadership outcomes and engage in the co-construction of leadership itself. Communication-centered perspectives on leadership move us away from segmented views of leader and follower and linear views of influence, and towards a more nuanced and systemic consideration of the context in which leadership and the dynamics of social influence are embedded.

Bridging the writing on communication and leadership studies, we can see how early thinking in both areas evolved in ways that allow for a consideration of leadership as a complex system (Hernandez et al., 2011; Kellerman, 2016) in which senders (i.e., leaders/influence advocates) and receivers (i.e., potential followers/influence targets) draw upon various channels and media to jointly engage and co-create influence outcomes (Collinson et al., 2017; Hurwitz & Hurwitz, 2017; Oc et al., 2013; Platow et al., 2017; Ruben, 2023; Ruben & Gigliotti, 2016, 2019).

A number of theories have attempted to blend these two traditions, explicitly recognizing communication as central to social influence (Barge & Fairhurst, 2008; Fairhurst & Connaughton, 2014; Ruben & Gigliotti, 2016, 2019). These perspectives characterize leadership as the joint product of contributions by those aspiring to lead and others who are responsive, supportive, and willing to collaborate and follow, situated within an appropriate and timely context. As Fairhurst and Collinson (2023) note:

> Much of the mainstream literature privileges and elevates leaders and neglects the active role of followers. It typically assumes that 'leaders' are in charge and make decisions and 'followers' simply carry out orders from 'above.' Relations between them are often ignored or taken for granted and, even when addressed, they tend to be (mis)understood as largely static, stable and predictable, while their dynamic, shifting character is underplayed.
>
> (p. 484)

What we describe as a resonance theory of leadership, aims to capture the dynamic interplay between leaders and followers (Ruben & Gigliotti, 2019, 2021). From this vantage point, leadership resonance hinges on the intersection of leaders, followers, and

contexts, and positions the locus of social influence as a byproduct of what scholars have described as a shared, distributed, plural, discursive, networked, or constitutive process (Denis et al., 2012; Yammarino et al., 2012). Therefore, these trends in scholarship and practice encourage a pivot from the leader as noun to the process, enactment, or manifestation of leadership as a verb. This direction in leadership scholarship also moves us beyond simple dichotomies that oversimplify the complexity of leadership and understate the role of communication (Collinson, 2014). As detailed further in the next section, communication-centered process views of leadership place an emphasis on social influence as a jointly constructed effort, and this more expansive view of leadership and social influence has the potential to raise a number of critical issues for organizational leadership theory, research, and practice.

Implications of Applying Emergent Views of Communication, Influence, and Leadership

The study and practice of organizational leadership is both important and complex given the multiple levels of analysis, the impact of individuals and systems on leadership dynamics and social influence outcomes, and the pervasive impact of organizational leadership practices on our lived experience. The application of a communication-theoretic perspective raises implications for a wide array of foci, including those related to: (a) the various manifestations of formal and informal influence; (b) the nature of reciprocal influence between leaders and followers; and (c) considerations of core communicative issues related to leadership resonance, activation, and cultivation. The following section highlights the ways in which a consideration of leadership as social influence might impact the study and practice of each of these areas, along with implications for future research.

Multiple Contributors to Formal and Informal Influence

While verbal, nonverbal, and sociomaterial considerations have long been acknowledged as important in communication research, the specific contributions of each, particularly considerations of nonverbal messages and sociomateriality, have received limited attention in studies of leadership and influence. Sociomateriality specifically takes account of "the constitutive entanglement of the social and the material in everyday organizational life" (Orlikowski, 2007). In professional practice, both nonverbal and sociomaterial aspects of communication are recognized as

important. Examples include the use of visual symbols and logos, acts of silence, the arrangement of meeting rooms and seating choices, and the adoption and integration of technology, which are all variously used to reinforce organizational, religious, cultural, and political agendas and identities. Each of these types of messages can be critical to the realization of social influence, and these messages and forms of communication may be adopted and utilized both intentionally and unintentionally. In response to global unrest, for example, leaders across sectors – including those in higher education – have faced tremendous pressure to issue responses regarding the Israel-Hamas conflict. Many presidents across the country experienced extensive blowback based on their responses – or their silence. As Flier (2023) noted in his op-ed in the *Chronicle of Higher Education*, "The extent to which college leaders should, in addition to their administrative roles, express institutional positions on contestable social and political issues is a matter of legitimate dispute." Advocating for institutional neutrality, Flier seems to call into question the role of university leaders as public spokespeople on these matters of global contention, which of course others might view as a violation of their responsibilities. In this particular example – one fraught with a great deal of tension – both formal and informal leadership communication efforts become a statement about the values, norms, and expectations of the organization, whether it be by design or default.

In addition to the direct and formal messages employed by leaders, influence also occurs through the implicit and indirect messages that result from the strategies, processes, and structures initiated by those engaged in leadership roles. Attention to the dynamics of indirect versus direct communication strategies remains a rich area for investigation and application. Future research may also consider the intersection of verbal, nonverbal, and sociomaterial considerations in the co-construction of leadership and the ways in which the composition of this communication architecture may contribute to influence dynamics and outcomes. Referring to the earlier example of public responses to issues of global unrest, the interplay of leaders and followers – both within and beyond one's organization – is precedent setting, shapes the perceptions and expectations established among members of a diverse community, and can have significant consequences for the support and potentially the continuing employment of the leader. This direction for future research invites us to more fully consider the relational components of leadership and process-centered studies of social influence within and across organizations and networks.

More recent leadership scholarship has also moved beyond a restrictive focus on individuals with titled positions of responsibility and authority. The result is a growing

emphasis on informal leadership and influence in interpersonal, group, community, and organizational contexts. The role of informal leadership provided by formal leaders of the past, aspiring future leaders, content area experts, and relationally skilled colleagues is well recognized in some sectors – higher education among them (Lawrence & De Lisi, 2021). When advancing a new idea, structure, program, or other change initiative in any sector or context, astute formal leaders recognize the importance of creating buy-in and commitment from those who may not occupy titled positions but who are nonetheless very influential among their colleagues. Although many leaders may recognize the importance of informal channels and messages in the pursuit of influence, there is a lack of systematic understanding or guidance available as to when and how formal and informal influence function similarly and differently, and in what contexts each might be most appropriate and effective.

Leader-Follower Reciprocal Influence

The increasing emphasis on followers as active agents in the social influence process, and the potential for agency and action attributed to these roles, also raise important theoretical and practical implications that would benefit from further thought and investigation. As noted previously, leader-centric theories of influence are increasingly seen as limited and limiting (Goldthwaite et al., 2023; Hernandez et al., 2011; Hurwitz & Hurwitz, 2017; Kellerman, 2008, 2016; Mendl, 1990; Mendl et al., 1985; Oc & Bashshur 2013; Platow et al., 2017; Ruben & Gigliotti, 2016; Uhl-Bien et al., 2014). As the expansion of research on followership suggests, leadership theory and practice remains incomplete without considering "the nature and impact of followers and following in the leadership process" (Uhl Bien et al., 2014, p. 89). Despite a broadened recognition of and appreciation for the role of followers in the co-construction of leadership, considerations of social influence tend to reinforce the centrality of formal and informal leaders who are primary agents of communicative influence. However, rejecting leader-centric views of influence in favor of follower-centric views may simply be another version of linear communication thinking, with comparable limitations. More refined conceptualizations of the responsibilities, activities, and interplay of all those engaged in leadership and followership would certainly help to enhance our understanding of the dynamics of influence in the co-construction of leadership. For example, questions might include the following: What do leaders bring to this shared experience? To what extent do leaders and followers provide both the necessary and sufficient conditions for influence? Finally, how might the activities of

leadership and followership be shared, distributed, or exchanged in ways that reinforce a bi-directional process of mutual influence? In short, as guided by the evolution of thinking on leadership and communication, considerations of social influence must account for the interplay of leaders *and* followers in the enactment of leadership dynamics and outcomes.

Leadership Resonance, Activation, and Cultivation

Central to our notion of social influence is a view of leaders and followers jointly involved in the co-creation of leadership (Ruben & Gigliotti, 2019), an idea that is described extensively in the burgeoning followership literature (Uhl-bien et al., 2014) and as described elsewhere as leadership in interaction. Building upon Fairhurst's (2007) work on discursive leadership and the linguistic turn in the social sciences (Gronn, 1983), scholars interested in leadership in interaction – including those interested in communication as constitutive of organizations (CCO) – focus on the ways in which leadership is enacted, accomplished, and made possible through communication between leaders and followers. Within the systems literature, the concept of mutual causality sheds further insight on leader-follower interactions (Bertalanffy, 2015; Maruyama, 1960, 1963; Mobus & Kalton, 2015). Applied in the context of leadership, aspiring leaders and responsive followers jointly enact influence through a process of resonance and mutual reinforcement (Borgo, 2006; Levitin, 2008; Ruben & Gigliotti, 2019). Influence is viewed as a consequence of resonance; and the absence of influence or unintended influence outcomes are viewed as the potential consequence of a lack of resonance.

In common parlance, many outcomes are labeled as leadership "successes" and casually viewed as the result of – essentially caused by – a leader's words or actions. From the perspective of resonance theory, however, such "successes" occur when a leader's aims, actions, or ideas connect – resonate – in a meaningful way with potential followers, whereby they tap into the susceptibilities, sensitivities, values, or needs of potential followers (Ruben & Gigliotti, 2019; Thoroughgood et al., 2012). Through the lens of resonance theory, "success" or "effectiveness" is not considered to be an outcome of leader behavior in isolation, but rather a consequence of a resonance that occurs between a sender and receiver of messages in a particular context. Following this same line of reasoning, "leadership failures" occur when requests, actions, or ideas fail to connect in leader-intended ways with the needs, susceptibilities, sensitivities,

and/or rules for information processing and interpretation of potential followers (Ruben & Gigliotti, 2019).

Activation refers to the triggering of a potential follower who engages with – senses, interprets, reacts to, or reinforces – messages that are initiated intentionally or inadvertently by the messages or actions of a would-be leader. The term "would-be" is chosen to imply that an individual becomes a leader if and when a connection is made with a "potential" follower (Ruben & Gigliotti, 2019). In that instant of connection, leadership is enacted through a mutually defining and reciprocal process. From a systems-oriented perspective, the notion of an absence of resonance and failed activation help to explain the many instances where would-be leaders initiate messages, strategies, processes, or structures designed to trigger responses or outcomes that do not occur (Ruben & Gigliotti, 2019).

As with a leader's emotions (Goleman et al., 2001), it is also possible that behaviors resonate, but in a manner that activates unpredicted or adverse reactions among would-be followers – responses that may, in fact, serve to amplify deviations between intended and realized outcomes (Maruyama, 1963). A failure of connection could be explained by any number of factors, some within the potential purview of control of a would-be leader (e.g., message or media choices), a follower (e.g., lack of awareness of the intended messages, inattention or competing messages), relational or contextual issues (e.g., an absence of mutuality relative to an alignment or misalignment of language, goals, needs, or ideology), or circumstances related to timing or other environmental factors (Kellerman, 2016; Platow et al., 2015; Ruben & Gigliotti, 2019; Thoroughgood et al., 2012). It should be noted an absence of resonance and activation at one point in time does not foreclose the possibility of a future connection, affirmation, or rejection.

Would-be leader and potential follower communication interactions are ongoing processes – in a work group, family, organization, community, or at a national or international level. The preferences, sensitivities, and susceptibilities activated (or not activated) at a particular point in time are, to a large extent, the consequence of the long-term dynamics of communication and influence – a process of socialization or what might be termed *cultivation* (Ruben & Gigliotti, 2019). Over time, through an ongoing process of communication, cultivation can result in broadening zones of resonance and progressive increases or decreases in the likelihood of activation in the directions a would-be leader or prospective follower intends. Individuals are embedded in many networks that produce messages that resonate and fail to resonate at every moment in their lives. As a result of these dynamics, the patterns of resonance and

non-resonance can evolve in various ways overtime as a consequence of evolving leader sensitivities and capabilities. Elsewhere, we employ the metaphor of waves breaking against a cognitive/emotion shoreline to capture an image of this influence process (Ruben & Gigliotti, 2016). Any single wave is likely to reinforce and fit with existing shoreline patterns, but over time, in small and large ways, the shifts in tidal directions, intensity of waves, direction of winds, and other contextual factors can lead to changes in the coastal shoreline and to the impact that individual waves may be perceived to have.

The resonance model explains various anomalies in leadership theory and practice. For example, it helps to explain why individuals who fail to embody many of the characteristics typically thought to be important for leaders are nonetheless able to maintain a strong base of followers. Resonance may result from compatible messages and interests, yet in other cases the resonance seems to be independent of specific messages, actions, or policies, triggered more by ideological and attitudinal complementarities. In such instances, the significance of any leadership message may be of secondary importance to the influence on the framing and interpretation that results from a resonance with ideologies, needs, or attitudes. In recent years, the political domain has offered many poignant examples where the reaction to messages is arguably more a function of personality, ideology, and political resonance than to the content of specific messages. In such cases, the leader provides messages that are interpreted by followers in ways that provide continued support, endorsement, or amplification – and the mutually-reinforcing process continues (Boyatzis & McKee, 2005; Ruben & Gigliotti, 2019, 2021). The resonance model captures the dynamic and inseparable relationship of leaders and followers in the creation and realization of influence – and the role communication plays in the mutually created influence merits considerable attention. Further applications of this theory could be both conceptually and pragmatically beneficial.

The concept of resonance and the focus on leadership as a co-constructed endeavor highlight the reciprocal and rotational roles played by leaders and/or followers in the process of social influence. At a macro level of analysis, formal leadership hierarchies are generally in place in every group, organization, or community, yet viewed at a micro level and in the short term, other role relationship patterns and hierarchies may emerge. More specifically, individuals in relationships, groups, teams, organizations, or communities may provide leadership on specific tasks, issues, or topics at one moment, and may then function as followers in the next.

Content area expertise, the nature of a task, communication styles, group dynamics, and other situational factors create alternative leader-follower role relationships that can be as influential as formally designated positions and responsibilities. As a consequence, in the ongoing dynamics of interaction, leader and follower roles may be rotated, alternated, or shared in such a way that traditional labels may fail to meaningfully differentiate. Clarifying our understanding of these dynamics, and developing a deeper understanding of the utility and appropriate application of reciprocal and rotational leadership-followership roles, are other areas where communication-based theory has much to offer and where further research would be beneficial.

Future Directions in Social Influence Scholarship and Professional Practice

Beyond the specific topics for further exploration discussed in the preceding sections, there is a more fundamental opportunity and need related to theoretical integration. The traditions of leadership, communication, and persuasion are each rich with their own histories, and these traditions interrelate in interesting ways. There are also relevant historical traditions in the literatures of persuasion (Hovland et al., 1953), propaganda (Lasswell, 1927, 1948), social and organizational power (Kipnis, 1984; French & Raven (1959), conformity and contagion (Asch, 1955; Le Bon, 1895/1960), psychological needs for ambiguity reduction (Berger, 1990; Fromm, 1941), obedience to authority (Blass, 2000; Milgram, 1963, 1974), and other related areas (Forsyth, 2014). Dedicated efforts to blend and integrate these theoretical strands of thought – all of which have substantial associated literatures and the potential to inform understanding of leadership, communication, and influence – could be beneficial.

Advances in influence theory and research will also help to support professionals who apply concepts of social influence in their work as teachers, trainers, consultants, and program developers. Few topics have received the attention in the professional domain that has been enjoyed by topics such as strategic plan development and implementation, change management, leadership development, and crisis leadership – each of which requires an understanding of and appreciation for the dynamics of resonance and social influence.

Conclusion

Viewed from the perspective of influence, the dynamics of leadership are inextricably intertwined with issues related to communication and the joint construction of meaning. This approach to leadership study offers an explanation for the challenges facing scholars and professionals interested in this topic from both fields.

Across many levels, we see tensions at play in leader-follower interactions and efforts to repair these relationships in ways that can help to garner broad-based support. Often these tensions are rooted in divergent perceptions as to whether to move toward new, transformational goals, or to return to policies and patterns of earlier times. This tension becomes especially pronounced in an era of increased distrust and polarization. Often, these tensions are fueled by disinformation, misinformation, concerns about emergent technologies, and a general distrust of those occupying positions of responsibility in social structures at all levels.

While leadership challenges are numerous and noteworthy, each also represents an important opportunity – an opportunity to enhance our understanding of how leadership theory aligns with the practices and dynamics we observe around us. In efforts to move forward in this important scholarly and applied inquiry, a focus on communication and the nature of social influence will continue to play a critical role.

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https://doi.org/10.1057/9781137472038_11. (This chapter reviews the historical evolution of the scientific study of influence and explores the range of direct and indirect approaches to social influence.)

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PART II

Context

11

LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION FROM THE PERSPECTIVE OF LEADER-MEMBER EXCHANGE

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-14

Leader-member exchange theory (LMX, Dansereau et al., 1975; Graen & Cashman, 1975) is among the first relational approaches to leadership. A focus on individual leader-member relationships was a radical pivot from traditional and prevailing theories that posited that leaders interacted the same with every member. However, by anchoring focus on the relationship that emerges as a leader and an individual member collaborate to accomplish organizational tasks, the transformative power communication plays in leading and relationship development and maintenance came to light.

While LMX was first introduced in the 1970s, it has shifted and grown owing to continued scholarly attention and pragmatic application. However, the root of the theory remains as true today as when it was first created: leaders develop unique relationships with each member. Decades of research also illustrate at least four major outcomes of leader-member exchange theory:

1. Leader-member relationships are communicative in nature, meaning that they develop and are maintained via ongoing communicative exchanges.
2. Leaders develop relationships of varying quality with each member.

3. The quality of one's leader-member exchange relationship impacts their workplace experience.
4. Individual leader-member relationships impact peer and team relationships and collective team functioning.

This chapter will explore these major outcomes via a communicative lens after first tracing the theory's conceptual and practical developments. Relevant leadership research on LMX is presented and discussed to highlight how communication can infuse or deflate this pivotal workplace relationship, while also impacting an employee's organizational experience. While LMX originally focused specifically on unique leader-member associations, more contemporary research will be reviewed to illustrate the impact these dyads have on peer and team relationships, thereby influencing collective group functioning. Finally, this chapter concludes with practical implications for LMX and a future research agenda.

The Evolution of Leader-Member Exchange Theory

Nearly 50 years since its inception, leader-member exchange theory (Dansereau et al., 1975; Graen & Cashman, 1975) continues to be a prominent and pragmatic approach to exploring and explaining the unique relationship that emerges between a leader and a follower. Graen and Uhl-Bien (1995) point out that attention to the theory has not waned but has rather increased because it focuses on the three primary elements of leadership: the leader, the follower, and the relationship they share. In addition to highlighting the foundational components of leadership, this theoretical lens remains relevant because LMX is premised on the fact that leaders' discretionary resources such as autonomy, mentoring, and inside information are limited. That is, the essential threads of leadership – from the leader and member to the inherent challenges of the role – are interwoven into the foundation and evolution of the theory allowing it to remain as applicable today as it was when first introduced. Considering the dramatic ways in which workplaces and the processes of work have evolved in tandem with societal expectations of leaders helps to illustrate the utility of LMX.

Vertical Dyad Linkage Model

Initially considered as vertical dyad linkage model (VDL; Dansereau et al., 1975; Graen & Cashman, 1975), this innovative approach to leadership acknowledged

something that had been otherwise overlooked: leaders form unique relationships with each of their followers. While this fundamental truth is accepted as a given today, it was a radical shift from a predominant focus on leader behaviors, traits, and approaches to focus instead on relationships. Relationships are communicative, meaning that communication shapes the nature of the relationship from when a leader and follower first begin working together until one of them leaves the unit.

In addition to illustrating that leaders neither interact with nor treat followers identically, VDL also resulted in naming a common outcome of varied leader-member relationships: in-groups and out-groups. While these are not formal, explicit subgroups within an organizational unit, they are an implicit grouping of team members. Based on how the leader interacts with each follower, members observe communicative clues to discern the quality of the relationship they share with their leader in contrast to others. Research indicates that employees tend to be very savvy discerners of their manager's communicative behaviors (Omilion-Hodges & Baker, 2013). Some ways in which relationship quality is revealed include how frequently a manager and member interact, the tone of the interactions, and the content of the conversations. For example, some leader-member duos may interact frequently because the leader is frustrated by the quality of the follower's work or otherwise feels as though this employee requires frequent check-ins and oversight. This is a qualitatively different relationship than a leader-member dyad who communicates frequently about high-level projects, to exchanges ideas, and even discuss non-work matters. While these are just two examples, the intricacies of common communication clues and encounters are explored later in this chapter.

Leader-Member Exchange Theory

While VDL focused primarily on the divisions that occurred in workgroups due to the varying quality of leader-member relationships, LMX shifted the focus to consider the makeup of individual dyadic relationships. This turn helps to showcase the role of communication more prominently as relationships vary largely based on the quality of the exchanges between leader and member. Thus, this shift moved the field from a binary view – either the in-group or the out-group – to understanding relationship quality on a continuum. Though leader-member exchange theory hinted at the nuances embedded in the unique connection a leader develops with each follower, research outcomes echo VDL findings. Just as in-group members enjoy more positive outcomes than those in the out-group, employees who share a high-quality relationship with their

leader do as well. For example, high LMX employees tend to be more successful, are more committed to their organizations, and are more motivated than those with a less established leader-member relationship (Culbertson et al., 2010; Van Dam et al., 2008).

Leadership Making

While VDL and LMX helped leadership scholars shift away from the Average Leadership Styles and management-by-exception approaches, the shift towards leadership making promoted the notion of managers developing high-quality relationships with each follower. This relational approach is not only better for individual employees, but also for the workgroup. Like the stages of role taking, role making, and role routinization present in LMX (Nahrgang et al., 2009), leadership making suggests leader-member dyads begin as strangers, move into an acquaintance phase, and can evolve into a mature partnership. Ideally, all leader-member couplings would grow into a mature partnership, though many remain in the acquaintance phase. While leadership making shifts attention from a couple of high-quality relationships to positioning relationship development as an ethical component of a leader's role (Graen & Uhl-Bien, 1995), the same pattern of varying quality associations remains.

Beyond the Leader-Member Dyad

Contemporary LMX research has evolved from dyads to groups. Recent research has found that employees observe and take stock of the communicative differences between the way their manager interacts with each peer. In turn, this impacts myriad outcomes such as perceptions of leader fairness (Omilion-Hodges & Baker, 2017), the development of peer and team relationships (Sherony & Green, 2002), and workgroup attitudes (Bakar & McCann, 2014), among other outcomes. Research in this area has also found that in some situations, peers can be better sources of creativity and innovation than leaders (Omilion-Hodges & Ackerman, 2018), and there are instances when particularly high team-member exchange can buffer against the otherwise negative effects of low LMX quality (Wang & Hollenbeck, 2019).

Reviewing the evolution of leader-member exchange theory highlights the inexorable role communication plays in the enactment of leadership and how a titled leader influences their workgroup in tangible ways. Communication is the vehicle and byproduct of leader-member exchanges. In VDL, communicative interactions between a leader and their members prompted fissures in workgroups, where employees who

shared similar relationships with their leader grouped together either as in or out-group members. The role of communication became slightly more pronounced in the shift to leader-member exchange theory as scholars began to find that leader-member relationships weren't necessarily good or bad, high-quality, or low-quality, or in-group or out-group. Rather, due to variance in the communicative relationships it became clear that there was a greater degree of difference or nuance within dyadic relationships. Leadership making introduced the impact and responsibility of leader and follower communication, highlighting that a leader should strive to cultivate mature relationships with each member. The expansion of LMX to account for peer couplings and the workgroup illustrates the far-reaching effects of leader-member relationships.

Leader-Member Exchange Theoretical Underpinnings and Outcomes

As the theory has evolved, so have conceptualizations of its theoretical underpinnings in addition to antecedents and outcomes. Before exploring the major outcomes of LMX research, it is important to consider underlying theoretical approaches as they present different views of the enactment of leadership.

LMX was built from the theoretical foundation of social exchange theory (Blau, 1964; Cropanzano & Mitchell, 2005). Social exchange theory (SET; Blau, 1964) is often used to explain workplace behavior because it posits that social actors engage in a series of interdependent exchanges where parties consider the costs and benefits of interactions. These exchanges may induce obligation and remain transactional or may develop into high-quality, trusting partnerships. SET does not explicitly recognize the role of communication. Instead, the theoretical underpinning takes more of a management perspective in presuming the role of communication – that is the more a leader and member interact or the higher the quality of the interactions – the more likely the pair is to develop trust and mutual respect. A SET perspective is common among management and social psychology scholars exploring leader-member exchange and related outcomes such as social loafing (Murphy et al., 2003), task and organizational citizenship behaviors (Kamdar & VanDyne, 2007), and how leader-member relationships impact peer relationships (Sherony & Green, 2002), among other findings. The point is not that social exchange theory is deficient as a theoretical foundation for LMX, but rather that it masks the role of communication. Though SET is the current dominant approach to explaining the theoretical foundations of LMX, others have drawn from communication-rooted theories and approaches.

Fairhurst (1993, 2007) has long argued for more communicative investigations of LMXs. In an early examination of LMX, Fairhurst (1993) employed social communication theory (Sigman, 1991) as a theoretical foundation to consider how leaders and members develop and maintain relationships and identities across time. This is a unique consideration for LMX as traditional and contemporary takes have retained a stable and linear view of relationship progression and maintenance (e.g., role taking, making, and routinization; stranger, acquaintance, and mature partnership). Utilizing a communication footing allows for a more in-depth view of individual LMXs and how communication is employed within the workgroup by both the leader and members. Exploring the predominant discourses or interpretive resources used within a workgroup goes further than categorizing relationships (e.g., low, moderate, high) to instead reveal a nuanced understanding of team culture, status differences, relational norms, and power distinctions among other notable outcomes. Social communication theory draws from the relational and group nature of workgroups to highlight the norms and idiosyncrasies that develop within these social spaces. Thus, focusing on the predominant discourses uncovers a richer understanding of relational dynamics.

Narrative theory is another avenue suggested as a theoretical underpinning of LMX (Fairhurst, 2007). Fairhurst (2007) found that the popular quantitative scale, the LMX-7, was created by reviewing stories shared by leaders and members about the nature of their relationships. In this sense, LMX is founded on a narrative foundation but is most often studied via a Likert scale. Like social communication theory, employing a narrative view of the development of LMXs induces a more sophisticated understanding of the makeup and maintenance of these dyadic relationships as a narrative approach aids in both sensegiving and sensemaking. As Fairhurst (2007) points out, "in-depth interviews give leadership actors a greater chance to discursively reflect upon their LMX experiences, thus taking advantage of the ways that sensemaking and meaning get worked out *in communication*," (p. 122, emphasis original). This highlights the multiuse role communication plays in this leadership theory and the enactment of leadership. Put simply, a communicative foundation helps to highlight the fact that relational exchanges give way to associations of varying quality, help to sustain, or alter these relationships, while simultaneously serving as a vehicle for meaning making.

In line with Fairhurst's communication-rooted approaches to exploring LMX, Jian et al. (2014) utilized interactional richness theory (Barry & Crant, 2000) to create the Leader-Member Conversational Quality (LMCQ) Scale. The LMCQ scale captures the quality of the conversation between leaders and members, again going beyond the traditional, rudimentary, and often binary classification of LMXs. Thus, the authors

posit that it is the nuanced daily interactions that best exemplify the quality of the relationship. Moreover, this approach integrates communication efficiency in both interpretation and information exchange, demonstrating that high-quality dyads may engage in fewer exchanges contrary to other superficial approaches that broadly equate more communication with a more established relationship. While this may seem counterintuitive at first glance, those who have an established relationship may be able to communicate more efficaciously due to the mature relationship in place. Utilizing interactional richness theory as a foundation helped to highlight that as the social distance between two (leader and member) decreases, the efficacy of their communication is likely to increase.

Taken together, while SET has long been the predominant theoretical foundation of LMX, there are additional avenues available that may result in a more sophisticated view of these special dyadic relationships. While SET is an effective underpinning, it glosses over the role communication plays in constituting the relationship between a leader and a member. Additionally, while SET explicitly acknowledges the role exchange or interaction plays in relationship development, the co-created nature of LMX is minimized when only considered through the lens of reciprocal exchange.

The Communicative Nature of Leader-Member Exchange Theory

It has been suggested that LMX is a communicative theory of leadership (Omilion-Hodges & Ptacek, 2021). Though often integrated into management research and considered through the more behavioral lens of SET, leader-member exchange theory rests on communicative exchanges, relationship development and maintenance, and discursive overtures. Viewing LMX simply to classify relationship quality camouflages the communicative processes that occur within workgroups such as goal setting, establishing boundaries, navigating conflict, and collaborating to realize tasks (Mathieu et al., 2008; Omilion-Hodges et al., 2016). Homing in on the communicative nature of LMX allows us to shift the focus of inquiry from the mere codification of relationships to instead broaden our understanding of the relationship that emerges between a leader and member within the milieu of a workgroup.

Leadership communication scholars (e.g., Bakar & Sheer, 2013; Fairhurst & Hamlett, 2003; Jian et al., 2014; Sheer, 2015) have long acknowledged a need to recast LMX through a communicative lens. Relatedly, scholars have called attention to aspects that overlook a more intricate view of leader-member relationships simply because they sidestep the communicative complexity at play. For example, Fairhurst and Hamlett

(2003) pointed out that LMX theory oversimplifies relationship development, reducing this multiplex and interactive process to a rudimentary, linear view. Vertical dyad linkage positions leader-member relationship development as a straightforward process via role taking, role making, and role routinization (Nahrgang et al., 2009). Even more contemporary views of LMX, such as leadership making (Graen & Uhl-Bien, 1995), employ a linear process of relationship development that begins as strangers, moves to acquaintances, and may evolve into a mature partnership. Though having terms to articulate the general progression that may occur as leaders and members collaborate is a helpful starting point, it should be just that – a springboard to further exploration to consider the communicative elements in play.

While there is still much to learn about the leader-member communication process (Jian, 2014), leadership communication researchers have helped to nuance the field's understanding. Through a combination of participant self-report data and the analysis of workplace conversations, Fairhurst (1993) identified explicit communication behaviors in LMX relationships. More specifically, aligning, accommodating, and polarizing behaviors emerged and were indicative of specific behavioral patterns and language usage, which aligned with the quality of a specific LMX. For example, leaders often used coaching and shared personal predicaments or accounts to shield a high-LMX member from backlash or other outside forces (p. 343). However, in LMXs with a larger power difference, Fairhurst (1993) uncovered instances of role negotiation where the leader would engage in polite offers or counteroffers to work within the clear bounds of the co-constructed relationship. As expected in low LMX associations, leaders were more likely to engage in power games including silence, put-ons, and boasting to demonstrate one-upmanship (p. 343). This work helps to add a depth of understanding of the communication processes between leader and member that had just been assumed or glossed over in the decades previous.

Relatedly, Omilion-Hodges and Baker (2017) posited that the exchange aspect (Sheer, 2015) of the dyadic relationship was observable, and therefore, the act of exchange in and of itself was communicative. In other words, peers observe the interactions between a colleague and their shared manager and make assessments regarding the quality of the relationship. Like Fairhurst's (1993) uncovering of various communication behaviors that were typical of high, moderate, and low-quality relationships, Omilion-Hodges and Baker (2017) found that certain types of exchanges – such as those centered around mentoring, professional development, and trust, among others – correlated with a high-quality relationship. The researchers also found that not only do those with lower quality LMXs receive fewer positive communication-based

goods (i.e., support, access to information, access to the leader), but they were often also recipients of negative communication exchanges such as lack of concern for their professional development.

Additional work by leadership communication scholars has also helped to showcase how communication and conversation practices constitute LMX relationships. Jian and colleagues (2014) created and validated the Leader-Member Communication Quality (LMCQ) scale. This was a significant contribution to a deeper understanding of the communicative processes constituting leader-member interactions. While other scales, such as the LMX-7 (Graen et al., 1982) and the LMSX (Bernerth et al., 2007) capture a member's perceptions of the quality of social exchange with their leader, the LMCQ operationalizes the task-related conversations that occur in the dyad. The scale utilizes items such as "When discussing work-related matters, my supervisor and I can convey a lot to each other even in a short conversation," and "When talking about how to get things done at work, my supervisor and I are usually in sync with each other." Indicating strong agreement to these items represents conversational practices such as efficiency and interpretation that illustrate shared meaning between parties that have a well-established relationship. Members who disagree with such items are likely indicating a tenuous connection with their leader, which impacts the degree to which they are connected. Correspondingly, Jian and Dalisay (2017) found that leader-member conversational quality ratings are associated with organizational commitment, but also that ratings of leader-member conversational quality vary based on an employee's LMX.

Relatedly, other communication scholars have made notable contributions to this area. Nearly two decades ago, Fix and Sias (2006) found that person-centered communication is the driving predictor of LMX quality and employee job satisfaction. More recently, Sias and Duncan (2019) illustrated that high LMX employees are more likely to engage in extra role tasks when their manager uses requests, acknowledgments, explanations, and appreciation rather than requests. On the other hand, the researchers found that those with lower LMX are likely to perceive extra role task requests as unreasonable (Sias & Duncan, 2019). Additionally, Bakar has contributed greatly to this area with findings regarding supervisory communication and the development of LMXs in a non-U.S. setting with multiple ethnicities. More specifically, Bakar and colleagues (2010) found that leader-initiated positive relationship communication practices, upward openness communication practices, and job-relevant communication practices culminate in positive leader-member relationships that, in turn, increase group commitment. Put simply, when leaders communicate intentionally with each employee,

dyadic relationships tend to thrive, leading to a positive work environment employees want to remain within. Bakar and Sheer (2013) echoed these findings and called for leaders to initiate and encourage information sharing and constructive negotiation among all group members as doing so could strengthen group cohesion (regardless of individual LMXs). Similarly, Mueller and Lee (2002) found that an employee's LMX influences how satisfied they are in interpersonal, organizational, and group contexts. In particular, the higher an employee's leader-member relationship quality, the more satisfied they tend to be with personal feedback and supervisory communication, communication with their peers, corporate communication, and the communication climate of the organization.

In summary, leader-member exchange theory is realized and constituted through communication. Though the theory is often considered from management or psychological perspectives, it has also been argued that this leadership theory could just as easily be framed as a communication theory (Omilion-Hodges & Ptacek, 2021). Considered in the most basic of terms, a leader and an employee engage in an ongoing series of communicative interactions that result in a negotiated relationship. This means that leader-member associations are produced by and are simultaneously a byproduct of communication. As will be discussed in the next section, these relationships exist on a continuum ranging from challenging and antagonistic to a mature, two-way relationship.

Leader-Member Relationships: From Positive and Prosocial to Challenging and Antagonistic

The second outcome that LMX research has continued to reiterate is the fact that leader-member relationships range in quality. A major and continuing critique of the theory is that it is little more than a shortcut for leader likeability (e.g., Dulebohn et al., 2017; Liu et al., 2020), in that those the leader likes are in the in-group, and those they do not connect with as readily may find themselves in the out-group. Dulebohn et al. (2017) conducted a meta-analysis and found that "liking is an important and distinct construct that facilitates the development of LMX and therefore should not be abandoned in organizational research that examine supervisor-subordinate relational quality" (p. 149). Naturally in the development of interpersonal relationships, elements such as demographic and lifestyle similarity influence liking and then facilitate the development of trust and respect. Though in lieu of exploring the interdependent interpersonal confluences together, many continue to resort to binary or otherwise reductive views of

the relationship, which conceals the group that likely best captures most employees' experience – that of middle-quality LMX.

Despite the dynamic nature of interpersonal relationships and scholars long suggesting (i.e., Gerstner & Day, 1997) LMX may shift over the course of a relationship, middle-quality LMXs have generally been overlooked in research literature. This aligns with the critique that the theory is often not used to its full explanatory potential, again just typically describing either low or high-quality relationships, glossing over the nuances of relationship quality. Even though the theory is virtually always examined from low and high-quality perspectives, Graen and Cashman (1975) called attention to in (high-quality), middle, and out (low-quality) groups. Graen (Graen & Uhl-Bien, 1995; Liden & Graen, 1980) continued to acknowledge the presence of a middle-quality group via the acquaintance stage described in the leadership-making model. Despite these explicit mentions of a middle-quality LMX group, very few scholars specifically identify this cohort in research. However, the research that has been conducted in this area suggests that there may be less turnover in this middle-quality group and these employees may also experience less stress and role ambiguity and more job satisfaction in contrast to peers with high LMX (Harris et al., 2005; Kramer, 1995; Vecchio & Gobdel, 1984).

Various processes for leader-member relationship development have been proposed (e.g., stage models in LMX and leadership making). Early studies focused on exploring the varied interpersonal relationships that leaders cultivated with each follower, and two poles emerged: high-quality exchanges and low-quality exchanges (Zalesny & Graen, 1987). Employees who had high-quality exchange relationships with their leader were seen as "trusted assistants" and often engaged in extra-role behaviors, whereas employees with low-quality exchange relationships described transactional exchanges and feeling like "hired hands" (Zalesny & Graen, 1987) rather than partners or valued contributors.

Though somewhat varied in their descriptions, the predominant relational processes share similarities. Whether considered as the stranger phase or as role taking, the initial stage of a leader-member relationship involves implicit and explicit testing by both parties. Explicitly, the leader assigns various tasks with follower performance guiding the next steps. In instances where the follower meets or exceeds the leader's expectations, they will likely be met with praise and additional role responsibilities that are more challenging, more visible, or otherwise of higher stakes. In instances where the employee does not meet the leader's expectations, they may consider mentoring, providing the employee more time to become acclimated or commence a formal

performance plan. Implicit testing occurs when the leader observes how the follower interacts in meetings, with peers, and with other stakeholders. Followers, too, may observe the leader to see how they handle stressors such as tight deadlines or other work-related challenges. New employees are also likely to observe how the leader interacts with other members to make sense of the range of relationships and workgroup norms such as the use of humor, level of professionalism, collaborative or competitive culture, etc.

The second phase of relationship development shifts to explicitly acknowledge followers' autonomy. For example, in the role-making phase, employees can advocate for themselves by lobbying for tasks that utilize their unique skill set and help them to reach their professional goals. The acquaintance phase too, unlike the stranger phase, implies a knowingness of followers in terms of their role and their specific LMX relationship and how they can better navigate the workplace. However, as research indicates, not all relationships will flourish in ways that allow for two-way communication, upward influence, and mutual trust and respect. The challenging aspect of role routinization (Nahrgang et al., 2009) is that once the relationship is established, it is not likely to change radically. That is, once you are perceived in a specific light by your leader, that assessment is not likely to change regardless of output.

To summarize, LMX is a relational and communication-rooted avenue for exploring leader-member dyads and the employee experience based on the quality of the association. Though a long-standing critique of the theory is that it is little more than a measure of leader likeability, assuming a communicative perspective allows researchers to better understand the process of relationship development and maintenance. Therefore, uncovering the varying relationship qualities between leader and member is only one piece in understanding an employee's experience.

Leader-Member Exchange and the Employee Experience

Most adults spend more time working than they do with their families and friends (Omilion-Hodges & Ptacek, 2021). This may mean, however, that when work is particularly demanding or employees are navigating challenging relationships, this sentiment is likely to bleed over to impact one's personal life. When the leader-member relationship is productive and respectful, then accessing information and asking for additional resources, for example, tend to be straightforward endeavors. However, if an employee's leader-member relationship is strained, then they may feel professionally

stifled (Kraimer et al., 2011), and seeking required resources such as access to project information or timelines may be anxiety-inducing (Omilion-Hodges & Baker, 2017).

LMX relationships vary in terms of the amount of information, support, trust, and resources exchanged between leader and member (Kraimer et al., 2016). Decades of empirical research reiterate that employees who share high-quality relationships with their leaders receive more formal and informal rewards, higher levels of trust, additional emotional support, and increased communication (Dienesch & Liden, 1986). Some have suggested that the increase in positive resources that high LMX employees enjoy is repayment or exchange for shouldering more responsibilities and taking on tasks above and beyond those in their formal job description (Harris & Kacmar, 2006).

There is a high degree of loyalty and obligation (Liden & Maslyn, 1998) associated with high LMX, which helps to explain why these employees tend to be more committed to the organization and in turn, receive more trust, support, sponsorship (Graen & Uhl-Bien, 1995; Sparrowe & Liden, 1997). Those with high-quality LMXs may receive increased resources and support from their leader in terms of recommendations for promotions, career opportunities, and career successes (Kraimer et al., 2011; Wayne et al., 1999). Considering this, it is of little surprise that those with high-quality leader-member relationships tend to be more satisfied with their jobs/careers and report having more professional opportunities (Byrne et al., 2008; Kraimer et al., 2011). What's more, LMX has a significant negative relationship with turnover and significant positive relationships with satisfaction with pay, empowerment, and job satisfaction (Dulebohn et al., 2012).

In tandem with leader-member exchange theory, others have utilized tournament theory (Rosenbaum, 1979) as an explanatory mechanism for why high LMX employees tend to be more successful professionally than their peers. From this perspective, Kraimer and colleagues (2016) explain that LMX is a form of sponsored mobility in the sense that leaders equip their trusted lieutenants with enhanced guidance, information, and support. As a result, high LMX employees are better prepared to step into promotions or assume more responsibility. Case in point, Schaubroeck and Lam (2002) found that LMX quality was related to bank teller promotions.

However, those with extremely high LMX may experience more stress than peers with a moderate-quality relationship, indicating that those in high LMX couplings are likely to assume extra role responsibilities (Harris & Kacmar, 2006). Jian (2014) found a curvilinear relationship between LMX and role overload and role conflict. Relatedly, Jian also found a negative linear relationship between LMX and role ambiguity. In sum, these findings reiterate that employees who have a well-established relationship with

their leader report more clarity and a better grasp on their role responsibilities. Jian's work highlights another important finding – those with moderate leader-member exchange relationships tend to report higher levels of role overload and role conflict than both low LMX and exceedingly high LMX peers. Recent research has continued in this vein and has shown that LMX positively affects empowerment, which negatively affects emotional exhaustion and depression (Schermuly & Meyer, 2016). Taken together, establishing a high-quality leader-member relationship may bring additional responsibility and perhaps some additional stress related to the extra duties, but employees who do so tend to make more money, are promoted more often, find more satisfaction in their careers, and enjoy the support, trust, and respect of their leader.

LMX quality also impacts the employee experience as it relates to culture and employee voice. Jian (2012) found that as immigrants' LMX quality increased, so did their retention of their original culture and their level of adjustment to American culture. Conversely, immigrants with lower-quality LMX reported lower levels of original culture retention and adjustment to American culture. This finding reiterates the potential power of establishing a high-quality leader-member relationship cross culturally. In short, Jian's (2012) study demonstrates the agency and related affordances associated with a high-quality LMX, in that those who have an established relationship with their leader may feel more comfortable retaining their original culture as they adjust and integrate into the host culture. Similarly, Botero and Van Dyne (2009) found that in independent samples collected in the U.S. and Columbia, LMX is positively related to employee voice, suggesting that as one's relationship with their leader increases, so does the likelihood that they will share ideas, information, and opinions. These findings again illustrate that leader-member relationship quality has implications for individual, group, and organizational outcomes.

While there are myriad positive outcomes documented regarding high LMX, it is equally important to consider the employee experience for those with a lower-quality LMX. What literature demonstrates is that those with less well-developed LMXs tend to not only receive fewer positive resources than high LMX peers, but rather that those with low LMX tend to be recipients of hostile and exclusive behavior (e.g., Omilion-Hodges & Baker, 2017; Thompson et al., 2018).

Supervisors who have low LMX relationships in the workgroup are more inclined to display incivility (Thompson et al., 2018). For example, Furunes et al. (2015) explored the potential effects of low LMX on various work-environment quality indicators across three industries. In samples with teachers, industrial workers, and bus drivers, the researchers found low LMX relationships were associated with increased levels of

stress, bullying, role conflict, and turnover intentions. Additionally, low-quality relationships were also linked to increases in age discrimination, and lower levels of job satisfaction, commitment, autonomy, social support, participation, and skills utilization. These findings demonstrate a very different employee experience for low LMX members in contrast to those with a mature partnership. Relatedly, Omilion-Hodges and Baker (2017) found that those with low LMX may be subject to a manager's harsh critiques, dirty looks, and exclusionary behavior such as sharing private information or withholding information required for the employee to complete their role responsibilities.

While there is a multitude of studies that demonstrate consequences or outcomes of leader-member relationship quality not included in this chapter, they largely map onto the findings presented. This binary grouping stems from early research that talked about leader-member followers typically being classified as cadres (in-group) or hired hands (out-group) (Graen & Uh-Bien, 1995). While classifying leader-member relationships as high or low is reductive and obscures the communication processes, the findings help to illustrate the impact of this leadership theory and how the leader-member relationship largely shapes an employee's experience. Yet even though the vast majority of related research winnows in on the distinction between low-quality and high-quality LMX, it is important to consider the research that has been done on employees with moderate LMX.

While some scholarship specifically addresses this middle group (e.g., Ferris et al., 2009; Nelson, 2013; Vecchio & Gobdel, 1984), other work discusses findings related to moderate LMXs' experiences. Ferris and colleagues (2009) address the lack of attention directed toward understanding the dimensions that undergird leader-member relationships, how they interact with each other, and how these relationships impact other workplace outcomes. These researchers considered leader-member relationship development across stages (initial interaction, development and expansion of roles, expansion and commitment, and increased interpersonal commitment) to nuance understanding of all employees' experiences, rather than the traditional high or low view. Relatedly, Nelson (2013) forwarded a multi-study dissertation to better understanding the middle-quality LMX group.

Others have examined LMX as dynamic and interactive in nature which implies a variety of relationship qualities within groups. For example, Omilion-Hodges and Baker (2017) acknowledge that a series of communicative exchanges between leader and member color the nature of the relationship over time. Other communication scholars (Bakar et al., 2010; Jian et al., 2014) examine LMX quality on a continuum

using correlation or curvilinear approach to move beyond the rudimentary high/low grouping. The reason communication scholars, in particular, tend to view LMX relationships on a continuum is because they tend to see relationships develop as a process and view relationships as ever changing (Sheer, 2015). As Sheer (2015, p. 5) aptly points out "For exchange, LMX theory misses an explicit discussion" suggesting that the theory would be better conceptualized via a series of communication-rooted, interactive exchange concepts, such as social communication exchange and work communication exchange among others. This line of thinking helps move the theory beyond a simplistic classification system to instead a view that is both more pragmatic and accurate (Jian & Dalisay, 2017). Taken together, while researchers seem to come to agreement that there is a group of employees who find themselves in the middle – between their low and high LMX counterparts – there is little scholarly research that specifically examines this group. This oversight presents an area ripe for future research. The latest phase of LMX research has expanded to consider how a workgroup's collective LMXs may impact peer and team relationships.

Beyond the Dyad: Leader-Member Exchange and Peer and Team Relationships

While a leader-member relationship does not develop nor exist in a silo, until the early 2000s LMX research retained a focus on individual dyads. More recent uses of the theory, however, account for the context in which these relationships develop and are maintained – the workgroup. Omilion-Hodges et al. (2016) argued that studying LMX in tandem with coworker exchange (CWX) and team-member exchange (TMX) provided a more accurate view of the communicative processes occurring in workgroups.

Contextualized LMX research illustrates the reach of leader-member associations. For instance, Sherony and Green (2002) demonstrated how LMX may further complicate (or enhance in some cases) an employee's experience. The scholars (Sherony & Green, 2002) found that employees with high LMX were more likely to befriend other in-group members. Relatedly, those with lower LMX tended to develop relationships with other out-group members. This demonstrates as have others since (Baker & Omilion-Hodges, 2013; Omilion-Hodges & Baker, 2013) that those who have high-quality relationships with their leaders are also likely to have access to even more resources via their relationships with high-status peers. Conversely, those who have a challenging leader-member relationship may realize that they also have less access to

resources since their likely exchange partners – others with lower-quality leader-member relationships – have collectively fewer resources to share.

LMX research beyond the dyad has also provided some insight into how LMX variability impacts employees and the team. Hooper and Martin (2008) found that as LMX variability increased in a team, employees' job satisfaction and their well-being decreased. In other words, in workgroups where LMX relationships are perceived to vary greatly, it negatively impacts the collective employee experience. LMX variance in teams impacts the allocation of resources (Omilion-Hodges & Baker, 2017) and workplace attitudes (Bakar & McCann, 2014). In a state-of-the-art review, Omilion-Hodges et al. (2016) presented LMX research that transcended the dyad in a series of diagrams to visually represent empirical research that utilizes LMX and how it overlaps with peer relationships and team relationships.

Implications and Future Directions

Pragmatic Implications: Why Does LMX Matter to Me?

Leader-member exchange theory directly impacts all organizational members. Formally titled leaders will be best served by efforts to cultivate strong, trusting relationships with each of their team members. Doing so will not only enhance employee well-being, but likely enhance workgroup output via employees engaging in extra-role behaviors and additional citizenship behaviors (e.g., Graen & Uhl-Bien, 1995; Omilion-Hodges et al., 2016). Moreover, when titled leaders strive to develop strong relationships with each member, they are likely to minimize LMX variance (Hooper & Martin, 2008), thereby further enhancing the functioning of the unit.

As has been long documented, it is typically in an employee's best interest to develop a highly effective relationship with their manager. Doing so usually results in employees having greater access to resources (Omilion-Hodges & Baker, 2017), more career successes (Kraimer et al., 2011), and higher career satisfaction (Kraimer et al., 2016). Moreover, since leader-member relationships are an outcome of communication, they impact other workgroup associations, thereby influencing whom an employee likely is to befriend and exchange with within the team.

The strength of a communicative view highlights the pivotal role communication plays in an employee's organizational experience. Through intentional, inclusive, and other-oriented communication, both leaders and members can positively impact the shared relationship. In communicating in an audience-centered manner, both parties are likely to demonstrate respect for the other, thereby building a foundation for a trusting

relationship to mature. In instances where the relationship is strained, a communicative focus may allow the pair to air grievances and jointly consider how to move forward productively.

Individuals who are new to an industry or new to the workforce are especially likely to benefit from working to establish a high-quality relationship with their leader. Research is replete with the benefits bestowed upon high-LMX employees ranging from access to work-related resources such as information and training to increased career opportunities and earning potential (Kraimer et al., 2016). While this is helpful for employees at any career stage, those who are new to the workforce or have recently changed industries may markedly benefit from a high-quality LMX. This aligns with research that shows that young adults entering the workforce seek mentors (Omilion-Hodges et al., 2019). Though it is hard to overstate the importance of the leader-member relationship, it may become less significant as employees grow in their careers and develop confidence and expertise. Similarly, LMX quality may be less important for those who are skilled communicators and or have well-developed networks (Bauer et al., 2006; Byrne et al., 2008). However, it has been proposed that LMX is more important for those who may be introverted, less proactive, or lacking in political skills (Bauer et al., 2006; Byrne et al., 2008).

Future Research Directions

Despite the decades of related research, there is still much to explore related to LMX. In fact, it continues to be argued that of all the levels of analysis typically conducted in organizational research (i.e., team, organization, etc.), the dyadic relationship is the one that is least understood and most poorly measured (Kim et al., 2020; Yammarino & Gooty, 2017), making the level that is also most often overlooked in research (Tse et al., 2021). In this brief section, calls for more qualitative approaches and temporal dynamics will be addressed, as will related developments in quantitative methods in the hope to inform scholars in future communication-focused LMX research.

As noted, measurement continues to be an area of critique thereby also leaving space for continued research. Sheer (2015), for example, has pointed out that LMX is treated as attributes of leader and member behavior, rather than as a meaningful consideration of the interactions that occur within the dyad. To more accurately measure LMX, Sheer (2015) suggests researchers explore the concept via four exchange dimensions including tangible work exchange, tangible social exchange, work communication exchange, and social communication exchange. Others too suggest that the measurement of LMX is

problematic for a variety of reasons, such as a disconnect with the social exchange foundation (Andersen et al., 2020), analysis completed at different levels than measured (Gottfredon et al., 2020), and focused too heavily on member-centered, cross-sectional data (Omilion-Hodges & Ptacek, 2021). In a state-of-the-science review on leader-member dyadic research, Kim and colleagues (2020) offered specific suggestions for moving the research forward. The researchers created a nomological network to illustrate related leader-member dyadic research that, in large measure, indicated that much of what is known about the leader-member dyad captures affective, behavioral, and cognitive variables outside of the association. As such, the authors (Kim et al., 2020) call attention to dyad-specific fissures ripe for exploration, including research on the leader-member interaction process, exploration regarding leader-member characteristics, and similarity of perceptions. In short, Kim et al. (2020) illustrate that research anchored specifically in the relationship shared between leader and member is largely absent and needed. Not only do the authors call for content-specific leader-member research, but also offer specific suggestions for methodology as well. For example, the authors call for longitudinal studies, network related approaches, in addition to multi-source and multi-wave designs. Taken together, scholars have long acknowledged shortcomings related to LMX measurement and there are precise, communication-rooted research gaps (i.e., research based squarely in the relationship) that need to be filled.

Regarding calls for additional nuance in qualitative explorations of LMX, Fairhurst (1993) has long called for more focus on the actual communicative exchanges that take place between leader and member. A discourse analysis, for example, allows for a more nuanced understanding of the varied relationships that a leader develops with each member. This and other qualitative approaches may allow researchers to explore the various types of relationships a leader develops in the workplace. This approach may help titled leaders to understand the various needs they seek to fulfill in the workplace via their relationships. Relatedly, employees too may be well served to have a more concrete idea of the various interpersonal and task-centered needs leaders are looking to fulfill.

In their book on Leader-Member Exchange, Omilion-Hodges and Ptacek (2021) called attention to the fact that leader-member and other workgroup relationships are dynamic, yet they are studied often only once (i.e., cross-sectional studies) and often from one perspective concealing the dynamism of relationships. Taking this approach may also yield additional insight into the middle-quality LMX cohort. The heart of LMX rests on interpersonal relationships suggesting that these relationships are not static, and

assessment of the quality may be in sync and other times, diverge (Hofmans et al., 2019). A communicative perspective encourages a view that occurs in situ; thus, it is important to consider the dynamic nature of the dyadic relationship rather than considering relationship quality carved in stone.

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Further Reading

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Kim, J., Yammarino, F. J., Dionne, S. D., Eckardt, R., Cheong, M., Tsai, C-Y., Guo, J., & Park, J. W. (2020). State-of-the-science review of leader-follower dyads research. *The Leadership Quarterly*, *31*. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.leaqua.2019.101306. (In-depth review of leader-follower dyads research with calls for recommended future research.)

Omilion-Hodges, L. M., Ptacek, J. K., & Zerilli, D. H. (2016). A comprehensive review and communication research agenda of the contextualized workgroup: The evolution and future of leader-member exchange, coworker exchange, and team-member exchange. *Annals of the International Communication Association*, *40*(1), 343–377. (The authors put leader-member, coworker, and team-exchange articles into conversation, highlighting specific areas for future research across communication specialties.)

Sheer, V. C. (2015). "Exchange lost" in leader–member exchange theory and research: A critique and a reconceptualization. *Leadership*, *11*(2), 213–229. (This conceptual article offers thoughtful insight on how to better explore leader-member exchange from a communication perspective.)

12

LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION AND WORKPLACE MENTORING

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-15

Introduction

Mentoring is traditionally defined as "a communication relationship in which a senior person supports, tutors, guides, and facilitates a junior person's career development" (Hill et al., 1989, p. 15). Productive mentoring in the workplace has long been regarded as a critical process in the development of people for work performance, career advancement, and socialization into occupations, as well as for the development of the organization and productive organizational culture (Long et al., 2014; Ragins & Kram, 2008; Varghese & Finkelstein, 2021). Because of such positive workplace outcomes, it is not surprising that leadership and mentoring continue to be a topic engaged by practitioners, industry thought leaders, and researchers across disciplines, exemplified by the sustained vigorous conversations on workplace mentoring as well as numerous research articles, edited volumes, and handbooks on this topic (e.g., Allen & Eby, 2007; Clutterbuck et al., 2017; Ragins & Kram, 2008). Workplace mentoring research traditionally privileges the prototype of mentoring that focuses on a dyadic relationship pairing a senior member (mentor) and a junior member (mentee) for career development. At the same time, research has moved beyond the traditional model to explore diverse formats (formal and informal, one-on-one, and group-based), directions (downward, reverse, and peer), contexts (face-to-face, online, and hybrid), and functions (psychosocial, career, role modeling, solidarity, and advocacy) of mentoring.

This chapter views mentoring as an essential enactment of leadership. The chapter adopts Fairhurst and Connaughton's (2014) definition of leadership as the co-management of meaning and influential organizing acts. Specifically, leadership involves co-management of meaning, whereby leaders and followers co-construct meanings as they engage in sensemaking, framing, and identity work. Leadership also involves influential organizing acts whereby leadership actors continuously produce, configure, and negotiate organizational structures (rules and resources) in everyday communicative actions. This social constructionist view of leadership highlights that communication processes define and constitute leadership. The chapter argues that mentoring is a crucial communication process that makes up leadership.

At the micro/interpersonal level, leaders play an important role in workplace mentoring. In the traditional mentoring relationship defined above, leaders – often as the more experienced, skilled, and knowledgeable counterparts – tend to assume the role of mentors, coaches, sponsors, and/or advocates in a mentoring relationship. In this way, leader mentors help mentees make sense of the organizational life, share their organizational knowledge, offer access to networks, champion new talents, and subsequently support the overall growth of the organization. In this way, mentoring communication between mentor-mentee overlaps with leader-member exchange, often as a dyadic interaction between a leader and a member (see Chapter 11 of the handbook). As they facilitate mentees' development and professional goal attainment, leaders in the mentor roles also benefit from the relationship by learning from their mentees, developing leadership skills, building their networks, and gaining a sense of accomplishment (Ragins & Kram, 2008). While leaders often serve as mentors, leaders must also be mentored to satisfy their continued learning and development needs. Thus, formal and informal leadership training/coaching can also be considered as mentoring.

At the meso/organizational level, leaders are core to the design and framing of organizational structures of mentoring. Mentoring structures can take the form of formal mentoring and onboarding programs, performance evaluations that reward mentoring efforts, informal mentoring networks, and/or mindful cultivation of team/organizational culture that values mentoring. Such mentoring structures are crucial to initiate and support organizational learning, whereby organizational members engage in collaborative internal processes that value openness, creativity, authenticity, imagination, and experimentation to generate transformative responses to turbulent environmental conditions (Bokeno & Gantt, 2000). Furthermore, new generational workers have demonstrated a stronger preference for mentoring and actively seek employers who can provide such programs (Hewlett et al., 2009). Therefore,

organizations must set up meaningful mentoring structures to continue to innovate and to attract and sustain talents.

Finally, leadership and mentoring connect at the macro/societal level through cultural discourses (systems of thought). The prototype of an ideal leader often overlaps with a wise and inspirational mentor in such discourses. In particular, transformative, servant, and relational leadership theories often feature mentoring followers as a core function/goal of leadership practice (Sosik & Godshalk, 2000; Sosik et al., 2004). Broader discourses about what makes a great leader and what makes a great mentor share a lot of similar qualities, such as empathy, authenticity, inspirational motivation, intellectual stimulation, role modeling, and so on. When viewing mentoring as an enactment of leadership communication, good mentoring becomes a form of high-quality leader-member exchange marked by trust, connection, and growth. In short, leadership and mentoring processes are co-dependent and intertwined. Examining mentoring processes when we study and perform leadership communication is essential.

This chapter is structured as follows to capture this robust area of inquiry on mentoring and leadership communication. This chapter begins with a brief review of current conceptualizations of mentoring by highlighting its key characteristics, benefits, and how it relates to other similar concepts, such as coaching. Next, the chapter outlines the rich interdisciplinary research on various forms of mentoring, including traditional forms of mentoring that focus on one-on-one relationships, and alternative forms of mentoring, including reverse, collaborative, networked, episodic, and advocate mentoring. As various forms of mentoring are laid out, the chapter surfaces leadership communication processes essential to traditional and alternative forms of mentoring in the workplace. The chapter ends with challenges and future directions for leaders and researchers to continue to study and practice mentoring to realize its benefits to individuals and organizations.

Understanding Mentoring as Developmental Relational Processes

In the last four decades, mentoring as a scholarly inquiry has blossomed in various contexts (e.g., youth, academic, workplace) and across different disciplines (e.g., education, psychology, nursing, management) (Clutterbuck et al., 2017; Mullen & Kilmaitis, 2021). Despite the differences in this body of literature, scholars have converged on some commonalities of mentoring – mentoring relationships are broadly characterized by reciprocity or mutuality of social exchange, developmental benefits linked to the mentees' work and career, and regular/consistent interactions between

mentors and mentees over some time (Mullen & Kilmaitis, 2021). It is recognized that trust, connectedness, respect, empathy, and a sense of autonomy are all essential relational considerations for mentoring processes (Mullen & Kilmaitis, 2021). As a developmental relationship, mentoring consists of four phases (Kram, 1983, 1985): (a) *initiation*, which is characterized by both parties having positive thoughts and idealistic expectations about one another as they enter the relationship; (b) *cultivation*, when the positive expectations from the initiation phase are continuously tested against reality as the two parties engage in frequent and more intense mentoring exchanges, (c) *separation*, when either member or both have outgrown the relationship, and the time has come for a structural and psychological change in the relationship marked by a decrease of mentoring interactions and increase of the mentee's autonomy; and finally (d) *redefinition*, that is, both parties aim to find new ways to relate to each other. For example, a mentoring relationship can shift into a collegial friendship characterized by informal contact, mutual support, and emotional bond.

Kalbfleisch (2002) further extended Kram's (1983) classic mentoring model by introducing the Mentoring Enactment Theory (MET). MET highlights the importance of communication in the enactment of mentoring. Specifically, MET focused on the proactive communicative strategies mentors and mentees can use to initiate, develop, maintain, and repair mentoring relationships. For relationships to be sustained healthily, mentoring partners need to be able to communicate openly and honestly, work through differences, negotiate tensions, and deal with issues that come up. If reconciliation is not achieved and the perceived cost is higher than the benefit of the relationship, the mentoring relationship is likely to end.

In this chapter, mentoring is used as an umbrella term that captures various developmental relational processes and structures in the workplace, acknowledging that there are other similar concepts. For example, managerial coaching can share overlapping boundaries with mentoring. Coaching can be defined as the supervisor/manager's communicative actions to facilitate employee learning to enhance their competence and performance (Jian, 2024). In this chapter, coaching behaviors are considered specific performances of mentoring that focus on job competence and performance, as mentoring involves communication actions whereby a senior person tutors and guides a junior person's development of job-related skills. Similarly, tutorship and apprenticeship, whereby the teacher transfers knowledge and facilitates the skill development of junior members of the organization, can also be considered as mentoring.

Traditional and Alternative Forms of Mentoring

Scholarship on workplace mentoring has examined traditional and alternative forms of mentoring, including their enactment, development, and outcomes. Although leadership is not often studied explicitly in this body of work, the mentoring literature underlies the idea that doing mentoring well involves mindful leadership communication. Such communication involved facilitating parties in mentoring relationships to engage in sensemaking and identity work and framing mentoring efforts as essential for employee growth and wellbeing and organizational goal attainment to various stakeholders (Fairhurst & Connaughton, 2014). Doing mentoring well also requires leaders to engage in various communicative actions with organizational actors to produce, configure, and negotiate workplace structures related to mentoring (e.g., rules to set up mentoring pairs, technical support, and financial resources to support the organization's formal virtual mentoring program) (Fairhurst & Connaughton, 2014). In this section, the chapter will highlight the connection between mentoring and leadership research by highlighting leadership communication in the enactment of traditional and alternative forms of mentoring.

Traditional Forms of Mentoring

Traditional mentoring often follows a dyadic arrangement, with the senior member as the mentor and the junior as the mentee. An effective mentor in this arrangement is traditionally understood as one in a superior position and not in competition with the mentee (Kalbfleisch, 1997). In this dyad, a mentor provides two main mentoring functions to a mentee: career and psychosocial mentoring functions (Kram, 1983). Career functions often involve career goals and planning, sponsoring and promoting, networking, skills development, training, and other related activities. The mentors usually act as the coach, helper, consultant, as well as sponsor in mentees' professional development. As traditional mentoring often focuses on one-way learning, it does not fully account for the immense value of reciprocal learning and growth, "although reciprocity and learning may nonetheless occur" (Mullen & Klimaitis, 2021, p. 21). In addition to career guidance, mentors perform psychosocial functions such as counseling and encouragement to enhance mentees' confidence and assist mentees in navigating organizational realities. However, as traditional mentoring often occurs within a hierarchical relationship of a senior (e.g., manager) and a junior (e.g., employee), psychosocial functions may be constrained by issues of power, privilege, authority, and control (Mullen & Klimaitis, 2021).

Traditional mentoring can be categorized based on the mentoring relationship's formal and/or informal nature. While formal programs are often prescribed by the organization regarding their meeting schedule, content, and format, informal mentoring allows both parties to interact in a more casual and flexible setting. Relationships where a third party matches the mentor and mentee and are part of an officially sanctioned mentoring program are typically considered formal mentoring (Ragins & Cotton, 1999). Relationships that develop naturally or spontaneously without outside assistance are considered informal mentoring (Ragins & Cotton, 1999). Traditional forms of mentoring can be either one-on-one or clustered. In clustered mentoring, one or more mentors can guide and support the development of more than one mentee (Huizing, 2012). Clustered mentoring is still considered a traditional form of mentoring as the mentor(s) are usually senior and more experienced members of the organization, and the mentees are junior members who can benefit from the teaching and advice from the mentor(s). One key benefit of cluster mentoring is that in addition to gaining support from the mentor(s), mentees can also engage in peer mentoring and develop a sense of belonging (Huizing, 2012).

Leadership Communication for Traditional Dyadic Mentoring Relationships

In traditional dyadic mentoring relationships, leaders may be responsible for serving as mentors in mentoring relationships and/or overseeing mentoring programs. Three leadership communication processes[1] stand out as important to ensuring productive traditional workplace mentoring relationships: matching mentees with mentors, socializing mentees through role development processes, and navigating negative mentoring experiences. The leadership communication processes are discussed with an emphasis on practical implications for leaders.

Matching Mentee–Mentor

Considerable mentoring research has examined the best practices for pairing mentees and mentors in mentoring dyads to harness the benefits of this developmental relationship. While some researchers suggest choosing a mentor from the dominant group of the organization can provide more access and resources for the mentee (Sosik & Godshalk, 2005), others recommend choosing someone with similar gender, race, and experiences in workplace challenges, as such relationships are more likely to bring rapport, emotional comfort, and enhanced self-efficacy (Allen et al., 2005; Varghese &

Finkelstein, 2021). The area of mentoring pairing research that is of particular interest to leadership communication is the studies on mentee-mentor identification. Humberd and Rouse (2016) argued that when mentoring parties identify with one another, that is, when they realize that they share common characteristics (e.g., all had international working experience) and/or workplace challenges (e.g., manage working parenthood challenges), they are more likely to have a productive relationship. Varghese and Finkelstein (2021) provided further empirical support that mentees who perceive their mentors have had similar workplace challenges or issues they are currently facing are more likely to adopt their mentors' perspectives and experience a higher level of self-efficacy. Applying these insights to leadership communication, it can be beneficial for leaders who serve as mentors in traditional mentoring relationships to disclose information about themselves and intentionally drive the conversation to find similar experiences between themselves and their mentees, particularly about workplace challenges and struggles. When leaders oversee mentoring programs, it is worth the time and effort to make space for mutual self-disclosure and relationship-building among mentors and mentees before pairing so that mentees can be paired with mentors they identify with.

Socializing Mentees through Role Development Processes

From a leadership communication lens, traditional dyadic mentoring can also be a critical venue for socializing new members to become part of the workgroup/organization. Socialization models suggest that organizational members generally go through multiple phases of socialization, including anticipatory, encounter, metamorphosis, and exit stages, as they complete a cycle of their organizational life (Jablin, 2001). In this process, organizational members work with their leaders to engage in role development processes to learn "the ropes", acquire the necessary skills and knowledge to perform their roles, and/or negotiate their roles in the organization (Jablin, 2001). As they navigate various role development stages, members can benefit from mentoring as a form of leadership communication. For example, in the encounter stage of socialization when members have just joined the organization, leaders can engage in mentoring communications to assign and introduce their job responsibilities, onboard the new members to the daily operations, and provide guidance and feedback to help them do their jobs. In the metamorphosis stage, when new members start to feel integrated into the organization, leaders can continue to engage in mentoring communication with the members to help them negotiate their roles, take on other responsibilities, and navigate social relations. From a socialization standpoint, a

leader's mentoring communication can enhance mentees' self-efficacy, which is linked to their readiness to step into leadership roles, adaptability to organizational changes, and willingness to generate and voice new ideas (Varghese & Finkelstein, 2021).

Navigating Negative Mentoring Experiences

Not all mentoring relationships are high-quality relationships. Some mentoring relationships can even do more harm than benefit. Negative mentoring experiences can result in higher stress, lower job satisfaction, and stronger turnover intentions for mentees (Eby & Allen, 2002). Eby et al (2000) reported that mentees experienced a wide range of negative experiences with some mentors, including: (a) *mismatch* within the dyad, which reflects that mentors and mentees differ in their values, work styles, and personalities, and tensions that emerge from such differences cannot be successfully negotiated; (b) *distancing behaviors*, which refer to mentors' behaviors that neglect mentees' needs or intentionally exclude mentees from meaningful developmental opportunities and information exchange; (c) *manipulative behaviors* that include situations whereby mentors misuse their power to inappropriately under- or over-delegate work to mentees, or engage in self-interested political behaviors at the expense of the mentees; (d) *lack of mentor expertise*, including both interpersonal and technical expertise to make the mentoring relationship beneficial for the mentees; and (d) *general dysfunctionality*, where mentors display a negative attitude towards their work or the organization, or has personal problems (e.g., addiction) that interfere with the their ability to mentor.

To avoid/minimize these negative experiences, leaders need to practice effective and ethical communication. To begin with, mentoring partners may face communication challenges to generate shared goals and meaningful interactions, relational tensions to deal with interpersonal differences, and/or practical constraints such as not finding the time and energy needed to sustain meaningful mentoring interactions. To deal with these challenges, leaders as mentors need to develop communication skills such as conflict resolution, perspective-taking, active listening, and empathic communication to facilitate meaningful mentoring relationships at work (Ragins et al., 2017; Varghese & Finkelstein, 2021). Additionally, leaders must effectively communicate a code of ethics to guide mentoring relationships (Johnson, 2017). It is a common myth to assume that good intentions can guarantee high-quality mentoring relationships. In reality, mentoring relationships with high power differences and loose ethical guidelines can often become a site for workplace bullying/incivility/harassment (Lutgen-Sandvik & Sypher, 2009). Build-in education and reflection on issues related to ethics and equity, frequent

check-in and feedback exchange, and accountability structures need to be in place to keep mentoring programs on track. At an organizational design level, it is crucial to recognize that mitigating negative mentoring experiences and building high-quality mentoring requires strong organizational support. For example, organizations can devote resources to provide workshops and training on mentoring, collect feedback on mentoring relationships, and conduct program evaluations to track mentoring relationship development and uphold ethical and equitable mentoring guidelines. Organizations should also recognize good mentoring by providing rewards and support for those who have devoted their time and energy to developing and sustaining productive mentoring relationships. Traditional mentoring, supported by strong leadership commitment, can be a crucial process to promote positive employee development and organizational cohesion and effectiveness (Ragins & Kram, 2008).

Alternative Forms of Mentoring

Increasingly, researchers and practitioners have been examining and implementing alternative forms of mentoring to either replace or complement traditional mentoring processes (Long et al., 2014; Mullen & Klimaitis, 2021). Alternative forms of mentoring challenge the dyadic mentoring model based on a senior-junior power dynamic and the assumption that the mentees tend to benefit more from the relationship. Instead, alternative mentoring highlights mentoring relationships with more democratic and distributed power structures, reciprocal collaborative exchanges, and growing attention to organizational issues related to diversity, equity, inclusivity, and social justice (DEIJ). Five types of alternative mentoring are highlighted below: reverse mentoring, collaborative mentoring, mentoring network, episodic mentoring, and advocate mentoring.

Reverse Mentoring

Reverse mentoring "involves the pairing of a younger, junior employee acting as mentor to share expertise with an older, senior colleague as mentee" (Murphy, 2012, p. 549). Flipping the mentor-mentee role in a traditional mentoring relationship, reverse mentoring emerges as an alternative form of mentoring responding to the changing demographic of the workforce and the drastic development of technology and knowledge. According to Murphy (2012), reverse mentoring is characterized by several features: (a) unequal status with the mentee often as the senior member in the hierarchy of the organization; (b) knowledge sharing with a focus on developing generational

perspectives; (c) career development with an emphasis on the professionalization and leadership development of the mentor; and finally (d) a commitment to mutual support. Reverse mentoring serves as a social exchange tool that leverages the expertise of generations, such as boomers and millennials, by engaging in mutual learning (Chaudhuri & Ghosh, 2012). The senior members (as the mentees) can learn from the junior members regarding the updated subject or technological expertise and unique generational perspectives on organizational issues. Junior members (as the mentors) can gain useful insights into the organization by tapping into the institutional memory and past experiences of the senior members. Additionally, junior members who serve as mentors can benefit from one-on-one interactions with senior members who usually hold leadership positions and have strategic perspectives on the organization's current state and future development. In this way, reverse mentoring allows younger generational workers to develop their leadership skills and foster their engagement with the organization. Reverse mentoring can also function as a strategic talent-retaining tool for the younger generational workers as it offers an avenue for them to have an immediate impact and develop strong work relationships with organizational leaders (Hewlett et al., 2009).

Collaborative Mentoring

Collaborative mentoring, sometimes called co-mentoring circles or peer mentoring groups, often involves three or more partners in a mentoring relationship that uphold values of reciprocity, ethics of care, equity, and collaboration. Collaborative mentoring differs from traditional mentoring in several important ways (Mullen & Klimaitis, 2021). First, collaborative mentoring challenges the inherent hierarchical relationship in traditional mentoring by championing power sharing and reciprocity. Individuals involved in such mentoring relationships are considered as co-/peer-mentors to one another. Mentoring partners collaboratively set shared agendas and goals, tap into the shared expertise, knowledge, access, and life experiences of one another, engage in mutual support, and work as companions to achieve common goals. Furthermore, collaborative mentoring challenges the boundary between personal and professional. Traditional mentoring often occurs at work with a focus on productivity and advancement. Collaborative mentoring embraces a whole person's perspective and recognizes that societal lives and positions influence organizational experiences (Rawlinson & Willimott, 2016). Collaborative mentoring, drawing from feminist values of care and justice, has increasingly been used as a mentoring model to support the growth and solidarity of marginalized organizational members in the workplace. For

example, Corple et al. (2023) reflected on their experiences of collaborative mentoring around feminist teaching practices. In their collaborative mentoring model, six individuals formed a "Feminist Pedagogy Collective" to work on their teaching. As they dealt with the uncertainties of COVID-19, they provided support for each other beyond work lives by creating space to discuss self-care strategies and grapple with life circumstances (e.g., mental and physical health, parenting, relationships). Furthermore, the mentoring partners of the collective engaged in co-mentoring to strategize ways to (re)consider how their teaching can become more equitable and inclusive while acknowledging the practical constraints of their respective organizations and their job duties.

Mentoring Networks

Mentoring networks, sometimes referred to as developmental networks, can be defined as "the set of people taking an active interest in a protégé as well as an action aiming at advancing the protégé's career by providing career-related and psychosocial functions" (Kim & Kim, 2007, p. 45). The mentoring network perspective emerges from the limitations of conceptualizing mentoring as solely a single dyadic relationship. Traditional research on mentoring tends to privilege the first-named mentor and the influence of such relationship in empirical data collection, rather than capturing how mentoring is co-enacted in multiple mentoring relationships occurring simultaneously, with support provided by a wide range of social systems (family, friends, nonwork organizations) (Higgins & Kram, 2001). Two network qualities are particularly important to consider when understanding mentoring networks: the diversity of individuals' developmental networks and the strength of the developmental relationships that make up these networks (Dobrow et al., 2012). *Diversity* of networks refers to the number of different social systems from which the ties originate (e.g., employer, professional association, community, friends, etc.). Network diversity determines the extent to which the information provided by one's network is similar or redundant. The more diverse the network is, the larger the access to valuable resources and information the person receives. In addition to diversity, the *strength* of networked relationships also matters in a mentoring network. Strong ties, characterized by closeness and strong interpersonal bounds, can promote reciprocity, mutuality, and interdependence for the network to sustain. Weak ties, such as casual contacts, can provide useful information and inspiration. Long and colleagues (2014, 2018) further argued that researchers and leaders should take nonhuman mentoring sources (such as books, online workshops, podcasts, training sessions, etc.) into consideration when

conceptualizing the ties that can make up developmental networks and recognize that mentoring networks need to evolve with one's changing mentoring needs, career stages, and life goals. Offering mentees a constellation of mentors from different work-life domains, mentoring networks can uniquely contribute to fostering nonhierarchical, cross-cultural, interdisciplinary partnerships and facilitating the growth and well-being of the mentees (Dobrow et al., 2012).

Episodic Mentoring

Unlike mentoring models that focus on recognized long-term relations, an episodic perspective views mentoring as developmental interactions that occur at a specific time and may not consistently be recognized as mentoring. In these mentoring moments, two parties exchange knowledge, build relationships, and enact social support (Fletcher & Ragins, 2007; Parse, 2002). These communication moments are highly spontaneous; they live in specific instances, occur at freely chosen times, and are agreed on explicitly or tacitly as mentoring by mentors and mentees (Parse, 2002). While the cumulative experience of mentoring episodes may yield a mentoring relationship, individuals can engage in mentoring moments without being in a relationship per se. While traditional mentoring models emphasize a mentor providing support to the mentee, episodic mentoring emphasizes mutual learning and influence whereby both parties serve as providers of information, support, and advocacy (Fletcher & Ragins, 2007). This "just-in-time" advice and psychological support from fellow organizational members can help to generate useful workplace strategies to navigate work/life negotiation issues, and manage workplace politics. Experiencing and recognizing these mentoring moments can be vital to mentees' feelings of inclusion into the organization (Long et al., 2014). Compared to research on other alternative mentoring forms, such as reverse mentoring, collaborative group mentoring, and developmental networks, research on episodic mentoring remains scarce. One challenge is that capturing these moments using empirical research methods is hard. Episodes, such as a conversation about how to deal with family-work conflict during social hours with colleagues, may not be recognized as mentoring. Furthermore, the causes and effects of episodic mentoring can be difficult to capture, measure, or quantify.

Advocate Mentoring

Sharing overlapping boundaries with the above mentoring forms, advocate mentoring differs from other forms of mentoring for its explicit critical edge. Advocate mentoring centers a social justice mission by supporting, sponsoring, and advocating for

organizational members who may encounter workplace challenges due to their differences (e.g., gender, race/ethnicity, sexual orientation, immigration status, cultural heritage, body, ability, religion, etc.). In advocate mentoring, a mentor assumes the role of an advocate, someone who speaks in support or defense of the mentee. Advocate mentors usually have social privilege in the organization (e.g., belong to the dominant/majority group and hold leadership positions). They must express a deep commitment to seeking social justice on behalf of the mentee, be willing to make mistakes, and understand the importance of emotional safety in their role as allies, advocates, and change agents (Harris & Lee, 2019).

The goals for advocate mentoring are two-fold. First, mentors as advocates must support mentees, who often occupy marginalized identities, to navigate and thrive in the organization. For example, mentors may support the mentees by buffering the negative effects of (ambient) discrimination at work and offering mentees a safe space to share their experiences and empathic acknowledgment of their feelings (Ragins et al., 2017). In addition, the mentors work as sponsors and allies for the mentees with the goals of fighting systemic racism, sexism, and other forms of oppression. Specifically, advocate mentors need to be educated about mentees' marginalized identities and experiences, acknowledge how they have benefited from systemic oppression, challenge their own discomfort and preconceived notions, and practice the communication skills of being an advocate (Harris & Lee, 2019).

Leadership Communication in Alternative Mentoring

In alternative mentoring processes, two additional leadership communication dynamics become highly relevant: generating meaningful mentoring conversations and developing care and justice-centered leadership.

Generating Meaningful Mentoring Conversations

Mindful and meaningful communication exchanges among mentoring partners are even more critical for alternative mentoring models as they emphasize reciprocity of exchange, shared values and goals, holistic understanding of one's mentoring needs, and high-quality connection. Research has studied ways that mentoring conversations can be productive and transformative. Unlike conversations that lack focus, *productive mentoring conversations* are purposeful and aim to address the mentee's needs. These interactions are thought-provoking as they entail deep reflection and collective action planning to develop a forward-looking perspective to support the growth of the

mentoring partners (Mullen & Klimaitis, 2021). Leaders in alternative mentoring arrangements are also encouraged to generate *transformative dialogues*, defined as interactions that promote critical reflections to challenge systematic workplace inequities and productive efforts to transform the organization (Deetz & Simpson, 2004). According to Deetz and Simpson (2004), transformative dialogues "become possible when interlocutors find their common-sense beliefs challenged as they encounter differences in interaction with an Other" (p. 154). For example, leaders can adopt an advocate mentor mentality and engage in reverse mentoring with junior colleges from under-represented groups to learn from their organizational experiences, including their struggles, challenges, and confusions. As they continue to develop their relationship, the mentoring partners can practice reflexivity, which refers to an ongoing process of recognizing and analyzing one's positionalities and how identity and power imbalances are implicated in how organizations develop workplace norms, set up processes, and distribute organizational resources (Linabary et al., 2021). Trust and reflexivity can then support the mentoring partners to collaboratively engage in transformative dialogues to challenge otherwise unquestioned assumptions and open the possibility of generative, productive, and sustainable change to make the workplace more inclusive and just (Larson et al., 2022).

Developing Care and Justice-Centered Leadership

Mentoring communication in alternative mentoring forms, particularly the ones that support transformative organizational changes, overlaps with leadership communication that centers on the ethics of care and justice. Buzzanell et al. (1997) argued that care-oriented leadership acts uphold the goals and interests of the community by collapsing hierarchies between leaders and followers and "[placing leaders]at the heart of activity rather than at the top" (p. 289). Similarly, Parker (2020) proposed the notion of catalytic leadership, which consists of "communication practices for doing social justice leadership in equitable partner with, instead of on, communities" (p. 13). Doing such care and justice-centered leadership involves mentoring communication in the forms of listening sessions to learn about partners' needs, aspirations, and experiences, assembling a network of resources and support, working together to learn from one another and develop shared goals, and elevating the voices of the other to advocate for resources. Leadership communication that values care and justice requires the leader to become mentoring partners in collaborative networks to advocate for change.

Summary

In short, the above sections have discussed traditional and alternative forms of mentoring – reverse, collaborative, network, episodic, and advocate mentoring. Although presented separately, these mentoring forms are not mutually exclusive. For example, alternative mentoring models such as advocate and reverse mentoring are built on traditional dyadic models but with different goals. One can also have multiple forms of mentoring present simultaneously: a formal mentoring relationship with a senior member, informal reverse mentoring relationships with a couple of new employees, and episodic mentoring with colleagues who are considered peers or collaborators. Together, these forms of mentoring constitute a vibrant mentoring network. Furthermore, alternative mentoring forms often share overlapping boundaries. For example, collaborative and advocate mentoring can all work towards goals to create a more inclusive and positive organizational environment. Episodic mentoring moments are building blocks for almost all forms of mentoring and key processes to support an organizational culture that values mentoring. In practice, leaders are encouraged to utilize different forms of mentoring to support dynamic and holistic mentoring experiences.

Future Directions for Mentoring and Leadership Research and Practice

The remainder of the chapter discusses a list of challenges and opportunities to study and design robust, meaningful, and inclusionary workplace mentoring processes. This list serves as a research agenda for scholars interested in mentoring and provides practical questions and strategies for leaders.

Mentoring and Workplace Technology

With the development of technology and the changing nature of work, the workforce today has been increasingly distributed. Virtual meetings, workplace social media, Artificial Intelligence (AI), and online collaboration tools have been part of everyday work for many organizations worldwide. While e-mentoring has been studied and often positioned as a default chapter in handbooks on mentoring (Clutterbuck et al., 2017; Ragins & Kram, 2008), we need more up-to-date empirical research that examines the intersections of workplace mentoring and information communication technology. Researchers can ask questions such as: How does mentoring (episode, networked, informal) occur during virtual meetings, online collaborations, and/or corporate social media? How do these mediated forms of mentoring work together with formal face-to-face mentoring programs? What are various affordances of workplace communication

technology that can support traditional and new forms of mentoring? It can also be interesting to consider AI's role as a nonhuman source of mentoring in socializing employees into the organization and their work roles. Furthermore, leaders can consider strategies to enact mentoring in the virtual workplace by addressing the following questions: What are the needs for mentoring, and what are the best ways to deliver mentoring to organizational members with various appointment types, schedules, commitments, and motivations online? It can be even more important for leaders of remote workforces to think about using mentoring communication to build trust, establish effective communication norms, and develop a sense of belonging and team cohesion.

Mentoring during Crisis and Disruption

Mentoring during crisis and disruption is a common leadership challenge yet receives very little empirical research. A crisis can be defined as an unanticipated event that puts stakeholders' expectations at risk and has the potential to negatively affect an organization's performance and generate other adverse outcomes (Coombs, 2021). Organizations in today's turbulent and competitive environments increasingly accept that changes, disruptions, and even crises are the new normals for organizing. How do leaders in crisis moments engage in mentoring to help followers navigate unanticipated, hostile, and emotionally draining circumstances? How do leaders themselves tap into various sources of mentoring to navigate crises? How do leaders use existing mentoring networks to facilitate collective sensemaking of the issues and actively learn from failures to implement constructive changes? In the context of mentoring during disruption and crisis, another highly relevant concept is resilience, defined as "the processes by which individuals and organizations reintegrate and foster productive change during and after career setbacks, material and personnel losses, disasters, or other obstacles" (Buzzanell, 2018, p. 14). Leaders can consider ways to employ mentoring practices to cultivate employee and organizational resilience by maintaining constant communication, practicing empathy, and actively seeking support for employees to navigate hardships. Furthermore, leaders can envision mentoring at micro, meso, and macro levels as part of the resilience-cultivating organizational processes. In this way, leaders can proactively prepare organizations for changes and disruptions by designing agile mentoring structures that build trust, common language, and ways of learning.

Mentoring, Intersectional Power, and Organizational Inclusivity

Like any other organizational process, mentoring is also deeply enmeshed in the power dynamics of the organization and the larger society (Ragins & Kram, 2008). Extant mentoring literature has examined how identity anchors such as gender and race shape mentoring needs and satisfaction (for a review, see Long et al., 2014). For example, Buzzanell et al. (2015), in their study of women engineering faculty's mentoring, argued that dominant workplace mentoring discourses often foreground a grand mentoring narrative suggesting that mentoring is a productive relationship, critical to career and life success and that mentoring processes and practices are standardized and universal. They argued that such a grand narrative ignores that individuals' intersectional identities, differential experiences, backgrounds, and needs require different mentoring forms, relationships, and content focus. As a result, workplace mentoring following the grand narrative often privileges the dominant identity group in the workforce (e.g., in the U.S., white heterosexual, middle-class, white-collar male workers often constitute the dominant group) and marginalizes the underrepresented minority. Future research can continue to examine how dominant and nondominant groups in organizations may experience mentoring differently and how leadership communication can address the inequities in workplace mentoring.

As leaders think about power relations in mentoring, an intersectionality lens can be helpful. Intersectionality, as a theoretical term, was coined and developed by American critical race scholar Kimberle Crenshaw to explain how racial and gender discrimination is compounded in Black women (Crenshaw, 1991). As a significant theory that has shaped feminist thought, intersectionality can be defined as the "interaction between gender, race, and other categories of difference in individual lives, social practices, institutional arrangements, and cultural ideologies and outcomes of these interactions in terms of power" (Davis, 2008, p. 68). From this perspective, mentoring can be analyzed as "a contested site for the reproduction of both marginalization and privilege, which offers opportunities to increase individuals' feelings of growth, inclusiveness, and well-being and to promote institutional change toward more inclusionary spaces" (Long et al., 2014, p. 401). In addition to gender and race dimensions, more research needs to consider how age, class, sexuality, body type, ability, and other identity anchors can work together in shaping one's mentoring experiences in various organizational contexts. With attention to intersectional power relations, leaders can design and cultivate mentoring structures (reverse, advocate, and episodic mentoring) that explicitly position mentoring as a catalyst for making our workplace more humane, just, and inclusive (Larson et al., 2022).

Mentoring beyond U.S.-European Workplaces

Finally, it is important to note that mentoring research is predominantly conducted in U.S.-European contexts. Mentoring beyond U.S.-European contexts is often treated as international case studies focusing on the application rather than the development of mentoring theories (e.g., Clutterbuck et al., 2017). The current chapter also primarily draws from published scholarship in the English language and major U.S. and European journals and edited books. Acknowledging this limitation, the chapter calls for more theorizing work of mentoring beyond Western, developed, English-speaking work contexts. Researchers and practitioners can consider questions such as: How has mentoring been conceptualized, reflected on, and/or engaged beyond U.S.-Euro-centered workplaces? How is mentoring conceptualized and enacted in relation to leadership communication in these contexts?

It is with these questions that the chapter draws to an end. Positioning workplace mentoring as an important aspect of leadership communication, this chapter reviews contemporary research on conceptualizing, designing, and sustaining productive mentoring processes in workplace settings. The chapter calls for more theorizing and practical engagement to connect leadership communication and mentoring to realize mentoring's productive and transformative potential.

Note

1. The chapter does not aim to capture all leadership communication that facilitates the enactment of mentoring relationships but to highlight a few important considerations. It is also beyond the purview of this chapter on mentoring to discuss leadership dynamics in depths. Please refers to other chapters of the handbook to learn more about specific aspects of leadership communication.⏎

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13

LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION IN WORK TEAMS

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-16

Teams are important for accomplishing complex tasks and dealing with organizational complexity (for an overview, see Meyer & Lehmann-Willenbrock, 2022). They are also the connecting element between individuals and organizations as a whole (e.g., Kozlowski & Bell, 2013). Therefore, teams are an essential social context for understanding leader-follower dynamics at work, and for studying leadership communication. Indeed, because teams are the building blocks of contemporary organizations (e.g., Mathieu et al., 2019), leadership communication is increasingly situated in team settings. Hence, several scholars have called for a stronger team focus in leadership research to account for the importance of the team context for understanding how leadership influence unfolds at work (e.g., Kozlowski et al., 2016). For a long time, the management and organizational psychology literature on leadership had been characterized by a leader-centric perspective (Lord et al., 2017). Only more recently, the field has begun to acknowledge the important role of followers in the leadership process (e.g., Bastardoz & Van Vugt, 2019; Malakyan, 2014; Oc & Bashshur, 2013; Uhl-Bien et al., 2014).

The extant research on communicative leader-follower dynamics has provided important contributions and insights into what constitutes effective leadership (for an overview, see Hemshorn de Sanchez et al., 2022). However, this prior work has typically adopted a dyadic perspective of leadership and followership (e.g., Meinecke et al., 2017). Such a dyadic focus can only provide limited insights to the role of

leadership in teams and the way in which leadership influence unfolds during team communication. Dyads are not groups (Moreland, 2010), and the communication patterns that emerge in a group or team setting are going to be different from those that arise in a dyadic leader-follower setting. This means that we cannot simply transfer insights regarding dyadic leader-follower communication to the team context.

Compared to dyadic leader-follower interaction settings, team contexts give rise to more complex dynamics unfolding as individual team members interact with one another and their leaders over time (Cronin et al., 2011; Waller et al., 2016). We survey a growing research base that acknowledges this, highlighting two broader research streams that have investigated leadership communication in the context of work teams: (1) formal leadership influence (e.g., using various leadership styles) within team interactions on the one hand; and (2) the communicative dynamics of informal leadership in work groups and teams on the other hand.

Defining Leadership Influence in Teams

We follow DeRue's (2011, p. 126) definition of leadership as:

> a social interaction process where individuals engage in repeated leading-following interactions, and through these interactions, co-construct identities and relationships as leaders and followers. These leader-follower identities and relationships are influenced but not entirely constrained by formal authority structures, such that the direction of influence in leading-following interactions can move up, down, and/or lateral in formal organizational structures.

It follows from this definition that leadership is deeply rooted in the social context and collectively constructed social interactions. Thereby, we acknowledge the collective nature of leadership (Denis et al., 2012). Because teams are such a prevalent organizing principle in contemporary organizations, we are focusing on leader-follower dynamics in the context of groups and teams in particular. In teams, leadership can take place either formally (i.e., social influence is exerted on team members by an appointed team leader) or informally (i.e., one or more team members exert influence over the other team members as a result of the team interaction process; for a detailed discussion of leadership as an influencing process, see also Hemshorn de Sanchez et al., 2022).

Both formal and informal types of leadership, and the corresponding routes of social influence, are not possible without communication. Per definition, leadership is a

process, meaning that it is dynamic subject to temporal changes. These dynamics are inherently tied to communication in teams, including specific leader-follower dyadic exchanges as well as follower-follower exchanges related to formal leadership. Moreover, the co-construction of leadership by those who are leading and those who are following (e.g., DeRue & Ashford, 2010) calls for considerations of the communicative dynamics inside the team that are at the core of team leadership and followership.

Formal Leadership Communication in Teams

Many leadership theories contain communicative elements, which can be more or less explicit in their definition of leadership and may or may not coincide with empirical approaches to actually capture these communicative elements. To illustrate this point, we selected three theories of formal leadership that are relevant for the team context, namely transformational or charismatic leadership theory, relational leadership theories (e.g., LMX theory), and functional leadership theory. For each of these, we highlight empirical findings regarding these communicative elements. Note that this list is not exhaustive, and we hope additional leadership research will follow that considers the team context more consistently (see also Kozlowski et al., 2016, for a detailed discussion of need).

Transformational or Charismatic Leadership Theory

Transformational leadership is a vastly popular construct in the leadership literature (for a review, see Antonakis, 2018). In their foundational work, Bass and colleagues (e.g., Bass, 1999; Bass & Riggio, 2006) differentiated *transformational leaders* who offer individualized consideration of every follower's needs, exhibit idealized influence (e.g., by providing a vision), deliver inspirational motivation (e.g., by communicating high expectations), and provide intellectual stimulation (e.g., by challenging employees) from *transactional leaders* who focus on getting tasks done and give rewards in exchange for followers' efforts. All of the defining characteristics of transformational leadership point to communicative elements of this leadership style: However, the behavioral manifestations of this style in terms of observable communication are underresearched. Particularly in the team context, only a few empirical studies have examined how transformational leadership contributes to successful communication processes and outcomes.

Hoogeboom and Wilderom (2015) conducted two empirical studies using analyses of videotaped team meetings and found that followers' perceptions of transformational leadership resulted when leaders' communication in the meeting was characterized by showing individual consideration as well as task delegation behavior. Another study of periodic team meetings by the same authors found that leaders were seen as more effective in their teams when they showed a combination of behaviors that initiate structure (e.g., directing, informing, or structuring the discussion) along with transformational leadership behaviors (e.g., inspirational motivation or individual consideration; Hoogeboom & Wilderom, 2019).

Looking at the behavioral consequences of communicating a transformational leadership style within the team interaction process, another field study of team meetings found that transformational meeting leaders can encourage problem-solving behavior by their team members, through modeling solution-focused behavior themselves. At the communicative event level, this study further found that meeting leaders' solution-oriented behaviors triggered ideas and solutions by team members and inhibited counterproductive statements such as criticizing others, complaining, or running off topic (Lehmann-Willenbrock et al., 2015). A further study focused on virtual innovation groups and found that language cues expressing transformational leadership were positively linked to idea generation in these groups (Becker et al., 2022). This finding shows that transformational leadership expressions also work successfully in online interaction scenarios and again underscores the role of language for successful leadership influence in teams.

Following conceptual criticisms of the transformational leadership construct as tautological and lacking behavioral specification (e.g., van Knippenberg & Stikin, 2013), the literature on charismatic rather than transformational leadership approaches has grown. Charismatic leadership can be defined as values-based, symbolic, and emotion-laden leader signaling (Antonakis et al., 2016). Such signals are clearly tied to how a formal leader communicates, and empirical studies of charismatic leadership often focus on speeches or written communication (e.g., Antonakis et al., 2022; Seyranian & Bligh, 2008). This approach is understandable given the ease of access to speeches and similar data, relative to analyzing the behavioral dynamics that constitute actual leader-follower interactions in dyads or teams. For example, earlier qualitative work by Murphy and Ensher (2008), who analyzed communication styles of television directors, shows that charismatic leaders communicated vision to their teams as well as expressed sensitivity to their team members' needs. However, focusing on individual

speeches of charismatic leaders does not yield insights into the actual communicative leader-follower dynamics at the dyadic or team level.

Relational Leadership Theories

Social relationships are pertinent to team functioning, and relational communication serves important group functions (e.g., Keyton & Beck, 2009). As such, relational leadership theories seem particularly relevant for understanding how leadership is communicated in work teams. In general, relational leadership theories are concerned with explaining how leaders develop relationships with different followers, assuming that leaders will build closer connections with some followers and treat them more favorably than others (Graen & Uhl-Bien, 1995).

Leader-member exchange (LMX) theory is a prominent example within the group of relational theories of leadership. According to LMX theory, effective leaders are those who have high-quality relationships with their followers (e.g., Graen & Uhl-Bien, 1995). A high quality relationship between a team leader and their team members heavily relies on leader-follower communication (for an overview and detailed theoretical discussion, see Fairhurst & Connaughton, 2014). The ways in which leader-follower communication shapes LMX is highly impactful for a range of follower outcomes. For example, Gajendran and Joshi (2012) found that LMX promoted team members' influence on team decisions when accompanied by frequent leader-member communication. Mayfield and Mayfield (2009) identified LMX as the mediating mechanism that explains how leader communication is linked to employees' job satisfaction and performance.

It follows from relational leadership theory that not all LMX relationships inside a team will be equal. Formal team leaders will form more favorable relationships with some followers than with others (e.g., because of sympathy or liking), which leads to so-called LMX differentiation (e.g., Henderson et al., 2009). This has manifold implications for individual team members (e.g., Emery et al., 2019), but also for leaders. For example, Eichenseer et al. (2020) found that higher LMX differentiation within a team was linked to lower satisfaction with the leader, lower leader effectiveness from the team's perspective, and lower communication quality of the leader. Moreover, LMX differentiation also has team-level consequences (for an overview of group outcomes and more detailed discussion of the LMX differentiation construct and operationalization, see Buengeler et al., 2021). For example, a study of team meetings found that LMX differentiation affected team members' proactive

behavior in the meeting, such that members belonging to the in-group showed more proactive behavior when LMX differentiation was higher (Estel et al., 2019). Furthermore, survey-based research has shown that the degree to which LMX differs within a team leads to differences in team members' perceptions of their team climate (Ford & Seers, 2006).

Functional Leadership Theory

Functional leadership theory offers insights about leadership and team communication because it identifies specific behaviors that establish leadership. According to functional leadership theory, these behaviors need to address prevailing team needs, which are determined by the respective temporal team context (McGrath, 1962; Zaccaro, Rittman, & Marks, 2001). Depending on the team's developmental phase and associated needs, team leaders should focus either on: (1) task-related communicative behaviors such as problem solving, clarifying others' contributions, providing goal orientation, or time management; (2) relational communicative behaviors such as expressing support or including others; and (3) change-oriented behaviors such as communicating a vision (e.g., Gerpott et al., 2019; Yukl et al., 2002).

Several papers have theorized about functional leadership communication in various team contexts (e.g., Homan et al., 2020), and meta-analytic findings show that both task and person-focused leader behaviors are positively linked to team outcomes – with a particularly strong effect of empowerment by the formal leader on team learning (Burke et al., 2006). However, empirical work in this area that actually examines these communicative dynamics remains sparse. A few studies have investigated functional leadership communication in the context of informal, but not formal team leadership (as discussed next). Indeed, as the preceding leadership theories have focused on formal team leadership, the leadership functions described in functional leadership theory can be fulfilled either by formally appointed leaders or by informal leaders (Morgeson et al., 2010), as in the case of emergent leadership in team interactions. Next, we consider communication behaviors and dynamics in the context of informal team leadership.

Informal Leadership in Teams

Teams benefit from informal team leadership in terms of their performance, cohesion, and social support (Badura et al., 2022; Zhu et al., 2018). Rather than stemming from formalized roles, informal leadership develops over time as team members interact

with each other collaborating towards a common goal or task (Cox et al., 2022; Zhu et al., 2018). Accordingly, informal leadership represents an emergent phenomenon (e.g., Acton et al., 2019; Cox et al., 2022; Day et al., 2004; Zhu et al., 2018). There are two important literature streams of informal leadership: Emergent leadership and shared leadership. Emergent leadership often focuses on individuals who emerge as leaders in groups and what predicts this outcome (Badura et al., 2022; Hanna et al., 2020). Shared leadership typically investigates how leadership is shared amongst team members and in what ways that affects outcomes (e.g., Klasmeier & Lehmann-Willenbrock, 2023; Zhu et al., 2018). Of note, both emergent leadership and shared leadership have been criticized as phenomena concerning a lack of conceptual clarity (Hanna et al., 2020; Zhu et al., 2018). What both concepts have in common is that they are generally conceptualized as emergent phenomena that evolve as team members engage with each other (Cox et al., 2022; Pearce & Conger, 2003). Thus, we refer more generally to informal leadership as an overarching term in this chapter.

Emergence involves a process in which "lower-level interactions result in effects and properties at higher levels" that evolve over time (Vullinghs & Dóci, 2020, p. 267). Thus, emergent phenomena require insights into the smallest units of interaction and their temporal dynamics. An emergence perspective on informal leadership resonates well with constructionist approaches to leadership (Vullinghs & Dóci, 2020). Such approaches postulate that leadership is constructed through interaction or discourse, whereby individuals co-create leader- (and follower-)ship roles and identities (Baxter, 2015; Fairhurst, 2008; DeRue, 2011; DeRue & Ashford, 2010; Vullinghs & Dóci, 2020). Applying these perspectives to informal leadership brings communication between team members to center stage (DeRue & Ashford, 2010; Fairhurst, 2008; Fairhurst & Uhl-Bien, 2012).

Informal Leadership and Verbal Communication

Verbal acts represent the most often researched behavioral antecedents of informal team leadership (Hemshorn de Sanchez et al., 2022). Most of this work takes a transmissional approach to communication. Here, communication is conceptualized as a vehicle and is considered as a process variable or outcome of other predictors (Fairhurst & Connaughton, 2014). Broadly, this literature can be clustered into two streams focusing on different communicative aspects. The first focuses on conversational features such as speech duration, frequencies, and speaker turns. The

second focuses on the content of the messages. In the following, we will provide a brief overview of this research.

The Role of Turn-Taking and Conversation Shares

The correlation between team members' speech duration and their ascribed levels of informal leadership is well-established (Badura et al., 2018; MacLaren et al., 2020; Mullen et al., 1989; Schmid-Mast, 2002)[1]. In a meta-analysis investigating the effect of gender, agentic (e.g., assertive, dominant, competent) and communal traits (e.g., warm, caring, nurturing), and participation on leadership emergence, Badura et al. (2018) found a mediation effect of participation for gender and communal/agentic traits on leadership emergence. The idea behind this "babble hypothesis" is that quantity of contributions rather than the quality of their content predicts leadership emergence (Bass, 1990, p. 93). Explanations of this effect include that longer talking time may signal expertise (Bottger, 1984; Gintner & Lindskold, 1975) as well as motivation and engagement (Sorrentino & Boutillier,1975), and increases individuals' salience which may benefit how importantly they are evaluated (Mullen et al., 1989).

In this literature, many studies investigate whether quantity or quality of communicative acts are a stronger predictor (MacLaren et al., 2020). The results of this work are mixed, some provide support for the babble hypothesis, while others do not (Jaffee & Lucas, 1969; Morris & Hackman, 1969). MacLaren et al. (2020) argued that limited ecological validity in many of the experimental designs, or not accounting for important control variables in more ecologically valid designs, pose a challenge for a definite conclusion. In their own study, they addressed some of these shortcomings and investigated interactions of 33 student teams in the planning phase prior to a simulation task. Analyzing speech duration and a series of control variables previously not included in one design, they found that speaking time predicted leader emergence. Unfortunately, speech content (i.e., quality) was not controlled for.

Using social network analysis, a few studies have analyzed speaker turns in team interactions to investigate informal leadership (e.g., Xie et al., 2018; Zhu et al., 2011). Network metrics such as centrality and density, can be extracted to provide information about leadership in teams (Zhu et al., 2018). Centrality indicates how central individuals are within the team and may inform how influential individuals are in the team (Zhu et al., 2018). Xie et al. (2018) investigated online posts of virtual student teams and classified them into "leader" and "non-leader" messages. Using this information, they performed a social network analysis and found that some students,

who were formally appointed as moderators as well as regular students, were particularly "central" (i.e., influential) to the network.

From a team-level perspective, network density provides information on how activity, and thereby influence, is distributed across the team (Zhu et al., 2018). Zhu et al. (2011), for example, analyzed messages exchanged between Wikipedia editors. They showed that leadership-related messages (i.e., leader behavior) were displayed by members who were both in central as well as peripheral positions of the social network indicating a high degree of shared leadership in that team. Yet, research employing behavioral information to study informal team leadership with a social network approach is limited.

The Role of the Communicative Content

Research investigating the content of communicative acts in informal team leadership has been largely conducted in the laboratory investigating verbal team interactions and to some extent as well as in virtual teams investigating their written communication (i.e., chats) (Hemshorn de Sanchez et al., 2022). Much of the early work relied on Bales' (1950) interaction process analysis scheme (Hemshorn de Sanchez et al., 2022). This early work as well as more recent research using other coding schemes provide solid evidence for the important role of task-oriented behaviors for predicting leadership emergence (e.g., Gerpott et al., 2019; Hawkins, 1995; Lee & Farh, 2019; Schlamp et al., 2020; Yoo & Alavi, 2004). The evidence for the role of relations-oriented behaviors is somewhat more mixed. Some studies find a positive effect (e.g., Lee & Farh, 2019), while others find no effect (e.g., Hawkins, 1995; Schlamp et al., 2020). One potential explanation is provided by Mitchell et al. (2019) who identified a linear relationship between task-oriented behavior and leadership emergence, while the relationship between relations-oriented behaviors and leadership emergence was curvilinear – both too few and too many of these behaviors predicted lower leadership levels.

One important caveat to these findings is the role of context. First, the interactive context in which behaviors occur plays a crucial role (DeRue & Ashford, 2010; Marchiondo et la., 2015). For example, *delegating a task* may be one discrete leader behavior. To be effective for the team, however, other team members need to act upon this (and accept and ideally carry out the task). Indeed, Lee and Farh (2019) found that the effect of specific leader behaviors expressed by one individual for predicting their ascribed leadership levels was moderated by the amount other team members displayed the same type of behavior in that phase of the task.

Second, the temporal context of communication is key to understanding emergent phenomena (Fairhurst, 2009). Thus, some behaviors may be relevant at one specific point in time but not at another (Gerpott et al., 2019). Research considering this perspective is rare. Gerpott et al. (2019), for instance, investigated junior consultant teams across a six-week project and video-recorded three meetings during the initial, mid, and end phase of the project. They coded all communicative acts and clustered them into task-, relations-, and change-oriented behaviors. The authors found that task-oriented behavior was a relevant predictor in all phases. Change-oriented behavior, however, only predicted leader emergence during the initial phase, while relations-oriented behavior predicted leader emergence in later phases of the team project.

Lee and Farh (2019) investigated teams across two phases in the lab (i.e., idea generation and idea enactment). They coded the verbal interactions for constructive (i.e., task-oriented) and supportive contributions (i.e., relations-oriented). Results showed that constructive contributions were a stronger leadership predictor during idea generation compared to idea enactment. Supportive contributions resulted as a leadership predictor in both phases. At first sight, these findings seem to contradict the results by Gerpott et al. (2019). However, one important difference between designs is the temporal level of analysis. Gerpott et al. investigated teams over several weeks, while Lee and Farh examined their teams across a few hours. These different time spans of the team's life may affect their needs and thereby require different behaviors across initial, mid, and end phases of the task. This illustrates the importance for considering temporal levels in study design and integrate these considerations in theoretical developments (Hemshorn de Sanchez et al., 2022).

Informal Leadership and Nonverbal Communication

Nonverbal behavior has received rather limited attention in informal leadership research (Hemshorn de Sanchez et al., 2022). This is surprising given the importance of nonverbal signals for leadership and communication more generally (Darioly & Schmid Mast, 2014). Vast amounts of information are encoded in a range of communication modalities that go beyond verbal semantics (e.g., gaze, hand gestures, facial expressions, posture, voice tone and pitch; Vinciarelli et al., 2009). Importantly, communication occurs across these modalities (Vinciarelli et al., 2009). Interestingly, early work on nonverbal communication and leadership ascriptions in leaderless groups, investigated the role of sensory modalities. Stein (1975), for example, presented participants video recordings of interacting teams across four conditions (full

audio-visual information, script of verbal information, visual and paraverbal information via filtered speech, and only visual information). He found that participants consistently identified informal leadership hierarchies in all four conditions, indicating that both verbal and nonverbal cues signal leadership independently of each other and independent of general participation rates.

More recently, computer scientists have started to explore different specific communicative acts in different modalities (i.e., social signals) and their combined (i.e., multimodal) impact on social dynamics, including leadership (Schmid Mast & Hall, 2017). Sanchez-Cortes et al. (2013), for instance, analyzed audiovisual information to investigated patterns of visual attention (via head pose) and speech activity. They identified interaction patterns that predicted emergent leadership and differentiated it from dominance. However, single features (i.e., only speaking activity) were a better predictor than multimodal features. Other social signaling researchers have extracted nonverbal and multimodal features and were able to estimate different emergent leadership styles using this information (Beyan et al., 2018; Capozzi et al., 2019). Promising work has also been conducted using machine learning algorithms that consider the sequential order of nonverbal and multimodal behaviors (Beyan et al., 2019). The authors showed that the time-sensitive algorithm performed better in detecting emergent leaders than conventional methods.

This work provides important insights into nonverbal features that are informative for leadership ascriptions. Yet, more research is required, in particular to develop theories that guide the integration of different modalities and their role in informal leadership. One important limitation of prior work[2] is that it considers behavioral information of one individual to predict that individual's ascribed leadership. Only very few studies have considered leader and follower behavior together. Butler and Geis (1990), for instance, investigated team members' affective responses towards informal leaders. One male and one female confederate were trained to utter specific leader-like behaviors in different constellation (solo leader, co-leader, and non-leaders). Independent coders rated participants' affects in terms of how pleased or unpleased they looked (i.e., facial expression) after confederates' contributions. Although male and female confederates uttered the same words and demonstrated the same nonverbal cues, female confederates received more negative and less positive responses than their male counterparts. These findings indicate that other, more static cues such as gender, may influence the behavioral dynamics that constitute informal leadership.

Implications for Team Leadership in Practice

The research insights discussed above are not only relevant to communication scholarship on team leadership but also to practitioners. First, practitioners may not only be interested in increasing performance and effectiveness more generally, but in fostering specific behaviors within the team interaction (e.g., novel ideas, solution-oriented behavior, etc.). Accordingly, the outcome of interest would not necessarily be at the end point of a linear relationship of variables, but embedded within the process team interaction. From this, a second implication follows, namely that discrete behaviors alone may not be in the focus of employee trainings but rather a more holistic focus on productive team communication. Such interactions could involve being more sensitive to constructive inputs from team members and how to provide resonance within the team, reacting and acting upon this input to maximize team effectiveness.

Given the communicative basis of successful leadership in teams, leadership and team development programs would benefit from a communicative perspective on team leadership. Instead of focusing only on the leader when designing leadership development programs, a team-based approach targeting the communicative skill of both leaders and team members seems more promising in order to optimize collaboration across the entire team. Such an approach acknowledges that communication in team leadership is (at least) a two-way street, meaning that the communication exhibited by a team leader can be just as impactful as the communication from team members to the leader. For example, leadership training could be enhanced by including the team through exercises or reflexive practices together with the team leader (e.g., Hedman, 2016). As another example, team leaders and their teams can collaboratively reflect and improve their communication processes using debriefs (e.g., Tannenbaum & Greilich, 2023), which may also be particularly helpful for self-managed teams who share leadership functions.

Directions for Future Research

Taken together, there is ample research on communicative behavior and both formal and informal leadership in teams. Most of these studies are based on relatively simplistic input-output models where discrete behaviors are hypothesized to predict leadership. These are important starting points to illuminate how team leadership plays out and unfolds in teams. Nonetheless, such a relatively simplistic and static perspective of leadership in teams neglects the contextual and relational character of communicative behaviors. The interactive context in which communicative behaviors occur is important (e.g., Lee & Farh, 2019), other cues that influence how behaviors are

interpreted and acted upon accordingly are vital (e.g., Butler & Geis, 1990), and temporal dynamics are critical for understanding the process of leadership in teams.

Here, we want to focus specifically on the last point – the role of time for team leadership. Previous publications have repeatedly emphasized the importance of embedding time into leadership theory and study designs (e.g., Castillo & Trinh, 2018; McClean et al., 2019; Shamir, 2011; Vullinghs & Dóci, 2020). In this regard, three elements are central to move the field forward. First, including temporal considerations into theorizing and defining time-sensitive research questions could help to derive hypotheses on the expected patterns of leader-follower interaction (e.g., linear, curvilinear, nonlinear). Further, time-sensitive theoretical reasoning would define the temporal scope at which a specific leadership phenomenon unfolds (Hemshorn de Sanchez et al., 2022; Klonek et al., 2019). That is, the time window within a phenomenon and its outcomes (or precursors) are expected to unfold (Hemshorn de Sanchez et al., 2022). Second, following these considerations would guide choosing a data collection method that is aligned with the theory. This comprises informing decisions on the rate of data sampling as well as the level of granularity that data is collected and further processed (Kozlowski et al., 2013). Third, the field would benefit from a more wide-spread knowledge of available time-sensitive methods in order to analyze temporal patterns in the data (for an overview and detailed discussion of methods and analytical approaches, see Lehmann-Willenbrock & Allen, 2018).

Finally, when considering temporal patterns in the context of leadership communication in teams, nonlinear methods seem promising as they provide a range of time-sensitive approaches. Moreover, nonlinear methods offer one promising route to account for the nature of complex temporal systems in leadership contexts (e.g., Guastello et al., 2007; Vullinghs & Dóci, 2020). For a while already, team research has acknowledged that teams are complex systems (e.g., Cronin et al., 2011). Team members and their leaders interact interdependently. Their previous interactions, to some extent, influence future interactions, and – importantly – their interactions give rise to patterns, including team leadership (Waller et al., 2016). Such complex systems of interactions do not necessarily evolve in linear relationships, and we look forward to applications of nonlinear methods in future research on leadership communication in work teams.

Notes

1. Note that the meta-analysis by Schmid Mast (2002) included leadership as one construct under the umbrella term "dominance."
2. One exception is the feature *visual focus of attention*. This feature considers gaze and speech patterns in unison (e.g., who is being looked at while talking).

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14

LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION IN HYBRID AND VIRTUAL CONTEXTS

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-17

Introduction

Leading people over time and space has long been a feature of teams and organizations. Whether done in corporate, military, science, not-for-profit, or other organizing sites, virtual leadership (Schmidt, 2014; also called distanced leadership, see Connaughton & Daly, 2005) has been made possible by various technology enabled communication channels (e.g., phone, email, video conferencing). Although telecommuting (Dahlstrom, 2013) and remote/virtual work (Olson, 1983) were common in some industries and sectors prior to, and in some cases decades before, COVID-19, the global pandemic made remote/virtual work necessary across many industries and sectors. One could say that COVID-19 prompted people and organizations worldwide to reimagine what work – and leadership – could look like, even after COVID-19 was no longer considered a global pandemic. Remote/virtual and hybrid work are today the (new) normal in many industries and sectors.

Although these kinds of work arrangements are increasingly common, leadership in these work arrangements can be challenging. In the late 1990s and early 2000s when a surge in virtual organizing forms took place, virtually leading and managing teams and people was thought to present challenges to leaders in terms of establishing vision, building trust, managing conflict, establishing a sense of connection to the organization,

and yielding productivity (see Duarte & Snyder, 1999; Lipnack & Stamps, 1997). Howell and Hall-Merenda (1999) cautioned that:

> Dramatic changes in organizational structures, size, complexity, and work arrangements imply that leaders are increasingly responsible for managing followers who reside at different locations. Leaders in network organizations, international companies, or domestic companies with far-flung sites are faced with the challenge of motivating and evaluating followers who [sic] they cannot see.
>
> (p. 683)

For these reasons, researchers like Connaughton and Daly (2005) encouraged scholars to study "the nuances and processes of this phenomenon" (p. 188) with an eye toward the ways in which communication constituted distanced leader-follower relationships and organizing.[1] In heeding this call and others, researchers from communication, management, psychology, information sciences, education, and other disciplines contributed insights into understanding this leadership phenomenon. They adopted various meta-theoretical perspectives to do so (see Fairhurst & Connaughton, 2014; Fairhurst et al., 2024; Gibbs & Connaughton, 2024 for details on these perspectives), and they studied virtual leadership at various levels of analysis (e.g., team, organization, inter-organizational levels).

Given that 32.5% of people around the world who work full-time do so either completely remotely or in some sort of hybrid work arrangement (Aksoy et al., 2023), now is the time to revisit and interrogate what is known about leadership in these contexts, and to reimagine what leadership in remote or hybrid work can and should look like. This chapter aims to do just that. Drawing on representative studies from communication and other disciplines, we contend that virtual leadership is a communicative phenomenon and that researchers must continue to investigate virtual leadership from multiple meta-theoretical perspectives, intentionally considering its implications for communication "at work" and organizing. We build our argument by first defining virtual work, hybrid work, and virtual leadership. Next, we present an analytical review of studies on virtual leadership, explicating four themes from these studies. Then, we provide evidence-based practical tips to those engaged in virtual or hybrid work. We conclude this chapter by charting a course for future research on virtual leadership that centers communication.

Defining Virtual Work, Hybrid Work, and Virtual Leadership

As noted above, virtual and hybrid work are relevant and pervasive across teams and organizations, and multiple definitions of each term exist in scholarly literature (ter Hoeven & Gibbs, 2019). *Virtual work* consists of "geographic dispersion and dependence on technology in work-related interactions between employees" (Raghuram et al., 2019, p. 1). Researchers often use the terms *distributed work* (Hinds & Kiesler, 2002; ter Hoeven & Gibbs, 2019), *telework* (e.g., Bailey & Kurland, 2002), and *remote work* (Fonner & Roloff, 2010; Kossek, 2016; Veinott et al., 1999) to refer to similar ways of doing work (see Table 1 in Höddinghaus et al., 2023, for explanations of these terms). This kind of work done over space and time has been examined at various levels of analysis. For instance, telework and remote work are often examined at the individual level (e.g., Fonner & Roloff, 2010; Leonardi et al., 2004; Van Zoonen et al., 2020). At the team level, a preponderance of research exists on (global) virtual teams (e.g., Connaughton & Shuffler, 2007; Gibson & Gibbs, 2006; Gilson et al., 2015; Jassemi, 2023; Martins et al., 2004). Furthermore, at the organizational level distributed collaboration in organizations has been examined (Fulk & Yuan, 2013; Gibbs et al., 2013), as has virtual work in interorganizational alliances and network organizations (e.g., Connaughton et al., 2017; Connaughton & Ptacek, 2020; Cooper & Shumate, 2012).

Although these various terms (virtual, remote, etc.) have been defined differently in the literature (e.g., Chudoba et al., 2005; Gibson & Gibbs, 2006; Kirkman & Mathieu, 2005), scholars generally agree that virtuality is a multidimensional construct. Raghuram and colleagues' (2019) co-citation analysis of studies on virtual work characterizes virtuality along two common dimensions: dispersion and technology dependence. Since the early 2000s, researchers in various disciplines have advanced typologies of virtuality (Bell & Kozlowski, 2002; Chudoba et al., 2005; Kirkman & Mathieu, 2005). These typologies not only help us define virtual work forms, they also help us see the variation across different virtual work forms and the need to research the nuances of these different forms (e.g., degree of virtuality, see Connaughton & Daly, 2005; Gibson & Gibbs, 2006).

One conceptual definition of virtual work embraces this variation. According to Gibson and Gibbs (2006), virtual work (in their article, virtual *teams*) can be thought of in terms of four dimensions: geographic dispersion, electronic dependence, dynamic structural arrangements, and national diversity. In considering these dimensions, the variation among virtual work becomes obvious. Take geographic separation/physical

distance, as an example. Scholars have investigated various degrees of geographic distance (globally dispersed to people working in the same building but communicating through mediated means; see Connaughton & Daly, 2005 and Gibbs & Connaughton, 2024, for discussions of various degrees of virtuality). Moreover, virtual teams vary in terms of how often team members and leaders interact face-to-face (Kirkman et al., 2004), sometimes not interacting face-to-face at all (e.g., short-term virtual project teams). Foregrounding these variations, Dixon and Pantelli (2010) encourage researchers to move beyond dichotomous thinking (i.e., teams are virtual or they are collocated) and instead to think of virtuality as continuities that may complement face-to-face interactions rather than substitute for them.

One work arrangement that has received increased attention and adoption since the COVID-19 pandemic is *hybrid work*, defined as a work arrangement in which individuals work remotely/from home at least 25% of the time while spending the rest of the time working from an in-person site such as an office (Moglia et al., 2021). This type of work can be leveraged to combine the flexibility of remote work and the connection and proximity of in-person work, thus, for some, providing the best of both worlds (Bloom, 2021; Moglia et al., 2021). Hybrid work is projected to be the dominant work arrangement moving forward (Bloom, 2021).

To be sure, since the turn of the century, research on leadership in virtual organizing forms has matured. Indeed, three recent reviews of extant literature demonstrate the pervasiveness of the literature: a meta-analysis (Brown et al., 2021), an analytical review (Greimel et al., 2023), and a narrative review of quantitative studies of leadership styles and follower "reactions" (e.g., performance, job satisfaction, Höddinghaus et al., 2023, p. 1). Höddinghaus et al. (2023) offers an informative categorization of empirical research and underscores the importance of considering the level of virtuality as a potential moderator of leadership effects.

The analytical review presented in the current chapter complements these existing reviews and others (e.g., Avolio et al., 2014) by focusing on what is known about virtual leadership *communication*. This is an important focus, for although communication is sometimes included in virtual leadership research as a series of variables, it is not often viewed as a constitutive concept of virtual leadership. Because the very nature of communication among virtual leaders and members has been shown to matter to various outcomes and to constitute leader-member relationships themselves (Connaughton & Daly, 2005), centering communication in discussions of virtual leadership is imperative. In doing so, this chapter embraces Gibson and Gibbs (2006) conceptualization of virtual work (teams) outlined above and is motivated by the spirit

of Connaughton and Daly (2005) who define "*dispersed-distanced* teams as teams whose members are generally separated by some degree of time or physical distance, and we conceptualize *distanced leadership* [virtual leadership] as leadership in those contexts" (p. 192, italics in original).

In the next section, we examine the literature on virtual leadership communication. We organize our discussion by the four themes that emerged during our literature review: (a) virtual leadership as constituted by communication; (b) virtual leadership communication as related to virtual team and organizational outcomes; (c) virtual leadership communication as navigating paradox and tensions; and (d) virtual leadership communication as limiting and manifesting equity and inclusion.

Themes in Virtual Leadership Research

Virtual Leadership as Constituted by Communication

Common to all these 21st-century forms of work is that they are communicative in nature (Connaughton & Daly, 2005; Gibbs & Connaughton, 2024), as is leadership in these contexts. In 2008, drawing our attention to the inextricable relationship between virtual teams and communication, Gibbs and colleagues (2008) advanced a conceptual framework for studying virtual teams that centers communication practices constituting virtual teaming. Their framework foregrounds four dimensions of virtuality: geographical dispersion, electronic dependence, cultural diversity, and dynamic structure. In advancing this framework, Gibbs and colleagues point to how ongoing interactions among team members constitute virtual teams.

Language and interaction constitute virtuality, virtual leadership, and the relationships that define them. One strand of scholarship focuses on how language and interaction constitute relationships among virtual team members. Gibbs' research (2009; Gibbs, Boyraz et al., 2021; Gibbs, Gibson et al., 2021), for instance, has examined the ways in which virtuality is conceived of and constituted through communication by highlighting how team processes are constructed through language and interaction. Other research pinpoints the quantity and perception of interaction with leaders as aspects of virtual team effectiveness. For example, in their studies of leadership in virtual teams, Connaughton and Daly (2003, 2004) revealed that positional leaders in a multi-national technology organization perceived communication – conceived of as information adequacy, information equity, and communication frequency – as crucial to virtual team functioning. In addition to the virtual teams context, research has found a positive relationship between the frequency of

communication among virtual leaders and followers and followers' identification with the organization (Wiesenfeld et al., 1999).

Research also has shown that the nature of virtual leaders' interaction with those working from afar matters. Studies have examined the relationship between leadership and frequent, supportive interaction. For example, researchers have underscored the role of virtual leaders' intensive and supportive interaction with virtual team members and the importance of virtual leaders engaging in effective and efficient communication (Zaccaro et al., 2004). This work accentuates the intentionality needed in virtual leaders' communication with virtual followers. In addition, Gibbs, Boyraz, and colleagues (2021) drew on textual data (i.e., emails) and interview data from a longitudinal study of two global virtual teams to reveal how the nature of communication influences perceptions of team subgroups, and how those perceptions – as discursively constituted – evolve over time, suggesting that subgroup perceptions influence team dynamics differently over time.

The nature of communication between virtual leaders and followers also influences how followers perceive their leaders. Studies of leadership in distributed teams and organizations from networks perspectives point to the relationships among leaders and followers in these teams as consequential (Dionne et al., 2010). For example, utilizing automated text analysis, social network analysis, and hierarchical linear modeling, Huffaker (2010) found that online leaders or those who were perceived to be "influencers" communicated more frequently and assertively and were thought to be more credible and central in the network.

Conceiving of virtual leadership as constituted by communication underscores why relational-oriented approaches to leadership are so important in virtual and hybrid work contexts. We say this not to undermine the role of the nature of tasks and task-oriented leadership to effective virtual leadership; however, understanding virtual leadership as constituted by communication lends further support to the importance of a relational approach to leadership (see the meta-analysis by Brown et al., 2021). Indeed, previous research has shown that virtual leader-follower relationships are related to several aspects of teams including trust (Jarvenpaa & Leidner, 1998), conflict (Hinds & Mortensen, 2005; Wakefield et al., 2008), emotional intelligence (Alam et al., 2023; Mysirlaki & Paraskeva, 2020), politics and power (Muganda & Pillay, 2013), and the multiplicities of culture (Connaughton & Shuffler, 2007). To navigate these aspects of team dynamics, then, virtual leaders can leverage the constitutive power of communication to take a relationally engaged approach to skillfully addressing these dynamics across virtual contexts.

Virtual Leadership Communication as Related to Virtual Team and Organizational Outcomes

Studies of leadership in virtual teams and remote work arrangements have found that the quality of the leader and follower's relationship, as constituted by communication, matters to team processes and outcomes. Guided by leader-member exchange (LMX) theory, Golden and Veiga (2008), for instance, found that individuals having the highest quality relationships with their leader, and with the longest duration of time working remotely, tended to have greater commitment, job satisfaction, and performance compared to those who had not worked remotely as long. In addition, Connaughton and Daly (2003, 2004) demonstrated that positional leaders perceived communication variables (information adequacy, information equity, and communication frequency) to be linked to followers' trust and perceptions of isolation, among other process issues and outcomes.

Researchers have examined the effects leadership style has on virtual work and virtual group outcomes (Sosik, 1997; Sosik et al., 1997) as well as leadership style and trust in virtual groups (Hoyt & Blascovitch, 2003). Purvanova and Bono (2009), for instance, found that one particular leadership style, leaders' transformational leadership, had a stronger effect on team performance in virtual teams than it did in collocated teams. Other empirical literature underscores the adverse influences that virtual leadership style can have on followers (as individuals). For example, Alam et al. (2023) found that virtual leadership (defined as leadership done through primarily technologically mediated channels) positively related to nurses' work stress and burnout and negatively related to their job performance. It is important to note that this study was done during a time (COVID-19 pandemic) when the hospital had transitioned from collocated to virtual leadership. Alam et al. (2023) further revealed that virtual leadership can enhance individuals' feelings of isolation and disconnectedness from the leader, team, and organization. Their study found that emotional intelligence moderated the relationship between work stress and burnout among nurses and those with higher levels of emotional intelligence were less likely to be adversely influenced by virtual leadership. The authors conclude that enhancing the emotional intelligence of nurses may be one way to combat the lack of face-to-face communication that followers have with their virtual leaders.

Previous research has examined types of leadership that are often seen in virtual contexts: shared leadership (Castellano et al., 2021; Hoch & Kozlowski, 2014; Mayer et al., 2023) and emergent leadership (Charlier et al., 2016; Loignon et al., 2023;

Purvanova et al., 2021). Findings from research on shared leadership give us reason to suspect that information and communication management – what Hoch and Kozlowski (2014) and others have called one form of structural supports – can positively influence virtual team performance. While Hoch and Kozlowski (2014) were interested in the team level, Mayer et al. (2023) were interested in the potential impacts of sharing task-oriented leadership behaviors (i.e., coordinating tasks) and relations-oriented leadership behaviors (i.e., giving support to team members) on individual team members. They found that individual team members were more productive and more satisfied if task-oriented leadership behaviors were shared among team members. They also found that individual team members negatively perceived relations-oriented leadership behaviors being shared. They wanted positional leaders to assume those social support and other relations-oriented functions. The precise communicative conceptualization and operationalization of these task- and relations-oriented leadership behaviors remains an area to be explored in future research.

Previous research on virtual teams suggests that leaders often emerge over time, rather than being solely designated as team leaders at the time of the team's formation. In studying emergent leadership in virtual teams, some researchers have examined communication. For example, those with higher levels of communication apprehension have been shown to be less likely to emerge as leaders in virtual teams (Charlier et al., 2016). Some studies, while focusing on virtual teams more broadly, offer recommendations for leaders of these teams such as choosing richer communication mediums that allow for more social presence and nurturing emergent leadership in addition to formal, hierarchical leadership (Shuffler & Carter, 2018; Shuffler et al., 2016).

Researchers have also used networks and computational approaches to examine how leaders can foster shared mental models among team members. Lungeanu et al. (2022), for instance, were able to use data from eight teams gathered over 45 days each to computationally model the results of 3,200 simulated teams. This process allowed them to test a wide array of leadership variables and demonstrate that a shared leadership model, a popular approach for geographically distributed teams, is the most effective at helping team members synchronize their mental models of the task at hand. With a computational approach, Serban et al. (2015) utilized agent-based modeling to demonstrate that the emergence of leadership in a team member is less dependent on the cognitive capacities of the individual in online contexts than it is for in-person settings (Serban et al., 2015). Other scholars have used network studies approaches to explore electronic data related to organizational leadership. These studies can help reveal

details about leader-follower relationships in an organization, such as Sutanto et al.'s (2011) conclusion that an organizational member's centrality in a network is predictive of their being perceived as a leader by the other members of the network (Sutanto et al., 2011).

Virtual Leadership Communication as Navigating Paradox and Tension

Research has demonstrated that virtuality invites paradox and tension, and that leaders navigate that paradox and tension communicatively. For example, Purvanova and Kenda (2018) drew on paradox theory to show that virtual leaders must navigate and embrace paradox as central to virtuality and hence, virtual leadership. Based on a review of the literature, they identified three paradoxical tensions that virtual leaders face: (a) the technology dependence paradox; (b) the geographic dispersion paradox; and (c) the human capital paradox. The technology paradox points to how our reliance on technology creates both opportunities and challenges for interaction. Technology enables us to interact with leaders and team members at different locations, and technology may constrain interaction given limited communication cues and technical difficulties in some cases. The geographic dispersion paradox underscores how being geographically separated creates both opportunities and challenges not only for interaction but for the way work is done. For instance, geographic dispersion may enable virtual leaders and their team members to capitalize on time zone differences and get work done more quickly; at the same time geographic dispersion may make it difficult for virtual leaders and team members to collaborate simultaneously. The human capital paradox points to how social capital and knowledge capital are both needed for teams to be effective yet are also difficult to develop and take advantage of in virtual teams. For instance, given their limited opportunities for informal, non-work-related interaction, virtual leaders and team members may lack social capital with one another and thus may not have the relational capabilities (i.e., trust with one another) to share knowledge that is needed in these teams. Each of these paradoxes has implications for how virtual leaders communicate with followers. As Purvanova and Kenda (2018) state: "the same virtuality feature (e.g., technology-mediated communication) simultaneously gives rise to opposing, yet mutually dependent, challenges (e.g., impersonal interactions) and opportunities (e.g., less biased interactions)" (p. 757). Purvanova and Kenda developed a conceptual model to identify three leadership styles virtual leaders could take to navigate these paradoxical tensions – synergistic, selective, and stagnant. They argue that the synergistic style embraces the realities of

what virtual leaders face; it embraces a both/and mentality, unlike the selective style which adopts an either/or mentality and the stagnant style which intentionally avoids addressing dialectical tensions. Future research should examine their conceptual model of paradoxical leadership through a communication lens.

Research has shown that tensions will inevitably arise in virtual team interactions as well. Thus, how leaders and team members navigate these tensions is consequential. Gibbs' (2009) ethnographic study of a global software team illustrates how team members can navigate these inevitable tensions productively through communicative responses. Gibbs identified three dialectical tensions in virtual team interactions: autonomy versus connectedness ("enabling individual autonomy while preserving team connectedness," p. 915), inclusion versus exclusion (whether individuals were integrated into teams), and empowerment versus disempowerment (power dynamics in the team). Individuals relied on three discursive strategies to navigate these tensions – selection (choosing to voice one pole of the tension), transcendence (walking the line between the two poles of the tension, articulating aspects of both or oscillating between one or the other), and withdrawal (removing oneself from the tension; i.e., not voicing concerns) – with only transcendence being a productive strategy as, in the author's words, it allowed for "embracing the ambiguity of dialectics and incorporating both poles in a positive, enabling manner" (p. 927).

Virtual Leadership Communication as Limiting and Manifesting Equity and Inclusion

One of the more recent strands of scholarship in virtual leadership communication seeks to unravel how leadership communication relates to equity and inclusion in remote/hybrid work arrangements. Within literature that adopts critical perspectives to virtual leadership communication, some take a relatively pessimistic stance, noting the potential for remote/hybrid work to introduce new barriers to equity and inclusion. For example, there is concern that this shift to virtual work may accelerate the rate at which certain jobs typically occupied by more marginalized individuals become obsolete, leading some scholars to question "the value and appropriateness of using advanced technologies to replace certain jobs that are predominantly held by underrepresented groups" (Ozkazanc-Pan, 2019, p. 2645). Additionally, even when virtual work enables greater diversity in work teams, such as the trend towards greater international composition of work teams in organizations utilizing remote work, these increases can entrench inequities. For multinational organizations that utilize English as their *lingua*

franca in particular, many individuals with lower positions of power in organizations often speak English as a second language, which can lead to miscommunications and misperceptions that further reinforce the relational/power distance between leaders and workers (Lockwood & Forey, 2016). Remote work also comes with the risk of decreased feelings of belongingness and meaning in work. Such feelings can disproportionately affect marginalized individuals who may face more structural stressors than other individuals, and so leaders are directed to be cognizant of and address the organizational forces that drive such experiences (Byrd, 2022). Finally, some scholarship questions the limits of virtual presence; some organizational contexts seem to require physical presence to adequately address the relational needs of leaders and followers (Ameel et al., 2022).

Despite the potential barriers to equity and inclusion organizational leaders face in remote work contexts, the literature also highlights several strong advantages offered by this shift. For one thing, virtual work is generating a shift in organizational structures towards a post-bureaucratic work design with flattened hierarchies and a push toward consensus building aimed to decrease the power distance between leaders and followers and helps give marginalized team members a larger voice (de Laat, 2023; Hodgson, 2004). Similarly, increased remote work favors leadership styles that promote inclusive and equitable work environments. Indeed, beyond generally reducing the relevance of a leaders' formal, hierarchical power in favor of relational power (Soga et al., 2022), virtual work is conducive to "authentic leadership," which can reduce workplace loneliness and promote interactional justice in virtual work (Cenkci & Bircan, 2023; Luthans et al., 2003). Remote and hybrid work also increases career and employment opportunities for underrepresented groups. For example, "access to remote work is also an important lever for improving gender equality in organizations" since it enables women with caregiving responsibilities more flexible schedules (de Laat, 2023, p. 135). Hybrid work has also been shown to be more conducive to compassionate leadership styles which, according to some studies, is more highly represented in women (Imhanrenialena et al., 2023). Beyond gender representation, remote work can offer increased access for other groups such as neurodiverse individuals who may find remote work advantageous in avoiding sensory overwhelm (Szulc et al., 2021).

Evidence-Based Practical Tips

Through empirical research, we can learn how to lead and work more effectively in hybrid and virtual contexts. Drawing on this diverse body of work, researchers have developed insights and instruments that can be used to determine if virtual leaders are communicating and working in ways conducive to desirable work processes and outcomes (e.g., Batirlik et al., 2022). In the paragraphs that follow, we offer four practical tips to support virtual team leaders, members, teams, and organizations.

Prioritize Relationship Cultivation

Virtual groups are ultimately comprised of individuals in working relationships with each other. Relationships are likely to be most successful when they begin early and are consistently maintained. For example, Wilbert et al. (2023) recommended that team leaders initiate communication by introducing new team members to help them become socialized into the group. By maintaining relationships, team members may be able to handle conflict more effectively and independently (Turesky et al., 2020) and achieve team goals collaboratively (Connaughton et al., 2010). Technological tools can assist in relational development and maintenance. For example, one virtual manager shared her experience using WhatsApp both for work and personal updates like Thanksgiving dinner and Christmas travel (Turesky et al., 2020).

Make and Take Space for All Team Members to Participate

When collaborating in a virtual environment, it is significantly easier for team members to avoid participating and remain silent. It is imperative that leaders make conscious efforts to solicit participation from all team members and that team members actively participate with each other. Lack of participation may be driven by lower commitment to a project or the team's culture in which some members or leaders monopolize speaking time (Connaughton et al., 2010). Despite these hurdles, though, participation is important for team success and cohesion. Wilbert et al. (2023) highlighted the importance of full team participation and found that team leaders can effectively encourage team participation by emphasizing the team as a whole through shared responsibilities and rewards. Teams should take advantage of technology and communication tools available to them to encourage participation. For example, some technology companies' virtual team managers took advantage of social networking apps like WhatsApp to encourage team collaboration (Turesky et al., 2020).

Utilize Communication Mediums Strategically

One of the challenges virtual leaders can face is the reduced social influence within their team that can result from the limited interactions that occur when leading remotely (Shuffler et al., 2016). In response to this challenge, and "in order to convey social presence needed for influence, teams would benefit from the use of richer media such as teleconferencing or videoconferencing" as these channels can empower leaders to both perceive and transmit more nonverbal and emotional cues than is possible through text alone (Shuffler et al., 2016, p. 6). However, it is also worth noting that different communication mediums can offer advantages at different stages of a team lifecycle, thus increasing the importance of making informed decisions at each stage. For example, using lean communication channels at the formative stages of a multi-cultural team can actually help improve group cohesion; lean channels can obscure the surface-level differences individuals often use to quickly form subgroups with similar individuals, thus enabling team members to first form more diverse relationships within the team before observing these surface level differences (Shuffler et al., 2016).

Take Advantage of Available Training and Development Opportunities

Many virtual leaders have expressed a desire for training, development, and support for improving their virtual leadership. When reflecting on the need to shift to virtual learning in 2020 due to the COVID-19 pandemic, virtual education leaders reported that both they and the teams they managed needed training that was specific to online learning (Azukas, 2022). Similarly, virtual team managers at different technology companies also felt that their training was often "self-taught, self-developed" (Turesky et al., 2020, p. 198). Training for hybrid and virtual environments should span both technical components and broader skills like effective communication. For example, virtual leaders and teachers required additional training for tools like learning management systems, online pedagogy, and bureaucratic management (Azukas, 2022). Although there are many similarities between virtual and proximate environments and leadership, key differences would be more effectively and efficiently navigated by virtual leaders with specific training and development opportunities.

Future Research Agenda

Fairhurst and Connaughton (2014) reminded us that future research on leadership must rigorously examine "issues of space, distance and time; the nature of virtual

environments and new technologies; and culture and the multicultural, just to name a few" (p. 23). Prior to that, Connaughton and Daly (2005) invited researchers to engage in systematic and multi-methodological studies of virtual leadership. They called on researchers, particularly communication researchers, to theorize distanced and distributed leadership, and to consider the social and ethical implications of virtual leadership across industries and sectors. At the time of the current chapter's writing, we find ourselves echoing those calls. Indeed, the literature on organizational leadership and communication in virtual contexts addresses the complexities and unknowns involved in the rapid shift to widespread remote/hybrid work, noting that it leaves leaders lacking answers regarding how to best manage organizational and employee needs in this new landscape (Babapour Chafi et al., 2021).

These realities motivate our first suggested future research direction: develop communication-centered frameworks and theories of virtual leadership. Researchers have argued for the development of theoretical models of hybrid leadership (Ameel et al., 2022). Future research should center the communicative in these models and, relatedly, must empirically test existing conceptual frameworks (e.g., Weewawardane & Jayadarwana, 2022; and Liao's [2017] multilevel virtual leadership framework). Larson and DeChurch (2020), for example, advance four ways in which researchers can conceive of the leadership-technology relationship to further empirical study. These frameworks should be empirically examined.

Second, future work should examine leader-follower relationships in virtual/remote contexts over time. Hirolla and Siitonen (2020) remind us that leadership processes and perceptions of leadership are not static; indeed, they change over time. This certainly applies to virtual leadership, particularly when we conceive of leadership as relational. Considering the way relationships change over time and the changing landscape of remote and hybrid work, researchers should attend to this dynamism in their research designs.

Motivated by critical theories, a third future research direction is the impact of remote work on countries in the Global South. A report for the United Nations surveyed existing literature on telework and found that "the vast majority of academic articles (84%) in [this] review come from developed nations… There is a need to further explore the impacts of telework in regions not currently well-covered by academic literature" (Moglia et al., 2021, p. 19). This applies not only to telework but also to virtual and hybrid work, as well as to leader-follower relationships in these work arrangements. In general, we have an ethical obligation to study these relationships in the Global South and to ascertain whether what is "known" about virtual leadership and

virtual work that has emerged from studies done on these organizing forms in the Global North apply to the Global South; perhaps there are other dynamics at play (i.e., culture; gender norms) that may influence virtual leadership communication in the Global South.

Fourth, researchers should continue to examine how language and interaction shape power dynamics among virtual and hybrid teams. Indeed, critical scholars note how language continuously challenges or reifies the power dynamics in a leader-follower relationship due to the way it constructs a complex, layered reality between individuals (Bjørn & Ngwenyama, 2009). From a critical perspective, leadership communication can thus be seen as "inherently power-based, a site of contestation about the nature of leadership" (Fairhurst & Connaughton, 2014, p. 8), and virtual leadership brings a unique set of ethical challenges to the table. These include the "exploitation of digitalization processes to inflict information overload onto employees, or to further blur the lines between one's work and personal life" (Cortellazzo et al., 2019, p. 2). Future research needs to grapple with how leaders can adequately address these concerns in contemporary virtual and hybrid work contexts.

Fifth, future research should examine virtual leadership in emerging contexts and realities. For instance, future empirical studies must examine not only leadership in traditional virtual organizing contexts but also leadership in virtual environments being shaped by emerging trends such as a shift towards the gig economy and the proliferation of AI. The gig economy, for example, involves situations in which organizations employ individuals for specific tasks, not for long-term employment. As Schmidt (2019) writes, "these trends [globally distributed teams and work in the gig economy] require leaders to engage in influence tactics and worker identity building activities through information technology in a virtual environment, with workers often possessing weak organizational ties" (p. 63). While the gig economy shifts employment structures, AI represents another emerging trend which is reshaping employment roles and opportunities by reducing or displacing the need for some roles (i.e., some copywriting), creating opportunities for new roles (i.e., "prompt engineers"), and increasing productivity for existing roles. With the rapid emergence of AI and its potential to dramatically shift these jobs and work contexts, future scholarship should attend to the role of virtual leadership in work contexts being shaped by artificial intelligence (see Pang & Zhang, 2021).

Conclusion

To be sure, virtual leadership has long been a feature of teams and organizations in some sectors. It is increasingly prevalent in a post-COVID era. Extant literature tells us

that virtual leadership is constituted by communication; virtual leadership communication is inextricably tied to virtual team and organization processes and outcomes; virtual leadership communication is about navigating paradox and tension; and virtual leadership communication is about limiting and manifesting equity and inclusion. Research findings related to these four themes and more motivate informed recommendations for leading virtually. Future organizing promises to continue to lean in to remote and hybrid work as the norm. As we continue to study the intricacies of these organizing forms and leadership within them, may we also continue to center communication in our theorizing, empirical knowledge production, and recommendations for evidence-based practice.

Note

1. Researchers have used various terms to examine leadership in virtual organizing forms. These terms include virtual leadership, e-leadership, remote leadership, among others (see Table 2 in Höddinghaus et al., 2023, for definitions and examples of studies that use these terms).

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15

LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION IN INTERORGANIZATIONAL COLLABORATION

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-18

Introduction

Interorganizational collaboration (IOC) is a hallmark of modern organizing and the de facto organizational form to address difficult social issues, meta-problems, or grand challenges that cross sectoral boundaries and are beyond the scope of any single organization. The complexity, uncertainty, and interdependency of contemporary work makes some type of collaborative organizational arrangement necessary for successful outcomes across many industries and sectors and presents unique opportunities for innovation and creative problem solving. IOCs are a staple of nonprofit management and public administration (Bryson et al., 2015) and increasingly relevant for private and corporate business endeavors (Majchrzak et al., 2015). IOC is a widespread organizational form with distinct features that also shape how leadership is practiced. Generally, IOC entails a variety of organizational arrangements, partnerships, and alliances that bring together multiple organizations – usually across economic sectors – that vary in scope and degree of formality and arise out of necessity and/or opportunity.

IOC is especially relevant and prevalent in the nonprofit/civil society sector, but increasingly has important applications for business, scientific, and municipal work. For example, issues as diverse as affordable housing, immigration, police reform, space exploration, education, healthcare, and renewable energy all involve multiple stakeholders representing different organizations and seeking to solve problems and

implement solutions that transcend their expertise and jurisdictions. Yes, important work is accomplished by individual organizations, but ultimate progress on any of these issues will almost always entail some sort of collaborative effort among relevant organizations. That is the valuable function of IOC and why IOC is a key site for organizational, leadership, and communication scholarship.

However, the distinct characteristics of IOC also challenge many aspects of our conventional wisdom about organizing and leadership communication and call for novel frameworks and theories to understand this important phenomenon and enhance our comprehension of leadership communication in this context. The key feature affecting leadership communication is the simple fact that IOC brings together representatives from different organizations representing multiple sectors of society who do not have authority over each other or other formal mechanisms to induce compliance or consent, what Boyer et al. (2019) refer to as the move from individual to shared control. In IOCs, members face less formal chains of command to control the work of others (Gazley, 2008) and must overcome different organizational cultures and operational standards to "get things done" collectively (Bryson et al., 2006), resulting in a "shared power world" (Crosby & Bryson, 2005) where it's difficult to determine who's in charge (Sullivan et al., 2012). Leadership in this context is best understood as a shared, plural, distributed, and relational phenomena that is manifest in situated communication practices.

Yet this notion shared control has profound effects for nearly every aspect of IOC work, especially leadership – which is all about trying to influence people towards common action and often presumes some measure of authority or power. Additionally, since IOC often involves organizations from different sectors of society, it means that multiple (and often conflicting) institutional logics are present that are difficult to reconcile when making final decisions. All of this has important implications for leadership communication because the distinct features of IOC magnify the relational aspects of organizing and the interactions among the stakeholders involved. As organizational forms, IOC lacks many of the key features of "normal" organizations we take for granted – physical structures, clear lines of authority, contractual relationships, etc. – and thus are better understood as communicative phenomena that exist in and through specific communication practices, with leadership perhaps the most significant practice for the success of IOC work.

Accordingly, this raises important questions about the relationship between leadership and authority. In this chapter I argue that exercising IOC leadership means to interact in ways that sustain and bolster the collective authority of IOC organizational

forms or draw upon this authority to accomplish IOC objectives and sustain the authority of the collective. IOC leadership can happen through conventional positions like the designated chair of an IOC, the representative of a lead agency, or the moderator of IOC meetings, but it is also something that can by enacted by any IOC member who influences interactions that are recognized and responded to as authoritative and result in marshalling consent towards goal accomplishment. This includes key moments of trust and legitimacy, interaction design, and boundary work, while also highlighting important issues related to visibility and organizationality that warrant further investigation. A key issue is to recognize the important relationship – but also conceptual distinction – between leadership and authority, something I develop and explain throughout the chapter.

Overall, my purpose here is to explore the unique leadership communication dynamics of IOC, focusing on how the distinct organizational features of IOC shape notions of authority, control, decision making, and the various patterns of interaction that constitute leadership communication in this context. Accordingly, this chapter proceeds with additional background information on interorganizational collaboration and the interdisciplinary research literature that shapes our understanding of this organizational phenomenon. Next, the chapter develops an approach to organizational authority rooted in constitutive communication theory that conceptualizes authority as a negotiated phenomenon distributed among organizational members, emphasizing more emergent forms of influence and accountability that transcend boundaries and hierarchies. I conclude with a discussion of several IOC leadership communication practices that are entailed from this approach to organizational authority plus directions for future research.

Background on Interorganizational Collaboration

Sorting through the extensive amount of research and information about IOC is a daunting and even unrealistic task, given the vast number of contexts and situations where IOC is employed and the wide variety of forms that IOC can take. There really is no way to develop an integrated IOC framework – and there probably shouldn't be. Plus, the upshot of the popularity and prevalence of organizational collaboration is that collaboration has come to mean almost anything, "hopelessly ambiguous" as Donahue (2010) puts it. The same can be said about the notion of leadership, another near-mythic term in our society that is applied to countless phenomena and often confuses more than it clarifies (as noted by several other chapters in this handbook). So, let's begin by

clarifying what is meant by IOC before exploring some of the communicative challenges and practices that are central to IOC leadership.

Definitions of collaboration are as frequent and varied as collaboration itself, but a few key themes tend to cut across most perspectives in the research and practitioner literatures, and thus provide a good starting point. Here's my best attempt to bring these key themes together into a coherent working definition:

> *Interorganizational collaboration is a simultaneous process and structure that involves organizational representatives who come together in a deliberate manner to address issues that affect multiple stakeholders and are beyond the scope or capacity of any single organization or sector, resulting in a distinct organizational form and identity that transcends the mere aggregation of participating organizations*.[1]

Let's look at each of these definitional components in more detail.

As a simultaneous *process and structure*, collaboration involves both how and what, verb and noun – *how* people interact with each other and *what* results from their interactions (and consequently how the results inform subsequent interactions, which shape subsequent results, etc.). Although we can make analytic distinctions between process and structure, they are best understood as mutually constitutive (see Keyton et al., 2008). This means that structure and process always shape and implicate each other – how we interact with others depends on structures that enable and constrain those interactions, which in turn reshape those structures that consequently shape subsequent interactions, and so on. What we often identify as "the collaboration" (noun) is really just a momentary configuration of ongoing processes (verb).

Next, *organizational representatives* are people authorized to speak and act for their organization, and conversely speak and act for the collaboration back at their "home" organizations. This also implies a separation among collaboration members such that they do not have hierarchical arrangements or formal authority over each other, though inevitable power differences and implications are always present. Furthermore, *come together* and *deliberate manner* mean that collaboration members are intentional about and aware of their partnership – collaboration is not just a loose network of abstract nodes or the result of invisible market forces. Then *address issues* can involve everything from exploring and updating to arguing and deciding. Some collaborations exist merely to share information and build relationships, others exist to solve specific

problems on a definite timeline, but all involve orienting towards some particular issue that warrants attention and engagement.

Multiple stakeholders means that several parties are affected by – and/or can affect – the issues involved and the work of the collaboration. Sometimes these stakeholders are "outside" of the collaboration because they do not have the capacity to represent themselves, such as children or disadvantaged populations (in fact, that's often why organizational collaborations form in the first place – the realization that important work needs to be done on behalf of others). *Beyond the scope or capacity* of any single organization or sector means that the issue(s) the collaboration is working on cannot be addressed or resolved without involvement from several organizations – either because the work it too big or because it cuts across jurisdictions, often resulting in problems that are both everyone's and no one's. Finally, a *distinct organizational form* suggests the emergence of a higher-order organizational entity that transcends the relationships among the participants and cannot be reduced to the contributions of any single member or subset of members – a specific organizational arrangement that is more than just the aggregation of members.

This definition also distinguishes collaboration from other related terms like cooperation or coordination. I see "cooperation" as the most generic, overarching term involving anyone merely working together and "coordination" as the alignment of tasks towards goal accomplishment. Collaboration obviously involves cooperation and coordination – clearly, people are working together and aligning their tasks in collaboration – but these necessary components are not sufficient to rise to the level of IOC in a more formal sense. For that, we need a greater level of interdependency and collective action among separate organizational participants, which is what distinguishes IOC from other organizational arrangements. IOC also differs from contractual relationships or professional associations, which are commonplace in a variety of sectors and may involve episodes of collaborative activity from time to time, but do not rise to the level of collaboration that we are examining here. Consequently, we are *not* talking about anytime organizations merely working together for any number of reasons, even if this work is casually referred to as a partnership, taskforce, alliance, or any other term implying collaboration. Instead, we are focused on a particular kind of organizational arrangement that exhibits the features described above. Yes, things are fuzzy at the boundaries – they usually are – yet these definitional components should give us sufficient analytic clarity to proceed with an examination of the key issues and challenges of leadership communication that are distinct for interorganizational

collaboration. But first, let's explore the centrality of authority in more depth because this provides the foundation for all aspects of IOC leadership communication.

Authority as the Central Concept for IOC Leadership Communication

As I noted in the beginning of this chapter, the key issue shaping almost everything about IOC leadership communication is authority. IOCs form to make decisions and take action, but they also involve organizational representatives who generally do not have any formal authority over each other, and thus have no formal mechanisms for inducing compliance. Yet, as organizational forms created for some kind of task or goal accomplishment, IOCs do require a degree of authority to achieve their objectives – there must be some mechanism to set agendas, structure deliberations, adjudicate between competing positions, and enforce decisions. Otherwise, IOCs have no functional purpose and devolve into mere open forums for sharing ideas but with no capacity to take action as a collective towards achieving specific goals or tasks.

Thus, a central issue for IOC – perhaps *the* issue – is accomplishing voluntary collective action apart from hierarchical mechanisms of control (Lawrence et al., 2002). This is the main leadership communication challenge for IOC: interacting in ways that create and sustain an adequate system of authority that enables collective action and decision making. However, conventional approaches to authority are not as relevant for IOCs, which generally exhibit more collective, shared, or distributed forms of leadership (Torfing et al., 2020) that are not based on hierarchical relationships exercised through managerial power and control. Instead, we should turn to a different approach to authority that is more relevant for how IOCs are structured and operate. Accordingly, this section reviews an alternative approach to authority rooted in communication theory that explains how patterns of stakeholder interactions can constitute distributed systems of influence, which helps us better understand the dynamics of IOC and provides a conceptual foundation for examining subsequent challenges of leadership communication. Authority has been a key focus of my research on IOC, so here I'll draw from several previous studies to sketch out the contours of a communicative approach to authority that can help us better understand IOC leadership.[2]

Every organizational arrangement requires some system of authority to coordinate collective action (Taylor & Van Every, 2014); authority is what makes organizations *organizations* and not other kinds of associations. And most IOCs are trying to achieve a certain level of "organizationality" (Dobusch & Schoeneborn, 2015) and thus need

some kind of authority mechanism to ensure a measure of accountability and task accomplishment. However, IOC brings together people and organizations that generally do not have authority over each other, and it blurs the boundaries between groups and gives rise to ambiguous authority relations that can be tricky to resolve. This can make it difficult to accomplish collaborative goals because there is no formal authority to mediate between competing interests or induce action toward certain priorities. The sheer diversity of ideas and perspective of multiple stakeholders invites a lot of conflict about how the IOC should proceed, and there has to be some way to reconcile various knowledge differences, power imbalances, and other "jurisdictional conflicts" that are sure to arise in any collaborative endeavor.[3] Thus, the challenge for collaboration is to establish a system of authority capable of coordinating the diverse interests of multiple stakeholders, but apart from hierarchical mechanisms of control (Lawrence et al., 2002). Without this level of cooperation, IOC can derail into a host of free-rider problems, deferred responsibility, minimal contributions, and overall inaction.

Traditional approaches to authority are grounded in the early works of Weber (1968/1922), Barnard (1938), and Fayol (1949), which view authority as an objective feature of hierarchical relations exercised through managerial power and control (Kuhn, 2008). Thus, authority is something people "have" by virtue of your place within an institutional structure. This approach is most relevant for hierarchical and bureaucratic organizations that function based on power vested in specific departments and offices. However, this traditional approach is increasingly less relevant for many aspects of modern work, especially IOC. Rather, the independency and complexity of IOC makes it difficult to predict or control who is accountable for various responsibilities, and IOC tends to obscure the boundaries among collaborators, which creates ambiguous authority relations that are difficult to reconcile. Accordingly, many scholars now conceptualize authority as a negotiated phenomenon distributed among organizational members, emphasizing more emergent forms of influence and accountability that transcend boundaries and hierarchies (cf. Kahn & Kram, 1994; Okhuysen & Bechky, 2009). The key point is that authority is worked out in practice as people interact with each other and make decisions about the scope of power they have over each other and their tasks. Yet, this raises a question of how local interactions can create the authority needed to coordinate and manage work across domains of knowledge and expertise. Organizational communication scholars have been especially interested in this question, and recent literature on the communicative constitution of organizations offers important insights to enhance our understanding of authority in ways that are more relevant for IOC work and leadership communication.

Scholars aligned with the Montréal School of organizational communication (see Brummans et al., 2014) have done the most extensive work to theorize authority as a negotiated and distributed phenomenon grounded in interaction (see Benoit-Barné & Cooren, 2009; Brummans, 2013; Cooren, 2010; Kuhn, 2008; Taylor & Van Every, 2014). Research in this vein depicts authority as a process of *authoring* where people struggle to "write" an official version of the organization that conveys specific notions of purpose, direction, and identity. This conception of authority relates to the textual existence of organizations, where interrelated networks of meaning are "read" in certain ways to enable coordinated action (Kärreman, 2001; Westwood & Linstead, 2001). These texts could be concrete, like mission statements or bylaws; or figurative, like unspoken norms or informal practices. Figurative texts are especially relevant here because they help explain why people often refer to organizing or coordinating as "being on the same page," while not referring to any formal documents per se.

Whether concrete or figurative, texts themselves can develop authority through the processes by which they are authored (note the connection between *author*ity and *author*ing). The result is more than a loose collection of texts, but rather an organizational abstraction taken to represent all the interactions to which this abstraction refers (Taylor et al., 1996). For instance, a small group of people begin meeting informally to discuss an ongoing issue, but over time simply refer to themselves as "the committee" – a notion meant to encompass all the people and interactions that make up their group. The emergent abstraction of "the committee" is now *a thing* that exists beyond the individual members or any particular interaction (i.e., people may come and go but "the committee" continues to persist because its existence is not reducible to any single member or incident). And it is this emergent abstraction that can become a source of authority for collaboration, what Kuhn (2008) refers to as an *authoritative text*. Authority is now attributed to the abstraction itself instead of any particular individual, and collective agency is now exercised in the name of this abstraction. Authoritative texts are figurative texts that portray an organization in ways that specify roles, duties, values, activities, outcomes, etc., while also explaining relations of power and legitimacy. Authority is then inscribed in efforts to shape the trajectory of an authoritative text, a qualitative characteristic of authoritative texts indicating the course or general direction of the collective (Koschmann et al., 2012). Authority, then, is not in a hierarchical position or a person who gives commands, but rather in the ongoing process of authoring a definitive representation of the collective.

But how does this textual abstraction of small-scale interactions become authoritative? This happens as localized interactions – like an IOC meeting or planning

session – "scale up" (Cooren & Fairhurst, 2009) and gain distance from their immediate circumstances, a process Ricoeur (1991) calls *distanciation*. The distancing from local interactions creates ambiguity because the textual outcomes of the interactions are inevitably generalized and simplified as they gain space from their original context. The resulting abstraction tends to discard evidence of individual authorship, meaning that the intentions and contributions of specific people are excluded or ignored and the remaining *abstraction itself* becomes the focus of subsequent interactions. Texts must then shed evidence of individual authorship and portray a collective accomplishment (whether intentional or not) that is seen as legitimate and commanding. It is this "vanishing" (Taylor & Van Every, 2011) of individual authorship that enables abstractions to develop authority. Increasingly, as more agency is attributed to the abstraction itself, it becomes reified in ways that convey authority and power. The more we do this, the more authoritative the abstraction becomes. Basically, we treat the abstraction as if it were a separate entity with its own motivations, responsibilities, and capabilities. Authority is now attributed to the *abstraction itself* ("Sorry, *the committee* won't let you do that"), and action is taken in the name of the abstraction ("*The committee* decided to pursue this new policy"), rather than any one person or group.

Additionally, this emergent authority is further bolstered because abstractions can accommodate multiple interpretations and still maintain a fairly consistent identity. Plus, it is increasingly difficult to challenge this authority because abstractions cannot be engaged with directly, and any individual can always defer to the abstraction when confronted ("I can't speak to that issue, you'll have to take it up with *the committee*"). And it's important to note that when analyzing collaboration for an authoritative text, we're not looking for a formal document per se, but rather trying to figure out what people are "reading" as they embark on their work. What is the dominant reading of the situation that seems to orient everyone to the work? When you figure that out you've found a key source of authority for IOC leadership, and thinking communicatively helps us do this more insightfully.

The crucial point here is that all of this happens in and through communication – it is not a form of authority that can be imposed as an objective feature of the collaboration structure, but rather an abstraction that emerges from interaction and gains power through representation in practice. I also want to be clear that I'm not equating leadership and authority here, even though that is often the case in contemporary discourse. Instead, I'm conceptualizing leadership as a process of facilitating emergent authority, where leadership is recognized, conferred, and legitimized through participation in authoring and sustaining the accepted depiction of the collective (see

Holm & Fairhurst, 2018 on this point). Without this important distinction we fall into the trap of conflating leadership with hierarchical positions and miss the ways in which authority functions in IOC work.

Thus, we now have a communicative account of authority as a negotiated phenomenon, a social accomplishment that is achieved in interaction. The main idea is that authority is *relational* because it emerges from interactive circumstances and can only be understood in reference to the actions of others. This shifts the emphasis away from hierarchical positions and more toward the meanings, interpretations, and texts that are worked out among collaboration members in practice. Collaboration leadership is not in a hierarchical position or people who give commands, but rather in the *process of authoring* a definitive representation of the collective. Authority is not something someone can *have*, but rather something people *do* as their interactions create (or not) figurative texts that are "read" in ways that perpetuate certain understandings of structure, direction, and relations of power. This directs our attention towards the ways in which people are interacting with each other and how those interactions enable (or constrain) the emergence of collective abstractions that develop the authority to organize and coordinate IOC work.

Distinct Leadership Challenges of Interorganizational Collaboration

The previous section provides the intellectual foundation for understanding IOC leadership communication, focusing on the central problematic of authority and collaborative work. However, even though identifying the significance of authority is conceptually accurate, it is also not analytically precise and does not necessarily illuminate specific IOC leadership communication practices to investigate and improve, nor does it address specific implications and applications of authority for IOC leadership communication. Given the understanding of IOC and authority developed in the previous sections, what then are the key communication challenges facing those tasked with leading IOC endeavors? Not just when leaders have to communicate in terms of basic message transmission, like sending emails or ensuring quality meeting minutes (an endless task), but rather the more communicative aspects of IOC leadership where human interaction constitutes IOC and sustains its existence and development. Things like establishing trust and legitimacy, designing interactional environments, and doing boundary work across organizations and sectors.

Accordingly, this section will cover some key aspects of IOC leadership and explore how we can think more communicatively about these facets of IOC leadership. But we

need to be careful here. We don't want to just come up with a list of "things leaders do" and thus perpetuate the notion of individualistic/heroic leadership. Instead, we're talking about practices and patterns of interaction that are especially communicative and relate to the way authority emerges and is recognized in the collective authority of IOC work. And the practices listed here are meant to be illustrative, not exhaustive. After all, the mutual constitution of communication and collaboration means that nearly *any* aspect of IOC work could be a key site for leadership and the recognition of collective authority. In fact, that's central to this approach to IOC leadership communication – recognizing the mundane, everyday moments when various practices and patterns of interaction constitute, reinforce, or expand the emergent authority of IOCs (i.e., IOC leadership) in order to achieve goals, accomplish objectives, and otherwise "get things done" collectively (Boyer et al., 2018). What we're talking about here instead are practices that people in designated positions of IOC leadership (e.g., chairperson, lead agency, moderator/facilitator) should cultivate, as well as things that any IOC member could focus on if they want or need to exercise leadership in a particular situation. And any of the items listed below could be its own handbook chapter, with a rich literature of empirical and conceptual studies that have addressed these topics in more depth. So, the goal here is mainly to present a survey of relevant issues and point readers in the right direction for further insights.

Trust and Legitimacy

Given IOCs lack of formal authority, trust and legitimacy become some of the primary mechanisms by which voluntary collective action is accomplished (Human & Provan, 2000; Sloan & Oliver, 2013). That is, IOC members tend to act based on the level of trust they have with their collaborative partners (Zhang & Huxham, 2009) and compliance tends to relate to the perceived legitimacy of the IOC and its work (Bryson et al., 2015; Lee & Esteve, 2023). Therefore, key leadership practices involve building and maintaining trust among IOC members, as well as sustaining the legitimacy of the collaboration and its perception among key stakeholders.

An extensive amount of research points to several practices that can establish and enhance trust and legitimacy for IOC endeavors, depending on the circumstances and people involved. This includes things like emotional engagement (Sloan & Oliver, 2013), rhetoric and persuasion (Dudau et al., 2020), cooperation and shared governance (Vayaliparampil & Wolterstorff, 2021), exhibiting actions of deference and creating identify fit (Zhang & Huxham, 2009), fostering mutual understanding (Beech & Huxham,

2003), demonstrating predictability and goodwill (Maguire et al., 2001), cultivating outside support (Human & Provan, 2000), threat regulation (Williams, 2007), procedural fairness (Bryson et al., 2015), regular interactions among IOC members (Provan & Kenis, 2008), moments of catharsis and catalysis (Owen & Currie, 2022), plus a variety of cognitive and behavioral mechanisms (Kostis et al., 2022), to name a few.

The key insight here is that IOC members in designated leadership positions or those who seek to exercise leadership regardless of their position should focus on practices that build and sustain trust among IOC members and perceived legitimacy among relevant stakeholders. Conversely, people engaged in IOC work related to trust and legitimacy are more likely to be recognized as leaders or seen as more influential, thus contributing to the emergent authority that IOCs need to develop and cultivate. Specific practices will always depend on the particular IOC and the people involved, but in general trust and legitimacy are key challenges for IOC leadership that should be met through communication practice.

Interaction Design

One of the biggest mistakes in the practice of collaboration is believing that the main task is to assemble the right people who are knowledgeable about the issues, assuming they will know what to do when they assemble – get people "at the table" or "in the room" and they'll figure it out. But *how* people interact with each other is at least as important as who's at the table and what interests are being represented. Of course, no one can predict the nature of IOC deliberations nor control the outcome of IOC meetings. But it is possible to shape IOC interactions in ways that make certain consequences more or less likely. That's what the concept of *interaction design* is all about, structuring the communication environment to increase the probability of more favorable outcomes and limit the possibilities for negative outcomes. As Aakhus (2007) explains, "design happens when there is an intervention into some ongoing activity through the invention of techniques, devices, and procedures that aim to redesign interactivity and thus shape the possibilities for communication" (p. 112). For IOC work, people in conventional leadership positions tend to have more capacity to shape the interactional environment, whereas people looking to exercise leadership can direct their efforts toward how people are interacting with each other and work to incorporate the kinds of interventions that Aakhus (2007) described. Thus, interaction design is a

key site for IOC leadership because it involves developing the communication practices that constitute IOC and enable its capacity for emergent authority.

How should people in IOC leadership positions or those seeking to exercise IOC leadership design IOC interactions? That, of course, depends on the IOC itself, the specific people involved, and the nature of their work. However, research points to several design principles that are especially relevant for IOC interactions. In my own work I have focused on communication practices that increase the value of IOCs by fostering the emergent authority needed to generate collective agency and enable successful collaborative work (see Koschmann, 2016a; Koschmann, 2020; Koschmann et al., 2012). One of the most important, overarching principles is to *increase meaningful participation* among IOC members. Motivating action in response to complex social problems – even if that action cannot be expected to solve those problems – requires communication practices that manage both the diversity of participants and the tensions between competitive and collaborative approaches to deliberation. Accordingly, a simultaneous ethic of inclusiveness and constructive confrontation is more likely to generate the meaningful participation needed for the creative, integrative, and legitimate solutions participants seek, as the IOC's authoritative text begins to encode the interests of multiple parties and eschews convenient compromises (Kuhn & Deetz, 2008; Lange, 2003). Underlying these claims is the communication theory concern for surfacing and reclaiming – rather than ignoring or suppressing – relevant conflicts as a route to legitimate consent generation and, ultimately, to broader support for collective decisions (Deetz, 1992). The important issue, then, is not merely whether a reasonably full set of representatives is present at the table but, rather, whether their participation is a meaningful part of an IOC's interaction environment.

Beyond ensuring meaningful participation among IOC members, another important IOC leadership challenge is managing the contrasting communication patterns that tend to characterize IOC interactions and intervening when things are out of balance. First is a tension between *aggregation and emergence*. Collaboration seeks novel and innovative solutions to complex problems, but this sort of knowledge cannot be accomplished through the mere aggregation of present thinking. Instead, collaboration calls for generative knowledge that emerges from "dialogic moments" that open existing positions and knowledge claims to contestation and negotiation (Milam & Heath, 2014). Too often IOC deliberations are characterized by a logic of aggregation, where members share their initial interests and basically advocate to maintain or advance those positions, and the main goal of the IOC seems to be to summarize and account for

all the various views among the member organizations – but without accomplishing anything that is more than the sum of the IOC parts. The leadership communication challenge here is to structure and nurture patterns of interaction that foster more emergent outcomes such as generative knowledge, identity formation, and collective agency – versus the mere aggregation of existing ideas and positions.

A second interaction dynamic that should be the focus of leadership communication is the contrast between *representation and exploration*. IOCs often focus on the important work of representing all the relevant interests and stakeholders in a given domain. The problem, however, is when a commitment to representation prevents the willingness to explore possibilities across and beyond initial positions and policies. Successful collaboration depends on the flexibility of interests and positions, as well as the receptivity of intertextual influences. However, an overemphasis on representation hinders the ability of group members to coauthor an authoritative text with the capacity for shared identity and collective agency, instead constituting a state of contrasting identities and competing texts, with no ability to act authoritatively as a collective. The leadership communication challenge here is to establish and maintain an interactional environment that does more than just create a space for IOC members to voice their concerns and have their interests represented; they also need to explore what else might be possible beyond their initial positions.

The tension between representation and exploration leads to a final interaction dynamic of IOC leadership communication, the contrast between *expression and engagement*. Following the work of Milam and Heath (2014) – and echoing Deetz (1992) – we can understand "expression" as non-participatory structures and monologic practices that involve conveying information and stating personal viewpoints and interests, whereas "engagement" involves a more substantive and lively encounters with other people and ideas. Generative knowledge and shared identity can only be achieved through the interactions among constituent parts of a system, not the mere accumulation of ideas that happens through expressing individual positions. Without the emergence of higher-order system properties, a collaboration cannot achieve the abstraction and reification needed to exercise agency and convey authority. A certain level of expression is undoubtedly necessary for any collaborative effort – stakeholders need a forum to convey their ideas to other people. However, mere expression is insufficient to achieve the emergence of insight and creativity required for collaboration to be successful. At issue is the need for interactions that overlap or *imbricate* (see Taylor, 2001), such that they provide scaffolding for the emergence of new ideas and innovative solutions.

Boundary Spanning and Translation

A final challenge for IOC leadership involves the communicative work needed to navigate the borders among IOC members and sectors. By their nature, IOCs almost always bring together stakeholders and organizations from different spheres or areas of society (e.g., business, government, education, nonprofit, grassroots, etc.) – given that IOCs tend to form in response to complex issue that no one organization or sector can address sufficiently on their own. The problem, however, is that the diversity of membership required for effective IOC formation is also what makes it difficult for IOC members to understand and influence each other. That's because various sectors of society operate from different institutional logics (i.e., accepted norms, practices, and assumptions; see Thornton & Ocasio, 2008) and employ contrasting discourses (ways of talking and related textual practices; see Hardy et al., 2005) to justify their work and interact with each other. This complicates intersectoral work because things that may be self-evident in one sector (like profit maximization or equitable service delivery) are often contested in other sectors. Therefore, a key practice for effective IOC leadership involves communicating across sectoral and organizational borders and helping IOC members understand each other.

The collaboration research literature refers to this as *boundary work* (Langley et al., 2019) or *boundary spanning* (Isbell, 2012), emphasizing those who work across borders to develop mutual comprehension and appreciation among people who think and talk differently about relevant IOC issues. Central to this work is the notion of *translation*, where the ideas and concerns of one sector are converted into the language, values, or norms of a different sector (Koschmann, 2016b). For example, when representatives from nonprofit organizations translate their interests and issue into economic terms valued by the business community, or conversely when financial concepts are converted into more humanistic language that foregrounds dignity and social equity. The danger of sector differences is that they can become ends into themselves, meaning that collaboration members no longer have to justify their positions but only demonstrate that other ideas do not meet the standards of their own sector norms. An idea can be wrong simply because it is not "business like" or "politically viable," which is just another way of saying that an idea does not fit within the norms and values of a particular sector. The leadership communication challenge here is to mitigate the tendency of IOCs to foreground sectoral boundaries and sector discourses and perpetuate their self-referencing rationalities, instead fostering more collaborative discourse that spans boundaries and translates provincial interests into a more

collaborative lingua franca required to achieve consensus and sustain a trajectory of progress.

Directions for Future Research

The challenges explained above also suggest directions for future research on IOC leadership communication, especially related to some of the key trends in the field of organizational studies more broadly. Specifically, there is a growing amount of recent organizational scholarship on the topics of *visibility* and *organizationality* – both of which are especially relevant for IOC and could have profound implications for leadership communication, thus warranting the attention of future research studies.

Visibility

A large amount of research in the fields of business, management, and administration focuses on organizations that are known and recognizable. Accordingly, *visibility* is a widespread assumption throughout much of organizational studies, that organizations want to be recognized, identified, and seen by relevant stakeholders or the general public – and are actively trying to do so. The same is true for a substantial amount of IOC work, with organizations touting their collaborative activity and interorganizational relationships in order to promote their work, attract supporters, secure funding, maintain legitimacy, uphold their reputations, or achieve any number of benefits that come from being known and recognized. However, a substantial amount of organizational activity is deliberately concealed, difficult to find, and operates in the shadows of society for any number of reasons, including to maintain privacy and security or to hide nefarious activities. Again, the same is true for IOCs, many of which operate in competitive or sensitive environments, or around controversial issues where visibility is not welcome and may even threaten the viability of their work. For instance, consider IOCs that work in areas of technology and artificial intelligence that push the boundaries of societal norms and values, or IOCs that work in areas of reproductive healthcare amidst legal restrictions and cultural resistance. In all these situations, maintaining concealment – not visibility – is key and thus an important aspect of IOC leadership communication.

As such, a growing amount of organizational scholarship now questions the assumption of visibility and highlights the leadership communication practices involved in maintaining various levels of concealment (consider the work of Albu, 2023; Fu & Cooper, 2022; Jensen & Meisenbach, 2015; Scott, 2013; Scott & Kang, 2023; Stohl &

Stohl, 2017). Yet this line of research has yet to examine the distinct context of IOC work, which is a notable gap, given the significance of invisibility and concealment for a substantial amount of IOC work. We need to know more about leadership communication in these contexts, especially how the challenges discussed above (trust and legitimacy, interaction design, and boundary spanning and translation) influence the practice of leadership when visibility is unwanted or even dangerous. Plus, we need to learn about leadership communication practices that create, maintain, and enhance invisibility if concealment is going to be an increasingly important aspect of IOC work. Accordingly, the topic of invisibility or concealment represents a promising and critical direction for future research on IOC leadership communication.

Organizationality

The field of organization studies initially developed with primary attention to formal organizations and continues to emphasize traditional organizational forms in much of the research literature (Adler, 2009; Clegg et al., 2006). Thus, there is a substantial amount of human activity that is indeed "organizational" yet largely absent or underappreciated in organizational scholarship or is shoehorned into "normal" organizational research without appreciating how various phenomena depart from conventional organizations yet are still organizational in some ways. Such is the case for IOC research, which largely depends on theories and concepts from established organizational, management, and leadership research and does not always acknowledge the distinctiveness of IOC forms. This is the issue of *organizationality*, and it represents a key gap in the literature that future IOC leadership communication should address.

To be sure, notable studies have examined various aspects of organizational informality (Gulati & Puranam, 2009), partiality (Ahrne & Brunsson, 2019), temporality (Burke & Morley, 2016), and impermanence (Weick, 2009). Yet, there are still shortcomings in the ways in which this work is often situated within the broader discipline of organization studies and, relegated to "alternative organizations" (Parker et al., 2014) or "non-traditional organizations" (Harter & Krone, 2001), implying something inferior about these arrangements and reinforcing the idea that conventional organizational forms are normative. Likewise, a notable amount of this work focuses on overcoming the absence of traditional organizational features or explaining how organizations were able to be successful despite lacking characteristics of "normal" organizations (Cheney & Munshi, 2017).

Again, these approaches suggest that conventional organizational forms and attributes are still the framework for how we should understand various phenomena. But that is not how IOCs usually work. Instead, IOCs rarely achieve the status of a full organization but rather exist in various states of partiality and alternative forms that come in and out of existence depending on the nature of their work and the need to activate or manifest various levels of organizationality. The subject of organizationality involves questions about what organizations are, how human activity becomes recognized as organizations, how systems of order arise, and how these collectives function as legitimate actors in given problem domains (Dobusch & Schoeneborn, 2015) – all of which are key issues related to leadership communication and thus important for future IOC research. Plus, the issue of organizationality is related to issues of visibility discussed above (see Cruz, 2017), given that IOCs often involve organizational forms that are informal and partial, coming in and out of existence in ways that are more fluid and temporary with varying levels of visibility. Taken together, both *visibility* and *organizationality* represent important directions for future research on IOC leadership communication.

Conclusion

This chapter presented some of the key leadership communication dynamics of interorganizational collaboration, focusing on authority as the central problematic of IOC leadership and explaining several corresponding leadership communication practices that are central to IOC work. These includes key moments of trust and legitimacy, interaction design, and boundary work, while also highlighting important issues related to visibility and organizationality that warrant further investigation.

IOC leadership communication is not a list of specific tasks or responsibilities that are separate for leaders, but rather a way of thinking about all aspects of IOC work and how various practices and patterns of interaction create, sustain, and enhance the collective authority of these distinct organizational forms. Accordingly, this chapter builds upon previous research that aims to provide "design guidance" (Bryson et al., 2015) and "conceptual handles" (Huxham & Hibbert, 2011) to inform reflective practice versus definitional precision or discrete categorization. Thus, we should understand IOC leadership not as something that a person does, but rather as a collective process that unfolds and become a system property that different people steward at various times throughout the lifecycle of an IOC – what Denis et al. (2012) refer to as "producing leadership through interaction" by decentering individuals, or

"leadership as practice and in communication." In this regard, we can understand the centrality of authority like a prism, examining how authority shines through IOC work to enable leadership from a variety of communication practices – all of which is critical for the important interorganizational work needed to address complex issues and face the grand challenges confronting our society.

Notes

1. I make no claim to originality here; this is simply my best attempt to synthesize definitions and ideas from many influential sources such as: Gray (1989); Hardy et al. (2005); Heath & Isbell (2017); Huxham & Vangen (2013); Keyton et al. (2008); Lewis (2006).⏎
2. Drawing mainly from Koschmann, 2020; Koschmann et al., 2017; Koschmann & Burk, 2016; Koschmann & McDonald, 2015; Koschmann, 2013; and Koschmann et al., 2012 if you want more details.⏎
3. These challenges and complications of collaboration and authority are explained more extensively in a number of important research publications, such as Kahn & Kram (1994); Kellogg et al. (2006); Okhuysen & Bechky (2009).⏎

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16

LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION IN THE CONTEXT OF ORGANIZATIONAL CHANGE

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-19

Introduction

Periodic reviews of the organizational change (OC) literature over the decades have consistently pointed to leadership communication as a reliable factor in impacting change (e.g., Ford & Ford, 2011; Lewis, 2019; Lewis & Seibold, 1998; Oreg & Berson, 2019). For example, Ford and Ford (2011) concluded that among numerous leadership behaviors and change activities, communication is the only factor that "is most consistently related to change outcomes across different forms of leadership" (p. 29). Oreg and Berson's (2019) comprehensive meta-analytic review similarly concluded that beyond the common leadership styles, effective communication is one of the key functions of leaders' behavior in influencing organizational members' responses to change. In the field of organizational communication, Lewis and Seibold (1998) and Lewis (2019) offered the most comprehensive reviews and conceptual analyses of the organizational change literature from a communication perspective, in which leadership has the potential to emerge from different stakeholder positions.

However, what remains less clear in existing reviews is: What is the nature of leadership communication in the context of change and how does it impact change processes and outcomes in complex ways? This is the point of departure of this chapter. I will: (1) present a conceptual review of various approaches in which leadership communication of OC is theorized and key empirical findings regarding its processes

and effects on change; (2) provide guidance for the practice of leadership communication of OC; and (3) offer directions for future theoretical development and empirical investigations.

Toward these goals, I begin by defining the boundaries of this conceptual review and laying out a framework upon which the review is structured. First, it is uncontroversial to say that leadership, by definition, implies behaviors or (inter)actions that drive change, progress, and movement (Barge & Fairhurst, 2008; Bass, 2008; Jian, 2019; Oreg & Berson, 2019). However, the context of change can vary in scope, purpose, and/or complexity (Lewis, 2019; Poole & Van de Ven, 2021). The focus of this chapter is on planned organizational change, for example, restructuring, strategic shift, downsizing, and mergers. This choice is intended to reflect the majority of the empirical literature of change in which leadership communication research has been carried out.

Having defined the OC context, the next question becomes, what is leadership communication of OC? Several ways of conceptualizing leadership communication have emerged explicitly or implicitly in the OC literature. First, leadership communication is viewed as managing change-related information and messages by change agents in managerial positions. Thus, leadership is equated to management with communication being a slice or stylistic feature of the managerial behavior (e.g., Yue et al., 2019). Second, leadership communication is conceptualized as influential communicative performances by leadership actors (leaders, followers, or other constituents) in the social construction of meaning that constitutes change. Leadership communication takes the form of making and giving sense to change through conversation (e.g., Blackman et al., 2022; Ford & Ford, 1995; Jabri, 2016), narrative (e.g., Balogun, 2015; Boje et al., 2016; Buchanan & Dawson, 2007), rhetorical framing (e.g., Cornelissen et al., 2011; Silince, 2005), and the performance of paradoxes (Fairhurst & Putnam, 2024). Third, change communication is depicted as a discursive struggle (e.g., Al Mahameed, 2024; Jian, 2011) with unintended consequences (e.g., Jian, 2007a; Sahay & Goldthwaite, 2024). Here, leadership is theorized as an elitist discourse that the managerialist class seizes to gain identity, status, and dominance (Alvesson & Spicer, 2012; Guiette & Vandenbempt, 2017), or as an empty and floating signifier upon which those in managerial positions attach shifting organizational demands in the contention for power and control (e.g., MacKillop, 2018).

The remainder of this chapter first illustrates each of the above three themes and discusses their practical implications. After mapping the theoretical terrain and empirical landscape, the chapter suggests opportunities for future leadership communication research in OC.

Leadership Communication as Change Information Management

Resonating with the popular management literature, this first stream of research equates leadership communication to managing change-related information by change implementers regarding its content, flow, channel, and timing, all with the purpose of gaining support and advancing the managerial change agenda. A key assumption underlying this approach is that OC creates an informational environment characterized by uncertainty and ambiguity that results in organizational members' feeling of loss of control and direction, insecurity, distress, and cynicism (Bordia et al., 2004). To counter the uncertainty, leadership communication perceived as open and transparent is shown to lead to positive change outcomes (Li et al., 2021; Yue et al., 2023). *Transparency* refers to providing "truthful, substantial, and useful" information, involving stakeholders in identifying their information needs (bottom-up communication), and being accountable for the top-down information provided (Rawlins, 2009, pp. 74–75). Largely overlapping with Rawlins (2009), Homburg et al. (2012) described *openness* as providing information "proactively, promptly and completely" (p. 114). The concept of *realistic previews of change* (Lewis, 2019; Lewis et al., 2013; Schweiger & DeNisi, 1991) also denotes openness and transparency.

Empirical research suggests that transparent and open communication is significantly associated with employee reduced perceptions of uncertainty (Li et al., 2021) and threat appraisal (Yue et al., 2023), but with increased perceptions of trust (Yue et al., 2019), commitment, and identification (Neill et al., 2020). Similarly, Sguera et al. (2022) employed the term *informational justice* to refer to "timely, detailed, and sincere explanations regarding organizational decisions" (Colquitt, 2001) during change, finding its significant predictive effect on reduced levels of employee cynicism toward adverse OC initiatives, such as layoffs and wage reductions. Similarly, Schweiger and DeNisi's (1991) field experiment demonstrated the positive effects of realistic previews on employee perceptions of an organization's trustworthiness, honesty, and caring. However, Lewis et al. (2013) found no significant difference of two-sided (i.e., both positive and negative) change messages over one-sided (i.e., positive) ones in their effects on change recipients' assessment of implementer's trustworthiness and honesty.

Scholars also paid attention to the effect of change leaders' message features on employee commitment to change. For example, drawing upon the Elaboration Likelihood Model (Petty & Cacioppo, 1986), Bayraktar and Kabasakal (2022) conducted an experiment involving job security. In a high job insecurity context, the

effect of rational content in a change message was stronger than that of an emotional appeal on employee commitment to change. In a low job insecurity context, an emotional appeal combined with a strong delivery style had the strongest influence on commitment to change. More comprehensively, based on a conceptual review, Armenakis et al. (1999) proposed five components necessary for effective change messages, including discrepancy (i.e., difference between now and a desired future state), efficacy (i.e., sense of confidence in one's ability to succeed), appropriateness, principal support, and person valence (i.e., the extent to which the change addresses self-interest and fairness).

Motivated by theories of uncertainty reduction (Berger, 1987), uncertainty management (Brasher, 2001), and psychological contracts (Guest & Conway, 2002; Rousseau, 1995), another line of research highlights the role of middle managers and line supervisors in managing and mitigating employee uncertainty, gaining support, and fulfilling psychological contracts. Lewis (2019) described these roles as "connectors" from a stakeholder perspective (p. 111). While senior managers are considered the preferred sources of strategic information, direct supervisors are the preferred source of implementation-related and job-relevant information (Allen et al., 2007). Tanner and Otto (2016), for instance, found that high quality supervisor communication during change compensated for low job satisfaction resulted from low support from upper management. Bligh and Carsten's (2005) case study in a large healthcare system suggested that middle managers' downward and bottom-up communication helped preserve the psychological contracts with their employees, while upward communication with senior management crucially sustained managers' own psychological contracts as they faced comprehensive change.

Finally, studies accentuate the positive effects of leadership communication that involves bottom-up information flow and message strategies in OC (Lewis, 1999, 2019) on cultivating trust and innovative ideas (Den Hertog et al., 2010; Rodríguez-Sánchez et al., 2020; Yue et al., 2019), inducing commitment (Hill et al., 2012), and generating employee engagement (Reissner & Pagan, 2013). For example, in a two-wave survey study of a large government agency, Hill et al. (2012) showed that bottom-up communication (e.g., soliciting input from employees) by top management influenced employee affective commitment by overcoming employee anxiety and uncertainty. However, Lewis and Russ (2012) noted that change implementers' solicitation of input tended to favor those who are supportive of a change initiative but avoid those with "a more negative take" (p. 285).

In summary, this stream of research largely defines communication as the transmission of information with a strong focus on its quality (e.g., openness and transparency) and message features. Managerial control is unproblematized, and the stability of meaning is assumed. Methodologically, variable-analytic, survey-based studies are most common together with experimental designs that aim to test message effects.

The conceptualization of predominantly linear relationships between quantified leadership communication variables (e.g., communication openness) and change outcomes (e.g., employee commitment to change) yields easy-to-follow practical advice with common sense appeal. Guidelines include maintaining open and transparent communication, involving employees through two-way communication, and incorporating an array of communication channels or mediums. To be effective in two-way communication, Lewis (2019) recommended careful consideration when soliciting input from stakeholders.

However, missing from this stream of research is the dynamic and often complex construction of meaning that constitutes change as a fluid process. An interest in the meaning construction surrounding change processes led scholars to examine leadership actors' meaning making and meaning giving performance, which I describe next.

Leadership Communication as Influential Communicative Performance

A meaning-centered approach to leadership communication of OC is grounded in several theoretical developments, including, sensemaking theory (Weick, 1995; Weick et al., 2005), speech act theory (Austin, 1962; Searl, 1979), narrative theories (Boje, 2001; Czarniawska, 1998), rhetorical theories (Cornelissen et al., 2011; Silience, 2005) and, more recently, a communication-oriented paradox approach (Fairhurst & Putnam, 2024). Building on these theoretical traditions, leadership communication of OC is conceptualized as influential discursive and embodied performance by leadership actors (i.e., leaders as the primary symbolizing agents or co-creators of meaning) in the form of conversation, narrative, and rhetorical accounts to make and give meaning, thus, constituting the process of change. The following reviews literature on sensemaking, sensegiving, and sensebreaking that provide a broad conceptual base for this stream of research, and then surveys several key strands of research animated by this work.

First, organizational change creates circumstances that are uncertain, unintelligible, ambiguous, or different from the routine or "expected state of the world" (Weick et al.,

2005, p. 409). Thus, sensemaking as a discursive process turns an ambiguous and uncertain circumstance into "a situation that is comprehended explicitly in words [i.e., conversation and text] and that serves as a springboard to action" (Taylor & Van Every, 2000, p. 40). Therefore, leadership communication involves addressing such questions as "what's the story here?" and "now what should [I/we] do?" (Weick et al., 2005, p. 410). However, early studies of sensemaking in OC contexts (Gioia & Chittipeddi, 1991; Gioia et al., 1994) showed that the ambiguity of a change could be, in part, by leaders' design to strategically destabilize the status quo and signal impending changes, a process that Pratt (2000) and Mantere et al. (2012) termed *sensebreaking*.

Second, leadership sensemaking is saturated with the use of symbols, metaphors, and narratives that are not simply representations of meaning and action but the very instruments of materializing influence and making change happen (Boje et al., 2016; Cornelissen et al., 2011; Czarniawska, 2004; Gioia & Chittipeddi, 1991; Gioia et al., 1994; Sillince & Golant, 2017; Vaara & Tienari, 2011). Because sensemaking is highly contextual, leaders must maintain interpretive flexibility (e.g., Bien & Sassen, 2020), which is imperative in organizations constituted by loosely-coupled units. For example, in their case study of sustainability transition in a German university, Bien and Sassen (2020) found that "identifying specific meaning in each discipline is a crucial step in change management to subsequently connect the overarching transformative vision to the personal level" (p. 10). In addition, institutional contexts are sources of interpretive frames for sensemaking (Weber & Glynn, 2006). Khan's (2018) study of microfinance in Pakistan shows that institutional contexts can come from a field of practice, such as commercial banking, or from broader society (e.g., the tribal cultural norms and beliefs). Leadership actors have to switch interpretive frames when responding to local situational demands (e.g., due to legitimacy challenges).

Third, sensemaking involves not only leaders making sense of ambiguous and changing circumstances for themselves while drawing upon a framework of change but also giving sense (i.e., *sensegiving*) to, and influencing the sensemaking of, other stakeholders (Gioia & Chittipeddi, 1991; Gioia et al., 1994). In a longitudinal case study, Logemann et al. (2019) challenged previous understandings of sensegiving as merely conveying meanings (the semantic effect) already formed by leaders. Rather, they argued, sensegiving can also afford a form or scaffolding ("the pragmatic effect") that organizational members can use to construct meaning of their own. Building upon and complementing the notion of sensemaking, sensegiving, and sensebreaking are four strands of research examining leadership communication of OC as conversational

performance, narrative performance, rhetorical performance, and performance of paradoxes.

Conversational Performance

Influenced by speech act theory (Austin, 1962; Searle, 1979), the seminal work by Ford and Ford (1995) argues that OC takes place in intentional conversations instigated by leaders or change agents. With "specific conversations [producing] specific aspects of change" (p. 556), they include initiation, understanding, performance, and closure. These conversations can be iterative, and leaders should take ownership to prevent breakdowns in the change process. Later empirical work demonstrates this approach's effectiveness in facilitating behavioral change and amending mental models (e.g., Blackman et al., 2022). Other recent research also looks at how change readiness takes place at the conversation level between change leaders and recipients, showing that solution-focused communication elicits change readiness, whereas problem-focused communication engenders resistance (Endrejat et al., 2020).

In contrast to a rather functional view of conversation, Jabri (2016; Jabri et al., 2008) grounds change conversation in Bakhtin's conception of dialogue. To engage the diversity of ideas and achieve a deeper identification with them, dialogical interaction must transcend individual consciousness toward a social consciousness. Jabri argues that managers who tend towards monologue dominate change conversations to create superficial unity or false consensus. In contrast, leading change is about creating a dialogic space and facilitating the production of surplus of meanings through participation, rather than forming consensus or arriving at one collective understanding.

Finally, seeing leadership communication from the lens of a practical art, Barge (2014) argues that to influence change is "to invite, design, and coordinate conversations using different mediums" (p. 69) and "to pivot from one conversation to another" (p. 74) in order to co-create meaning and advance the task. He emphasizes the practice of a relationally responsive approach to reflexivity in managing conversations by paying attention to the context and the consequences of our communication (Barge, 2004).

Narrative Performance

According to Czarniawska (1998), narratives are discursive accounts in which a plot threads together "an original state of affairs, an action or an event, and the consequent

affairs" (p. 2). Buchanan and Dawson (2007) argue that OC is a multi-story process. Narrative performance is central to the sensemaking and sensegiving necessary for leading change. First of all, narratives are discursive resources that help leaders construct a frame for change. For example, Boje et al. (2016) showed how antenarratives (i.e., living stories that are incomplete and fragmented) were linked to grand corporate narratives (or storylines) to make the case for strategic change. In the context of international mergers, senior leaders marshalled globalist antenarratives to legitimatize mergers and establish new corporate identities, while being in dialogue or in conflict with nationalist and regionalist antenarratives (Vaara & Tienari, 2011).

Second, leaders use strategic ambiguity to intentionally create multiple narratives to simultaneously engage different stakeholders, maneuver meaning, and hedge their bets for the future (Eisenberg, 1984). Narrative performance as a multi-story process effectively challenges such simple dichotomies as change agents/recipients, positive/negative change, and change acceptance/resistance, which populate the OC literature. For example, Balogun's (2015) narrative study revealed that senior managers of a large multi-national corporation constructed two sets of narratives in order to make sense of their change experience, one as recipients of a wider organizational change directed by corporate executives and another as change agents in their local contexts. These managers ongoingly connected these two narratives, which evolved over time given the shifting local change context. Because senior managers were both change recipients and agents, resistance and acceptance of the changes proved more dynamic and ambiguous than previously assumed.

Rhetorical Performance

Research from the rhetorical tradition defines leadership communication of OC as employing rhetorical devices, frames, or accounts to shape values and foster identification. For example, Cornelissen et al. (2011) argued that a strategic change was more likely to be considered legitimate when leaders applied metaphors and analogies that were relationally and culturally familiar to their stakeholders. To shift employee identity from deidentification with old values and practices to reidentification with new ones, Fiol (2002) stressed the importance of using common language markers as rhetorical devices, such as negation ("not") or inclusive referents (e.g., "we").

Social account theory (Bies, 1987; Cobb et al., 2001) offers another rhetorical lens by classifying the explanations leaders make for change into three types: causal (i.e., emphasizing external forces), ideological (i.e., appeal to higher order values), and

referential (i.e., offering a point of reference). Ideological accounts were found to have a stronger association with employee trust in management than other types of accounts (Arnestad et al., 2019; Tucker, 2013).

Rhetorical performance also includes leaders' deployment of other forms of rhetorical frames. For instance, Silince (2005) identified differentiation and integration rhetoric by top management when framing change to adapt to contingent, uncertain environments. While integration rhetoric includes the rhetorical processes of creating purpose and consistency (e.g., a coherent strategy), differentiation rhetoric takes the form of emphasizing context (i.e., paying attention to local circumstances and variations), and switching perspectives (i.e., incorporating multiple voices and points of view and involving comparison and contestation among accounts) (Silince, 2005). Silince (2005) argues that integration rhetoric has to be balanced with differentiation rhetoric.

Performance of Paradox

Recognizing that OC is fraught with paradoxes and tensions and that organizational actors construct paradoxes while engaging them (Fairhurst, 2019; Ford & Ford, 1994; Jian, 2007b; Lewis, 2000; Lüscher et al., 2006; Lüscher & Lewis, 2008; Smith et al., 2017), research that adopts a performative lens of paradox (Fairhurst & Putnam, 2024; see Chapter 3 by Fairhurst in this volume) attends to the practice, process, and temporality of constructing and responding to paradoxes as they unfold over time (Fairhurst & Putnam, 2024). A performative approach has produced unique insights in leadership communication of OC.

First, leadership actors communicatively construct paradoxes in affecting and materializing change. For example, Jarzabkowski and Lê (2017) revealed how middle managers tasked with implementing change used humor to interactionally construct paradoxes and to legitimize their responses to paradoxical tensions. On the negative side, studies have shown how managers' mixed, contradictory or ambivalent messages, especially in double-bind situations, can lead to resistance and paralysis (e.g., Larson & Tompkins, 2005; Lüscher et al., 2006). Furthermore, leadership actors of OC were also found to communicatively construct *knotted* (e.g., multiple interdependent) paradoxes that "mutually impact one another in either prismatic (amplifying) or anti-prismatic (mitigating) ways," leading to innovative action or inaction (Sheep et al., 2017, p. 469).

Second, leadership communication of OC also takes the form of creating discursive spaces that allow organizational members to work through paradoxes. For example, managers at Legos worked through paradoxes in *sparring sessions* where collective sensemaking and workable solutions took place through paradoxical inquiry and collaborative interaction (Lüscher & Lewis, 2008). In the context of implementing regulatory change, Jian and Fairhurst (2025) identified what they called *phronetic pivoting* that involved the creation of safe conversational spaces and empathic learning to allow organizational systems to pivot from one paradoxical pole to the other without losing sight of its opposite.

Finally, in longitudinal case studies of change (e.g., Abdallah et al., 2011; Archambault-Janvier et al., 2025; Cuganesan, 2017), strategic responses to paradoxes cannot resolve paradoxes once and for all; success in the short term may paradoxically sow the seed of failure in the longer term; and paradoxical poles often move dialectically over time. As an example, by tracking how a large international corporation managed the paradox of openness-closeness to voices of stakeholders in making corporate strategic shift, Archambault-Janvier et al. (2025) discovered that voice opening and closing oscillated over time but not in a mutually exclusive manner, that is, "some form of closure needs to be nurtured during the opening process" and vice versa (p. 1). As another example, Abdallah et al.'s (2011) case study documented how organizational leaders constructed transcendent discourse that reconciled contradictory demands in the short term. However, the factors that enabled the transcendent discourse's short-term success, including "quasi-resolution of conflict, strategic ambiguity, and groupthink," undermined its sustainability over the longer term and allowed the contradictions to resurface (Abdallah et al., 2011, p. 333).

In summary, research on leadership communication of OC examined through influential communicative performances has accumulated significant insights that buttress and advance the proposition that change takes place *in* and *through* communication, instead of the other way around (Ford & Ford, 1995; Jian, 2011; Lewis, 2019). Although research from the rhetorical and narrative traditions continues to center individual leader/rhetor/narrator's account in its analysis, the agency of leadership in the performance of paradox and conversation has taken a much more collective and interactional form. Finally, because many studies in this stream of research employ longitudinal cases, instead of cross-sectional surveys, leadership emerges in a complex, iterative process of meaning negotiation. Meanings that start at the top get refashioned when interacting with middle managers or other key change constituents. Many studies in this stream of research demonstrate that change is a dynamic, communicative

accomplishment over time with shifting meanings and evolving outcomes that are deeply shaped by its organizational and institutional contexts.

Because of its focus on the situated practice and performance of leadership communication of OC, the above findings often directly serve as practical suggestions for those leading or managing change. For example, practicing managers can benefit from Barge's (2014) advice on designing and leading conversations in situations of key leadership change. Besides focusing on one particular form of communicative performance, Logemann et al. (2019) suggest that change leaders combine rhetorical framing with narratives in order to amplify the effect of sensegiving and sensemaking. Jian's (2019) hermeneutic model of leadership could be used as a theoretical basis for developing reflexivity and sensitivity to both narrative and conversation in the co-production of meaning. Such reflexivity is especially critical in working through paradoxes of change (Fairhurst, 2019). Along with Cunha and Putnam (2019), Fairhurst (2019) recommended adopting "reflection-in-action" in such forms as collaborative dialogue, reframing, and challenging boundaries (p. 17) to develop the capacity of recognizing, constructing, and responding to paradoxes.

Despite the impressive depth this body of work has achieved in uncovering the complexity of leadership communication of change, what is largely missing is theorizing OC as a political process in which power effects change through communication. In particular, there is a need to critically examine how communication in the guise of contemporary managerialist leadership discourse and neoliberal discourse operates to establish managerial hegemony and colonizes the lifeworld of organizations (Deetz, 1992). The following delves into this critical stream of scholarship.

Leadership Communication as Discursive Struggle over Power and Control

The critical scholarship of leadership communication of OC casts leadership communication as the process of discursive struggle over power and control. First, building upon critical leadership studies (Alvesson & Spicer, 2012; Collinson, 2005; Harding, 2014; Learmonth & Morrell, 2021; see Chapter 6 by Collinson in this volume), research conceptualizes leadership as an empty signifier (Laclau & Mouffe, 1985; Jian, 2011; Kelly, 2014; MacKillop, 2018) and leadership communication as the production of managerialist hegemony. As Kelly (2014) contends, as an empty but seductive signifier,

> the very purpose of [leadership] is not to provide a single meaning, but to create a space through which possible meanings can be negotiated and navigated... the empty signifier 'leadership' provides the space for an exercise of power in the form of deciding whose interpretation matters most.
>
> (p. 914)

For example, MacKillop (2018) argues that:

> change and its leadership can be analysed as the constant mobilization of strategies of inclusion and exclusion (political logics), drawing up of rules, values and norms (social logics) and mobilising individual fears and desires (fantasmatic logics) to hegemonise those spaces and manage grievances.
>
> (p. 218)

As shown in Jian (2011), leadership communication creates discursive closure and establishes managerial hegemony through the neoliberal discourse of the free market and the authority of social scientific knowledge. For example, a social psychological stage model of organizational change when mobilized through talk can redefine the power relationship in OC, such as when the managerial identity shifts to psychological counselors who exercise power over change dissenters as psychotic patients (Jian, 2011).

Further revealing how OC occasions the (re)production of managerialism, Guiette and Vandenbempt (2017) coined the term "change managerialism" to represent a broader managerial discourse that marks managerial superiority. Features include top-down control, standardization, crisis rhetoric, and grandiose vocabularies. Change managerialism inhibited the micro-processes of sensemaking at the level of middle management and professional staff by constraining reflexivity and the enactment of meaning, resulting in a manufactured "close-mindedness" (Alvesson & Willmott, 2012) and a false sense of control. In Al Mahameed et al.'s (2024) case study of corporatization of U.K. universities, the COVID-19 pandemic functioned as a catalyst and discursive resource to legitimize greater managerial control and further undermine the power position and identity of academic faculty. Finally, in a critical semiological analysis of a once cooperative city orchestra, corporate change discourse emerged as myth construction of the managerialist ideology that symbolized power, status, and success to gain credibility and establish hegemony (Bathurst & Monin, 2010).

Second, critical research of leadership communication in the context of OC establishes how discourse as language-in-use associates with specific forms of power

and the interactive production of power relationships that effect change. The pioneering work by Fairhurst et al. (1995) showed how, at the conversational level, traditional authority relationships were reinforced and reproduced in manager-initiated discussion patterns and employee approval-seeking behaviors that constituted inertia toward more democratic power relationships. As such, leadership as the enactment of power and control requires attention to the communicative interaction *between* leaders and followers instead of focusing solely on leader's change-oriented behavior. Such an interactional approach was taken up by Sonenshein's (2010) narrative study, in which managers were shown to intentionally produce equivocal narratives to maximize control over employee interpretations, while employees were able to "embellish" and reinterpret the narratives with subversive meanings that resisted change.

Finally, dialectical views of organization and change also adopt the critical line of inquiry (Benson, 1977; Fairhurst & Collinson, 2023; Van de Ven & Poole, 1995; see Chapter 6 by Collinson and Chapter 3 by Fairhurst in this volume), in which contradictions in a system animate change and generate unintended consequences. In a longitudinal case study of successive downsizing efforts, leadership discourse constructed contradictory downsizing strategies as derivatives of the primary contradiction between managerial interests in profits and workers' interests in employment stability (Fairhurst et al., 2002). In a process model, Jian (2007a) sharpened the focus on the social construction of unintended consequences through communication in a dialectical power relationship between senior management and employees. Furthermore, Sahay and Goldthwaite's (2024) analysis of OC in a healthcare organization revealed that change implementers constructed participation as a control technique by limiting its meaning and scope in order to curb resistance but, paradoxically, engendered greater resistance as an unintended consequence.

Examining leadership communication of OC from a critical perspective generates two broad practical takeaways. First, by revealing the power-laden, contradictory, and emergent processes of change with unintended consequences, these studies pay greater attention to the *collective* management of emergent tensions (contra leaders as the primary symbolizing agents). There is a sensitivity to the dialectic of power and control, along with an openness to alternative interpretive schemes and creative ways of meaning construction. Second, by exposing OC as a process of managerial hegemony and leadership as an empty and floating signifier, the scholarship empowers organizational members to contest the meaning of leadership by developing emancipatory voices and resisting managerial domination.

Directions for Future Research

As shown above, research has engendered significant insights into leadership communication of OC in the last few decades. However, significant gaps remain in relation to three fundamental issues that all theories of change must address implicitly or explicitly, as Van de Ven and Poole (2021) argued: people, space, and time. The first gap concerns people and space. As the stakeholder theory of OC (Lewis, 2019) suggests, the agents of OC leadership are not singular but consists of a wide array of interconnected leadership actors from managers at different levels in different units, to change implementation teams, and opinion leaders from the lower ranks who occupy distinct social and physical spaces in organizations. For example, Gibson and Groom (2021) showed that middle managers needed to manage up, down, and across in order to successfully navigate the political challenges of OC. Yet, theory and research tend to focus on the messages, behavior, or performance of a particular category of change agents (e.g., senior managers or middle managers). Future leadership communication research of OC must theorize the interaction and negotiation among leadership actors at different levels and in various spaces (i.e., professional, hierarchical, geographical, and political) to better understand system, not just interactional, change dynamics. The theoretical framework of collective leadership (Fairhurst et al., 2020) and stakeholder theory (Lewis, 2019) could be promising starting points in this direction.

Second, also related to people, research is scarce in addressing the role of emotion in relation to leadership communication in the context of OC, although there are a few notable exceptions. For example, Harikkala-Laihinen (2022) observed that top-down information sharing may alleviate negative emotions but without the benefit of generating positivity, while interactive communication practices, such as dialogue, creates positive emotions during change. Huy et al.'s (2014) longitudinal study of a change process revealed senior leaders' communicative behaviors influenced how middle managers emotionally reacted to and judged the formers' legitimacy, and middle managers' emotional reactions and legitimacy judgements shifted over the course of change. Furthermore, as mentioned earlier, emotional appeals in leaders' change messages can have potent effects on recipients' commitment to change (Bayraktar & Kabasakal, 2022). Affect also has been shown to be an integral part of change leaders' narrative evaluations of change (Balogun et al., 2015). These studies suggest very complex relationships between emotions and leadership communication, which may shape both the trajectory and outcomes of change. Future research should further explore and theorize how emotions constitute the communicative performance of change

leadership, including narrative effects on the body when the pace or effects of change turn chaotic (Fairhurst & Putnam, 2024).

Third, OC inevitably involves changes to the material world around us, thus expanding our understanding of space from being merely levels of analysis (Poole and Van de Ven, 2021) to include considerations of physical and material influences. However, there is a dearth of understanding how leadership communication is related to materiality in making sense of and shaping change. Guiette and Vandenbempt (2017) captured a glimpse of these effects in artefacts like new stationary, logos, and car stickers, which "helped to make the transition from the conceptual sphere of the change discourse to the pragmatic sphere of lived reality" (p. 70). Tan et al. (2015) demonstrated how online video texts (e.g., vlogs) constructed different leadership styles and managerialism during a university restructuring initiative. Building upon the theoretical development in communicative constitution of organization (Bencherki et al., 2022; Clifton et al., 2021), future research should more systematically investigate and theorize the joint effect of materiality and communication (both online and offline) in achieving OC leadership.

Finally, temporality defines change. What works well in one stage of a change process may fail in the next. Research development that incorporates time has been uneven. On the one hand, there has been a growing number of longitudinal studies from the interpretive and critical streams of research, which track the shifting dynamic of leadership communication in the unfolding process of change (e.g., Abdallah et al., 2011; Archambault et al., 2025; Cuganesan, 2017; Fairhurst et al., 2002; MacHillop, 2018). On the other hand, the research stream that focuses on change information management is largely confined to a cross-sectional understanding of change. To advance the research here would require incorporating time into conceptual models and methodological designs.

Conclusion

This chapter has presented three research streams of leadership communication in the context of OC. Each stream has cast leadership communication from a unique lens ranging from a focus on managerial information management to influential communicative performance and discursive struggle over power and control. As shown above, each body of literature has accumulated significant theoretical and practical insights into the ways in which leadership communication both constitutes change and impacts its processes and outcomes. Future research should draw upon the pluralistic

development surveyed here and strive to develop more comprehensive theories to explain its richness and complexity and better inform change leadership practice.

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Further Reading

Balogun, J., Bartunek, J. M., & Do, B. (2015). Senior managers' sensemaking and responses to strategic change. *Organization Science*, *26*(4), 960–979. (A narrative

analysis that demonstrates the dual role that leadership actors assume as change recipients/change agents while making and giving sense to themselves and others and mediating local and wider organizational changes.)

Jian, G. (2011). Articulating circumstance, identity, and practice: Toward a discursive framework of organizational changing. *Organization*, *18*(1), 45–64. (A model of leading change as discursive struggle.)

Lewis, L. K. (2019). *Organizational change: Creating change through strategic communication* (2nd ed.). Wiley Blackwell. (A comprehensive review of the organizational change literature from the perspective of communication and stakeholder theory.)

Oreg, S., & Berson, Y. (2019). Leaders' impact on organizational change: Bridging theoretical and methodological chasms. *Academy of Management Annals*, *13*(1), 272–307. (A meta-analytical review that integrates the literatures of leadership and organizational change.)

Poole, M. S., & Van de Ven, A. H. (Eds.) (2021). *The Oxford handbook of organizational change and innovation* (2nd ed.). Oxford University Press. (A comprehensive coverage of the literature on organizational change.)

17

LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION AND RESISTANCE

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-20

From a communication perspective, both organizational leadership and resistance entail symbolic influence processes. However, scholars have conceptualized the relationship between organizational leadership and resistance in multiple ways. After a brief overview of these concepts, this chapter delineates how scholars' theoretical perspective influences their understanding of power, which has significant implications for their theorizing of the relationships among communication, leadership, and resistance.

As we will discuss, many functionalist and normative researchers understand power in episodic terms as the apparent, often interpersonal, exercise of authority around conflict. The approach reflects the (still largely) dominant managerial stance in leadership communication literature, where the concept of resistance emerged as an important problem for managers. The chapter describes a significant body of research concerned with overcoming employee resistance to management directives. However, we also observe a line of episodic research that views resistance as a potential organizational resource. We then compare how critical researchers' systemic view of power, which interrogates apparent consensus for hidden conflicts, challenges managerial biases in the literature. Although suspicion of leadership as a form of hegemony leads some critical scholars to avoid or critique the very concept of leadership, there are several lines of critical leadership studies that dialectically highlight the power-ridden and performative dynamics in the leader-follower

relationship (Fairhurst & Collinson, 2023). Some of these approaches conceptualize employee non-compliance as a valuable tool in marking the limits of managerial power, while others theorize organizing resistance *as* leadership, introducing concepts such as "resistance leadership" or "anti-establishment leadership" (Fairhurst et al., 2008; Sinha et al., 2019). After discussing research exemplars in these areas, the chapter ends by describing agendas for future research.

Overview: Conceptualizing Leadership and Resistance

To begin, we provide a brief overview of different ways that leadership and resistance have been understood. Leadership may be treated as the property of organizational roles (e.g., management), as a set of personal traits and behaviors such as charisma (Beal, 2016; Fairhurst et al., 2020; Offord et al., 2016), or in more constructionist terms, as a symbolic process including individual or collective forms of influence and coordinating action (Fairhurst, 2007; Fairhurst & Connaughton, 2014). For example, a constructive approach to studying leadership, particularly relational or empathetic forms of leadership, "conceptualizes leadership as constituted in communicative actions and collective meaning-making in interdependent contexts" (Jian, 2021, p. 933). Examining leadership as a process bound up with followership is consonant with theoretical perspectives such as the "communicative constitution of organizations" that view organizing as a medium and outcome of communication processes (McPhee & Zaug, 2009). Resistance is also conceptualized in many ways, generally highlighting forms of non-compliance with or opposition to dominant norms, policies, and/or directives in organizational settings (Zoller & Ban, 2024). Similar to conceptualizations of leadership, resistance may be treated as more individual or more collective (Ganesh et al., 2005), as well as relatively covert or overt (Fairhurst et al., 2020). Resistance may be treated in psychological terms, such as attitudes (e.g., rejecting managerial frames for behavior), or as communicatively enacted, such as disagreement, confrontation, or even strikes (Fleming & Spicer, 2007; Ganesh & Zoller, 2012).

By focusing on opposition, the concept of resistance is dialectically linked with power. Surveying empirical studies of leadership dialectics in the past 20+ years, Fairhurst and Collinson (2023) found that power is a concept frequently and closely connected to leadership yet "often ignored in leadership studies" (p. 494). Further, the authors suggest the need to address the missing "power" link in leadership literatures by exploring power in multiple and interwoven forms.

Our review finds that researchers' orientation to the relationship between leadership and resistance depends on explicit or implicit assumptions about organizational power. In organizational communication, power is invoked when we view organizing as a communicative struggle among competing interests. More functionalist and managerially focused researchers conceptualize power episodically (Foldy & Ospina, 2022), meaning that they focus on the direct exercise of power, such as influence, coercion, or manipulation. From an episodic view of power, leadership is understood in terms of the legitimized right to decision-making power based on positioning within organizational hierarchies. Episodic views conceptualize power in terms of the direct exercise of authority, coercion, or manipulation based on individual skills, resources, or authority (Fleming & Spicer, 2007). Other leadership scholars theorize power as systemic. Often associated with critical scholarship, a systemic viewpoint conceptualizes power as pervasive in constituting relationships of domination and control. Critical organizational communication researchers view power in terms of discursive formations that foster taken-for-granted assumptions that become sedimented as "common sense" assumptions about reality that influence material and institutional practices (Fairhurst, 2007; Fairhurst, 2008; Hardy & Phillips, 2004; Mumby, 2001; Pal, 2014; Parker, 2016; Wodak et al., 2011). Thus, the direct exercise of power results from the complex negotiation of deeper structures of meaning. These structures produce hierarchies, legitimate authority, and influence resource distribution. As a result, leadership may be associated with forms of hegemony or with resistance itself.

In the next section, we delineate some key ways in which resistance and leadership are conceptualized when leadership is understood episodically as an individual form of influence. Then, we will discuss systemic views, wherein leadership's connection to episodic power is situated within larger systems of domination.

Episodic Power – Viewing Leadership as Individuals Carrying out Organizational Roles

A significant body of research theorizes leadership and resistance in terms of an episodic exercise of power. Much of this research locates leadership within organizational hierarchies. We identify two primary orientations toward episodic power within the literature on leadership-resistance dynamics. In the first, the role of leadership is understood in the context of overcoming the irrationality of subordinate resistance. This line of research is interested in how leaders exercise individual or institutional power to generate consent among employees/organizational members.

Analyzing power dynamics often entails examining interpersonal dynamics between leaders and resisters, including issues such as satisfaction, authority, and decision-making. The second way of understanding leadership and resistance follows a pluralist logic of organizational rationality, treating dissent as routine and potentially beneficial for leaders who can harness the creative energy of dissenting voices.

Leadership as Organizational Agent(s) Overcoming Resistance

In this area of literature, resistance is often understood as one of the ways that organizational members react to power relations enacted in leadership behavior. For example, in their study of leader-follower interactions in a military organization, Offord et al. (2016) compared three categories of follower reactions to leadership: engagement, disengagement, and leveling. Offord et al. (2016) viewed leveling as "resistance to leadership," characterized by challenges to the leader's authority or status through conspicuous communication and demonstration of dissent. In a similar study in the military context, Beal (2016) offered examples of how organizational members level unrealistic leader demands with "animated language and gestures… for example, direct criticism, feigned ignorance, mocking or gossip" (p. 11). This understanding of leveling focuses on the situational aspect of the leader-follower relationship – resistance is conceptualized in the context of specific leadership behaviors.

Episodic research frequently focuses on how leadership can overcome employee dissent to reassert managerial control (Bemmels & Reshef, 1991; Coch & French, 2016; Collinson, 1994; Kotter & Schlesinger, 1979). Indeed, early leadership frameworks drew from political and social theories that equated leadership with the process of creating consent (Ainsworth & Flathman, 1995; Bernays, 2016). Expanding into the business context, promoting consent was thus treated as a key responsibility of management and a valuable pathway to achieving managerial control (Ciulla, 2015; Presthus, 1958). For example, Bergen (1940) suggested that "[j]ust as political government functions with the consent of the governed, so also must management function with the consent of the managed" (p. 276). In practice, leaders may view employee dissent as a threat to their legitimate authority (Garner, 2014).

These approaches often reflect paternalistic views of management-employee relationships. In this view, resistance is irrational and detrimental to organizational stability and efficiency by generating problematic conflict. When resistance is seen as a battle between employee self-interest and leaders' commitment to organizational well-

being, resistance is framed as inherently unfavorable and in need of suppression (Coch & French, 2016; Waddell & Sohal, 1998). This orientation leads a significant body of organizational and leadership communication literature to treat resistance, especially overt resistance such as dissent, as something to be managed and countered by leaders who occupy legitimate roles in the hierarchy (Ansoff, 2006; Pondy, 2006; Tichy & Ulrich, 1984).

A major strand of this research focuses on management overcoming employee resistance to *change*. In this view, employees seek to maintain the status quo in the face of managerial initiatives and/or attempts at transformation (Ansoff, 1965; Zaltman & Duncan, 1977). Employees' recalcitrance is treated as a counterproductive challenge to leadership (Bemmels & Reshef, 1991; Collinson, 1994; Kotter & Schlesinger, 1979; Waddell & Sohal, 1998). Employees' negative attitudes towards change may be framed as rational or irrational (Neck, 1996), including concerns about loss of status and pay (Dent & Goldberg, 2016), threats to security and stability, and/or fear of uncertainty (Bateh et al., 2013).

Researchers are concerned with assessing which leadership styles can prevent the disruption of non-compliance. For example, Appelbaum et al. (2015) posit that leadership styles serve as "inputs" that moderate employee reactions to change. They found that transactional, transformational, and change-oriented leadership styles are associated with alleviating employees' anxieties pertaining to change. Scholarship also suggests that "ethical leadership" styles, based on "normatively appropriate conduct" reduce and deter employee deviance and resistance during times of change (Brown et al., 2005; Neves et al., 2017; Rahaman et al., 2020). Thus, managerial roles, attributes, behaviors, and communication skills are conceptualized as a way to reduce resistance to change (Lundy, 2013). Authors in this area suggest that it is important to train organizational leaders so that they can prevent or overcome resistance to change (Appelbaum et al., 2015; Bateh et al., 2013).

Leadership as Organizational Agent(s) Harnessing Dissent

In general, leadership models and styles that espouse a pluralistic logic of organizations recognize multiple rationalities within the organizing process and may therefore be more likely to view resistance as a routine, mundane part of organizational life. This second approach within the episodic framework treats dissent in more positive terms. It is no longer the goal of leaders to eradicate resistance through concentrated authority. As more research theorizes tension and disorganization as a routine feature of

organizing (Ashcraft & Trethewey, 2017), complete consent is viewed as unrealistic or undesirable. As a result, researchers and practitioners may treat dissent as a relatively rational reaction that serves as a source of feedback that allows leaders to improve organizational functioning.

For example, the dissent literature focuses on employee non-compliance with norms and organizational requirements based on personal ethical considerations (Kassing, 2009) or concerns with the organization's best interests (Piderit, 2000). Dissent researchers, who generally theorize leadership in terms of supervisory/managerial roles, assess how supervisor communication influences the potential for resistance and reacts to dissent when it occurs. For example, Garner (2014) delineated different ways that leaders respond to dissent – on a spectrum that ranges from "open doors" to "iron cages" approaches. Dissent researchers are concerned with how effective leadership communication can positively impact individual outcomes, such as employee satisfaction, commitment, and performance, as well as organizational outcomes, such as improved decision-making, innovation, and organizational cohesion (Garner, 2014; Peterson, 1997; Rowland & Parry, 2009; Tourish, 2014). Taking a consensus rather than conflict orientation to power, much of the dissent literature presumes that effective forms of employee dissent and dissent management serve the interests of the organization as a whole (Garner, 2014; Kassing, 2009; and see Zoller & Ban, Forthcoming).

Researchers who focus on ways that organizational leaders can harness resistance point to negative outcomes when dissent voices are controlled or suppressed. For example, researchers observed that dissent suppression strategies can actually trigger more resistance (Sprague, 2013).

Researchers also found that top-down suppression can reduce dissenting voices at the cost of member morale and organizational growth. For example, Milliken et al. (2003) found that many employees do not speak up about organizational problems because they fear being ostracized, experience retaliation, or believe that actions would be futile. These perceptions are often based on past organizational experiences. The researchers suggest that leaders who desire to surface employee concerns about organizational problems will have to overcome these prior experiences.

Similarly, Bisel et al. (2012) used the term "hierarchical mum effect" to describe organizational members' reluctance to carry out boat-rocking or dissenting forms of communication, even when these are considered important to organizational effectiveness. Bisel et al. associate the hierarchical mum effect with the way resistive voices in organizations are muted and suppressed, linking micro-level supervisor-

subordinate interactions with macro-level organizational outcomes. "When bottom-up disagreement is suppressed by the communicative context of subordinate-supervisor relationships, ignorance grows, while learning and adaptation falter" (p. 137).

Another strand of this research promotes transformational leadership as a means to effectively harness the creative energy from conflicts and disagreements to spur organizational innovation. For example, a growing body of scholarly work elaborates on the effectiveness of transformational leadership in fomenting productive forms of resistance. Nijstad et al.'s (2012) study of innovation surveyed the members of 36 top management teams about minority dissent and leadership. They found that the presence of minority dissent was positively associated with teams developing radical innovations (e.g., major technological development such as switching to electricity as a form of fuel for automobiles), even after controlling for other factors such as team size, diversity, and conflict. They also found that the relationship between minority dissent and radical innovation was stronger in the presence of transformational leadership. Nijstad and colleagues argued that transformational leadership contributes to a psychologically safe team climate, which stimulates minority input that triggers radical innovations.

One key point of confluence among these episodic approaches to power is an analytical focus on the individual abilities and styles of leaders in managing conflict with subordinates. Additionally, reflecting a consensus viewpoint guiding functionalist and some interpretive research (Deetz, 2001), this research tends to reinforce managerial goals, emphasizing ways to meet or enhance existing organizational goals and practices. As a result, the analysis of individual communicative events – leaders promoting obedience, compliance, or other forms of consent that foreclose or overcome resistance – is often abstracted from broader systems of power.

Systemic Power – Understanding Leadership in the Critique of Domination and Subjectification

In contrast to that consensus orientation, systemic views of power (Fleming & Spicer, 2007; Foldy & Ospina, 2022; Mumby, 2001) highlight apparent and hidden conflicts marking the organizing process (Deetz, 2001). Critical researchers capture dynamics of domination and subjectification by investigating how actors "mobilize institutional, ideological and discursive resources to influence organizational activity" (Fleming & Spicer, 2007, p. 240). Many critical scholars view power and resistance dialectically

as mutually constitutive (Mumby, 2016). This has implications for the study of leadership.

Critical scholarship situates visible, episodic instances of conflict within larger discursive dynamics that influence taken-for-granted assumptions, cultural norms, and practices. These dynamics include the privileging of meaning in ways that construct and legitimate the influence of certain groups as leaders (Ashcraft & Mumby, 2004; Mumby & Clair, 1997; Parker & Mease, 2008). Foldy and Ospina (2022) observed that research taking a systemic view of power and an emergent view of leadership has the following features: (a) they assume that power is intrinsic to the processes of co-constructing leadership; (b) they reveal that systemic power works to place some people in positions associated with more authority and leadership; and (c) they acknowledge the shifting and complex relations of power and resistance.

As we previewed in the introduction, our review finds two primary approaches to critical theorizing of leadership and resistance dynamics. The first associates leadership with hegemony, which may spur scholars to celebrate subordinate resistance as emancipatory, or to avoid theorizing leadership altogether. A second trajectory theorizes resistant communication as a form of leadership, focusing on influence dynamics in the formation and expression of noncompliance.

Resisting Hegemonic Leadership

Systemic views of power question the apparent consensus among organizational members to uncover organizational conflicts and inequities. One implication is that, as Zoller and Fairhurst (2016) observed, many critical theorists avoid theorizing leadership because they equate the concept, and the leadership literature, with reflecting and reinforcing dominant interests. These scholars often conceptualize power in terms of hegemony and control rather than leadership. Those who do engage with theorizing leadership have directly challenged the category of leadership and its association with managerialism (Alvesson & Spicer, 2012; Calás & Smircich, 1991; Kerr & Jermier, 1978). For example, Alvesson and Spicer (2012) described "anti-leadership" researchers who view leadership as a way of promoting conformity and reducing autonomy.

Focusing on the association between leadership and control leads some critical scholars to critique leader power in ways that overlook resistance. Critical studies have investigated how charismatic, transformational, and other kinds of leaders establish cultures of consent that promote followership and reduce questioning and extreme forms

of loyalty (Marcuse, 2020; Tourish, 2013; Tourish & Vatcha, 2016). Tourish (2013) described the "dark side of transformational leadership" in celebrating charismatic and heroic leadership in ways that produce narcissism and poor decision-making in cult-like cultures. Tourish and Vatcha (2016) detailed Enron leaders' use of cult-like strategies to prevent critical questions regarding growing corruption and fraud, leading to organizational collapse. This study reflects a systemic approach by theorizing power in terms of the absence of apparent conflict and by situating leadership within larger systems of power, including the dominance of managerial ideologies, capitalist economic pressure, and the policy environment.

Other scholars who equate leadership with domination respond by celebrating or promoting the role of resistance in contesting leadership. In the workplace, this often means highlighting employee resistance to managerial imperatives. Whereas some episodic researchers focus on the value of resistance in achieving the goals of an organization's dominant coalition, this viewpoint takes a non-managerial or anti-managerial stance (Jamjoom & Mills, 2022; Jimenez-Luque, 2020a, 2020b), focusing on the benefits of resistance to followers/employees in reducing power inequalities and/or creating more just forms of organizing. Critical researchers situate resistance as a route to contesting or transforming layered systems of domination, such as denaturalizing taken-for-granted assumptions, promoting autonomy for marginalized groups, or creating more equitable opportunities for voice and decision-making (Murphy, 2016; Sotirin & Gottfried, 2016; Westwood & Johnston, 2013).

The systemic view of power takes a critical interest in acts of influence that are covert and implicit, precisely because subordinates need to avoid negative sanctions by management (Courpasson, 2017; Putnam et al., 2016). On the other hand, scholars also document how subordinates may organize more overt and collective forms of resistance. For example, Zanin and Bisel's (2017) ethnographic study of a college athletic department detailed how a coach's use of managerial inquisition resulted in a football team's collective refusal to identify a teammate accused of minor wrongdoing, despite the threat of collective punishment. The authors observed that the strategy actually weakened the coach's authority by creating "concertive resistance" as the "team generated power through their resistant solidarity – a form of group-level power, which was made available to them in the unfolding discourse triggered by the inquisition" (Zanin & Bisel, 2017, p. 53).

This line of research identifies resistance to leadership as a normal part of organizing processes, demonstrating the fragilities of leader authority (Alvesson & Spicer, 2012), and investigating potential pathways towards equitable organizing.

However, Alvesson and Spicer (2012) observed that criticism of leadership can lead scholars to romanticize resistance and undervalue the need for authority and order in achieving collective goals. They propose critical performativity as a route to balancing critical commitments with (progressive) pragmatic interventions. Other critical theorists caution against celebrating resistance that does little to meaningfully challenge or transform larger systems of power and inequity (Ganesh et al., 2005). Although there are significant challenges in tracing the full implications of subordinate resistance, more researchers are linking resistance with social change outcomes (e.g., Courpasson et al., 2012).

Resistance as Leadership

Rather than focusing on subordinate resistance to leadership, another strand of systemic research considers resistance *as a form of leadership*. Zoller and Fairhurst (2016) and Fairhurst and Zoller (2008) observed that organizational scholars had largely failed to consider organizing collective resistance to power as a form of leadership. They focused on collective contestation that aimed to transform structures of domination and "formulate discourses of dignity and justice for the marginalized" (Zoller & Fairhurst, 2016, p. 1347).

This approach challenges the longstanding equation of leadership communication with management, recognizing more fluid influence dynamics that embrace a dialectical stance towards power-resistance and leadership-followership (Fairhurst, 2007; Fairhurst & Collinson, 2023). Zoller and Fairhurst (2016) argued that persuasive dynamics involved in collective organizing among people with less organizational power constitute significant forms of leadership. For example, they described how a group of manufacturing workers' seemingly spontaneous walkouts in the face of management's increasing productivity demands reflected ongoing forms of collective meaning-making. These efforts constituted leadership by naming problems and building solidarity in ways that rendered sudden action by individual employees as obvious and imperative. The authors called for more research investigating leadership processes entailed in connecting individualized and more covert forms of non-compliance with more collective and overt forms of resistance to exploitation. However, they also noted that the transition between hidden and apparent communication can be difficult for researchers to observe.

In addition to considering how subordinate groups (e.g., employees) can take on leadership in ways that contest dominant constructions of their role and challenge

managerial power, a systemic lens complicates power-leadership relationships by situating communication within macro-level structures. For example, people with organizational authority and leadership titles may be marginalized in other capacities, necessitating contestation. Parker (1997) situated African American women executives as agents of change who challenged dominant (white) understandings of instrumentality and collaboration. Jamjoon and Mills (2022) adopted a postcolonial lens to investigate how Saudi women who occupy leadership roles resist dominant gender stereotypes. Focusing on everyday forms of communication, the authors described how women leaders subtly and overtly challenge stereotypes through verbal reframing (e.g., reacting to being told that "this is a man's job" by saying that her breasts were her balls, strategic silences), and technological means (e.g., using WhatsApp to share their perspectives). Moreover, the authors explicitly framed their selection of Saudi women leaders as their own act of resistance to dominant stereotypes that treat Saudi women as oppressed and passive.

Scholars also attribute "resistance leadership" to people with organizational authority who seek to reformulate larger social orders including dominant neoliberal and capitalist forms of organizing. For example, leadership scholars have documented how executives resist status-quo assumptions about business. Gröschl and Gabaldon (2017) situated executive leadership at Puma as resistance leaders, countering dominant norms that support unsustainable business decisions. The executives introduced sustainability profit and loss reporting, creating a lasting structural impact that transforms standard accounting schemes. The authors attributed "leadership" both to the managerial role and the communicative influence generated to change status quo practices. Similarly, Manolopoulos (2021) developed a theory of environmental leadership that distinguishes between preservational leadership, which maintains the status quo and dissent leadership, which challenges the status quo by developing more ecocentric forms of organizing.

This line of research theorizes the ability to mobilize dissent as a tool for transformational leaders (Carroll & Nicholson, 2014; Nicholson & Carroll, 2013). For example, Carroll and Nicholson (2014) examined how leaders can be trained to engage in resistance through Leadership Development Programs (LDP). They noted that LDPs could have progressive potential in cultivating leaders who challenge organizational rationalities and realities. Focusing on the training process, they found that although programs encourage participants to question and challenge the status quo as part of what it means to be a leader, program heads often treat participants' challenges to the education as irrational and seek to prevent or overcome them. The authors encourage

facilitators to promote co-constructed, interactional decision-making to achieve a more level playing field with participants.

Zoller and Fairhurst (2008, 2016) encouraged attention to the ways that employee efforts to foster collective agency can contribute to social movement organizing, particularly in transforming social policies affecting workers and their communities. Scholars have also dialectically considered how existing social movements can cultivate dissent leadership. Each approach has introduced new theories of leadership. For example, Mitra (2013) examined how leaders and followers at the climate change nonprofit 350.org co-construct transformation processes through dialogic interactions that bridge new forms of organizing and traditional institutions. Zoller et al. (2020) examined how management can invite and promote employee resistance leadership using social movement resources. The Equitable Food Initiative (EFI), an agricultural multi-stakeholder third-party verification mechanism, trains workers to participate with management on teams tasked with implementing EFI standards on a daily basis. Leadership Teams monitor standards compliance, solicit employee feedback about problems, and create potential solutions related to social relationships, health and safety, environmental sustainability, and economic protections. By breaking down traditional formal and informal authority lines, the Leadership Teams promoted employee influence over worker rights, which the authors theorized as "concertive advocacy" (see also Zoller et al., 2022). Addressing the systemic power differences that remain between managers and workers, the authors cite the external certification evaluation and inspection process as a structural mechanism inhibiting management from co-opting or undermining the program.

Jimenez-Luque (2020b) also expanded the concept of resistance leadership by theorizing decolonial leadership, defined as "emancipatory processes led by subaltern social groups" (p. 155) in an advocacy organization for Native Americans. The author explicitly eschewed conceptualizing "Native American leadership," instead focusing on collective resistance based on cultural identity against a dominant worldview that suppresses and undermines that identity. Drawing from Tourish (2014), the authors challenged theories of transformational leadership that legitimize the concentration of power, seeking to reformulate leadership around equitable social groups. At a broader level, Ledbetter (2012) described "resistance leadership" in Occupy Wall Street as a way to communicate moral imagination in promoting more peaceful and just organizations.

Although more work is needed to fully develop the concept of resistance leadership, the systemic view of power in this body of research challenges dominant hierarchical

logics in the attribution of organizational leadership. Zoller and Fairhurst (2016) observed that: "attributions of leadership themselves are formed and influenced by power/knowledge constructions" (p. 1339). By challenging dominant constructions that locate leadership in opposition to resistance, researchers can identify and theorize new forms of leadership that work *with*, *for*, or *as* resistance. At the same time, Alvesson and Spicer (2012), among others, caution against expanding the concept of leadership around resistance to the point that leadership becomes indistinguishable from other concepts.

Agenda for Future Research

This chapter has explored multiple approaches to leadership-resistance communication dynamics. Across perspectives, greater recognition of resistance demonstrates the potential fragility of leader power even where it seems unassailable (Alvesson & Spicer, 2012). However, significant differences in theorizing relationships among communication, leadership, and resistance can be traced to different orientations toward power. As we discuss the implications of these differences for future research, we suggest that connecting the episodic exercise of power with systemic constructions of inequity would strengthen leadership communication research.

First, episodic views of power yield important insights that can be further elaborated with attention to systemic relations of power. Research investigating resistance as irrational or problematic reactions to managerial imperatives can be valuable when hesitancy to change impedes important organizational imperatives. However, leadership scholars need to challenge managerial biases by considering more carefully whose interests guide what counts as rational or irrational viewpoints. Similarly, viewing resistance as potentially valuable managerial feedback can help us understand how communicating principled dissent can contribute to more inclusive and ethical leadership systems that facilitate and effectively respond to employee voices. Yet, scholarship in this area can do more to consider the norms that influence what counts as principled or unethical decision-making. This research can also connect relations of authority to larger power dynamics, including constructions of social and cultural hierarchies related to gender and sexuality, ethnicity, class, country of origin, and ability status. Organizational rationalities embedded in the attribution of leadership and leadership communication processes reinforce structural inequities related to these differences (e.g., Carrillo Arciniega, 2020; Fairhurst, 2009; Parker, 2016).

Additionally, critical research provides multiple theoretical lenses that can be used to evaluate the emancipatory potential of leadership initiatives. For example, theories of systematically distorted communication can help to evaluate managerially driven empowerment practices that encourage the expression of difference and invite dissent. Critical perspectives encourage ongoing attention to the limits on the degree and types of resistance that are allowed, even with more pluralist leaders and organizational settings, and the ideological and material implications of those limits. These avenues highlight how structural power is at work even when no overt, oppositional dynamic can be observed in leader-follower dynamics (Ban & Zoller, 2021; Zoller & Fairhurst, 2016).

Second, critical scholars who avoid or critique the leadership concept due to its association with hegemony may miss important organizational influence dynamics. For example, given growing interest in alternative organizing that challenges corporate/capitalist hierarchies (Parker et al., 2014; Zanoni, 2020; Zoller, 2021), leadership scholarship can shed light on how flatter dialogic organizations can manage ongoing cycles of domination and resistance that construct, reinforce, or challenge nascent formal or informal hierarchies (Bourlier-Bargues et al., 2023). For example, leadership scholarship has much to contribute to our understanding of how worker-owned enterprises can manage both episodic and structural inequities that arise among members.

Third, our review suggests that more work is needed to build on the resistance-as-leadership framework. This approach challenges the equation of leadership with the expression of systemic power by considering resisting dominant structures as a form of leadership. However, much of the existing research continues to focus on resistance among people with organizational authority, leaving more space for understanding emergent forms of contestation from below. We need more insights into the communication dynamics that contribute to expressing resistance, including relationships between charismatic or skilled individuals and more distributed leadership within groups. This research would connect more individualized and micro-level contestation with more collective and macro-level attempts at organizational and social change.

Overall, this chapter spurs greater dialogue between scholars of leadership communication and critical theorists who focus on communication and organizational power. This review suggests that we have moved beyond the historical equation of leadership with hegemony and the study of leadership with managerial ideologies. However, significant work remains to theorize relationships among communication,

power, resistance, and leadership, particularly in addressing the "deep structures" of hegemony and counter-hegemony.

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18

CRISIS AS A LEADERSHIP CONTEXT

Roles and Responsibilities

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-21

Few topics have engendered more interest from researchers than leadership (Fairhurst, 2008; Fairhurst & Connaughton, 2014; Hogan & Kaiser, 2005). Perhaps because of their visibility as the heads of groups and organizations or perhaps because of the widely held belief that their actions have a very direct relationship to outcomes, leadership has been examined within a wide variety of organizational and social contexts using a diverse set of theoretical frameworks (Seeger, 1992). Most position communication as a principal component of the leadership processes as the mechanism through which leadership is exercised. Leadership can foster coordination with key stakeholders to enhance goal attainment. This coordination achieved through communication processes is considered an essential aspect of leadership effectiveness (Johansson & Bäck, 2017).

While leadership, as well as leader communication has been examined widely, comparatively few efforts have explored crisis leadership; even though there is almost universal recognition that leadership is especially salient during crises (see Gigliotti, 2019; Mitroff, 2001; Muffet-Willett & Kruse, 2009; Riggio & Newstead, 2023). Some observers have described five core functions for crisis leadership: sensemaking, coordinating teamwork, decision making, facilitating learning, and communicating (Riggio & Newstead, 2023). However, the most fundamental responsibility of leaders during crises is to protect the lives, livelihoods, safety, and well-being of their constituents (Comfort, Kapucu, Ko et al., 2020). Thus, most of the crisis research has

focused on the post-crisis stage to provide an assessment of effectiveness in crisis response and image repair strategies (Benoit, 2014; Coombs, 2007).

This chapter examines the concept of leadership and crisis communication. We first describe crisis as a context for leadership and then discuss the role of the leader as a crisis communicator. This includes monitoring and risk sensing, sensemaking and sense giving, decision making and crisis management, recovery and renewal, and learning and preparing for future crises. We conclude by discussing the challenges of leadership in dynamic environments of emerging and expanding hazards as well as new forms and channels of communication, and position crisis leadership as an increasingly essential skill.

Crisis as a Context for Leadership

The concept of crisis as an abnormal condition or state may be understood in contrast to normal times. During times seen as normal, organizations function in largely predictable ways following well-defined routines, norms, and procedures using established structures. Roles are generally articulated, and operations occur within clear parameters with known stakeholders. In addition, processes of leadership are conceptualized as part of the normal process of organizational activity (Riggio & Newstead, 2023). The role of the leader is described according to established conventions, patterns of activities, and norms of conduct. Thus, a crisis denotes an abnormal circumstance, characterized by rapid change, uncertainty, and a suspension of routines, roles, and procedures; usually signaled by some dramatic event that is unanticipated and creates significant harm or the potential for harm (Sellnow & Seeger, 2021).

The sudden radical and often dramatic departure from the status quo and the violation of general assumptions and expectations limits the ability to anticipate and predict, creating elevated levels of uncertainty and associated stress. To reduce uncertainty, leaders engage in information seeking behaviors with stakeholders; to sort out conflicting information or overlapping messages and to identify opportunities for convergence (Anthony & Sellnow, 2016). Routine operations, established structures, norms, and roles are disrupted, including leadership roles and processes. Weick (1995) described a kind of crisis-induced, psychological dislocation that he termed a cosmological episode,

> When people suddenly and deeply feel that the universe is no longer a rational, orderly system. What makes such an episode so shattering is that both the sense of what is occurring and the means to rebuild that sense collapse together.
>
> (p. 633)

Our understanding of the nature of crisis as a disruption demanding a response, represents the outer framework from which a more nuanced view may emerge. That is, crises are not static and able to be resolved with a single decision or strategy to mitigate or remove the threat to life and property. Rather, crises are dynamic, occurring over time, with critical points where decisions must be made to respond to the changing circumstances (Sellnow et al., 2009). Uncertainty stemming from a crisis affects how people respond because they are concerned about the extent of the damage, whether friends or loved ones are affected, whether the crisis has passed, and/or the likelihood of it happening again (Houston et al., 2018). Uncertainty prompts information seeking to reduce or manage uncertainty (Brashers, 2001). The dynamic and disruptive nature of a crisis poses a unique challenge because previous assumptions, norms, and decisional processes may no longer be viable. These decision-making tensions associated with the crisis or disaster will require leaders to make ongoing adjustments to their communication strategies.

Examples such as Hurricane Katrina in 2005 (Vanderford et al., 2007), the 2008 Contaminated Milk crisis in China (Lyu, 2012), the Volkswagon emissions crisis in 2015 (Raupp, 2019), and the COVID-19 pandemic that began in 2020 (Malecki et al., 2021) illustrate the diverse range of crises and the role of communication. Katrina involved fundamental failures in communication coordination between response agencies. The contaminated milk scandal illustrated the impact of response strategies employed by different political and media systems. The Volkswagon emission crisis demonstrated the importance of image repair communication. COVID-19 is a powerful example of the global reach of a crisis, its disruptive nature and the compounding of harm that can occur through misinformation and disinformation.

Crises have been broadly described as having three defining characteristics (Hermann, 1963; Sellnow & Seeger, 2021). First, they are almost always unanticipated by key stakeholders and decision makers; although signals (often weak and difficult to interpret), warning signs, and precursors are present before a crisis erupts (Roux-Dufort, 2016). The failure of key decision makers to receive, recognize, interpret, and makes sense of these signals is one confounding variable in the onset of a crisis

(Nowling & Seeger, 2020). Acting upon warning signs may allow organizations to reduce and limit harm, and in some cases, avoid the crises.

A second feature typically associated with a crisis is a perceived threat to high priority goals (e.g., property, personal physical and psychological well-being); as well as the goals of friends, family, and co-workers; or those associated with organizational image, profitability, and viability, among others (Coombs, 2002). Additionally, threat creates important affective elements associated with a crisis (e.g., anger, fear, and/or stress) that also should be considered (Faraji-Rad & Pham, 2017). Although the severity may vary in some cases, a crisis creates existential threats to individuals, families, organizations, and communities. While threats are always features of a crisis, they also may mask important opportunities inherent to the disruption of the system (Ulmer et al., 2007).

The need for some immediate action or response to limit and contain the harm is the third defining condition of crisis. Crises have short- and long-term impacts and may damage the environment, harm human health, create loss of life, lead to severe financial hardship, threaten organizational and business stability, and undermine the viability of communities, among other factors. The nature of the threat plays a significant role in the development of the specific crisis response strategies including leadership processes (Littlefield, 2013). In general, strategic responses should be initiated as soon as possible to limit and contain harm.

These strategic responses may be initiated by some authority, such as an evacuation order from a hurricane by a state agency or the requirement by the Centers for Disease Control to wear masks in conditions of high incidence of an emerging infectious disease. They also may be part of an emergent organizing effort in response to the crisis. These mitigation strategies usually require communication in the form of public recommendations for mitigation strategies, risk communication about hazards, coordination communication between response groups, or messages designed to reduce uncertainty and address concerns. They may take the form of narratives (Liu et al., 2020), instructional messages (Sellnow et al., 2017), or alert and warning messages (Mehta et al., 2022).

All three of these crisis conditions – uncertainty, threat, and restricted response time – implicate leadership processes, both formal and informal. To further understanding of leadership within the crisis context, we describe five key crisis leadership processes, including: monitoring and risk sensing; sensemaking and sense giving; decision making and crisis management; recovery and renewal; and learning and preparing for future crises.

The Role of the Leader in Crisis Decision-Making

Monitoring and Risk Sensing

As noted earlier, a crisis almost always is proceeded by risk signals, warning signs, and risk cues, often weak and difficult to interpret (Roux-Dufort, 2016). One responsibility of leadership is to monitor for these risk cues, enact environmental risks messages, and create a culture of risk awareness and high reliability organizing (Bowers et al., 2017; Martínez-Córcoles, 2018; Nowling & Seeger, 2020). While leaders play a leading role in monitoring for emerging risks from the perspective of their organizations, they also must consider how external stakeholders understand risks. Choosing to operate from the paternalistic perspective of, "We know what's good for them," is poorly suited for successful risk monitoring. Diverse groups of stakeholders are important sources of information about emerging risks. The initial identification of an emerging risk may come from unexpected sources. The understanding of emerging risk and mitigation strategies, therefore, is enhanced with a culture-centered approach where leaders and members of stakeholder groups engage in a co-created process to arrive at a shared understanding of the risks and potential responses (Littlefield, 2013). Dutta (2008) described how the culture-centered approach works, suggesting that the purposeful inclusion of community members in the decision-making process is essential. As their perceptions and lived experiences are foregrounded in the decision-making process, shared meanings are created. This stakeholder engagement is most effective in the pre-crisis phase when there is an opportunity to develop positive pre-event relationships and a reservoir of good will (Jones et al., 2000; Seeger, 2006).

Leaders also have a role in promoting risk awareness, facilitating the reporting of risk, and enacting organizational or societal cultures that are sensitive to the implications of emerging risks. For example, the High Reliability Organizing (HRO) model describes how an organization enacts a culture that is sensitive to risk and suggests that those organizations maintaining strong safety records while operating within high-risk environments have common features (Vogus & Sutcliffe, 2007). These safety records are associated with leadership processes and include being receptive and detecting small discrepancies and failures that may signal larger problems, encouraging reporting of problems, and facilitating openness in upward communication (Martınez-Corcoles, 2018). Leaders may engage in environmental monitoring and risk sensing and may promote processes and practices that encourage both risk awareness and risk reporting. Awareness allows management activities to reduce risk or mitigate the impact of crises when they occur.

Sensemaking and Meaning Making

The disruption of routines, roles, and norms during a crisis also disrupts established repertoires and narratives of sensemaking and meaning. Leadership is essential in reconstructing meaning and sharing that meaning with others (Boin & Renaud, 2013; Jong, 2017; Sellnow & Seeger, 2021).

Sensemaking is a communicative process whereby individual construction and reconstruction of meaning is based on available information and experiences (Fairhurst, 2011; Maitlis & Sonenshein, 2010; Weber et al., 2015; Weick, 1988). Because crises disrupt established patterns or action and interaction, new inputs, information, and experiences must be accounted for in meaning systems (Sellnow & Seeger, 2021). This need to make sense of an equivocal crisis occurs at the very time when the processes and resources necessary for making sense are disrupted (Weick, 1988).

Through sensemaking processes, inputs are noticed, bracketed, and organized; meaning is created, shared, and made material through situations, processes, and organizations (Weick et al., 2005). Sensemaking is often reciprocal as leaders seeking to understand and interpret crises and engage in communication with multiple stakeholders, introduce the necessary meaning strategies enabling action (Weber et al., 2015). As leaders seek to make sense of the equivocal situation imposed by a crisis, they should also consider the perspectives of stakeholders.

Leaders have significant responsibilities both to engage in and facilitate sensemaking processes during crises (Combe & Carrington 2015; Fairhurst, 2011). Leaders are expected to manage the meaning of crisis events, "even when others are unable; they emerge as leaders because they interpret uncertainty and frame 'the situation here and now' *in ways that connect with others*" (Fairhurst, 2011, p. 44, italics in original). As the visible representative of the organization, and often the designated crisis spokesperson, leaders are expected to be at the center of the network for information, to have decisional authority, to communicate understanding about what is happening and why, and to provide support for those who have been harmed (Lucero et al., 2009).

Sense Giving and Meaning Sharing

In addition to sensemaking, leaders serve as sense givers during crises. Sense giving has been described as, "[a] process of attempting to influence the sensemaking and meaning construction of others" toward consensus around a redefinition of organizational reality (Gioia & Chittipeddi, 1991, p. 442). During a crisis, this involves efforts to persuade others to adopt a specific understanding of the event and associated

explanations of cause, responsibility, and response. Sense giving is the process whereby leaders enact interpreted versions of environmental conditions, such as those occurring during crises, and then share their interpreted understanding with other key stakeholders (Gilstrap et al., 2016). This is an iterative, sequential, and often reciprocal process that may involve leaders interacting with both internal and external stakeholders (Gioia & Chittipeddi, 1991) during both the pre-crisis and post-crisis stages (Klein & Eckhaus, 2017).

One of the initial processes of sense giving is the framing of a circumstance as a crisis (Fairhurst, 2011). Crises are often first signaled by some non-routine information that indicates a discrepancy between the current and desired states. Leaders must assess the situation, including the scope of threat or harm, and determine if the circumstance should be framed as a crisis. Doing so focuses attention and may leverage material resources, as well as certain forms of decisional authority, and may activate response plans and protocols.

In addition to initial framing by leaders, three additional frameworks for sense giving processes with organizational stakeholders during crises have been described: instrumental knowledge, normalcy, and dynamic learning (Gilstrap et al., 2016). Instrumental knowledge involves disseminating the resources necessary for sense giving. This may include information about the nature of the crisis, anticipated impacts, and response strategies. Leaders are expected to respond quickly, honestly, decisively, and in a cooperative, supportive, and empathetic manner (Gilstrap et al., 2016; Seeger, 2006). An essential goal of crisis management is to return to a normal or near normal state. This may involve sense giving that includes projecting a calm and competent response that is consistent with the core organizational culture and values. A third sense giving frame concerns post-crisis learning and encompasses the processes employed to evaluate and assess responses to ensure that similar events do not occur again. Gilstrap et al. (2016) described this as a diagnostic frame and as an opportunity to create a comprehensive understanding of the event. Crises have been described as learning and change opportunities (Ulmer et al., 2007), as forces that can drive organizational resilience (Vogus & Sutcliff, 2007), and as the basis for cultural adjustment (Elliott & Smith, 2006).

When taken together, sensemaking and sense giving follow an intraorganizational process that involves envisioning, signaling, re-envisioning, and energizing (Gioia & Chittipeddi, 1991). This four-stage process begins with leaders engaging in sensemaking to initiate an interpretation and associated vision for the response to a crisis. Leaders may then share the interpretation and response with stakeholders through

the process of sense giving. As the external stakeholders make sense of the plan, they interpret and engage in additional sense giving to convey their understanding of the message so others can have the opportunity to re-envision the plan. At this point, both primary and external stakeholders engage in sensemaking/sense giving until they reach some levels of convergence on the course of action and are motivated to move forward with the response.

Weber et al. (2015) described this process as they analyzed the sensemaking and sense giving that occurred in response to a post-9/11 change in the Maritime Transportation Security Act involving patrol boats in the Great Lakes. As part of a response to the crisis of 9/11, the Midwest District Office of the United States Coast Guard sought to increasing preparedness for future attacks by mandating the mounting of new weapons on patrol boats and the running of exercise drills on the Great Lakes using live ammunition. As the external publics received the notice, there was a public outcry that developed into a major issue. Sense giving failed as the primary and external stakeholders could not find convergence with the interpretation that preparedness required an armed response, prompting the withdrawal of the proposal.

Decision-Making and Crisis Management

During a crisis event, leaders have a primary role in the management of the crisis, and making decisions is at the core of both crisis communication and management (Claeys & Coombs, 2020). Crisis typically empowers a leader with additional authority to make decisions and undertake harm reducing actions. This authority often exceeds what leaders might experience during normal times and is granted so that they may make decisions and undertake actions to manage the crisis (Littlefield & Quenette, 2007; Lucero et al., 2009). Decision making during crisis is a complex and dynamic process that often occurs outside the normal leadership process. A primary constraint on leadership is making highly consequential decisions, often rapidly, under these conditions of high uncertainty.

In addition to uncertainty, crisis leadership requires decision making under conditions of high perceived threat to priority goals. To understand the impact of threat, Jin and Cameron (2007) examined internal versus external threat and threat duration, long versus short term. Leaders could be expected to exert more control over internal threats than external. Short-term threats were more easily managed than long term. Not surprisingly, they found that threat type and threat duration impacted threat appraisal, emotional arousal, and degree of accommodation. Overall, "[the] external and long-

term threat combination led to higher situational demand appraisals and more intensive emotional arousal" (p. 255). Perceptions of threat can influence leader decisions, decisional power, and indicate the relative consequences of the decision.

Claeys and Coombs (2020) noted that organizations often decide to implement sub-optimal crisis response strategies that prioritize avoiding short-term losses over those that may offer more substantive long-term gains. A variety of factors may account for this tendency. They suggested that crisis decisions often are made in an intuitive rather than an analytical manner. Intuitive decisions are fast, nonconscious, automatic, independent of cognitive ability and critical evaluation, and applications of information (p. 301). The short decisional time frame and the complex and often contradictory information environment of a crisis often favor intuitive decisional processes. In addition, discounting time tends to prioritize present rewards more so than future rewards, while myopic loss aversion prioritizes losses over gains. Finally, the open versus closed leader style, the structural components of the decision system, as well as time pressure have been described as significant impediments to the maintenance of decisional vigilance (Neck & Moorhead, 1995). These characteristics of the crisis decisional context may serve as impediments to effective decision making and the selecting of optimal approaches to crisis management.

As noted, crisis decisions need to be made while the crisis is occurring, *in situ.* Seven tensions of strategic communication decision-making (TSCD) (Littlefield, 2020) impact decision-making as a crisis unfolds:

1. *Amount of information* – How much information should be released?
2. *Timeliness* – When should the information is released?
3. *Certainty* – Is the information to be released verifiable?
4. *Level of responsibility* – What is the level of responsibility to be assumed by the organization for the crisis?
5. *Focus of interest* – To what extent is or should organizational self-interest be reflected?
6. *Emotional connection* – To what level of emotional connection should be demonstrated?
7. *Control of the narrative* – Who has the authority in the reporting of the information about the crisis?

These tensions represent a discursive struggle for leaders making decisions during a crisis, requiring the prioritization of these tensions at moments of crisis to create the

best communication strategy within the dynamic crisis context. In addition, leaders also may be forced to accommodate competing values and diverse crisis stakeholders.

Comfort et al. (2020) and Comfort (2007) argued that crisis decision making is fraught with uncertainty and becomes an adaptive process with four distinct components: cognition, communication, coordination, and control. These components represent both resources and domains for decision making. Crisis management cognition is the "capacity to recognize the degree of emerging risk to which a community is exposed and to act on that information" (Comfort, 2007, p. 189). Cognition involves accessing information about emerging risks and providing the resources necessary to inform the leader's decisions and actions. Communication is necessary to create shared meaning among the various actors and stakeholders who have different roles and relationships to the crisis. Communication similarly informs partners and the public about emerging risks, mitigation measures, and collective responses. Leaders must make a variety of strategic decisions about what to communicate, when, to whom and in what ways. Among the most consequential crisis decisions for leaders concerns coordination. Coordination involves aligning resources, responsibilities, and activities in complementary ways that support shared crisis management goals (Comfort, 2007). In contexts of competing priorities and values, high uncertainty, shifting crisis conditions, and coordination can be a significant leadership challenge. The fourth crisis decisional domain is control. Control within the context of crisis is a response capacity deployed to mitigate threats and harms (Comfort, 2007; Comfort et al., 2020). This capacity is a function of leader power as well as the availability of crisis plans, slack resources, and resources (including reputational resources).

Varma (2019) argued that the contingency theory of accommodation used the perspective of public relations because, "the most significant and unifying characteristic of all crises is its potential for causing incalculable damage to an organization and its reputation" (p. 234). The contingency theory of accommodation explains the influence of multiple variables on an organization's response to interaction with its publics, "to minimize reputational damage and … maintain the organization's competitiveness and/or its sustainability" (Varma, 2019, p. 234).

Researchers have sought to identify and understand the impact of factors that may constrain decision making during a crisis. Building on efforts to identify variables that could influence an organization's position in relations to its publics (Cancel et al., 1999), Varma (2019) proposed an axiomatic model of decision making comprised of the decision situation and the decision process. Within this model, the decision situation identified the factors to be considered in the decision-making process; among them, the

formalization of the decision-making process, the politicization of the process within the decision-making structure, the impact or severity of the risk or crisis on the publics directly affected, and the financial liability associated with the crisis response.

The decision process revealed how the factors that influenced the crisis strategies would be used as proscriptive variables – those that impede or hinder accommodation of stakeholder positions – or supportive variables that help or encourage advocacy for an organization's position. Formalization of decision-making processes, such as having predetermined crisis teams and decisional processes and criteria, improved the use of information and the quality of decisions. Varma (2019) considered the politicization of the decision-making process to inherently have ramifications requiring "resolution through the transaction of power" (p. 237) within the decision-making structure. Crisis impact or severity is an essential factor affecting decision making because it directly impacts the stakeholders and is unique to every crisis. The financial impact of the crisis will also influence how the organizational leaders explain and justify crisis related decisions to their stakeholders.

Decision making is an essential part of crisis management and a key function of leaders during crisis. Making decisions under the conditions of high uncertainty and short response time is especially challenging and is influenced by a variety of contextual variables. Moreover, decisions must be made throughout the crisis life-cycle – from pre-crisis planning to post-crisis recovery and renewal – as the dynamics of the crisis change.

Recovery and Renewal

Following the disruption from a crisis, systems may return to the previous state and may stablish a new form of equilibrium (Gunderson & Hollings, 2002). Recovery often is described as a return to the status quo while the transition to a new state of organizing is sometimes characterized as renewal (Carpenter et al., 2002; Ulmer et al., 2007). Leaders have an important role in overseeing the post-crisis phase, promoting a return to the pre-crisis, normal condition, or transition to a new normal. They may serve as a nexus for articulating a post-crisis vision, help leverage resources, and build support.

Crises vary in the levels of disruption. In all cases, a post-crisis stage includes efforts to move beyond the crisis, to rebuild and recover. Recovery is a complex process with psychological, social, economic, and material dimensions progressing through planning, short-term, intermediate, and long-terms stages (FEMA, 2016). Comfort et al. (2010) pointed out that the process often involves "interacting

jurisdictions, public agencies, private and nonprofit organizations," that requires collaboration and leadership (pp. 669–670). In addition, leaders have reported that recovery involves five related activities: (1) planning and evaluation; (2) education and training; (3) fundraising and donations management; (4) building relationships; and (5) disaster behavioral health (Craddock et al., 2016).

In some cases, disruptions are relatively modest, and the organization can return very quickly with little adjustment to normal or near normal operations and a stable situation. The harm may be relatively modest, and rebuilding and recovery may occur quickly. In other cases, the disruption may be much more significant if the system is disrupted to a degree that a return to the previous state is not possible. In this case, a new form of system equilibrium may emerge (Gunderson & Hollings, 2002). Renewal theory has been used to describe this response to more serious disruptions (Seeger & Ulmer, 2002).

Renewal theory argues that crises can be a turning point leading to fundamental change in systems that would not be possible in normal times. Discursive processes create points of convergence following a disruption around which an organizing or reorganizing process can emerge. Leaders are at the center of these processes. Renewal has been described as a process, leading to "seeing, understanding, and moving beyond the immediate harm created by a crisis; to leverage systemic opportunities for positive change that can be collectively embraced by a group, organization and/or community" (Sellnow et al., 2022). Seeger and Sellnow (2016) argued that effective crisis response often requires organizations to revise core values and reconstitute operational goals in fundamentally new and unanticipated ways.

Five conditions for renewal have been described: strong, visible leadership; a compelling vision of the future; positive stakeholder relationships; value-based ethics; and a spontaneous, honest response. Leaders serve as a visible point of connection and attraction around which organizing occurs. They speak directly to stakeholders to help shape and maintain shared understanding of the challenges created by the crisis and the necessary steps to confront the challenges and move forward in a constructive and compelling way. Renewal involves an immediate and instinctive response based on the positive values and virtues of a leaders rather than a strategic response that emphasizes escaping issues of responsibility or blame (Ulmer et al., 2007). Renewal is based on a compelling vision of the post-crisis condition that arises through sensemaking process and is shared through sense giving. This includes future optimism, using the crisis as a "turning point" in an organization's life to "focus on [its] fresh [and renewed] sense of purpose and direction" (p. 307). Stakeholders are key sources of post-crisis support

and positive relationships, and reputations can help facilitate support for reorganizing and rebuilding. A crisis also activates and reveals values and the ethical stances of organizations. Compelling values can provide the basis for unity, connection, and future directions as an organization seeks to change and move beyond the crisis.

Recovery positions the leader as a facilitator and collaborator working to repair the harm. The theory of crisis and renewal views leaders as central figures in significant post-crisis change, especially when the disruption has been so significant that a new form of organization must emerge. Processes of sensemaking and sense giving are used to create a compelling prospective post-crisis vision that allows various stakeholder groups to participate in processes of reorganization.

Organizational Learning

Organizational learning is the process whereby organizations acquire new information and understanding and use this knowledge to implement strategic changes. Through learning, knowledge and routines are built, supplemented, and organized; cultures adapt to improve organizational efficiency and effectiveness (Dodgson, 1993, p. 377). Organizational learning theory frames a crisis as a learning opportunity, and learning from failure as a process that leads to improved performance. Crisis induced learning has been defined as:

> the processes organizations use to rapidly adapt to uncertain and threatening circumstances that require an immediate response by drawing on both existing knowledge and developing new knowledge through scanning, use of networks and subject matter experts to develop responses, routines, and structures.
>
> (Islam et al., 2022)

Crises reveal errors, contradictions, vulnerabilities, and deficiencies, and they motivate change (Nathan & Kovoor-Misra, 2002). Learning allows organizations to develop greater resilience, as well as to prepare for future crises (Carmeli & Sheaffer, 2008; Mitroff, 2001).

Leadership has been linked to organizational learning in several ways. For example, various leadership styles, such as transformational or transactional leadership, may promote different forms of learning under different conditions. Transformational leadership likely will challenge existing institutional knowledge and learning processes. In contrast, transactional leadership may serve to reinforce established institutional knowledge and learning processes. Leadership style may promote a

learning culture that facilitates experimentation, models openness, and rewards learning. Leaders also may create and make use of systems and procedures that help achieve their goals of systematically creating, distributing, storing, and implementing new knowledge (Vera & Crossan, 2004).

Crisis learning processes, such as post-crisis after action reviews, are used in a variety of contexts. They are designed to enhance preparedness activities and plans (Savoia et al., 2012; WHO, 2019). While after action reviews are mandated by many organizations and agencies, translating recommendations from specific events into generalized knowledge and practice is challenging. Leaders play an important role in ensuring that after action reviews are comprehensive and meaningful and have an implementation component.

Two forms of organizational learning may be especially relevant to crises: experiential and vicarious. Experiential learning comes from the organizations' prior experiences, including lessons from previous crises management successes and failures. This form of learning may be powerful especially given the often-negative consequences of crises. Vicarious learning processes, in contrast, involve the observation of others' successes or failures; they may be less costly, yet effective as organizations can learn from others in their field (Nathan & Kovoor-Misra, 2002). In some cases, leaders may actively seek out information from peer organizations to develop knowledge about risk management and crisis response.

Leadership in the Era of Emerging and Expanding Hazards

A variety of interconnected and nested social, economic, and environmental factors are increasing both the frequency and severity of crises events. Hazards from climate change, emerging infectious diseases, population migration, political unrest, and system complexity (their confluences and interaction) suggest that crisis leadership will be an increasingly essential skill. In fact, our analysis suggests that crisis communication and management, and a range of specific activities and responsibilities throughout the crisis life cycle, increasingly may define leadership. These specific tasks include monitoring and risk sensing, sensemaking and sense giving, decision making and crisis management, recovery and post-crisis renewal, and learning. Factoring in the current and emerging risk environments supports the view that crisis leadership is an increasingly important, if not essential skill.

This importance is illustrated in two ways. First, multiple crisis events occur within the same physical and temporal context and many crises have secondary, often

unanticipated impacts. Converging events, such as emerging infectious diseases and natural disasters, can extend the threat and harm; they complicate risk sensing, sensemaking and sense giving, decision making and crisis management, recovery, and post-crisis renewal and learning. Moreover, events often cascade in unanticipated ways with secondary impacts. Second, the scope and scale of many crises means that the threat severity is higher and extends to a wide range of stakeholders. This forces leaders to consider diverse and often conflicting needs, backgrounds, and values. It also creates a set of leader obligations to engage in authentic, ongoing, and honest communication with stakeholders about risk, preparedness, response, recovery, and renewal.

Conclusion and Future Directions

We have argued that crisis communication and management are essential leadership skills that have become more salient in an era of large-scale crises that often converge with cascading impacts. We also believe there are several important directions for future research.

First, crises may take a variety of forms (e.g., hurricanes, fires, infectious disease outbreaks, mass shootings, floods, transportation accidents, chemical spills, among others) and are caused by a variety of risk factors (Sellnow & Seeger, 2021; Shaluf et al., 2003). Contemporary crisis management models tend to adopt an all-hazards approach where planning is general. These models seek to accommodate a wide range of crisis types. Leader responsibilities, however, may vary by crisis type, as well as by leadership context. Context, such as corporate, elected or community leader, or emergent leader can help determine position power, access to resources, and audiences. The impact of these factors needs further exploration.

Important assumptions about the leaders' roles in interorganizational coordination and advocacy around risks factors warrant inquiry. Part of the monitoring and risk sensing function of crisis leadership may include obligations to engage in risk advocacy. Risks, such as those associated with climate change, are multi- and inter-organizational. Leaders have unique opportunities to call attention to emerging risks and enact risk-reducing processes and decisions. For example, under what conditions do leaders decide to speak out? How do they promote risk awareness and advocate for risk reduction? Some of the most effective advocacy for addressing climate change, for example, has come from corporate leaders, such as Microsoft's Bill Gates.

A third area of future research addressing crisis leadership concerns the tension between post-crisis strategies of recovery (where building greater organizational resilience through transactional leadership is necessary) and fundamental crisis-induced change and renewal facilitated by transformational leadership. In some cases, strategies of recovery and building resilience can bolster some of the very features that resulted in the crisis. In fact, surviving a crisis, especially so-called near miss events, may create the belief that organizations have adequate response strategies and need not change. These beliefs may impede necessary transformative change. Leaders must be able to assess when an event simply calls for modest adjustments and when transformative change is needed. Examining the conditions that promote greater resilience, those that promote change, and the ways leaders make and give sense about those conditions are important areas of investigation.

Researchers agree that more crisis events with extended and severe impacts are occurring, driven by significant and far-reaching risk factors such as climate change. Leaders will play an essential role in advocating, limiting, and mitigating risk, engaging with multiple stakeholders, helping others make sense of crisis events, and facilitating recovery and renewal. As Comfort and her colleagues noted (2020), leaders must accept fundamental responsibilities to protect the lives, livelihoods, safety, and well-being of their constituents.

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Future Reading

Frandsen, F., & Johansen, W. (2020). *Crisis communication*. DeGruyter Mouton. doi.org/10.1515/9783110554236. (This handbook provides a broad review of the discipline of crisis communication from the textual to the inter-societal level.)

Schwarz, A., Seeger, M. W., & Kim, S. (In Press). *The handbook of international crisis communication research* (2nd ed.). Wiley. (The second edition of this handbook presents the growing international literature on crisis communication, including the broad theoretical, methodological, cultural and practical implications of domestic and transnational crises.)

PART III

Practice

19

LEADERSHIP FRAMING AND TACTICS OF INFLUENCE

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-23

In the late 1970s, David Kipnis and colleagues' research series explored how managers "got their way" with bosses, coworkers, and employees. An enduring legacy from their research emphasized the efficacy of rational tactics or "explaining the reason for my request" (Kipnis et al., 1980, p. 447; Yukl & Falbe, 1990). About the same time, another notable organizational research line, visionary leadership, emphasized the performative purveying of ideals and epistemic solutions (e.g., Westley & Mintzberg, 1989). Though these bedrock approaches provide valuable insights on leaders' influence on followers, they gloss over *how* leaders shape the meaning of events, provide directions, or provide rationales. Theory and research in *framing* offer additional, valuable insights in understanding how leaders' wording and language use influences others' perceptions of events, situations, and needed action.

To frame is to select some aspects of a perceived reality and make them more salient in a communicating text, in such a way as to promote a particular problem definition, causal interpretation, moral evaluation, and/or treatment recommendation for the subject matter described (Fairhurst, 2011). Similar conceptualizations include sensegiving, vision casting, and issue-selling (e.g., Hensman, 2015; Lauche & Erez, 2023). Using common parlance, is framing simply expressing a point-of-view? Is someone else's frame adopted immediately, or does it emerge weeks later in retrospective sensemaking? Questions also persist as to whether leaders can learn to frame strategically and if and when frames are effective (e.g., Carnahan et al., 2019; Fairhurst, 2005).

One challenge rests in the nature of framing; few concepts are so simple to grasp, yet so difficult to comprehensively define. Other challenges arise from multiple definitions, varying approaches regarding what to measure and what constitutes effectiveness, and its multi-level, processual nature. To appreciate framing as a potential communicative means of leader influence,

it is important to assess theoretical and research developments in this area and note known applications and tactics.

To accomplish these goals, this chapter begins with a review of four overlapping approaches to framing, highlighting their insights offered to the practice of leadership: anthropological/sociological (Bateson, 1972; Goffman, 1974; Snow et al., 1986); cognitive/psychological (Kahneman & Tversky, 1979); interactive/relational (Donohue, 2011); and message design logics (MDL; O'Keefe, 1988). Because framing has been examined as both an art and a science, treatment is next given to framing effects and mechanisms, followed by theoretically informed strategies for enacting framing in practice. The intersections of framing and leadership are then explored in a variety of organizational and relational contexts, followed by critique and directions for future research.

The Science and Art of Framing

Frames can be explored from the perspective of individuals, dyads, groups, and mass audiences. The framing process may consist of a one-way attempt at asserting one's frames or an interactive co-creation of mutual understanding or agreement. As expositions exist of ontological and epistemological differences among approaches to framing (e.g., Cornelissen & Werner, 2014; Dewulf et al., 2009; Fairhurst, 2005), this select literature review provides readers with a general background and delineates among approaches to defining and evaluating framing behaviors.

It is important to note that those who enact leadership vary in their communication acumen, deliberativeness, strategic ability, and/or moral character and thus in their comfort with and ability to frame. Certain contexts may also be more or less conducive toward the employment of framing (i.e., bureaucracy, routine manufacturing, sales department). The sophistication and ethical considerations in framing use also range, depending on individual, relational, and contextual elements. Additional complexities play out in its enactment as almost any belief, motivation, object, situation, relationship, or action can be "framed."

What is a Frame and What Does it Mean to Frame?

Several shared premises are present in popular approaches to framing, presented below and in Table 19.1: (a) all humans use frames to categorize and organize their experience; (b) when individuals share their frames with others in a deliberate manner, they aim to make the frame's attributes salient to recipients; (c) frames are also shared inadvertently without intent to persuade; (d) individuals are influenced by exposure to others' frames; and (e) frames often foreground one or more interpretations while ignoring or placing others in the background as nonessential or less relevant. When framing efforts are strategic in nature, message senders are deemed rational in their intention and design of messages. Less agreement among the approaches exists as to the prominence of goal specification and audience analysis.

Table 19.1 Popular approaches to framing and their application in organizations

Conceptualization	*Anthropology/ sociology*	*Cognitive/social psychology*	*Interactional/relational*	*Message design logic*
Key works	Bateson, 1972; Goffman, 1974; Snow et al., 1986; Bedford & Snow, 2000	Kahneman & Tversky, 1979, 1984	Donohue, 2011	O'Keefe, 1988; Fairhurst, 2005; Fairhurst & Sarr, 1996
Description	Individuals define situations according to their frame of reference and communicate to convince others to view their frame as the "accurate" or "real" definition.	Framing a situation and its outcomes in positive or negative terms influences an individual's attention, evaluation, and choice.	Framing is an interactive process over time where parties seek to change or align each another's interpretations to result in various degrees of shared agreement.	Throughout the lifespan, development in cognitive complexity results in implicit beliefs about communication and the ability for greater sophistication in crafting messages.
Theoretical basis	Evolutionary biology, symbolic interactionism, social construction, social movements.	Prospect theory, rational decision making, economics.	Conflict management, negotiation, social construction.	Cognitive complexity, communication competence.
Key communication aspect	Organic and/or strategic communication as the means of shared understanding.	Articulation of scenarios and relevant consequences.	Communication creates transient structures that guide message exchange and meaning construction.	Acumen in using strategy for audience- and goal-oriented communication.
Prototypical context	Symbolic interpretation of human experience.	Decision making.	Interpersonal communication and negotiations.	Tailoring of interpersonal and mass messages.

Conceptualization	*Anthropology/ sociology*	*Cognitive/social psychology*	*Interactional/relational*	*Message design logic*
Leader communication considerations	A leader's role involves communicating to define situations in terms that align with the organization's mission and vision and benefit organizational stakeholders.	Positive/negative or gain/loss explanations shape risk assessments and can influence how followers evaluate or buy in to leaders' decisions.	Leaders are responsible not only for crafting framed messages, but for facilitating frame alignment. Framing involves two-way communication in the context of an existing relationship.	Depending on the situation and audience, the use of an expressive, conventional, or strategic (rhetorical) logic may be more effective. Strategic MDL use reflects a leader's heightened sensitivity to language and thus to the concept and act of framing.

Conceptualization	*Anthropology/ sociology*	*Cognitive/social psychology*	*Interactional/relational*	*Message design logic*
Follower communication considerations	Follower interpretations may be disadvantaged in shaping organizational realities given power imbalances and the weight afforded to leaders' sensegiving communication. Informal communication and coalition building provide means through which followers can assert their collective understanding of organizational happenings.	Understanding how gain or loss framed messages prime follower responses can increase resilience and resistance to persuasion attempts. The use of framing can help draw decision makers' attention to and evaluation of certain courses of action.	Followers must participate in joint framing activities if expected to believe in and/or commit to the interpretations and actions associated with the frame. Follower communication is likely to vary when leaders' framing attempts are intended to induce compliance vs. foster mutual agreement.	Challenging assumptions that followers should be compliant or conventional can open door for strategic follower communication. Emphasis on preparation and premeditation (read, priming) in the tailoring of communication.
Example leader framing studies	Liu, 2010	Naidoo, 2016	Lauche & Erez, 2023	Barbour et al., 2013

Sensegiving, helping others to understand themselves and their work (Foldy et al., 2008), is a similar, but a distinct concept. A chief charge of framing is to help accentuate various messages over others, thereby shaping others' understanding. In contrast, sensegiving restricts individuals' ability to create and select frames, while also artificially severing potential collective sensemaking processes. Recent longitudinal work indicates that sensegiving effectiveness varies by person, indicating that, despite a leader's best efforts, some followers may dodge, delete, or

disregard information that does not align with their personal mental models (Hoppmann et al., 2023).

Early works position frames psychologically as linguistic concepts to define or transform the meanings of situations that individuals experience (Bateson, 1972; Goffman, 1974) or schemata (un)consciously used to organize and convey one's experience (Entman, 1993). Later works emphasize frames as communication acts that seek to interpret events or uncertainties for others (Fairhurst, 2011; Fairhurst & Sarr, 1996) or as "transient structures disputants build around conflict issues" that convey points of view (Drake & Donohue, 1996, p. 302). As communicative acts, frames are built to be interpreted in a certain way accompanied by the intention to affect a change (attitudinal, emotional, and/or behavioral) or response in the message recipient.

Anthropological/Sociological Approaches of Framing

Bateson's (1955, 1972) works highlight the importance of "play" in meta-communication, where parties distinguish the meaning of a behavior (i.e., fighting) when it deviates from that which is typically denoted by the behavior (playfulness rather than hostility). Categorizing an activity as "This is play," a party interprets the associated actions differently from a threat, which requires the ability to discriminate between behavioral nuances and "frame" the behavior accordingly.

The analogies of a picture frame and mathematical set theory illustrate the way psychological framing delimits a set of messages or actions (Bateson, 1972). "The picture frame tells the viewer that he is not to use the same sort of thinking in interpreting the picture that he might use in interpreting the wallpaper outside the frame" (p. 323). Definitional statements from leaders or followers such as "This workgroup is a family" or "This team is a circus" imply that behavior among its members should be enacted and interpreted differently than other teams that cannot be classified as such. For Bateson, salience is a key aspect, "the frame merely assists the mind in understanding the contained messages by reminding the thinker that these messages are mutually relevant and the messages outside the frame may be ignored" (p. 323).

In turn, Goffman's (1974) popular ideas about framing stem from his dramaturgical metaphor of life as theater and from an integration of structuralist notions with Bateson's work. Individuals and social groups rely on frameworks – assumed interpretations of the world – without which experience would have no meaning. Certain frameworks are primary to individuals' identity, whereas others are "contested" as individuals interact with one another and learn of alternative views. For our purposes here, an important contribution is his introduction of *keying* and *fabrication* triggering mechanisms.

Keying involves a reclassification of an experience to indicate its true and changed meaning. Keying statements such as "They're not fighting, they're just horsing around" or "Hauling this wood isn't a job, it's how I stay in good health" serve not only to clarify what is seen as true, but to alter how the behavior is interpreted and evaluated. Alternatively, fabrication deceives rather than clarifies and can be benign (surprise parties and practical jokes) or exploitive (fraud, lying to discredit a competitor). In both cases, individuals' understanding of "what happened" is altered through the transformation that occurs when their or another's experience is framed.[1]

A key takeaway from these approaches is that a change in description of an action can alter how an action or event is understood and appraised. Though frames derive seemingly with ease, developing more nuanced frames may rely at times on refined skill and experience. Organizational leaders with considerable access to information may have greater confidence in their own frames and might be perceived as more credible than those with less experience or lacking similar information access. In this regard, receptivity to a leader's frame or developing a frame independently might be more of an act of uncertainty management than uncertainty reduction (Kramer, 2014), though both outcomes seem readily possible. How individuals choose between equally plausible frames became the focus of cognitive and social psychologists, which is considered next.

Cognitive/Social Psychological Approaches of Framing

Psychological approaches emphasize framing's effects on cognitions, attitudes, and decisions. In a now classic series of studies, Kahneman and Tversky (1979, 1984) presented lab subjects with logically equivalent scenarios where the gain/loss framing affected the extent to which a subject selected a risky option. At the risk of oversimplification, gain framed messages tend to result in risk averse decisions whereas loss framed messages evoke an openness toward taking risks to mitigate the extent of potential losses. These studies depicted what is commonly referred to as prospect theory, where decision makers experience aversion to loss, and inspired a host of studies intent on comparing the efficacy of framing effects.

Academic fields interested in the use of frames for social influence include public health messaging, political, environmental communication, and mass-media research. For instance, agenda-setting media scholars tie framing to selection and salience (Entman, 1993). Scheufele (2004) articulates specific types of framing effects (activation, attitudinal, formation, and transformation) to distinguish framing from priming and agenda setting. A priming mechanism makes existing cognitive schema more accessible whereas the applicability of a framed message introduces new schema and can facilitate cognitive or attitudinal change (Scheufele & Terksbury, 2007).

Meta-analyses to date, however, provide modest to minimal support for framing experiments in controlled lab settings. Meta-analyses of lab studies indicate that positive and negative framing have small effects on moral-type political judgments (McDonald et al., 2021). In testing for differences in effectiveness between positively and negatively phrased disease prevention messages, only positive framing for dental hygiene and loss framing for breast cancer messages (O'Keefe & Jensen, 2007, 2009) had modest effects and other diseases (e.g., smoking) were not significant. In addition, Amsalem and Zoizner (2022) found modest significant effects associated with both positively and negatively framed political messages for attitudinal and emotional political outcome variables, but marginal effects on behavioral outcomes. The actual magnitudes of such effects may remain elusive due to an inability of research designs to parse out whether the effect is due to frame exposure or persuasive messaging more generally (Carnahan et al., 2019).

Many lessons for leadership framing can be taken from cognitive/social psychological research. Leaders' intent on motivating employees to embrace changes in structure might emphasize a frame that highlights the relatively easy steps that can lead to well-received outcomes (e.g., increased access, less paperwork, greater profitability). Alternatively, efforts to motivate followers to engage in major changes may be more successful by emphasizing certain dangers such as a fall in the public's esteem, loss of market share, or job losses. Certainly, the success of any leader change-messages appears to address followers' "values, ideal, and needs" (Yukl, 2012, p. 75). Yet, the presence of competing messages within the organization or in popular media coverage could easily reduce the perceived magnitude of gain or loss conveyed in a leader's message.

Interactive Approach to Framing

A third approach to framing focuses on interaction patterns in dyadic communication episodes such as negotiation. Broadly speaking, frames are co-constructed between parties and lend themselves more to a constellation or constellations of positions, rights, and motivations. In the context of negotiation, frames can be defined as "transient communicative structures disputants build around conflict issues during each turn at talk" (Drake & Donohue, 1996, p. 302). This conceptualization emphasizes the use of linguistic codes to co-create, dispute, and reach agreement on relevant issues and positions. Similarly, Dewulf et al. (2009) state, "Conflict framing is an interactional process in which the meaning of the conflict situation is co-constructed through the meta-communicational aspects of discourse" (p. 163).

Frame analysis of interactions can identify topical patterns that serve as a marker within which progress toward explicating interests and positions occurs. Frames operationalized as patterns of linguistic synchrony (via textual analysis) offer insights into frame construction, modification, evidence of mutual understanding of others' perspectives, and the goals of the parties during the interaction (Niederhoffer & Pennebaker, 2002; Putnam & Holmer, 1992). The content or meta-communication message in frames during a negotiation may shift from differing expectations to greater alignment of interests (Strokes & Hewitt, 1976). If, for example, one party contests another's framing by offering a competing or counter perspective, agreements are less likely to occur. Consequently, by considering frames as interaction structures and employing a move-by-move analysis over time, researchers can observe the way frames are introduced, dismissed, reframed, and transformed in a systematic manner. Though descriptive in nature, interaction frames yield "important insights about how conflict contexts are constructed, and how these contexts are linked to outcomes" (Donohue, 2011, p. 49).

Leaders may benefit from considering framing as interactive in nature, a two-way communicative activity. Often leadership is conceptualized in terms of vision casting, which can exaggerate the influence of the leader's one-way messaging on a broad audience. Leaders daily engage in a myriad of interactions where they are dialoguing or working through advantages or disadvantages to courses of action in problem solving sessions, playing the devil's advocate when in one-on-one or team meetings, or prodding higher-level executives or those below in the hierarchy to consider different stances (Barnes et al., 2023; Steinbach et al., 2019). A larger

question is to what extent leaders' frames evolve in response to feedback from others and their attempt to build upon presently accepted points of view. Alternatively, to what extent do leaders push back unacceptable frames of subordinates or nudge subordinates' frames toward positions more acceptable to the leaders? By paying attention to the patterns in dyadic or small group conversations, leaders can more readily discern current relational states, the extent to which reciprocal communication is occurring, and whether such patterns are evolving into shared understanding and alignment. Relatedly, MDL (O'Keefe, 1988) offers additional insight into framing, and potential leadership tools.

Message Design Logics

MDL theory (O'Keefe, 1988; O'Keefe & McCornack, 1987) provides a conceptual framework leaders can draw upon when assessing their communication goals, persuasive efforts, potential rhetorical devices, and other communicative acts. In contrast to fields where framing is more or less depicted in neutral terms, communication scholars cast framing as a value-laden and ethical activity in organizational contexts rife with politics and competing agendas (Fairhurst, 2011). MDL theory provides a backdrop for leaders to learn to use language to influence individuals' cognitive schemas as well as managing more collective sensemaking through vision articulation.

According to O'Keefe (1988), individuals have implicit theories about how to construct messages and tend to choose one of three MDLs: expressive, conventional, and rhetorical. The expressive MDL assumes the purpose of communication is to share one's thoughts and feelings clearly with another. Individuals who rely on this logic tend to speak directly and interpret messages literally. The conventional logic views communication as a game where appropriateness and cooperation are valued in light of contextually situated social rules. The third is a rhetorical logic, one based on the understanding of communication as the "creation and negotiation of social selves and situations" (O'Keefe, 1988, p. 87). The rhetorical logic, as the name suggests, is employed by savvy and persuasive communicators who possess the ability to frame sophisticated messages to reach multiple goals.

Applications to leader framing and influence efforts from MDL research have investigators sharing scenarios and asking participants to craft a goal-oriented message. These messages are then coded by researchers as expressive, conventional, or rhetorical (e.g., Barbour et al., 2013; White & Malkowski, 2014). For instance, O'Keefe and McCornack (1987) report positive associations between MDL sophistication, cognitive complexity, and competence. Applied to efforts to offer supportive communication, person-centered messages use a design logic framework where sophisticated messages (re)frame a relevant situation. The goal is to influence the recipient to receive support by interpreting a stressor (e.g., rhetorical message) in a new light (Burleson, 1987).

In sum, these four approaches to framing offer greater insight into how leaders seek to influence others than global "rational" tactics (Yukl & Falbe, 1990) or visionary leadership (Westley & Mintzberg, 1989) that garnered widespread attention over three decades ago. Each gives clues for how individuals advance their perspectives and values in discussions or even organization-wide

messaging to others. An interest in the use of frames in organizations is widespread (e.g., Cornelissen & Werner, 2014). Yet, few expositions or practical tools exist on how to frame.

Message design offers an important point of departure for leaders who seek to improve their communication skills and influence those with whom they interact. Fairhurst (Fairhurst, 2011; Fairhurst & Sarr, 1996) provides one of the few expositions and practical tools to assist managers and leaders in leveraging frame opportunities throughout everyday interactions. The following section briefly considers her guidance to leaders, with commentary selectively inserted.

The Art of Enacting Framing

Framing as an art involves strategic management of meaning and requires attention to one's own perspective and goals, the experiences and perspectives of others, and context. Leadership opportunities occur at every communicative touchpoint, where managers serve as a source for how employees view organizational actions and interpret events. Leaders who possess a keen sensitivity to language (i.e., strategic/rhetorical design logic) and its use are more likely to develop competence in framing than those who routinely enact expressive or conventional responses (Fairhurst & Sarr, 1996). Adopting a MDL approach (O'Keefe, 1988), frames can give context to the purpose of a team meeting, interpret the organization's mission, or help employees understand their role in the organization's success.

When done well, framing can define a vision, shape impression management, and enhance empowerment (Fairhurst, 2001; Fairhurst & Sarr, 1996). Yet without reflection and keen sensemaking skills, leaders may struggle to enact frames that influence others. This may stem from the fact that while many leaders are skilled verbally (i.e., expansive vocabulary, mastery of industry jargon, confident voice projection, etc.), leadership training and practice can reflect a rudimentary transmission model of communication. *The Art of Framing* sought to introduce to management audiences a meaning-centered model (rather neglected up to that point in time), which emphasized the potency of communication inherent to charismatic, visionary, and transformational leadership theories (G. Fairhurst, personal communication, December 7, 2023). Taken together, framing in practice is a complex and layered practice that requires high levels of communication competence.

Fairhurst and Sarr (1996) argue that framing can be broken down into skill sets which independently enhance one's ability to frame. In combination, skills such as goal setting, figurative language use, priming for spontaneity, context sensitivity, and developing mental models can enhance frame efficacy (Fairhurst, 2005). The basics of developing framing skills involve three components: language, thought, and forethought (Fairhurst & Sarr, 1996).[2]

Developing Framing Skills: Language, Thought, and Forethought

Language enables individuals to make sense of or manage situations that may be vague or abstract. Mental pictures, created through frames, classify or sort information into categories or familiar schema, which can be recurrently drawn upon. Initial framing efforts often use metaphoric

language that offers valuable comparisons and illustration (Fairhurst, 2005). A recent study reports a number of the ways that employees use metaphors to describe their managers. Metaphors such as mama bear, KGB agent, or even Hitler illustrate how otherwise abstract thoughts generate reference points to paint managers as powerful, empowered, and powerless (Omilion-Hodges & Shank, 2023). Additional rhetorical devices that help in framing include jargon/catchphrases, contrast, spin, and stories (see Table 19.2).

Table 19.2 Framing tools

FramingTool	*Definition*	*Example*	*Uses*
Metaphors	A language form that compares one thing, typically something that is complex, to something else that is often easier to grasp and visualize.	"Our team functions like a well-oiled machine."	Helpful when you want to convey a complex or abstract idea or when you want to emphasize meaning.
Jargon	The use of catchphrases or other shorthand references can convey specific meaning within a specific group or industry.	"We need to put our noses to the grindstone and get this project done."	Jargon can be helpful to enhance or otherwise stress meaning.
Contrast	Defining or describing a subject via a comparison or highlighting the opposite of the subject.	"This week will not be like last week; we have completed the planning stage."	You may consider contrast when it is easier to define a subject to something else such as a previous project, client, or task.
Spin	An intentional use of language to cast a subject into a positive or negative light.	"The new sales management system is going to save you countless hours while helping you to earn higher commissions."	This framing tool is helpful when you want to either emphasize the benefits or drawbacks of a particular subject (i.e., process, client, initiative).

FramingTool	*Definition*	*Example*	*Uses*
Stories	Explain a subject by providing vivid examples, anecdotes, or experiences.	"You are now part of an organization that began when two humble sisters united the community to care for those who couldn't care for themselves. Let me tell you more about the Smith sisters… ."	This tool can be helpful in building rapport, shaping culture, and engaging others' attention.

Source: Adapted from Fairhurst & Sarr, 1996

Thought, the second component in Fairhurst's (Fairhurst & Sarr, 1996) framing enactment, appropriates mental models or individual images and ideas to depict how the world (or organization) works (Senge, 1990). In essence, "leaders who understand their world can explain their world" (Fairhurst & Sarr, 1996, p. 23). Leaders should be able to answer followers "why, where, what, and who" questions (Fairhurst, 2011, p. 7). In *The Art of Framing*, Fairhurst and Sarr (1996) capture a conversation where a manager shares ideas about leadership and the managerial role with an employee, using terms like "participation," "involvement," and "wrestling with issues" (p. 9). The mental model is opined to the employee in an attempt to forge shared understanding. This employee has her own mental models of leadership, illustrating that frames can be readily contested. It also illustrates that self-reflection and discussions with others are vital to cultivate a greater understanding of the assumptions that guide interpretations and behaviors. As Dewulf et al. (2009) note, an initial challenge resides in managers struggling to consider other perspectives and "see the world through multiple lenses" (p. 185).

Forethought, the third skill component, entails exerting control over spontaneous communication (Fairhurst, 2011). Many interactions in organizational settings are impromptu, but it is still important to exert awareness over communicative choices. The goal is to be strategic *and* goal oriented when in spontaneous exchanges (Fairhurst, 2005). This aspect of framing includes reflection, as awareness of one's mental models is essential to engage in forethought. A premise here is that leaders with greater self- and other-awareness have greater resources with which to shape their communicative encounters with others, from planned meetings to spontaneous conversations that occur in passing. Leaders' mental models act as "a perceptual filter through which information is passed" (Paoletti et al., 2019, p. 284) and impact all aspects of their tasks and performance (Partlow et al., 2015). Those who understand their mental models are positioned to converse in a way that aligns with those models and workgroup goals rather than simply reacting to others' frames.

Implementing Framing Skills

A major challenge for leaders (and everyone else) is moving from ideation to articulation (Astley & Zammuto, 1992). Fairhurst and Sarr (1996) suggest that individuals first draw from their mental

models (which are general) to the context (which is specific) to consider what to say and how to say it. They position framing as a process that begins from the inside out, emphasizing the inexorable link to tasks, relationships, or identity. Task goals in the workplace include project deadlines, new initiatives, or implementing changes to procedures. Relationship goals focus on preserving, enhancing, and/or maintaining interpersonal associations. Identity goals, the third type of goal, often center around maintaining self-image or impression management.

Although articulating task, relational, and identity goals in framing may seem clearcut, factors such as timing, conflict, and complexity present challenges to messaging when interacting with others. Most employees have multiple task goals that they manage simultaneously, and leaders have their own goals while also managing the task goals for the team. Moreover, employees or entire unit personnel may not agree with the leader's project priorities or have invested in competing goals. Managers must often navigate multiple goals, where task accomplishment goals compete with relational or identity goals. This illustration helps to demonstrate the complexity of goals and the communicative challenges associated with considering specific contexts.

Coaching and Training

Although the regular, often inadvertent use of frames is a common aspect of most communication, leaders may feel ambivalent about developing their ability in strategic framing (Fairhurst, 2005). Framing involves a challenging skill with cognitive formation (interpretations, scripts, schemas) and communicative enactment (messages, language) aspects. The art of framing thus involves reflexivity of one's own perspective and goals, awareness, and sensitivity toward the recipient's point of view, and the ability to use language to articulate a plausible and persuasive description of the relevant issue or event (Fairhurst & Sarr, 1996). Leaders may have a point of view but expressing it in a way that shapes employees' viewpoints is another matter altogether.

Coaching may help leaders become more explicitly aware of the frames that they rely upon to make sense of the world and how these frames connect to their goals, priorities, and assumptions. For example, leadership frames held by leaders or followers may be based on implicit views of prototypical leader/follower behavior (Lord et al., 2020) or be blinded to their own or systemic biases (Deetz, 2003). Reflecting upon one's leadership frame(s), perhaps through metaphor, carries implications for both the leader's self-presentation and their perceived relationship to followers (Omilion-Hodges & Shank, 2023). In short, research should explore the extent to which assisting leaders in gaining self- and audience-awareness facilitates their ability to align frames to their followers or employees. Coaching conversations (Witherspoon, 2014) that explore the intersection between a leader's interpretations, actions, and their communication is likely to be an insightful endeavor.

Leaders can also be trained to incorporate rhetorical devices such as metaphor, jargon, contrast, spin, and story into their leadership practice (Fairhurst & Sarr, 1996; Reference Table 2 for examples). The use of such devices enhances the "stickiness" of a frame by evoking emotion through credible, easy to understand messages (Heath & Heath, 2007). Training leaders to improve at framing is not without challenges given the complexity associated with spontaneously adjusting

communication in light of instrumental, relational, and identity goals (Fairhurst, 2005). Effective training may require familiarity with rhetorical methods, understanding of message characteristics that encourage diffusion or adoption, in addition to deliberate practice in different situations and contexts to encourage generalization and transfer of framing skills to the variety of situations a leader will encounter (Ericsson, 2006; Ford et al., 2018).

The transfer of learned skills to in situ practice involves more than what occurs in a formal training experience. Leaders' attitude or disposition toward the concept of framing, the opportunity to practice the new skill in a supportive workplace environment, and the extent to which they receive feedback on their growth can all enhance or undermine skill development (Fairhurst, 2005; Ford et al., 2018). This overview of the art of framing provides a broad map of the nuts and bolts of formulating frames. The next section considers several related persuasive strategies within organizational contexts and directions for framing future research in this arena.

Looking Back to Move Forward

Related Persuasive Strategies

Compliance gaining and upward influence are strategic communication strategies designed to have another (or a group) comply with a request. Considering the intent of these persuasive strategies, it is easy to see why many find this form of communication attractive. This brief overview presents its foundational studies, highlights ethical and efficacy considerations surrounding their use, and considers links between compliance gaining, upward influence, and framing.

Marwell and Schmitt's (1967) seminal work identified 16 different communication strategies that individuals use to induce compliance with their requests (see Table 19.3). These strategies are organized via five types of communicative techniques including rewarding and punishing activities, expertise, and activation of impersonal and personal commitments. Table 19.3 exemplifies the various communication strategies with common workplace illustrations, using the shouldering of the imaginary "Smith project" as the message sender's goal.

Table 19.3 Illustrating compliance gaining strategies in the workplace

	Compliance gaining strategy	*Workplace illustration*
Rewarding activity	Promise	"I will put your name up for the promotion if you lead the Smith project."
	Liking	You compliment your subordinate's work frequently and treat them to a special lunch when you ask them to lead the Smith project.
	Pre-giving	You increase your subordinate's work budget before asking them to lead the Smith project.

	Compliance gaining strategy	*Workplace illustration*
Punishing activity	Threat	"You will take yourself out of the running for the promotion if you do not lead the Smith project."
	Averse stimulation	"There is no budget increase and in fact your funds are frozen unless you plan to lead the Smith project."
Expertise	Expertise (positive)	"If you lead the Smith project, your work will be more visible and therefore you're more likely to earn a promotion and a larger salary."
	Expertise (negative)	"If you do not lead the Smith project, higher-ups will likely remain unaware of your contributions and therefore you're not likely to be considered for a promotion."
Activation of impersonal commitments	Self-feeling (negative)	"You will feel bad about yourself if you decide to pass on the Smith project."
	Self-feeling (positive)	"You will feel proud of yourself when you lead the Smith project."
	Altercasting (positive)	"Since you're a senior employee with loads of experience under your belt, you naturally want to lead the Smith project."
	Altercasting (negative)	"It would be selfish if an experience seasoned employee chose to pass on leading the Smith project."
	Moral appeal	"It feels wrong to have anyone else lead the Smith project, because you are the senior employee, and you can take on more than your peers."
	Esteem (positive)	"Not only will our unit applaud your work, but the higher-ups will think highly of you if you lead the Smith project."
	Esteem (negative)	"It will be pretty disappointing to your peers and even to the higher-ups if you don't lead the Smith project."
Activation of personal commitments	Debt	You explicitly tell your subordinate how much you have done in terms of mentoring and removing obstacles to get them to a place where they are equipped to successfully lead the Smith project.
	Altruism	"Our unit really needs a win, so I'm asking you to lead the Smith project as a personal favor."

Since this foundational work, communication scholars have explored compliance gaining in a variety of ways, including in terms of message selection (i.e., Hunter & Boster, 1987), as a form of politeness (Baxter, 1984), and in relational communication such as between physicians and patients (Burgoon et al., 1987). Others have linked compliance gaining with leadership to explore

how those in titled leadership positions use compliance gaining (i.e., Roach, 1991; Sullivan et al., 1990), whereas others have explored how subordinates employ these same strategies to advocate for their own interests (Garko, 1993; Lamude et al., 1987). More contemporary views of subordinate use of compliance gaining falls under the umbrella of upward influence.

Upward influence tactics, such as inspiration, consultation, ingratiation, rationality, legitimating, coalitions, and pressure, provide stand-alone or coupled strategies to induce compliance and/or commitment from higher status organizational targets (Kipnis et al., 1980; Yukl & Falbe, 1990). Meta-analytic findings suggest soft and rational approaches (i.e., inspiration, consultation, rational persuasion) as more positive means of acquiring task and relational commitment whereas pressure or legitimating (hard tactics) were associated with negative outcomes (Higgins et al., 2003; Lee et al., 2017). The selection and efficacy of influence tactics may depend in part on pre-existing relationships. High LMX employees may simply need to ask or provide rational explanation whereas low-LMX counterparts may require the assistance of coalitions (Williams et al., 2016). As with any social influence technique, the short- or long-term nature of the goal, potential relational implications, and extent to which one has the authority to enact a more direct approach are all relevant considerations.

Managing up can piggyback on framing as a means for lower power actors to strategically impact outcomes (e.g., Barnes et al., 2023; Kipnis et al., 1980; Steinback et al., 2019). While traditional notions of leadership typically encapsulate a titled leader communicating to those at lower levels (downward communication), current research indicates that is not always the case. Barnes et al. (2023) found that employees in lower-level positions may be best positioned to challenge or question their leaders because of their unique understanding of day-to-day organizational issues. For instance, those at lower levels are more likely to have their finger on the pulse of the workgroup and larger organization issues than powerful leaders. As such, those who are the right-hand partner may heedfully challenge the leader in an individualized way that allows the latter to consider alternatives and better understand potential implications.

Those who manage up potentially include every member in an organization below the executive, and, according to formative research by Kipnis et al. (1980), it likely involves ingratiation, rational, coalition, exchange, and even assertiveness tactics. Future upward influence research that links lower-status employees' framing behaviors with traditional influence tactics may offer insights into the extent to which task, relational, identity frame-based goals are coupled with ingratiation or coalition tactics. Similarly, the use of framing would seem to be a key tool for those who are seeking to enlarge or change their job responsibilities (Miller et al., 1996). Those engaging in role negotiation may frame their request, in part, in terms of how changes in assignments or duties would enhance a workgroup's or their supervisor's productivity (Kramer et al., 2024).

While these persuasive strategies may offer an appealing option to influence others, there are ethical and relational considerations to weigh. Employing persuasive strategies may result in quick compliance, but with negative consequences. In established relationships there is the expectation that someone, a manager, for example, will simply ask an employee to lead a project, take on

another client, or prepare the presentation. When managers activate personal commitments or indebtedness strategies multiple times, employees may question their manager's motives if they violate the communication norms of the relationship. The effectiveness of persuasive strategies may also be short-lived. Leaders who leverage rewards or punishments to achieve compliance may create unsustainable working relationships.

The link between framing and the above persuasive strategies is more than an implied one. Both presuppose leaders employ the nuances of language, emphasize the positioning of ideas in an intentional manner, and require the source to be perceived as credible. A frame consists of an interpretation with which a communicator attempts to define or elevate the importance of a point of view, which others incorporate into their way of thinking (Druckman, 2001). Though they may involve frames, influence tactics emphasize external social and relational obligations (i.e., compliance gaining) or even rational arguments as well as relational appeals (i.e., upward influence) while leveraging the authority or status of the initiator of the request. It is important to note that a member may reject the leader's frame, yet still comply due to pressure of some kind. Alternatively, member belief in or commitment to a point of view suggests an acceptance of the frame.

New Directions for Framing Research

While framing has a rich and long history, there are clear avenues for future research. While not exhaustive, three areas that hold particular promise for communication scholars include strategic change framing, the notion of managing up, and influencing peers. First, strategic change framing from the perspective of visionary leadership and strategic management is not new (Westley & Mintzberg, 1989). However, this area has seen a considerable resurgence of attention as of late (i.e., Cooper et al., 2023; Hensman, 2015; Lauche & Erez, 2023). The heart of visionary leadership aligns with strategic management (Westley & Mintzberg, 1989) in that leaders were thought to assume a particular type of visionary leadership (e.g., creator, idealist, diviner, etc.), thereby strategically attempting to influence followers in a specific way. More contemporary research (Cooper et al., 2023) has also included honesty and message credibility, reframing honest communication as a shared dyadic process that begins with belief formation and ends with recipient understanding. In this sense, a leader, for example, would be charged with developing and validating how much information they intend to share with their followers, and then decide the extent to which they want to be truthful, how much information they are willing or able to disclose, and how they intend to deliver the information (Cooper et al., 2023). This line of inquiry moves beyond shortcuts such as omission, dodging questions, avoidance, and misleading responses to better understand the strategic and complex communicative framing processes at play.

Another vein of related contemporary visionary leadership research includes issue selling. Unlike most other perspectives, Lauche and Erez (2023) considered framing from the perspective of followers and how they (individually or collectively) strategically impact organizational change. They found that productive confrontation, avoiding escalation, and collective moaning were part and parcel with the framing process via opportunity, renewal, and avoiding past

problems respectively. In this sense, followers – often thought to have little power – can initiate and shape organizational change via issue selling, which begins with strategic framing. Similarly, Steinbach et al. (2019) emphasize the fact that while much information is disseminated in organizations, it is not clear how messages are interpreted and if there are multiple interpretations for the same event. In this sense, managers are encouraged to engage in self-regulation to further develop their capacity to modify how they process information. In this sense, the leader is not the only nor necessarily the predominant source of information, but rather simply part of the strategic framing process.

Second, prominent in broader conceptualizations of leadership include "external" actions, such as networking, external monitoring, and representing (Morgeson et al., 2010; Yukl, 2012). More communication-based conceptualizations (e.g., Johansson et al., 2014) also consider interactions and efforts at influencing other managers at the same level but in different departments. In other words, those in leadership positions engage in networking, information seeking and sharing, protecting their unit's budget and personnel from other units, and forming coalitions (Appelbaum et al., 2012). As Morgeson et al. (2010) point out, obtaining other unit leaders' buy-in to ideas or arriving at agreements on the nature of problems are vital functions in increasingly less centralized organizations. Like nascent investigations into managing up, research explorations on framing laterally within organizations has yet to be a focus of serious inquiry. Influencing peers through framing may offer particularly unique insights into frames that depict gains or losses (Kahneman & Tversky, 1984) related to potential agreements and courses of action or arriving at agreements though parties see issues differently (Dewulf et al., 2011; Donohue, 2011).

Research Challenges

Critiques of psychological framing research offer recommendations for examining its effects in more precise ways (Carnahan et al., 2019; Liu & Scheufele, 2016; Scheufele & Tewksbury, 2007). Namely, research designs must consider whether to use equivalent messages framed differently (equivalence framing) or messages that emphasize contrasting positions on an issue (emphasis framing). How frames are operationalized can help to distinguish framing from other psychological effects such as priming or agenda setting. Further, measuring how familiar an individual is with an issue can shed light on whether the message simply reinforced a pre-existing belief or value or influenced a change in perception due to the presentation of new or unique information (Carnahan et al., 2019).

Framing research that focuses on how frames are built or designed does not include the information necessary to precisely understand the effects of the frames on the recipient. Interaction patterns identified in conversations provide insightful descriptions about how framed messages are reciprocated and challenged yet are limited in the inferences it can make about causal relationships. Message design logics theory, though intuitive, involves assumptions on effective communication and may be biased in suggesting rhetorical messages as the more sophisticated and strategic option. Future investigations that explore employees' responses to their leaders' frame

efforts, especially those that generate insight into the reasons for accepting or rejecting frames, may offer timely information from an audience-centered perspective. For example, do senior or mid-level managers actually abandon their frames that offer alternative perspectives to the chief executive's framing of organizational actions or outcomes? Do these followers temporarily adopt the executive's frame out of loyalty, because they are persuaded, or due to political expediency?

A major limitation to framing research is the difficulty in addressing competing sources of influence that confound the intuitive notion that framed communication messages are highly impactful. The modest to moderate framing effects in lab experiments (McDonald et al., 2021) are likely to diminish in organizational settings where competing messages and political motivation abound. In this context, leaders and followers would not disadvantage themselves by learning to frame messages through more artful and persuasive communication. However, the multitude of influences (e.g., norms, leader-member relationship, power, peers, etc.) present in leadership episodes make it difficult to parse out whether it is the frame that results in a desired outcome. Research that involves more precise measurement, consideration to alternative sources of influence, and examines the duration of the effect over time will add considerable value.

Finally, the current landscape of technological, structural, and cultural developments associated with distributed or remote work, artificial intelligence, mediate messages, polarization, etc. presents a complex communication ecosystem for the study of framing. Organizational leaders must grapple with how to tailor framed messages to resonate in one-on-one contexts or with a group of stakeholders while not evoking negative reactance from secondary or unintended audiences. Ethical and legal considerations also become imperative when organizations use AI technologies to determine which aspects to make salient in internally or externally conveyed frames. Given the prevalence of competing, sometimes polarizing, frames encountered in and about organizations that may disrupt influence attempts by leaders and member alike, the science and art of strategic leadership framing is of compelling relevance.

Notes

1. Of note, the action itself does not change, only its meaning. "The systematic transformation that a particular keying introduces may alter only slightly the activity thus transformed, but it utterly changes what it is a participant would say was going on" (Goffman, 1974, p. 45).⏎
2. A similar, alternative pedagogical model, entitled the Rules of Reality Construction by Fairhurst (2011), consists of "control the context, define the situation, apply ethics, interpret uncertainty, design response, and control spontaneity" (pp. 2–8).⏎

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Further Reading

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20

NARRATIVES IN LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-24

Introduction

Steve Jobs once famously said that "the most powerful person in the world is the storyteller. The storyteller sets the vision, values and agenda of an entire generation that is to come." It is thus perhaps not surprising that narratives and storytelling are fundamental to the constitution of leadership. In and through storytelling, leader identities are talked into being and notions of leadership are created, negotiated, and sometimes challenged. This relevance of narratives and storytelling is further reflected in the considerable research interest from scholars across disciplines, including Business and Organisation Sciences, Linguistics, Communication, Education, and Medicine, just to name a few. Given the focus of this handbook, in this chapter we mainly zoom in on research conducted within the first three of these fields of inquiry.

We begin this chapter by providing a brief overview of some theoretical concepts relevant to research on leadership narratives and storytelling, before discussing two strands of empirical research that respectively revolve around stories *about* leadership and stories *doing* leadership. We then discuss implications for practice, before ending the chapter with a brief outline of an agenda for future research.

Theoretical Foundations of Leadership Narratives and Storytelling

In line with the narrative turn in the social sciences more generally, leadership studies are increasingly paying attention to narratives and storytelling. They are interested in understanding who tells a story, when and what role the audience plays, as well as what functions these stories perform, and how they are being told. Most research on leadership narratives focuses in particular on exploring how the processes of meaning-making, knowledge construction and identity negotiation are accomplished in and through narratives, rather than "establishing universal relationships among abstract concepts" (Fenton & Langley, 2011, p. 1184).

But what exactly is a narrative? The answer to this question is far from straightforward as there are many differences between various disciplines and research traditions regarding what is labelled as a narrative. We follow McCabe and Van De Mieroop (2022, p. 245) when they claim that "*not all discourse is narrative*" (emphasis in original), and we believe that stretching what is covered by the label "narrative" too much merely dilutes its meaning (Reisigl, 2021), potentially even to the extent that the term may become meaningless (Van De Mieroop, 2021). To complicate matters further, particular research traditions often also adhere to certain highly specific terminological distinctions relating to narrative. To name just one illustrative example from the two research strands discussed in more detail below: regarding the basic difference between narratives and stories, many researchers in the discursive tradition view the former as a an umbrella term and the latter as a specific type of narrative (i.e., stories are narratives "with a point," cf. Norrick, 2007, p. 128), while in organisational narrative analysis, stories are viewed as "existing narratives that can be told and retold in various forms" (Vaara et al., 2016, p. 498). Yet, in both traditions, the terms are often also used interchangeably (see e.g., Vaara et al., 2016 as well as Clifton et al., 2020) – as we will also do in this chapter.

Given the terminological and definitional confusion surrounding the term narrative, we now clearly stipulate that in this chapter, we draw on the linguistic tradition and use Labov's minimal definition of narratives as "a sequence of two clauses which are *temporally ordered*" (Labov, 1972, p. 360). Much earlier research on narratives defined in this way has focused on so-called "big stories," which are typically "personal, past experience stories of non-shared events" which are relatively long, well-structured, and very tellable (Georgakopoulou, 2006, p. 123). These big stories are often told (and re-told) in interview contexts, and they tend to follow, more or less closely, the canonical structure of narratives identified by Labov and Waletzky (1966). Such stories typically start with an *abstract* which explains why the subsequent story is worth telling. This is followed by the *orientation* in which the scene of the story is laid

out by introducing the characters, place, and time of the story. Next comes the *complication*, which is typically the main body where a series of events is narrated. After the complication, an *evaluation* may occur where the point or morale of the story is made explicit and the teller's attitude to the story becomes clear. This is often followed by the *resolution* (i.e., an outline of the results or outcomes of the events narrated earlier), and finally the *coda*, which enables the teller to leave the story world and return to the here-and-now of the storytelling context. However, although this narrative structure is very compelling, it is important to acknowledge that not all stories follow this strict order – especially the *evaluation* is often dispersed across the story – nor do stories always contain all these elements. Rather, many stories do not follow this structure – such as habitual narratives (Carranza, 1998) or chronicles (De Fina, 2003) – and may be more fragmented and fractured. Such stories are often grouped together under the umbrella term "small stories," which refers to "a gamut of under-represented narrative activities, such as tellings of ongoing events, future or hypothetical events, shared (known) events, but also allusions to tellings, deferrals of tellings, and refusals to tell" (Georgakopoulou, 2006, p. 123). This variety of different types of stories and narrative genres is potentially endless as these story types and genres may intersect with each other. The narrative dimensions model developed by Van de Mieroop (2021) addresses this issue and focuses on *dimensions* rather than specific genres. These dimensions either revolve around the narrator – who can have more or less ownership, authorship, and tellership of a story – or around the narrated events – which may vary along the dimensions of time, frequency, and evaluation. This model enables researchers to situate a story more precisely than a straightforward categorization according to story genres would do.

While canonical, big story narratives often aim at creating "an autonomous, unique self in discourse" (Johnstone, 1996, p. 56), all these other types of stories usually serve a range of different functions in the day-to-day business of living and telling (Georgakopoulou, 2007) in which they occur. For example, while big stories may portray the teller as a heroic and visionary leader, a hypothetical story may be a useful strategy to assist the teller to engage in leadership activities, such as giving feedback. Due to their flexibility and ability to perform a myriad of functions, stories – whether big or small – are excellent means of doing and constituting leadership.

Most research on leadership narratives and storytelling falls within one of two major strands, namely organisational narrative analysis (e.g., Boje, 2001, 2008; Vaara et al., 2016) and discursive approaches (e.g., Clifton et al., 2020). We briefly outline each.

Organisational Narrative Analysis

Organisational narrative analysis conceptualizes stories relatively broadly as "temporal, discursive constructions" (Vaara et al., 2016, p. 490) which help "make sense of organizational phenomena and [act] as a means by which such phenomena are produced, maintained and potentially challenged" (Empson, 2023, p. 205). For example, Foroughi et al. (2019, p. 135) demonstrate that "different historical periods are characterized by specific narrative ecologies," which in turn give rise to different types of narratives and counter-narratives which shape certain leadership types. Some studies take an explicitly critical perspective and illustrate how narratives are powerful allies in challenging mainstream discourses of leadership (e.g.,Jamjoom & Mills, 2023; Just & Muhr, 2019).

According to Vaara et al. (2016), three strands of research exist within organisational narrative analysis, namely functional-realist, interpretive, and poststructuralist approaches. Functional-realist approaches view narratives as tools to capture and research aspects of reality that exist "out there" independently of the narratives themselves. Interpretative approaches, on the other hand, are closely linked to sensemaking processes and analyse constructions of specific organizational phenomena and realities – whether by individuals (in so-called individual narratives) or by larger groups and collectives (in so-called composite narratives). Poststructuralist approaches to organisational narrative analysis "aim at uncovering the complexity, fragmentation and fluidity of narrative representations" (Vaara et al., 2016, p. 499). They achieve this through narrative deconstruction (which problematizes and often challenges hegemonic and taken-for-granted mainstream discourses) and narrative emergence (which focuses on how narratives contribute to the construction of organizational phenomena).

Leadership studies within the organisational narrative analysis strand often explore processes of identity construction (e.g., Shaw, 2010; Sparrowe, 2005; Wright et al., 2012). For example, analysing interviews with organizational leaders and autobiographies by prominent political, military and business leaders, Shamir et al. (2005, p. 13) find that narratives – in particular, life stories – "provide[...] the leader with a self-concept from which he or she can lead, and that telling the life story or parts of it is an important leadership behavior." While more recent research is trying to move beyond a focus on life stories, the interest on the interplay between narratives, leadership, and identity construction remains. For example, Empson et al. (2023) explore the dynamic interplay of narratives of individual and collective leadership

within a professional service firm and observe that in and through the narratives that organizational members share, they are able to claim leader identities for themselves while at the same time also granting a leader identity to the collective.

However, in spite of these recent developments, organizational narrative research still mainly focuses on big stories typical for interviews and autobiographies (Freeman, 2006), even though some efforts were made to broaden what we understand by a story, for example by introducing the concept of "antenarrative" (Boje, 1995). In spite of these efforts, most studies largely overlook other narrative genres which organically emerge in everyday interactions, and which are often less extensive than canonical narratives. Moreover, most organizational narrative analysis research views stories as end products and reflections of some sort of external reality rather than exploring how in and through the telling of stories, realities are created and literally talked into being (Clifton et al., 2020). These criticisms are addressed by research studies taking discursive approaches to leadership.

Discursive Approaches to Leadership Narratives

Discursive approaches to leadership narratives focus on the language through which stories are told. More specifically, they explore *how* stories are constructed and how in and through this storytelling certain aspects of organizational realities – such as leadership – are created and talked into being. Firmly based in the tradition of discursive leadership (Fairhurst, 2007), studies conducted in this strand of research employ a range of discourse analytical frameworks to identify and unpack the specific communicative processes through which leadership is accomplished in and through storytelling, and through which leader (and other) identities are constructed and negotiated.

For example, using different analytical approaches (including Positioning Analysis, Conversation Analysis, Membership Categorization Analysis, Interactional Sociolinguistics, and Critical Discourse Analysis), Clifton et al. (2020) demonstrate the benefits of each approach to empirically capture and analyze a specific aspect of leadership, such as dark leadership and authentic leadership. Moreover, using Positioning Theory, Clifton (2014) analyses small stories told by the participants of a business meeting and observes that storytelling is an important discursive resource assisting the tellers in creating and managing organizational meaning, thereby enabling them to create a leader identity. This ability and power of stories to not only create and manage organizational meanings, but also to decide what it means to be a leader and

what counts as effective leadership, is further attested in Schnurr's (2023) study of the stories told by celebrity leaders around the world in mediatized talks and interviews. Using Interactional Sociolinguistics for an in-depth analysis of the stories told by women in leadership positions, Schnurr observes that some of these stories challenge hegemonic discourses of leadership (which often portray leaders as tall, handsome, white, alpha males of privilege (Grint, 2010, p. 69)) and create concrete alternatives. Thus, in contrast to organizational narrative analysis, discursive approaches – regardless of which analytical approach they employ – focus on the language of storytelling and explore what the stories *do* and accomplish by being told in a particular way.

In the next section we apply the theoretical foundations of leadership narratives and storytelling that were introduced in this section to two concrete examples of short stories. Focusing on the latter of the two strands of research on leadership narratives outlined above, we illustrate how discursive approaches to leadership narratives work, paying particular attention to identifying and describing the discursive processes through which the stories are told and linking them to leadership.

Empirical Research

In this section, we discuss two research strands within the tradition of discursive leadership, which are discerned on the basis of the type of narrative that is subjected to analysis, namely, stories *about* leadership and stories that contribute to *doing* leadership in situ.

Critically Analysing Narratives About Leadership

One need not look long and hard to find stories told by leaders, as books about leadership journeys and online or TV-interviews with all sorts of leaders abound. In these outlets, storytellers share their personal experiences of how they became leaders or how they acted as leaders in crucial moments in their careers. Such stories have inspired others to use these as input for deriving what makes a person a great leader, resulting in yet another immense amount of books, videos, and websites about leadership skills and leader qualities. However, this whole body of communication is based on a "sensegiving" perspective on these narratives, rather than viewing them as "sensemaking" exercises (Fairhurst, 2007). In other words, these stories are usually understood as merely reproducing the meanings that certain events and crucial life

moments *have* in relation to these leaders' careers, while, from a discursive perspective, this meaning is actually not simply "out there" waiting to be narrated. Rather, such meaning is produced *in situ*, namely in the activity of telling the narrative. An approach that particularly capitalizes on this local production of narratives in relation to their context, is the narrative as social practice approach. This approach integrates "a focus on local interaction as a starting point for analysis" into "an understanding of the embedding of narratives within discursive and sociocultural contexts" (De Fina & Georgakopoulou, 2015, p. 3). We now discuss the three main aspects of this description, namely the analysis of: (1) the local interaction in relation to; (2) discursive; and (3) sociocultural contexts.

First of all, the analysis of the "local interaction" refers to taking a micro-oriented perspective on the specific discursive features of stories. This implies that the specific formulation of each story is studied closely so that even the tiniest discursive details are not overlooked. Typical features that are scrutinized are the use of hedges, boosters, pronouns, lexical choices, rhetorical devices, membership categories, and so on. The analysis of such features helps to tease out the specific ways in which the speaker constructs and negotiates meaning.

Second, regarding the discursive context, researchers tend to look at the specific interactional setting in which narratives are told. For example, when thinking of the vast array of leadership stories that are available on YouTube and that are produced in interviews, TED Talks, and all sorts of speeches for a variety of audiences, it is relevant to consider these specific contexts and take them into account when analyzing the narratives that are produced. For instance, below we present a story that was told during a "Women's leadership forum" and before the speaker, Reshma Saujani, comes to the stage, she is introduced as follows: "*Please join me in welcoming CEO, lawyer, author, mother, wife and genuine trailblazer Reshma Saujani.*"[1] Both elements are potentially relevant for the analysis, namely the specific context of a leadership forum that is oriented to women, as well as the fact that in addition to being introduced on the basis of professional categories to which the speaker belongs (i.e., "CEO," "lawyer," and "author"), the speaker's membership in the categories of "mother" and "wife" are also explicitly mentioned. Because of this, they are *made relevant* for this particular activity, and they can thus be easily picked up by the speaker as useful categories. However, it is equally possible that the speaker ignores these. This is, of course, more self-evident for giving a speech – because it is monologic and tends to be pre-prepared – in comparison to an interview setting, as interviewers may emphatically probe for particular identity aspects of the interviewee. Yet, even then, the interviewee may still

ignore this through the agentive choices they make (for an example, see Chapter 1 in Clifton et al., 2020), but it may require some discursive work to refute the relevance of certain identity categories when they are explicitly projected upon a speaker. Moreover, the role of the audience should not be overlooked. As we know from life story research (Van De Mieroop & Clifton, 2016), narrators are well aware of the fact that their stories are received and evaluated by their audiences in the here and now of narrating. While these audiences may be present live and may thus be a part of the local interactional context, they may also listen to the story at a different time and/or space. Because of this, narrators may also orient their stories to these "ghostly" or "imagined" audiences (Van De Mieroop & Clifton, 2016) and this is perhaps the case now even more than ever, as online contexts tend to offer many affordances for story recipient evaluation – e.g., each YouTube video is literally framed by recipients' comments and thumbs up or down (see e.g., also De Fina & Perrino, 2017). The local context thus has an important impact on the very specific way in which stories are told on a turn-by-turn basis.

Finally, researchers of stories should also try to consider how these stories relate to hegemonic expectations of the societies in which they are told. These expectations are captured in so-called big "D-Discourses" (Gee, 1999) or "dominant discourses," which can be defined as "pre-existent sociocultural forms of interpretation" (Bamberg, 2005, p. 287). Rather than considering these as fixed monolithic entities, such Discourses should be regarded as fairly abstract and fluid baselines of particular ways of understanding the world which are subject to (intra)personal variability (Clifton & Van De Mieroop, 2016, pp. 203–204). Thus, when people tell a story, they selectively draw upon specific versions of these Discourses, or, alternatively on Discourses that counter hegemonic expectations – the so-called counter-narratives (Bamberg & Andrews, 2004) – or even on conflicting Discourses within one story. Moreover, the question of how these Discourses relate to one another also does not have a straightforward answer, as this is also closely related to the context in which stories are told. For example, while on many forums, the myth of the male leader as heroic (Gemmill & Oakley, 1992; Grint, 2010) may still be ubiquitous and may thus be considered a hegemonic Discourse, this may be much less so when giving a speech at the "Women's leadership forum" (cf story below). In this community, a much more gender-neutral Discourse – for example that of ethical leadership (Brown & Treviño, 2006) such as the caring leader (Gabriel, 2015) – may hold a strong position, which may be hegemonic in certain other (sub)communities. It is thus clear that one cannot speak of *the* hegemonic leadership

Discourse, and that such Discourses should always be critically considered in relation to the specific storytelling activity at hand.

Overall, what the narrative as social practice approach mainly aims to show is that a story is not a report of some a priori existing reality, but rather creates a new reality through the act of storytelling. A story may thus seem to be only about the past, but in fact, it is as much about the present, especially because it serves a particular goal in relation to the storytelling context. This has been made very tangible in the study of repeated narratives (see e.g., Bamberg, 2008; Schoofs & Van De Mieroop, 2019; Van De Mieroop, 2009), which show that narrators may make crucial adjustments to their stories when telling them again at another time and another place. Thus, in short, discursive studies aim to uncover the locally situated nature of narratives and demonstrate that through telling their stories, narrators indeed "give" meaning to past events rather than "make" sense of a fixed past reality (Fairhurst, 2007). They thereby create specific notions of leadership – often in relation to hegemonic Discourses.

We illustrate this crucial point by showcasing a narrative by a famous leader, Reshma Saujani, founder of the non-profit organization Girls Who Code and author of various bestselling books. Saujani features frequently on leadership forums and interviews about leadership during which she often shares the ups and mostly downs of her personal career journey – in particular that she was defeated when she ran for public office. By doing so, she not only illustrates how she herself, as she puts it, "*rise[s] like a phoenix from the ashes*,"[2] but she also links this to some of her views on leadership as advocated in one of her books (Saujani, 2013), namely that it is important to embrace failure and risk. In this way, she presents her own journey as a story *about* leadership. We focus here on a short extract from a speech she gave during the 2016 Women's leadership forum. In this speech, she describes when she came up with the idea for Girls Who Code, namely at a moment when she had just experienced the failure of her dramatic defeat when she ran for office, winning only 19% of the votes.

Fragment 1[3]

```
1     i got 19 percent of the vote i was humiliated and
2     as i went to bed that night i was broke (.)
3     i had no contingency plan no job i was humiliated
4     and as i laid there and i thought about a::ll the
people
```

5 that i had let down my family my friends my field organizers
6 .h the people that i kept thinking about over and over and
7 over again (.) was actually the people that i had never seen
8 on the campaign trail (.) you see when you run for office (.)
9 i would visit a lot of schools and i'd go into the robotics
10 labs and their computer science classes and i'd see hundreds
11 of boys clamoring to be the next steve jobs or mark zuckerberg
12 and i thought to myself where are the girls (.) right
13 in this question of where (are) the girls
14 started as a question and became my obsession and
15 as i dug into that (.) dug into that right at a time where (.)
16 women are the majority in college the majority in the labor
17 force where are we in the industry that is shaping our
18 collective future tech
((10 lines omitted))
29 and it didn't make sense to me
30 this is probably a good time for an important disclosure
31 i'm not a coder i didn't major in computer science
32 i majored in poli sci and speech communications
33 so i don't come to this issue (.) because of my professional
34 experience and i don't come to this issue because (.)
35 i'm a woman i don't care about gender parity
36 for the sake of gender parity
37 the lack of women in technology matters for me because of
38 (.) who gets access to those jobs of the future

There are many interesting things that can be observed about this fragment, but given the length limitations of this chapter, we only highlight a few points here. First, in terms of

story set-up, we can observe that it is presented as a "leadership crucible," i.e., an intense, unplanned experience that transformed the narrator and that was used as a source for her development (Bennis & Thomas, 2002). In particular, in the initial part of the fragment, the narrator extensively situates herself and her feelings after her political defeat (lines 1–5). From this failure, she then sketches how a new idea started to bloom (lines 6–12) and how this then developed further (lines 13–29). As she thus explicitly locates the origin of this idea at an extreme low in her life, she presents herself as an emblematic example of her views on the important role of failure for leadership. She thus enacts her own conceptualization of a leader identity in the way she lays out and causally links her own experiences.

Second, in terms of formulation, it is important to observe that the narrator mainly adopts a personal perspective (e.g., the many first-person pronouns) and as such strongly claims personal agency regarding the idea for the Girls Who Code initiative. This personal perspective only shifts once in this fragment, namely in lines 17 and 18, in which the narrator uses a collective perspective (i.e., where are *we* in the industry that is shaping *our* collective future tech). Given the context of this utterance, it is clear that she addresses an ingroup of women that consists of the live audience as well as the female part of the ghostly audience. As such, it is clear that she orients to the local embedding of her speech in a women's leadership event, and at the same time draws attention to the shared identity of the narrator and the story recipients as women.

Third, it is interesting to note how she nuances her identity as leader of Girls Who Code further in the final part, in which she adds several disclaimers, namely that she is "not a coder" (line 31), that her identity as a woman is not relevant in this respect (lines 34–35), and that she is not in favour of "gender parity for the sake of gender parity" (lines 35–36). These self-characterizations are important, as they clearly aim to counter certain expectations regarding leaders of an organization such as Girls Who Code. So, in this way, she adds further nuance to her identity, amongst others refuting the expectation that only STEM-experts or feminists would start an organization like this.

So, we could observe here that the narrator constructs a nuanced female leader identity and gives meaning to her own conceptualization of leadership, among others by linking failure to personal agency and success. Through the chronological ordering of certain events and the way in which agency is claimed and self-characterizations are inserted to counter certain expectations, a specific reality is talked into being, which in turn gives rise to a particular version of leadership.

In this way, discursive studies of narratives about leadership uncover that there is no antecedent reality that has formed a leader, but rather that it is the agentive act of the

storyteller linking one event to another and presenting experiences in a particular way in order to make a particular point. These experiences could, of course, be narrated in an entirely different way, and rather than serving as an illustration of a leader's difficult road to success (as was the case here), they could just as well be incorporated into a story of failure. In this way, through narratives *about* leadership, narrators construct what leadership is to them, and they literally talk themselves into being as leaders – and often also the leaders that their audiences expect them to be.

Analysing Narratives Doing Leadership

In addition to narratives that revolve around leadership, there are also stories that may be involved in doing leadership without necessarily topicalizing it. This links up with the *doing* of leadership as an interactional influence process (see e.g., Larsson & Lundholm, 2013). In this process, language is central, and one of the means through which influence may be *done* is the activity of telling stories. For this activity, narrators may draw on a range of verbal as well as non-verbal resources and they may engage in this activity on their own, as well as in collaboration with others. While stories that are used for *doing* leadership may follow the canonical structure as explained above, they may just as well be examples of one of the many different other narrative genres, such as habitual narratives, hypothetical stories or chronicles, situated at various positions on the narrative dimensions' continua (Van De Mieroop, 2021).

Regardless of the shape or size of these stories, it is important to engage in a critical investigation of how they contribute to the negotiation of meaning among the participants in the interaction as well as in relation to the larger spatio-temporal contexts in which they occur. This is in line with the approaches that we foregrounded in the previous section, but in this section the interactional and locally embedded nature of these stories is even more important. In particular, it is crucial to ask why a story is told in the course of an ongoing institutional interaction (such as a meeting or a performance interview) in the first place. This is not a self-evident matter, as during famous leader interviews or speeches as discussed above, stories are expected by the audience. However, in interactions outside of interview contexts, stories are more unusual as telling a story requires taking the turn and securing the floor for an extensive amount of (work) time at the expense of the chances for other participants to take turns.

Research in the domain of (multimodal) conversation analysis, which is an approach that focuses on uncovering the mechanisms of social interaction through the micro-oriented analysis of naturally occurring talk, has scrutinized stories by zooming in on the

activity of "telling" rather than on the story itself (Mandelbaum, 2014). In other words, conversation analysts investigate the interactive work all the co-present participants engage in during storytelling. In this sense, they capitalize on the importance of the story recipients, who should not be regarded as passive at all. For instance, in order to allow for the telling of a story to emerge in interaction, recipients have to enact alignment with the "structural asymmetry of the storytelling activity" (Stivers, 2008, p. 34), so that the ordinary turn-taking arrangement of conversation becomes suspended (Sacks et al., 1974). Furthermore, it has been shown how the recipients' responses and embodied behavior – e.g., gaze (Goodwin, 1984) – contribute in important ways to the storytelling activity and possibly also the actions the teller is trying to achieve. This highly interactive view on storytelling typical of (multimodal) conversation analysis thus really foregrounds the local embedding of the story in its interactional context. It thus fits well with discursive leadership approaches that also foreground the locally achieved, collaborative nature of leadership.

From a discourse analytical perspective, researchers typically aim to tease out how storytelling may contribute to the doing of leadership by studying the highly fragmented and fleeting nature of the various identities – leader, follower, and other identities – that are constructed, interactionally negotiated, and sometimes fervently challenged in a variety of storytelling activities in day-to-day interactions. More specifically, the interactional sociolinguistic perspective on language in the workplace (Holmes et al., 2011) has highlighted some of the discursive strategies that people may draw on to *do* leadership (e.g., Choi & Schnurr, 2014; Schnurr, 2009), and they may use stories for that purpose as well, for example for giving advice, conveying feedback and criticism, lightening the mood, creating a sense of team, and much more (e.g., Clifton, 2014; Clifton et al., 2020; Schnurr & Mak, 2011).

To illustrate how storytelling may be used to do leadership, we will now discuss a story that emerged during a meeting between staff of a care home for the elderly. Prior to the fragment below, some of the nurses have been extensively discussing the coaching of the new employees. Up to this point in the meeting, their superior had not contributed anything to this discussion, and at the end of the discussion, the nurse who has mainly been doing the talking (Nurse 1), asks the superior about his view on the matter (see extract 2 in Van De Mieroop, 2020). She thus projects a leader identity onto the superior, whose opinion and agreement is presented as a prerequisite for the pending decision. Yet, the latter responds in a very negative way and takes the floor for an extensive turn in which he explains his negative opinion about the coaching of new staff members, amongst others by means of a story.

Fragment 2 (S: Superior; N1, N2: Nurse 1/2)

1 S ik vind dat de begeleiding
i think that the coaching
2 van nieuwe personeelsleden
of new staff members
3 eigenlijk hier ondermaats is (.)
is actually below all standards here (.)
4 ik vind dat na een paar weken mensen
i think that after a few weeks people
5 die bepaalde basisdingen nog ni weten
who still do not know certain basic things
6 .hh het kan ook een deel aan hun eigen liggen
.hh it can also partially (be) their own fault
7 moar (.) do[ar geloof ik ni altijd even goe in
but (.) i do not always believe that equally well
8 N2 [ja
yes
9 N2 der z[en (mensen geweest)
there have (been people)
10 S [AANGEZIEN DAT ER afspraken zijn (.)
BECAUSE THERE are agreements (.)
11 die=da- die=da gewoon ni nageleefd worden
that- that simply are not followed
12 >vorige week nog stoat er weer
>last week still there was once again
13 ne student aan die kassa te sukkelen
a student having trouble at that cash register
14 .h afspraken zen studen#ten worden niet opgeleid
.h agreements are students are not trained
s # straight hand gestures-->
15 voor die kassa te doen<# .h
for doing that cash register< .h
s -->#
16 >ze worden ook ni opgeleid
>they are also not trained
17 maar dan wordt er ineens gezegd
but then it is suddenly said
18 joa doe de kassa maar<

```
            yes nevertheless do the cash register<
19        .h: neen. da zijn zo van die
            .h: no. that are some of those
20          µ dingen da kik mij aan erger .h dat eu:h µ (.)
            things that annoy me .h that e:rm
      n1     µ nods                                    µ
```

After his initial and highly explicit negative evaluation of the coaching procedures for new staff members (lines 1–5), the superior formulates a partial concession regarding his strong opinion in line 6. Here he hypothetically attributes some of the blame for new staff's questionable performances to themselves, which he then immediately refutes again (line 7). After one of the nurses starts building further on the attribution of blame to the new staff (line 9), the superior overlaps in a loud voice. He regains the floor and continues refuting that the new staff is to blame by adding the argument that the current staff is not following the agreements. This is thus a direct criticism of the present staff members. Then, at this crucial point, the superior provides proof for his face threatening statement by initiating a short narrative (line 12). The previously uttered criticism now functions as a story abstract, which is followed by an orientation phase, sketching the time ("last week"), place ("at the cash register"), frequency ("once again"), and the story protagonist ("a student") of the events. The complication is also uttered immediately, namely that the student is "having trouble" (line 13). This complication is then contrasted with the explicit formulation – which is emphasized by repeated hand gestures – of the official agreements regarding students who work at the care home (lines 14–15) and the contrasting practical treatment of them (lines 16–18). It is interesting to note that in uncovering this inconsistency, the superior uses the passive voice ("it is said," line 17) thereby avoiding blaming one specific person. The story events are then evaluated by a sigh and a negative particle marking the superior's negative evaluation. This is then extended by a framing of the story as an example of "things that annoy" the superior (line 20), which is met by silent agreement of the nurse who presented the new coaching initiative prior to the fragment (cf. n1's nodding).

This story could be described as minimal and not very extraordinary. It is presented as an example that is emblematic of the substandard way in which new staff members are treated in the care home, and it thus serves to support the superior's negative opinion – which goes against the positive vibe in the group that the presentation of the coaching initiative prior to the fragment had generated. As the superior's go-ahead is oriented to as needed for the decision to be made, the latter thus enacts a leader identity

as he exerts influence via his critical reaction and his – at least temporary – blocking of the achievement of this organizationally relevant goal. In interactional terms, it is not surprising that the superior takes the floor for an extensive turn – including a story – after (and partially during) one of the nurses' attempts to align with an alternative reason for the new staff's substandard performance. As such, he silences disagreements with or minimizations of his strong negative opinion, and he holds on to the floor until one of the other nurses starts nodding to express her agreement (during line 20). In terms of leadership activities, this short story clearly serves to provide proof for the superior's harsh criticism of the current situation, and it thus makes his criticism difficult to refute by other staff members. As giving feedback and formulating criticism have been identified as leadership activities (see e.g., Clifton et al., 2020), the story in this way contributes to the "doing" of leadership. It also shows how the decision-making process (i.e., in relation to the new coaching initiative) can temporarily be paused – as the superior is holding on to the floor for an extended turn – as well as influenced – as disagreements are silenced. As leadership has been conceptualized as a dynamic influence process, whereby multiple individuals lead each other to the achievement of organizational goals (Pearce & Conger, 2003), analyzing this interactional side of storytelling enables researchers to capture leadership processes in vivo. Such an analytical approach thus provides valuable insights into the ways in which the various participants in the meeting contribute to this leadership process.

However, regardless of whether the analytical focus is on stories about leadership or stories doing leadership, research on storytelling and narratives in leadership communication has a range of implications for practice, some of which we briefly mention in the next section.

Implications for Practice

Being aware of and utilizing this power of storytelling is an effective strategy for professionals. One aspect that makes storytelling such a powerful tool for leadership is the versatility of stories and the diversity of functions they may perform. In addition to the multiple functions of stories through which they may contribute to the accomplishment of leadership, as outlined above, research has also identified other concrete areas where stories and storytelling may be beneficial for leadership. For example, Damiani et al. (2017, p. 684) demonstrate the benefit of narrated experiences and co-constructed learning in leadership programs. They maintain that embarking on one's own leadership stories constitutes a valuable "method to co-construct and explore

the possibilities to collaborate and facilitate creative spaces for developing emergent leaders" (ibid.). Similarly, Auvinen et al. (2019) show how digital storytelling is an important skill for leaders to master when embarking on organizational meaning making, creating a coherent strategy, building collaboration and consensus, and constructing a compelling vision for the organization.

Storytelling is also a powerful tool to instigate and support organizational change. For example, several studies have shown that stories are important places where mainstream Discourses around gender and women in leadership roles are produced, reinforced, and communicated to a wider audience (e.g., Elliott & Stead, 2018; Schnurr, 2023). Stories thus constitute important concrete platforms which help not only to identify and understand these mainstream Discourses and their underlying – often discriminatory – ideologies, but stories also have the power to change organizational practices and address gender discrimination and other social issues, thereby creating alternative organizational realities (see also Mullany & Schnurr, 2023).

Due to their versatility stories of any shape and form should thus be taken seriously by those who are performing leadership. As our examples above have hinted at, some leaders have a repertoire of stories they tell and re-tell in different situations to achieve their aims. However, in spite of this relevance and power of stories for leadership, more research is necessary to better understand the complexities of leadership stories and storytelling.

Directions for Future Research

While research on narratives in leadership communication is flourishing, there are several areas which have been largely overlooked and would benefit from future research. In line with our empirical analyses above, we would like to encourage future research to conduct more empirical studies on small stories, focusing on *how* these stories are told by using some of the discursive approaches outlined above. Moreover, recent research has begun to acknowledge the relevance of non-verbal aspects in storytelling and has conducted multimodal analyses to systematically incorporate gaze, gestures, and other non-verbal aspects (e.g., Liu et al., 2017; Vaara et al., 2016, Van De Mieroop et al., 2020). However, in spite of these recent developments, we still know relatively little about the specific processes and wide variety of (multimodal) resources through which leadership and leader identities are constructed and negotiated in and through storytelling. Nevertheless, such insights about the processes and accomplishments that constitute leadership are crucial as they provide new evidence

and make important contributions to current debates around conceptualizations and theorizations of leadership (see also Schnurr & Schroeder, 2019).

Future research should also focus more on exploring leadership narratives in currently largely overlooked contexts – such as new digital media – and in a wider range of socio-cultural contexts. The recent digitalization of narratives has led to changes in strategy narration, which increasingly utilizes digital media (such as webcasting, intranet, and Skype) as key elements in top management leadership work. However, the resulting "digital plurivocal narration with several participants is likely to result in multiple organisational 'truths'" (Auvinen et al., 2019, p. 205). This poses new challenges for those in leadership positions, which should be further explored by future research. Moreover, while recent research has begun to move beyond the traditional focus on an Anglophone White (and largely male) population (e.g., Pieratos et al., 2021; Schnurr, 2023;), there is a dire need for more such studies. As the work by Jamjoom and Mills (2023) on women leaders in Saudi Arabia, and the study by Smit (2017) on Black school principals in rural schools in South Africa has shown, such research promises to lead to genuinely new insights into narratives in leadership communication.

Finally, it is important to note that in this chapter, we have focused on narrative approaches to leadership that are firmly embedded in the tradition of discursive leadership, and which explore how leadership can be accomplished practically by means of verbal as well as non-verbal resources through stories told in real-life environments. Yet, there is a large gap between this type of "sensegiving" approach, on the one hand, and organizational narrative studies (e.g., Boje, 2001, 2008) that prioritize the view of stories as "sensemaking devices" (Gabriel, 2004, p. 61), on the other hand (as discussed earlier in the chapter). Bridging the gap between these two research strands would be beneficial for the domain of leadership studies, and in this respect, approaches such as the hermeneutic leadership theory (Jian, 2019), are quite promising. But while researchers may still disagree whether stories are "sensemaking" or "sensegiving" activities, they do agree on the importance of storytelling for human life in general, and for leadership in particular. There are thus still many exciting avenues for future research that will contribute to further understanding the intricate relation between leadership communication and narratives.

Notes

1. See www.youtube.com/watch?v=OMRrdyUaUF0, last consulted April 28, 2023.⏎

2. See www.youtube.com/watch?v=SgPVgPYnT_M, last consulted April 28, 2023.⏎
3. Both fragments were transcribed using simplified conversation analytic transcription conventions (see Jefferson, 1984), and in the case of fragment 2, simplified multimodal transcriptions conventions were added as well (see Mondada, 2016).⏎

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Further Reading

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Vaara, E., Sonenshein, S., & Boje, D. (2016). Narratives as sources of stability and change in organizations: Approaches and directions for future research. *Academy of Management Annals*, *10*(1), 495–560. (This paper provides a good overview of key issues in organisational narrative analysis.)

Van De Mieroop, D. (2021). The Narrative Dimensions Model and an exploration of various narrative genres. *Narrative Inquiry*, *31*(1), 4–27. (This paper presents an overview of (preceding research on) narrative genres and integrates them into a multidimensional model.)

21

LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION AS MATERIALITY, EMBODIMENT, AND AESTHETICS

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-25

Introduction

The field of leadership communication has seen a diversification in recent years, including a growing interest in the themes of materiality, embodiment, and aesthetics, which are the focus of this chapter. As Ladkin (2008), Hansen et al. (2007), and others argue, much leadership research can be faulted for framing leaders and followers as rational information processors, suggesting that leadership communication primarily concerns ensuring effective coding and decoding of messages. Consequentially, it is often disregarded how leadership processes are also shaped by the physical environment in which the participants find themselves, their corporeality, and aesthetic aspects such as sensoriality and emotions. Rather than exerting simple linear and mechanical influences on leadership situations, such aspects dynamically play into the participants' developing and culturally mediated expressions and understandings, attesting to the inherent complexity of local communicational events (Fairhurst, 2007; Fairhurst & Grant, 2010).

In the following, some central understandings of leadership communication will be presented, along with a discussion of some key choices made in scoping the present review. Afterwards, an example of leadership communication is presented that will

serve to illustrate various points throughout the chapter. These illustrations fall in the course of the chapter's three main sections, where theoretical approaches and empirical studies related to each of the three focal themes are presented in more detail. The chapter is concluded with a discussion of promising approaches for future research and practice.

Definitions and Delimitation

Fairhurst and Connaughton (2014) describe the leadership communication literature as diverse, observing in their review that different approaches are variably oriented towards meaning and/or processual aspects of communication, focus on how leadership communication may constitute leaders and followers relationally, involve influence in relation to organizing future action, and reflect power/resistance-dynamics, for example. And in relation to leaders as persons, Ruben and Gigliotti (2017) argue that "leaders can not not communicate" (p. 25). Leaders do not only communicate through their utterances and gestures; also outward appearance in the form of clothing (Ford et al., 2017) or facial features (Olivola et al., 2014) may be imbued with meaning by others and thus seen as means of communication. Consequentially, much of the leadership literature can be said to relate to communication in some shape or form.

Our review approach is inspired by Ruben and Gigliotti (2016, 2017) who distinguish between studies adopting a classical linear (i.e., transmission) model of communication focusing on "intentional creation of messages with particular influence outcomes in mind" (p. 470); other approaches inspired by an interactional model that frames communication processes as dynamic, reciprocal, and ongoing; and a third group of approaches taking a systems model as their point of departure, which tends to view communication as a highly general process taking place between a wide variety of sources (living and not). While Ruben and Gigliotti primarily associate materiality with the systems perspective, our review considers how studies based on any of the three models of communication may attend to materiality. The three models are distinguished here based on whether they attend to the sending and receipt of individual messages (classical linear model), on the establishment of intersubjective understandings in exchange sequences (interactional model), or on pluralistic communication processes where outcomes are shaped over time, often by a multitude of actors that consciously or unconsciously communicate messages (systems model).

In engaging with the three themes of embodiment, aesthetics, and materiality, each of which may be delimited and defined in various ways, our review approach prioritizes

inclusivity while focusing on work directly related to both leadership and communication. Consequently, research that focuses mainly on philosophical and phenomenological aspects of the focal themes, for example, will not be covered. While numerous overlaps can be observed between research relating to the three focal themes of this chapter, the themes are initially treated separately for reasons of clarity. Our review focuses on some main distinctions and discussions that can be observed in the literature relating to each theme, noting the different underlying models of communication employed in the included studies. First, however, an example is presented in order to illustrate and anchor our argument.

An Illustration: Steve Ballmer as Microsoft CEO

Steve Ballmer led Microsoft for 14 years, becoming known for his occasionally eccentric behavior. A clip of his presentation at Microsoft's 25th anniversary convention in front of an audience of Microsoft employees and affiliates has been widely circulated online (e.g., Youtube, 2023). A traditional transcription of this clip focusing on the "main discourse" could read as following:

Speaker: Ladies and gentlemen, Steve Ballmer
Ballmer: I have four words for you: I love this company

Although the verbal aspect is often in focus in studies of leadership communication, here it accounts for little of what is going on. Readers unfamiliar with the clip are encouraged to seek it out; however, the following transcription seeks to capture some additional relevant features:[1]

[A large stage with a lectern and giant Microsoft logos is visible. Loud energetic music is played]
Speaker: Ladies and gentlemen STEEEVE BALLMERRRR
[Ballmer runs onto stage as his name is called. The audience erupts into cheers, clapping and whistling. Ballmer runs across the stage, yelling and flailing his arms]
Ballmer: UURHR (.) HUUUHRHR (.) HUUURHRH (.) COOME OOON (.) GET UUP (.) GET UP (.)
[Ballmer runs back and forth on stage, occasionally jumping]
COME OOOOON (.) UH HU (.) AH (.) COME OOOON (.) GIVE IT UP FOR MEEE (.)

[Ballmer paces the stage, pointing at the audience while screaming]

Ballmer: WOOH (.) WOOOOH (.) COME OOON (.)

[Ballmer moves behind lectern, adopts "serious" facial expression]

Ballmer: WHO SITS DOWN? [grins]

Audience: [laughing]

[Ballmer breathes heavily for several seconds, some audience members yell]

Ballmer: I HAVE FOUR WORDS FOR YA (.) [raises arms] I (.) LOVE (.) THIS (.) COMPANY YEEEES

[Ballmer motions arms in sync with his words]

Audience: [clapping and cheering]

This example is taken up again below to illustrate how leadership communication relates to each of our three focal themes.

Materiality

Materiality has been defined in various ways; while critical theorists have used the term to describe economic structures and systems engendering inequality (e.g., Lettow, 2017), much recent research has employed an understanding oriented towards things or spaces that have "a physical mode of being, namely possess spatial attributes – a unique location, shape, volume, and mass" (Faulkner & Runde, 2012, p. 51), or as referring to the enduring physical or digital aspects of the environments we engage with (Leonardi et al., 2012).

A number of authors criticize the tendency to disregard physical or virtual environments in the performance of leadership (Carroll, 2016; Fairhurst & Cooren, 2009; Hawkins, 2015; Sergi, 2016). In the Steve Ballmer example, it can for instance be noted how materiality plays a role through how Ballmer is raised above the seated audience on a stage; the stage holds a large "Microsoft" logo, suggesting that those able to take the stage may represent the company; and furthermore, Ballmer's voice is projected throughout the venue through the use of audio equipment, which, together with the use of video, also captures the event and grants it potential impact beyond the immediately present situation, including as an online record for us to draw on in this chapter. The example thus attests to how, in Sergi's words, "[m]ateriality participates in leadership" (2016, p. 113).

Materiality as a Resource for Performing Leadership

The participation of materiality in leadership comes in a variety of ways: closest to a linear understanding of communication are studies showing how materiality may be employed as a resource for (humans) performing leadership. For example, Tan et al. (2015) describe how a university used online videos in response to changes in management approaches within the university sector. In the production of the videos, various techniques related to cinematography and sound were employed to promote certain managerial discourses (i.e., top-down versus a more collegially oriented leadership). The authors studied the use of these techniques following a "digital multimodal discourse perspective," with multimodality here referring to combining attention towards auditive, visual, and textual aspects of the data. Alvehus (2018) presents examples of how a manager orchestrated leadership through material objects as the manager edited down a presentation deck he was meant to use in a meeting with employees and outwardly chose to disregard a game supposed to teach the employees corporate values.[2] In doing so, the manager positioned himself as being distanced from the top management and open towards the employees' perspective. At a similarly "micro" level, Carroll (2016) discusses how a manager's simple act of fetching a koosh ball from his desk facilitated leadership by mobilizing team members to disengage from their tasks and join in a shared "team time" activity.

Taking a more interactional approach to communication and drawing on multimodal conversation analysis attending to both sound and video data, Arvedsen and Hassert (2020) analyze the role of materiality in online team cooperation, noting how control over the cursor and shared presentation media was central in accomplishing interactional influence and thus leadership in their study. And Holm and Fairhurst (2018) study hierarchical and shared leadership in the form of authoring, showing how authoritative documents such as organization charts, research papers, or webpages, were employed to claim authority (i.e., rights to define future figurative or concrete texts) in meetings.

Humans and Objects as Symmetrical

A second perspective advocates a more symmetrical view of human and inanimate objects as senders of messages, as represented by actor-network theory (Latour, 2005) and some variants of the communicative constitution of organization (CCO) perspective (Sergi, 2023), thus moving closer to the systems-oriented view of communication. Here it is argued that both humans and materiality hold agentic possibilities, although one

may outweigh the other in practice. Furthermore, agency lies not in the individual actor, but in the contributions of varied actors that operate in local settings (Sergi, 2016). For example, Grint (2005) argues that the leadership effects of traffic lights are not accomplished by the lights themselves, but through a network of actors that also spans legal support and law enforcement. Oborn et al. (2013) argue that while materiality constitutes the relationships between human actors, leadership in relation to policy formulation processes in the U.K. health sector occurred in a distributed manner, showing that the "capacity for leadership is relational, dynamic and collective rather than inherent in one actor" (p. 268). Fairhurst and Cooren (2009) use the cases of hurricane Katrina and California wildfires to show how wide networks of human and material actors contribute to making leadership present. And Hawkins (2015) argues that networks of human and material actants together produce leadership in the navy, focusing on how material actants hold affordances that shift as the concrete or symbolic contexts they are embedded in change (for example, in relation to whether a ship is at sea or at shore). However, since the networks or actors are also shaped by overarching power relations, material actants may ironically contribute to promoting understandings of leadership that are human-centered, for example, through canonization of historical naval figures in statues and names of naval institutions.

One may ask how leadership as a concept is affected by seeing leadership as brought about by a multitude of actors with no clear coordination. As Sergi (2016) notes, there is a risk that the concept of leadership becomes diluted and equivocated with organizing more generally as leadership is argued to "appear as a processual, collective, and mundane effect of unfolding action" (p. 123), not holding any "essence" (p. 127). The potential challenges of adopting such a conceptualization will be discussed below. However, it should be noted that the symmetrical view of human and non-human actors is not only found in studies taking a communicational systems perspective. For example, within interaction-oriented studies, Clifton et al. (2021) state that "artefacts do leadership" (p. 256), showing how the configuration of human actors and a piece of software in a meeting leads a customer to commit to using a specific software package.

The Contribution of Materiality to Constituting Persons as Leaders

Returning to a more person-centered understanding of leadership, materiality may also participate in constituting leaders. In Carroll's example of the koosh ball mentioned above, she goes on to mention how material objects not only function as tools for doing leadership, but also hold symbolic value enabling them to suggest identities. Similar

linear perspectives can be found in how Sinclair (2005) describes access cards as signaling leadership status for their holders, and in Hawkins' (2015) example of how badges and rank slides denote formal leader status in the navy. From an interactional perspective, Meier and Carroll (2020) study meetings between teachers and participants in a leadership development program, showing how the graphical profiles of personality tests used in the program structure discussions regarding participants' leadership style by demarking what can be considered normal or deviant, potentially constraining participants' ability to claim a leadership identity.

Focusing on how leadership identity is presented towards a broader audience and based on a more linear communicational model, Guthey and Jackson (2005) study photographical CEO portraits and their role in constructing the authenticity of the leaders themselves and the organizations for which they work. The authors argue that portraits give organizations a human face, which may increase trust and visibility; however, the portraits construct (rather than simply reflect) their subjects because the portraits rely on common photographic or cultural conventions. The fact that organizations and their leaders can build authenticity in the eyes of the public through heavily stylized and orchestrated portraits creates what the authors call an authenticity paradox, leading them to question whether it is possible to truly know the leaders on display. More recently, numerous studies have addressed how corporate or political leaders shape others' perceptions of them using social media, and media more generally. Elon Musk, Jeff Bezos, and Donald Trump have all built and nurtured celebrity status for themselves, curating content in which they are depicted as entrepreneurial, successful, and popular (Deye & Fairhurst, 2019; Smolović Jones & Hollis, 2023). These studies are related to Boje and Rhodes' (2005) concept of the virtual leader construct, which describes either virtual representations of actual persons or fictional characters that are actively created by organizations, such as Ronald McDonald, clown and "chief happiness officer" of the McDonald's corporation. According to Boje and Rhodes, the constructs are created and employed to project a malleable image of leadership, which can be edited and made to fit outside actors' expectations, and which can also create presence and visibility in many different settings beyond what would be possible for actual "flesh-and-blood" leaders. However, as shown by Liu et al. (2017), media accounts may also challenge leaders' narratives by constructing more critical storylines about the leaders' performance in light of contextual circumstances, as demonstrated in their analysis of how banking CEOs were portrayed during the global financial crisis.

Embodiment

In moving on to the theme of embodiment, it is relevant to first note that many studies combine a focus on embodiment and materiality (e.g., Ford et al., 2017; Pullen & Vachhani, 2013; Ropo & Salovaara, 2019; Sinclair, 2005), often without defining a clear boundary. Compared to the last section, our focus here is on studies that more closely attend to the body itself, including clothing and the different ways it has been addressed in the leadership communication literature. Also addressed is the embodied practice of leadership, which refers to how human bodies are involved in various aspects of the doing of leadership: in efforts to establish leadership, in sensing such efforts, and in reacting to them. Returning to Steve Ballmer's speech, it can be noted how he deliberately utilizes his body to communicate, both through running and flailing his arms, but also more subtle expressive gestures; for example, by grinning after yelling "WHO SITS DOWN?," he can be seen as taking a joking stance towards the "larger-than-life" persona projected by his entrance.

Like materiality, several authors have pointed out that the leadership literature has largely ignored the body. For example, Bathurst and Cain (2013) argue that leadership is typically viewed as cognitively oriented "headship," i.e., a disembodied activity (p. 359), and Sinclair (2005) describes how the body is often represented as merely another subject of leadership, pointing to the parallels between managers' achievement of organizational goals and personal fitness goals, such as completing a marathon or triathlon (see also Johansson et al., 2017). Pullen and Vachhani (2013) suggest that the body is mostly placed in the background in relation to leadership, where it is assumed that bodies are able and can be commodified to fit organizational demands, for example as a carrier of emotion or motivation.

Embodiment as Appearance

Some studies have focused on the ways in which outward appearance is involved in leadership communication. Following a predominantly linear approach, Kelan (2013) studies how MBA students attribute meaning to female managers and businesswomen's ways of dressing, as captured in pictures. The study finds that participants' responses are particularly oriented towards whether the women's appearance was viewed as industry-appropriate, with glamourous or sexy appearances being described as unprofessional. The study attends to several communicational processes in that the photographed women's dress were seen as a relevant indication of their leadership ability, while the study participants' comments were simultaneously seen as

communication oriented towards positioning themselves as competent leaders. Relatedly, Ford et al. (2017) explore the subjective experiences of people working in formal leadership roles. Drawing on a combination of psychoanalytic object relations theory and the new materialist theory of Karen Barad (2007), their study describes the lay theories underlying how these individuals work to "constitute leadership through complex entanglements," (Ford et al., 2017, p. 1553) including what clothes to wear and how to carry oneself.

More oriented towards a systems-based understanding of communication and drawing on Butler (1993), Sinclair (2005) argues that hierarchies of bodies are established through structures such as gender regimes, class-based assumptions and socially and culturally constructed taboos. However, bodies are also performative as individuals seek to actively navigate societal expectations through their style of dress or their exercise routines, for example. While such forms of "body performance" may be highly demanding, some people are granted a free pass by holding bodies that are naturalized and thus unlikely to draw attention – in Sinclair's words, the "male, powerful and senior" (p. 390). Sinclair's points are illustrated through two cases of how a female police commissioner and an Aboriginal principal's body performance were negotiated in relation to the wider systems they participated in.

Similarly, Muhr and Sullivan (2013) draw on queer theory to discuss and critique the "heterosexual matrix that permeate our understanding of leadership" (p. 416). Analyzing predominantly interview data, the authors show how transgender leader Claire's varying appearance as male or female shape not only others' expectations towards her, but also her own performance of her leadership role and awareness of whether she is perceived as acting feminine. While the change towards openly dressing as a woman at work is met with acceptance, traditionally gendered expectations still surface; for example, her employees describe her "masculine" leadership style as being remarkable, and Claire experiences pressure to assume a more submissive style.

Embodiment as Gesture

Other studies focus on the role of embodied gestures in accomplishing leadership, either in the sense of establishing a leader position or in shaping the course of interaction and its consequences. These studies typically attend to the interactional aspect of leadership communication. For example, analyzing rhetorical devices in political speeches, Bull (2016) argues that not only is the audience's clapping an embodied phenomenon, but clapping is also interactionally mobilized by the speaker through embodied aspects of

the delivered speech, such as varying levels of emphasis and intonation. Baxter (2014) explores the establishment of leader positions in a group of female MBA students working together on a tower constructing exercise, showing how various movements can be central elements in this process, including demonstrations of potential manual approaches towards the task, gesturing at specific other participants, and positioning one's body in relation to the ongoing activity.

Van De Mieroop et al. (2019) use multimodal conversation analysis of embodied actions to show how negotiations of formal and informal leadership in a meeting setting is negotiated through "multimodal gestalts," which involve hand gestures, gaze and nodding, along with interaction with material objects and the surrounding space. And in a similar vein, Clifton et al. (2018) demonstrate how the authority to make decisions and manage the agenda can be negotiated nonverbally based on data from a meeting setting within an Indian company. For example, various participants may potentially nominate next speakers through their eye gaze; yet, when several participants do so at the same time, certain participants' gaze are treated as holding priority, as evidenced by who of the nominated speakers go on to take the conversational floor.

Other studies have attended to gesture at a more general level, drawing on different understandings of communication. For example, Ladkin and Taylor (2010) take a linear communicational perspective, suggesting that authentic leadership depends on relevant embodied behaviors, the nature of which can be elucidated through the work of acting theorist Stanislavski (i.e., method acting; 1936). Because people tend to infer psychological states from embodied action, leaders should take note of whether their body language supports what they intend to communicate. And Bathurst and Cain (2013) employ an interactional approach, drawing on data from the performance of classical music to argue that leadership in both organizational settings and music performances revolves around the presentation and recognition of relevant gestures. Leadership is thus seen as related to "creating opportunities for organizational members to participate in the co-creation of their enterprise" (pp. 360–361). It can be noted that numerous studies also attend to gestures through a more aesthetically oriented lens, and some of these are addressed below.

The Positioning of Bodies in Space

Some studies go beyond individual gestures to discuss how the positioning of the body in space contributes to leadership through the types of actions that are enabled or disabled, highlighting yet another point of contact between the themes of embodiment

and materiality. One example is presented by Mesinioti et al. (2020), who study leadership as interaction in simulated medical emergency situations. Focusing on how clinicians position themselves spatiomaterially, they identify five important zones in relation to the patient (for example, on the left or right sides of the bed or at the foot end), arguing that employees' positioning within these zones is crucial to their enactment of medical expertise and their ability to manage the conversational floor, for example in order to provide directives for others. Similarly, but departing from a more linear understanding of communication, Carroll (2016) argues that the matter of whether managers are positioned facing towards or away from their employees is indicative of different leadership orientations: managers who face employees may be specifically oriented towards being able to represent the team towards others on the outside, such as higher-level managers, whereas managers facing away from their employees may symbolically assert their rights to make decisions independently.

Also, at the boundary of the embodiment and aesthetics-oriented literatures, various authors have attended to the body as a type of sensory device that facilitates engagement in leadership communication processes. As mentioned above, Bathurst and Cain (2013) argue for the centrality of being able to recognize gestures to leadership processes, and Sinclair (2005) states that "the body registers feelings. It allows us to take note, for example, of a hunched posture or shallow breath, and make bodily and mental adjustments" (p. 404). Similarly, Ladkin (2023) cites Duke (1986) in arguing that leadership is fundamentally a perceptual process, where sensory information is ascribed meaning and acted on; central to this perceptual process are our "eyes, ears and bodies" (p. 278). To the extent that this type of sensing is viewed as simple and automatic, it is most closely related to linear communicational perspectives. However, others draw on the concept of sensing in a more metaphorical manner, where sensory input is imbued with meaning by being placed in relation to experiences or other types of verbal or preverbal information to form judgments about people or situations, as expressed in the phrase "the sense we are using to judge a new boss or colleague the first time we meet them" (Ladkin, 2023, p. 277). Because of the multitude of factors that may influence such "sensing," both related to the senser and external to them (e.g., experiences and cultural understandings versus features of the setting), these latter studies are most closely aligned with the systems model of communication.

Aesthetics

Koivunen and Wennes (2011) note that the emergence of an interest in aesthetics in the organization and management literature is based on the notion that "aesthetic factors, such as emotions, intuition, symbols and sense perception have an equally important role in organization behavior than cognitive activities" (p. 54; see also Hansen et al., 2007; Ladkin, 2023). However, the term aesthetics is used with a number of different meanings in relation to leadership. For example, Katz-Buonincontro (2011) distinguishes between four meanings: aesthetic leadership as sensory and somatic attentiveness, as emotional awareness and empathy, as the promotion of moral purpose, and as interest in organizational beauty. Consequentially, the term has been connected to a host of different leadership aspects and theories, including the bodily reactions and subjective experience of those observing leaders; transformational, charismatic, and authentic leadership; leadership as a form of art; and ethics as a philosophical discipline (Hansen et al., 2007; Ladkin, 2008, 2023). In relation to the Ballmer example, aesthetics is, for example, relevant in relation to Ballmer's energetic and seemingly uninhibited running across the stage. This type of behavior is highly unusual for a top manager; however, in conjunction with the energetic and loud music, it may have evoked the jubilant reception from the crowd. Below, four important understandings of aesthetics and how they relate to leadership communication will be presented.

Aesthetics as Sense Perception

The term aesthetics is derived from the Greek term *aisthētikós*, referring to sense perception, often used as a contrast to intellectual concepts or rational thought. If viewed from the perspective of the classical linear understanding of communication, this understanding of aesthetics highlights how recipients integrate information from different sense modalities into a comprehensive experience and, indirectly, how senders of communication contribute to this experience through their actions. For example, Ladkin (2008) recounts seeing the singer Bobby McFerrin in concert, arguing that he:

> Demonstrated distinctive skills of communication. Much leadership literature focuses on verbal aspects of communication; getting the message "right" in terms of its content. McFerrin never spoke to us. He communicated through gestures, vocal inflections, and the way he used his body.
>
> (p. 33)

Several authors link aesthetics to sensing and to a form of non-rational assessment and judgement. For example, Hansen et al. (2007) emphasize that leadership involves being able to acknowledge and communicate to others "sensory knowledge and felt meaning of objects and experiences" (p. 545), providing meaning and shaping subsequent actions (see also Bathurst & Cain, 2013). Somewhat similarly, Bathurst et al. (2010) describe how aesthetic leadership involves "presencing and concretization" (p. 316) whereby ideas are developed and taken up by leaders and followers (or artists and audiences), respectively. Koivunen and Wennes (2011) study the collaborative work of conductors and classical orchestras, describing how all parties should engage in a social process of relational listening, and how especially the conductors must show aesthetic judgement in shaping the orchestra's performance and responding to challenges met during rehearsals. And Weick (2011) argues that being perceptive and able to convert perceptions into language that captures experience fully is central to enabling change, arguing that leaders should act as change poets: "Poets wrap perceptions in conceptions and in doing so attempt both to gather more flux and to preserve what has been gathered using images that narrow the gap between continuous flux and discrete names. Poets talk airy nothing into existence" (p. 9). Compared to the studies focusing on sensing mentioned in relation to embodiment (see above), the studies mentioned in this section can be said to bring together different communicative understandings in relation to how leaders shape impressions from pluralistic communication systems into convincing, linearly transmitted messages.

Aesthetics as Emotional Awareness

A second aspect of aesthetics in relation to leadership communication is emotional awareness and empathy. While emotions may be conceived as subjectively felt phenomenological experiences (e.g., Ropo & Salovaara, 2019), other studies approach emotions as social displays in interaction, as briefly touched upon above in relation to embodiment (e.g., Bathurst & Cain, 2013). Viewing emotions as part of the negotiated social order in interaction and taking a conversation analytical approach, Nguyen and Janssens (2018) study interactions between a manager and other parties in meetings in a social partnership setting, showing how different utterances ascribe primacy to either the emotional aspects of the situation or to other aspects, such as who could be considered to have more expertise or a stronger claim to decide on the group's actions. The emotional order of the situation is shown to be negotiated, for example, through how speakers invite others to emotionally endorse their positions on the matters at hand,

and how such endorsements can be withheld by other parties, projecting dissatisfaction. The disconnects between participants in their study in relation to the emotional order sustained interactional troubles, underscoring the concrete manifestations of emotionality in situations related to leadership. Ruusuvuori et al. (2019) study sequences in employee-manager performance appraisal talks where employees complain about coworkers. They show how the sensitivity of the matter calls for substantial interactional work, and how the managers may engage in complaint facilitation by acknowledging the employees' emotional stance through a variety of concrete verbal and nonverbal practices.

Relatedly, but focusing on more problematic handling of emotional aspects of work interactions, Ajslev et al. (2020) analyze participatory workshop interactions in a construction setting. They show how a manager's outright rejection of a suggestion made by employees can threaten their social face, while also leading to repeated indirect challenges from the employees towards the manager, in turn challenging his face.

Aesthetics as Morality

As a third aspect, aesthetic leadership also concerns the promotion of moral values.[3] This aspect is, for example, visible in the work of Ladkin (2008) who, based on a linear communication perspective, emphasizes that aesthetic leadership involves different elements. Among these are: (1) coherence, or self-expression that is aligned with one's values and goals and thus connected to authenticity; and (2) purpose, i.e., whether one's goals reflect what is important more generally, which relates to ethics. Others have taken a nominalist perspective: for example, both the studies by Guthey and Jackson (2005) and Liu et al. (2017), mentioned above, focus on how authenticity is constructed through visual media in the form of portraits or newspaper stories and cartoons, and Fairhurst and Sheep (2020) discuss Trump's identity work constructing himself as authentic in spite of the frequent and widely publicized examples of him lying. Relatedly, Bouilloud and Deslandes (2015) discuss how the phenomenon of top managers' *beau geste* (such as publicly rejecting a bonus in a given year) can be seen as a symbolic gesture meant to deflect potential criticism and position themselves as ethical.

Recently, Jian (2022) has provided a communicatively oriented theorization of empathic leadership, arguing that empathic leadership is practiced both diachronically

and linearly through leaders' narratives, whereas understanding of and empathy towards others' perspectives may be nurtured synchronically in interaction with specific others.

In other studies taking an interactional perspective, Larsson et al. (2021) show that authentic leadership should not be attributed to the leaders' behavior alone, but rather be seen as co-constructed, for example, through whether other parties acknowledge or challenge moves that signal authenticity. Furthermore, Wåhlin-Jacobsen (2019) also focuses on interaction and how managers construct their responses to employees' use of voice as being justifiable and accountable through the use of various discursive devices.

Aesthetics and the Arts

A fourth aspect of aesthetics is its relation to beauty and the arts. As mentioned above, in explaining what leading beautifully might mean, several authors give examples from the arts: Ladkin (2008) discusses situations from a concert, Koivunen and Wennes (2011) and Bathurst and Cain (2013) emphasize the aesthetic aspect of collaborating in a musical performance, and Ladkin and Taylor (2010) draw on acting theory to describe how authentic leadership is embodied. Also, Ladkin (2008) describes "leading beautifully" as constituted not only through coherence and purpose as mentioned above, but also the aspects of mastery in terms of understanding one's context and mastery of the self. However, the relationship between leadership and beauty is contested, with some fundamentally questioning the connection (Hansen et al., 2007).

Following the Steve Ballmer example above, it could be argued that speeches also constitute a type of orchestrated performance. Bull (2016) reviews existing studies of speaker-audience interaction in political speeches, focusing on how audience contributions are explicitly and implicitly invited and initiated by the speaker through, for instance, various rhetorical devices. Without explicitly discussing aesthetics, he notes how such audience contributions are strongly evaluative, supporting, or disaffiliating with the speaker. Through the audiences' "unscripted" contributions, the speech turns out more dialogical than monological (Bull, 2016), emphasizing the relational aspect forwarded by Koivunen and Wennes (2011). Furthermore, such studies demonstrate how what others call aesthetic judgment is not only based on individual experiences but is an integral part of interaction, with communicative practices such as rhetorical devices playing a key role.

Concluding Discussion

As the studies mentioned here attest to, materiality, embodiment, and aesthetics feature prominently in leadership communication in practice, shaping everyday leadership situations. Competent leadership actors understand this, showing an effort to orchestrate the situation for certain effects, as demonstrated in our discussion of the Steve Ballmer example. While most studies attending to our three focal themes are relatively recent, there is already remarkable diversity in their underlying theoretical perspectives and methodological approaches, so much so that it seems impossible to consider all aspects of how the three themes shape communication processes within the same analysis; still, engaging with the themes provides an important antidote to the rationalist and language-centered currents that characterize the leadership literature at large, helping us understand in greater detail how leadership communication is practiced "in the wild" and why.

Although our review has addressed the three themes separately, various overlaps should be noted. For example, there are clear connections between embodiment and materiality, as in Sinclair's (2005) example of how uniforms or access cards become part of one's bodily appearance, or how space and body are inherently related (Ropo & Salovaara, 2019; see also Pullen & Vachhani, 2013). And embodiment is tied to aesthetics in studies investigating how space (Ropo & Salovaara, 2019) or symbols (Ladkin, 2023) are perceived. Certain analytical frameworks used in the leadership literature already connect our three focal themes, for example, Goffman's dramaturgical approach, which views people as performing roles based on the metaphor of a theater stage, connecting aspects of embodiment (gesture and appearance), materiality (props and costume), and aesthetics (leadership as art) (e.g., Sinha et al., 2021; Sørensen & Villadsen, 2018).

Still, future theory and practice could go much further in recognizing and understanding the three focal themes' significance in relation to leadership communication. First, one may ask which understandings of leadership communication are proffered through the existing literature related to the three themes: as mentioned, many studies draw on a classic linear model of communication. Here, it could be argued that it is not too challenging to note that leaders employ material, embodied, or aesthetic aspects in their communication towards others; the more important question is what these aspects mean in practice – are they consequential, and if so: how? A stronger focus on the uptake and outcomes of employing these aspects in leadership communication could illuminate when they are important to the situation, and when they are not.

Such a focus can be found in methodological approaches inspired by conversation analysis, which systematically attends to the immediate consequences of communicative features. While Ruben and Gigliotti (2016, 2017) argue that the interactional model of communication holds various limitations compared to a systems model, it is also important that analyses adopting a systems model demonstrate, rather than claim, how the many different elements thought to potentially influence meaning interact in practice.

Relatedly, it can be noted that a number of studies approach the ontological status of materiality as unproblematic, considering materiality to be pre-existing (Ropo & Salovaara, 2019); this is remarkable given how most studies on embodiment as appearance (arguably the most "material" aspect of embodiment) generally approach the meaning of the body as co-constructed. As an alternative, Ropo and Salovaara argue that materiality and humans hold a processual relationship characterized by ongoing mutual constitution and, consequently, that we should engage analytically with these processes in and by themselves. Here, adopting interactional or systems perspectives on communication may shed additional light on how the meaning of materiality is negotiated socially and how such negotiations influence leadership processes.

Perhaps related to the precedence of linear communication models, there appears to be a far stronger focus on leadership as relating to formal leaders than as a general social influence process in the studies discussed in this chapter. Consequently, the current literature risks reinforcing leader heroism and romanticism, neglecting how different participants contribute to leadership processes in practice (cf. Ashford & Sitkin, 2019). By further embracing the practical and interaction-oriented leadership approaches that have proliferated in recent years (e.g., Crevani & Lammi, 2023; Larsson & Meier, 2023), it would be possible to develop a stronger understanding of how materiality, embodiment and aesthetics play into leadership processes outside of traditional hierarchical role relations, as well as how each of the themes shape situated negotiations concerning the meanings of holding formal leader versus follower roles.

Methodologically, Hindmarsh and Llewellyn (2018) argue that the vast majority of empirical studies attend to materiality and sociomateriality only indirectly, by drawing on interview accounts of materiality – a criticism that can be extended to the leadership communication literature. In relation to research on embodiment and aesthetic leadership, empirical studies have also typically been qualitative and based on interview or ethnographic methods. Many studies take an interpretative/phenomenological approach focusing, for example, on the sensing aspects of aesthetics or on beauty (Koivunen & Wennes, 2011), and numerous scholars have argued for including the analysts' personal experiences as an empirical resource (e.g.,

Hansen et al., 2007; Ladkin, 2023). In comparison, fewer studies engaging with notions of aesthetics and leadership are based on observations and audio/video recordings of work practices, such as Bull (2016). One risk in this regard is that without observational data, subjective experiences are empirically foregrounded. This may mean that the meanings that interviewees attach to material objects or bodies are taken for granted, rather than addressed analytically, as mentioned above.

Furthermore, the retrospection and discursive ordering of interview narratives may also reaffirm the understanding of aesthetics as subjective or even ephemeral (cf. terms such as "airy nothing" or "pre-cognitive, sensory experience" found in quotes above). However, methods do exist that allow us to systematically analyze the communicational processes that contribute to aesthetic experience. Besides widening the use of innovative multimodal analytical approaches such as the one presented by Tan et al. (2015; see also Smolović Jones & Hollis, 2023), it may be relevant to look beyond the leadership literature for analytical approaches that are suited for capturing the richness of situated human interaction (e.g., Goodwin et al., 2012; Mondada, 2019).

In terms of furthering leadership communication practice, embracing the role of materiality, embodiment and aesthetics is likely to provide us with a better basis for discussing issues of everyday relevance for leadership actors. If we follow Grint's (1999) claim that leadership is more of an art-form than a science, traditional theory-oriented approaches to leadership training and development may fail to equip the participants for certain important aspects of their jobs. Research on the three focal themes of this chapter can provide a systematic language for those phenomena that fall outside the realm of classical rationalist leadership theories, and thus are at risk of being written off as idiosyncratic or otherwise unworthy of academic attention. Such a language may better prepare leaders for sensing and verbalizing those aspects of the situation that otherwise may escape attention, a leadership skill that various authors argue to be central, as noted above.

A number of relevant training approaches drawing on insights concerning materiality, embodiment and aesthetics already exist. For example, Heifetz, Grashow and Linsky (2009) take as their point of departure that observing and sensing what goes on in leadership settings can be challenging while immersed in the stream of action. Based on the metaphor of "getting on the balcony" (p. 49), they suggest that leaders step out of the action momentarily, focusing on what is going on in the present situation, and subsequently designing interventions so as to mobilize people in the intended direction.

Relatedly, Sinclair (2005) argues for leaders developing greater body awareness, Gagnon et al. (2012) discuss the use of improvisational theatre in leadership

development, and Gayá Wicks and Rippin (2010) describe how doll-making may inform leadership classes. Also, Jansson (2018) describes how weekly choral singing sessions was undertaken in a management team, discussing the intervention in the context of a wider taxonomy of "aesthetics-based leadership development." Importantly, Jansson discusses how such leadership development initiatives may be variably oriented towards instrumental versus aesthetic values, and how they may draw on approaches that are intellectual (e.g., considering art as metaphorical to leadership) or artistic and immersive (e.g., participants perform themselves).

In this way, although research on materiality, embodiment, and aesthetics in relation to leadership communication is still in a budding phase, there already exists a number of relevant theoretical and practical approaches that may inspire and inform organization members as they engage in leadership processes in the course of their daily work. Based on the growing interest in the three themes, more are sure to come.

Notes

1. Copyright limitations prevent us from presenting video screenshots, which could have further illustrated points relating to our three focal themes. In the transcript, [] denote transcription notes, CAPITALS denote utterances made with high volume, (.) indicates a pause.⏎
2. It should be recognized that the study also holds interactional elements; however, the contribution of materiality to framing the situation is mainly treated from a linear perspective, with a focus on how the focal manager's messages are supported.⏎
3. This theme is also addressed in the wider literatures on ethical and authentic leadership, which will not be covered in detail here (see Fairhurst et al., 2024).⏎

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22

LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION AND TECHNOLOGY

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-26

Introduction

The field of organizational communication historically has treated organizational phenomena, like leadership, separately from the technologies used to communicate and accomplish work. In reviewing early organizational communication handbooks (e.g., Jablin & Putnam, 2001; Jablin et al., 1987; Putnam & Mumby, 2013), there is often a chapter on communication technology and one on leadership. Over time, views on technology, agency, and nonhuman agency have expanded in our field and more technology-related chapters appear in our scholarship and handbooks (Miller & Poole, Forthcoming). But rarely, if ever, have scholars considered organizational technology, leadership, and communication together, and never has that been more important than now; therefore, that is the goal of this chapter.

Studies of the interplay between technology and organizations have changed over time, yet the strong reliance on theory and empirical research has persisted. In the 1980s and 1990s, organizational and management scholars studied individual technologies – often referred to as information and communication technologies or ICTs – compared their use and identified variables influencing and influenced by their use. These important foundations established the norm for theorizing ICT use and conducting rigorous empirical research (e.g., Daft et al., 1987; Fulk, 1993; Rice, 1993). Over time, studies of ICTs and organizations expanded to discuss more than one ICT (Stephens,

2007) and began focusing on affordances – opportunities for action – of technologies (e.g., Treem & Leonardi, 2012). Additionally, organizational communication research focused on how organizing and communicating happen around and in the presence of ICTs (e.g., Ganesh & Stohl, 2010; Stephens, 2018). And now our field has added an agency and power focus, specifically around how humans, technologies, and machines work and communicate together (Endacott & Leonardi, 2022; Shaikh & Cruz, 2022; Stephens et al., 2023).

While the word "leadership" is not often specifically mentioned within the technology literature that has amassed, the evolution of technologies in and around organizations is central for leadership concepts. The term manager, on the other hand, is regularly used along with technology because managers perform tasks, such as budgeting and making personnel decisions, where communication technologies function more as conduit for this information. This chapter views leadership as a social construction that is realized by both human and material actors, and an interpretive phenomenon where power dimensions play integral roles (Fairhurst et al., Forthcoming). Yet we also acknowledge that people functioning as leaders are often tasked with making decisions around technology use. This chapter embraces theoretical concepts such as sensemaking and understanding the complexity of agency and affordances as we entwine leadership communication along with communication technologies. This is a rapidly changing time in the evolution of technologies, and discussions of agency and the social construction of meaning are key because some technological nonhuman agents are able to accomplish work previously done by humans, and they are beginning to take on human-like qualities. Discussions around leadership in the future will likely not only include humans; it may become more collective and distributed with nonhuman actors, like algorithms and robots, of many forms (Ospina et al., 2020).

This chapter discusses theories that inform the evolving organizational landscape and provides examples and directions for leaders and leadership scholarship to contribute. We focus first on contemporary issues around using communication technology devices and platforms because there are many organizational leadership practices that still involve these. Next, we bring leading with automation into the discussion, provide additional theoretical perspectives on how automation shapes workplace and how human and technology actors interact to construct leadership, and offer empirically based ideas for what this form of leadership might entail.

Leading and Constructing Leadership Alongside Technologies

We begin by considering three key theories that have shaped contemporary communication technology use in organizations and have important leadership implications. While the chapter makes a distinction between communication technologies that have been studied and used in organizations for decades and those more focused on automation, these three theories also apply to more automated processes. In this section of the chapter, we use these theories to inform how technologies, like enterprise social media and mobile communication, are used and how technologies shape important organizational issues such as virtual work and work-life concerns.

Theories and Sensitizing Concepts

Communication technologies can be considered material objects, and their capacity to enable or constrain actions relates to a useful concept known as affordances. Affordances are defined as the capacity for action; they emerge from the interactions between human and nonhuman actors and include understanding how material features of technologies can support human behaviors (Gibson, 1979). In other words, a technology's material properties afford various possibilities for action based on the contexts in which they are used and the actors who are using the technology. In the context of leadership and technology, affordance perspectives explain that when individuals or groups use technologies, they also make choices about their use of technology features to accomplish their objectives, which may shape power and construct new leadership dynamics. Interactions with technologies can also lead to the construction of new work routines or the need for a new technology (Faraj & Leonardi, 2022).

The proliferation of communication technologies, such as social media, enterprise social networking sites, websites, and intranets, have changed the visibility of communication practices in organizations. The theory of communication visibility (Leonardi, 2014) highlights how enterprise social networking sites can change metaknowledge, defined as the awareness of "who know what and who knows whom in the organization" (p. 811). Visibility is also problematized in work that is related to public social media platforms and organizational communication. Specifically, Stephens and Powers (2020) argue that organizations' communication practices and activities are more public now, especially if organizations or their employees use public social media. By using those public platforms, non-organizational members can get glimpses of what happens between the organization and their internal and external stakeholders,

thus organizations can be considered more translucent – or see through – because their practices are more visible.

Leadership practices and opportunities to participate in leadership have also become more visible. Employees, other organizational stakeholders, and curious outsiders can learn about organizational leaders by searching online for official and unofficial statements and view opinions that current and former employees make about the leadership and the organization as a whole. By doing this, stakeholders can evaluate the actions of organizations and make their own interpretations around leadership practices, which contribute to the construction of leadership. Therefore, leveraging social media and building trust through being transparent and responsive to stakeholders' needs, such as the need to provide timely information, is crucial to shaping the construction of leadership (e.g., Ellison et al., 2015; Gibbs et al., 2013; Leonardi, 2014; Treem & Leonardi, 2012).

While early theories around technologies in organizations focused on predicting ways to use ICTs (e.g., Daft et al., 1987), and social influences on how people use technologies (Fulk, 1993), adaptive structuration theory (AST) expanded ways of thinking about technology. AST stemmed from structuration theory and raised awareness around how technologies shape organizational life by acting as structures (DeSanctis & Fulk, 1999; DeSanctis & Poole, 1994). Central to AST is that technologies are configurable, and the concept of *spirit* functions to help users understand what behaviors are appropriate in the context of using a specific technology. AST speaks to several different aspects of leadership, and in their 1994 theoretical paper, DeSanctis and Poole discuss how ICTs can provide opportunities for leadership to emerge as well as the role of participation and domination when the technology is used and knowledge about the technology is communicated. It also highlights the important role technology decisions play in organizations and cautions decision makers that technology adoption is unpredictable and different groups will use technologies in distinct and often contradictory ways. For example, in Barrett's (2018) study on integrating electronic health record (EHR) technology in a hospital setting, workers evolved their EHR system to better suit their working needs and different groups used the EHR system differently. While AST has been used for several decades, it is still very relevant today especially as products containing artificial intelligence and assisted decision making are being used in organizations.

Adapting to Changing Work Practices and Technology

While there are many theories that inform studies of leadership, technology, and organization, we chose the previous three theories because they frame and help explain some of the contemporary issues around using communication technology devices and platforms. Communication technologies have material properties, contain various affordances, and they shape and are shaped by organizational life. Here we focus on two specific communication technologies, enterprise social media, and mobile devices where these three theories are at play. We also discuss core organizational issues around work-life boundaries and virtual work that are often shaped by communication technologies and leadership practices.

Enterprise Social Media

Enterprise social media (ESM) are defined as:

> Web-based platforms that allow workers to (1) communicate messages with specific coworkers or broadcast messages to everyone in the organization; (2) explicitly indicate or implicitly reveal particular coworkers as communication partners; (3) post, edit, and sort text and files linked to themselves or others; and (4) view the messages, connections, text, and files communicated, posted, edited and sorted by anyone else in the organization at any time of their choosing.
>
> (Leonardi et al., 2013, p. 2)

While Treem and Leonardi (2012) identified four specific affordances of ESMs (visibility, editability, persistence, and association), the affordances of visibility and association are most closely related to leadership.

Studies relying on visibility affordances and ESMs have found they make knowledge and differences in a status hierarchy more visible, and thus they can both reproduce hierarchical differences as well as help some workers gain access to previously unshared knowledge (Kim, 2018). ESMs can also be a source of innovation. Because they afford visibility in people, content, and ideas, they can also expose people to new networks and concepts, thus contributing to organizational learning (Leonardi et al., 2013). This research suggests the importance of attending to the visibility of communication and knowledge sharing in organizations (Ellison et al., 2015; Gibbs et al., 2013) because knowledge is often the power base of leadership and a precursor to innovation. These theoretical and empirical findings speak to a more socially constructed view of leadership because having access to these forms of ESM can shape leadership practices.

There is a growing norm that people want to be connected to others at all times (Bayer et al., 2016), and thus, ubiquitous mobile technologies raise several new challenges for leadership (Stephens, 2018, 2023). For leaders to be innovative, they need to understand issues that arise around inequity and communication technologies. For example, with the rise of bring-your-own-device-to-work policies (BYOD), employees are being asked to pay for their own mobile devices and the associated service charges. Only occasionally are they provided any reimbursement of those work-related expenses, and the people most often reimbursed are at a higher hierarchical level within an organization (Stephens, 2018).

With the ubiquity and mobility of ICT use in organizations, there is often a perception that team members can be reached anytime and anywhere. There are myriad ways ICTs are entwined with work/life concerns and practices (Kirby & Buzzanell, 2014), and many of them are relevant when discussing leadership. For example, the norms around connectivity – often attributed to the proliferation of mobile devices (Bayer et al., 2016) – have complicated issues of agency and boundaries. Specifically, work around mobile technology paradoxes reveals that while using these technologies can enhance agency by empowering people and providing independence, the flip side is that they can also enslave people and make them dependent on their devices (Jarvenpaa & Lang, 2005).

These paradoxes and constant connectivity issues have driven some countries (i.e., Canada, Portugal, France, and other parts of Europe) to establish laws because they want to prohibit employers and coworkers from contacting one another after work hours (Stephens, 2023). In countries where such laws do not exist, for example, in the U.S., that means the regulation of these work-life boundaries falls on the shoulders of organizational leaders or working groups who enact their own boundaries. There are occasions for dialogue around these issues and opportunities for organizations and work groups to make sense of their own practices, agree upon boundaries, and make the norms visible and equitable for all members.

Another form of mobility in work concerns what is often called virtual work. While the fields of communication, management, and computer science have studied virtual work and virtual teaming for decades (e.g., Gibbs et al., 2017; Jarvenpaa & Leidner, 1999), COVID-19 sent many workers away from offices and into their homes. Leaders and workers struggled, and opportunities to co-construct leadership changed (Stephens et al., 2020). Almost overnight the nature of work became more invisible in many

physical ways. Managers and co-workers could not look around an office and "see" the work of their colleagues, and impromptu meetings and conversations were shut down.

But at the same time that the in-person work became less visible during the global pandemic, technology was used to increase the visibility of work online and connect people working in different locations. For example, the use of web conferencing (e.g., Zoom, Teams, WebEx) increased to help people meet synchronously even while not face-to-face. There was also a rise in the surveillance of workers including behind-the-scenes tracking of work and actively monitoring employee activities (Vitak & Zommer, 2023). These practices can create issues around trust between employers and employees, and leadership must identify ways to resolve this challenging issue. Finally, as people returned to a physical workspace, employees around the globe wanted more flexibility to work from home, so there were challenges getting people back into a physical office (Smite et al., 2023). The invisibility of physical work and the changing nature of what makes work visible in a work-from-home context provides new challenges and opportunities for the co-construction of leadership.

There are many opportunities to continue studying what is called virtual work or work-from-home practices within an interpretive leadership lens. Often included under the future of work concept, these forms of working inherently involve technologies for connecting and communicating. The prime opportunities in this area center around encouraging dialogue and sensemaking as leaders work together to co-create structures that are visible and accessible to all members of organizations. As we work to make the hidden visible, technology platforms can help. New leadership opportunities will likely emerge and so will a more egalitarian approach to using technology at work. Research in this area should also include a focus on practices that are acceptable to all members concerning how to leverage technology communication tools, but still provide reasonable boundaries so people do not feel they have to be always available for work.

Leaders Working with Automation

While the previous section of this chapter connected leadership with the communication technology tools often actively used in organizations, this section narrows in on automation and artificially intelligent technologies (AI) – defined as a set of computational technologies that are inspired by, but typically operate quite differently from, how people use their nervous systems and bodies to learn, reason, sense, and take action (Stone et al., 2016). Organizational leadership practices must consider both the positive and negative implications of automation as we make sense of and implement

automation into our changing organizational environments. Because emerging technologies are increasingly embedded in complex constellations of organizational relations, the technologies are enacted in and defined by these dynamic relations (Bailey et al., 2022; Faraj & Leonardi, 2022). Put differently, these technologies can afford or constrain leadership and organizational actions based on a host of other entities in which they are embedded, such as the human actors who use them, the external databases the technologies draw upon, and the rules that govern how the technologies are used (Bailey et al., 2022). All these actors have agency, but their position and relation to other actors may vary in different contexts. To understand the relationship between leadership and technologies, we take this relational perspective because it acknowledges that material and human agency are emerging and fluid and is more compatible with a view that leadership is co-constructed by myriad human and nonhuman actors.

In this section, we first discuss key theoretical frameworks that help to understand leadership in a context where many aspects of work are highly automated by advanced technologies, such as robots and AI tools. We then discuss the future of work and highlight the role advanced technologies plays in shaping our work. We end by discussing the applications of these advanced autonomous technologies in organizations, as well as leadership challenges and considerations that have emerged and these can lead to meaningful future research.

Theories Informing Automation Technologies and Organization

By acknowledging there can be a more intimate relationship between humans and technologies, prior theories (e.g., Adaptive Structuration Theory) can be helpful when considering automation, but so can more contemporary notions of agency. Borrowing from a relational perspective, we define agency as an effect realized through a constellation of both human and nonhuman/technology actors. This definition reconceptualizes agency not as a property inherently possessed by humans but shifts agency to an emergent and fluid capacity realized through the interaction and relations of humans and nonhumans (Bailey et al., 2022; Faraj & Leonardi, 2022). In the context of considering leadership alongside technologies, there is a web of interaction and mutual shaping between leaders, organizational members, and technologies in use, and they all exhibit agency. Though technologies and structures (e.g., messaging applications) may not act on their own, by interacting with humans, they affect and are affected by human actions and therefore they enable and constrain messages and actions.

Another useful lens to help leaders understand the entwinement of organizations and technology is the perspective of sociomateriality. That is, organizations are not simply collections of people or technologies, rather, they consist of networks of interactions between people, technologies, and other material artifacts. These sociomaterial networks play a crucial role in shaping how technology is used and how organizational change happens with technologies being implemented and used (Orlikowski, 2007, 2010). Actor-network-theory (ANT, Latour, 1984, 2005) is one of the most influential examples within this body of research. ANT denies the distinction between the humans and technologies and construes power as an effect of networks consisting of both humans and technologies. Thus, both humans and technology artifacts are participants in a course of action, and they shape one another (Latour, 1984, 2005). This body of research has a lot to offer leaders and leadership practices. For example, it provides a systems perspective that views technology as an counterpart within a system of relations that extends beyond an immediate context (Anthony et al., 2023). It also explicates how technological systems and artifacts play a vital role in the construction of networks of people and things that contribute to the development of new technologies, leadership, and organizational routines (Leonardi, 2012). More importantly, it helps to conceptualize leadership as socially constructed and increasingly realized through interaction with other actors (e.g., technological objects, sites, and people) (Fairhurst et al., in press).

With technologies becoming increasingly more capable of independent action and human-like, they have transformed the nature of organizing and communicating in several ways. Earlier theories on human and computer interaction such as computers as social actors (CASA) suggested humans perceive computers as social actors (Nass & Moon, 2000). That is, when humans interact with computers, they mindlessly apply social rules and expectations used for human interactions to computers (Nass & Moon, 2000). CASA theory has been instrumental in explaining that people can treat computers and other technologies as social others, and how this can affect organizational use of technologies. For example, recent research shows that workers who trained an AI model to automatically label tweets associated the AI model as a teammate. As a consequence, they experienced emotions and even self-doubt when they needed to overwrite or correct the work of the machine (Stephens et al., 2023). As more agentic technologies are being implemented in organizations to fulfill organizational goals, they have prompted the formation of networked interrelationships among humans, technologies, and institutions. However, CASA does not fully provide the explanatory

power to understand the effects of networks of humans and technologies, especially how processes adapt and change on an organizational level.

With the rise of AI technologies and increasing interactions between humans and these intelligent machines, recent scholarship has positioned AI and autonomous technologies as more than simple tools people use to accomplish work, but as agents that interact and can communicate with human beings (Guzman & Lewis, 2020). This adds more complexity in understanding the mutual shaping effects between humans and machines. As automated technologies are being implemented and used in organizations, leaders inevitably encounter issues surrounding the benefits and costs of the intelligent machines as well as the implications of such technologies on the overall organizational functioning. These theoretical frameworks provide leadership – both formal and informal – with tools to understand advanced technologies and platforms that are currently being used or developed. These theories also provide sensemaking devices and offer ways to examine the implications of workplace technologies, sensitize people to precautions they might take when implementing new technologies, as well as help leaders in any capacity to contemplate their own role in shaping the workplace into a better environment.

Advanced Technology Used in Workplace and the Construction of Leadership

When activating the theories just discussed, there are many implications for how leadership can be constructed when advanced technologies are being used and implemented into organizations. There are opportunities for new leadership to emerge because understanding these advanced technologies is an important form of organizational expertise. Decisions around using these technologies need to be openly discussed, and while they can offer considerable advantages for efficiency, effectiveness, and could improve the lives of some workers, they also can be a hidden source of bias, control, and error (Littman et al., 2021). Leadership, both formal and informal, has never been more important because organizational members have a responsibility to become AI literate and be both optimistic and cautious as they recommend new technologies to their peers. In the following section, we share literature on various workplace technologies of automation and how the use of automation and AI tools shift power dynamics and construct a new form of leadership that can exert invisible and autonomous control. Lastly, we shift the discussion of

leadership from a theoretical conceptualization to specific considerations leaders need to engage with when working with automation.

Using AI Technologies at Work

Smart tools such as AI technologies are used extensively to assist data processing and support leadership decisions (Barbour et al., 2023). For instance, automated systems can assess individuals' credit risk by examining their social networks, and AI bots can automatically detect inappropriate or controversial social media content to aid in human workers' decision-making practices (Jarrahi, 2018). Increasingly, automated machines do not only constitute tools of work and decision support, but rather tools of managing work and making decisions, thus rendering leadership less visible (Lammi, 2020). These technologies have the potential to exert more control over workers and their work (Kellogg et al., 2020). Specifically, automated systems can recommend workers make certain decisions and take specific courses of action because they can quickly sift through a large amount of data and generate insights based on the algorithms programed into the systems. Furthermore, these systems can impose restrictions on work behaviors that are not desirable by the organizations and restrict certain information that ideally should be available to workers (Jarrahi, 2018; Kellogg et al., 2020).

Automated systems can also track and record a wide range of workers' behavior, evaluate workers' performance, and adjust work in real-time for work performance. For instance, computer algorithms can assign tasks to workers, set working paces, screen and recruit workers, evaluate workers' performance, and even determine workers' compensation based on criteria input by humans (Harms & Han, 2019; Langer et al., 2019). Uber, a networked transportation company, is one of the many platforms that automates workers' routines. Even without explicit formal leadership, the Uber platform's algorithm appears to be the behind-the-scenes manager to Uber drivers and this can deprive Uber drivers' sense of power (Gibbs et al., 2021). In healthcare, AI is used to interpret imaging results and make diagnostic decisions, all driven by machine learning algorithms; however, the accuracy and specificity of AI diagnostics have been debated (Østerlund et al., 2021).

AI technologies also prevail in organizations and are used for organizing and coordinating purposes (Beane & Orlikowski, 2015; Endacott & Leonardi, 2022; Wajcman, 2019). These AI-powered tools can shift organizational power dynamics and introduce questions of who controls whom. For example, sharable calendar systems that utilize automated algorithms have become the standard tools for coordinating time and synchronizing work activities (Wajcman, 2019). One of the key features of these

calendar systems is visibility, which is designed to make individuals' time visible to others, thus maximizing the efficiency of scheduling processes. However, this priority of organizational efficiency can clash with individual workers' goals and impose control over workers' time. Consequently, workers can be kept in motion with endless meetings because their free time slots are visible to the organization, and they can be booked with activities anytime. Similarly, when people use highly automated scheduling tools, they worry about losing control of their ability to manage the impressions of their communication partners (Endacott & Leonardi, 2022). This is because the AI scheduling tool can communicate with others without consulting the human, and the communication decisions made by the AI schedule tool sometimes differ from those that people would make themselves. This has led to users' apologizing for their misbehaved AI boss in an effort to restore a positive impression.

The use of automation is not limited to data processing tasks or virtual support systems but includes tasks in the physical spaces where humans work alongside robots. This is what Fortunati et al. (2018) describes as a shift from industrial to social robotics. In hospitals, for example, surgical robots have been introduced to assist minimally invasive operations, pharmacy stock-dispensing robots have been used in hospitals to increase organizational efficiency, and robotic telepresence has been integrated into coordination systems for hospital workers (Barrett et al., 2012; Beane & Orlikowski, 2015; Sergeeva et al., 2020). However, the introduction of social robotics at workplaces can shift power dynamics, reconfigure job roles and work practices, and unevenly impact the human workers that work alongside the robots. For example, the use of pharmaceutical dispensing robots in hospitals has intensified entry-level workers' work and set restrictions on their work patterns that have had negative consequences (Barrett et al., 2012).

Leadership Challenges and Considerations and Future Research

The expanding use of AI technologies at work has made positive changes, but it also raises issues that warrant attention and additional future research. Some of the same technologies that have positive impacts can also restrict some organizational members from opportunities to demonstrate their leadership abilities and limit opportunities to develop members into leaders capable of leading with technology. For example, providing one group of employees with access to gain knowledge and skills of using AI technologies while restricting access for others can lead to inequitable outcomes and opportunities (Kellogg et al., 2020). While there are many challenges that could be

considered, next we raise issues related to individual and team performance, AI transparency, power, control, resistance, human labor replacement, and technology integration and offer suggestions for how these could be studied.

The use of technologies of automation requires attention and potential changes in leadership practices to minimize negative implications. When workers interact with AI technologies, they may not simply use the technology as a tool, instead, it constitutes a form of communication between the workers and the technology in use, through which the workers make sense of the intelligent machine and build relationships with the technology (Guzman & Lewis, 2020; Stephens et al., 2023). This has implications for individual workers. Workers may struggle because it is cognitively taxing to work with technologies that make decisions autonomously, and workers may experience decision overload. For example, research demonstrates that when human workers need to correct or overwrite decisions made by the smart machine partners, they experience emotions and even self-doubt (Stephens et al., 2023). Along the same vein, other studies have found the use of intelligent technologies can impact teams. One recent study found that people tend to use more intelligent technologies to complete their tasks when they experience time scarcity (Shaikh & Cruz, 2022). However, the use of intelligent technologies negatively impacts team performance and creativity due to reduced interactions among team members even when they have abundant time (Jensen et al., 2022; Shaikh & Cruz, 2022). Therefore, leadership practices should consider these issues and how technologies can support and augment workers, such as incorporating technologies designed for a specific context and offering training for workers to help them team effectively with the technologies (Jarrahi, 2018; Stephens et al., 2023).

Many AI technologies and algorithms used by organizations lack transparency around exactly how the machines function and make decisions. A lack of transparency and explainability – or how the AI technology arrives at a given solution – can hamper the reliability of leadership decision making, and limit trust from the human partners (Østerlund et al., 2021). This may lead to worker frustration as these systems' decision-making processes are not intelligible to workers (Kellogg et al., 2020). Research suggests that leaders should center questions around technology transparency early in the design stage of a technology. This is to ensure the effects of automation on workers and organizations are transparent and visible (Xu, 2023) because "developing, implementing, and using a technology are all parts of the process of organizing" (Leonardi, 2012, p. 19). Additionally, research suggests that offering education and training on AI literacy to workers is essential for bettering knowledge and use of AI tools because workers must make sense of AI tools, navigate the opacity of these

technologies while they try to achieve organizational objectives, and address situations when AI malfunctions (Østerlund et al., 2021).

Automation at work can impose more control and restrictions over the interactions human workers have with one another, and this can impact leadership opportunities. When AI systems restrict certain information available to workers or eliminate opportunities for workers to communicate directly with managers, workers tend to experience reduced voice and control (Kellogg et al., 2020). Automated technologies can function as a formal structure at work, such as managing and controlling work, but employees at all levels in the hierarchy possess capacities to resist that structure. For decades, organizational scholars (e.g., Meyerson, 2001) have acknowledged that sometimes this resistance is valid and worthy of attention, but those same technologies also can be used to resist the technological control of work, which may result in negative implications for management and organizations (Lammi, 2020).

As technologies continue advancing, people tend to attribute more power to them. Because the classic aim of automation is to substitute humans' manual control and planning, it is easy to forget that automated systems require human involvement and often render supportive workers invisible (Barbour et al., 2023; Campolo & Crawford, 2020). Rather than viewing intelligent technologies as replacements for workers, leaders should consider technologies as team members that complement and augment workers' capabilities, and not remove human judgment and critical appraisal of the situations (Gibbs et al., 2021; Malone, 2020; Østerlund et al., 2021). Because workers' livelihoods and careers are becoming incrementally intertwined with the smart machines and the larger sociotechnical systems that enable their work, workers should play a crucial role in the design and ongoing alignment of AI technologies in their everyday practices (Østerlund et al., 2021; Wolf & Blomberg, 2019; Xu, 2023).

Another leadership challenge concerns balancing organizational productivity and profits with decisions to replace human workers with machines. Research from the 1990s on this topic suggested caution because the financial gains achieved by simply automating work and replacing human workers tend to be short-term and exert a profound, but less visible, impact on workers and workplaces, such as a deskilled and demoralized workforce (Mumford, 1994). The 100-Year Report on AI, suggests that while this form of replacement is not likely to disrupt the global workforce, especially in care-giving contexts, it is important to continue monitoring this possibility for grander societal reasons (Littman et al., 2021). AI and automated systems may be able to help humans make better decisions, but it is important to not think of them as replacing human intelligence, rather, they can augment decisions (Littman et al., 2021). In fact, research

suggests that non-managerial level organizational members may play a central role in supporting the decision-making functions and maintaining automated systems, capabilities that cannot be necessarily replaceable by AI (Fox et al., 2023; Jarrahi, 2018). There are opportunities to study how and why some employees fear being replaced at work, and as some jobs are replaced, research will be needed to understand the ethical implications and the human consequences of automating work processes and outcomes.

A final challenge of automation at work concerns technology integration or how all the various systems work together. Many workplaces have become thoroughly digital, and the execution of work relies not only on one automated system but a web of many systems and human actors. Despite their increasing versatility, there are still compatibility challenges when coordinating them (Lammi, 2020). Indeed, the integration of automated technologies in organizations is a complex process that is time consuming and labor intensive, and the integration only works if the technologies are judiciously incorporated into the social fabric of the organizations by considering the complex constellations of human and technology actors (Sawyer & Jarrahi, 2014). Even when an automated system appears to have been carefully integrated into organizational routines, the implications or effects of automation can be easy to overlook and difficult to forecast because the effects of using the same automation technologies can vary in use (Bailey & Barley, 2020; Barbour et al., 2023).

Key additional opportunities to study AI technologies and leadership center on awareness, continual learning, and balance. Future research on leadership around automation might focus on how organizational members understand what the technologies are doing, such as how technologies are making decisions, and how to actively monitor the quality of the decisions being made by AI and human-AI teams. This often means looking beyond a single disciplinary perspective to better understand both the technology and the human-centered concerns around using AI systems. Being thoughtful and involving diverse organizational members in implementation decisions is one way to help avoid the rush to adopt new technologies that have been trained using biased data or generate erroneous results – also called hallucinations. If our goal is to expand the conception of what organizational leadership is today, we must consider technology, and in doing so, we create new opportunities to lead along with and through communication technologies of the future.

Conclusion

This chapter is one of the first to integrate communication, leadership, and technologies in organizations, and thus, there are many opportunities for future research in these integrated areas. While automation and AI technologies are certainly important for the future of organizations and leadership, so are the technology tools that are commonly used to communicate. Organizational communication scholars are well positioned to study the mutual constitution of humans and technology; a view that leadership is socially constructed, and so is the agency of automated technologies. Leaders can be innovative and use their power to shape what technology is, what it can do, and how it should be used. They also can be important change agents around the use and implementation of technology that can in turn also shape how members perceive leaders and leadership.

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23

EMOTION AND HUMOR IN LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-27

Introduction

Fairhurst and Connaughton (2014) observed that reviews of leadership communication published in the first two editions of *The Handbook of Organizational Communication* (Dansereau & Markham, 1987; Fairhurst, 2001) were primarily derivative of the then-dominant leadership psychology paradigm. The individualistic focus on leaders in that psychology corpus ignored the effects of their r*elationships* with followers, and cognition was highlighted more than *emotion* (i.e., mental reactions such as surprise or fear that are experienced by the individual as strong feelings directed toward a specific object, person, or other entity). Notwithstanding these limitations, some traditional (*pre*-2000) perspectives – e.g., styles, functions, situational, and transactional/transformational approaches to leadership – did illuminate key facets of leadership *communication and emotion*. By way of introduction to the contemporary review of *post*-2000 studies, the chapter begins by briefly reviewing each of those approaches and what they revealed about emotion and leadership communication.

Traditional Scholarship on Leadership Communication and Emotion

Early management practices did not consider, or hardly considered, emotions in leadership (Taylor, 1923). Within a few years, management scholars and practitioners

recognized that workers were best guided when they felt supported by management (Roethlisberger, 1947). The *leadership styles perspective* included studies of democratic (Lewin et al., 1939) and team management/participative (Blake & Mouton, 1985) *behavioral styles of interacting* with followers. Central to enactment of the most person-centered of these leadership styles was the communication of discrete or multifaceted emotional responses such as supportiveness, respect, concern, considerateness, and listening to feelings related to followers' needs. The most relationship-focused leadership styles included behaviors that signaled – and sought – trust, openness to input, discussion, and collaboration with followers (as well as their performance and satisfaction). Conversely, Ashforth (1994) revealed six dimensions of a leadership style with negative behaviors and associated emotions that he termed petty tyranny: arbitrariness and self-aggrandizement; belittling subordinates; lack of consideration; forcing conflict resolution; discouraging initiative; and noncontingent punishment.

In tandem with other scholarship in the *leadership functions tradition*, Cartwright and Zander (1968) distinguished between goal achievement functions and *maintenance behaviors*. Emotion-related communication in the latter leadership functions included keeping interpersonal relationships pleasant, involving reticent followers, and providing support and encouragement. Related, Yukl and Tracey (1992) studied nine communicative influence tactics leaders used with subordinates among other stakeholders. Four of those tactics explicitly were intended to invoke *emotions* as the path to what the leader sought: inspirational appeals (arousing enthusiasm); ingratiation (enhancing mood); personal appeal (feelings of loyalty); and pressure (demands/threats to increase stress). Inspirational appeals, ingratiation, and personal appeals were moderately effective in influencing subordinates' task commitment, while pressure was ineffective.

Within the *situational approach to leadership*, Fiedler's (1978) contingency model of leadership predicted leader effectiveness from the match between the leader's orientation to leading (person-centered versus task-oriented) and characteristics of the situation which favor that orientation (member-leader relations, positional power, and task structure). Leader-orientation was determined by one's score on the Least-Preferred Coworker Scale, which requested 18 ratings of the coworker with whom the rater had least preferred working. Nearly all the rated behavioral pairings are *emotion-laden*: tense/relaxed, supportive/hostile, kind/unkind, gloomy/cheerful, cold/warm, among others. Fiedler's research revealed that these emotion-related assessments of others with whom they had least preferred working predicted effectiveness for task-

motivated leaders more than relationship-motivated leaders. The latter had more positively rated even those with whom they least preferred working, and thus could adapt to a wider range of others' emotions and behaviors.

Working within the *transactional/transformational perspective on leadership* (Burns, 1978), Bass and Avolio's (1990) examinations of the four components of transformational leadership (charisma, inspiration, individualized consideration, and intellectual stimulation) emphasized the importance of *communication*: motivating by communicating high expectations and using symbols to focus efforts; interacting in ways that communicate respect and responsibility; and communicating new ideas that challenge the status quo and stakeholders. *Emotions* such as passion, optimism, and excitement were part of transformational leaders' communication, while those leaders also were targets for followers' emotions: frustration, fears, and hopes. The resultant relationships between transformational leaders and followers were grounded in emotional bonds around transcendent visions, aspirations for improvements to the status quo, perceptions of confidence in both parties, and inspiring each other.

Scholars also identified the *dark side* of charismatic leadership, often manifested through communication (and conveying *negative emotions*). For example, Conger (1989) pointed to abuses of charismatic leaders: failures of vision (e.g., projecting personal needs over followers' needs); misarticulation of goals (e.g., exaggerated self-descriptions, suppression of negative information, and attribution of failure to others); and poor management practices (e.g., egoism and thus difficulty relating to others' successes, failure to plan for succession).

Perspectives on Emotion *and Organizational/Workplace Communication*

Although the role of *emotion* and *communication* is apparent in the foregoing traditional perspectives on leadership by psychology, sociology, and management scholars, relatively little research on *leadership communication* by organizational communication scholars has focused explicitly on *emotion*. More of our understanding of emotion in organizational communication flows from theory and empirical research on emotional practices that inhere in *organizational processes* such as emotion labor (Tracy & Tracy, 1998), the socialization of emotion (Scott & Myers, 2005), humor in sensemaking and identity management (Tracy et al., 2006), emotion metaphors (Krone & Morgan, 2000), organizational conflict and emotional expression (Paul & Riforgiate, 2015), and positive emotional experiences (Lutgen-Sandvik et al., 2011) among others. Waldron (2012) provided a comprehensive treatment of communicating emotion at work

that is relevant to this review, especially the relational functions of emotion in leadership communication.

Overview

In the sections that follow, we review contemporary (*post*-2000) scholarship concerning what *characteristics, competencies, and/or functions* are required of leaders regarding emotion. Second, are studies that emphasize the *relational functions of emotion* in leadership communication. The third set examines the burgeoning scholarship on leadership and *humor*, which offers important strategic uses in conveying emotions and with which we link scholarship on leadership communication and emotion. The conclusion offers a summary of key themes emerging from the review of emotion and leadership communication, including qualities necessary for leadership; the relationship of emotion to the leadership process; the relative importance of leaders' emotional displays compared with the content of leaders' messages; the impact of leaders' emotional processes on performance; the diversity and rigor of research methods in this area; leaders' age versus emotional aging; implications for practice such as leadership training; as well as opportunities for intersectional research on leader gender, age, race, and social class in scholarship on leadership communication and emotion.

Review

Characteristics/Competencies/Functions Required of Leaders Regarding Emotions

Recent studies reveal a variety of characteristics, competencies, and functions required of organizational leaders regarding emotions. First, several investigations link leaders' and followers' emotions with leaders' behaviors including *communication*. For example, as Rubin et al. (2005) observed, communication from leaders to followers often carries emotional content – including manifesting emotions as well as motivating emotion in others. In their study of 145 managers of a large biotechnology/agricultural U.S. company, *emotion recognition, positive affectivity, and agreeableness* all positively predict transformational leadership behavior.

Furthermore, transformational leaders seek to inspire members to higher values and aspirations – and thus emotion and communication have been viewed as central (Bass & Riggio, 2006). Transformational leaders' passionate values-focused rhetoric (Waldron,

2012) forges closer connections with followers (Conger, 1989) and inspires them to higher aspirations through the communication of emotions such as *hopefulness, positivity, and resilience* (Gardner et al., 2005).

Also linking leaders' communication and emotion, Dasborough (2006) found that certain leader behaviors (e.g., empowering followers, *communication*, demonstrating concern, recognizing employee effort) caused affective events in followers thus leading to emotion experiences. Related, Banks et al. (2023) found that eight *verbal* ethical leadership behaviors (ELS) were associated with leaders' emotions, which included leaders' expressions about: (1) altruistic action; (2) corrective action; communication regarding; (3) upholding rules and norms; (4) decision making; (5) the importance of two-way interaction; and (6) rewarding moral behavior; as well as (7) virtue signaling (i.e., making statements about her or his own moral character); and (8) discussing illustrative examples that portray what the leader believes is morally right or wrong. Collectively, these behaviors signaled not simply leaders' ethical commitments, but emotions associated with them such as righteous anger and pride.

Second, *other leader behaviors* are closely linked with leaders' own and/or followers' emotions. For example, how leaders *regulate displays* of their emotions, as well as their sense of the *scripts* they must follow, has been theorized to affect followers' perceptions of the appropriateness of those leaders' behaviors (Jordan & Lindebaum, 2015). Additionally, Edelman and van Knippenberg (2017) found that leaders' *emotion regulation skills* can be enhanced through training to increase their leadership effectiveness. Also, recent research reveals that *leader behaviors* are closely linked with leaders' own and/or followers' emotions. Shelia and Aycan (2022) found that experiencing *positive emotions* can be positively associated with individuals' decisions to nominate themselves for a leadership position (although no association was found for negative emotions). A positive relationship also exists between individuals' *emotion recognition capability* and their emergence as leaders (Walter et al., 2012).

Third, and regarding leader *gender*, Brescoll (2016) proposed an explanation for how *gender stereotypes of emotion* lead to biased evaluations of *female leaders* that may be especially detrimental when women are in high-status positions in the workplace. Brescoll suggested that gender–emotion stereotypes create two complexities that female, but not male, leaders must manage: (1) identifying *how much* emotion should be displayed; and (2) identifying *what kind* of emotions should be displayed. Brescoll argued that female leaders can be penalized for minor or moderate displays of emotion, especially when the emotion conveys dominance (e.g., anger or pride). This is

especially concerning for African American female leaders who must combat the stereotype of the "Angry Black Woman" (Lawson, 2018). However, being emotionally unexpressive also may be sanctioned because unemotional women are seen as not fulfilling their warm, communal stereotypical role. However, Gentry et al. (2015) found that signaling *empathic concern* can be advantageous for women leaders in terms of long-term career benefits, while *not* displaying gender-stereotypical empathy can include perceptions of adverse career consequences. Findings in this third area, while important, invite both expansion and refinement. For example, leaders' facility at anger expression must be nuanced. As Allen (2011) reminds, modulating expressions of anger and other emotions linked with dominance can be important not only for women but also for African Americans in a majority Caucasian setting. The conclusion calls for more intersectional research on leadership communication and emotion–especially the *intersection of gender, age, race, and social class*. In the next section, however, *relational* implications of emotions in leadership communication are explored.

Relational Functions of Emotions in Leadership Communication

Not only are particular characteristics, competencies, and functions required of organizational leaders, but emotions are implicated relationally between leaders and members. Workplace relationships are "emotionally unique" (Waldron, 2012, p. 104), involving risk, status inequality, and task performance, often in public settings and with influence on persons' lives outside of work. More specifically, the leader-member relationship entails emotional communication implicating both leadership and followership. Team leaders, managers, and organizational heads often benefit from the status advantage in their relationships with less powerful coworkers. Higher status affords increased autonomy. Because leaders often make, model, and enforce organizational norms, they are freer to express a wider range of emotions. Supervisors may express anger in response to a worker needing correction or motivation. In fact, organizational norms may provoke workers' expectations for specific kinds of emotional responses to situations like performance failures. Alternatively, supervisors may violate expectations by displaying positive emotions, remaining calm instead of expressing anger, or displaying sympathy rather than casting blame. In displaying positive or negative emotions, leaders can exercise their emotional autonomy with potentially potent and long-term effects on their relationships with their subordinates. By contrast, lower-power employees have less emotional autonomy than their leaders (Waldron, 2012).

Furthermore, in many kinds of labor, leaders and members must work interdependently. Successful task completion may elicit positive emotional responses, such as pride and excitement, whereas challenging group experiences may catalyze negative emotional responses, such as intense frustration or disgust. Regarding risk, how leaders and members engage in their emotional performances may impact their opportunities for career advancement.

This review of relevant literature focused on the role of emotions enacted in the communicative *relationship* between leaders and members. In the following subsections, the impact of a leader's emotion on members' behaviors and the impact of a leader's behavior on members' emotions are discussed.

Leader Emotion and Member Behavior

While the content of leaders' messages is important, leaders' emotional displays have had a larger impact on member perceptions of leaders in some circumstances (Humphrey, 2002). Those instances are discussed next.

Positive Leader Emotion

Overwhelmingly, leader positive affect produces positive perceptions of leader effectiveness. Avolio and colleagues (2004) found that positive emotions mediate the relationship between member identification with the leader, member effort, and job performance. More specifically, authentic leaders, defined as, "those individuals who are deeply aware of how they think and behave and are perceived by others as being aware of their own and others' values/moral perspective, knowledge, and strengths" (pp. 802–804), were associated with member optimism, first through identifying with members and then by evoking members' positive emotions. Additionally, Caza and associates (2015) found that members who believed their leader was more emotionally sincere reported greater trust in that leader and delivered better work performance.

Members also learn about emotion rules through relationships with their leaders, often by observing leaders enact and cope with their own emotions. For example, novice firefighters learned through observation that one way in which veteran firefighters cope with grief, sometimes associated with particularly traumatic pediatric calls, is through calling their loved ones upon return to the fire station (Scott & Myers, 2005).

Negative Leader Emotion

Alternatively, negative emotion displayed by leaders can be associated with more negative follower outcomes. Much of the research on negative emotion displays of leaders focuses on anger and the impact of anger on followers' attitudes and behaviors (see Shao & Guo, 2021, for a review). In a laboratory study, Lewis (2000) altered leader emotional displays and gender through video-taped leader speeches. Neutral leaders received higher effectiveness ratings than angry or sad leaders, and male leaders displaying anger were seen as more effective than male leaders displaying sadness. However, regardless of gender, Glomb and Hulin (1997) found that leaders showing anger were rated lower in effectiveness than those not showing anger. Yun and colleagues (2020) reported that a leader demonstrating no anger was perceived higher in leadership effectiveness than a leader showing either moderate or intense anger. In addition to measuring anger's effect on members' perceptions of leader effectiveness, Koning and Van Kleef (2015) found that leaders' expressions of anger may undermine followers' intentions to engage in organizational citizenship behaviors, which are voluntary activities such as working overtime to help an organization meet important deadlines or helping with socialization of new colleagues. Furthermore, leaders displaying inappropriate anger, as assessed by followers, had the most negative impact on followers' motivation to perform organizational citizenship behaviors (Koning & Van Kleef, 2015; Wang et al., 2018).

Member Behavior

While much of the literature examines the influence of leader emotion on member behavior, Tietsort and colleagues (2023) suggest that a member's hesitation to express suffering constrains a leader's ability to communicate compassion. The extent to which a leader may enact compassion is related to the extent to which suffering members make sense of disclosing and discussing suffering at work. More research is needed to understand the organizational and interpersonal contexts and cultures that encourage and/or inhibit members' willingness to communicate suffering and the resulting leader emotional responses.

Leader Behavior and Member Emotion

Leader behavior often influences member emotion too. Generally, more favorable leader behaviors are associated with more positive emotions and outcomes, and more unfavorable leader behaviors, such as anger, are associated with member negative affect. One notable finding to the contrary suggests that anger can enhance perceived

leader effectiveness, particularly when leader anger is expressed in response to integrity-based violations (Wang et al., 2018).

Favorable Leader Behaviors

Charismatic leader behaviors are the most widely studied favorable leader behaviors in evoking member positive affect. Erez and colleagues (2008) found that leader charisma included positive affective expressions, which led to positive member affect. Additionally, members' perceptions of leaders' efforts to attend to members' needs and emotions, such as modifying the situation or reframing events, were positively associated with leader member exchange, with organizational citizenship behaviors performed within interpersonal relationships, and with job satisfaction (Little et al., 2016; Van Kleef, 2014).

McColl-Kennedy and Anderson (2002) reported that transformational leadership had a direct positive influence on member-experienced optimism and a direct negative influence on member-experienced frustration, which then both contributed positively to member performance. Notably, the negative influence of frustration had a stronger effect on performance than the positive influence of optimism. This underscores the impact of frustration on members' performance and the potential for transformational leadership to reduce frustration levels and indirectly impact performance positively.

Unfavorable Leader Behaviors

On the unfavorable side, styles of leadership contribute to member emotion. Chiang and colleagues (2021) found that authoritarian leaders are likely to create an emotion suppression climate, defined as "team members' shared perception about the extent to which it is inappropriate for them to express emotions at work" (p. 1086), which then detrimentally affects member team performance. Ashkanasy and Dorris (2017) note that emotions suppressed at work may be released in other contexts, potentially spilling over to the family domain, and eventually influencing employee well-being (e.g., life satisfaction, marital satisfaction) and long-term job behavior (e.g., job satisfaction, organizational commitment, performance) (Allen et al., 2000). Counterintuitively, charismatic leadership also contributed to member emotion suppression. Menges and colleagues (2015) suggest that charismatic leadership may contribute to members' emotional suppression, due to being awestruck, but emotional suppression over time can lead to emotional exhaustion and estranged work relationships.

Leader Behavior and Leader Emotion

While most of the literature in leadership communication examines the relationship between leaders and members, a few studies have examined the emotional experience of leaders resulting from their own behavior. Managers perceived the atmosphere surrounding punishment of employees as highly emotional, with most of the emotions being negative. Interestingly, beyond the negative emotions experienced by those employees punished, Butterfield and colleagues' (1996) seminal work suggests that managers also experienced negative emotions because of their own behavioral involvement in enacting punishment.

After reviewing the impacts of emotion on the relationship between leaders and followers, attention is now turned to one type of emotion-laden communication that has received considerable attention in leadership scholarship – humor. Surprisingly, research on leaders and their strategic use of humor in the field of communication is limited. The next section links leadership and humor as a communicative strategy.

Leadership and Humor

Humor offers unique qualities that can make it an effective means of communication for leaders. Holmes and Marra (2006) declared that humor is "a valuable strategic resource in workplace discourse which leaders can choose to use where appropriate" (p. 133). Theories most commonly used in leader-humor studies are psychologically-based and include incongruity theory, relief theory, benign violation theory, and superiority theory (Rosenberg et al., 2021). More socially-focused uses of humor can be framed by affective event theory and emotional contagion theory. Early theorizing on leaders' use linked humor to an individual's character, rather than a skill. For example, Thorson and Powell (1993) questioned whether all leaders can use humor or whether it is best used only by those who are naturally funny. Research affirms that the ability to use humor is not a trait, but a skill that can be developed as a useful tool to enhance communicative relationships between leaders and followers (Kong et al., 2019), but they might use humorous communication in different ways. Evans and Steptoe-Warren (2018) identified three style clusters of managerial humor including: (1) those who frequently use positive humor and occasionally negative humor; (2) those who infrequently use humor, but when they do their style is negative; and (3) those who frequently communicate humor and use a variety of humor types. This section discusses research on the motives and effects of leaders' use of humor on workers, leader-worker relationships, and how leaders' use of humor appears to affect the workplace.

Leaders' Motives for Using Humor

Research concludes that humor fosters positive interactions. In a Robert Half (2017) survey, 84% of executives believed that individuals with a sense of humor are better leaders. In fact, studies show that humor is an invaluable tool for leaders linked to: reduced workplace stress and increased worker motivation (Shah, 2018); enhanced productivity and strengthened workplace culture (Holmes & Marra, 2006); improved newcomer adjustment (Rosenberg et al., 2021); lower turnover and absenteeism (Robert & Wilbanks, 2012); improved citizenship behaviors (Cooper et al., 2018); strengthened team cohesion (Watson & Drew, 2017); empowerment by establishing leader identity, assertiveness and authority (Watson & Drew, 2017); minimized power differences (Tan et al., 2021); and a means to deal with difficult issues such as minimizing the negative impact of feedback and protecting another's positive identity (Holmes & Marra, 2006). This section covers research on two general functions of leader humor: (1) as a source for enhancing amusement, which can reduce stress; and (2) as a means unifying the group, which can include asserting superiority over out-group individuals.

First, research demonstrates that humorous interactions can be amusing, which can simultaneously relieve stress. Early studies found that laughter is a type of release valve that works at the physical and emotional levels (Rosenberg et al., 2021) to help relieve workers' stress by lightening the mood and countering boredom (Collinson, 1988; Malone, 1980). Humor reduces stress by pointing out incongruities or contradictions enabling individuals to laugh at absurdities (Rosenberg et al., 2021). Even in contexts known for seriousness, leaders' humor makes a positive difference as Priest and Swain (2002) found in their study of military leaders as assessed by cadets. Good leaders were generally perceived to have a better sense of humor, and a warm humorous style was strongly related to effective leadership. Overall, leader humor is found to increase workplace enjoyment because it sets the tone for others' use of humor in the workplace.

Second, studies have identified how leaders can use humor to manage emotions by signaling their identification with workers and strengthening in-group relationships (Romero & Pescosolido, 2008). One means of connecting with workers is to minimize status differences between themselves and their members. A leader can poke fun at themselves so that workers have the opportunity to laugh at the leader's self-acknowledged foibles. Alternatively, leaders can also use humor to unify workers by signaling superiority over others (Meyer, 1997). One strategy is targeting outsiders encouraging workers to join them to collectively make fun of the competition or unreasonable customers. Thus, humor can elevate in-group status by affirming

commonly-held group values and experiences, while simultaneously dividing or distinguishing boundaries between the in-group and out-group.

Gender also plays a role in leaders' use of humor. Miron-Spektor and associates (2022) found that women who use humor generally have more influence, but the tactics they use may be important. Decker and Rotondo (2001) found that when females use positive humor they gain a stronger boost in perceived leader behavior and effectiveness, but when females use negative humor they experience more negative outcomes than their male counterparts. National culture appears to affect how women's humor is received. In a replication study conducted in China, Decker and colleagues (2011) found different effects. Compared to Chinese female leaders, Chinese male leaders benefited more from positive humor, but were hurt more by negative humor. Other studies highlight women's strategic use of humor in leader roles. For example, Schnurr (2008) found female leaders use humor to navigate the challenges of fitting into a man's world, which favors task accomplishment while simultaneously supporting relationship development.

Other factors affect a leader's ability to use humor. Lynch (2009) suggested that the workplace culture is the basis of individuals' interpretation of humor. When members identify with and feel that they are a part of the organization, they are more inclined to respond favorably to humor. Relatedly, Yang and Yeh (2021) argued that the effectiveness of leaders' humor often is predicated by the length and quality of the leader-follower relationship. When workers do not feel comfortable with the leader, they may not know how to respond to the leader's attempts at humor, asking themselves, "Is the boss attempting to be funny, or am I just not understanding what they are saying?" Inappropriate use of humor is linked to followers' perceptions of incompetence, which can erode leader status (Bitterly et al., 2017); however, there's little agreement about what constitutes "appropriateness." Good leaders also need to appreciate others' humor, even when it is targeted toward them. As Priest and Swain (2002) argued, "A good leader uses good natured jests to put others at ease" (p. 176), while bad leaders "misinterpret the intent of others' good-natured kidding" (p. 176).

Contexts that Affect Leaders' Use of Humor

National and industry culture can be implicated in whether leader humor positively affects workers and the workplace. As Yang and associates (2020) found, in Confucian cultures, leaders who use humor may be less appreciated because seriousness is prioritized over lighthearted communication. Thus, while humor is a valuable social tactic in Western cultures signifying a positive disposition, in Confucian cultures, those

who use humor can be thought to be less serious (Yue et al., 2016). Humor in these contexts is less overt, and more low-key (Yue, 2010). Related to the workplace, Karakowsky et al. (2020) studied leaders and followers in a large Canadian retail organization. They found that leaders who use humor facilitate trust in the leader and positively influence subordinate feedback-seeking behavior with the supervisor. In the hospitality industry, Wu et al. (2020) found that leaders' humor can influence hospitality workers' desire to provide good customer service.

Conclusion

Summary of Key Themes

As noted in the introduction, traditional pre-2000 scholarship on leadership *conceptualized* the important role of emotions in leadership processes and performance. However, cognition often was emphasized over emotion as well as task performance over relational processes, and empirical studies too infrequently attended to leadership and emotion. Perhaps for that reason, Humphrey (2002) claimed that "research into the relationship between leadership and emotions is just beginning" (p. 502). It certainly has burgeoned as is evident in the dozens of post-2000 studies reviewed here.

In 2020, Humphrey identified four key themes in seven articles published in a special issue of *The Leadership Quarterly* devoted to leadership and emotion. The first theme related to qualities necessary for leadership: empathy is linked to leadership emergence. The second involved the relationship of emotions to the leadership process: a key leadership function is to manage the emotions of group members, particularly feelings related to frustration and optimism. The third theme implicated perceptions: leaders' emotional displays have a larger impact on perceptions of leaders than the content of the leaders' messages, at least in some circumstances. The fourth theme linked leadership and performance: leaders' influences upon emotional process variables affect performance.

We concur, and believe those trends were more widespread than in the several studies Humphrey reviewed. This review also found other trends noted next – and opportunities for further research. Finally, a cursory review of the references in this chapter suggests that the relationships among leadership, emotion/humor, and even communication are more studied in disciplines such as management and psychology than in communication. Organizational communication scholars have studied leadership communication, as well as emotion in workplace communication, but their work has not

been conjoined to study emotion and leadership communication. Hence, many of the conclusions below also offer opportunities for more nuanced work by organizational communication researchers.

Directions for Future Research

Leadership Communication and Emotion in Diverse Contexts (e.g., Gender, Age, Race, etc.).

As discussed, scholarship on leadership reveals challenges for female leaders who can be perceived negatively when they necessarily communicate in authoritative ways. However, research has identified ways in which women can use effectively emotion-based communication to create a positive identity, improve relationships and enhance organizational performance. In addition to gender, age may also play a role in the relationship between leadership communication and emotion. For example, Walter and Scheibe's (2013) review drew attention to a gap in research on leadership and emotion. They identified studies in which leaders' age was related to outcomes such as task accomplishment and relationships with subordinates, but these studies essentially ignore the role of emotions and the communication associated with these differences. While a few studies on age–leadership linkages have drawn insights from life-span psychology research, none of the studies have utilized *emotional aging* theories such as socioemotional selective theory and affect valuation theory, to explicate the role of leaders' age and emotion. These theories would spark studies focused on age-related resilience gained over time, differences in desired social effects of interaction, and how differences in time horizons motivate older workers to prioritize current experiences such as deepening relationships rather than making more social connections (Jiang & Fung, 2019). Doing so might reveal insights about variation in emotion-laden communication strategies as related to age and effects on leadership.

Finally, there may be important benefits to *intersectional research* on leadership communication and emotion – especially the *intersection of gender, age, race, and social class*. While Rosette and colleagues (2016) found racial and gendered stereotypes of Black and Asian American women aligned with two dimensions of agency, competence and dominance, that may hinder women's progression to leadership positions, the role of emotion has not been thoroughly explored. Notably, Motro and colleagues (2022) found that a black woman's anger was attributed to internal factors due to stereotype activation, which then led to lower performance evaluations and

poorer assessments of leadership capabilities, but further intersectional research is needed to better understand the emotional dimensions of leadership experienced by diverse populations.

Methodological Diversity and Rigor

Research on leadership and emotions has been admirably noteworthy for its diverse methods of study. Beyond conventional survey, experimental, and observational field methods, studies of emotion and leadership reviewed here also have utilized textual analysis of message content (Banks et al., 2023), physiological measures (Shelia & Aycan, 2022), multisource data and comparison studies across nations (Walter et al., 2012), and evaluations of training interventions (Edelman & van Knippenberg, 2017).

Other Methodological Considerations

The leader-member relationship has often reflected a "dyadic rating effect," in which high ratings assigned to one member of the dyad are accompanied by lower ratings assigned to the other member (Glomb & Hulin, 1997). Particularly in studies in which participants are asked to observe a dyadic interaction, it is common for observers to take sides with one or the other member of the dyad, contributing to the dyadic rating effect. Additionally, it is important to note the powerful role of affective asymmetry, defined as the likelihood of subordinates to recall more negative affective events involving their leaders than positive ones (Dasborough, 2006). This may reflect the power of leaders' negative emotions and behaviors on members' emotions and behaviors.

This review of the literature echoes Jian's (2022) call for a social constructionist approach to empathy, moving away from entitative leadership studies that has predominantly raised the question about whether empathy as an emotional trait or display of such trait makes a difference in leadership outcomes. Communication scholarship should consider moving toward Jian's conceptualization of empathic leadership practice, acknowledging both leaders and members as potential agents of empathy and co-producers of meaning in empathic processes.

Furthermore, and as shown, humor often has been ignored in leadership communication research. Humor is difficult to measure and assess (Rosenberg et al., 2021), and what is and is not humorous is context dependent (Lam et al., 2012). Humor is related to one's knowledge of the situation, the people involved or cultural context. How humor interacts with context, personality, and leaders' general and social skills, and in particular environments are opportunities for continued exploration.

Implications for Practice

Edelman and van Knappenberg (2017) concluded that *emotion regulation* is not only an understudied aspect of leadership effectiveness but also an underused aspect in leadership training and development. Their investigation offers management development practitioners and higher education leadership educators evidence that leader emotion regulation can be trained and provides guidelines for delivering that training to make organizational leaders more effective – especially those who have difficulty dealing with emotions (e.g., Adame et al., 2021).

Finally, recent research highlights how the expression of emotions can affect coworkers, teams, and overall organizations (Bradley et al., 2023). Mayer and associates' (2016) offer a model to guide individuals on the use of emotional intelligence including perceiving emotions, facilitating thought using emotion, understanding emotions, and managing emotions. They point out that emotional intelligence is a problem-solving skill that must be developed and used. Management also should be trained on how their strategic use of emotional intelligence can positively affect workplace culture, potentially making it more inviting for job candidates and improving relationships and retention.

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Jian, G. (2022). From empathic leader to empathic leadership practice: An extension to relational leadership theory. *Human Relations*, *75*(5), 931–955. https://doi.org/10.1177/0018726721998450. (This article examines the relational elements of leadership by focusing on leader empathy and leader emergence.)

Waldron, V. R. (2012). *Communicating emotion at work.* Polity Press. (This book provides an extensive overview of emotions in the workplace.)

24

LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION AND DIVERSITY, EQUITY, AND INCLUSION

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-28

Introduction

Diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) is at a "critical juncture" in today's world because of tensions around its worth, and lack thereof, as well as changes in national and global contexts (Nkomo et al., 2019, p. 498). In taking a 50-year view of DEI work, Nkomo et al. contend that the trajectory has shifted

> from an initial anti-discrimination and US-centric perspective of the underrepresentation of racial minorities and women…to individualized experiences of belonging to multiplex, fluid categories, and from diversity management to global theorizing and practices with complex socio-political-cultural-legal forces supporting and hindering equality initiatives.
>
> (p. 500)

Management and communication scholars have analyzed several tensions in organizational diversity approaches. Their critiques center on valuing diversity, or representation, for competitive advantage implying that discrimination, if profitable, could be justified; positioning human bodies as commodified resources marked as different or as subjects of diversity; reifying binary and stable notions of identity; acting in ways that need not link with social justice; and attempting closure whereas DEI is an

evolving, contradictory sociomaterial construction for inclusion or belongingness and valuing different worldviews and identities (Parker & McDonald, 2019). Nkomo et al. assert that by "'appearing to recognize difference, yet failing to appreciate white normativity and systemic inequality,' the current diversity discourse impedes meaningful progress, masking persistent discrimination and inequality while doing little to alleviate them" (p. 506). In this critical juncture, organizations and society are inseparable. The resurgence of negative behaviors – hate crimes, regressive policies (against LBGTQAI+, women, migrants, religious groups, and others, Nkomo et al., 2019), white supremacy (elevating the ideological and material privileges and normativity of whiteness, Nkomo & Al Ariss, 2014) – affects and may be affected by leaders' and leadership DEI communication and ideal imagery.

Leadership is particularly important for DEI not only because of the effects of top-down initiatives and strategies on organizational functioning but also because different leadership discourses relate to organizational members' mental health in positive (well-being and psychological functioning) and negative (affective symptoms, stress, and health complaints) ways (Montano et al., 2023). These negative effects often are exacerbated by membership in non-dominant groups. In addition to mental health, Uhl-Bien (2021) contends that "for all those who argue that leadership doesn't matter, 2020 proves them wrong: leadership can be, literally, the difference between life and death" (p. 1400). Drawing from complexity theory that attends to pressures demanding adaptive challenges, Uhl-Bien condemns bureaucracies mired in "outdated governance and political systems" (p. 1400). She also condemns failed co-created leadership-followership that abdicated responsibilities by advancing lies, engaging in misdirection, and advocating actions that led to others' deaths during the COVID-19 pandemic. Today's challenges demand leadership that can handle current complexities including the sociopolitical context that contests and sparks DEI and innovative worldmaking (Van Gilder et al., 2024) through paradoxical organizing, particularly leadership's role (Sharma et al., 2021), and leadership rhetoric (Leslie et al., 2024).

Leadership is, by its nature, contradictory, exclusionary, and focused on effectiveness in much of Western literature. Leadership's paradoxical nature is explored by Fairhurst and Collinson (2023) who overview dialectical leadership-followership empirical research to expose, in part, leadership's multiple competing interests and need to be both adaptive to changing circumstances and cognizant of not overreaching in singular directions. They note how solutions devoid of socio-historical and cultural forces and contestations of diverse stakeholders' agency have hampered leadership-followership understandings.

Leadership's exclusionary practices typically celebrate those who ascend organizational hierarchies and/or assert influence. For most people, leadership and leaders are inseparable (Uhl-Bien, 2023). Leaders often are male, heterosexual, able-bodied top officers, and white or members of majority social identity groups in race/ethnicity. Whereas numbers do not make up the full leadership story (see glass and class ceilings, Ashley et al., 2022; Buzzanell, 1995), "being numerically dominant is only one among many sources of status and control within the organization" (Fairhurst & Snavely, 1983a, pp. 359–360). Indeed, the picture is much more complex in explaining tensions among social inclusion-assimilation, power-control, integration-exclusion, and belongingness-isolation. The lack of representation is ironic given that increased diversification and inclusionary practices of multinational corporate C-Suites and their boards tend to exhibit financial gains (see Kossek & Buzzanell, 2018). Yet these results occur only when DEI is authentic and infused throughout organizational systems.

Third, leadership is focused on effectiveness, not only as an outcome but also in how leadership constitutes effectiveness and for whom. As an outcome, leadership scholarship has numerous theories that promote advantageous organizational functioning. These theories range from charismatic and transformational leadership to less glamorous renditions in level 5 and path-goal leadership with the outcomes being bottom-line results and positive branding and imagery, including consistent internal and external organizational ethical stances.

Whereas the preceding discussion about the paradoxical, exclusionary, and effectiveness-oriented nature of leadership is aligned with formal organizational leadership, leadership also is embodied in grassroots and collective visionary movements, like Black Lives Matter (BLM), and in more localized settings such as sharing and informal economies (Cruz, 2015; Jackson, 2021; Parker, 2020). Here leadership engages in making sense of and having influence over unfolding events and thinking about the future. Sometimes these occasions are momentary as in the case where rhetorical exigencies call forth those who can frame situations advantageously for various stakeholders (Fairhurst & Sarr, 1996). Examining organizing and, by extension, leadership as fluid, inclusive, shape-shifting, adaptive, and paradoxical can help to decolonize Western holds on processes and practices (Cruz & Sodeke, 2021).

To discuss and challenge leadership communication and DEI, the rest of this chapter is divided into three parts: (1) demanding leadership for DEI (i.e., how and why DEI is critical for leadership in today's world); (2) leading for DEI (i.e., how leadership can advocate for and embody DEI); and (3) embracing DEI to transform leadership (i.e., how leadership can be changed through genuine commitments to DEI and praxis). This

last section encourages transformation from what might be surface-level to deep-level DEI, such that the very nature of and inherent qualities of leadership are challenged.

Demanding Leadership for DEI

In this section, we delve into some critical exigencies of DEI in leadership communication, highlighting how and why it is not only positioned as imperative for success in today's world but also how it incurs backlashes against DEI and Corporate Social Advocacy (CSA) communication. These exigencies concern the need for leadership to direct and guide for beneficial internal and external consequences; more competent and global leadership; safeguards against unintended negative outcomes; and publicizing DEI's tangible impact on team dynamics, innovation, and organizational success.

First, DEI has emerged as a vital component of organizational discourse. DEI "happy talk" positions DEI as an essential driver of success, innovation, and organizational resilience even as it is juxtaposed against expressions of hatred and differential treatment subsumed within white normativity and systemic inequalities (Nkomo et al., 2019, p. 506). On one hand, leadership's role, in concert with HR and other functions, is to identify talent and maximize membership potential through coursework, trainings, mentoring, and DEI offerings. Leadership's role also is to cultivate cultures that are inclusionary and foster senses of belonging. Ideally, leadership would challenge for whom actions are effective, whose voices are missing in (re)conceptualizing leadership, and where and/or how positive or value-in-diversity narratives (Leslie, 2024) have gone awry and with harmful results. Intense scrutiny and partisan factions locally and globally challenge organizational commitments to CSA and leadership in human rights. For instance, Ben and Jerry's is known for its DEI and social justice stances, yet Ben and Jerry's was also accused of child labor violations and of engaging in political conflicts (Milczarek-Desai, 2024).

Second, leadership that promotes DEI can have beneficial internal and external consequences on micro through macro levels even as backlashes can diminish DEI initiatives' effectiveness if not handled with complexity and honesty. According to Lee et al. (2021a), a diversity-oriented leadership approach examines behaviors that welcome, invite, and recognize contributions from and participation in decision-making by employees of diverse backgrounds. This approach can foster ethical, healthy, dialogic cultures that contribute to excellent public relations and organizational membership. Such leadership is especially important during crises where DEI-oriented

leadership can promote employee engagement and knowledge sharing (Lee et al., 2021b; see also Men et al., 2023). For example, when those who do not self-identify as queer perform leadership that values queering and queer members, their actions show commitments to and responsibility for the organizational community thus generating new possibilities for leadership, allyship, and workplace relations (Pryor, 2020). DEI efforts also include Microsoft's Autism Hiring Program in which individuals on the autism spectrum contribute their unique skills in software testing (Krzeminska & Hawse, 2020). Furthermore, prospective and current employees who evaluated organizations in terms of public support for Black communities – especially after race-related events and protests and including BLM movements – perceived higher organizational support for DEI and higher organizational attraction while also increasing revenues (Corrington et al., 2022).

The flip side is complicated. Following a series of high-profile racial justice events and the BLM protests, Nike launched a campaign that featured a powerful message supporting racial equality and social justice. The company's public alignment with the movement and its commitment to addressing systemic racism resonated with many consumers. This led to a surge in demand for Nike products among individuals who supported the cause, resulting in a substantial increase in sales and revenue for the company. Yet, Nike's CSA racial equality and other campaigns promoting gender justice and pro-hijab are complicated by past sweatshop use for production and past (and current) internal gender pay discrimination lawsuits (Waymer & Logan, 2021). Indeed, conservative groups have launched campaigns against Nike and other CEOs for "woke capitalism" (corporate actions such as advertising that pertain to social justice) and engagement in discriminatory actions and labor violations (Javers, 2021).

In exploring how and why DEI approaches incur negative responses, Eagly and Chin (2010) explore the ways in which organizational and societal members' subscription to the enduring white male leader prototype tends to override perceptions of competence and access to leadership roles. Inquiries into the performance of leadership and the political effectiveness of leaders from diverse identity groups in situations marked by explicit differences such as race, ethnicity, gender, sexuality, ability, and other aspects of outgroup status necessitate commitments to leadership and accountability. Eagly and Chin advocated that better integrating DEI and leadership literatures would advance theoretical contributions to make leadership more inclusive in general and more appropriate to different world regions. As an illustration, in a study conducted by Erskine et al. (2023) within the scope of Catalyst's research on workplace encounters involving women who self-identified as BIPOC (Black, Indigenous, and People of

Color) and/or LBGTQAI+ across Australia, the U.K., Canada, South Africa, and the U.S. (n = 2734), researchers found that half of the participants encountered workplace racism. Additionally, LGBTQAI+ women and those from marginalized racial/ethnic groups had a higher likelihood of experiencing racism. Accordingly, they also found that antiracist leaders must address racism and discrimination from an intersectional lens, or such efforts would not be as effective as desired, and would even lead to increased turnover and decreased job satisfaction and well-being for employees.

DEI communication can assist formal leadership in safeguarding against unintended negative outcomes (Javers, 2021). When leadership lacks a comprehensive grasp of DEI complexities, their decisions might inadvertently undermine intended outcomes and DEI's transformative potential, thus hindering organizational capacities to reshape organizational and societal cultures and innovation. As a case in point, Anheuser-Busch supported LBGTQAI+ issues for over a decade while having the top-selling beer consumed by and marketed to sports-minded younger men. In efforts to expand the consumer base, Anheuser-Busch shipped a customized can with the image of Dylan Mulvaney to this self-identified trans TikTok influencer who then posted her delight in this gift on Instagram. Core constituencies and conservative factions responded through boycotts and ultimate dethroning of Bud Light as the number one beer consumed in the U.S. (CBS News, 2023). Similarly, Target donated funds to and provided merchandise supporting LBGTQAI+ communities for over a decade. However, Target's sales dropped and employees received threats in 2023 over protests about its Pride merchandise, particularly its branding of children's gear with Pride emblems and its inclusion of "tuck friendly" bathing suits designed to conceal male genitalia (Holman, 2023). Thus, value-in-diversity practices and rhetoric are common but also need to be tempered with DEI contingent-rhetoric that admits to paradoxical DEI process and outcome results and to the caveat that "benefitting from diversity requires creating the conditions needed to overcome its challenges" (Leslie et al., 2024, p. 598). In sum, DEI and leadership are crucial and inextricably bound in today's world yet need nuanced and consistent attention to leaders' communication about the challenges of advocating for DEI, as is discussed in the next section.

Leading for DEI

In the recent years, social movements like #NoBanNoWall, Black Lives Matter, Stop Asian Hate, #MeToo, and #TimesUp have brought the most hideous injustices to the surface of the public mind and have acted as catalysts of societal and organizational

changes. As a result, people across the U.S. report that they are more likely to speak up against injustices, with the sentiment of increased responsibility to create more respectful and inclusive work environments shared by employees and those in formal leadership roles (Tilo, 2022). However, against the backdrop of recent events, conflicting leadership issues persist. Organizational leadership remains widely homogenous, and DEI still is viewed as contributing to bottom-lines through utilizing resources like diverse viewpoints and skillsets, rather than discourses aimed at systemic change (Douglas, 2021; Janssens & Zanoni, 2021). Additionally, specific cases, like ESPN's 2021 controversy, where a telephone conversation was leaked in which Rachel Nichols (a white reporter), said that Maria Taylor (a Black reporter) was chosen to host the 2020 N.B.A. finals coverage only because ESPN was "feeling pressure on...diversity" (Blanchet, 2023), illustrate how DEI efforts that are successful "on paper" fail to translate to actual equity and inclusion.

A sizeable portion of success and failure of DEI efforts depends on how people in formal leadership positions actually lead and advocate for DEI in practice. Despite abundant research, there is little agreement on what specific leadership and management practices are most effective, partially because what successful DEI initiatives look like is highly contextual given that organizations are unique assemblages of difference (Shore et al., 2018). Other reasons are traditional views of organizations as neutral backgrounds for DEI initiatives, instead of starting with the maxim that organizations play an important role in "(re)producing inequality" (Janssens & Zanoni, 2021, p. 2), and of discriminatory and exclusionary environments and policies as located within individuals' "biased cognitive processes" (Janssens & Zanoni, 2014, p. 317). These assumptions place the blame and responsibility on individuals – leaders and employees.

There is merit in individual-oriented solutions like engaging in trainings, mentoring, and networking as ways to promote more inclusive and equitable workspaces. But without addressing the oppressive nature of capitalistic organizations, "reflecting and reproducing societal power and privilege relations both in terms of relations between groups of employees and between the employer and its employees" (Janssens & Zanoni, 2021, p. 5), such individually-oriented solutions fall short of their goals. Thus, leader and leadership development must be intertwined since leadership-followership dynamics are co-created, negotiated, and interdependent in work for systemic change (Uhl-Bien, 2023). Admittedly, much leadership-followership development appears idealistic. Yet, it offers empirically-based practices that can and must be complicated and contextualized in pursuit of effective DEI. These research-to-practice recommendations include: (1) leading with allyship and curiosity; (2) leading with

emotional and cultural intelligence; (3) leading for change and/with others; (4) expanding the idea of leader(ship) and DEI; and (5) leading with contingent rhetoric (Leslie, 2024).

In leading with allyship and curiosity, formal leaders play a significant role in cultural changes in organizations and are co-creators of employees' felt inclusion (Allen, 2018; Brimhall et al., 2017; Gotsis & Grimani, 2016). They translate abstract organizational DEI-related policies for employees through such mundane activities as task assignments, modeling behaviors, and informal communication (Buengeler et al., 2018). They become symbolic bridges between an organization's DEI policy and outlook, and employees' experiences of/with it (Gündemir & Kirby, 2022). They redefine communication norms within their teams to promote equity and inclusion and decenter the individual as solely responsible for (re)producing inequity and exclusion. They broaden norms of what constitutes a "good job" and "good employee," creating spaces where employees can express their identities freely (Janssens & Zanoni, 2014), and uphold fair and respectful interactions (Erskine, 2023; Erskine et al., 2023; Kossek et al., 2024). These behaviors depend on curiosity and vulnerability that deny immovability of the status-quo, welcome and initiate change, and do not resist or avoid chaos and conflict. Instead, leading for DEI should be a prefigurative activity, that is, leaders envision the "future beyond the present" (Janssens & Zanoni, 2021, p. 16) that incorporates members' co-creation of these visions and decision-making (Roberson & Perry, 2022; Smrokowska-Reichmann & Janus, 2022).

Second, in leading with emotional and cultural intelligence (EI & CQ, Fujimoto & Presbitero, 2021), high EI is positively correlated with orientation to implement DEI initiatives (Roe & Anderson, 2023). Leaders who are empathetic, self-aware, and have strong command of such social skills as listening, commitment to growth of other people, stewardship, and aspiration to build community with others – all essential to high EI (Jiménez & Moore, 2023; Roe & Anderson, 2023) – epitomize social justice-focused organizational leadership. For example, leadership for social justice develops and constantly reflects upon commitments, works collaboratively, and utilizes "communication skills, emotional awareness, and the ability to build meaningful and long-lasting relationships" to make their "engagement work meaningful, self-sustaining, and proactive" (DeMatthews & Mawhinne, 2014, p. 848). However, such leadership faces dilemmas in terms of the demands on their own personal and organizational resources as well as their feelings of discouragement, especially when faced with resistance and when trying to figure out how to "choose among varying degrees of right

versus right options" (p. 850) and where to focus efforts and resources in multiphase social justice actions.

In addition to EI, leaders' CQ and its perception by organizational members impacts DEI efforts (Fujimoto & Presbitero, 2021). While minority staff recognized the acts of racial microaggressions directed at them, their non-minority colleagues did not (Alabi, 2015). Alabi (2015) explained that this difference in perception reveals the need to raise non-minority staff's awareness on issues of diversity and develop commitment to cultural reflection and cultural humility. Cultural humility entails a lasting commitment to "recognizing and minimizing power differences, promoting respect, individual focus of not only the other but of the self, flexibility, making bias explicit" (Foronda, 2020, p. 8) and is inextricable from attempts to address unjust power structures, inequities, and marginalization in organizations. In their research of inclusive leadership, Roberson and Perry (2022) found that culturally and emotionally aware leaders tend to act as role models of both EI and CQ. Yet, awareness raising should not be the end goal of leading for DEI, as acquired knowledge must result in changed attitude and behavior.

Specifically, Janssens and Zanoni (2014) offer strategies that utilize and demonstrate EI and CQ of leaders. These include redefining indicators used in hiring processes to value competencies of minorities, and not just of white majority (e.g., formal education and years of work experience); promoting collaborative work where everyone has a chance to contribute to minimize the typical singling out of marginalized employees as less competent; encouraging an emphasis on personal growth to instill a sense of worth in employees and emphasize the diverse range of skills that can be cultivated and appreciated within a company; supporting manifestations of diverse identities through allowing demonstration/wearing of religious symbols and following religious practices, as well as formally announcing them, so that other employees are aware of such events; and creating and enforcing strict anti-discrimination policies. Finally, implementing a policy of individual-centered flexibility, which recognizes and respects a wide range of requests from employees would allow all employees, regardless of their other social roles, to arrange their working hours in ways that were compatible with their personal needs and obligations outside of work. By treating all requests as equally legitimate, leadership can foster an inclusive environment that values the diverse identities and responsibilities of the employee, and communicates not only CQ and EI, but commitment to DEI.

Third, leading for change and with others coincides with Worley's (2022) directive that "if the goal is to make equity and inclusion possible, we need to better understand what works, for whom, in what context, and for what duration" (p. 234). Since the

impact of leadership behaviors varies across different individuals and workgroups, leadership communication would ideally be adjusted to accommodate the diverse needs and dynamics of an organization's workforce (Ghosh et al., 2023). Such leadership is collaborative. Creating a pool of change agents that act alongside formal leaders but, unlike formal leaders, aim to engage with other employees in simple conversations about DEI ensures that trainings are not one-off events, but are embedded into daily routines through employee-to-employee communication (Worley, 2022).

Fourth, expanding the idea of leader(ship) and DEI means that organizations and leaders should consider how to move past leader and follower binary categories marked by hierarchy and difference (Collinson, 2005, 2011). Leaders are revered or vilified for their actions that influence employees' motivation, resilience, and overall workplace experience. Although inclusive leadership (Chen et al., 2020), empowering leadership (Amundsen & Martinsen, 2014), participative leadership (Lumby, 2013), and collective leadership (Fairhurst et al., 2020; Ospina et al., 2020) evidence a shift, leader-centric models are still prevalent. While leaders have an important role to play in DEI (Korkmaz et al., 2022), moving towards acknowledging that a leader is anyone who finds and develops potential in the self, others, and in circumstances is key if DEI efforts are to become successful. Additionally, viewing DEI as something that "evolves between people rather than something that is possessed" (Holling & Rodriguez, 2006, p. 49) emphasizes the importance of employees' contributions to human diversity efforts. It is employees' commitment to DEI rather than simple compliance with its practices that should be the goal. This commitment would displace the burden of DEI work from non-dominant group employees' unpaid and often (un)recognized labor (Kane, 2023) to DEI as dispersed effort.

Along these lines, Lopez and Jean-Marie (2021) use the example of challenging anti-Black racism in schools, to showcase that DEI efforts cannot be simple prescriptions or appendages to the usual ways of doing things in organizations. Rather, they must be ongoing and collective if a system change is the aim. Additionally, official leaders can encourage self-leadership in DEI practices by their own example, including inviting others to have open courageous conversations about the successes, failures, and ways of improvement; demonstrating openness to new ideas; and modeling behavior where the leader constantly turns to employees for their expertise (Pearce & Manz, 2005). In this way DEI practices can vary iteratively and contextually depending on different levels of knowledge and understanding, enhancing an organization's overall success on the way to social justice.

Fifth, to address the challenges in today's socially and politically fraught environments, leading with contingent rhetoric offers opportunities for formal leaders' communicative effectiveness. Leslie et al. (2024) argue that "benefitting from diversity requires creating the conditions needed to overcome its challenges" (p. 3). These conditions advance value-in-diversity rhetoric that is aligned with fairness for minority groups and women and extols DEI's desirability, along with contingent rhetoric that acknowledges and presents negative information or challenges subtly and in ways that increase employee's diversity efforts "with intensity and persistence" (p. 8). These efforts incorporate "a range of specific behaviors, such as avoiding discrimination, supporting minority groups, or helping to develop diversity initiatives…instead of focusing on one specific behavior" (p. 9). Since leaders fear appearances of being prejudiced such that their actions can prompt scrutiny and backlashes, contingent rhetoric admits that diversity efforts might feel uncomfortable and that the goals are difficult. Contingent rhetoric affirms that everyone is responsible (collective efforts), requiring personal efforts.

Embracing DEI to Transform Leadership

Although many people subscribe to the business case for diversity (demanding leadership for DEI) with additional motivations of social justice, ethical responsibilities, and demographic reasons, Perriton (2009) notes that contemporary depoliticized DEI efforts fail to truly challenge discriminatory treatment and outcomes. As Perriton puts it, "the irony is that the business case discourse has proved just as ineffectual in bringing about change as the equality discourse" (p. 224). Likewise, efforts to engage in leading for DEI by organizational leadership and membership often operate in and reinforce the status quo by adding trainings and procedures to recruit and retain women and underrepresented group members without becoming inclusionary in ways that could fundamentally alter organizing and create cultures of belongingness (for the need for designing fundamental change rather than adding on DEI, see Eddington et al., 2020). They often are based on what dominant groups need to know to interact with others rather than delving into how leadership per se is socially and materially constructed to retain power inequities (Buzzanell, 1995). Moreover, there are very few organizations and leaders that have developed contingent rhetoric communication strategies (i.e., those that advance DEI's benefits while admitting to the difficulties, challenges, and personal responsibilities of embodying DEI best processes, Leslie, 2024). In short, DEI issues are much more complex than numerical imbalances or

representation and deployment of generic "special programs" (e.g., trainings, networking events); within particular contexts, considerations must be given to membership status and power bases and abilities to influence (see Fairhurst & Snavely, 1983a, 1983b). Fairhurst and Snavely (1983b) point out the contradictions in DEI efforts that advance interests and careers of minoritized members, or tokens. They warn that these efforts might lead to greater token-majority relational conflict but also to greater understanding and "a more equitable distribution of the power and control within the work environment" (p. 299). Forty years later, the tensions, particularly about token with "triple and double deviancy," now discussed as intersectionalities, are still relevant and the answers are still not fully known.

Thus, rather than demanding leadership for DEI or leading for DEI within current organizational and leadership systems, this final section challenges leadership itself by embracing DEI to transform leadership. It is based on paradox, meaning that the only way to embrace DEI is to dismantle and transform contemporary leadership. The reason is that "leadership itself is not a value-free concept. It is inextricably bound up with the dominant social and cultural norms of society" (Logan, 2011, p. 451) and bound up with the white leader prototypes despite the changing global labor force (Eagly & Chin, 2010). This section embraces DEI to transform leadership by discussing: discourses of contemporary leadership in neoliberal organizing; dissolution of the conflation of leader and leadership; DEI that faces uncomfortable truths; and communication to transform leadership through DEI.

First, contemporary leadership theory and practice can be seen as the fulfillment of neoliberalism thus making DEI a contested space in which traditional Western leadership and DEI are fundamentally incompatible. Brown (2009) states that neoliberalism "reduces political citizenship to an unprecedented degree of passivity and political complacency" (p. 43). This neoliberal critique contends that mainstream leadership conceptualizations are not publicly oriented but are individualistic, competitive, and linearly minded meaning that leadership is founded on inequality for all. These points directly contrast with and are paradoxical when coupled with programs and sensibilities that promote equality, inclusivity, accountability, different ways of doing things, and belongingness. At the most extreme, discourses of contemporary leadership deepen control and exclusion with neoliberal organizing expecting followers to labor beyond work hours to engage in unpaid labor of branding themselves as productive organizational citizens, promoters of business services and products, and orient toward engagement with organizational missions without regard to personal precarities. Although there is push-back in anti-work, quiet quitting,

disengagement/disidentification, and compassion scholarship and popular media, many workers willingly accept their organizational and societal precarities as their lot in life (e.g., Neff, 2012). Except for a select few who rise to and maintain leadership positions, their expertise in life and paid labor is not sought unless desired by and beneficial for the organization – meaning that diversity is not inclusive, and power is not redistributed. The divisiveness in traditional leadership (un)intentionally supports follower passivity such that followership consumes rather than produces leadership.

If leader-follower behaviors remain hierarchically ordered so that roles inhibit agency and prompt individuals to always feel left out or marginalized because they are not in power, then DEI efforts falter. Ladkin (2022) asserts that Western notions of leadership and DEI cannot move past binaries. However, collective grassroots leadership advocates for proactive and transformative moments that can make deep change by innovating structurally to challenge existing power systems with hospitable spaces and co-production of knowledge (Parker, 2020). Besides grassroots leadership, collective leadership in other organizational settings can destabilize traditional hierarchical leadership. To do so, collective leadership struggles with three challenges (Fairhurst et al., 2020). First, leadership must be recognized as ambiguous in conceptualizations, distinctive in collective and hierarchical leadership forms, and inherently constituted by disorder, competition, and power. Second, differences in leadership would prompt researchers to examine leadership by failure, alternative definitions, key moments, and/or relationships to similar processes as relevant in collective settings. Third, collective leadership is processual, such that "the *experience* of action and its consequences affects actors, 'changing qualitatively the phenomena they help co-create'" (p. 608). Fairhurst et al. advocate consideration of leadership as constituted paradoxically in many forms/collectivities and always in a fluid process of becoming (see also Ospina et al., 2020).

Second, if DEI is taken seriously, then different ideas and inclusionary logics would dissolve the conflation of follower-leader/followership-leadership, framing the use of hierarchical terms such as leader(ship) and follower(ship) as divisive, and reconsidering organizations as communities that have the capacities to promote multiple goals including wellbeing. In this sense, leadership can be reimagined as an imperfect learning opportunity and followership – not as passive receivers – but as those who are supposed to critically engage with all that happens organizationally as co-owners governing control. This idealized version of leadership-followership neglects the ways in which people interact in ironic, complicit-and-resistant, and unexpected ways. For instance, during a company founder's pregnancy, the founder and organizational

members engaged in shifting roles, cycles of attachment-detachment, (un)constructed policy changes, communication style adjustments, and other processes that made visible the double standards and special privileges of some while the founder and organization per se continued to espouse relational and feminist orientations (Ashcraft, 1999). Likewise, D'Enbeau and Buzzanell (2011) also challenged idealized portrayals of feminine leadership when feminist ideologies and market sustainability collided and required sophisticated discursive and material maneuvers to maintain commitments to social change.

Additionally, Nkomo et al. (2019) point out that social class is not often investigated in organizational and management studies, nor are multi-category intersections, transnational and postcolonial identities, or categories as self-identified and other-identified. Ladkin and Patrick (2022) theorize that leadership has been e-raced by examining transformational leadership from the lens of critical race theory (CRT) arguing that not only BIPOC members, as well as those who are white, are harmed. Ladkin and Patrick (2022) delve into systemic racism to assert that "leadership as a phenomenon is grounded in assumptions based on White privilege as well as a White perspective on the world" (p. 207). In describing leadership, they identify three habits of Whiteness: normalization (Whiteness as the standard against which all other perspectives are considered), solipsism (Whites acting in ways that benefit themselves such as COVID-19 vaccines being appropriated by majority White and wealthy nations), and ontological expansionism ("White people have the right to extend themselves into every geography or psychic landscape," p. 212). They describe published critiques about how transformational leadership is inherently biased, atheoretical, based on charismatic or heroic notions, and lionized habits of Whiteness. Fundamentally, transformational leadership creates two classes of people – the privileged and all-knowing leaders and the passive, powerless followers – or the "abject other" predicated on hierarchy, social distance, and (lack of) personhood or humanity. Such divisiveness, casting all into hierarchical relations, and unrealistic expectations of omniscient leaders not only harm followers but also leaders themselves.

Third, embracing DEI to transform leadership means that, paradoxically, DEI forces organizational members to face uncomfortable truths. In terms of gender equality, Conzon (2023) captured the paradox between managers' espoused commitments to gender equality and the different ways they undermined policies in large part because such initiatives could disrupt how managers, especially women managers, interacted with others, particularly direct reports, in conducting their roles. Additionally, Jackson (2023) found that highly committed DEI leadership and membership can ironically

reject measures used for white recruitment (i.e., transactional recruitment favoring efficiency, opportunity, pay, and quantity) in favor of developmental recruitment (favoring ethics, equity, community, and commitment) that inevitably undermines DEI efforts. Such differential approaches were based on members' reactions to transactional market concerns as "repugnant," yet their developmental approach failed to achieve aims, especially in recruiting and retaining diverse members at all organizational levels.

Fourth, communication in transforming leadership through DEI must make paradoxes evident so that there are openings for change. According to Ladkin (2022), leadership is embedded within, framed by, and actualized through whiteness as the way things are. Because discrimination is structurally embedded, Ladkin's perspective shifts the conversation about racism away from individual to structural ways in which racism privileges white structures. Whiteness in leadership can be dissolved through exerting agency to de-hierarchialize thus dissolving fixed leader-follower binaries and conceptualizing the self as relational, pluralistic, fluid, and expected to speak. Ladkin also advocates that people listen to others in different spaces and as community members. She maintains that even when listening to stories of individuals, people are listening to communities, such that people's talk is informed by the community. She takes the stance that dissolving binaries is built upon understandings that everyone is always leading and following simultaneously. These same strategies are applicable to others who would benefit from DEI leadership, namely those who have disabilities, are LBGTQAI+, are members of lower status classes and castes, and so on, as well as white men.

Using Black women professionals as an example, Smith et al. (2019) demonstrate how even when DEI is implemented to radically change organizing and organizational cultures, intersectional invisibilities and visibilities can have paradoxical effects based on intersectional (dual stigma), professional (professional investment and support), and personal (family support, self-assurance) contexts. Smith et al. attribute their complex findings to benign and hostile intersectional invisibility with agentic tactics to create credible visibility, lean into risk, use bold autonomy, strategically deploy invisibility, and craft relationships intentionally. These strategies are similar to those found by Tian and Bush (2020) in their study of Chinese women political leaders who work not only to adapt to their traditional male professional and societal cultures but also to transform their own and others' circumstances.

The issue for leadership is whether members want to truly espouse DEI, since it cannot be an add-on like an extra function, nor can it be the province of particular

people such as the chief diversity officer (CDO) or HR unit, but must be integrated throughout. This means that prioritizing DEI must be integrated in every action, statement, object, and so on to reflect commitment throughout the culture. The entire organization exerts leadership internally, with all relevant stakeholders, and in society. This is a tall order – one that is idealistic and perhaps, some would say, detracting from main organizational purposes like business or not-for-profit missions. It takes continual effort to fulfill the promises of equity, belongingness, and inclusion that are at the heart of DEI. In short, work on, for, and about DEI has not gone far enough. Contemporary DEI work is still about advancing women and minoritized group members rather than challenging leadership as a whole. Thus, the agenda must be dual in nature – affording ways to better promote DEI within current systems and dismantling leadership literature and organizational systems simultaneously. Future research should attend to the paradoxical nature of leadership, especially with regard to leadership communication and DEI.

Conclusion

We discuss DEI and leadership by reviewing research and strategies for: (1) demanding leadership for DEI; (2) leading for DEI; and (3) embracing DEI to transform leadership. In each section, we relate the challenges and opportunities of organizing with DEI in socio-politically, culturally, and globally contentious times. We provide value rhetoric arguments, advocate for contingency rhetoric that recognizes the difficulties of and struggles surrounding DEI work and leadership, and encourage radical constitution of leadership as fluid, collective, shifting, contradictory, and inclusionary communication. We encourage transformation from surface-level to deep-level DEI such that the very nature of, paradoxes in, and inherent qualities of leadership are challenged for inclusive worldmaking.

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25

LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION AND ORGANIZATIONAL LEARNING AND DEVELOPMENT

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-29

Perhaps Harvard Business School professor, David Garvin, summed it up best by saying, "Before people and companies can improve, they first must learn" (Garvin, 1998, p. 47). Learning has been widely viewed as a necessity for an organization's growth and ability to adapt and to change within a growing and more complex global environment (Schein, 1993). Management scholar Peter Senge's seminal text *The Fifth Discipline* (2006) popularized the notion of a "learning organization" – "where people are continually learning how to learn together" (p. 1), echoing, again, the call for organizations to embrace learning as a means for remaining economically viable amid more competitive and diverse markets (e.g., Bass, 2000; Real et al., 2014). Some researchers define organizational learning as a process of improvement (Fiol & Lyles, 1985), while others assess learning based on evidence of behavioral change (Huber, 1991). No doubt this influenced scholars and practitioners alike to better identify what organizational learning is and determine whether it has occurred. Empirical research in this area has examined the impact of theories in practice on double loop learning (a more reflexive form of learning that explores root causes of structural issues and challenges) and the capacity for leaders to think more critically about one's own assumptions and beliefs (Houchens et al., 2012; Weiner & Lamb, 2020). Meanwhile, Basten and Haaman (2018) offer an extensive review of the more seminal and widely

cited theories and approaches regarding organizational learning, including single and double loop learning, which we address below, and organizational knowledge creation theory.

Although research lacks a consistent conceptualization of organizational learning, most experts concur that learning is key to the contemporary organization's survival. Learning in the 21st century is now, more than ever, an ongoing necessity considering the rapid change, competition, social/economic instability, and shifting work environments (i.e., hybrid/virtual) characterizing today's workplace. As such, leadership remains an important aspect in creating strong learning environments (e.g., Vera & Crossan, 2004). Our discussion is primarily centered around the influence of leader communication on learning and development processes.

To that end, this chapter provides a brief overview of leadership communication perspectives within the research, followed by a review of literature surrounding organizational learning and the various theoretical and empirical data illuminating its connection to leadership. Then we turn our attention to the leader-learning relationship within the context of organizational culture, expanding on the different contexts and processes for facilitating learning and development within organizations. We end with some considerations for researchers and practitioners underlying this body of work as well as offer future directions that can expand our understanding and practices of learning and effective leadership.

Leadership Communication

The voluminous amount of research on leadership established over the years has subsequently led to numerous definitions, theoretical perspectives, and paradigms within the field. The very idea of leadership crosses an array of disciplinary boundaries with some of its earliest conceptualizations being rooted in cognitive psychology (Bass, 1981) and emphasizing leadership in more hierarchical and masculine ways. As the impetus for this handbook would suggest, social scientific and communication-based approaches of leadership have taken hold in recent decades and given way to more meaning-centered and discursive forms of leadership (e.g., Barge, 2007; Barge & Fairhurst, 2008; Fairhurst, 2007; Jian, 2022) as well as critical (Collinson, 2020) and dialogical perspectives that emphasize the reflexive nature between leadership theory and practice (Barge, 2014).

Early research in leadership was predominantly focused on more normative, leader-centric views in which communication is characterized as peripheral to leadership and

thus, treated as a transmission or conduit rather than as central to leadership development (Putnam, 1983). Within such a framework, leadership communication is understood in terms of the various speech characteristics, skills, and behaviors of leaders that influence different organizational outcomes.

This has arguably been the most ubiquitous and impactful approach when it comes to influencing practitioners' views and understanding of leadership (Jian & Fairhurst, 2019). However, such frameworks naturally undermine the role of followers as co-creators of leadership (Uhl-Bien et al., 2014). Although a positional and hierarchical view of leadership is still privileged in much of the managerial literature today, a growing body of interpretive and critical research examines the socially constructed nature of leadership in which both leaders and followers act as symbolic managers of meaning (Fairhurst & Grant, 2010; Fairhurst, 2011). This lens views leadership as a shared versus positional phenomenon stemming from the relational dynamics (e.g., power) and processes (e.g., teams, decision making) within complex organizational systems. Communication is viewed as being central to leadership, and, thus, centered around the various discursive and non-discursive practices that are co-created among organizational actors through their ongoing sensegiving/sensemaking and framing efforts (Fairhurst, 1993).

While this is in no way a comprehensive review of where the leadership communication research stands (see Fairhurst et al., 2024), the burgeoning research in leadership communication calls for more theory-informed praxis (Cunliffe & Eriksen, 2011; Barge & Fairhurst, 2008) and more synergy among scholars and practitioners to understand the communicative processes of leadership, and contexts and environments in which these processes can be more readily understood and practiced. Jian and Fairhurst (2019) propose that as organizations increasingly experience unstable environments and accompanying speeds of change, there is a need for understanding the role that leaders play in educating employees to help them navigate the inevitable tensions that come with such complexities. Thus, understanding the influence of leadership communication on learning at both the organizational and individual level is warranted.

Organizational Learning

The social context of organizational learning, as March (1991) points out, consists of mutual learning processes in which organizations accumulate and diffuse knowledge through various norms, rules, and procedures while individuals are simultaneously

being socialized to these norms, which then requires further adaptation of that knowledge to individuals and their beliefs. Closely akin to these perspectives on organizational learning are systemic processes involving knowledge management, whereby members obtain, coordinate, and communicate knowledge, as well as knowledge creation in which organizational learning is developed around explicit (i.e., codified) and tacit (i.e., intangible) forms of knowledge (Basten & Haamann, 2018). Wu and Chen (2014), along with the other scholars in this area, note organizational learning is central to the creation and utilization of knowledge (e.g., Zhao et al., 2013). Further efforts have been made to distinguish between *knowledge* as an objectified or static resource versus *knowing* as an actionable, dynamic process (e.g., Barley et al., 2018; Kuhn & Jackson, 2008) – the latter being arguably more connected to the social constructionist views of leadership and learning given its focus on knowledge as something to be created and accomplished among actors rather than something that already exists for distribution.

That said, Atwood et al. (2010) assert that organizational learning is best achieved in settings characterized in part by a shared vision and team learning. Teams are considered an important context for organizational learning in that its members, when faced with new knowledge and insights, will adapt their attitudes and behaviors based on collective discussions and reflections (Hedlund & Österberg, 2013). Leaders are positioned to influence this type of learning by modeling behaviors that encourage feedback and, consequently, the psychological safety and trust needed for exploring new ideas among team members (Hedlund & Österberg, 2013; Vera & Crossan, 2004). In their five-point framework describing what leaders are doing when they lead, Kouzes and Posner (2006) emphasize the role of leaders as learners themselves when they view events as learning experiences. Given the influence that leaders have both within teams and the broader organizational structure (Popper & Lipshitz, 2000), leadership becomes a central, albeit complex, construct when determining what makes for an effective organizational learning environment.

Leadership Communication and Learning

The literature postulates various models to explain the interrelationships among the myriad constructs influencing organizational learning, namely leadership and specifically that of transformational and transactional leadership. Different factors that ultimately contribute to learning effectiveness within the organization have been traced back to several leadership behaviors and styles that further establish the role of leaders

as facilitators and "architects" of learning (Cooksey, 2003; Do & Mai, 2020). Leaders are poised to create an environment that inspires a shared vision and, consequently, a collective commitment to learning (Schein, 1993; Senge, 2006; Soomro et al., 2021). Research examining transformational leaders has been prolific in highlighting the communication and behaviors that motivate innovation and learning.

Transformational leaders demonstrate the ability to communicate a shared vision and encourage the communication of diverse viewpoints that ultimately leads others to learn and innovate (Garvin et al., 2008). Moreover, Choudhary et al. (2013) argue that change is at the core of the learning process and because transformational leaders, with their charisma and ability to catalyze others to action, are so integral to the change process, they are naturally an important contributor to organizational learning. Indeed, research examining the behavioral characteristics of transformational leaders, including that of communicating a shared vision, has been linked to organizational learning (Soomro et al., 2021; Vera & Crossan, 2004). Other linked factors include knowledge transfer (Do & Mai, 2020), innovation (Garcia-Morales et al., 2012), and overall performance (Arif & Akram, 2018). Garcia-Morales et al. (2012) found that transformational leadership was strongly correlated with organizational learning and influenced overall performance through organizational learning and innovation.

Despite ongoing efforts demonstrating the influence that transformational leaders have on learning, additional research has found evidence illuminating the ways in which transactional leaders can positively influence the learning process. Unlike transformational leaders, transactional leadership is based on the idea that leaders' relationship with followers is determined by a set of expectations and feedback given to members in exchange for their efforts in meeting those expectations (Bass & Avolio, 1993). Given the emphasis that transactional leaders place on the exchange of task and rewards, their efforts can be instrumental to the strategy and institutionalized learning (e.g., structures, procedures) of an organization (Vera & Crossan, 2004), as well as its development of existing knowledge (Jansen et al., 2009). Research suggests that contingency reward leadership, a major aspect of transactional leadership, has a strong impact on the learning construct of information acquisition and a more direct impact on the behavioral and cognitive changes associated with learning than transformational leadership (Zagoršek et al., 2009).

Leadership over the past few decades in various sectors (e.g., politics, religion, business) has also seen its share of questionable practices, which has further fueled efforts to promote ethical and authentic leadership styles. One style which has gained traction over the years in both the academic and popular press literature is servant

leadership. Although similar to transformational leadership in many ways, servant leadership differs in terms of the leader's orientation towards followers. While transformational leaders are attuned to engaging the skills and talents of followers in meeting their potential, servant leaders' priority is squarely on serving followers and providing for their welfare through a caring and supportive relationship (Greenleaf, 1977). Servant leaders forgo their own self-interests to focus on the growth and development of their followers. As such, servant leaders create an environment primed for individual learning, growth, and experimentation (Choudhary et al., 2013). Song et al. (2015) discovered that strong knowledge sharing environments (i.e., learning) mediated the relationship between servant leadership and team performance. Additional research suggests that servant leadership further promotes an organizational learning environment by strengthening the relationship between workplace engagement and innovation (Dalain, 2023).

In a similar vein, authentic leadership is claimed to promote an environment that allows for greater learning and innovation by fostering greater self-awareness and relational transparency with followers. It is this particular focus on ethics and transparency that allows for authentic leaders to promote an environment whereby the sharing and dissemination of information, as well as the trust created in that process, equips members to make the cognitive and behavioral adaptations needed for learning (Mousa et al., 2019). Some researchers (e.g., Alvesson & Einola, 2019) have more recently called into question the feasibility of these different outcomes, citing the lack of solid theory and evidence to be conceptually distinct from other positive forms of leadership (e.g., transformational) and, thus, accurately measured. Instead, they argue for research to focus more on leader/follower relations and how members' perceptions and sensemaking serve to legitimize their leaders' said authenticity and related constructs such as honesty and sincerity.

Nevertheless, the idea of shared and distributed leadership is one that extends existing leadership approaches by focusing on communication among leaders and members across all levels within the organization, even including nonhuman actants (e.g., objects, sites; Fairhurst et al., Forthcoming; Spillane, 2006). Social constructionist views of leadership such as this consider communication as defining and central to leadership and the use of language in conversations as the mechanism by which social identities and structures are created. Previous research in this area has focused on leaders' use of language as both a sensegiving and sensemaking tool upon which leaders and members co-create and learn shared systems of meaning within the organization. Weick (1995) defines sensemaking as "the placement of items into

frameworks, comprehending, redressing surprise, constructing meaning, interacting in pursuit of mutual understanding and patterning" (p. 6), while sensegiving refers to leaders' efforts in giving shape and meaning to members' understanding of constructed frameworks (Gioia & Chittipeddi, 1991).

Fairhurst and Sarr (1996), in their book *The Art of Framing*, offer an in-depth look at various language forms and framing tools (e.g., stories, spin, jargon, metaphors) that leaders employ to shape meaning in their communication with followers. Similarly, Alvesson and Spicer (2011) illustrate the important role that metaphors play as a tool leaders can use to aid in members' sensemaking of organizational events and occurrences. However, Fairhurst's work (1993) emphasizes that framing should not be an act exclusively reserved for leaders, but, instead, a reciprocal one in which valued members of the organization play a role as they seek clarity and ultimately reframe through their social interactions with one another. When confronted with equivocal situations especially, frames serve as a type of cognitive map that members utilize to learn and collectively make sense of new knowledge that accompanies a rapidly changing environment, thus paving the way for leadership to be shared or distributed among organizational members.

Indeed, a contemporary understanding of leadership communication is centered around a more distributed and co-constructed or managed nature of meaning assigned to various organizational processes that require learning and unlearning. James et al. (2007) call for learning design models that promote the practice of distributed leadership, while additional research in education notes the impact of professional communities, as a form of distributed leadership, on collective understanding and organizational learning (e.g., Hamzah & Jamil, 2019).

Although space limits our ability to cover all aspects of the leader-learning relationship, the totality of this and other research suggests that learning is not an isolated event, but rather an ongoing interactive and social process (Elkjaer, 2004) occurring at and among all levels within the organization. Leaders are considered central to this diffusion through their interactions with other leaders and followers, as well as through modeling behaviors that help to create a cultural environment where members have a natural proclivity to learn (Cooksey, 2003).

Leadership, Culture, and Learning

Schein and Schein (2017) define culture as a pattern of basic assumptions that "is defined by what a group has learned in solving its problems of external adaptation and

internal integration" (p. 149). Perhaps most notable within his conceptualization is the idea that impactful cultures are formed and reshaped around the social and adaptive learning processes that occur in response to changing external forces.

Thus, resilient, healthy cultures are those in which learning can take place. A culture focused on learning shapes how, why, what and the extent to which learning takes place (Shao et al., 2017). However, this presents somewhat of a paradox in that while learning requires that the organization be fluid and adaptable to change, strong cultures are stabilizing forces within the organization, and, thus, difficult to adapt and change. Schein and Schein (2017) imagine a type of learning culture that is inherently flexible and open to continuous learning and positions leaders as the key to navigating this stability/flexibility tension. According to Schein (2009), leaders must be connected to their external environment as much as they are to the internal workings of the organization. This requires that they listen and scan their environments to better understand the complexities of the problems they face and to help the organization learn. Moreover, leaders must commit to the learning process by creating the psychological safety and trust for learning to occur as well as be engaged learners themselves by modeling behaviors that others will follow (Popper & Lipshitz, 2000). According to Hedlund and Österberg (2013), team leaders, especially, are key to facilitating the open communication and collaboration necessary for creating a learning culture. They found that coaching by the team leaders provided the language and context support needed for multiple learning activities to occur, which is critical in developing a learning environment.

Rijal (2016) proposed a model that more specifically examines the impact of transformational leadership and culture on the development of a learning organization. Those findings revealed that transformational leaders, as well as the culture they influence, had a positive impact on the creation of a learning organization. Similarly, Shao et al. (2017) found that a learning culture mediated the relationship between transformational leadership and organizational learning. Additional research found a positive relationship between cultures characterized by innovation and change (i.e., transformational culture) and various individual/organizational outcomes (Parry & Proctor, 2000).

However, despite the critical need for successful organizations to be able to learn, there is little evidence that they do, which then begs the question that Schein (1996) articulates "why do organizations fail to learn how to learn?" (p. 9). He suggests that organizations fail to learn or remain competitive due to a lack of alignment of value-based assumptions underlying occupational subcultures (i.e., communities) within the

organization. This misalignment occurs in large part to the different languages and frameworks used by these communities to orient others to their purpose and values. Others argue that an organization's failure to learn is due, in part, to its preoccupation with success and inability to destigmatize what it means to fail (Gino & Staats, 2015). Although failure is not a one-size-fits-all, low-risk outcome for everyone, leaders are generally encouraged to challenge their own thinking and mindsets when it comes to failure and to create a culture where members feel safe to credibly detect, analyze, and learn from mistakes without fear of punitive measures (Edmonson, 2011). How they go about doing this represents a more pragmatic question within the learning-leadership literature.

Therefore, the processes, both formal and informal, by which leaders help to build a sustainable learning environment is an area both scholars and practitioners alike continue to investigate.

Contexts and Processes for Learning and Development

Considering contexts and processes for learning in organizations takes into consideration the who, where, and how of learning and development. That is, who are the individuals and teams learning, where does learning take place, and how does it occur? Knowing the "right" or most effective approach to learning is a struggle, due, in part, to a lack of concrete prescriptions for ensuring that learning and development takes place (Basten & Haamann, 2018). Meanwhile, organizations face the challenge of planning effective programs weighed against the realities of business pressures, pace, and busy schedules.

Nevertheless, learning initiatives and strategies include those that are formal and informal, just-in-time and continual, classroom and learning journey based. To help sketch the terrain, we propose looking at learning and development along two dimensions: individual or team-based and organization-wide learning. Another factor that we consider in this section is how formal or informal the learning might be, which we discuss in both dimensions. Our goal here is to capture various possibilities for organizations to make sense of the myriad contexts and processes and to guide future research, which we discuss in the final, closing section.

Individual/Team-based Learning and Development

A helpful starting point is learning that is aimed at the individual/team level and typically more formal or goal oriented. Action learning is one such form that takes many shapes, but its primary goal is putting knowledge immediately into action (Basten & Haaman, 2018). Action learning blurs the lines between formal and informal learning. It involves a specific gathering of individuals and teams (in-tact or dispersed) to solve specific problems, but it is less formal since it is typically non-hierarchical in composition and less structured. For instance, a team or small group of individuals from across an organization, known as a "set," might center a current challenge or problem (e.g., generating new revenue streams) and work through a process of thinking critically and collaboratively toward innovative solutions (Kesby, 2008). Then, solutions are put into practice, followed by after-action reviews. Team exercises in sectors such as the military, healthcare, and aviation typically leverage action learning to learn and improve their competencies in communication, decision making, processes, and dealing with stress (Hedlund & Österberg, 2013). Two crucial factors in whether learning occurs, according to Hedlund and Österberg (2013), are post-action collaborative discussion and reflection, and a leadership coaching style that promotes "psychological safety," where team members feel free to share, discuss, and experiment freely, without fear of reprimand or retribution (Edmondson, 2011). Simply put, learning in any context is difficult if one does not feel safe; leadership communication plays a vital role in establishing a safe climate.

Another emerging approach is leadership coaching. Commonly referred to as performance coaching or executive coaching, among others, coaching helps individuals in organizations boost performance and improve behavior (Boyatzis et al., 2022) so they can achieve business results (Hunt & Weintraub, 2007). Coaching can focus on skills at micro (e.g., how to deliver better sales presentations), meso (e.g., how to build an effective team), or macro (e.g., how to make better decisions and execute) levels. Likewise, coaching can be reactive or needs-based, as in bringing in a coach to help a struggling executive, or systematic, when members of a learning cohort all receive one-on-one and/or group coaching. External coaches are commonly utilized and typically have diverse expertise that provides an added benefit (e.g., specialized degrees) and have proven to be valuable in helping coachees in their future coaching roles with team members (Hunt & Weintraub, 2004). Coaches can also be from within the organization such as by a manager, which is desired but less common (Lombardo & Eichinger, 2001). Managerial coaching, however, is advantageous and links to employee learning and commitment (Park et al., 2021), which provides an interesting connection to enhanced employee attitudes, an important prerequisite to organizational learning.

Perhaps the most common form of formal learning and development in organizations is training. Training takes myriad forms and is driven through various modalities including traditional classroom (e.g., seminars, keynote presentations) and virtual learning (e.g., webinars). Goals of training include improving morale, driving employee engagement, and, crucially, developing skills necessary for one's job (Rodriguez & Walters, 2017). Although most training focuses on "tangible" skills, more recent approaches target dispositions by promoting mindfulness for leaders (Fyke & Cigelske, 2017). Training stretches across individual, team, and organization boundaries insofar as individual skill development might be the focus, but training aims to affect "individuals' knowledge, skills, and attitudes in order to improve individual, team, and organizational effectiveness" (Aguinis & Kraiger, 2009, p. 452). Moreover, although training workshops or seminars are commonly offered for individuals' skill development and career advancement, training requires a level of commitment by individuals and organizations to ensure maximum impact over the course of one's work trajectory (Jehanzeb & Bashir, 2013).

Thus, recent decades have seen a rise in large-scale corporate "universities" intended to provide robust learning and development opportunities. For instance, Dollar General Corporation's "DGU" offers employees at all levels with training opportunities beginning with their "DGU Core," "a new modern curriculum dedicated to [employees'] professional growth and development at Dollar General" (Dollar General, n.d.). From there, the offerings are "leveled up," including their Store Manager Training, District Manager Training, and Emerging Leaders Program, to name a few. These examples highlight how training may be built for individuals but scaled for organization-wide success. It aims to improve individual capabilities but is a catalyst for organizational competitive advantage (Noe et al., 2014).

Organization-wide Learning and Development

According to Basten and Haamann (2018), "Organizations learn regardless of whether they apply systematic learning approaches" (p. 1). However, the challenge lies in ensuring that the learning that takes place is effective in helping organizations meet the challenges they encounter. To this end, there are various approaches to organization-wide learning and development, such as paradox approaches, learning academies, and single/double-loop learning.

In today's landscape, marked by ever-increasing complexity, speed, a confluence of social and business mission, changing markets, and massive disruptions such as the rise

of artificial intelligence (AI), organizations have a greater need to learn, develop, and grapple with change. Enter research and practice centering paradoxes and the like (e.g., tensions, dialectics; for reviews see Fairhurst, 2019; Fairhurst & Putnam, 2024; Putnam et al., 2016). In brief, research and organization development (OD) interventions in this vein seek to embrace, rather than deny, the presence of paradoxes and tensions, in organization change. For instance, Fyke and Buzzanell's (2013) study demonstrates how firms attempt to grapple with tensions between social and business missions, and short-term execution and long-term visioning. They find that although it is normal for members to lean toward one pole, OD change agents, as well as leaders, play a crucial role in helping find harmony in and learn from paradoxes. Other interventions in this area of research, which Fairhurst (2019) reviews in detail, include the competing values framework, action science, third spaces, and dialectical inquiry, the outcomes of which include richer dialogue, better problem solving and decision-making, strategic planning, and collective sensemaking.

Our discussion of situating paradoxes in organizational studies, especially in today's business environment provides a helpful connection back to work on transformational and transactional leadership. When it comes to transformational versus transactional leadership, research suggests that both play a role in facilitating the type of learning needed to meet demands within the existing learning environment (Jansen et al., 2009). Utilizing Crossan et al.'s (1999) "4I" (i.e., *intuiting, interpreting, integrating, and institutionalizing*) framework of organizational learning, Vera and Crossan (2004) highlight the connection between strategic leadership on organizational learning and the challenge that comes from the tension in balancing exploration learning (e.g., risk taking, creativity, experimentation) with exploitation learning (e.g., efficiency, refinement and implementation), both of which characterize the interdependent nature of learning as it moves through various levels of the organization. As information flows forward from the individual and groups to organizational-level forms of knowledge (e.g., culture, procedures, structures), there is simultaneous information flowing backwards to guide individual and group level learning. They argue that balancing these learning tensions requires that leaders enact both transformational and transactional styles and, as such, propose that the exploration and exploitation learning underscoring transformational and transactional leadership, respectively, should challenge and reinforce institutionalized learning (Vera & Crossan, 2004).

One burgeoning approach to learning in organizations that bridges individual learning (e.g., training) and organizational learning is cohort-based, multi-session learning academies. As a shared approach to learning, academies take a group of

dispersed or in-tact teams from either the same organization or across organizations through a learning journey. The learning could be in-person or contain virtual experiences. Either way, they create a shared experience, known as "everyone-to-everyone" learning, wherein members of an organization or the entire organization, for that matter, goes through the same experiences and content (NeuroLeadership Institute, 2024). Learning academies offer collaboration, a critical factor in creating shared meaning and helping individuals, teams, and organizations learn and grow (Heath & Heath, 2017). Since people are heavily influenced by social norms, even in the context of learning, academies and their reliance on shared experience help facilitate social learning (Cassiday, 2022).

Neuroscience offers support for why the learning academy and shared experience approach works, namely because our brains are subject to change as new material is introduced and reinforced ("neuroplasticity"; Bresciani Ludvik, 2016; Collins, 2019). Although much of the neuroscience in learning is applied to traditional education environments, there is much promise for organization learning. Indeed, if neuroscience shows strategies for helping students connect learning to the "real world" (Bresciani Ludvik et al., 2016), it seems reasonable that those strategies are effective when learning is occurring in the real world of work over time in learning academies. Another reason academies are effective is that they take advantage of spacing, a factor that is important in learning. Simply put, people learn more effectively over time than when information is crammed into shorter spurts (Sisti et al., 2007). The connection between leadership and learning is apparent here, for instance, from a transformational leadership standpoint, insofar as transformational leaders promote the right culture and environment in which effective learning takes place. Thus, cohort-based learning coupled with transformational leadership practices can make for a potent learning experience.

Another helpful, albeit less formal, framework for organization-wide learning is what Basten and Haamann (2018) refer to as learning competencies. Chief among these are that of single versus double loop learning (Argyris & Schön, 1996) and Garvin's (1998) five building blocks of organizational learning (i.e., problem solving, experimentation, learning from experience, learning from others, transferring knowledge). Argyris (1994) argues that while organizations remain sites for learning and that success depends upon its learning, most people within organizations do not know how to learn. Learning, therefore, depends less upon factors such as incentives and motivation, but rather how individuals reason about, and reflect upon, their own behavior. He further introduces this distinction as single loop versus double loop

learning. Single loop learning is learning that occurs by examining the problems that exist and relying upon existing knowledge systems and structures to arrive at solutions without disturbing the underlying values and norms of the organization.

Double loop learning, however, requires a deeper, more critical reflection of not only what appears to be the different observable factors surrounding the problem but the reasons for those factors as well. Thus, this type of learning would have members reflecting upon their own actions and the underlying assumptions of those actions (Argyris, 1994). A critical factor and practice that makes a difference in ensuring that learning takes place is the role of the leader. Here, the leader follows an individual's learning journey and offers support and encouragement along the way, formally and informally. Formal support involves tying training to performance goals via practices such as performance reviews. Informal methods include monthly check-ins to track progress toward developmental goals. Whether formal or informal, the leader's role helps facilitate learning, and notably helps promote the promises of neuroplasticity in neuroscience (Collins, 2019). Additional research further leverages these ideas beyond the micro-level behaviors of individuals to include those interactions that occur between groups and team members (Amy, 2008; Atwood et al., 2010).

Issues in Leadership and Learning and Development

Two important issues cut across and impact many of the approaches, processes, and contexts we covered in this chapter, namely assessment and learning modalities. As such, we consider these meta-issues and briefly review them here, to set up several directions for future research, which we cover next.

First, of all the tricky issues in training, evaluating what and whether trainees learned *and* can then transfer that training back into their jobs is arguably the most difficult. The most used assessment framework is Kirkpatrick's four levels: reaction, learning, behavior, results (see Kirkpatrick & Kirkpatrick, 2006; Kirkpatrick & Kirkpatrick, 2016). The levels cover how trainees felt about the training in terms of engagement, relevance, and other affective dimensions; whether they acquired intended knowledge and skills; whether they can and will apply what they learned; and what impact the training had on key performance indicators (KPIs) such as higher sales, revenue growth, lower turnover, or increased customer satisfaction. Aside from formal methods, leaders play a role in helping ensure employees are learning and transferring that knowledge back to their work through reflection, discussion, and check-ins (Hunt & Weintraub, 2007; Hagen, 2012).

Second, technological advances have reshaped the possibilities of where and how training can occur (Bell et al., 2017). Most recently, the COVID-19 pandemic's impact on remote working ushered in a new level of expectation in terms of the accessibility of remote training and development offerings. A term commonly used is mobile learning (m-learning), which is a robust and stand-alone discipline (Grant, 2019), and most certainly can refer to the portability of users and their devices. Just a sampling of some of the possibilities of m-learning (Butler et al., 2021) include asynchronous micro-learning (e.g., LinkedIn Learning), simulations, and gamification (Landers et al., 2019), to name but a few. Beyond m-learning, videoconferencing software such as Zoom and Microsoft Teams offer accessible options for remote learning. Not surprisingly, one common finding in the past two plus years is that although employees are happy to have accessible options, decreased engagement and fatigue with the use of multiple online options are real struggles (Mikołajczyk, 2022). Here, leaders will continue to play a role in offering learners support and encouragement as they navigate changing demands on their work.

Conclusion and Directions for Future Research

In this final section, we close with several promising areas for research and practice. First, we call for future research in less formal methods of learning assessment. Specifically, given the crucial role leaders play in helping learners reflect, future research should explore how that process takes place. For instance, journaling studies could ask leaders and employees to reflect and journal their experiences from learning events or processes (e.g., academies, coaching). Attention should be paid to whether/how skills, competencies, and content are being transferred back into the job.

Second, given the vast array of learning available in the 21st century (e.g., m-learning, e-learning), researchers should continue to explore the efficacy of the available approaches. Organizations will continue to look to disruptive innovations like gamification and AI as a means for competitive advantage in terms of ongoing learning but also employee retention. Thus, researchers have an exciting opportunity to study how these advances help people learn and with what consequences.

Third, we believe there are research pathways that overlay leadership approaches with learning and development. For instance, authentic leadership (e.g., Mousa et al., 2019) could be applied to studying learning practices of reflection and meta-cognition. That is, what are the best practices through which individuals and teams learn in authentic and sustainable ways? It is one thing to attend a seminar and gain some

interesting content, while another to take that information and authentically apply it to one's personal leadership brand and style.

Finally, research would be well served to continue to investigate the collective nature of leadership, especially some of the traditional and emergent paradigms (e.g., transformational, trait-based). For instance, emerging research recognizes that authentic leadership happens in interaction (Larsson et al., 2021). What is lesser known, however, is how leader *development* is an interactive process. In other words, if a group of leaders is engaged in a leadership academy over a period of six months, how do they support each other and grow together in that process, and what are the keys for that collective development to take place?

As noted in the beginning, learning is a prerequisite for organizational effectiveness. As we have shown, leadership, along with other factors such as culture, is a crucial factor in promoting learning. Leaders not only set the tone for learning, but also support, encourage, and coach. Indeed, in the important context of learning, leaders take on their roles as "designers, stewards, and teachers" (Senge, 2006, p. 321).

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26

THE INTERSECTION OF LEADERSHIP, STRATEGY, AND COMMUNICATION

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DOI: 10.4324/9781003380115-30

Introduction

In the intricate web of managing organizations, the threads of leadership, strategy, and communication are often intertwined. Now crucial to implementing strategy, executives are facing imperatives to integrate these elements and synchronize their approach to strategy development and execution (Argenti et al., 2005; Vaara & Langley, 2021).

Research shows that organizational performance is linked to effective leadership – namely the ability to create, articulate, and cultivate support for compelling visions (Kopaneva, 2019). So, it should stand to reason that leaders who take a myopic approach to communicating their strategic visions might struggle competitively (Berggren & Bernshteyn, 2007; Stam et al., 2010; Kirkpatrick & Locke, 1996). But while many managers are able to develop strategy at a high level, a surprisingly small number think strategically about what consumes most of their time – communication (Argenti, 2023).

Laid out within this chapter, we emphasize that leaders must do more than just form great strategies. They should think about leadership and communication strategically to execute them. Let us illustrate this point practically by introducing two real-world case studies.

Facing substantial annual losses in 2006, Alan Mulally joined Ford Motor Company as CEO with complete clarity about how to turn Ford around (M. Goldsmith, personal

communication, July 18, 2023). He fostered a "one-company" culture to revitalize the organization (Argenti, 2016; Epstein et al., 2023). Using communication adeptly, he integrated vision and culture into the firm's new "One Ford" strategy, implementing clear expectations for his employees and cultivating an atmosphere of trust that expedited a cultural transformation. As a result, Ford experienced a successful turnaround, which stood in stark contrast to its rivals who sought government bailouts during the financial crisis.

Compare this to the cautionary tale of former Wall Street darling, General Electric. At its peak, the industrial titan was a market leader in sectors spanning from appliances to finance. Yet, during his tenure from 2017 to 2018, CEO John Flannery was criticized for making strategic missteps and failing to align key constituencies at a strategic and cultural inflection point – the slow pace of change was symptomatic of what some have attributed to problems with communication. The resulting sharp drop in market value, removal from the Dow Jones Industrial Average, and extensive restructuring that followed eventually led to Flannery's dismissal.

The difference between Ford's success and General Electric's apparent fall from grace offers insight into the challenges of implementing strategy. Unclear communication leads to a lack of understanding, a lack of alignment, and an inability to ultimately win in the marketplace. Exemplified by Ford's turnaround, we argue that the opposite is also true: clear and well-understood strategies can help corporations achieve great success. This idea sets the stage for us to explore the influence of leadership and communication in executing strategy.

While many have written about the link between communication and an organization's ability to succeed (Argenti, 2017), less has been written about the need for a new approach to using communication strategically – not only in developing strategy, but also as one of the only ways to execute it. This chapter attempts to address that concern, collecting insights from academics and practitioners to articulate the power of three separate, yet interlinked, core competencies: *strategic leadership*, *strategic thinking*, and *strategic communication*. We believe that leaders who master these three core competencies will position themselves to develop and implement strategy more effectively than their peers.

Strategic Leadership – Charting the Course

Existing literature on leadership presents a complex array of theories about the traits, attributes, qualities, and behaviors that make the best leaders, sometimes in an attempt

to forecast their success (Fairhurst et al., 2024; Derue et al., 2011). Other approaches evolved in complexity and scope, further suggesting that definitions of leadership are indeed quite plastic (Gallie, 1956; Grint, 2005; Wittgenstein, 1953). In search of clarity, others define leadership with more focus on actions that cultivate alignment with organizational objectives (Fairholm, 2001). Well respected in the domain of leadership, the U.S. Army shares the idea that leadership is a set of actions, defining it as "the activity of influencing people by providing purpose, direction, and motivation to accomplish the mission and improve the organization" (Department of the Army, 2019).

Despite these varying perspectives, the consensus among behavioral scientists and practitioners is that leadership is a tangible and significant factor in organizational effectiveness (Yukl, 2020). Great leadership may even improve an organization's capacity to adapt, innovate, and respond to change (Elenkov et al., 2005). Understanding the value of leadership, we argue that the successs of corporate strategies is dependent on the actions of senior executives, leaving their approaches to *strategic leadership* a ripe topic for inquiry and discussion.

We define *strategic leadership* as the set of actions and processes that shape corporate strategy and enhance its ability to respond to change. *Strategic leadership* is a skillset that necessitates the use of communication to articulate the organization's mission, values, vision, and strategy in a way that fosters alignment across the organization (Collins & Porras, 1996; Hitt et al., 2023).

We believe the "Hierarchy of Company Statements" – popularized in the *Harvard Business Review* – is a very useful tool for *strategic leaders* in creating this alignment. This framework delineates what a corporation stands for and distills many facets of strategy into four clear statements that shape a company's future (Collis & Rukstad, 2008). Those four statements are: Mission, Values, Vision, and Strategy.

Mission Statement: Why do We Exist?

At its core, a mission statement pinpoints organizational purpose and is intrinsically tied to long-term strategy (Alegre et al., 2018; Collins & Porras, 1994; Campbell & Yeung, 1991). As an instrument of culture, it reflects corporate ideals, articulates shared aspirations, and captures the timelessness of a company's identity (Fairhurst et al., 1997; Knowles et al., 2022; Toh et al., 2022). Inspiring mission statements are broad in scope, concise, and serve as powerful rallying points that unite key constituencies around ideas that transcend the simple act of selling goods and services (David, 2020).

Consider the purpose behind some of the world's most recognizable brands. On the surface, Starbucks sells premium coffee, but its stated mission is "to inspire and nurture the human spirit – one person, one cup, and one neighborhood at a time." Similarly, Johnson & Johnson's far-reaching impact extends beyond commercial healthcare products. Encapsulating this and representing the company's strengths, Johnson & Johnson "blends heart, science, and ingenuity to profoundly change the trajectory of health for humanity."

It is paramount for *strategic leaders* to shape this sense of purpose and help others understand why their company exists. While there is mixed evidence regarding how much mission statements directly affect financial performance (David, 2020; Salehi-Kordabadi et al., 2020), some research shows that well-crafted mission statements can lead to superior performance (Allison, 2019), even improving satisfaction and commitment among employees (Kopaneva, 2019).

Values Statement: How Will We Behave?

Similar to the purpose found in a company's mission statement, a values statement should also possess a generational and timeless quality that reflects meaning and commitment to the organization (Fairholm, 2001; Greyser & Urde, 2019). The common values that drive strategic alignment within organizations reside within this statement, functioning as beacons that orient and synchronize employee actions like buoys guiding ships through a harbor (Cady et al., 2011; Campion et al., 2020).

But controlling the behavior of thousands of employees across large firms and directing them toward a common goal is undeniably challenging, exemplified by notorious scandals like that of Volkswagen. In 2015, the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency found that Volkswagen intentionally rigged diesel engines to pass emissions tests, flagrantly violating the company's stated commitment to responsibility and sustainability. Such high-profile stories reveal the unsettling consequences of deviating from values-based behavior, but the underlying problem may be even more pervasive. According to some research, a mere 40 percent of companies appear to reflect their desired values in reality (Wright, 2002). With so much at stake, what can a company do to influence employee behavior more effectively?

On the surface, effective values statements define core beliefs. But we suggest that *strategic leaders* must do more than merely document those values. It is much more important to define and create alignment around the right organizational values through engaged leadership and effective communication (Collins, 2000). Through this

engagement, *strategic leaders* can use values statements to their advantage, building an important foundation for organizational culture and energizing long-term alignment with the organization's identity (Collis & Rukstad, 2008). In this way, using company values and competency models make it possible to align, but not necessarily control, employee behavior (Campion et al., 2020).

Vision Statement: Where Are We Going?

Beyond a company's values statement, its vision statement sets an inspiring view of the future. A vision statement sets a directional heading, forming meaningful answers to key questions such as "where are we going?" and "what business are we in?" Many executives have already realized the importance of answering these questions, as vision-setting is hardly a new idea. In the latter part of the 20th century, as the power of rhetoric in strategy became a widely accepted practice, the share of U.S. corporations with mission and vision statements doubled in the span of a decade (Levering, 2000; Walter, 1995).

The responsibility of setting this direction and forming this statement sits squarely on the shoulders of senior executives (Hart & Quinn, 1993). This sentiment is corroborated by a McKinsey & Company study, where high-profile CEOs emphasized the vital importance of setting this direction through clear vision statements (Dewar et al., 2022). But while vision statements are designed to articulate a firm's direction and competitive goals (David, 2020), the path forward is not always certain and may demand some room for adaptation and flexibility.

Research suggests that vision statements need to be actively created, debated, negotiated, and sometimes even discarded and changed when appropriate (Jalonen et al., 2018). Vision statements are, therefore, helpful in setting a direction, but need not be so rigid as to constrain an organization's ability to respond to change. In this sense, vision-setting and strategy development become more of an ongoing and iterative effort for executives, encompassing a broad range of coordinated choices that can capture value in both the long and short term (Collis, 2021).

Unlike the enduring nature of mission and values statements, the vision statement should be more dynamic – enough to allow firms the ability to adapt to changing business environments (Brorström et al., 2022). King et al. (2019) suggest that leaders should embrace this flexibility by revising their vision statements as often as every ten years. But abiding by this timeframe does not suit the needs of most organizations. According to Booz Allen Hamilton, the global average CEO tenure is about seven

years, with nearly half of all CEOs failing within their first 18 months (Charan, 2005). This underscores a challenge: while a vision statement presents an aspirational future, its efficacy relies heavily on a leader's tenure and his or her ability to act upon it (Brorström et al., 2022). With limited time at the helm, perhaps executives should revisit their vision statements more frequently than each passing decade. We propose that *strategic leaders* should consider framing their visions within a horizon of three-to-five years.

Exemplifying this concept brilliantly is the head of Brooks Running Company, Jim Weber. As CEO, he regularly develops a three-year playbook called "Charting Brooks Future," which details overarching goals and a general execution plan for his team (J. Weber, personal communication, July 18, 2023). This document has achieved both alignment and flexibility, allowing Brooks to grow, adapt to market changes, and beat their competition. As a credit to Weber's success, the company's annual sales now exceed one billion dollars.

Strategy Statement: How Are We Going to Get There?

The strategy statement captures the organization's short-term plan, providing a focused, singular objective that connects daily operations to its overarching mission and vision (McKone, 2022). A well-defined strategy statement also outlines an organization's competitive advantage over its rivals (Gluck et al., 1980), explicitly describing observable parameters (Slavik & Roby, 2011) that help organizations prioritize resource allocation and seize emerging opportunities (De Andreis, 2019). Such parameters often include the essential components of *objective*, *scope*, and *advantage.* The *objective* delineates the desired end goals, *scope* specifies the business domain or landscape in which the firm will operate, and *advantage* outlines the unique means by which these objectives will be achieved (Collis & Rukstad, 2008).

But no matter the goal, it is imperative for *strategic leaders* to stay responsive to change. This highlights the importance of developing a sustainable approach to strategy, which guides organizations forward with certain amounts of conviction despite constant, dynamic shifts in the market. On this front, there is much debate about how often a company should shift its strategy. But given the nature of the modern business landscape, we advise that *strategic leaders* should revisit and update their strategy to address emerging issues and incorporate new data into their decision-making processes as frequently as once a year (McKone, 2022).

Strategic Thinking – Linking Vision to Execution

What is Strategic Thinking?

Despite the proliferation and popularity of these four company statements, they are not always well-written or understood. But it is not just employees who struggle with succinctly summarizing their company's core strategy – it is an issue for senior leaders as well (Argenti, 2016; Collis & Rukstad, 2008; Sull et al., 2015). One might begin to wonder, if employees and leaders don't understand or can't articulate their company's strategy, how can they solve their most pressing strategic problems? This question becomes even more complex when you consider that a startling 85 percent of executives believe that their companies do not even have the right capabilities to diagnose their problems, let alone solve them (Collis, 2021; Wedell-Wedellsborg, 2017).

With that in mind, we posit that *strategic leaders* are capable of recognizing the need to respond to new problems. However, it is not always clear how that might be done. As Grint (2005) aptly stated, leadership is the art of solving problems that haven't been seen before. Though adopting the hierarchy of statements may be an important first step, *strategic leaders* should take a holistic and collaborative approach to address these challenges. Therefore, we further suggest that a great *strategic leader* should also become a *strategic thinker*.

Grounded in half a century of scholarly research, *strategic thinking* epitomizes a leader's capacity to forge strategic insights, act with agility, and foresee opportunities and challenges in changing environments (Smriti et al., 2021). By developing this second core competency, we believe that organizations will be better suited to bridge the gap between strategy development and execution. Executives can accomplish this by focusing on two central elements of *strategic thinking* that augment and depend on each other. The first is a strategic mindset, which allows organizations to identify and solve the right strategic problems. The second is an ability to create a "one-company" culture, which lays the foundation for change.

Developing a Strategic Mindset

A strategic mindset is an intellectual outlook that compels leaders to think critically, holistically, and long-term about their goals (Argenti, 2016). It embraces Albert Einstein's perspective on problem-solving, which underscores the significance of investing considerable time into understanding problems before attempting to solve them (Spradlin, 2012). Inspired by this approach, we propose that *strategic thinking*

must go beyond solving big problems; it requires finding ways to prioritize and understand the right ones. In this context, leaders have great influence on both the problem identification and problem-solving processes, often shaping the settings in which such decisions are made (Grint, 2005).

In the realm of prioritization, U.S. President Dwight Eisenhower developed a useful matrix (Figure 26.1) to help *strategic thinkers* frame their problems (Covey, 2013; Nevins, 2023). By sorting the litany of potential decisions and myriad activities into four categories, *strategic thinkers* can delineate their priorities on spectrums of urgency and importance. As detailed within the matrix, once leaders organize their problems, they can then make decisions and allocate resources to solve them. McKinsey's extensive research ultimately supports the usefulness of this framework, revealing that the best CEOs tend to focus on the most essential, long-term, strategic problems rather than frequently shifting their company's attention to other urgent and less-important issues (Dewar et al., 2022; Nevins, 2023).

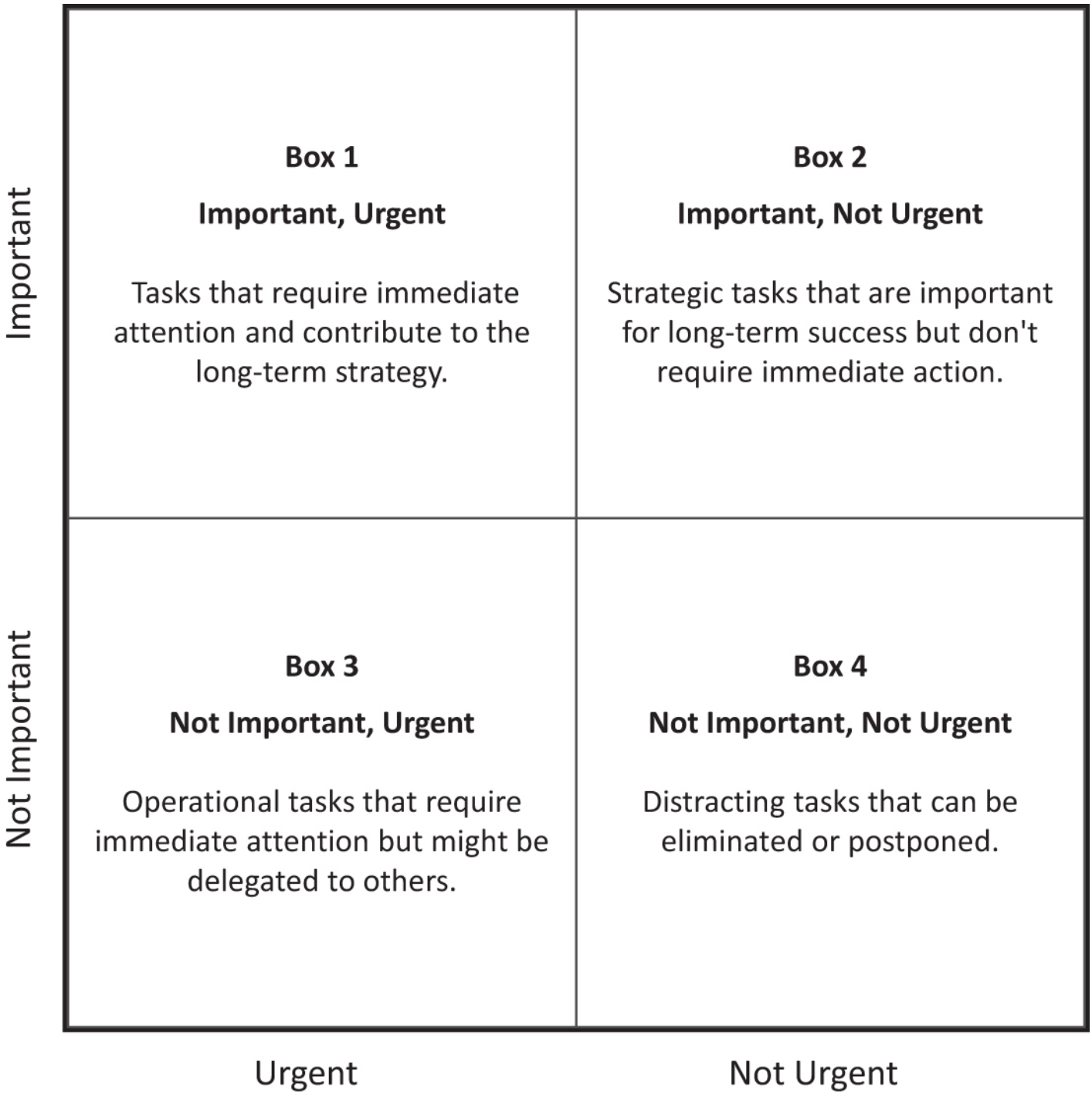


Figure 26.1 The Eisenhower Matrix, adapted from Stephen Covey (2013)

Akin to Eisenhower's approach, Grint (2005) refers to Rittel and Webber's (1973) work to reveal various approaches to problem framing. "Tame" problems have clear solutions and endpoints and can be delegated to those with the appropriate experience. "Wicked" problems, however, are more intricate and do not have a definitive solution. Grint (2005) argues that there are no right answers to wicked problems, per se. Instead, their solution requires that leaders take a strategic perspective and collaborative

approach to ask the right questions, emphasizing the wisdom in Einstein's focus on understanding. Building on this perspective, leaders should involve their organizations in the problem-framing process to understand which problems the organization needs to solve. To accomplish this, *strategic leaders* should ask two important strategic questions: "what are we doing that we shouldn't be doing?" and "what aren't we doing that we should be doing?"

While both Eisenhower and Grint's problem framing techniques can be helpful, *strategic thinkers* face the same imperatives as *strategic leaders* – they must prioritize problems and galvanize organizational support to solve them. Big problems require an inquisitive and collaborative approach to understand them (Grint, 2005; Tannenbaum & Schmidt, 1958), and strategic problems may be the biggest and most complex of them all. And because these strategic problems are often characterized by an inherent complexity, it is difficult for any leader to solve them alone. With this in mind, *strategic thinking* necessitates that employees be included and collaborate in the process of strategy development, which can be accomplished by building a "one-company" culture.

A "One-Company" Culture

Strategic thinkers align the interests of both the corporation and its employees, just like the "One Ford" approach Mullaly used to transform Ford Motor Company (Argenti, 2016; Epstein et al., 2023). The "one-company" culture approach shifts focus away from individual work towards collective involvement and ownership, engendering trust and motivating individuals to act in the organization's best interest (Argenti, 2016). On this topic, traditional strategy research emphasizes the importance of convergence, reflecting a state in which corporate employees don't just understand the company's mission, values, vision, and strategy – they actually share the organization's priorities and objectives (Floyd & Wooldridge, 1992).

To create a unified "one-company" culture, executives must ensure the strategy is understood through direct and clear messaging, perhaps by using such frameworks as the hierarchy of company statements. Then leaders need to strengthen trust and confidence in these statements by nurturing genuine relationships and fostering open communication between management and employees. This will help amplify marginalized voices and uncover suppressed ideas, thereby unlocking latent creativity and problem-solving capacity that exists within the organization (Maclean et al., 2021; Tavella, 2021).

Leaders must also instill a sense of ownership and joint investment, motivating employees to actively contribute to the company's objectives. Empirical evidence popularized by Nobel Prize-winning psychologist Daniel Kahneman further validates this idea, showing that people are five times more supportive when they feel included (Dewar et al., 2022). With such collective support, a "one-company" culture enhances an organization's adaptive capabilities and equips it to navigate uncertainty more effectively (Kopaneva, 2019). Naturally, the opposite is also true. Failing to involve employees in activities like strategy development will dampen enthusiasm, foster dissatisfaction, and negatively affect performance (Twum, 2021).

If done properly, *strategic thinkers* can harness the full potential of their employees to develop and execute strategies with long-term staying power (Argenti, 2022; Kopaneva, 2019). Highlighting the benefits of doing so, McKinsey's analysis shows that when organizations cultivate such cultures, they are more than twice as likely to succeed against other high-performing organizations (Epstein et al., 2023).

However, understanding and identifying the right problems is not enough. Without a strategic approach to communication, it is challenging for large companies to implement their solutions (Argenti, 2016). Therefore, we propose that leaders should take a strategic approach to involving key constituencies in both the development and execution of strategy. Once the foundation is laid within the organization, *strategic leaders* and *strategic thinkers* must then develop into *strategic communicators* who guide their teams towards their shared objectives.

Strategic Communication – The Key to Execution

Strategic communicators align the company's messages with its overall strategy to enhance its competitive positioning (Argenti, Howell & Beck, 2005; Hallahan et al., 2007). When done well, employees feel more connected to their work, quality and productivity increases, and firm performance improves (Bartkus et al., 2006; Collis & Rukstad, 2008; Musheke & Phiri, 2021; Pinos et al., 2006). Stressing this point, firms that have a well-crafted approach to communication not only yield higher returns to shareholders, but they also foster employee engagement and benefit from enhanced intellectual capital (Argenti, 2023; Dolle & Kuzmina-Merlino, 2020).

In their research, Vaara and Langley (2021) discuss the constitutive role of communication in strategy, underscoring how it has now become a central component of strategy execution. Their work enriches discourse on existing research and serves as a major contribution to our overall understanding of the power of communication in the

strategic process (Vaara & Langley, 2021). Leading practitioners Marshall Goldsmith (world renowned Executive Coach and best-selling author) and Korn Ferry's Richard Marshall (former Chief Communications Officer for three Fortune 500 companies) emphasize this point, asserting that communication is among the most important leadership competencies in today's business landscape (M. Goldsmith, personal communication, July 18, 2023; R. Marshall, personal communication, July 20, 2023).

At a basic level, the takeaway is quite clear: strategy cannot be executed if it cannot be communicated. But even with so much attention being placed on the indelible influence of communication in spurring organizational change, our understanding of the challenges with implementation remains partial and fragmented. Explored in this final section, we attempt to consolidate the most pressing concerns within the field of corporate communication and recommend approaches that *strategic communicators* may use to solve them.

Implementation Challenges

The Silent Barriers of Unheard Strategy

Imagine this – if someone came into your house in the middle of the night and woke you up, could you easily recite the key elements of your organization's strategy? More importantly, would your answer match your colleague's response? If not, the company either doesn't have a strong strategy, or it is simply not well understood. This is a common problem, as few organizations can easily pass this *dead-asleep test* (Argenti, 2016).

Crafting compelling visions and sound strategies are both crucial, but it is the human element of managing people (the "soft stuff") that creates the vast majority – as much as 72 percent – of an organization's barriers to success (Keller & Schaninger, 2019). Unfortunately, many leaders exacerbate these problems with poor communication (Germaine et al., 2021). Supported by John Kotter's (2007) research, the most significant errors in implementing strategy included leaders under-communicating their vision and insufficiently involving others in the process.

Infrequent communication leaves employees unsure of how the strategy translates into their daily work, and it risks weakening the company's identity (Fairhurst et al., 1997). And when employee viewpoints are not incorporated into organizational narratives, a significant incongruence develops between the intended meaning of official mission and vision statements and their interpretation (Kopaneva & Sias, 2015).

Even among talented leaders and high-ranking executives, consistency is the most often overlooked element of strategic communication, as they often underestimate how often messages need to be repeated before they are truly understood and internalized (M. Goldsmith, personal communication, July 18, 2023).

Leaders need to be aware of not just how often they are communicating, but how they are communicating too. Unclear communication, though often unintentional, even comes down to word choice. In a comprehensive review of 180 sources on vision communication, researchers found that many leaders resort to using generalized statements about the future instead of providing tangible, visualizable goals to their employees (Carton & Lucas, 2018). It seems that many communicate vision with conceptual rhetoric and think of the future in abstract terms, rather than painting a mental picture in much-needed, vivid detail. In these circumstances, failing to implement strategy is likely the result of an organization's inability to make the vision actionable and tangible in the eyes of various constituencies (Fairhurst, 1993). Researchers discovered that this made goals less clear to employees, sometimes even having a counterproductive effect – the lack of clarity even went as far as creating distrust towards the organization and its leadership (Fairhurst et al., 1997). As we can see, insufficient and unclear communication can make creating a much-desired "one-company" culture quite the elusive goal.

The Evolving Role of Corporate Communications

Some executives underestimate the role of corporate communications in shaping strategy itself (Argenti, 2023). Communication is typically seen as a tool for spreading ideas after a strategy is formulated rather than being part of the initial development process. This might result from the inclination to distinguish the abstract aspect of communication from the more tangible processes of strategy development and execution (Bencherki et al., 2021).

Highlighted by the Page Society, a consortium of premier Chief Communications Officers (CCO) and leading scholars, many executives are aware of this issue. In turn, there has been a marked transformation in the CCO's mandate. Rather than just handling internal and external communications, they are now expected to serve as business strategists and adept problem solvers (Arthur W. Page Society, 2016). But the evolving role of the CCO presents a pressing challenge for many businesses, with both CEOs and CCOs grappling to fully understand the role's full potential and standardize its shifting responsibilities, functions, and capabilities.

Increasing Complexities of the Modern Corporate Landscape

The corporate landscape is now influenced by evolving digital advancements, globalization, and rising stakeholder influence (Arthur W. Page Society, 2016). Among these, perhaps the biggest challenge for executives is the need to respond to global, intercultural, and social impact issues, far beyond the limited local scope that concerned many executives in the past (M. Goldsmith, personal communication, July 18, 2023). Modern executives must be able to navigate the complexity of these competing priorities responsibly, especially those that extend beyond the financial bottom line.

The advent of the internet has fundamentally changed the way that people interact with, report, and collect information from various sources: newsrooms, other organizations, and even the general public (Arthur W. Page Society, 2016; M. Sneed, personal communication, July 18, 2023). In the digital age, the proliferation of communication channels has generally enabled widespread information sharing, which has often been to our benefit. However, the use of so many channels to distribute this information can now distract, deflect, and reduce the effect of even the best laid strategies. The multifaceted use of communication channels often creates a tremendous amount of dissonance if the actions are not well coordinated (R. Marshall, personal communication, July 20, 2023).

Many executives have attempted to address these challenges through structure and processes, creating a plurality of specialized roles, hierarchies, and channels to tackle the communication problem (Volk et al., 2017). Even if these roles are formally structured, they often lack standardization between companies, which has also complicated the management landscape for CCOs (K. McGinnis, personal communication, July 18, 2023).

Pinpointing Root Causes

Despite extensive work on understanding strategy since Michael Porter popularized his framework in the 1980s, execution remains a primary concern. Approximately 70 percent of large organizations still struggle to implement strategy (Sull et al., 2015). But determining the root cause of such failures is often unclear, whether they arise from flawed strategies, poor messaging and talent management, or lackluster execution. Complicating this diagnosis, the vast majority of CCOs and academics lament that key performance indicators (KPI) and tools used to measure performance of corporate communications change regularly, either indicating inconsistency or demonstrating the field's steep learning curve (Arthur W. Page Society, 2016; Swenson et al., 2018).

Implementing the Solutions

The Strategic Chief Communications Officer (CCO)

Communication starts with senior leaders, so it would be prudent for corporate executives to link communication and strategy formally through structured roles and staff functions at the executive level (Argenti, 2023). Supporting this notion, recent studies emphasize that executing strategy depends on leaders with adept people management and communication skills – chiefly through the combined efforts of the CEO and CCO (Simsek et al., 2017). In doing so, executives can leverage communication functions strategically to accomplish their goals and execute their strategies (Argenti, 2017).

In the realm of *strategic communication*, the power of language is paramount. As experts in communications, CCOs must take a leading role in strategy to ensure that messages remain clear and aligned with organizational goals (Mantere, 2014). Even beyond mastering the use of language itself, leading practitioners assert that the most effective CCOs do not just understand and communicate the strategy – they are actively involved in shaping it (M. Goldsmith & M. Sneed, personal communication, July 18, 2023). To accomplish this alignment, CCOs should be viewed as more than just storytellers, but also as trusted advisors who are empowered to speak with the CEO's authority when communicating strategy (Arthur W. Page Society, 2016; Shackleton, 2007; R. Marshall, personal communication, July 20, 2023).

The CCO's evolving role as a business strategist and problem solver amplifies the importance of a cohesive, well-aligned relationship with the CEO. The bond between CEO and CCO has become an indispensable partnership, serving as both linchpin and cornerstone for strategic decision-making and communication. To truly succeed in their respective roles, the CEO and CCO need to operate with one voice, which emphasizes the obvious benefits of a direct-report relationship (Arthur W. Page Society, 2016; M. Sneed, personal communication, July 18, 2023; E. Dachs, personal communication, July 19, 2023).

Develop a Strategic Principle

Strategic communicators need to have a well-understood strategy (Argenti et al., 2005). Conceptualizing those ideas into a succinct collection of words or phrases can be difficult, but it plays a critical role in making sense of strategy and cultivating shared understanding (Jalonen et al., 2018). One way to accomplish this is by developing a

strategic principle. While somewhat similar to the hierarchy of company statements, a strategic principle condenses the same collection of ideas into a single phrase.

Orit Gadiesh, Chairman of Bain & Company, stated that strategic principles should be "clear, compelling, and actionable" phrases that drive consistent action throughout the organization (Argenti et al., 2005). Effective strategic principles distill complex business philosophies into memorable catchphrases: Walmart's "Save Money, Live Better" succinctly conveys its commitment to affordability and improved living, while Mastercard's "Kill Cash" encapsulates its vision for a cashless, digitally empowered consumer experience.

Crystallizing a firm's strategy in this way can hone its strategic focus. A strategic principle should, therefore, be rooted in an organization's core strengths and serve as the compass that directs its strategy (Bencherki et al., 2021).

*Strategic communicator*s can use this checklist to validate the strength of their strategic principle:

- Can it guide strategy?
- Does it capture the company's mission and purpose?
- Is it clear, concise, and memorable?
- Can everyone in the organization recite it?

If developed correctly, executives can use a strategic principle to evaluate challenges, prioritize the allocation of resources, and make critical business decisions (Gadiesh & Gilbert, 2001). It may also help organizations pass the *dead-asleep test* mentioned earlier within this chapter (Argenti, 2016).

Embrace Ambiguity

Scholars assert that employees do commit to the organization's vision, goals, and values if their leaders can clearly articulate them (Niehoff et al., 1990). Indeed, these mission and vision statements should be clearly articulated, but they should serve as guideposts and avoid being too oppressively prescriptive. Otherwise, the organization risks losing its much-needed strategic flexibility.

Organizations carry elements of their founding (mission, purpose, and culture) into the future (Sinha et al., 2020). Employees view them as core parts of their identity, and these so-called "imprints" can often be rigid and resistant to change. But while a strategic principle offers clarity and shared understanding, there is valuable space for ambiguity as well. Such ambiguity, in this context, allows employees to act with

flexibility and strategic agency (Mantere, 2014) without being so overly prescriptive that it constrains creativity and adaptability. Sinha et al.'s (2020) study adds nuance, revealing the power of modifying and adapting these "imprints" over time as the organization's strategy evolves, eventually regarding them more as "strategic guideposts" when the need for change arises.

Maintaining some ambiguity within the vision and mission statements can foster inclusivity, as well, especially within large, complex, and diverse organizations where employees might only share partial agreement on meaning and purpose (Brorström et al., 2022; Jalonen et al., 2018). Maclean et al. (2021) explored this concept in a 15-year study of Procter and Gamble, concluding that the benefits of such ambiguity emerged as "organizational ambidexterity," which helped the organization maintain inertial strengths while allowing room for necessary change (Bamford et al., 2000). As such, *strategic communicators* should feel empowered to embrace a certain amount of ambiguity when developing their communication strategies.

Rhetorical Narratives Make Strategy Relatable

Strategic communicators play a role in linking individual employee behavior to the overarching business strategy. This goes beyond simply understanding the company's values and strategy – employees must manifest them in their daily behavior. Practitioners and academics advise that a storytelling approach may help solve this problem by relating how the company's vision actually manifests in behavior at the individual level.

To make their visions more relatable, *strategic communicators* should consider using more specific imagery and less abstract rhetoric in their messages. Garreau et al. (2015) focus on the interpretive power of visual representations and demonstrate how much they facilitate strategic thought. Their research shows how visual representations – much more than abstract rhetoric alone – cultivate shared understanding and generate the valuable buy-in that executives aim to achieve. For example, Bill Gates' vision for a computer in every home or Henry Ford's vision of every person owning a motorized car both use language that visualize strategic goals as tangible objects, actions, and events (Carton & Lucas, 2018).

Like Gates and Ford, today's leaders can use powerful imagery and storytelling to convey their aspirations (Carton & Lucas, 2018; Westley & Mintzberg, 1989). This use of language is much more effective than statements filled with business jargon and abstract buzzwords. Employees need to see how their daily actions connect to and translate to the company's mission, purpose, and strategy through this communications

practice. Image-based rhetoric helps *strategic communicators* craft more powerful narratives that their employees can understand, properly internalize, and put into practice. Doing so helps break down high-level directives into specific objectives, thereby bringing the broader organizational goals into the more understandable context of everday narratives (Cooren et al., 2011; M. Sneed, personal communication, July 18, 2023).

Repetition Matters

Strategic communication is not merely a one-off event. Instead, it is a consistent practice that sustains strategy over time. Executive coach Marshall Goldsmith and Fremont CEO Eric Dachs emphasize that strategic messaging must be repeated constantly – nearly to the point of exhaustion – to drive execution (M. Goldsmith, personal communication, July 18, 2023; E. Dachs, personal communication, July 19, 2023). Research into the illusory effect substantiates this idea, asserting that repeating information more frequently seems to affect the degree to which people believe it (Hassan & Barber, 2021). This implies that repeating the messages may not merely increase understanding, but it may even inspire a deeper sense of belief in the company's vision and purpose.

Strategic communication is also a carefully orchestrated process. While repetition matters, leaders must also consider various factors like timing, audience, and channel to convey their messages (Germaine et al., 2021). Therefore, top-notch *strategic communicators* must not only vocalize the vision repeatedly, but they must also adapt it over time (Vaara & Langley, 2021) and across different media to ensure consistent exposure to the workforce (Westley & Mintzberg, 1989).

Measure Success

Strategic communicators need to take responsibility for their messages, as implementing strategy often hinges on the effectiveness of their communication. In the same way that organizations measure the effectiveness of their strategies, *strategic communicators* need to assess how well their communications practices support those goals (Shackleton, 2007). Therefore, leaders need to use measurement tools to gauge alignment and guide managerial choices and communications practices. There is extensive literature (see material covered by Swenson et al., 2018) in the field of measurement and evaluation that supports this assertion, highlighting various and evolving responsibilities within corporate communication departments. Portions of that

research suggest that measurement systems should be geared towards assessing the firm's day-to-day communications activities.

Qualitatively, *strategic communicators* can assess whether messages have permeated the organization by observing employee behavior, taking note of whether they are solving problems in ways that are consistent with the company's values (E. Dachs, personal communication, July 19, 2023). Quantitatively, CCOs have embraced new KPIs that gauge employee engagement, customer loyalty, social influence, and the tone of media coverage (Arthur W. Page Society, 2016; M. Sneed, personal communication, July 18, 2023; R. Marshall, personal communication, July 20, 2023). In either case, metrics that fall short of desired targets should reveal when corporate communication is not aligned with the company's goals.

Building on practitioner insights, a more conceptual approach to measuring success can be found in the Corporate Communication Strategy Framework (Figure 26.2), which can be a helpful tool for *strategic communicators*. It provides a method for tailoring messages to certain constituencies and evaluating their effectiveness (Argenti, 2023).

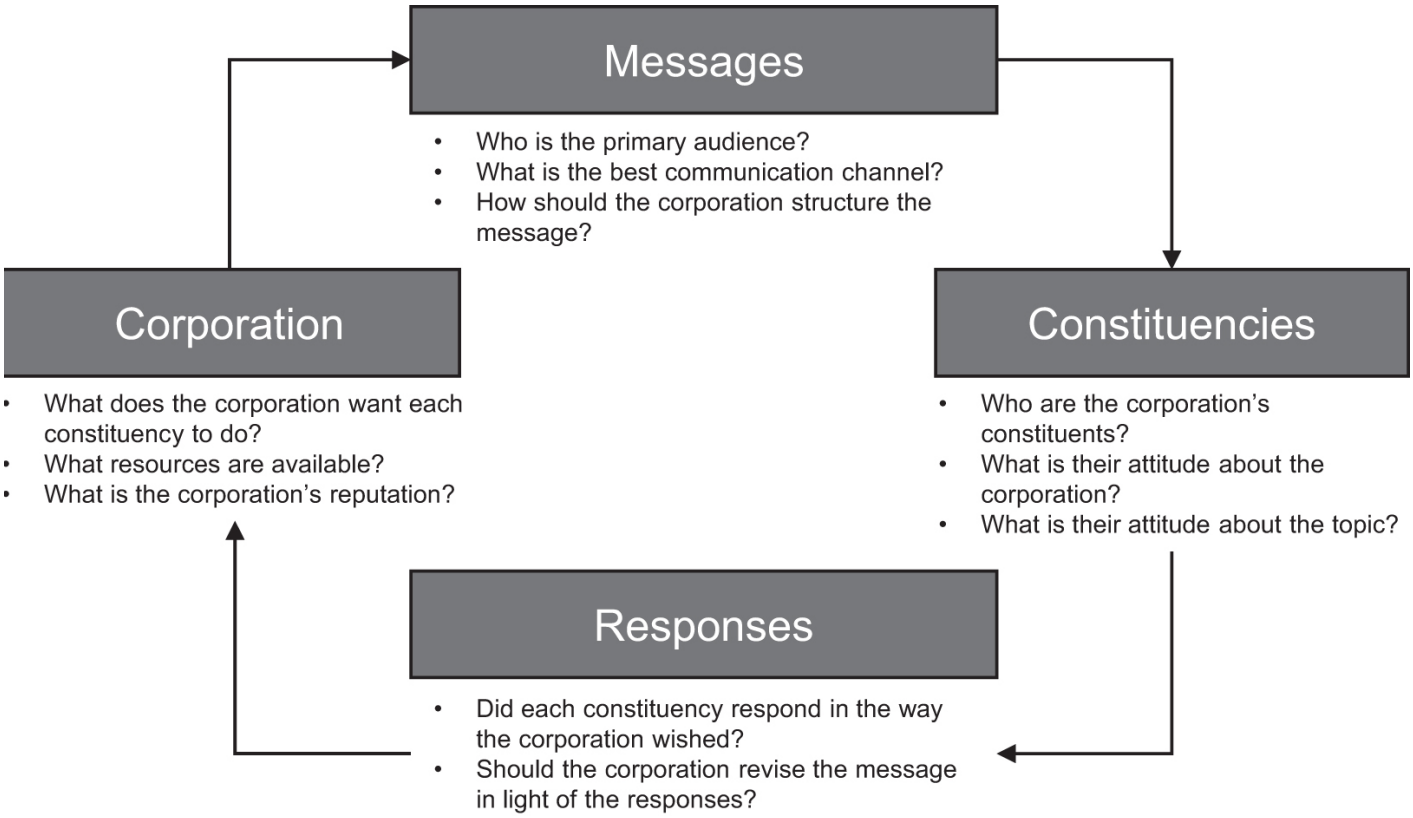


Figure 26.2 The Corporate Communication Strategy Framework (Argenti, 2023)

Central to this framework is setting clear objectives. Leaders should posit, "as a result of this communication, my constituency will" and then retrospectively assess if

those constituencies responded as intended. This assessment enables *strategic communicators* to measure whether their organization is on track to accomplish its desired goals.

In conjunction with this communications framework, Swenson et al. (2018) also outlined a three-step process that *strategic communicators* can use to assess the effectiveness of corporate communications. First, use the findings to adjust communications activities. Second, align communications plans with work across business units. Finally, integrate communication measurement and reporting with other strategic objectives and priorities.

In concert, incorporating these various solutions may help *strategic communicators* overcome several existing barriers to strategy implementation in today's dynamic business landscape.

Conclusion

In this chapter, we explored the powerful effect of having a strong strategy, the benefits of framing and solving the right problems, and the important role of communication in strategy execution. A blend of research, expert articles, interviews, and practitioner insights helped us bring these complex ideas together into a new framework for executive leaders. This framework outlines the potential benefits of developing three core competencies: *strategic leadership, strategic thinking*, and *strategic communication*.

We hope that practitioners and academic researchers reading this chapter feel inspired to think deeply about how this framework can help improve organizational performance. If used properly, we hope that it will change how strategy is formulated and enhance how communication is used to implement it. But as this chapter comes to an end, we encourage our readers to think of this discussion as a starting point rather than a conclusion.

To extend the impact of our proposals and findings, we recommend that future research be conducted through surveys and in-depth interviews with CEOs and CCOs. In particular, we see benefit in examining the correlation between the hierarchy of company statements, strategic principles, and company performance over time. Combined with empirical studies on their effect, new phenomenological research may help develop or challenge our existing theories about *strategic leadership*. Future research could be published in journals renowned for contributing to management practice and theory.

We are optimistic that future researchers may also explore how *strategic thinking* impacts organizational agility. A mixed-methods approach could help researchers examine problem-framing processes used by *strategic thinkers*, hopefully synthesizing quantitative data analysis with qualitative case narratives to show their effectiveness. This would enable both researchers and practitioners to understand how *strategic thinking* influences decision-making, especially in times of uncertainty. It may also help determine whether certain problem-framing approaches have an effect on organizational performance. Journals with reputations for methodological thoroughness could be ideal platforms to engage a broad readership of thought leaders in academia and industry alike.

Our initial inquiry into *strategic communication* was informed by a careful synthesis of scholarly articles and in-depth dialogues with communications executives. Subsequent studies could investigate the efficacy of *strategic communication* through an empirical lens. A methodological shift towards data-driven analysis and interpretive qualitative research could explore the relationship between communication strategies, the role of the "strategic" CCO, and organizational outcomes. Such studies may validate our recommendations and champion the important role played by corporate communication executives in strategy execution.

In addition to studying each of these three core competencies independently, we encourage academics to develop approaches that examine the impact of applying these qualities in unison. Perhaps future work could corroborate our theory that the most meaningful impact on corporate strategy comes from operating at the intersection of *strategic leadership*, *strategic thinking*, and *strategic communication*.

Acknowledgements

I owe special thanks to my co-author and lead researcher, John A. Haynes, for his significant contributions in developing this chapter.

I am also grateful to those we interviewed, whose practical experience in leadership and corporate communication inspired a wealth of insights: Fremont CEO Eric Dachs, Executive Coach Marshall Goldsmith, Korn Ferry's Richard Marshall, Levi's CCO Kelly McGinnis, former Johnson & Johnson CCO Michael Sneed, and Brooks CEO Jim Weber.

Finally, I would like to thank my editors, Guowei Jian and Gail Fairhurst, for asking me to write this chapter and helping to clarify my thinking on this topic.

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INDEX

Note: Page numbers in *italic* type refer to figures; those in **bold** type refer to tables. Endnotes are indicated by the page number followed by 'n' and the note number (128n4).

9/11 attacks 74, 88, 126, 260

Aakhus, M. 216
AARs (after-action reviews) 114, 264
Abdallah, C. 231
ABN Amro 87
abstract, in narratives 294
abstraction 213–214
Abu Bakar, H. 151
abusive communication 101
academies 381
acquaintance phase, leadership making 147, 152
action learning 379
action research 50
activation 9, 138
"activist dissent" 104
actor-network theory (ANT) 60, 62, 331
actors, dialectical and paradoxical perspectives 46, 51
Adame, E. A. 110
adaptive structuration theory (AST) 328, 331
advocate mentoring 164, 168, 171, 172
aesthetics 3, 11, 13, 309–311, 316–317;

and the arts 318–319;
as emotional awareness 317–318;
future research 319–322;
as morality 318;
as sense perception 317
affective event theory 347
affordances 326, 327
African American female leaders 247;
gender-emotional stereotypes 344;
racial and gendered stereotypes 350
after-action reviews (AARs) 114.264
agency: Simpson's typology of 71, **72**;
and technology 327, 331
aggregation, in interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 216
Aguinis, H. 380
AI (artificial intelligence) 11, 13, 128n4, 201, 202, 330–331, 332–335, 336;
framing research 288;
mentoring 173;
organizational learning 383; *see also* technology
Ajslev, J. Z. N. 318
AL (authentic leadership) 97–98, 123, 126, 128, 199, 315, 318, 376, 383
Al Mahameed, M. 233
Alabi, J. 362
Alam, F. 196
Alarcon, M. 97
Allen, B. J. 344
Allen, T. 119, 120–121, 125
Alsarve, D. 83
Alvehus, J. 312
Alvesson, M. 12, 96, 246, 249, 377
ambiguity 120;
ambiguous leadership spaces 29;
strategic communication 399

Amernic, J. 98
Amsalem, E. 278
Anderson, R. D. 346
“Angry Black Woman” gender-emotional stereotype 344
Anheuser-Busch 360
animator 60
ANT (actor-network theory) 60, 62, 331
antithesis (Hegel) 48
Antonakis, J. 2
appearance 314–315
Appelbaum, S. H. 244
Apple 126
applied linguistics and pragmatics 28
Appreciative Inquiry Summits 37
Archambault-Janvier, C. 231
Argyris, C. 381–382
Aristotle 133
Armenakis, A. A. 227
Aromaa, E. 27
“arresting moments” 40
artefacts, and leadership 76
artificial intelligence (AI) *see* AI (artificial intelligence)
arts, the, and aesthetics 318–319
Arvedsen, L. D. 312
Ashcraft, K. L. 6, 84
Ashforth B. 341
Ashkanasay, N. M. 347
Asian American leaders, racial and gendered stereotypes 350
AST (adaptive structuration theory) 328, 331
Atwood, M.A. 375
authentic leadership (AL) 97–98, 123, 126, 128, 199, 315, 318, 376, 383
author 60
authoring 124;

interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 212–213, 214
authoritarian leadership, and emotion 347
authority 124;
interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 209, 211–214
automation 11, 13, 327, 330–334, 336; *see also* technology
Auvinen, T. 304
Average Leadership Styles 147
Avolio, B. J. 342, 345
Aycan, Z. 344

babble hypothesis 183
Badura, K. L. 183
Bain & Company 399
Baker, C. R. 150, 154, 155
Bales, R. F. 183
Ballmer, S. 310–311, 314, 316–317, 319
Balogun, J. 230
Balwani, R. 99–100
Bamberg, M. 298
Banks, G. C. 343–344
Barad, K. 314
Barfod, J. R. 59
Barge, J.K. 2, 39, 41, 229, 232
Barnard, C. 212
Barnes, L. Y. 284
Barrett, A. K. 328
Barthold, C. 35
Bass, B. M. 179–180, 342
Basten, D. 373, 380, 381
Bateson, G. 34, 277
Bathurst, R. 314, 315, 316, 317, 319
Baxter, J. 315
Bayraktar, S. 227
Beal, B. 243

Ben and Jerry's 359
Bencherki, N. 59, 60
benign violation theory 347
Benoit-Barné, C. 61, 65
Berdahl. J. L. 83
Bergen, H. B. 243
Berson, Y. 225
Besharov, M. L. 49
Bezos, J. 313
Bien, C. 228
big story narratives 294–295
biological origins of ethics 107–108
BIPOC (Black, Indigenous, and People of Color) people 360, 366
Bisel, R. 61, 108, 110, 112, 113, 115, 124, 128, 245, 246–247
Black Lives Matter (BLM) 358, 360, 361
Black women leaders 305, 367
Blanco, K. 74
Bligh, M. C. 227
body, the 2;
  embodied moral knowing 114–115; *see also* embodiment
Boeing 50, 86
Bohm, D. 34, 36
Boje, D. M. 229, 313
Bono, J. E. 196
boomers, and mentoring 169
Booz Allen Hamilton 392
Botero, I. C. 154
Bouilloud, J.-P. 318
boundary spanning, in interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 217–218, 219
bounded rationality 109
Boyer, E. J. 208
Boyraz, M. 195
Brescoll, V. L. 344

bring-your-own-device-to-work (BYOD) 329
Brooks Running Company 392
Brown, E. 103
Brown, W. 365
Brughmans, F. 51
Brummans, B. 60
Buchanan, D. 229
Bud Light 360
buildings, architecture and power differentials 85
Bull, P. 315, 319
bullshit 96, 102–103
bullying 85, 168; *see also* toxic leadership communication
Bush, G. W. 87–88, 125
Bush, H. 367
Bushe, G.R. 37
Butler, D. 185
Butler, J. 314
Butterfield, K. D. 347
Button, J. 101
Buzzanell, P. M. 172, 173, 174, 366, 380
BYOD (bring-your-own-device-to-work) 329

Cain, T. 314, 315, 316, 319
California wildfires 312
Cameron, G. T. 260
caring leaders 298
Carreyrou, J. 99, 100
Carroll, B. 24, 75–76, 78, 124, 248, 312, 313, 316
Carsten, M. K. 227
Cartwright, D. 342
CASA (computers as social actors) 332
Cashman, J. F. 152
Caza, A. 345

CCO (communicative constitution of organization) 1–2, 8, 28, 42, 59–60, 61, 65–66, 71, **72**, 76, 77, 78, 84, 137, 312;
identity-constitutive leadership communication 119, 123–124, 128;
and leadership 62–65, *63*;
leadership-as-practice (L-A-P) **72**, 73–74;
sociomateriality 13;
temporality 12; *see also* Montreal School
Cerulo, K. 88
Challenger disaster 86
change *see* organizational change (OC)
change managerialism 233
charismatic leadership 2, 3, 6, 82, 179, 180, 246, 358;
and emotion 342, 346, 347
Chaskalson, M. 3
Chen, J. 375
Chiang, J. T. J. 347
Chief Communications Officers (CCOs) 397, 398, 402
Chin, J. 360
China, Contaminated Milk crisis, 2008 256
Chinese women political leaders 367
Chittipeddi, K. 259
Choudhary, A.I. 375
Chreim, S. 29
Chronicle of Higher Education 136
Ciulla, J. 84
Claeys, A. S. 260
Clifton, J. 23, 62, 98, 296, 313, 315
climate change 265
clothing *see* appearance
CLS (critical leadership studies) 81–82
coaching 165;
and framing 283;
leadership coaching 379;

by team leaders 378; *see also* mentoring
Cockburn, C. 89
co-construction 3, 27
coda, in narratives 294
coercive communication 85; *see also* toxic leadership communication
"coercive persuasion" 100
cognition, crisis decision making 261
cognitive/psychological perspectives on leader identity 121–122
collaboration *see* interorganizational collaboration (IOC)
collaborative leadership 19, 363
collaborative mentoring 164, 168, 169–170, 173
collective leadership 2, 7, 19–20, 58, 234, 365;
co-production of 24;
interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 211;
and learning 383;
as a "lens" 7, 19, 24, **25–26**, 26, 28;
methodological approaches 20;
and power 7, 19–20, 26–28;
as a "type" 7, 19, 20, **21–23**, 23–24, 28
collective movements, leadership in 358–359
Collinson, D. 4, 48, 49, 89, 135, 242, 358
Collinson, M. 70, 71, **72**, 73
Colquitt, J. A. 226
co-mentoring circles *see* collaborative mentoring
Comfort, L. K. 261, 262, 265
"committee, the," in interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 213–214
communication: corporate communications 397, 398–402, *401*;
crisis decision making 261;
early theory and practice 133–135
communication metatheory 6
communication skills 168;
dialogue as reflective inquiry 37–38
communication theory, and social influence 132, 133

communication visibility 327–328
communicative constitution of organization (CCO) *see* CCO (communicative constitution of organization)
communicative content 183–184
communicative practice, leadership as 74–76
complementarity over conflict 75
complexity leadership 19, 20; *see also* collective leadership
complexity theory 358
compliance gaining 283–284, **285**
complication, in narratives 294
computers as social actors (CASA) 332
concealment, in organizational collaboration (IOC) 219
conflict management 48
conformity, paradox of 120
Confucian cultures, and humor 349
Conger, J. 58, 62, 342
Connaughton, S, L. 84, 98, 122, 163, 192, 194, 195, 196, 200–201, 309, 341
Connell, R. W. 83
constitutive social process, leadership communication as 1–4
constructionism 1, 2
contingency model of leadership 342
contingency reward leadership 376
contingency theory of accommodation 261
contradiction 45, 48, 51, 52;
  contradiction principle 47
contrast, in framing 281, **281**, 283
control: control dynamics, critical perspectives 8, 81–82;
  crisis decision making 261; *see also* power
conventional MDL (message design logic) 279, 280
conversation: conversational performance 226, 229, 232;
  conversational shares 182–183;
  conversational travel 75;
  meaningful conversations in mentoring 171–172

conversation analysis 29, 60, 296, 301, 315, 317, 320
conversational-poetic stance 40
Conzon, V. 366
Coombs, W. T. 260
cooperation 211
coordination 211;
  crisis decision making 261
Cooren, F. 60, 61–62, 65, 74, 124, 312
co-production, of collective leadership 24
Cornelissen, J. P. 230
Corple, D. J. 169–170
Corporate Communication Strategy Framework *401*, 401–402
corporate communications 397, 398–402, *401*
Corporate Social Advocacy (CSA) 359, 360
corporate social responsibility 107, 108
corporate "universities" 380
corruption, and power 86
Cortellazzo, L. 201
cosmological episodes 256
COVID-19 pandemic 192, 256, 330, 358, 382
co-worker exchange (CWX) 155
CQ (cultural intelligence) 362–363
Craddock, H. A. 262
Craig, R. 1, 4, 10, 98
Crenshaw, K. 174
Crespy, D. 23
Crevani, L. 70, 73, 78
crises 359;
  mentoring in 173–174
crisis leadership 10, 255–257;
  crisis-based leader identity 9, 119, 125–126;
  decision making and crisis management 260–262;
  future research 264–265;

monitoring and risk sensing 257–258;
organizational learning 263–264;
preparation for future crises 264;
recovery and renewal 262–263, 265;
sense giving and meaning sharing 259–260;
sensemaking and meaning making 258–259;
temporality 12
crisis management 10, 260–262
critical dialectical leadership perspective 48, 49
critical discourse analysis 28, 296
critical leadership 71, **72**
critical leadership studies (CLS) 81–82
"critical performativity" 2
critical perspectives 8, 81–82, 90;
future research 90;
gendered leadership 82–83;
power and communication 83–88;
power-resistance dialiectics 88–90;
Prozac leadership communication 6, 8, 87–88, 89, 90;
toxic leadership communication 8, 85–87, 89, 90
critical race theory (CRT) 366
critical scholarship 2, 5, 6, 12;
resistance 241, 242, 245–246, 249–250
critical studies of men and masculinity (CSMM) 83
Crossan, M. 380–381
CRT (critical race theory) 366
CSA (Corporate Social Advocacy) 359, 360
CSMM (critical studies of men and masculinity) 83
cultivation 9, 138
culture: cultural intelligence (CQ) 362–363;
cultural origins of ethics 107–108;
and humor 348–349;
leader-member exchange (LMX) 154

Cunha, M. P. 232
Cunliffe, A. L. 38, 39, 40
curiosity, in dialogue 38
CWX (co-worker exchange) 155
Czarniawska, B. 229

Dachs, E. 400
Dalisay, F. 150
Daly, J. A. 192, 194, 195, 196, 200–201
Damiani, J. 304
dark side of leadership 6, 8, 96, 103–104, 127, 246;
  bullshit and lies in 96, 102–103;
  communication 98–104;
  definitions of 96–98;
  emotion 342;
  hubristic leadership communication 96, 100–101;
  subordination of self to corporate purpose 101–102; *see also* power
Dasborough, M. T. 343
Davis, K. 174
Dawson, P. 229
De Fina, A. 297
de Laat, K. 199
dead-asleep test 396
deception 103
DeChurch, L. A. 201
"decision communication" 124
decision making: crisis leadership 10, 260–262;
  hypermasculine cultures 86;
  tensions of strategic communication decision-making (TSCD) 260–261
Decker, W. H. 348
decolonial leadership 248–249
decolonisation 359
Deepwater Horizon oil spill 119, 121, 125
Deetz, S. A. 6, 35, 172, 217

DEI (diversity, equity and inclusion) *see* diversity, equity and inclusion (DEI)
Del Fa, S. 74
delegation 184
DeMatthews, D. 362
D'Enbeau, S. 366
Denis, J. L. 220
DeNisi, A. S. 226–227
DeRue, D. S. 13n2, 179
DeSanctis, G. 328
Deslandes, G. 318
destructive leadership 97; *see also* dark side of leadership
developmental networks *see* mentoring networks
Dewulf, A. 41, 278, 282
dialectical materialism 47
dialectical perspective 8, 45–46, **46–47**, 51–52, 358;
  "dialecting the paradox" 52;
  historical and current theory **46**, 47–48;
  leadership communication **47**, 48–49;
  "paradoxing the dialectic" 52
dialectics 2, 12, 45, 233
dialogic tradition/models of communication 2, 3–4
"*dialogical discomfort*" 37
dialogical leading 7–8, 33;
  contours of dialogue 33–35;
  future research 41–42;
  as reflective inquiry 36–38;
  as relational becoming 38–41
dialogical organizational development 37
dialogue 5;
  containers for 37;
  dialogical leading 33–35;
  discursive coordination 34;
  generativity 35;

holism 34–35;
productive 35;
reproductive 35;
safe space for 37;
tensionality 35
differentiation rhetoric 230
digital storytelling 304; *see also* storytelling
digital technology *see* technology
dimensions, in narratives 294
disability: power and inequality issues 83
discourse 6
discourse analysis 60, 301;
identity-constitutive leadership communication 119, 123
Discourse (big "D" discourse) 3, 27, 84, 128n4, 298
discourse (little "d" discourse) 27, 128n4
discursive coordination 34
discursive leadership 6, 9, 36, 58–59, 84, 137
discursive perspectives on leader identity 121–122
discursive processes/strategies, collective leadership 24–25
discursive strategies, dialectical perspective 49
disruption: mentoring in 173–174; *see also* crises
dissent 244–245; *see also* resistance
distanced leadership 192; *see also* virtual leadership
distanciation 213
distributed leadership 19, 20, 58, 59, 201;
interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 209, 211;
and learning 376–377; *see also* collective leadership
distributed work 193
diversity, and mentoring 168, 170, 361
diversity, equity and inclusion (DEI) 11, 357–359, 367;
backlashes against 359;
demanding leadership for 359–361;
leading for 361–364;

to transform leadership 364–367
Dixon, K. R. 194
Dóci, E. 182
Dollar General Corporation, “DGU” 380
Donahue, J. D. 210
Donohue, W. A. 278, 279
Dorris, A. D. 347
double loop learning 373, 381–382
downsizing, narratives of 62
Drake, L. E. 278
Duke, D. L. 316
Dulebohn, L. H. 151
Duncan, S. L. 151
Dutta, M. J. 258
dynamic network analysis 28

Eagly, A. 360
Eby, L. T. 167–168
Edelman, P. J. 344, 351
EFI (Equitable Food Initiative) 248
EI (emotional intelligence) 362–363
Eichenseer, V. 181
Einarson, S. 97
Einola, K. 96
Einstein, A. 393, 394
Eisenberg, E. M. 120
Eisenhower Matrix 393–394, *394*
Elaboration Likelihood Model 227
elasticity, paradox of 120
embodiment 11, 13, 309–311, 313–314;
as appearance 314–315;
embodied moral knowing 114–115;
future research 319–322;
as gesture 315;

positioning of bodies in space 315–316; *see also* body, the
e-mentoring 173; *see also* mentoring
emergence, in interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 216
emergent leadership 182, 196
emotion 11, 341–343, 349–350;
characteristics/competencies/functions of leaders 343–344;
future research 350–351;
and gender 344, 348–349, 350;
implications for practice 351;
negative 342, 344, 345–346;
in organizational change (OC) research 234;
positive 344, 345;
relational functions of 344–347; *see also* empathy; humor
emotional contagion theory 347
emotional intelligence (EI) 362–363
empathy 351;
female leaders 344; *see also* emotion
employee experience, leader-member exchange (LMX) 153–155, 156
employee resistance *see* resistance
employee voice, leader-member exchange (LMX) 154
Empson, L. 295
empty signifier, leadership as 226, 232, 233
Endrissat, N. 70
engagement, in interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 217
English language, and remote/hybrid working 198
Enron 4, 5, 85, 107, 108, 112, 246
Ensher, E. A. 180
enterprise social media (ESM) 327, 329
entity, paradox of 120
environmental leadership 248
Episcopal Church 49
episodic mentoring 164, 168, 170–171, 172–173
episodic power 12, 241, 242–243, 249

Equitable Food Initiative (EFI) 248
equity *see* diversity, equity and inclusion (DEI)
Erez, A. 346
Erez, M. 286
Erickson, M. 38
ERO (ethically-reliable organization) theory 111–116
Erskine, S. 360
ESM (enterprise social media) 327, 329
ESPN 361
ethical leadership 126, 128, 244, 298, 343–344, 376
ethics 8, 107–108;
  embodied moral knowing 114–115;
  ethically-reliable organization (ERO) theory 111–116;
  framing research 288;
  future research 112, 113, 114;
  high-reliability teams and organizations (HRT&Os) 110–111;
  institutionalizing ethical excellence 112–113;
  interpersonal consideration 113;
  leadership framing and culture 108–109;
  mentoring 168;
  moral mindlessness and organizational communication patterns 109–110;
  moral/ethical leaders identity 9, 119, 126–127;
  SEO (sensitivity to the ethics of operation) 115–116;
  simplification of ethical applications 113–114
ethnicity: power and inequality issues 83; *see also* racism
ethnomethodology 29
evaluation, in narratives 294
Evans, T. R. 347
"everyone-to-everyone" learning 381
exchanges 150; *see also* leader-member exchange (LMX)
executive coaching 379
experiential learning 264
exploration, in interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 217

expression, in interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 217
expressive MDL (message design logic) 279, 280

fabrication 277
face-to-face interactions, power differentials in 84–85
facilitators, communication skills 37–38
Fairhurst, G.T. 2, 3, 6, 9, 26, 27, 41, 48, 49, 50, 52, 58–59, 62, 71, **72**, 73, 74, 84, 98, 101, 103, 122, 123, 125, 135, 137, 148, 149, 150, 157, 163, 200, 201, 231, 232, 233, 242, 246, 247, 248, 258, 280–282, **281**, 309, 312, 318, 341, 358, 364, 374, 377, 380
Farh, C. I. C. 184
Farrell, M. 103
Fayol, H. 212
FBI 88
Feidler, F. E. 342
feminine leadership 366
feminist studies 82–83, 89;
  and mentoring 169–170; *see also* gender; women
Fenton, C. 293
Ferris, G. R. 155
Finkelstein, L. 167
Finkelstein, S. 104
Fiol, C. M. 230
Fischer, T. 97, 127
Fix, B. 150–151
Flannery, J. 389–390
Fletcher, J. 28
Flier, J. 136
floating signifier, leadership as 69, 226, 233
Foldy, E. 27, 245
Ford, H. 400
Ford, J. 97
Ford, J. D. 225, 229
Ford, L. W. 225, 229

Ford Motor Company 389, 390, 395
forethought, in framing skills **281**, 282
Foronda, C. 362
Foroughi, H. 295
Forsyth, D. R. 132–133
Fortune 99, 101
Foucault, M. 84, 85–86, 128n4
framing 10, 40, 41, 76, 273–274, **275–276**, 377;
  anthropological/sociological approach 273, **275–276**, 277;
  art of enacting 280–283, **281**;
  coaching and training 283;
  cognitive/social psychological approach 273, **275–276**, 277–278;
  of crises 259;
  ethics 108–109;
  future research 286–287;
  gain/loss framing 277–278;
  implementing framing skills 282;
  interactional/relational approach 273, **275–276**, 278–279;
  issue-selling 273, 286–287;
  language, thought and forethought, in framing skills **281**, 281–282;
  message design logics (MDL) approach 273, **275–276**, 279–280, 287;
  related persuasive strategies 283–286, **285**;
  research challenges 287–288;
  sensegiving 273, 274;
  sensemaking 280;
  vision casting 273, 279
Frankfurt, H. 102
Freire, P. 34
Friedrich, T. 23
Frimann, S. 40
functional leadership 179, 181–182
functional-realist approach, organizational narrative analysis 295
Furunes, T. 154

future of work concept 330
future research 11–13;
  crisis leadership 264–265;
  critical perspectives 90;
  dialogical leading 41–42;
  emotion and humor 350–351;
  ethics 112, 113, 114;
  framing 286–287;
  identity-constitutive leadership communication 127–128;
  interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 12, 218–219;
  leader-member exchange (LMX) 12, 157–158;
  leadership narratives and storytelling 304–305;
  leadership-as-practice (L-A-P) 12, 76–78;
  materiality, embodiment and aesthetics 319–322;
  mentoring 173–175;
  organisational strategy 402;
  organizational learning 383;
  resistance 249–250;
  social influence 139–140;
  team leadership 12, 186;
  virtual leadership 200–202
Future Search 36, 37
Fyke, J. P. 380

Gabaldon, P. 248
Gabriel, Y. 102, 103
Gadiesh, O. 399
Gagnon, S. 321
gain framed messages 277–278
Gajendran, R. S. 181
Galea, N. 83
gamification 383
Garcia-Morales, V. J. 376
Garner, J. T. 244

Garreau, L. 400
Garvin, D. 373, 381
Gates, B. 400
Gates, Bill 265
Gayá Wicks, P. 321
Geis, F. L. 185
gender: appearance 314–315;
emotion 344, 348–349, 350;
gendered leadership 82–83, 90;
humor 348–349;
leadership 298;
mentoring 174;
remote/hybrid working 199;
resistance 89; *see also* men; women
General Electric 102, 389–390
generalized symmetry 60
generational differences, reverse mentoring 169
generativity 35
Gentry, W. A. 344
Georgakopoulou, A. 294, 297
Gergen, K. J. 33, 34, 78
Gerpott, F. H. 184
Gibbs, J. L. 194, 195, 198
Gibson, C. B. 194
Gibson, L. 234
gig economy 201
Gigliotti, R. 98, 309, 310, 320
Gilstrap, C. A. 259
Gioia, D. E. 259
Girls Who Code 298–300
Giuliani, R. 74, 126
Global Financial Crash, 2007–2008 87, 88;
banking CEOs' evidence 98–99

Global South, remote work 201
Glomb, T. M. 346
Goffman, E. 60, 277, 319
Golden, T. D. 196
Goldsmith, M. 396, 400
Goldthwaite, C. 233
Goodwin, C. 59
Gordon, R. 24, 27
Graen, G. B. 146, 152
Grant, D. 122, 125
graphic representations 59
Grashow, A. 321
grassroots leadership 358–359, 365
“great man” leadership 58
Green, S. G. 155
Gregory, M. R. 83
Grint, K. 39, 59, 62, 65, 74, 104, 125, 296, 312, 321, 393, 394
Gronn, P. 29
Groom, R. 234
Gröschl, S. 248
Guiette, A. 233, 234
Guthey, E. 313, 318

Haaman, T. 373, 380, 381
Hall-Merenda, K. E. 192
hallucinations 336
Hamlett, S.R. 149
Hansen, H. 59, 309, 317
Hargie, O. 98–99, 103
Hargrave, T. J. 50
Harikkala-Laihinen, R. 234
Harkins, B. 312, 313
Hassert, L. O. 312
Hawkins, B. 313

Heath, R. G. 217
Hedlund, E. 378, 379
Hedman, E. 39, 41
Hegel, G. W. F. 48
hegemony: hegemonic masculinity 83;
  and resistance 246–247, 250
Heifetz, R. 321
here-and-now ethics talk 8, 108, 110, 113
hermeneutic leadership 40, 232
heroic leadership 71, **72**, 81, 82, 83, 104, 246, 298, 320
Hersted, L. 40, 78
heteroglossia 38
hierarchical mum effect 245
High Reliability Organizing (HRO) 258
high-reliability teams and organizations (HRT&Os) 110–111
Hill, N. S. 227
Hill, S. E. K. 163
Hindenberg Research 103
Hindmarsh, J. 320
Hirolla, T. 201
Hoch, J. E. 196
Höddinghaus, M. 194
holism, and dialogue 34–35
Holm, F. 26, 27, 312
Holmes, E. 99–100
Holmes, J. 83, 347
Homburg, C. 226
homosociality 83
Hoogeboom, M. A. 180
Hooper, D. T. 156
Howell, J. M. 192
HRO (High Reliability Organizing) 258
HRT&Os (high-reliability teams and organizations) 110–111

Hseih, C. 98
hubristic leadership communication 96, 100–101
Huffaker, D. 195
Hulin, C. L. 346
humans: human actants 8, 60, 61, 62, 65;
  symmetry with objects 312–313
Humberd, B. 167
humor 231, 343, 347–349, 351;
  and gender 348–349; *see also* emotion
Humphrey, R. H. 349–350
Humphreys, D. 27
Hurricane Katrina 74, 88, 119, 125, 256, 312
Huy, Q. 234
hybrid and virtual contexts, mentoring 173
hybrid leadership 201
hybrid work 9–10, 13, 192–193, 194–195, 198–199, 200, 201, 202; *see also* remote work; virtual work
hybridity 74
hypermasculinity 6, 83

IBM 126
ICA Audit 1, 2
ICTs (information and communication technologies) *see* technology
identity construction 295
identity-constitutive leadership communication 8–9, 119–121;
  CCO (communicative constitution of organization) 119, 123–124, 128;
  cognitive psychology and discursive perspectives 121–122;
  crisis-based leader identity 9, 119, 125–126;
  discourse analysis 119, 123;
  future research 127–128;
  membership categorization analysis (MCA) 41, 119, 122–123, 127–128;
  moral/ethical leader identity 9, 119, 126–127
immigrants, leader-member exchange (LMX) 154
inclusion *see* diversity, equity and inclusion (DEI)

inclusive leadership 362
inclusivity, and mentoring 174
incongruity theory 347
influence: and framing 280;
  issue selling 286–287;
  related persuasive strategies 283–286, **285**; *see also* social influence
informal leadership 136–137
information: control and withholding of 85–86, 89;
  unidirectional communication and dark side leadership 100
information and communication technologies (ICTs) *see* technology
information transfer model of leadership communication 3, 5–6, 83
informational justice 226
in-groups 146, 151, 154
integration rhetoric 230
integrative leadership 19; *see also* collective leadership
inter-action 71, **72**
interaction analysis 29, 60
inter-action, communication as 71, **72**, 73
interaction design 215–217, 219
interaction process analysis scheme 183
interactional framing 41
Interactional Sociolinguistics 296
interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 10, 208–209, 220;
  and authority 209, 211–214;
  background on 209–211;
  boundary-spanning and translation 217–218;
  future research 12, 218–219;
  interaction design 215–217;
  leadership challenges 214–218;
  meaningful participation in 216;
  organizationality 212, 219;
  trust and legitimacy in 215;
  visibility 218–219

interpretive approach, organizational narrative analysis 295
interpretivism 5, 6
intersectionality 360, 367;
  emotion and leadership 344, 350;
  mentoring 174
invisibility, in organizational collaboration (IOC) 219
IOC (interorganizational collaboration) *see* interorganizational collaboration (IOC)
Isaacs, W. 37
Islam, K. 263
Israel-Hamas war 136
issue-selling 273, 286–287
Iszatt-White, M. 78, 123

Jabri, M. 229
Jackson, B. 313, 318
Jackson, S. R. 366
Jacquart, P. 2
James, K. T. 377
Jamjoon, L. A. 305
Janssens, M. 317–318, 361, 362–363
Jansson, D. 321
jargon, in framing 281, **281**, 283
Jarzabkowski, P. 231
Jayyusi, L. 123
Jean-Marie, G. 363
Jian, G. 40, 69, 73, 76, 149, 150, 153–154, 226, 230, 231, 232, 233, 242, 318, 351, 374
Jiminez-Luque, A. 248–249
Jin, Y. 260
job security 227
Jobs, S. 126, 293
Johnson & Johnson 391
Johnstone, B. 294
Joshi, A. 181

Jouillié, J. E. 27, 100
journaling studies 383

Kabasakal, H. 227
Kahneman, D. 277–278, 395
Kalbfleisch, P. J. 165
Karakowsky, L. 349
Kärreman, P. 74
Katz, A.M. 40
Katz-Buonincontro, J. 316
Kelan, E. K. 314
Kelly, S. 5, 122, 232
Kempster, S. 77, 78
Kenda, R. 197–198
Kerr, R. 125–126
keying 277
Khan, A. S. 228
Kim, J. 157
Kim, M. J. 170
Kim, S. K. 170
King, D. 392
Kipnis, D. 273, 284
Kirkpatrick, D. L. 382
Kirkpatrick, J. D. 382
Kirkpatrick, W. K. 382
Knight, E. 51
knotted paradoxes 231
knowing 375
knowledge creation 375
knowledge management 375
Kohlberger, M. 62
Koivunen, N. 316, 317, 319
Koning, L. F. 346
Kotter, J. 396

Kouzes, J. M. 375
Kozlowski, S. W. J. 196
Kraiger, K. 380
Kraimer, M. L. 153
Kramer, M. 23
Kreiner, G. E. 49
Krysfeldt, M. 89
Ktam, K. 165
Kuhn, T. 59, 75, 78, 123–124, 213
Kulik, B. 97

Labov, W. 294
Ladder of Inference 38
Ladkin, D. 309, 315, 316, 317, 318, 319, 365, 366–367
Langley, A. 293, 396
language: in framing skills 281, **281**;
  interactional sociolinguistic perspective on 301
Larson, L. 201
Larsson, M. 24, 318
Latour, B. 60, 62, 65
Lauche, K. 286
"lay ontologies" 48
LBGTQAI+ people 360
Le, J. K. 231
leader communication: organizational learning 375–377;
  unidirectional communication and dark side leadership 100
leader framing 108–109
leader identity *see* identity-constitutive leadership communication
leader-follower encounters 34–35
leader-member exchange (LMX) 2, 9, 145, 196;
  communicative nature of 149–151;
  employee experience 153–155, 156;
  evolution of theory 146–147;
  future research 12, 157–158;

groups and teams 147, 155–156;
implications of 156–157;
Leader-Member Conversational Quality (LMCQ) Scale 149, 150;
Leader-Member Exchange Conversational Quality Scale 2;
leadership making 147, 149, 152;
LMSX scale 150;
LMX-7 scale 148, 150;
relationship quality 151–153;
team leadership communication 179, 181;
theoretical underpinnings and outcomes 148–149;
vertical dyad linkage model (VDL) 146, 147; *see also* mentoring
leadership 58–59, 96, 163;
and authority 209;
care and justice-centered 172;
and diversity 358, 360;
early theory and practice 133–135;
episodic power 241, 242–243, 249;
exclusionary practices of 358;
"successes" and "failures" 137–138; *see also* resistance
leadership communication 374;
as change information management 10, 226–228;
as a constitutive social process 1–4;
context overview 9–10;
as discursive struggle over power and control 10, 226, 232–233;
future of 11–13;
hubristic 86, 100–101;
as influential communicative performance 10, 226, 228–232;
as metadiscourse 4–7;
practice overview 10–11;
skills 37–38;
theory overview 7–9
leadership development 321, 383;
and diversity 361;

leadership-as-practice (L-A-P) 75–76, 78;
resistance leadership 248;
and team leadership communication 185; *see also* mentoring; organizational learning
leadership influence *see* social influence
leadership making 147, 149, 152
leadership narratives and storytelling 10–11, 293;
discursive approaches to 296;
discursive context 297, 298;
empirical research 296–303;
future research 304–305;
implications for practice 303–304;
local interaction context 297;
narratives about leadership 293, 296–300;
narratives doing leadership 293, 300–303;
organizational narrative analysis 295–296;
sociocultural contexts 297, 298, 304–305;
temporality 12;
theoretical foundations 293–296
leadership psychology 1, 4–5, 9
Leadership Quarterly, *The* 98
leadership resonance 9, 132, 135, 137–139
leadership typologies 71, **72**, 73–74
leadership-as-practice (L-A-P) 8, 26, 28, 35, 69;
and dialogic leading 36;
distinguishing communication in 71, **72**, 73–74;
future research 12, 76–78;
leadership as communicative practice 74–76;
searching for "communication" in 70–71
learning: and power dynamics 34; *see also* leadership development; organizational learning
learning academies 381
learning competencies 381–382
learning organizations 373–378; *see also* organizational learning

Least-Preferred Coworker Scale 342
Ledbetter, B. 249
Lee, J. 151
Lee, S. M. 184
Lee, Y. 359
legitimacy, interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 215, 219
Lemoine, G. J. 127, 128
Leonardi, P. M. 329, 335
Leslie, L. 361, 364
leveling 243
Lewis, K. M. 345–346
Lewis, L. K. 225, 227, 228
lies 103
Linsky, M. 321
listening 37
Little, M. 39
Littlefield, R. S. 260–261
Liu, E. H. 3, 5
Liu, H. 313, 318
Llewellyn, N. 320
Lloyd, R. 78
LMX (leader-member exchange) *see* leader-member exchange (LMX)
"locus of leadership" 19, 20
Logan, N. 364–365
Logemann, M. 229, 232
Long, Z. 170, 174
Lopez, A. 363
loss framed messages 277–278
Luhmann, N. 124
Luhmannian Systems Theory 124, 128
Lumby, J. 85
Lundholm, S. E. 24
Lungeanu, A. 197

Lynch, O. H. 349

Machiavelli, N. 103
MacKillop, E. 232
MacLaren, N. G. 183
Maclean, M. 399
management-by-exception 147
managerialism: change managerialism 233
managing up 284
Manolopoulos, M. 248
Mantere, S. 228
March, J. G. 375
Maritime Transportation Security Act, US 260
Marra, M. 347
Marshak, R.J. 37
Marshall, H. 97
Marshall, R. 396
Martin, R. 156
Marwell, G. 284
Marx, K. 47
masculinity: "aggrieved masculinity" 84;
  male-dominated leadership 82–83; *see also* men
MasterCard 399
materiality 2, 11, 42, 59, 74, 309–311;
  constituting persons as leaders 313;
  critical perspectives 90;
  future research 319–322;
  humans and objects as symmetrical 312–313;
  in organizational change (OC) research 234;
  as a resource for performing leadership 311–312
mature partnership phase, leadership making 147
Maupin, C. 28
Mawhinne, H. 362
Mayer, C. 196–197

Mayer, J. D. 351
Mayfield, J. 126, 181
Mayfield, M. 126, 181
McCabe, A. 293
McColl-Kennedy, J. R. 346
McCornack, S. A. 280
McCoy, J. 125
McDonald, R. 313
McFerrin, B. 317
McGuire, T. 52
McKinsey & Company 392, 394, 395
McPhee, R. D. 242
MDL (message design logics) 273, **275–276**, 279–280, 287
meaning 3;
  communication as 71, **72**
meaning making, in crisis leadership 10, 258–259
meaning sharing, in crisis leadership 10, 259–260
Médecins Sans Frontières (Doctors without Borders) 61
Mehraein, V. 96–97
Meier, F. 124, 313
Meindl, J. R. 133
membership categorization 41, 296
membership categorization analysis (MCA): identity-constitutive leadership communication 41, 119, 122–123, 127–128
men: "aggrieved masculinity" and victimhood 84;
  gendered leadership 82–83, 90;
  male-dominated leadership 82–83;
  masculine subcultures 86, 89;
  sexual harassment 83, 86; *see also* gender
Menges, J. I. 347
mental health, and diversity, equity and inclusion (DEI) 358
mentoring 9, 163–164;
  advocate 164, 168, 171, 172;

alternative forms of 164, 165, 166;
beyond U.S./European workplaces 174–175;
clustered 166;
collaborative 164, 168, 169–170, 173;
as developmental relational processes 164–165;
and diversity 170, 361;
episodic 164, 168, 170–171, 172–173;
four phases of 165;
future research 173–175;
intersectionality and inclusivity 174;
leadership communication in alternative mentoring 171–172;
leadership making 152;
meaningful conversations in 171–172;
mentee socialization through role development process 167;
mentee-mentor matching 166–167;
negative experiences 167–168;
networks 164, 168, 170, 173;
nonhuman sources 170;
reverse 164, 168, 169, 172, 173;
traditional 165–166, 169, 170;
workplace technology 173;
young employees 156; *see also* leader-member exchange (LMX); leadership development
Mentoring Enactment Theory (MET) 165
Mergen, A. 127
Mesinioti, P. 316
message design logics (MDL) 273, **275–276**, 279–280, 287
MET (Mentoring Enactment Theory) 165
metadiscourse 1, 4–7
metaphors 281, **281**, 283, 377
metatheoretical epistemologies 5
#MeToo movement 83, 86, 361
Microsoft: Autism Hiring Program 359; *see also* Ballmer, S.

Milam, J. M. 217
military operations, Afghanistan, ventriloquial analysis 62–65, *63*
millennials, mentoring 164, 169
Milliken, F. J. 244
Mills, A. J. 305
Milton, T. 103
mindfulness 35, 51;
  high-reliability teams and organizations (HRT&Os) 111;
  moral 8, 111–112
Miron-Spektor, E. 348
mission statement 390–391
MIT learning organization and dialogue projects 36
Mitchell, T. D. 183–184
Mitra, R. 248
m-learning 382
Moglia, M. 201
monitoring, crisis leadership 10, 257–258
Montiero, R. A. A. 37
Montreal School 59–62, 124, 212
moral foundations theory 107, 108
moral intuitions 107–108, 109
moral mindfulness 8, 111–112
moral mindlessness 110
moral psychology 107
moral/ethical leader identity 9, 119, 126–127
Morgan, G. 84
Morgeson, F. P. 286
Mortion-Thiokol 86
Motro, D. 350
Mueller, B. H. 151
Muhr, S. L. 314–315
Mullaly, A. 389, 390, 395
Mulvaney, D. 360

Murphy, M.W. 169
Murphy, S. E. 180
Musk, E. 101–102, 313

narratives: narrative performance 226, 228, 229–230, 231;
  narrative theory 148–149; *see also* leadership narratives and storytelling
Native Americans 248–249
negative emotion 342, 344, 345–346
Nelson, T. A. 155
neo-charisma theories 4–5
neoliberalism 365
networked leadership 19, 23; *see also* collective leadership
Neuman, A. 100
neuroplasticity, and learning 381, 382
Nguyen, T. 317–318
Nichols, R. 361
Nicholson, H. 248
Nielsen, R. K. 51, 120–121
Nijstad, B. A. 245
Nike 360
Nikola 103
Nkomo, S. 357, 366
#NoBanNoWall 361
Nonaka, I. 48
nonverbal communication 136, 184–185, 304
norms 109

Obama, Barack 61–62
objects, symmetry with humans 312–313
Oborn, E. 312
OC (organizational change) *see* organizational change (OC)
Occupy Wall Street 249
O'Connor, P. 85
OD (organizational development), dialogical organizational development 37

ODA (organizational discourse analysis) 28, 123
Offord, M. 243
O'Keefe, B. J. 279, 280
Omilion-Hodges, L. M. 150, 154, 155, 156, 158
online settings 42
Open Space 37
openness 226
Oreg, S. 225
organizational change (OC) 10, 48–49, 225–226, 235;
  change information management 10, 226–228;
  discursive struggle over power and control 10, 226, 232–233;
  future research 234–235;
  Hegelian dialectics 48;
  influential communicative performance 10, 226, 228–232;
  leadership narratives and storytelling 304;
  strategic change framing research 286;
  temporality 12; *see also* resistance
organizational culture: diversity, equality and inclusion (DEI) 361–362;
  ethics 108, 109, 111;
  humor 349;
  leadership framing 108–109;
  masculine subcultures 86, 89;
  "one-company" culture 389, 395, 397;
  subcultures in female-dominated organizations 89; *see also* gendered leadership
organizational development (OD), dialogical organizational development 37
organizational discourse analysis (ODA) 28, 123
organizational form, in interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 211
organizational learning 11, 13, 373–374, 375;
  contexts and processes 378–382;
  crisis leadership 10, 263–264;
  evaluation of 382;
  failures in 378;
  future research 383;

individual/team-based 379–380;
issues in 382;
leader communication 375–377;
leadership, culture and learning 377–378;
organization-wide 380–382
organizational representatives, in organizational collaboration (IOC) 210
organizational strategy 11, 389–390;
future research 402;
implementation challenges 396–398;
implementation solutions 398–402, *401*;
mission statement 390–391;
"one-company" culture 389, 395, 397;
strategic communication 395–402, *401*;
strategic leadership 390–393, 402;
strategic mindset 393–394, *394*;
strategic thinking 393–395, *394*, 402;
strategy statement 392–393;
values statement 391;
vision statement 391–392
organizationality, in interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 212, 219
orientation, in narratives 294
Orlikowski, W. J. 136
Ospina, S. 7, 27, 29, 245
Őosterberg, J. 378, 379
other-than-human actants 8, 60, 61, 62, 65
Otto, K. 227
out-groups 146, 151, 154
Ozbilgin, M. F. 127
Ozkazanc-Pan, B. 198

Pantelli, N. 194
Paoletti, J. 282
paradox 228, 358;
of identity 120;

paradoxical leadership 5;
performance of 226, 230–231
paradoxical perspective 8, 45–46, **46–47**, 51–52;
"dialecting the paradox" 52;
future research 12;
historical and current theory **46**, 49–50;
leadership communication 50–51;
"paradoxing the dialectic" 52
paradoxical thinking 50, 51
Parker, P. S. 172, 247
Paroutis, S. 51
Parry, K. 59
participation, meaningful participation in interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 216
Patrick, C. 366
Pearce, C. 58, 62
peer mentoring groups *see* collaborative mentoring
performance coaching 379
performativity, in communicative practice 75
Perriton, L. 364
Perry, J. 362
person-centered communication 150–151
persuasion *see* social influence
phronesis 41
phronetic pivoting 231
pivotal leadership 2
place, and leadership 59
plural leadership 19, 58;
interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 209; *see also* collective leadership
police service, UK, masculine cultures, misogyny and harassment 86
polyvocality 38
Poole, M. S. 234, 328
Poon, M. 62
Poorhosseinzadeh, M. 83

Positioning Theory 296
positive bias, in leadership research 12
positive emotion 344, 345
positivism 1, 3
positivity: "relentless positivity" in leadership discourse 96; *see also* Prozac leadership
Posner, B. Z. 375
post-bureaucracy 4
post-heroic leadership 58.59, 71, **72**, 73, 74, 81
postpositivism 5, 6;
  postpositivist leadership communication 2, 3;
  postpositivist leadership psychology 3
poststructural approach, organizational narrative analysis 295
poststructuralism 2
"post-truth claims making" 84
post-truth leadership 4, 5
Potter, J. 123
Powell, F. C. 347
power 2, 3, 4;
  AI (artificial intelligence) 333;
  architecture of buildings 85;
  collective leadership 7, 19–20, 26–28;
  corruption 86;
  critical perspectives 8, 81–90;
  episodic 12, 241, 242–243, 249;
  face-to-face interactions 84–85;
  framing 109;
  future research 12;
  leadership communication as discursive struggle over 10, 226, 232–233;
  learning 34;
  mentoring 168, 174;
  resistance 241;
  spatial segregation, and power differentials 85;

systemic 245–246;
virtual/hybrid worki 201; *see also* dark side of leadership
Powers, C. J. 328
"practical theory" 2
practical wisdom 2, 41
practice, definitions of 70
pragmatics 60
Pratt, M. G. 228
praxis principle 47
Priest, R. F. 348, 349
principal 60
printing industry, UK, masculine subculture 89
problem-solving, Eisenhower Matrix 393–394, *394*
process, organizational collaboration (IOC) 210
processual leadership 19; *see also* collective leadership
Procter and Gamble 399
productive dialogue 35
prospect theory 278
Proteus 4, 5
Prozac leadership communication 6, 8, 87–88, 89, 90
Ptacek, J. K. 158
public relations 261
Pullen, A. 314
Purvanova, R. K. 196, 197–198
Putnam, L. L. 50, 52, 88, 123, 232

Qu, Y. 51
queer leadership 359
questions, in dialogical leading 40–41

race: mentoring 174;
power and inequality issues 83
racism: anti-Black racism in schools 363;
systemic 366;

in the workplace 360, 362
Raelin, J. 35, 36, 70, 78
Raghuram, S. 193
Ramsey, C. 26, 75, 77
Rawlins, B. 226
realistic previews of change 226
recovery phase, crisis leadership 10, 262–263, 265
reflection 40–41;
"reflection-in-action" 232
reflective inquiry, dialogical leading as 36–38
reflexivity 12, 39, 50, 172, 232
Rego, A. 2
reinforcement 9, 137, 138
Reitz, M. 34–35
relational becoming, dialogical leading as 38–41
relational event monitoring 28
relational leadership 179, 180–181;
and dialogic leading 36;
interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 209
relationality 3, 75
relationally-responsive signaling 39–40
relationship cultivation, virtual leadership 199
relief theory 347
religion, power and inequality issues 83
remote work 5, 13, 193, 202, 382;
and framing research 288
renewal phase, crisis leadership 10, 262–263
repetition, and strategic communication 400
representation, in interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 217
reproductive dialogue 35
resistance 10, 88–90, 241–242;
"activist dissent" 104;
dark side of leadership 96;

episodic power 241, 242–243, 249;
future research 249–250;
harnessing dissent 244–245;
of hegemonic leadership 246–247;
as leadership 241, 247–249, 250;
against neoliberal work environment 365;
power-resistance dynamics 88–90;
resistance leadership 10, 248–249;
resistance to leadership 10, 243–244;
systemic power 245–246;
and technology 335
resolution, in narratives 294
respect, in dialogue 37–38
reverse mentoring 164, 168, 169, 172, 173
rhetoric 60;
strategic communication 400
rhetorical MDL (message design logic) 279, 280
rhetorical performance 226, 228, 230, 231, 232
rhetorically-responsive communication practice 38–39
Rhodes, C. 313
Rice, C. 88
Ricoeur, P. 213
Rigg, C. 27
Rijal, S. 378
Rippin, A. 321
risk: hypermasculine cultures 86;
risk sensing, crisis leadership 10, 257–258
Rittel, H. 394
Roberson, Q. 362
Robert Half 348
Roberts, W. R. 133
robots 331, 333–334
Rohn-Endres, S. 23

role conflict, leader-member exchange (LMX) 153–154
role development process 167
role overload, leader-member exchange (LMX) 153–154
role-making phase, leadership making 152
Ropo, A. 59, 320
Rosette, A. S. 350
Rotondo, D. M. 348
Rouse, E. 167
routines 109–110
Royal Bank of Scotland (RBS), UK 87
Ruben, B. 98, 309, 310, 320
Rubin, R. S. 343
Rules of Reality Construction 288n2
Russ, T. L. 227
Ruusuvuori, J. 318

safety, in dialogue 37–38
Sahay, S. 233
Salovaara, P. 320
Sanchez-Cortes, D. 185
Sarr, R.A. 280–282, **281**, 377
Sassen, R. 228
Saudi women leaders 247–248, 305
Saujani, Reshma 297, 298–300
Schatzki, T. R. 70, 71
Scheibe, S. 350
Schein, E. H. 109, 377–378
Schein, P. A. 377–378
Scheufele, B. 278
Schmidt, G. B. 201–202
Schmitt, D. R. 284
Schnurr, S. 296, 348–349
Schweiger, D. M. 226–227
scientific management 82

secrecy: control and withholding of information 85–86, 89
Seeger, M. 262–263
Seibold, D. R. 225
self-action 71, **72**
Sellnow, T. L. 262–263
semiotics 29, 60
Senge, P. 373, 383
sensebreaking 229
sensegiving 229, 377;
  crisis leadership 10, 259–260;
  framing 273, 274;
  leadership narratives 297, 305
sensemaking 40, 228–229, 377;
  crisis leadership 10, 258–259;
  framing 280;
  leadership narratives 297, 305;
  technology 327
Serban, A. 197
Sergi, V. 26, 61, 62, 65, 312
servant leadership 126, 128, 376
SET (social exchange theory) 148, 149
sexual harassment 83, 86
sexual orientation, power and inequality issues 83, 86
Sguera, F. 226
Shamir, B. 295
Shao, Z. 378
shared leadership 19, 20, 23, 58, 182, 196;
  interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 209, 211;
  learning 376–377; *see also* collective leadership
"shared-power world" 27
Sheep, M. L. 119, 120, 318
Sheer, V. C. 151, 155, 157
Shelia, S. 344

Shepherd, G. J. 74
Sherony, K. M. 155
Shotter, J. 38–39, 40, 41, 119
Shuffler, M. 200
Sias, P. M. 150–151
Siitonen, M. 201
Silince, J. A. A. 230
Simpson, B. 24, 26, 71, **72**, 73, 75–76, 78, 123–124, 172
Simpson, J. 35
Sinclair, A. 313, 314, 316, 319, 321
single loop learning 373, 381–382
Sinha, P. N. 399
Sitkin, S. 97, 127
Sklaveniti, C. 24, 28
"small stories" 294, 304
Smirchich, L. 84
Smit, B. 305
Smith, A. 367
Smith, W. K. 49
Snavely, B. 358, 364
social account theory 230
social class 366
social communication theory 148
social constructionism 12, 47, 121, 163, 226, 233, **275**, 351, 374, 375, 376;
  communications and technology 326, 327;
  dialogical leading 33, 37, 38;
  leader identity 121–122;
  leadership-as-practice (L-A-P) **72**, 73, 74–75, 76, 77;
  organizational learning 375, 377;
  social construction/production principle 47
social exchange theory (SET) 148, 149
social influence 9, 132–133, 140;
  evolution of theory and practice 133–135;

formal and informal influence 136–137;
future directions 139–140;
leader-follower reciprocal influence 137, 140;
resonance, activation, and cultivation 9, 132, 135, 137–139; *see also* influence
social media 313, 327–328;
ESM (enterprise social media) 327, 329
social network analysis 183
sociality 75
socialization, of mentees through role development process 167
sociocultural contexts, leadership narratives and storytelling 297, 298, 304–305
sociolinguistics 29
sociomateriality 2, 5, 6, 13, 49, 50, 61, 136, 331
Somer, M. 125
Sonenshein, S. 233
Song, C. 376
South Africa, Black women leaders 305
space 59, 76;
in organizational change (OC) research 234;
positioning of bodies in 315–316;
spatial segregation, and power differentials 85
sparring sessions 231
Spector, B. 84
speech act schematics 29
speech act theory 228
speedbump (Latour) 60, 62
Spicer, A. 101–102, 246, 249, 377
spin, in framing 281, **281**, 283
spirit functions 328
Spoelstra 103
stakeholders 328;
crisis leadership 263, 264;
Deepwater Horizon oil spill 121;
dialogical leading 36, 37;

ethics and interpersonal consideration 113;
multiple stakeholders in interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 208, 210–211, 211–212;
organizational change (OC) 231, 234
Stanislavski, C. 315
Starbucks 391
"stealth power" 85
Stein, H. 100
Stein, R. T. 184
Steinbach, A. L. 286
Stephens, K. K. 328
Steptoe-Warren, G. 347
Stewart, J. R. 34, 78
Stivers, T. 301
Stop Asian Hate 361
stories, in framing 281, **281**, 283
story making, systemic 2, 40
storytelling: strategic communication 400; *see also* leadership narratives and storytelling
Strachan, G. 83
stranger phase, leadership making 147, 152
strategy *see* organisational strategy
strategy statement 392–393
strong man leaders 84
structuration theory 47–48, 328
structure, organizational collaboration (IOC) 210
subprime mortgages 87
Sullivan, K. R. 314–315
superiority theory 347
surveillance 89
suspension, in dialogue 38
Sutanto, J. 197
Sutcliffe, K. M. 111
Sveiby, K.E. 28

Swain, J. E. 348, 349
Swenson, R. 401–402
synthesis (Hegel) 48
systemic power 12
systemic story making 2, 40

"tame" problems 394
Tan, S. 234, 311–312, 321
Tanner, G. 227
Target 360
Taylor, J. 60, 228
Taylor, M. 361
Taylor, S. S. 315, 319
Taylor, T. J. 4
team leadership 9, 20, 178;
  charismatic leadership 179, 180;
  definition 179;
  formal leadership 179–182;
  functional leadership 179, 181, 182;
  future research 12, 186;
  implications for practice 185–186;
  informal leadership 182–195;
  learning 378;
  nonverbal communication 184–185;
  relational leadership 179, 180–181;
  transformational leadership 179–180;
  verbal communication 182–184;
  virtual teams 194, 201; *see also* collective leadership
team-member exchange (TMX) 155
teams: impact of AI (artificial intelligence) on 334;
  learning and development 375, 379–380
technology 11, 42, 326–327, 336;
  automation 330–334;
  connectivity and work/life issues 329–330;

future research 336;
integration issues 335–336;
leadership challenges 334–336;
power and control issues 82;
theories and concepts 327–328;
training and development 382; *see also* AI (artificial intelligence); automation
telecommuting 192; *see also* virtual work
telework 193
temporality 12–13;
of communication 184, 186;
in organizational change (OC) research 234;
paradox of 120;
virtual leadership 201
tensionality, in dialogue 35
tensions 45, 48, 52;
TSCD (tensions of strategic communication decision-making) 260–261
texts, interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 213, 214
Theranos 96, 99–100, 103
there-and-then talk 108
thesis (Hegel) 48
Thomas, R. 23
Thorson, J. A. 347
thought: in framing skills **281**, 282;
strategic thinking 393–395, *394*, 402
Tian, Z. 367
Tietsort, C. J. 346
time *see* temporality
#TimesUp 361
totality principle 47
Tourish, D. 96, 98–99, 100–101, 246, 249
tournament theory 153
Town, S. 51
toxic leadership communication 8, 85–87, 89, 90

Toyama, R. 48
Tracey, J. B. 342
Tracy, S. J. 49
training and development 200, 283, 361, 379–389; *see also* organizational learning
trans-action 71, **72**, 75
transactional leadership 179–180;
  crisis leadership 263–264, 265;
  emotion 342;
  learning 376, 380–381
transformational dialogues, in mentoring 172
transformational leadership 6, 97, 179–180, 196, 358;
  crisis leadership 263, 265;
  emotion 323, 342, 346;
  learning 375–376, 378, 380–381;
  resistance 245, 246, 248, 249
transgender leaders 314–315
translation, in interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 218, 219
transmission, communication as 71, **72**, 73
transparency 226, 335
Treem, J. W. 329
Trump, D. 4, 5, 84, 313, 318
trust, in interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 215, 219
TSCD (tensions of strategic communication decision-making) 260–261
Tsoukas, H. 41, 119
turn-taking 12, 23, 182–183, 301
Tversky, A. 277–278

U. S. Army 390
Uber 333
Uhl-Bien, M. 29, 123, 137, 146, 358
uncertainty: crisis leadership 256;
  organizational change (OC) 226–227
"Undercover Boss" TV show 85
United Nations 201

upward influence 283, 284–286

Vaara, E. 295, 396
Vachhani, S. 314
values statement 391
Van De Mieroop, D. 24, 28, 294, 301, 315
Van de Ven, A. H. 50, 234
Van Dyne, L. 154
Van Every, E. J. 228
Van Kleef, G. A. 346
van Knappenberg, D. 344, 351
van Nistelrooij, A. 37–38
Vandembempt, K. 233, 234
Varghese, L. 167
Varma, T. 261–262
Vatcha, N. 246
Veiga, J. F. 196
ventriloquism 8, 59–61, 65, 124;
  ventriloquial analysis, military operations, Afghanistan 62–65, *63*
Vera, D. 381
verbal communication 136;
  informal leadership 182–184
vertical dyad linkage model (VDL) 146, 147
vicarious learning 264
videoconferencing 382
Vine, B. 23
virtual leadership 9–10, 192–193, 194;
  as constituted by communication 195–196;
  equity and inclusion 198–199;
  further research 200–202;
  paradox and tension in 197–198;
  practical tips 199–200;
  virtual team and organizational outcomes 196–197
virtual work 9–10, 13, 42, 192–194, 330

visibility: communication visibility 327–328, 329;
interorganizational collaboration (IOC) 218–219;
virtual work 330
vision casting 273, 279
vision, hazards of a compelling vision and unifying ideology 99–100
vision statement 391–392
visionary leadership 4, 6, 273, 280, 286, 294
visual representations, and strategic communication 400
Volkswagen emissions crisis, 2015 256, 391
Vrij, A. 103
VUCA (vulnerability, uncertainty, chaos, and ambiguity) conditions 36
Vullinghs, J. T. 182

Wachner, L. 101
Wåhlin-Jacobsen, C. D. 318
Waldman, D. 98
Waldron, V. R. 342
Waletzky, J. 294
Walmart 399
Walter, F. 350
Walumbwam F. 97
Wang, D. 98
Warnaco 101
Weatherell, M. 123
Webber, M. 394
Weber, J. 392
Weber, M. 212
Weber, M. S. 260
“we-discourse” 27
Weibler, J. 23
Weick, K. E. 111, 256, 317, 377
Welch, J. 102
Wennes, G. 316, 317, 319
WeWork 100, 103

whistleblowing 108
whiteness 357, 366
“wholes” 76, 77
“wicked” problems 42, 121, 394
Wilbert, J. B. 199, 200
Wilderom, C. P. M. 180
Willocks, K. 70, 71
Wodak, R. 24
“woke capitalism” 360
women: appearance 314;
  Chinese women political leaders 367;
  emotion 344, 348–349, 350;
  female leaders 82–83, 90, 296, 297, 298–300, 304, 305, 366;
  humor 348–349;
  mentoring 174;
  remote/hybrid working 199;
  Saudi women leaders 247–248;
  sexual harassment 83, 86;
  subcultures in female-dominated organizations 89; *see also* African American female leaders; BIPOC (Black, Indigenous, and People of Color) people; Black women leaders
work teams *see* teams
working from home 194, 330; *see also* remote work
World Café 37
Worley, J. 363
Wright, A. 124, 128
Wu, I. 375
Wu, L. Z. 349

Xie, K. 183

Yang, I. 349
Yeh, C. C. R. 349
Yukl, G. 342

Yun, D. 346

Zander, A. 342
Zanin, A. C. 246–247
Zanoni, P. 361, 362–363
Zaug, P. 242
Zhu, H. 183
Zoizner, A. 278
Zoller, H. M. 48, 246, 247, 248